Mandarin, Step by Step, Character by Character

A composition-driven introduction to standard Mandarin

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Starter edition — seven short lessons in one cumulative chapter.

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Chinese. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the characters and sounds needed for it, shows what those characters are built from, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. There is no character list to memorise first.

Two things about Mandarin will be new to a reader coming from a European language, and this book meets both in its first chapter rather than deferring them. The first is that Chinese is written in *characters*, not letters: each one is an evenly sized block built from smaller recurring components, and words are one or more of those blocks. The second is that *pitch is part of the word*. Said on a high flat note, a falling note, or a low dipping one, the same syllable is three different words. That is not emphasis; it is as much a part of the word as a consonant.

This book is also honest about one thing it cannot do. A related language would let a new word be attached to English words the reader already owns through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*. Chinese and English share no ancestor, so there are no cousins to show, and inventing some would be worse than having none. What replaces them here is the composition of the characters themselves: 好 is 女, woman, beside 子, child. That is a real and visible structure, and it does help — but it anchors a new word to knowledge you are acquiring in the same breath rather than to knowledge you already had, so it is a weaker hook than a shared ancestor would give. Where a component gloss is a traditional memory picture rather than settled history, this book says so.

Romanization (pinyin) stays beside the characters in this starter edition and will fade gradually. The variety taught is standard Mandarin in simplified characters; traditional characters are a labelled future edition, not a silent substitute.

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Chapter 1

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (2) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can greet someone in Mandarin and answer when greeted, reading both characters unaided and saying the greeting with the tone a speaker actually uses rather than the one the dictionary prints.
>
> *A two-line meeting in which both voices say the same word — read from the characters alone, with the first third tone raised by sandhi.*

1.1 mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

Nothing to recall yet. Before the first Chinese word arrives, one thing your voice is about to be asked to do that English never asks of it.

The sounds and tones in this word

In English, pitch carries mood. *Really.* and *Really?* are the same word, said two ways.
In Mandarin, **pitch is part of the word**, exactly the way a consonant is. Take the syllable *ma* and give it four different pitches and you get four unrelated words:

- **mā** — held high and flat, one steady note. *Mother.*
- **má** — rising, like the pitch on a surprised English "huh?". *Hemp.*

- **mǎ** — dipping low, a little creaky. *Horse.*
- **mà** — falling sharply, like a clipped "No!". *To scold.*

There is a fifth, the **neutral** tone: short, light, no mark written at all. The accent over the vowel is how the romanization writes the tone: a flat bar in **ā**, a rising stroke in **á**, a hook in **ǎ**, a falling stroke in **à**. The Chinese characters themselves record no tone anywhere, so the accent is a teaching aid, not part of the writing.
Say all four in order now, slowly: **mā, má, mǎ, mà**. *Twice through.*

Writing — trace four visible paths

Keep the model visible. With a finger first, then a pencil, trace only the mark above each **a**: **ā, á, ǎ, à**. Move flat, up, down-then-up, and down. Say the matching pitch while your pencil moves.

Stop after one slow pass. This is not a memory test, and these pinyin marks are not Chinese characters. The next lesson will give your hand its first two-stroke character; this tiny step only lets pitch become a line you can see and follow.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mā** high and flat, then **mà** falling — hear how far apart they are
- *Answer:* if you change the pitch of a Mandarin syllable, what changes?

Before you move on

Which accent tells you to dip low? (The hook, as in **ǎ**.) Does changing a Mandarin tone change how you feel about a word, or which word it is? (Which word it is.)
Source: the tone inventory this track keeps

1.2 你 — "you", and the first character

Say the four tones on *ma* once, in order. Hold the third one — low and dipping. The first Chinese word carries exactly that

pitch.

The sounds and tones in this word

nǐ. The *n* is the English *n*; the *i* is the *ee* of "see". The hook over it is the **third tone**: start low, stay low, let it creak. *Twice through.*

Script — 你, and the person hiding on its left

Chinese is not written with letters. It is written with **characters**, each an evenly sized square block, and each block built from smaller recurring pieces called **components**.

你 has two of them: a narrow piece on the left, a wider one on the right.

The narrow left piece is the "person" component, *rén*. On its own, the character for a person is two legs walking. Pushed to the left edge of a block, it is squashed upright: one short slant over one vertical.

The right piece, *ěr*, is there for its *sound*, not its meaning. Chinese builds most of its characters this way — one component pointing at the meaning, another at the pronunciation.

Stroke order is a real, taught system here: top before bottom, left before right. So the person piece first, then the sound piece. The writing lessons hand you each piece, stroke by stroke.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你 *nǐ* — **you**, addressing one person.
Here this book has to be honest with you. A related language lets a new word be anchored to English words you already own through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*, all from Latin *gratia*. **Chinese shares no ancestor with English.** There is no cousin web for *nǐ*, and inventing one would be worse than having none.
What replaces it is what you just read: the character is itself decomposable, and its pieces mean things. 你 carries a person on its left because it is about a person. That is the hook — not history you share with English, but structure you can see.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ** — low and dipping, not flat
- *Read it:* 你 — point to the person piece, then the sound piece

Before you move on

Which half of 你 is the person? (The narrow left one.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

1.3 好 — "good", and what replaces etymology here

Say the word for "you" without looking. Which of its two components is the person? Now hold that low, dipping pitch — the next word wants the same one.

The sounds and tones in this word

hǎo. The *h* is a little rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth. The *ao* is one gliding vowel, the *ow* of "how". The hook accent is the same third tone you already met: low, dipping, creaky. *Twice through.*

Script — 好, a woman beside a child

Two components again, side by side. The left one is the character for "woman", said *nǚ*: a crossing stroke, a curved leg, a horizontal through the middle. The right one is "child", said *zǐ*: a hooked top, a hooked vertical, a horizontal arm. Left before right, as always.

Notice what just happened. Woman and child are not letters spelling out the sound *hǎo* — neither is pronounced anything like it. They are whole characters with their own meanings, reused as building blocks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好 *hǎo* — **good**, and also **well**.
A woman beside a child, and the character means "good". That picture is the hook — and it stands in for the cousin web that a related language would supply, because **Chinese and English share no ancestor** and there is no honest chain from *hǎo* to any English word. Two cautions, because a memory aid that pretends to be history rots:

- "Woman + child = good" is the **traditional gloss**. It is genuinely useful for remembering the shape, but palaeographers

do not all accept it as the historical origin; some read the child component as a phonetic element instead. A picture that helps, not a proven derivation.

- Component glosses are hooks, not translations. 好 does not "mean" woman-child. It means good.

The word itself is inherited from Middle Chinese *xawX*, "good" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The picture belongs to the writing, not to the word.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hǎo** — low and dipping, the *ow* of "how"
- *Read it:* 好 — point to the woman on the left, then the child on the right
- *Answer:* why does this track use component pictures instead of English cousins?

Before you move on

What does 好 mean? (Good, or well.) Is its woman-and-child picture a proven etymology? (No — a traditional and useful gloss, disputed as history.)
Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Two characters, both already yours. Say the one that means "you". Say the one that means "good". Now put them in that order and you have said hello — but say it slowly for one more moment, because the tones are about to do something.

The exchange

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

The greeting and its answer are the same word. Say it to one person you have just met, at any hour of the day.

Grammar Lens — a word can be more than one character

English counts a word in **letters**. Chinese does not have letters, so the tempting guess is that it counts a word in **characters** — one character, one word. That guess is wrong, and correcting it early saves a great deal of confusion.
A character writes one **syllable** and usually one **meaningful piece**. A **word** is one or more of those pieces:

- 你 — one character, one word: *you*
- 好 — one character, one word: *good*
- 你好 — two characters, still **one word**: *hello*

Nobody hearing 你好 parses it as "you good", any more than an English speaker hears "good" and "bye" inside *goodbye*. The pieces are visible, which makes the word easy to remember; the whole is what it means.

Why it's said this way

你好 is safe, neutral, and understood everywhere — which is exactly why a course teaches it first. But it is worth knowing that it is used less freely than English "hello". Between people who already know each other, a Mandarin speaker is more likely to open with a small situational remark than with 你好 at all. Reserve it for meeting someone, and you will sound right.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你好 is a Chinese compound of two inherited words: *hǎo*, "good", from Middle Chinese *xawX*, and *nǐ*, "you", usually traced to the older second-person word *nyeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — greeting someone you have just met

- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — answering that same greeting
- *Answer:* how many characters is this word, and how many words is it?

Before you move on

Which character comes first, and what does it mean on its own? (你, "you".) Is 你好 one word or two? (One.)
Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Say the greeting once, slowly, giving both syllables the low dipping third tone you were taught. It should feel awkward in the mouth. That awkwardness is the whole lesson.

Grammar Lens — one rule, and it is not optional

When two third tones come one after the other, the first is spoken as a second (rising) tone.
So the greeting, written **nǐ hǎo**, is actually said **ní hǎo** — the first syllable climbs instead of dipping. *Twice through.*
Nothing about this shows in the writing. Dictionaries print **nǐ hǎo**, because that is the citation tone each word carries on its own, and the two characters never change at all. A learner who trusts only what is written will say the commonest greeting in the language wrong every time.
Why does it happen? Two dipping tones in a row would need the voice to sink, climb, sink and climb again inside a fifth of a second. Speakers do not do that; the first one gives way. This is a real rule of the sound system, not a sloppy shortcut, and every native speaker applies it without thinking.
Compare it to what English does with *"the"*: written one way, said *thuh* before a consonant and *thee* before a vowel, and no English speaker thinks of that as two words. The difference is that here the change lands on **pitch** — the same property that distinguishes one word from another.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ní hǎo** — first syllable rising, second dipping
- *Say it:* it again, at speaking speed, without the pause between them
- *Answer:* which spelling changes when the rule applies — pinyin, characters, or neither?

Before you move on

Two third tones meet. What happens to the first? (It rises.) What happens to the characters? (Nothing.)
Source: Chinese Text Project, on tone in Mandarin

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Name the character built from a woman and a child, and say what it means. Hold its tone: low and dipping.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The very same character, 好, has a second reading — and the only thing that separates the two is the tone:

- 好 *hǎo*, dipping third tone — **good**
- 好 *hào*, sharply falling fourth tone — **to be fond of, to like**

Same strokes. Same components. Same shape on the page. Two words. This is the cleanest proof available of what the first lesson claimed. Tone is not decoration on a word; it is *inside* the word, doing the job a consonant does in English. Change *hǎo* to *hào* and you have not said "good" with feeling — you have said a different word, the way *bat* and *pat* are different words.
The two readings are related in meaning, and the relation is a good hook: what is **good** is what one is **fond of**. That is a link inside Chinese, between two readings of one character. It is not a link to English. There is none.
You are not asked to produce **hào** yet. Recognising it is the point: when a familiar character turns up wearing an unfamiliar tone, the

tone is telling you this is a different word.
Both readings are inherited from Middle Chinese: the Guangyun lists *xawX*, "good", and *xawH*, "to be fond of" (in Baxter's transcription). Making a related word by moving it into the departing tone, the *H* of these spellings, is a well-known pattern of Middle Chinese.

Your turn

- *Answer:* **hǎo** or **hào** — which one means "good"?
- *Answer:* what changed between them, and what stayed the same?
- *Answer:* which two components is this character built from?

Before you move on

One character carried two words today. What told them apart? (Only the tone.)
Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Retrieve the two words separately first: the one meaning "you", then the one meaning "good". Do not run them together yet.

The exchange

A: 你好 *ní hǎo!* B: 你好 *ní hǎo!*

Two lines, one word, both voices. Every piece is already yours: the characters from their own lessons, the meaning from the greeting lesson, the rising first syllable from the sandhi rule. Nothing new is hiding here.

Say A's line, pause, then answer as B. *Twice through.*

What you've built this chapter

Four things, and only one of them is vocabulary:

- 你 is a person component plus a sound component; 好 is woman beside child. Characters are built from parts.

- Those parts are the memory hook this track uses, because Chinese and English share no ancestor and therefore no cousin web.
- 你好 is two characters and one word. Characters are not letters.
- Pitch is part of the word, and a neighbouring word can change it without changing a stroke.

Your turn

- *Say it:* greet someone you have just met
- *Say it:* answer that greeting
- *Read it:* 你好 aloud from the characters alone, with no pinyin

Before you move on

Run both lines once more. If the first syllable dips instead of rising, go back to the sandhi lesson only — not to the whole chapter.
Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

Chapter 2

Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time

Modes: ↙ **pen** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write each component the greeting's two characters are built from, and then assemble both characters from those pieces rather than recalling them as whole shapes.
>
> *The second assembly, built from two components the reader wrote individually a moment earlier — and a caution that the memorable story about why it means what it means is a story, not a source.*

2.1 人 — two strokes, and a person walking

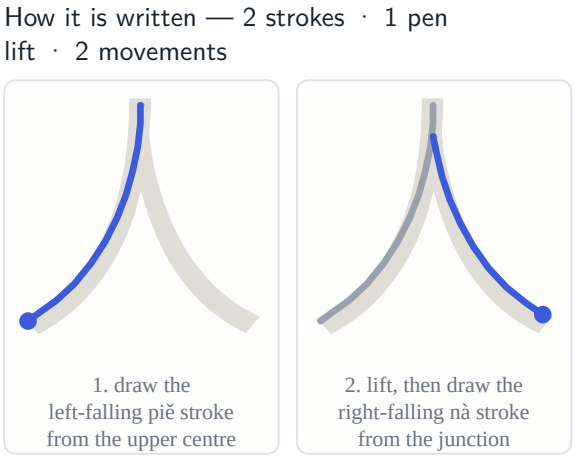
You have heard Mandarin pitch. Now you meet the writing, and this book will hand it to you **one piece at a time** — never a character you have not been shown the parts of first.

This is the whole first piece:

人

Two strokes. That is the entire character.

Script — the shape



How 人 is written, stroke by stroke

人 *rén* means **person**.

Look at it before you read another word about it. A stroke leaning down-left, a stroke leaning down-right, meeting at the top. **It is a figure standing on two legs, seen from the side.** You are not being asked to take that on faith — the oldest surviving forms of this character, scratched into ox bone three thousand years ago, are recognisably a standing person, and the two legs are the part that lasted.

Write it in this order, and the order is not a suggestion:

1. the **left** stroke, from the top down to the lower left — a falling sweep
2. the **right** stroke, starting near the top of the first and pressing down to the lower right

Left before right. Almost every character you meet will obey it, and it is worth meeting here — on a character with two strokes — rather than later on one with fifteen.

The pitch is **second tone**: *rén* rises, like the end of an English question.

Your turn — copy with the model visible

Keep 人 visible. Point to the left stroke, then the right. Copy the character once immediately below the model: left stroke first, then right. Say *rén* as you finish it, and compare the meeting point at the top before moving on.

This is guided copy, not a memory test. One careful copy is enough.

Before you move on

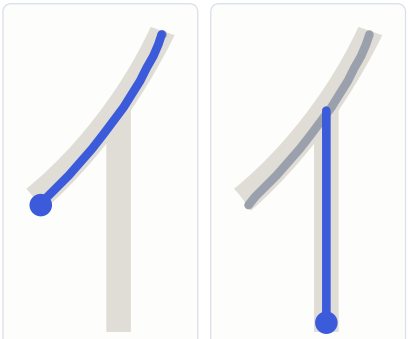
Which stroke goes first — the one leaning left, or the one leaning right? (The **left**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.2 亻 — the same person, standing sideways

Write the two-stroke character for *person* once, from memory. Left stroke, then right.

Script — one character, two postures

How it is written — 2 strokes · 1 pen lift · 2 movements



1. draw the left-falling piě stroke from upper right to lower left

2. lift, then draw the vertical shù stroke from the junction to the baseline

Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–2 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 亻 is written, stroke by stroke

Every Chinese character is written inside an **evenly sized square block** — whether it has two strokes or twenty, it occupies the same footprint. That one fact drives everything you are about to see.

Because when two pieces have to share a block, one of them must get out of the way. Here is what *person* looks like when it moves to the left edge to make room:

亻

Still two strokes. Still the same piece. But the wide-legged stance has been pulled upright into **one short slant on top of one long vertical**, narrow enough that something else can sit beside it.

This is not a different character. It is the same one, squashed. Chinese does this constantly, and the squashed forms are called **components**. When you see 亻 at the left edge of a block, the character is telling you: *this word is about a person.*

Write it:

1. the **short slant**, down-left, at the top
2. the **long vertical**, dropping from the middle of that slant

Top before bottom — the second of the two rules.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 人, then 亻 beside it. Notice you did not learn a new piece — you learned a new **posture**.
- *Notice:* 亻 is tall and thin because it is only using the left half of its square.

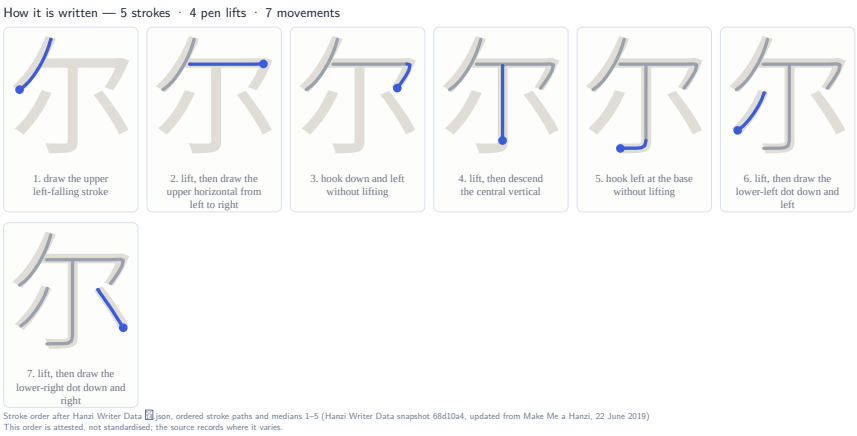
Before you move on

Why does *person* change shape at all? (To leave room in the square for whatever stands beside it.)
Source: Unicode CJK Radicals Supplement chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.3 尔 — a piece that is there for its sound

The narrow upright person — draw it once. Short slant, long vertical.

Script — the other kind of component



How 尔 is written, stroke by stroke

So far a component has meant something: the person piece says *this is about a person.* Here is a component that works the other way.

尔

尔 *ěr*. Five strokes: a short slant across the top, a broad cover beneath it, a central vertical that finishes with a hook, then a small stroke each side of it, left first.

Now the part that matters, and it is the single most useful fact about Chinese writing:

Most characters are built from one component pointing at the MEANING and another pointing at the SOUND. When 尔 turns up inside a character, it is usually there because the word sounds something like *ěr* — not because the word has anything to do with what 尔 means on its own.

That is a strange idea when your reading habits come from an alphabet, where every piece is sound and none is meaning. It is also a relief: it means characters are not arbitrary pictures to be memorised whole. They are **built**,

from a small stock of pieces, and once you know the pieces you can often guess both halves of a character you have never seen.

The pitch is **third tone**: *ěr* dips low.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 尔 — top slant, cover, the middle and its hook, then the two dots
- *Say it:* **ěr**, low and dipping

Before you move on

Two kinds of component, then. One tells you what a word is **about**; the other tells you roughly how it **sounds**. Which kind is 尔?
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

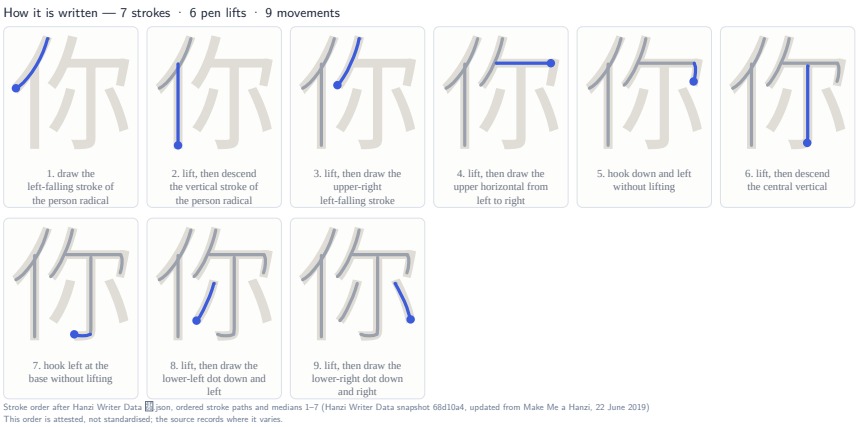
2.4 Putting two pieces together — and reading the result

Two pieces, both already yours. Draw them side by side:

亻 尔

The narrow person on the left. The five-stroke sound piece on the right.

Script — the assembly



How 你 is written, stroke by stroke

Push them into one square block and you have written a character:

亻 + 尔 → 你

Read it the way you now know how to read it, half at a time:

- the **left** half is the person component. So this word is **about a person**.
- the **right** half is the sound piece *ěr*. So this word **sounds something like** *ěr*.

The word is *nǐ*. And that is the honest state of the sound half — *nǐ* and *ěr* are close, not identical. **A sound component gets you into the neighbourhood, not to the door.** Sound components were chosen over two thousand years of pronunciation change, and the pronunciations moved out from under them. Expect a hint, and you will be right most of the time; expect a rule, and Chinese will embarrass you weekly.

Write it left before right, exactly as you learned each half:

1. 亻 — short slant, long vertical
2. 尔 — top slant, cover, then the middle and its hook

Seven strokes in total, and you did not memorise a single new one.

What you've built

Stop and take the measure of what just happened, because it is the reason this book teaches script this way.
You have not been shown a picture and asked to remember it. You were given two pieces, one at a time, and then shown that a character is what you get when they share a square. **The next character works the same way, and so does the one after that.** There are only a few hundred components in common use, and they recombine — which is what makes several thousand characters a climb rather than a cliff.

Your turn — look, cover, rebuild

Copy 你 once while the model is visible: complete 亻, then complete 尔. Point to the meaning half and the sound half. Now cover every model, wait ten seconds, and rebuild the character from memory. Uncover and compare the two halves separately; correct only the half that stalled.

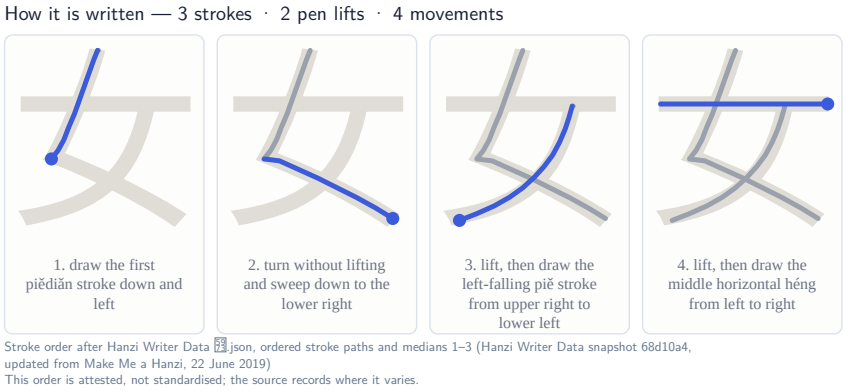
Before you move on

Two pieces, one block, and a character you can take apart again whenever you need to. Which half would you look at to guess the pronunciation?
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.5 女 — three strokes, seated

One character so far assembles from two known halves. Draw it, and name each half as you write it.

Script — the shape



How 女 is written, stroke by stroke

A new piece, and like the first one it is old enough to still look like what it meant:

女

女 *nǚ* — **woman**. Three strokes.

The oracle-bone form is a **kneeling or seated figure with the arms crossed in front**. The modern character keeps the crossing: that long horizontal running right across the middle is the arms, and the two curving strokes beneath and around it are the folded body. It has straightened out over three thousand years, but nothing has been added or taken away.

Write it in this order:

1. the stroke that starts upper-right and **curves down and left**
2. the stroke that crosses it, going **down-left then flicking right**
3. the **long horizontal**, last, sweeping across both

That third stroke going last is worth noticing — a long horizontal that crosses everything else usually waits until the end.

The pitch is **third tone**, and the vowel is the rounded *ü*: say *ee* and then push your lips into a whistle without changing the tongue.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 女 — and let the crossing bar go last
- *Say it:* **nǚ**, low and dipping, lips rounded

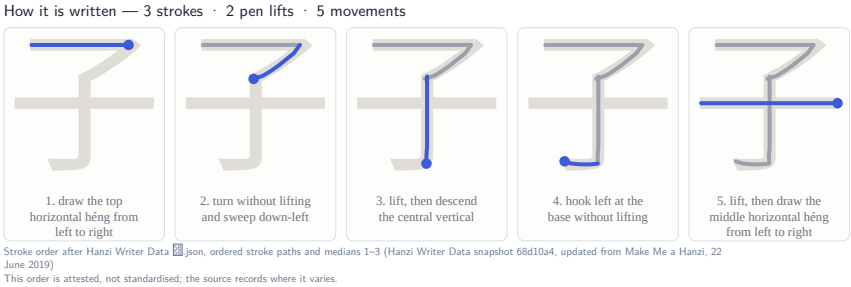
Before you move on

Which stroke comes last, and why? (The **long horizontal** — a bar that crosses the whole character usually waits.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.6 子 — three strokes, a child

Three strokes, crossing bar last. Draw the seated figure you met a moment ago.

Script — the shape



How 子 is written, stroke by stroke

子

子 *zǐ* — **child**. Three strokes again, and again a figure you can still see once you are told where to look.

This one is an infant drawn **from the front**: a large head on top, two arms out to the sides, and the legs bound together so they read as one stroke rather than two. Babies were carried swaddled, and the character kept the bundle.

Write it:

1. the short stroke across the **top**, turning down — the head
2. the **vertical with a hook**, dropping through the middle — the wrapped body
3. the **horizontal** across the middle — the arms

The pitch is **third tone**. The *z* is not the English *z* of *zoo*: it is the *ds* at the end of English *beds*, made with the tongue tip against the teeth.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 子 — head, hooked body, then arms
- *Notice:* two characters now, both three strokes, both once pictures of people. Draw them side by side and compare which parts are curved.

Before you move on

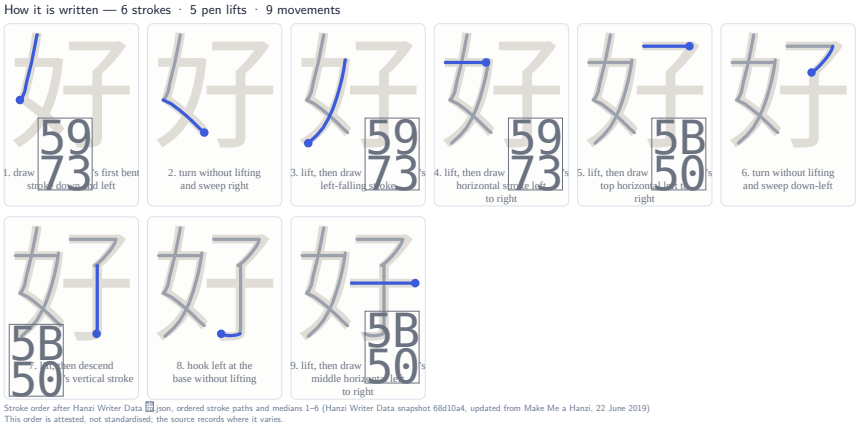
The stroke that runs down the middle carries a hook. What part of the picture is it? (The **wrapped body and legs**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.7 Two pieces again — and a warning about the story

Both pieces are yours. Draw them side by side:

女 子

Script — the assembly



How 好 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Squeeze them into one block, woman on the left, child on the right:

女 + 子 → 好

好 *hǎo*. Six strokes, three from each half, and again nothing new.

Note what is **different** about this assembly. The first one you built had a meaning half and a sound half. This one has **two meaning halves and no sound half at all** — neither piece sounds like *hǎo*. Both kinds of character are common, and you cannot tell which kind you are holding until you look.

When 女 is squeezed into the left of a block its long crossing bar stops short rather than sweeping past the middle, so as not to collide with what stands beside it. Same piece, narrower posture — the same accommodation you already saw the person component make.

What you've built — and a caution

You will find it said that 好 means *good* **because** a woman with a child is a good thing.

Treat that as a story, not as evidence. It is memorable, it is repeated everywhere, and there is no agreement among specialists that it is what happened — competing accounts read the woman as the sound half in an older pronunciation, or read the pair as a woman *caring for* a child. This book will hand you an etymology when there is

a source behind it and tell you plainly when there is not, and this is one of the second kind.
Use the pairing as a **memory hook**, which it genuinely is. Do not file it as a fact about why the word means what it means.

Your turn — from the spoken word to the page

Copy 好 once while looking: finish 女, then 子. Notice that the crossing bar on the left stops before the right half.

Now close the page. Have a person or screen reader say *hǎo* with no character visible. Wait ten seconds, write 好 from the spoken cue, then uncover it. Compare the left half and right half separately. If one half stalled, revisit only its three-stroke lesson before trying the dictation again.

Before you move on

Six strokes, two pieces, and you built both pieces yourself. What is the one claim in this lesson you should NOT repeat as fact?
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

Chapter 3

One to Five — Where the Character Is the Count

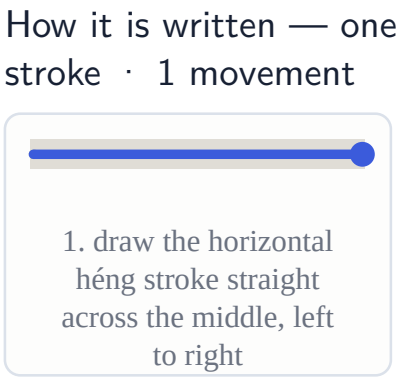
Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **pen** (5) **Hands-free start:** none of the 11 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count from one to five in Mandarin and read all five characters cold and out of order, and I know which of them I could have worked out and which I simply had to learn.
>
> *The five numerals read out of sequence, then off a lift panel with the fourth floor missing — and the reader knows why it is missing.*

3.1 一 — one stroke, and that is the character

Two chapters ago a character was a block to take apart. You learned pieces first, then the characters they build. This chapter asks nothing of the sort. Put the pieces down.

Script — the whole character



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 一.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–1 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 一 is written, stroke by stroke

Here it is:

一

That is not a fragment. **That is the character.** One horizontal stroke, drawn left to right across the middle of the square, and nothing else.

Write it: **one héng stroke, left to right.** No pen lifts, because there is nothing to lift between. It is the shortest character you will ever write.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 一 — one stroke, left to right, straight and level

Before you move on

A character you did not have to decompose. How many times did you lift the pen? (**Not once**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.2 一 — one, and the number is the strokes

Write it: the shape you just learned — one stroke, left to right

The sounds and tones in this word

一 *yī* means **one**.
Take those two facts together, because their meeting is the point: **One stroke. And it means one.**
Chinese will do this exactly three times, and you are about to meet all three in a row. It is the gentlest corner of a writing system with a reputation for being anything but.
Now the sound, and here is something new. Every word this book has given you so far has dipped (*nǐ*, *hǎo*, *ěr*) or risen (*rén*). This one does neither.
First tone: high and flat. Start high and stay there — not a question, not a statement, just a held note. Hum a single steady pitch and put *yi* on it. *Twice through:*
One honest note, so it does not surprise you later. **一 does not always keep this tone.** In front of certain syllables it shifts to *yí* or *yì* — the same kind of change that turned 你好 into *ní hǎo*. Counting is exactly where it stays *yī*, so counting is where this book leaves it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一 *yī* is inherited from Middle Chinese *'jit*, "one" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The single stroke is the history of the character; the word is the inherited one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **yī** — high and flat, held
- *Read it:* 一 — say it, then say how many strokes it has

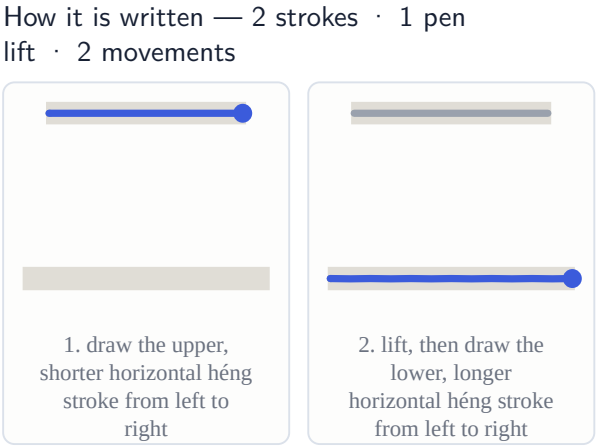
Before you move on

Which tone is *yī* — the dipping one, or the flat one? (**Flat**, held high.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.3 二 — two bars, and neither is decoration

Draw the character for one. Now guess what two looks like before you read on.

Script — you were right



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 二.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–2 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 二 is written, stroke by stroke

二

Two strokes, both horizontal, and the order is the one this book has repeated since the person radical: **top before bottom.**

But look properly, because they are **not the same length**:

- the **upper** bar is the **shorter** one
- the **lower** bar is the **longer** one

That is not decoration. A character occupies a square, and two identical bars floating in one look like an accident. The widening bottom gives the block a base to sit on. You will meet the same instinct everywhere: the last

horizontal tends to be the widest, because it is the one holding everything up.

Write it: **short bar. Lift. Long bar beneath.**

Your turn

- *Write it:* 二 — short bar on top, then the long one below

Before you move on

Two strokes for two. Which goes first? (The **top**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.4 二 — two, and a syllable you have met before

Write it: the shape — two bars, short over long

Count the strokes and say what number you expect it to be.

The sounds and tones in this word

二 *èr* means **two**. Two strokes, and it means two — the pattern holds. **èr** is **fourth tone**, the last of the four you had not used in a real word. Fourth tone **falls**, sharply and from a height, the way an English speaker says a short firm *"No."* Drop it, do not trail it. *Twice through.* Now hold **èr** next to a piece you already know:

尔 *ěr* — the sound-component inside 你

二 *èr* — the number two

Same syllable. Different tone. Completely unrelated characters. One dips; one falls. Nothing else separates them. You met this idea once already, when 好 *hǎo* "good" turned into 好 *hào* "fond of" on a change of pitch alone. That was one character with two readings; this is two characters colliding in sound. Both are the same lesson: **in Mandarin the pitch is not decoration on the word. It is part of the word.**

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

二 *èr* is inherited from Middle Chinese *nyijH*, "two" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **èr** — falling, dropped firmly
- **ěr**, then **èr** — dip, then fall. Feel the difference in your throat.
- **yī, èr** — flat, then down

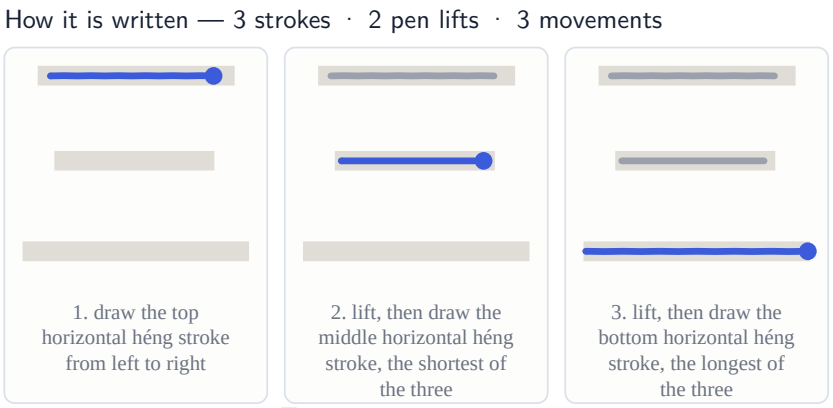
Before you move on

What separates *ěr* from *èr*? (**Only the tone** — and they are different characters entirely.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.5 三 — three bars, and the pattern's last stand

One bar. Two bars. Say what comes next out loud before you look.

Script — the pattern holds one last time



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 三.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 三 is written, stroke by stroke

三

Three strokes. Top, then middle, then bottom — the same rule, a third time.

The lengths are not a simple ladder:

- the **top** bar is medium
- the **middle** bar is the **shortest** of the three
- the **bottom** bar is by far the **longest**

Pinching the middle and widening the base keeps 三 from reading as three identical lines you would have to stop and count. Your eye takes it in whole. That is the difference between a **character** and a **tally** — and the reason the next one cannot be four bars.

Write it: **top, lift, middle, lift, bottom.** Two pen lifts.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 三 — top, middle short, bottom long
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 — point at each and count its strokes

Before you move on

Imagine four bars stacked in a square. Could you read it, or would you have to **count** it? (Count it — which is why the next character is not four bars.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.6 三 — three, and the end of the easy road

Write it: the three bars — middle short, bottom long

The sounds and tones in this word

三 *sān* means **three**. Three strokes, three — for the third and last time.
sān is **first tone**, the flat high one you met on *yī*. Hold it level. The *a* is open, the *n* light at the end. *Twice through.*
So of your first three numbers, two sit flat and one falls:

yī flat, **èr** falling, **sān** flat

Say the run. It goes *level, down, level*, and that shape is the first thing a listener recognises — before any of the individual words.

Why it's said this way

Three characters in, one stroke per unit, a system so regular it barely needs teaching. **It stops here**, and you should know why before it happens.
Every counting system humans have built hits the same wall in the same place. Roman numerals go I, II, III and then break to IV, because stacked marks stop being readable at about three. This one breaks for exactly the same reason.
You are being told now so that the next character feels like a solved problem rather than a broken promise.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

三 *sān* is inherited from Middle Chinese *sam*, "three" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The final *m* has since become *n*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **yī, èr, sān** — level, down, level
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 — say each as you point at it

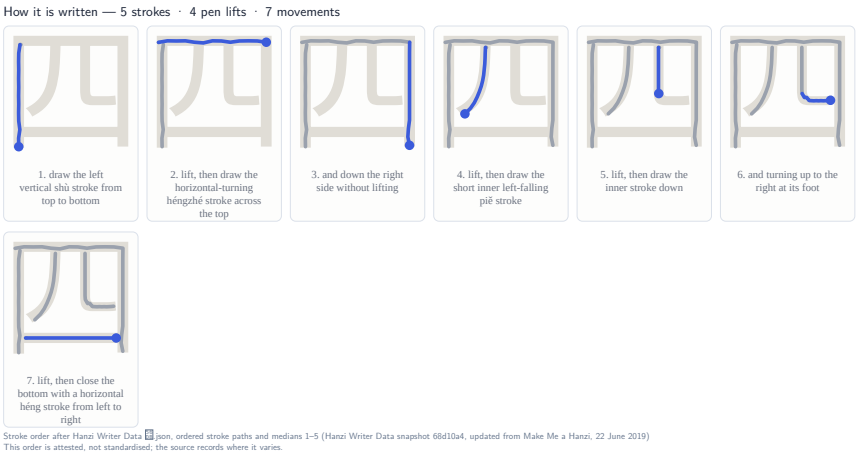
Before you move on

Three characters, three stroke counts, nothing memorised. That ends now.
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.7 四 — a box, and the rule that governs every box

Draw one, two and three. You were told this is where it stops.

Script — five strokes, for four



How 四 is written, stroke by stroke

四

Five strokes, for the number four. The trick is gone, exactly as promised.

四 is a **box with two things inside it**, and every box obeys one rule: **close the bottom LAST.** Walls, then contents, then shut the door.

In order:

1. the **left vertical**, top to bottom
2. the **top and right side in one turning stroke** — across, then down without lifting the pen at the corner
3. the short **inner left-falling** stroke
4. the **inner stroke that turns up** at its foot
5. the **bottom bar**, closing the box — **last**

Two strokes of wall, two of filling, one to shut the door. Four pen lifts.

Notice that the corner in step 2 is **one stroke, not two.** A horizontal that turns and runs downward without the pen leaving the paper is a single unit — *héngzhé*, "horizontal-turn". Miscounting it is the commonest way a beginner's stroke count goes wrong.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 四 — walls, then the two inner strokes, then the bottom last

Before you move on

Is the turning corner one stroke or two? (**One** — *héngzhé*.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.8 四 — four, borrowed for its sound

Write it: the box — walls, contents, bottom last

Count the strokes: five, for the number four.

The sounds and tones in this word

四 *sì* means **four**, and the shape has nothing to do with fourness. 四 is not a picture of four things. It is a shape that already meant something else, **borrowed for its sound** — the same move you met in 尔, a piece carried for how it sounds rather than what it means. The

borrowing won outright: nobody reads 四 as anything but four now. **sì** is **fourth tone**, falling, like *èr*. The vowel is not the *ee* of "see": after *s*, pinyin *i* is a tight buzz in the same position as the *s* itself. Say *sss*, then voice it without moving your tongue. *Twice through.*

Why it's said this way

A reason to get that tone right, and it is a real one:

sì (falling) — four

sǐ (dipping) — die

Separated **by pitch alone** — the third time this chapter has shown you that tone is part of a Mandarin word's identity, not an accent on it. Not a curiosity, either: it is why many buildings in China number floors 1, 2, 3, 5, skipping four the way some Western buildings skip thirteen.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

四 *sì* is inherited from Middle Chinese *sijH*, "four" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The sound-borrowing above is the history of the character: the word came first, and a shape was borrowed to write it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **sì** — falling, firm
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 四 — in order, then out of order

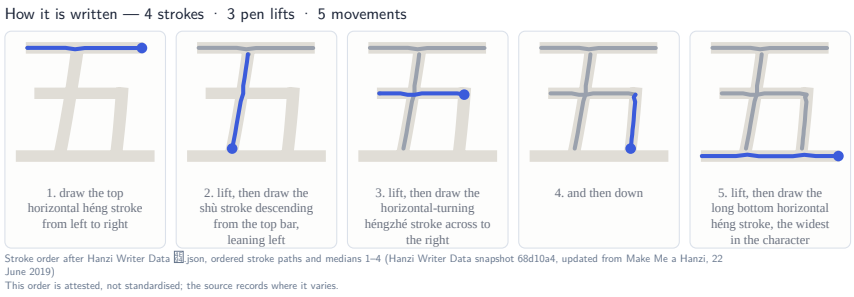
Before you move on

Four is the first number here you could not work out. What replaced the trick? (**A shape borrowed for its sound**, built to a rule.) Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.9 五 — count the strokes and be wrong

Guess, out loud, how many strokes the character for five will have.

Script — four, for five



How 五 is written, stroke by stroke

五

Four strokes. For five.

If you guessed five, good — that guess is the point. The trick that carried you through the first three is not merely retired, it now actively misleads.

The four strokes, in order:

1. the **top horizontal**, left to right
2. the **descending stroke**, from the top bar down, leaning slightly left
3. the **turning stroke** — across to the right, then down
4. the **bottom horizontal**, the widest in the character, closing it

You already know why the last is widest: it is the base, the same instinct as the long bottom bar of 二 and 三. Three pen lifts.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 五 — top bar, descender, turn, then the wide base
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 四 五 — name each shape without saying the numbers yet

Before you move on

Which stroke is widest, and why? (The **bottom** — it is the base.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.10 五 — five, and the run is complete

Write it: the shape — four strokes, for five

The sounds and tones in this word

五 *wǔ* means **five**.
wǔ is **third tone**, the low dipping one you have had since *nǐ*. Keep it low and let it creak; do not push it back up. *Twice through.*
You already own two words on this tone:

你 *nǐ*, 好 *hǎo*, 五 *wǔ*

All three dip. Say them in a row: the pitch should not change shape once, only the mouth around it.
One spelling note while you are here. In *wǔ* there is no consonant hiding under that **w**: the *w* **is** the *u*, written that way because pinyin does not begin a syllable with a bare *u*. Round your lips and voice it.

What you've built — one to five

You can now count:

一 二 三 四 五

yī, èr, sān, sì, wǔ

Say it as one run, not five separate words. The tone shape is **level, down, level, down, dip**, and that rhythm is what a listener hears first.
Five characters, and three ways one can come to you: two you derived, one was borrowed for its sound, and two you simply learned. That mix is Chinese writing in miniature, and you have now met all of it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

五 *wǔ* is inherited from Middle Chinese *nguX*, "five", whose *ng* Mandarin has lost (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). It is usually compared with Tibetan *lnga*, a likely Sino-Tibetan cognate.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **nǐ**, **hǎo**, **wǔ** — three dips, one shape
- **yī èr sān sì wǔ** — one run, at speed

Before you move on

Which tone do *nǐ*, *hǎo* and *wǔ* share? (The **third** — low and dipping.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.11 Practice — read the numbers off a wall

Count to five aloud, in order, without looking. Then do it again with your eyes on the characters:

一 二 三 四 五

Script — the same five, shuffled

Counting in order is slightly dishonest: the sequence carries you, and you can recite *yī èr sān* without reading anything.

So here they are shuffled. Name each before moving on, without letting your eye run back to the row above:

四 一 五 二 三

三 五 一 四 二

If one of them made you pause, it will be 四 or 五 — the two you could not derive. That is expected, and it tells you exactly which two to drill.

Why it's said this way

Not a party trick. A lift panel, a floor directory, a bus number, a market price — all use these characters **on their own**, with no sentence around them. That is why five are already useful; you are not waiting on grammar:

You see: 三

You say: *sān* — third floor.

And when the panel reads

一 二 三 五

with no 四 between three and five, you know why, and you are not confused by it.

The exchange

Two voices, using only what this book has given you:

A: 你好 — *ní hǎo* (the sandhi tone, as always)

B: 你好 — *ní hǎo*

A: [pointing at a panel] 五 — *wǔ*

B: 五 — *wǔ*

Small, and entirely real: repeating a floor number back is what people do in a lift, in any language.

Your turn

- *Read it:* 四 一 五 二 三 — cover the row above first
- *Say it:* **yī èr sān sì wǔ** — one run, level, down, level, down, dip
- *Write it:* 五 — top bar, descender, turn, wide base

What you've built this chapter

Five characters, and three different ways a character can come to you:

- 一 二 三 — transparent. The strokes *are* the number.
- 四 — borrowed for its sound, and built on a box whose rule you can reuse.
- 五 — plain. Four strokes for five, learned as a shape.

That spread is not an accident of this chapter. It is the whole writing system in small: a little of it can be reasoned out, more of it is borrowed sound, and the rest is simply known. You have now met all three, on characters short enough that none of them hurt.

Before you move on

You can read the five characters cold, in any order, with no sentence around them. A panel reads 一 二 三 五 — which number is missing, and why? (四, because *sì* sits one tone from *sǐ*.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 4

One Box, Two Characters, and the First Thing You Can Refuse

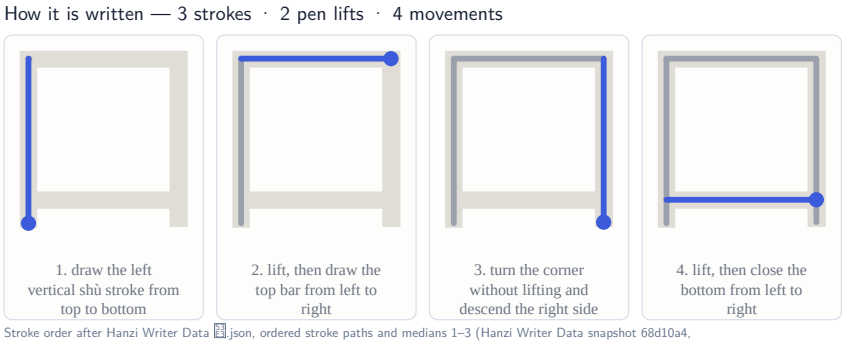
Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **pen** (3) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 口 and 日 – the second being the first with one bar added – and I can disagree in Mandarin by putting 不 in front of a word I already know, because Mandarin has no standalone word for no.
>
> *The first exchange in the book that contains a disagreement – a greeting, a question, and a refusal built by negating a word the reader has had since the opening lesson.*

4.1 口 — the box, on its own

Write 四. Walls, then the two inner strokes, then the bottom last.

Script — the shape



How 口 is written, stroke by stroke

口

Your hand can already write this. Three strokes, in exactly the order you learned inside 四, and the rule from there is the whole instruction:

1. the **left vertical**, top to bottom
2. the **top and right side in one turning stroke** — the *héngzhé*, across then down without lifting
3. the **bottom bar**, closing it — **last**

Three strokes, two pen lifts. Walls, then the door.

One honest note, because it will save you trouble later. The enclosing frame around 四 and this character are **not the same piece**, even though they are written identically. Chinese has a separate enclosure component that does the surrounding, and 口 is a character in its own right. What transfers here is the hand movement, not the identity — and the hand movement is most of the work.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 口 — left wall, turning stroke, bottom last
- 四, then 口 — the same movement, two different pieces

Before you move on

How many strokes? (**Three** — the turning corner counts as one.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.2 口 — mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere

Draw the box. Three strokes, bottom last.

The sounds and tones in this word

口 *kǒu* means **mouth**.
Look at it again now that it means something. **It is an open mouth, seen from the front** — squared off, the way every Chinese character is squared off to fit its block, but a picture all the same. The oldest forms are rounder and even more obviously a mouth.
kǒu is **third tone**, the low dipping one you have had since *nǐ*. Keep it low. *Twice through.*

Why it's said this way

You have already met pieces that live inside other characters — 女 and 子 sit inside 好. 口 is the commonest of them all. When you see it as a **small element in a corner** of a bigger character, it very often says the word has something to do with the **mouth**: speaking, eating, calling, tasting.
The size matters. A full-height frame around a whole character is a different piece doing a different job; the mouth hint is for the small one tucked into a corner.
That is worth more than the word itself. You are not going to memorise five thousand characters as pictures; you are going to learn a few hundred pieces and read the rest as combinations. 口 is one of the commonest pieces there is.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

口 *kǒu* is inherited from Middle Chinese *khuwX*, "mouth" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The open-mouth picture is the history of

the character; the word is the inherited one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kǒu** — low and dipping
- *Write it:* 口 — and say what it is a picture of

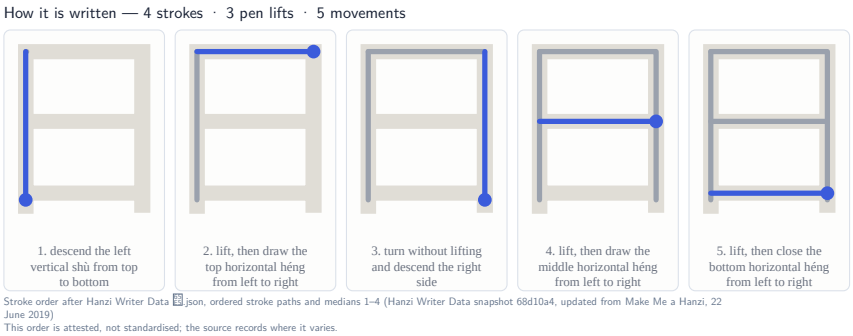
Before you move on

If you meet this box inside a bigger character, what does it usually hint at? (Something to do with the **mouth**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.3 日 — one bar inside the box

Draw the box. Now hold it in your head; you are about to fill it.

Script — the shape



How 日 is written, stroke by stroke

日

The same box, with one horizontal bar across the middle. That is the entire difference, and it buys you a second character.

Four strokes, and the order has one thing worth getting right:

1. the **left vertical**

2. the **top and right side**, one turning stroke
3. the **middle bar**
4. the **bottom bar**, closing it — still last

The middle bar goes in before the bottom. Fill the box, then shut it. That is the same instinct as the box rule itself, applied one level in: you never close a space you still have to write inside.

Three pen lifts. If your box was comfortable, this cost you one line.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 口, then 日 — the same four movements plus one
- 日 — and check that the middle bar went in before the bottom

Before you move on

How many strokes separate this character from the box? (**One**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.4 日 — the sun, and the day it measures

Write it: the box, then the box with a bar

Two characters, one shape.

The sounds and tones in this word

日 *rì* means **sun** — and also **day**.
The picture is the sun: a disc with a mark in the middle. Squared off, like everything else, but that is what the bar is doing there. The oldest forms are a circle with a dot.
rì is **fourth tone**, falling. The *r* is not an English *r* and not a Spanish one either: start where your tongue sits for the *s* in English *measure*, then **curl the tip back** a little. Let the vowel be short and tight.
Twice through:

Why it's said this way

Sun and **day** in the same word is not a Chinese quirk. It is what happens in language after language, because the sun is how a day was counted before anybody had a clock. English does the same thing from the other end: we say *the sun rose* and *three days later*, and nobody finds it strange that a *day* is both the light and the span.
So this is one of the rare characters where you get two meanings and have to learn neither: they are the same idea, and the context tells you which.
Like 口, this one turns up **inside** other characters, and when it does it is almost always about the sun, light, or time.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

日 *rì* is inherited from Middle Chinese *nyit*, "sun, day" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). It is usually compared with Tibetan *nyi ma*, "sun", a likely Sino-Tibetan cognate.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **rì** — falling, and the *r* of *measure*
- *Write it:* 日 — and say both of its meanings

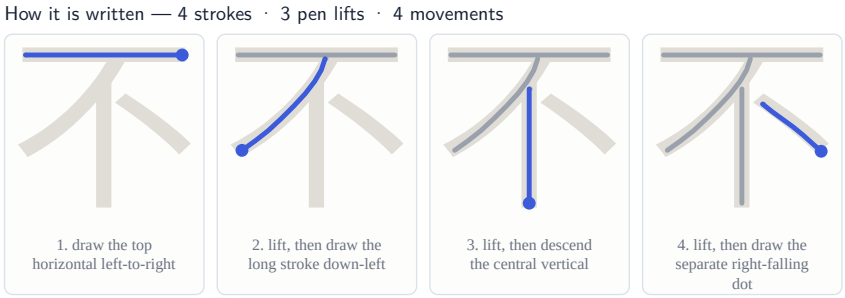
Before you move on

If you meet this shape inside a bigger character, what is it hinting at? (**Sun, light or time**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.5 不 — four strokes, all of them separate

Write 日. Middle bar before the bottom.

Script — the shape



How 不 is written, stroke by stroke

不

Four strokes, in this order:

1. a **top horizontal**, left to right
2. lift, then a **long stroke from the upper centre down to the left**
3. lift, then the **central vertical**, straight down
4. lift, then a **short right-falling dot**

Three pen lifts, and every stroke stands alone. Nothing joins here. That is unusual enough to be worth saying plainly: the boxes you have just written were one continuous movement in places, and this is the opposite — four deliberate, separate marks under a single roof.

The commonest beginner's version runs the second and third strokes together into a corner. They are not a corner. Lift.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 不 — top bar, the long left-falling stroke, the vertical, the dot
- it again, counting the lifts aloud. There should be three.

Before you move on

Do the second and third strokes meet in a corner? (**No** — lift between them.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.6 不 — how Mandarin says no

Write it: 不, counting three lifts

Then say **hǎo** — good.

The sounds and tones in this word

不 *bù* means **not**.
bù is **fourth tone**, falling — the same firm drop you learned on *èr* and *sì*. *Twice through.*

Grammar Lens: there is no word for "no"

Here is something that surprises nearly every learner, and it is better met now than discovered later.
Mandarin has no single word meaning "no."
English has one. So does French, Spanish, Russian. Mandarin does not. What it has instead is 不, which goes in front of a word and turns it around:

好 *hǎo* — good

不好 *bù hǎo* — not good

So when someone asks you a yes-or-no question in Mandarin, you do not answer with a word for "no". **You answer by negating the thing they asked about.** Ask whether something is 好, and "no" comes back as 不好.
This sounds like extra work and is actually less: you already know 好, so you already know how to refuse it, and the same holds for every word you have so far.
One word will break the pattern later — Mandarin has a second negator for *having*, and you will meet it with the word it belongs to. Everything in this book up to now takes 不.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

不 *bù* is inherited from Middle Chinese, and it is already a negator in the oldest Chinese writing. The Guangyun lists it as *pjuw* and as *pjut*, both "not" (in Baxter's transcription); Mandarin *bù* continues *pjut*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bù** — falling, firm
- *Say it:* **hǎo**, then **bù hǎo** — good, then not good
- *Write it:* 不好

Before you move on

You have known 好 since the first lesson. How much did its opposite cost you? (**One character**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.7 Practice — one box, two characters, and a refusal

Write it: 口, then 日 — one line apart

The exchange

Two voices, using only what you have:

A: 你好

ní hǎo

B: 你好

ní hǎo

A: 好

hǎo — good?

B: 不好

bù hǎo — not good.

Small, and it is the first time in this book you have been able to **disagree**. Up to now every exchange has been agreement: a greeting answered by the same greeting, a number read back. This one has a no in it.

What you've built this chapter

Three characters, and not one of them cost what it looks like it cost:

- 口 *kǒu*, mouth — you already knew the shape; it is the box from the number four, standing on its own
- 日 *rì*, sun and day — the same box with one bar added
- 不 *bù*, not — four separate strokes, and it turns every word you own into its opposite

That last one is the largest thing in the chapter. **不 does not add one word to your vocabulary; it doubles what you already have.** Everything you have learned to say so far, you have now learned to refuse.
And the two boxes are a down payment of a different kind. 口 and 日 both turn up **inside** other characters — mouth for speaking and eating, sun for light and time — so the next character that contains one will already be half read.

Your turn

- *Read it:* 口 日 不 — name each one, then say what it means
- *Write it:* 日 — and check the middle bar went in before the bottom
- *Say it:* **hǎo**, then **bù hǎo**

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's characters share a shape? (口 and 日.)
Back in the lift: a voice calls *sì*, then *èr*. Say each floor back, and say which of the two some panels leave out. (*Sì*, *èr* — and 四, four, is the one a panel may skip.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 5

Yes, No, and a Tone That Moves

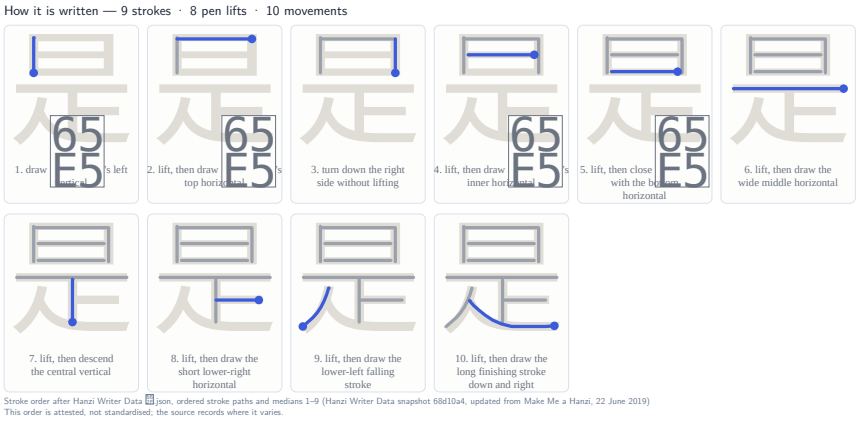
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) ↙ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 是 by finishing 日 before the body underneath, answer a yes-or-no question either way by keeping or negating the word I was asked about, and apply the rule that 不 rises before a falling tone even though the writing never shows it.
>
> *The first exchange in which the reader can answer either way – 是 for yes, 不是 for no – and hear the negator's pitch rise on a page that records no such thing.*

5.1 是 — finish the sun, then build under it

Write 日. Four strokes, middle bar before the bottom.

Script — the shape



How 是 is written, stroke by stroke

是

Nine strokes. That is more than double anything you have written, and it is the point at which counting strokes stops being useful and structure takes over.

Here is the structure, and it makes the character easy: **是 is 日 sitting on top of a body.** You have written the top already.

1-4. **日, complete.** Left vertical; top and right in one turning stroke; the middle bar; the bottom bar closing it. Exactly as you learned it.

Then, underneath:

1. a **wide horizontal**, wider than the 日 above it
2. a **central vertical** coming down
3. a **short horizontal** at the lower right
4. a **falling stroke** to the lower left
5. a **long finishing stroke** down to the right

Finish 日 before you begin the body. This is the same instinct as the box rule and the middle bar: complete an enclosed unit before moving on. Chinese stroke order is a small number of habits applied over and over, and you now have three of them.

Eight pen lifts. Take it slowly; nobody writes this quickly at first.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 日 on its own, then 是 — and notice the first four strokes are identical
- 是 again, saying "sun first" before you start

Before you move on

How many of the nine strokes did you already know? (**Four**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

5.2 是 — "is", and the nearest thing to "yes"

Write it: 是 — sun first, then the body

The sounds and tones in this word

是 *shì* means **is** — am, is, are, all one word with no changes for person or number.
shì is **fourth tone**, falling. The initial is the same retroflex position you met on *rì*: tongue tip curled back, and this time unvoiced — closer to the *sh* of English *shirt* than to *s*. *Twice through.*

Grammar Lens: yes by echo

You already know that Mandarin has no single word for **no** — you negate the word you were asked about. The other half of that rule is now available to you:
Mandarin has no single word for "yes" either. You echo the word back.
Asked whether something 是, you answer 是. That is the yes. It is not a separate word meaning agreement; it is the word you were asked about, returned.
It is not the *only* way Mandarin says yes — spoken Mandarin has other affirmatives you will meet in time. It is the one that follows from what you already know, and the one that works whenever the question hands you a word to give back.
Neither half of the pair is the word an English speaker goes looking for.

This is worth holding onto, because it is the shape of a great many Mandarin answers: **the reply is the question's own word, kept or turned.** You have the keeping half now; the turning half is the next lesson, and you already own the character it needs.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

是 *shì* is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzyeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). In the oldest texts it meant "this"; its use as "to be" came later, and Unihan still lists both senses.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shì** — falling, tongue curled back
- *Say it:* **shì** as an answer meaning "yes"
- *Write it:* 是

Before you move on

What is the yes, asked about 是? (是 — the same word, returned.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

5.3 不是 — "is not", and the second tone that moves

Say **shì**. Then say **bù**. Both fall.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

不是

Nothing new on the page: 不 in front of 是, exactly the rule you already have. It means **is not**.
But say the two words you just warmed up with, one after the other, and something is wrong. **bù** falls. **shì** falls. Two sharp drops in a row, back to back, and your mouth does not want to make them.
Both words are inherited from Middle Chinese: *pjut*, "not", and *dzyeX*, "this, to be" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Why it's said this way

Mandarin does not make you do it. 不 **changes its own tone rather than collide.**

written: 不是 — *bù* + *shì*

spoken: **bú shì** — *bú* **rises**

不 becomes second tone, rising, whenever a fourth tone follows it. Before anything else it stays *bù*, falling — which is why 不好 was *bù hǎo*, unchanged, with 好 in the third tone.
You have met this exact machinery once before. When two third tones met in 你好, the first one moved and became rising, so *nǐ hǎo* came out as *ní hǎo*. Same problem, same kind of solution: **when two tones would clash, the first one gives way, and the spelling never records it.**
That is the **second** rule of this kind you have been taught in full, and both share one warning: **the page will not tell you.** You were also warned about a third, on 一, which shifts its own tone in front of certain syllables — that one is still waiting, and it will arrive with the words that need it. 不是 is written with the falling-tone 不 every time. The change lives in the mouth, and you have to carry it yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **bù**, then **shì**, deliberately clashing. Hear why it is awkward.
- **bú shì** — the first one rising now
- **bù hǎo**, then **bú shì** — falling, then rising, and say why

Before you move on

Does the writing change when the tone does? (**No** — 不是 is written the same way every time.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

5.4 Practice — answering either way

Write it: 是 — sun first, then the body underneath

The exchange

Two voices, and for the first time the second one has a real choice:

A: 你好

ní hǎo

B: 你好

ní hǎo

A: 是

shì — is it?

B: 是

shì — yes.

And the same exchange, refused:

A: 是

shì

B: 不是

bú shì — no.

Say the last line twice and listen to the first syllable. It **rises**. Written down, it falls. That gap between the page and the mouth is the whole lesson.

What you've built this chapter

One character, and with it both answers.
是 is nine strokes, the longest thing you have written — but four of them were 日, finished before the body began, and that is why it was manageable. The habit of completing an enclosed piece before moving

on has now carried you through a box, a box with a bar, and a nine-stroke character built on top of one.
And the pair is closed. Mandarin gives you neither a word for yes nor a word for no; it gives you one word and two things to do with it. 是 keeps it. 不是 turns it. Every yes-or-no answer you learn from here will work the same way.
The tone rule is the part to carry away, because nothing on the page will remind you: 不 **rises before a falling tone.** That is the second such rule taught in full, after the one on 你好, and a third — on 一 — has been flagged and not yet taught. Every one of them is invisible in the writing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shì**, then **bú shì** — yes, then no
- *Say it:* **bù hǎo**, then **bú shì** — and say which one moved, and why
- *Write it:* 是, then 不是

Before you move on

Do either of the rules you have been taught show up in the writing? (**Neither**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 6

See You Again

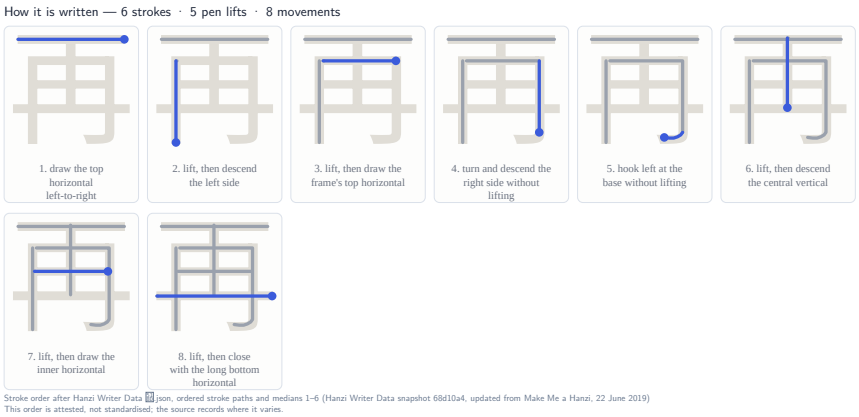
Modes: **voice** (2) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 再 and 见, say goodbye with 再见, read the word literally as "see again" because its two pieces genuinely add up, and name which expressions I know are spoken differently from how they are written.
>
> *The first exchange in the track that opens, turns and closes – greeting, an answer either way, and a parting – with every line built from characters the reader has written rather than a phrase memorised whole.*

6.1 再 — a bar, a frame, and a line that closes it

Write 是. Nine strokes, and the sun on top finished first.

Script — the shape



How 再 *is written, stroke by stroke*

再

Six strokes. Fewer than the last one, and the structure is easier to see: a horizontal bar across the top, a frame hanging underneath it, and a long horizontal closing the whole thing at the bottom.

1. the **top horizontal**, left to right
2. the **left side**, coming straight down
3. the **frame**: start again at the upper left, cross to the right, **turn down** the right side, and **hook left** at the base — all without lifting
4. the **central vertical**, down through the middle
5. the **inner horizontal**, left to right
6. the **long bottom horizontal**, left to right, wider than everything above it

Five pen lifts.

Stroke 3 is the one to watch. It is a **single stroke that changes direction twice** — across, down, then a hook to the left. You have met most of it before: the outer wall of a box is always one turning stroke, never two or three. Compare it with the frame you drew in 日 — the same across-and-down turn, with a hook added at the end.

And the closing bar is last. **The box is not sealed until the end** — the same rule that made you draw the middle bar of 日 before its bottom bar. Chinese stroke order keeps re-using a small set of habits, and this is one you now know well enough to expect.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 再 — bar, left side, then the turning frame in one movement
- *Write it:* 再 again, and count the lifts. There are five.
- *Say it:* **zài** — falling, from high to low

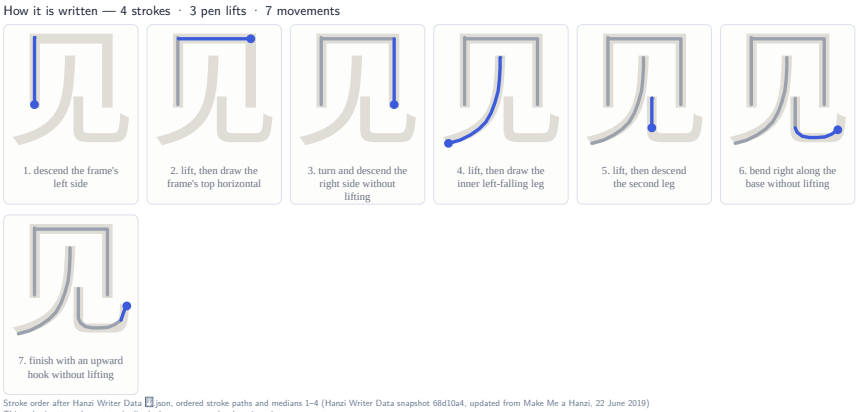
Before you move on

Which stroke of 再 is drawn last? (**The long bottom bar**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

6.2 见 — an eye on two legs

Write 人. Two strokes, left before right, a figure on two legs.

Script — the shape



How 见 *is written, stroke by stroke*

见

Four strokes, and after the last two characters that will feel like a rest. It is built in two parts, top and bottom:

- on top, a **frame** — a narrow box, which the traditional reading takes to be an **eye**
- underneath, **two legs**, written 儿 — which is what 人 becomes when it has to stand underneath something

The legs have changed a little in this position. The left one still falls away to the lower left exactly as it did. The right one no longer just presses down: it descends, **bends right along the base, and finishes with a hook upward**. That is what a leg does when it has to carry a frame above it.

The order:

1. the frame's **left side**, coming down
2. the frame's **top**, turning down the **right side** — one stroke, no lift, and this one is exactly the turn you drew in 日, hook and all absent
3. the **left leg**, falling to the lower left
4. the **right leg**: down, bend right, hook up — one stroke, no lift

Three pen lifts. Two of the four strokes turn, and neither of them is allowed to be broken into pieces.

A frame over a person, and the word means "to see." That is a memory hook, not a proof — but it is the kind of hook this book has been giving you in place of a shared ancestor with English, and this one is unusually easy to hold.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 人, then 见 — and find the legs in the second one
- *Write it:* 见, stopping after stroke 2 to check the frame is closed on three sides
- *Say it:* **jiàn** — falling

Before you move on

How does the last stroke finish? (**With a hook, upward**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

6.3 再见 — the word that says what it means

Write it: 再, then 见 — six strokes, then four

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

再见

再见 *zàijiàn* — **goodbye**. Two characters, one word, and you can already write both of them.
Now the meanings, which have been held back until you had the shapes:

- 再 *zài* means **again**
- 见 *jiàn* means **see**

So the word is **"see again."** That is no mnemonic: it is what the two characters say, and what the word means.
Every earlier component gave you a *hook* — 亻 at the left of 你, 女 beside 子 in 好 — labelled a memory aid rather than history. **Here the parts add up.** Chinese does this often. Start expecting it.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *tsojH*, "a second time", and *kenH*, "see" (Guangyun).

The sounds and tones in this word

Both syllables are **fourth tone**. Both fall.
Say it slowly: *zài* falls, then *jiàn* falls. Two separate drops. The common mistake is to run them into one long slide. Reset your pitch upward between them. *Twice through.*
And no *rule* moves. Neither of the two tone rules you have been taught applies to two fourth tones, so **再见 is said with the tones it is written with.** A native speaker does clip that first fall a little short

— but that is a shading of the same tone, not a different one, and neither the characters nor the pinyin change. Which is the point: the shadings live in the mouth.

Why it's said this way

If you know any German: *auf Wiedersehen* is "on seeing again" — the same two pieces, in the same order. A coincidence of thinking, not of ancestry; **Chinese and German share no common ancestor.** But parting by promising to meet again is an idea many languages reach for on their own, and that makes 再见 far easier to hold than a shape memorised cold.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **zàijiàn** — two falls, resetting the pitch between them
- *Read it:* 再见 — give its literal reading before its translation

Before you move on

Does either tone move in 再见? (**No — both fall, and nothing changes**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

6.4 Practice — a conversation that ends

Say **zàijiàn**. Two falls, with the pitch reset between them.

The exchange

Everything below is a character you have written yourself. *Read it:* the exchange straight through

A: 你好

ní hǎo — hello.

B: 你好

ní hǎo — hello.

A: 是

shì — is it?

B: 不是

bú shì — no.

A: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

B: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

That is a conversation with a beginning, a middle and an end. It is short, and it is real: two people meet, one asks something, the other declines it, and both leave properly. **Nothing in it is a phrase you memorised whole.** You built every line from characters and rules.

What you've built — and what stays invisible

Read it: the exchange out loud once more, and count the places where your mouth does something the page does not record

- 你好 is written with two low dipping tones and spoken *ní hǎo* — the first one rises.
- 不是 is written with a falling 不 and spoken *bú shì* — the 不 rises.
- 再见 is written with two falls and spoken with two falls. No rule moves.

Two out of three. That ratio is not a fluke, and it is the single most useful thing to know about reading Mandarin aloud: **the writing records the words, not the way the words meet each other.** From here on, whenever two pieces sit side by side, ask what happens between them.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping

- *Say it:* it again, taking B's side, and answer 是 instead of 不是
- *Write it:* 再见 — six strokes, then four

Before you move on

In this exchange, how many of the three expressions are spoken exactly as written? (**One** — 再见.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 7

Good Morning, and a Rule That Declines to Fire

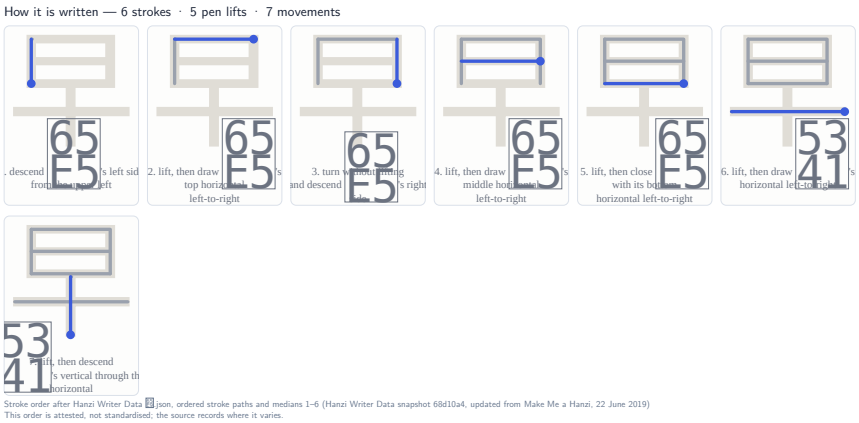
Modes: **voice** (3) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 早 and 上, greet someone with 早上好, hear a neutral-tone syllable as the absence of a tone mark rather than a mistake, and say why the third-tone rule changes 你好 but leaves 早上好 alone.
>
> *The first exchange where the reader chooses between two correct greetings rather than reciting the only one available – and the first place all three tone behaviours in the track line up side by side, one moving and two declining to.*

7.1 早 — sun on top, one more time

Write 日. Four strokes. Middle bar before the bottom bar.

Script — the shape



How 早 is written, stroke by stroke

早

Six strokes, and you can already guess how it starts.

早 is 日 on top of 十. You have written the sun before. The piece underneath is 十, which on its own is the character for **ten** — you have not been taught it and you do not need it today. Treat it as two strokes: one across, one down through it.

1-4. **日, complete.** Left side; top and right in one turning stroke; the middle bar; the bottom bar closing it.

1. **十's horizontal**, left to right
2. **十's vertical**, coming down *through* that horizontal

Five pen lifts.

Predict the rule before you read it: does 日 get finished first? It does — the same habit that made 是 manageable, and by now it should be doing the work for you rather than the instruction.

A word about what 早 means, offered as a memory hook and labelled as one: the sun sitting above a short line is easy to read as **the sun just up over the horizon**, and 早 means **early**. That is a picture worth keeping. It is not a proof, and the honest position is that the lower piece's history is disputed.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 日, then 早 — and stop after four strokes to check the sun is closed
- *Say it:* **zǎo** — low and dipping

Before you move on

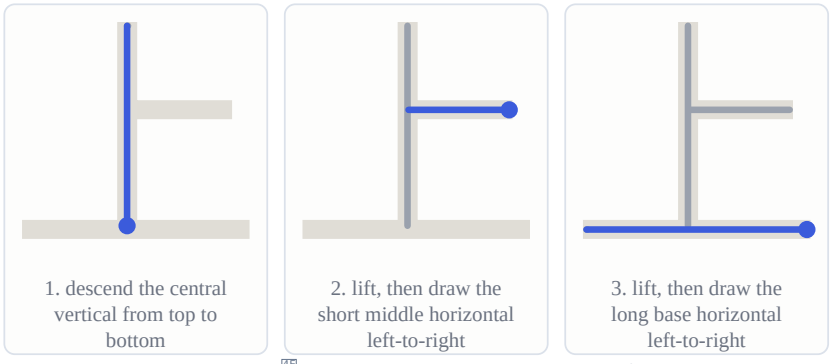
Which way does the last stroke go? (**Down, through the horizontal.**)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

7.2 上 — the same rule, read the other way

Write 早. Sun first, then the two strokes below.

Script — the shape

How it is written — 3 strokes · 2 pen lifts · 3 movements



1. descend the central vertical from top to bottom
2. lift, then draw the short middle horizontal left-to-right
3. lift, then draw the long base horizontal left-to-right

Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 上.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 上 is written, stroke by stroke

上

Three strokes. A vertical, a short horizontal to its right, and a long horizontal underneath.

Now guess the order, and expect to be wrong:

1. the **central vertical**, from the top down
2. the **short horizontal**, left to right, starting at the vertical
3. the **long base horizontal**, left to right

Two pen lifts.

The vertical comes first, and you wrote the opposite one lesson ago. Inside 早, the two strokes of 十 went **horizontal first, then the vertical down through it**. Here the order is reversed.

The difference is what the two strokes do to each other. In 十 they **cross**, and the horizontal leads. In 上 the short bar **starts at** the vertical instead of crossing it — so there is nothing to cross, and the vertical goes first.

That is worth meeting on a three-stroke character, because it tells you something true about the system: these are **strong tendencies with conditions**, not laws. Learn the condition and you can predict the order instead of memorising it.

The other thing to notice: **short horizontal before long horizontal.** The base bar is the widest stroke and it goes last, exactly as the closing bar did in 再. When two horizontals differ in length, the long one is usually the finisher.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 上 — vertical first, even though your hand will want the short bar
- *Write it:* 上 again, and say "short, then long" as you draw the two bars
- *Say it:* **shàng** — falling

Before you move on

Which of the two horizontals is drawn last? (**The long one**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

7.3 早上 — morning, and a syllable that goes light

Say **zǎo**. Low and dipping, and hold the bottom of it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

早上

早上 *zǎoshang* — **morning**.
The parts add up again, though less tidily than 再见 did. 早 is *early*; 上 on its own means *up* or *on top*. Early-up, the early part of the day. Take that as a hook rather than a definition: what you need is that the two characters you just wrote make the word for morning.
Both halves are inherited from Middle Chinese: *tsawX*, "early, dawn", and *dzyangH*, "above" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

The sounds and tones in this word

The pinyin for this word is *zǎoshang* — and **上 has lost its tone mark.**
On its own 上 is *shàng*, fourth tone, falling — you practised it that way. Inside this word it goes **neutral**: short, light, and pitched by whatever came before it. Neutral syllables are written with **no mark at all**, and that absence is the information.
This is a fifth thing a syllable can do, alongside the four tones. It is not a tone that moves — you have met two of those — it is a syllable **giving up its tone** because it is unstressed. *Twice through.*
Careful or slow speech sometimes restores the full falling tone, *zǎoshàng*, and you will hear it. The standard reading, and the one to imitate, is the light one.
Say it: *zǎo* low and dipping, then *shang* light and quick, riding on the end. The commonest mistake is to give the second syllable a full falling tone out of habit, which makes the word sound like two words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **shàng** alone, falling — then **zǎoshang**, with the second syllable light
- **zǎoshang** twice more, and say aloud which syllable carries no tone

Before you move on

Does 上 keep its falling tone when it stands alone? (**Yes** — the light reading belongs to the word, not to the character.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

7.4 早上好 — the greeting was a pattern all along

Say **zǎoshang**. Second syllable light.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

早上好

早上好 *zǎoshang hǎo* — **good morning**.
It ends in 好 — the same character, the same word, that you met in the first greeting in this book.
That is the payoff, and it is worth being explicit about. 你好 was never a phrase to swallow whole. It is 你 *you* followed by 好 *good*, and the second half is reusable:

你 + 好 → 你好, and 早上 + 好 → 早上好

Put a person or a time in front of 好 and you have a greeting. You have not learned two greetings; you have learned a **frame** and filled it twice. Every one of the other times of day works the same way, and you will be able to build those greetings the moment you have the words for those times.
Every piece is inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsawX* "early", *dzyangH* "above" and *xawX* "good" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and Chinese put the greeting together from them.

The sounds and tones in this word

You know a rule about two third tones meeting: the first one rises, which is why 你好 is said *ní hǎo*.
早 is third tone. 好 is third tone. So does 早上好 become *záoshang hǎo*?
No — and the reason is the whole point of a rule having conditions. The rule needs the two third tones to be **next to each**

other. Here they are not: 上 sits between them. A light, toneless syllable is still a syllable, and it keeps the two dipping tones apart. So *zǎoshang hǎo*: 早 low, 上 light, 好 low and dipping. Nothing rises.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **nǐ hǎo**, then **zǎoshang hǎo** — and say which one moved
- **zǎoshang**, then **zǎoshang hǎo** — the greeting is the word plus 好

Before you move on

Why does the third-tone rule not fire in this greeting? (**The two third tones are not next to each other**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

7.5 Practice — greeting the time of day

Say **zǎoshang hǎo**. Low, light, low.

The exchange

A: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

B: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

A: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

B: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

Short, and for the first time you had a **choice** to make. 你好 would also have been correct. 早上好 is the one that fits the hour, and choosing between them is a thing a speaker does, not a thing a phrasebook does for you.

What you've built — three tones, three behaviours

Line the greetings up and every tone behaviour you have been taught is visible at once:

- 你好 — two third tones, side by side. The first **rises**: *ní hǎo*.
- 早上好 — two third tones, held apart by a light syllable. **Neither moves**.
- 再见 — two falling tones. **Neither moves.**

That middle line is the one that repays study. It is the same rule as the first line, and it does not fire, because the condition it needs is not met. **A rule you can only apply is half a rule; a rule you can also decline to apply is a whole one.**
And none of it shows on the page. Every character in all three is written exactly as it would be alone.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo**, then **zǎoshang hǎo** — and say which one moved
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 早上好, then 再见

Before you move on

Which of the three expressions above has a tone that moves? (**Only 你好.**)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 8

Saying Who You Are

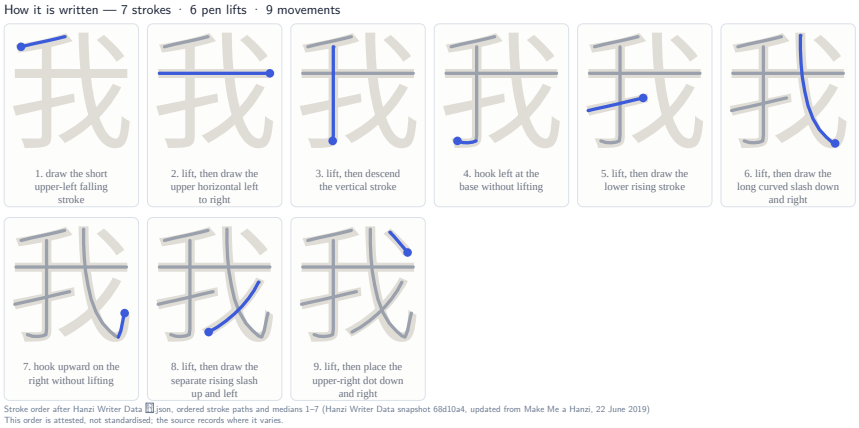
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) ↙ **pen** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 我, 名 and 字, introduce myself with 我是 and my own name, recognise 名字 as the word for a name, and I know that Mandarin never changes a word to show what job it is doing in a sentence.
>
> *The first exchange the reader cannot finish without supplying something of their own – their name – and the first place the book names a gap it is choosing not to fill, rather than teaching a sentence no speaker would say.*

8.1 我 — seven strokes, and an honest admission

Write 是. Nine strokes, sun finished on top.

Script — the shape



How 我 is written, stroke by stroke

我

Seven strokes, and here this book owes you a straight answer.

Every character so far has had **at least one piece you already owned**: 你 is 亻 beside 尔, 是 sits on 日, 早 sits on 日. 我 **has none.** Its right side is a shape called 戈 — there it is, but naming it is all this lesson will do with it, because you have not been taught to write it. Its left side is a squeezed hand. Neither is a piece you own.

So learn it as a **route**, not as a sum. Follow the order and it holds together:

1. a short **falling stroke** at the upper left
2. the **upper horizontal**, left to right
3. the **vertical**, coming down and **hooking left** without lifting
4. the **lower rising stroke**
5. the **long curved slash** down to the right, **hooking upward** at its end
6. a separate **rising slash** up to the left
7. a **dot** at the upper right, pressed down-right

Six pen lifts.

Two of these are joined strokes that must not be broken: **stroke 3** (down, then hook) and **stroke 5** (the long slash, then hook up). Everything you have learned about turning strokes applies here — the pen changes direction, the stroke does not end.

The dot goes **last**. Small marks at the upper right are finishers, and you will see that again.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 我 slowly, twice — and keep strokes 3 and 5 unbroken
- *Write it:* 我 once more, saving the dot for last
- *Say it:* **wǒ** — low and dipping

Before you move on

Is this character built from pieces you already know? (**No** — and this book would rather say so than invent a story.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

8.2 我 — I, me, and saying who you are

Say **wǒ**. Low and dipping, and hold the bottom of it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

我 *wǒ* — **I**. And also **me**.
English uses two words there and swaps between them depending on the job: *I saw her*, *she saw me*. **Mandarin uses 我 for both**, and this is your first sight of something that will save you a great deal of work: **Mandarin never changes a word to show what job it is doing in a sentence.** No I/me swap, no case endings, no agreeing with a subject. 我 is 我 in either seat.
Mandarin does bolt small extra pieces onto words for *other* jobs, and you will meet them — but never to mark who is doing what to whom.
Now put it to work with a word you already have:

我是 *wǒ shì* — **I am**

是 is the word you learned for answering yes. Its actual job is to link two things: 我是 and then who you are. Say your own name after it and you have introduced yourself.
There is a second way to say this, built on a word you do not have yet. 我是 **is not a stand-in for it** — both are real, and this is the one you can write today.
Two third tones meet in *wǒ shì*? No — 是 is **fourth** tone. Nothing moves.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **wǒ**, then **wǒ shì** — low and dipping, then falling
- *Say it:* **wǒ shì** followed by your own name, out loud, twice
- *Write it:* 我是

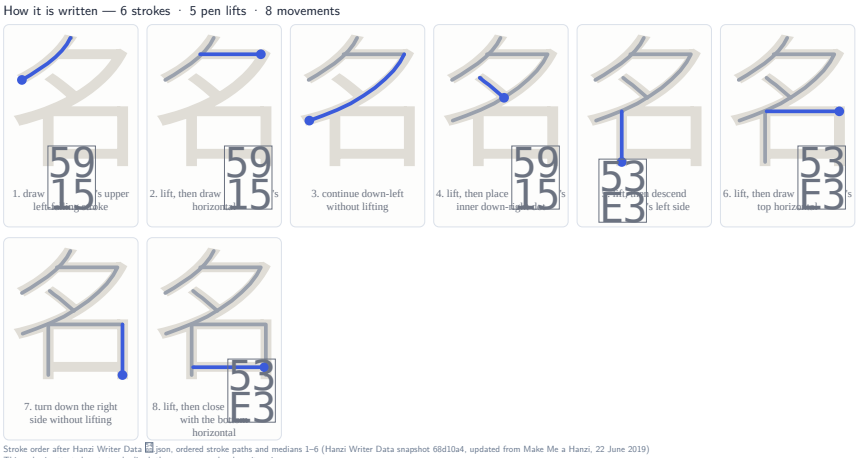
Before you move on

What does 是 do in 我是? (**It links you to whatever comes next**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

8.3 名 — a mouth with something above it

Write 口. Three strokes, and the box is not closed until the last one.

Script — the shape



How 名 is written, stroke by stroke

名

Six strokes, and three of them are 口, which you already own.

名 is 夕 sitting on top of 口. The lower half is the mouth. The upper half is 夕, a shape this book has not taught you as a character of its own — here it is a piece, and naming it is enough:

1. **夕's upper falling stroke**, down to the left
2. **夕's horizontal**, continuing **down-left without lifting** — one stroke
3. **夕's inner dot**, pressed down-right

4-6. **口, complete.** Left side; top and right in one turning stroke; the bottom bar closing it.

Five pen lifts.

Finish 夕 before you begin 口 — the same instinct as finishing 日 before the body of 是, and finishing the sun before 十 in 早. You have now met that rule often enough that it should feel like the obvious thing to do.

A hook worth having, offered as a hook: 夕 is the shape used for **evening**, and a mouth beneath it reads easily as **speaking your name in the dark, when you cannot be seen**. That is a traditional story, not proven history — but 名 does mean **name**, and the picture makes the character stick.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 口 alone, then 名 — and notice the last three strokes are identical
- *Write it:* 名 again, keeping stroke 2 unbroken
- *Say it:* **míng** — rising

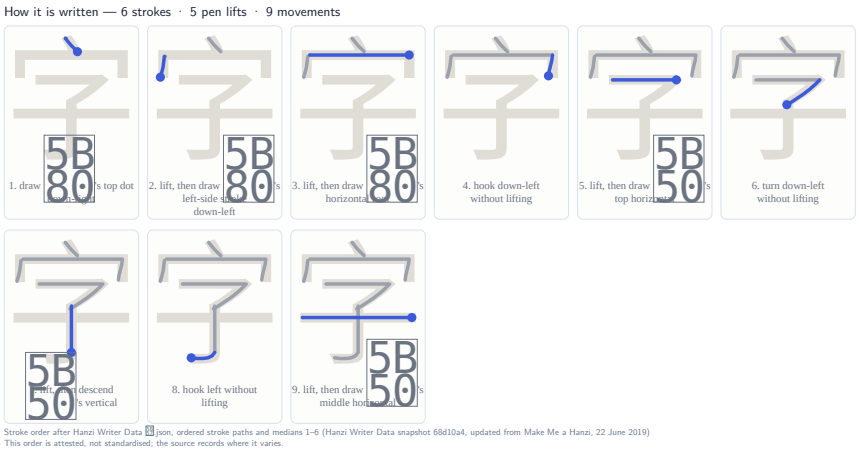
Before you move on

Which half goes first? (**The top** — as always.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

8.4 字 — a child under a roof

Write 子, the child — the piece that stands beside 女 in 好.

Script — the shape



How 字 is written, stroke by stroke

字

Six strokes, and the bottom three are 子, which you have written since the first chapter.

字 is 子 under a roof. The roof is 宀, a piece rather than a character — three strokes that make a lid:

1. **宀's top dot**, pressed down-right
2. **宀's left side**, a short stroke down-left
3. **宀's horizontal roof**, running right and **hooking down-left** at its end — one stroke

4-6. **子, complete.** Its top horizontal turning down-left; its vertical with a left hook; its middle horizontal last.

Five pen lifts.

Roof before child. A covering piece is finished before whatever sits under it, which is the same habit as 日 before the body of 是 and 夕 before 口 in 名.

And now the meaning, which is the reason this character is worth the effort. 字 *zì* means **character** — a written Chinese character. It is the word for the thing you have been learning to make since the first page of this book. The roof-and-child picture is the traditional hook: something raised and kept under shelter.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 子 alone, then 字 — the difference is a roof
- *Write it:* 字, saying "roof first" before you start
- *Say it:* **zì** — falling

Before you move on

Which goes first, the roof or the child? (**The roof**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

8.5 名字 — the word for a name

Say **zǎoshang**. Second syllable light and short.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

名字 *míngzi* — **name**.
Both halves are characters you have just written, and both mean something:

- 名 *míng* — **name**
- 字 *zì* — **character**, a written unit

So the word is **"name-character"**, and that is not a stretched hook. A Chinese personal name *is* a small number of characters, usually two or three, each chosen deliberately for what it means. The word for "name" says what a name is made of.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *mjieng*, "name", and *dziH*, "written character" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

The sounds and tones in this word

míngzi, not *míngzì*.
字 is fourth tone standing alone, and you practised it that way — but in this word it goes **neutral**, short and light, exactly as 上 did inside 早上. Second syllables do this often, and you now know the signal: **no tone mark means no tone.**
míng rises; *zi* rides on the end of it. *Twice through.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **zì** alone, falling — then **míngzi**, with the second syllable light
- **míngzi** twice, and say what each of its two halves means

Before you move on

Which syllable of *míngzi* carries no tone? (**The second**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

8.6 Practice — saying who you are

Say **wǒ shì** — low and dipping, then falling.

The exchange

Two people meet in the morning. The gap in the third line is yours to fill.

A: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

B: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

A: 我是 …

wǒ shì … — I am … (your name).

B: 我是 …

wǒ shì … — I am … (their name).

A: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

Say it with your own name in it, out loud. That is the first time this book has asked you for something it could not supply.

What you've built — and one thing deliberately withheld

You can now greet by time of day, say who you are, and leave. Every line is built from characters you have written.
One honest gap, and it is worth naming rather than hiding. You have the word for **name** — 名字 — but not yet the way to **ask** for someone's. The natural Mandarin question needs a word this book has not given you, and asking it with only the pieces you have would mean teaching you a sentence a speaker would not say. It is coming, and it is worth waiting for.
What 名字 buys you now is real: you can recognise the word when someone else uses it, and you know that a name is **characters** — which is why a Chinese speaker asked about their name will often tell you which characters it uses.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **wǒ shì**, then your own name, three times
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, taking both parts
- *Write it:* 我是, then 名字

Before you move on

Can you yet ask someone else for their name? (**Not yet** — and the book would rather say so than hand you a sentence nobody says.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 9

What?

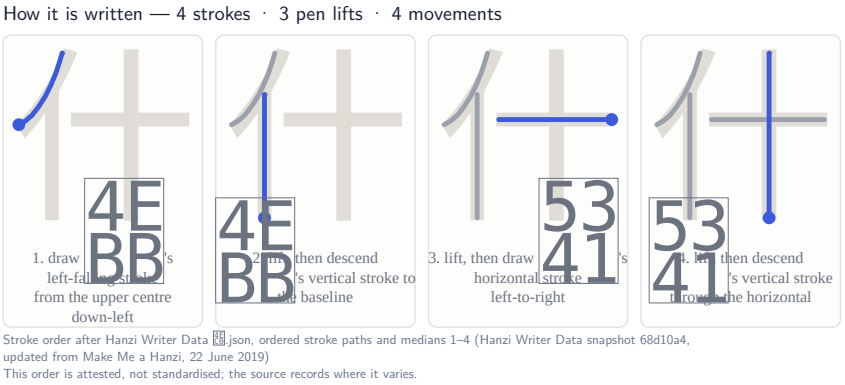
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) ✓ **pen** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 什 and 么, ask 什么 to mean what, use it on its own to get something repeated, judge that it is blunt with a stranger, and I know its two characters carry the word's sound rather than its meaning.
>
> *The first exchange in the track that goes wrong – one speaker mishears – and the first the reader can repair, which matters more than another memorised line because it is what keeps a conversation alive when the Mandarin runs out.*

9.1 什 — both halves are old news

Write 亻, the standing person — two strokes, at the left edge of a block.

Script — the shape



How 什 is written, stroke by stroke

什

Four strokes, and after 我 that will feel like a rest.
什 **is** 亻 **beside** 十, and you have met both:

- 亻 you wrote in the very first word of this book, standing at the left of 你
- 十 you drew inside 早, underneath the sun

1. 亻**'s falling stroke**, from the upper centre down to the left
2. 亻**'s vertical**, straight down to the baseline
3. 十**'s horizontal**, left to right
4. 十**'s vertical**, down *through* that horizontal

Three pen lifts.

Finish 亻 **before starting** 十 — left before right, the oldest habit you have. And inside 十, horizontal before vertical, because the two cross.

A note on 十, since this is the second time it has turned up without being taught. It is the character for **ten**, and you still do not need to write it on its own. When it eventually arrives as a character in its own right, you will already have drawn it twice.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 亻 alone, then 什 — the second half is two strokes
- *Write it:* 什 again, saying "person, then ten"
- *Say it:* **shén** — rising

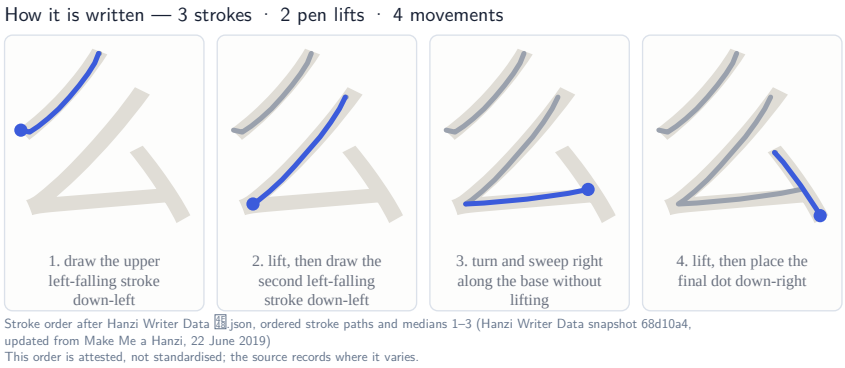
Before you move on

Which stroke of 十 comes first? (**The horizontal** — the two cross.) Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

9.2 么 — three strokes, and one of them turns

Write 什. Person on the left, ten on the right.

Script — the shape



How 么 is written, stroke by stroke

么

Three strokes, and the middle one does the work:

1. a short **falling stroke** at the top, down to the left

2. a second **falling stroke** down-left that **turns without lifting** and **sweeps right** along the base

3. a **dot**, pressed down-right

Two pen lifts.

Stroke 2 is one movement, not two: down-left, then a turn, then out to the right. Lift in the middle of it and you have written something else. You have handled this before — the frame of 再, the leg of 见 — and the instinct is the same: **the pen turns, the stroke does not end.**

The dot goes last, as it did in 我.

The sounds and tones in this word

么 is *me* — and that is the whole pronunciation. **No tone mark, because it has no tone.**
You met neutral syllables inside words, where 上 and 字 gave their tones up. 么 is different: it is neutral in the dictionary, standing alone. Some characters simply never carry a tone, and this is your first.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 么 — and keep stroke 2 unbroken through its turn
- *Say it:* **me** — short, light, flat, no shape to it at all

Before you move on

Why does this character have no tone mark? (**Because it has no tone**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

9.3 什么 — what

Say **me**. Short and flat, no tone at all.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

什么 *shénme* — **what**.
shén rises; *me* is light and toneless behind it. Both characters are ones

you have already written.
This one is different in kind from everything before it. 你好, 是, 不是, 再见, 早上好, 我是 — every one of those **gives** something. 什么 **asks.** It is the first word in this book whose job is to get something back from the other person.
Here the honest note this book owes you: the two halves of 什么 do **not** add up the way 再见's did. 再 and 见 each brought their meaning into the word. 什 and 么 bring only their **sound** — 什 is standing in for how this word is pronounced, not for anything it means.
And keep the levels apart. The pieces you drew *inside* 什 — the person and the ten — belong to that **character**, not to this **word**. "Person plus ten" explains nothing about *what*. Some words are built; others are not.
Where the word comes from is not settled. It appears in writing from about the Tang dynasty, spelled several ways, and its two characters were chosen for their sound.

Why it's said this way

什么? by itself means **"What?"** — the thing you say when you did not catch what someone said. That is real, everyday Mandarin and it is the most useful thing you can do with this word today.
One caution, because register matters and this book would rather tell you than let you find out. A bare **什么?** is **blunt** — closer to English "What?" than to "Sorry?". Between friends it is unremarkable. To a stranger, or to anyone you would be careful with, it lands harder than you intend, and Mandarin has gentler ways to ask for a repeat that need words you do not have yet.
So: use it, and know what it weighs.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shénme** — rising, then light
- *Say it:* **shénme?** as a question, as though you missed something
- *Write it:* 什么

Before you move on

Do the two halves of 什么 add up to its meaning? (**No** — they are there for sound.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

9.4 Practice — when you did not catch it

Say **shénme** — rising, then light.

The exchange

Two people meet. One of them mishears. Fill both gaps with real names.

A: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

B: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

A: 我是 …

wǒ shì … — I am …

B: 什么?

shénme? — what?

A: 我是 …

wǒ shì … — I am … (said again, slower)

B: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

That fourth line is the point of the chapter. Until now every exchange in this book has gone perfectly, which is not what conversations do. **B did not catch it, said so, and got it repeated.** That is a repair, and being able to make one is worth more than another memorised phrase — it is what keeps a conversation alive when your Mandarin runs out.

What you've built — and the question you still cannot ask

You can greet by the hour, say who you are, ask for a repeat when you miss something, and leave.
The gap named last chapter is still open, and it is worth being precise about what changed. You now have 什么, the *what* of "what is your name?" — but not yet the rest of that sentence. Both halves of the question exist in Mandarin; this book has handed you one of them. The other needs a character the font in this book cannot yet print, which is a dull reason, and a true one.
So the honest position: **什么 is a question word you can use today** in the ways above, and a piece of a question you will finish later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, including the mishearing
- **shénme?** twice — once flat and clipped, once softened and drawn out on the rise. Same word; the second is the one you would risk on a stranger

Before you move on

Is a bare 什么? gentle or blunt? (**Blunt** — fine with friends, heavy with strangers.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 10

One Character, Two Courtesies

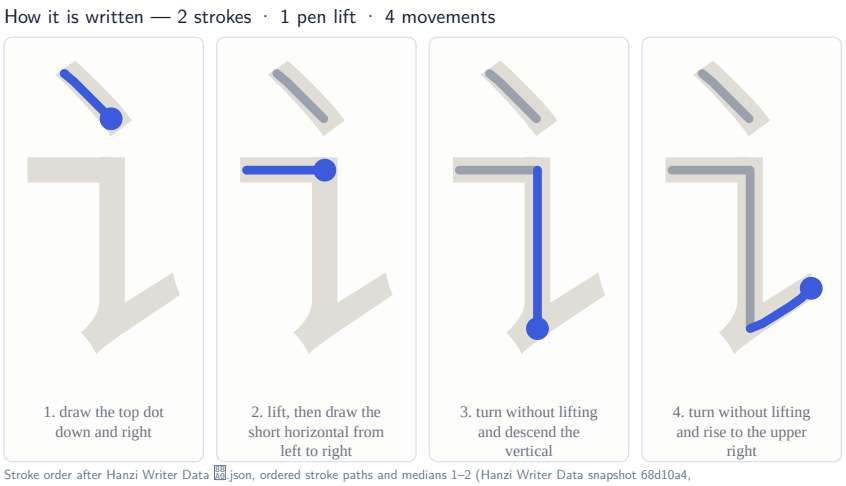
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) ↙ **pen** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write the speech radical 讠 and the twelve-stroke 谢, thank someone with 谢谢, answer thanks with 不谢, and predict from the rule alone that 不 rises before 谢 because 谢 is a falling tone.
>
> *A whole courtesy exchange bought with one new character – doubled for the thanks, negated for the reply – and the first place the reader predicts a tone change from a rule rather than being told how a word sounds.*

10.1 讠 — the speech radical

Write 讠 . Two strokes, squeezed to the left edge of a block.

Script — the shape



How 讠 is written, stroke by stroke

讠

Two strokes, one pen lift, and it is not a character. Like 亻, it is a **component** — a piece that lives at the left edge of other characters.

1. a **dot** at the top, pressed down and to the right
2. a short **horizontal**, which **turns down** and then **finishes rising** to the upper right — all one stroke, no lift

That second stroke does three things without stopping. You have handled worse: the frame of 再, the leg of 见, the turn in 么.

讠 **means speech.** It is the squeezed form of 言, the character for words and speaking, and it does the same job 亻 does: it tells you what the character is *about* before you know how to say it.

讠 joins 亻 as a component that carries **meaning** rather than sound, and the pair is worth holding together:

- 亻 at the left edge → the character is about a **person**
- 讠 at the left edge → the character is about **speech**

You will meet 讠 often. Every time you do, you can guess something true about the word before anyone tells you.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 讠 — dot, then one unbroken turning stroke
- 亻 , then 讠 , side by side — two meaning-carrying components

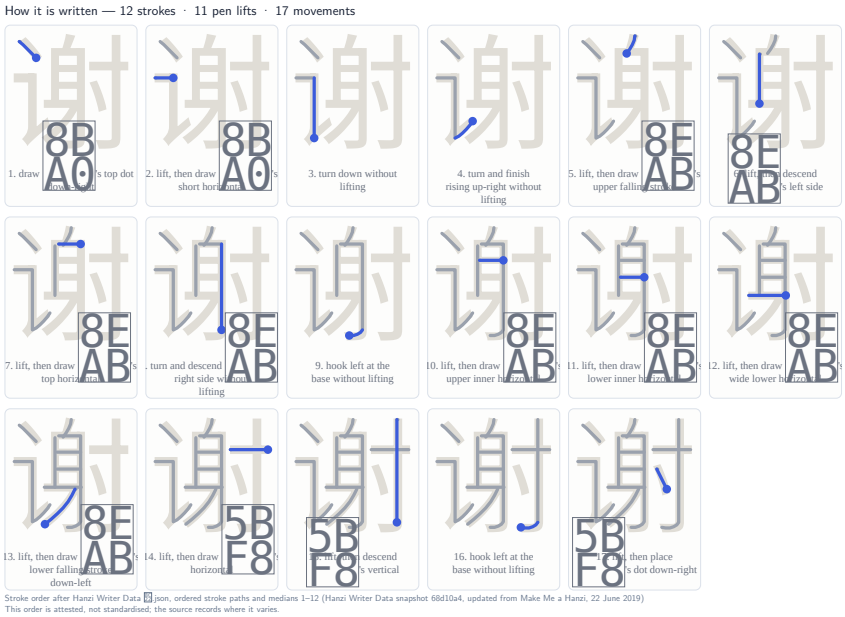
Before you move on

How many pen lifts does 讠 take? (**One**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

10.2 谢 — twelve strokes, and three pieces

Write 讠 . Dot, then one turning stroke.

Script — the shape



How 谢 *is written, stroke by stroke*

谢

Twelve strokes. That is the longest thing in this book, and the number is about to stop mattering.

You were told once that stroke-counting gives out and structure takes over. This is where that pays off. **谢 is three pieces, left to right**, and you have just written the first:

讠 + 身 + 寸

- 讠 — speech, two strokes, done
- 身 — a shape meaning *body*, seven strokes
- 寸 — a shape meaning *inch*, three strokes on the right

身 and 寸 are pieces, not characters you are being asked to own. Read them, place them, move on.

讠 (strokes 1-2). As you just practised.

身 (strokes 3-9). An upper falling stroke; the left side down; the top and right side in one turning stroke that hooks left at the base; two short inner horizontals; a wide horizontal beneath them; then a falling stroke down-left.

寸 (strokes 10-12). A horizontal; a vertical that hooks left at the base; and a dot, last.

Eleven pen lifts. **Left piece finished before the middle, middle before the right** — the oldest habit you have, applied to three pieces instead of two.

Compare it honestly with 我. 我 was seven strokes and had **no** pieces you could hold on to. 谢 is twelve and has three. **The long one is the easier one.** That is the whole argument for learning structure rather than counting.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 讠, then the middle piece, then the right piece — stopping between each
- *Write it:* 谢 straight through, and say "speech, body, inch" as you go
- *Say it:* **xiè** — falling

Before you move on

Which was harder to learn, this one or 我? (我 — and it is five strokes shorter.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

10.3 谢谢 — said twice

Say **xiè** — falling, from high to low.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

谢谢 *xièxie* — **thank you**.
It is 谢 **written twice**. Nothing else. You learned one character and you have the word.
This is new, and it is not a quirk. Mandarin builds a great many words by **saying a piece twice**, and doubling usually softens something — it makes an action smaller, lighter, more everyday. That pattern is worth knowing; you will meet it again.
Two cautions about this particular word, so you do not over-apply it. 谢谢 **is a fixed expression**, not something you assemble fresh each time — it does not mean "to thank briefly". And 谢 **is not said on its own**: it lives inside words, so do not reach for a bare 谢 and expect it to work.
谢 is inherited from Middle Chinese *zjaeH*, glossed "to decline, take leave" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); "to thank" is a later sense, and the doubled form is a Chinese formation.

The sounds and tones in this word

xièxie, not *xièxiè*.
The first 谢 falls. The second **goes neutral** — short, light, no tone mark. You have seen this twice already, on 上 inside 早上 and on 字 inside 名字, and now on a syllable that is the *same character* as the one before it.
That is the useful lesson: **the light syllable is not a property of the character, it is a property of the word.** 谢 falls in this word's first half and goes light in its second — and you will meet 谢 falling again, in its second position, before this chapter is out. *Twice through.*

Say it: *xiè* dropping, then *xie* small and quick behind it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **xiè** alone, falling — then **xièxie**, with the second syllable light
- *Say it:* **xièxie** twice, and say which of the two 谢 carries a tone
- *Write it:* 谢谢 — the same twelve strokes, twice

Before you move on

How many new characters did this word cost you? (**One**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

10.4 不谢 — answering thanks

Say **xièxie** — falling, then light.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Someone thanks you. What do you say back?

不谢

不谢 — and it is made of two things you already have. 不, the negator you have carried since 好 and 不好, in front of 谢, which you learned an hour ago. Nothing new. You could have built this yourself.
It works the way 不是 works: **put 不 in front of the word and you turn it.** Here turning it is a polite refusal of the thanks — *no need to thank me* — which is how a great many languages answer being thanked.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *pjut*, "not", and *zjaeH*, "to decline, to thank" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

The sounds and tones in this word

Before you say it, work it out. **谢 is fourth tone.** What does 不 do in front of a fourth tone?
It rises. *bú xiè*, not *bù xiè* — exactly as 不是 became *bú shì*.

This is the second time that rule has fired, and this time you were told the condition before the word. That is the difference between a rule you have been given and a rule you can use: **you can now predict the pronunciation of a word nobody has said to you yet.** *Twice through.*

Why it's said this way

不谢 is real and correct, and it is not the commonest reply. The one you will hear most often needs two characters this book cannot yet print, so it is waiting. 不谢 will be understood everywhere, and it has the advantage of costing you nothing you did not already have.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bú xiè** — the first syllable rising, and know why
- *Say it:* **bú shì**, then **bú xiè** — the same rule, twice
- *Write it:* 不谢

Before you move on

How many new characters did this reply cost you? (**None**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

10.5 Practice — thanks, and the answer

Say **bú xiè**. Rising, then falling — and you know why the first one rises.

The exchange

A: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

B: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

A: 谢谢

xièxie — thank you.

B: 不谢

bú xiè — you're welcome.

A: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

Six lines, and **one new character** paid for two of them.

What you've built — one character, a whole exchange

This chapter cost you 谢 and nothing else. Out of it came the thanks (谢谢, the same character twice) and the reply (不谢, a negator you already had). That is what a system does for you that a phrasebook cannot: pieces recombine.
Three things you did here without being led:

- you **doubled** a character to make a word, and knew the second half would go light;
- you **negated** a word to make its answer, the same move that turned 是 into 不是;
- and you **predicted a tone change** from a rule, before hearing the word said.

That last one is the real marker. Early on you were told what 你好 sounds like. Now you are told a rule and you work out what a word sounds like. Those are different kinds of knowing, and only the second one travels to words nobody has taught you.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Say it:* **xièxie**, then **bú xiè** — light on the second, rising on the first
- *Write it:* 谢谢, then 不谢

Before you move on

Which two of these did you work out rather than being told? (**The light second syllable, and the rising 不**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 11

After You

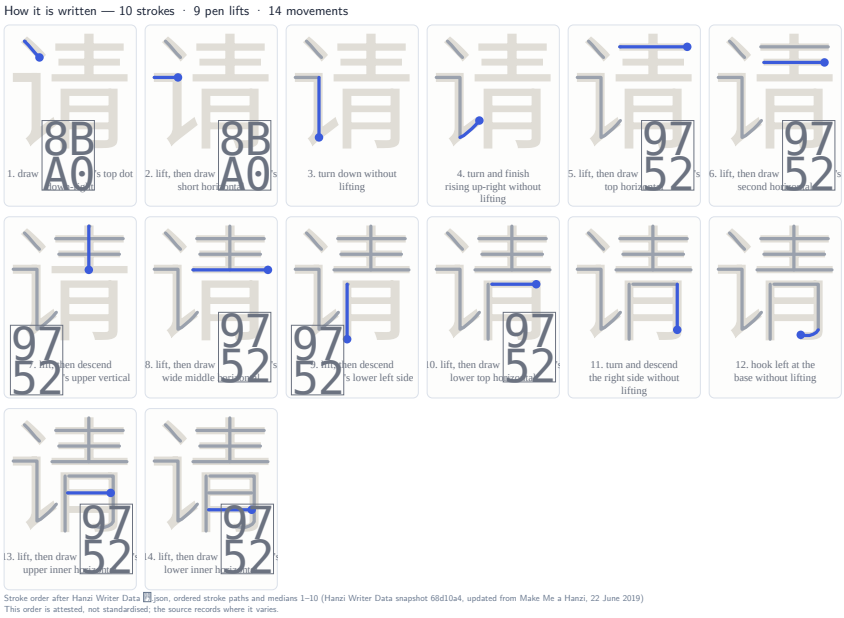
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 👁 **eyes** (2) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write 请, say it on its own to mean after you, explain that it invites rather than softens and so is used far less than English please, and I know a character half can point at the sound instead of the meaning.
>
> *A complete courtesy in four words, and the point at which the reader learns a character can carry two kinds of hint at once – one half for what it means, the other for how it sounds – which is what makes the writing system learnable rather than thousands of unrelated pictures.*

11.1 请 — a half that tells you the sound

Write 讠 . Dot, then one turning stroke. What does it tell you about the word? (**Speech**.)

Script — the shape



How 请 *is written, stroke by stroke*

请

Ten strokes, two pieces, and 讠 is on the left again as you would expect.

讠 + 青

讠 **(strokes 1-2).** Speech. You know it.

青 **(strokes 3-10).** A top horizontal; a second horizontal; a vertical down through them; a wide middle horizontal; then the lower box — its left side, then its top-and-right in one turning stroke that hooks at the base, then two short inner horizontals.

Nine pen lifts. **讠 finished before 青.**

Now the part worth stopping for. In 谢, both halves pointed at **meaning** — speech, body, inch. Here the right half does something else entirely.

青 is said *qīng*. The whole character is said *qǐng*.

Say those two aloud, one after the other. Same consonant, same rest of the syllable; only the pitch differs. **The right half is not telling you what the word means. It is telling you how to say it.** That is a

phonetic component — the job 尔 was doing inside 你, which you could only take on trust there. This time you can hear it. Once you can spot one you have a genuine reading strategy: meet an unknown character, find the half you recognise, and you often have a guess at the sound.

It is a guess and not a guarantee — the sound has drifted in plenty of characters over a few thousand years, and the tone in particular is often different, as it is here. But a guess beats nothing, and you will be right often.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 讠 , then 青 — stopping between the two pieces
- *Say it:* **qīng**, then **qǐng** — the sound half, then the whole character
- *Write it:* 请 straight through

Before you move on

Is the sound half exactly right? (**Not quite** — the tone differs.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

11.2 请 — please, and after you

Say **qǐng** — low and dipping, like *hǎo* and *wǒ*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

请 *qǐng* — the word a dictionary will give you as **please**.
That translation is close enough to use and loose enough to mislead, so here is the more accurate version: 请 is closer to **"I ask you to"**, **"I invite you to"**. Where English *please* softens a demand, 请 **hands the action over**.
Which is why it works **on its own**. Hold a door and say 请 — that is *after you*, *go ahead*, *be my guest*. Offer someone a seat and say 请. No other words needed, and none of them would be an apology for asking.
The word is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshjengX*, glossed "to beg, to request, to ask" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the asking sense is the old one.

Why it's said this way

English *please* is a **softener**. You bolt it onto a request to take the edge off, and you can put it almost anywhere: *please sit*, *sit, please*, *could you please sit*.
请 does not work like that. It comes **before the action it invites**, never bolted on after it — there is no Mandarin habit of tacking 请 onto the end of a request the way English tacks on *please*.
The consequence is practical, and it surprises learners: **Mandarin uses 请 far less often than English uses please** — and with people you are close to it can sound distant rather than polite. Leaving it out is not rude the way dropping *please* can be in English. Warmth in Mandarin is carried more by what you say and how you say it than by a single courtesy word.
So: use 请 to hand something over or to invite. Do not reach for it every time you would say *please* in English — you would sound stilted rather than polite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **qǐng** on its own, as though holding a door open
- **qǐng**, then **xièxie** — the invitation, then the thanks

Before you move on

Does Mandarin use 请 as often as English uses *please*? (**No** — far less.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

11.3 Practice — after you

Say **qǐng** — low and dipping.

The exchange

Two people reach a door at the same time.

A: 请

qǐng — after you.

B: 谢谢

xièxie — thank you.

A: 不谢

bú xiè — you're welcome.

B: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

Four lines, four words, and a complete small courtesy. Nobody in it asks for anything or explains anything, and it still works — which is most of what courtesy is.

What you've built — a component that predicts

Consider what the two halves of this chapter's character bought you. 讠 **on the left** told you the word was about speech before you knew what it meant — and it did the same in 谢. Two characters, one component, one reliable guess.

青 **on the right** told you roughly how to say it. You were told once before that a half could do this — 尔, on the right of 你 — but you had to take it on trust, because 尔 is *ěr* and nothing in it sounds like *nǐ*. Here you can hear it for yourself: *qīng*, *qǐng*.

So the claim made in passing back then is now one you can check: a Chinese character can carry **two kinds of hint at once**, one for what it means and one for how it is said. That is the single most useful thing to know about reading Chinese, and it is why the writing system is learnable at all rather than being thousands of unrelated pictures.

You will not always get both hints, and neither is a promise. But from here on, when you meet a character you do not know, you have something to do other than look it up: **find the half you recognise, and ask which job it is doing.**

Your turn

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts

- *Say it:* **qǐng**, **xièxie**, **bú xiè** — three courtesies in a row
- *Write it:* 请, then 谢 — and say what their left halves have in common

Before you move on

Which half of 请 would help you guess its pronunciation? (**The right**.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

11.4 Eight exchanges, one meeting

Every chapter so far has ended on a two-voice exchange, and you have practised each one on its own. From memory: the one that opens a meeting, and the one that closes it.

You'll want to know: they were always one conversation

Eight exchanges arrived one per chapter. Put them in the order a meeting uses them and this book's whole first act is there:

the move	what it added
greet	你好, both voices
introduce, ask	a name given, a name asked for
identify, negate	saying it is so, and saying it is not
thank, be polite	谢谢, and the reply that follows it
part	再见

Nothing in that column is new. What is new is that **no chapter ever asked you to run them one after another**, and a meeting is exactly that: eight small moves with no pause between them for looking anything up.

Your turn: the whole meeting, no stops

Say these aloud:

- both voices of the greeting
- give your name, then ask for theirs
- answer a yes-or-no question, once affirming and once denying

- thank them, then give the reply you would receive
- take your leave

Before you move on

Which exchange opens a meeting, and which closes it? (你好 and 再见.) Which pair is a yes against a no? (**Identify** and **negate**.) What did the thanks exchange add beyond the word itself? (**The reply** that comes back.) And what is new here, when every piece is old? (**Running them together**, with no stop.)

11.5 好 — one character, and three things it is not

Say 好 twice, once in each tone you have met, and say what each one means. One character, two words.

You'll want to know: four cautions, and 好 carries three of them

These chapters have warned you four separate times about reading too much into what you see. 好 is where three of the four meet:

- **A character is not a word.** 你好 is two characters and one word. A character writes a syllable and usually a meaningful piece — not a word.
- **A component is not always a meaning.** 好 is 女 beside 子, woman beside child, and the lesson that built it warned you against reading a story into that. The pieces are how the character is *assembled*, not what it argues.
- **A tone is not a decoration.** *hǎo* is good; *hào* is to be fond of. Same character, same strokes, different word.

Script: the component that carries a sound

尔

The fourth caution is the other way round. 尔 is in 你 to say how it **sounds**, not what it means — a component doing phonetic work. Once you expect that, a great many characters stop looking arbitrary.

Against it, 口 *kǒu* (mouth) and 日 *rì* (sun, and also day) are components that do mean what they draw. **Both kinds exist, and the character does not announce which you are looking at.** That is the caution worth carrying forward.

Your turn

- *Say it:* 你好 — then say how many characters and how many words
- *Say it:* 好 in both tones, with both meanings
- *Look:* at 你 and name the component that is there for its sound
- *Say it:* 口 and 日, and what each one draws

Before you move on

How many words is 你好, and how many characters? (**One word, two characters**.) What are the two halves of 好, and what do they tell you about its meaning? (**女 and 子** — and **nothing** you should rely on.) What does 尔 contribute to 你? (**Its sound**, not its meaning.) And which of 口 and 日 means what it draws? (**Both** — which is why the two kinds have to be told apart.)

Chapter 12

People under one roof

Modes: **voice** (10) **eyes** (2) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first 3 of 14 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write six HSK Level 1 people-and-family words, building 儿子, 女儿 and 家人 only after their spoken meanings and component characters are secure.
>
> *Six family words pass separate listening, speaking, reading and no-model writing checks; pinyin cannot compensate for an unread character, and a strong skill cannot compensate for a weak one.*

12.1 人 — a person

Write it: the two-stroke figure

Then say **wǒ** — I.

What to know first

人 — *rén* — **person**

Hear the rising tone first. Say *rén*. *Read it:* the character you already know

The meaning is singular here: one person. Number comes from context or another word; the character itself does not grow a plural ending.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

人 *rén* is inherited from Middle Chinese *nyin*, "person" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Its *ny* became the Mandarin *r*, as in *rì*.

Your turn

Say **person** in Mandarin. *Read it:* 人
Cover: 人, then wait five seconds
Write it: the character

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 170.

12.2 女 — female, woman

Say **person**. *Write it:* the three-stroke left half of 好

What to know first

女 — *nǚ* — **female; woman**

Say it low: *nǚ*. The rounded vowel is the same written **ü** you met in the character lesson. On its own, 女 labels female gender; it is not a polite way to call out to a woman. Here you are learning the word for reading and building.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

女 *nǚ* is inherited from Middle Chinese *nrjoX*, "woman" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Read it: 女, then cover it
Write it: the character, from the meaning cue **female**

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 152.

12.3 Hear *érzi* — son

Say **person**, then **female**.

What to know first

érzi — **son**

Hear two beats: rising *ér*, then a short, light *zi*. Say the whole word once from the meaning. Keep the characters covered; the new first shape comes next.

Érzi is built from Middle Chinese *nye*, "infant", and *tsiX*, "offspring".

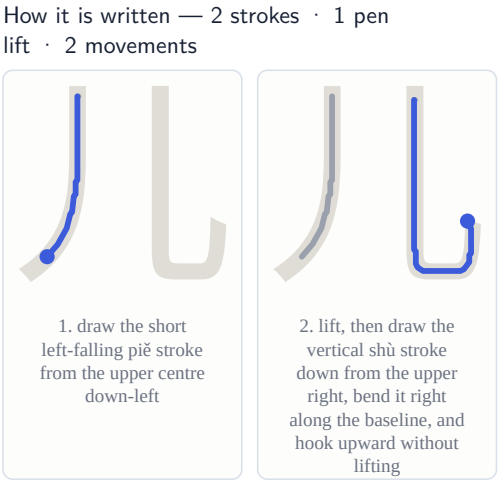
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 48.

12.4 丿儿 — fall, then bend and hook

Say **son**, then write 人.

Script — the shape



How 儿 is written, stroke by stroke

儿

Two strokes. First a short fall down-left. Then start high on the right, descend, bend right along the floor, and hook upward **without lifting**. Unlike 人, the two strokes do not meet at the top.

Your turn

Trace 儿 once. Copy it once. Point to the bend that keeps it apart from 人.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 儿, pinned stroke paths and medians.

12.5 儿子 — son on the page

Say **son**. *Write it:* 儿 and 子 separately

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

儿子 — *érzi* — **son**

The first syllable rises. The second is light. Both characters carry child meanings, but the whole word—not either character alone—is the ordinary kinship word **son**.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *nye*, "infant", and *tsiX*, "offspring" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 儿子, while saying *ér-zi*
Read it: 儿子 once without pinyin

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 48.

12.6 Hear *nǚ'ér* — daughter

Say **female**, then **son**.

What to know first

nǚ'ér — **daughter**

Say two clear syllables: low *nǚ*, rising *ér*. The apostrophe only keeps the vowel boundary visible in pinyin. It is not a pause and not part of the Chinese writing.

Nǚ'ér is built from Middle Chinese *nrjoX*, "woman", and *nye*, "infant".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 153.

12.7 女儿 — daughter on the page

Say **daughter**, then write 女 and 儿 separately.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

女儿 — *nǚ'ér* — **daughter**

Nothing is hidden: 女 gives female and 儿 gives child. Read the two characters without the pinyin, then say the whole word without a pause.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *nrjoX*, "woman", and *nye*, "infant" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Look at 女儿, cover it, wait five seconds, and write it from **daughter**.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 153.

12.8 Hear *jiā* — home, family

Say **daughter**, then **son**.

What to know first

jiā — **home; family**

Hold the pitch high and level: *jiā*. The word can name the household place or the family belonging to it. Keep the character covered; it has ten strokes, and the next lesson gives them to you in two familiar-sized pieces.

Jiā is inherited from Middle Chinese *kae*, "dwelling".

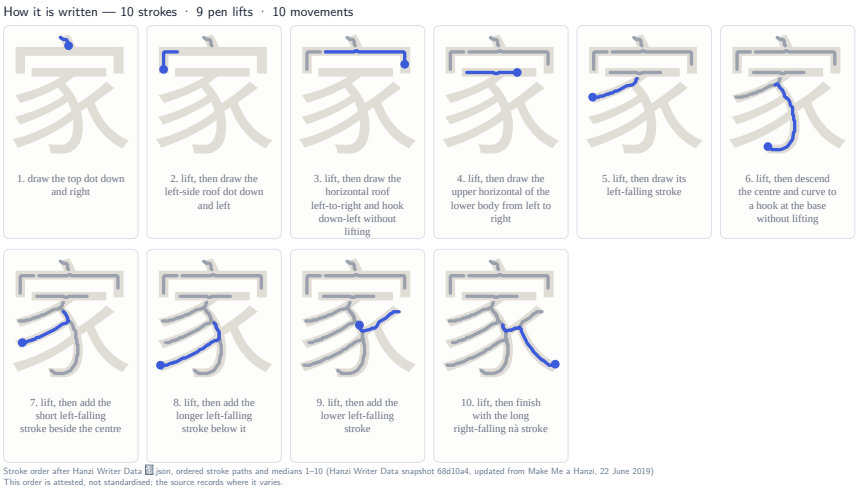
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 86.

12.9 家 — roof first, body second

Say **home**, then write the roof from 字 and the whole character 字.

Script — the shape



How 家 *is written, stroke by stroke*

宀 + 豕 → 家

Finish the three-stroke roof first. Under it, write the lower body from its top horizontal through the centre curve, three left-falling strokes, and the long right-falling finish. Ten strokes; nine lifts.

The old lower component is 豕, livestock. That decomposition is real history and a useful shape boundary. It is not a claim that a present-day home or family is defined by an animal.

Your turn

Trace 家 once. Copy it once, saying **roof**, then **body**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 家, pinned stroke paths and medians.

12.10 家 — home on the page

Say **home or family**. *Write it:* 宀

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

家 — *jiā* — **home; family**

Read it: 家 once without pinyin
The high line over *ā* records first tone; the character records no tone mark at all.
家 is inherited from Middle Chinese *kae*, "dwelling" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); Mandarin softened its *k* to *j*.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 家, from the model — name the roof before you write the lower body

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 86.

12.11 Hear *jiārén* — family members

Say **home or family**, then **person**.

What to know first

jiārén — **family members; family**

You already own both sounds: *jiā* + *rén*. The compound names the people of the home. Say it once from the meaning before looking at either character.

Jiārén is built from Middle Chinese *kae*, "dwelling", and *nyin*, "person".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 87.

12.12 家人 — the people of the home

Say **family members**, then write 家 and 人 separately.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

家人 — *jiārén* — **family members; family**

Read from the characters: home + person. The word is plural by meaning here, but Mandarin adds no plural ending to 人.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *kae* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and the pair is old: it names a hexagram in the Book of Changes.

Your turn

Look at 家人, cover it, wait five seconds, and write it from **family**.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entry 87.

12.13 Retrieve six people and family words

Say **name**. *Write it:* 儿 and 家

Your turn

Hear the six words in a shuffled order and say each meaning. Then, from six English meanings, say each word. *Read it:* the six character cards
Write it: only the two you missed
Repair one item at a time.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary entries 48, 87, and 153.

12.14 Payoff — six family words in four skills

Say **name**. *Write it:* 儿 and 家 without a model

Your turn

1. **Listening:** hear six words in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking:** produce all six from their English meanings, with tones audible.
3. *Read it:* the six character cards without pinyin
4. **Writing:** hear all six. *Write it:* all six without a model

Pass each skill separately. If one misses, repair that skill and retry only that part. This is a family vocabulary map, not yet a full family-description task.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 task outline pp. 2–3 and vocabulary entries 48, 86–87, 152–153, and 170.

Chapter 13

From study to university student

Modes: **voice** (11) **eyes** (3) **pen** (3) **Hands-free start:** the first of 17 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write six HSK Level 1 size-and-school words, gaining 大, 学 and 生 one gently staged character at a time before recombining them as 大家, 学生, 大学 and 大学生.
>
> *Three newly secured characters produce six useful words, each checked separately in listening, speaking, unassisted reading and no-model writing.*

13.1 Hear *dà* — big

Say **home** and **family members**.

What to know first

dà — **big; large**

Let the voice fall firmly on the single syllable: *dà*. Keep the character covered for now. The next lesson gives its three strokes one at a time.

Dà is inherited from Middle Chinese *daH*, "big"; the Guangyun also lists a second reading, *dajH*.

Before you move on

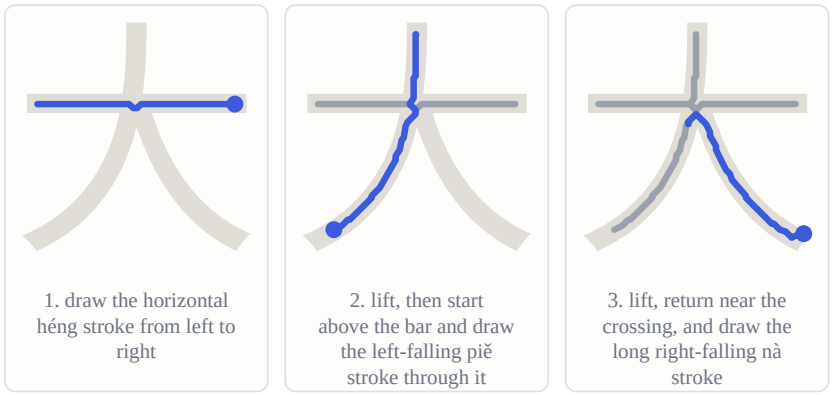
Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.2 大 — one bar, two falls

Say **big** in Mandarin.

Script — the shape

How it is written — 3 strokes · 2 pen lifts · 3 movements



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 59/27.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 大 is written, stroke by stroke

一 + 丿 + 乀 → 大

Write the horizontal first. Start the left-falling stroke above it and cross through it. Lift once more, return to the crossing, and fall long to the right.

Your turn

Trace 大 once. Copy it once while saying **bar, left, right**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 大, pinned stroke paths and medians.

13.3 大 — big on the page

Say **big**. *Point to:* the first stroke of 大

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

大 — *dà* — **big; large**

Read it: the character without pinyin
Then say it once with a clear fourth-tone fall.
大 is inherited from Middle Chinese *daH*, "big"; the Guangyun also lists a second reading, *dajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 大, from the model — keep the crossing near the centre

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.4 Hear *dàjiā* — everyone

Say *dà*, then *jiā*.

What to know first

dàjiā — **everyone; everybody**

Hear two beats: falling *dà*, then level *jiā*. The whole word means everyone. Its written form will contain only characters you already know.

Dàjiā is built from Middle Chinese *daH*, "big", and *kae*, "household".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.5 大家 — everyone on the page

Write 大, then 家 with a small gap.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

大家 — *dàjiā* — **everyone**

Close the gap. Read the two characters as one word and keep both tone shapes.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *daH* and *kae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Older texts use the pair for a great household; "everyone" is the later sense.

Your turn

Look at 大家, cover it, then write it once from memory.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.6 Hear *xué* — study, learn

Say **everyone**.

What to know first

xué — **study; learn**

Begin low enough to rise clearly through *xué*. Stay with sound and meaning; the eight-stroke character comes next in small groups.

Xué is inherited from Middle Chinese *haewk*, "to learn".

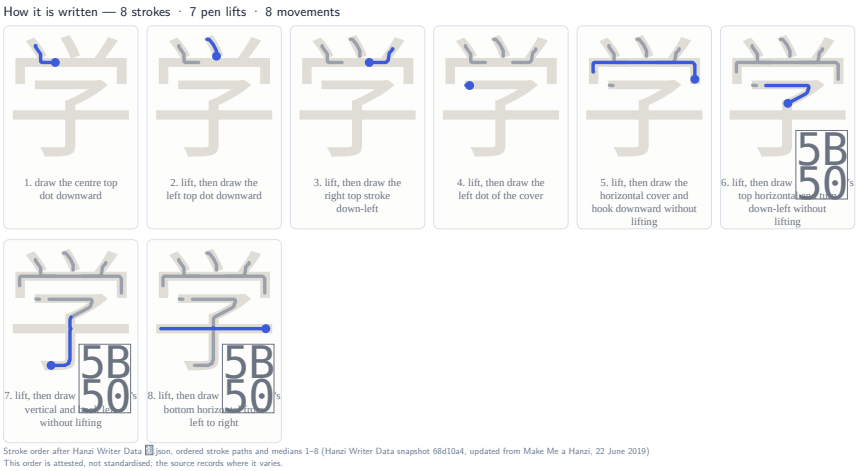
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.7 学 — top, cover, child

Say **study**, then write 子.

Script — the shape



How 学 *is written, stroke by stroke*

丷 + 冖 + 子 → 学

Place the three short marks across the top. Add the covering dot and hooked line. Finish with the familiar three strokes of 子 below. Eight strokes total; do not let the top marks crowd the child.

Your turn

Trace 学 once. Copy it once while saying **top, cover, child**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 学, pinned stroke paths and medians.

13.8 学 — study on the page

Say **study**. *Point to:* 子 inside 学

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

学 — *xué* — **study; learn**

Read it: 学 without pinyin, then give the syllable a clear rise
学 is inherited from Middle Chinese *haewk*, "to learn" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); Mandarin lost the final *k*.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 学 — pause mentally after the top, after the cover, and after 子

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.9 Hear *xuésheng* — student

Say **study**.

What to know first

xuésheng — **student**

Rise on *xué*. Keep *sheng* short and light. Hold the second character back; the next lesson gives its five strokes.

Xuésheng is built from Middle Chinese *haewk*, "to learn", and *srjaeng*, "life, birth".

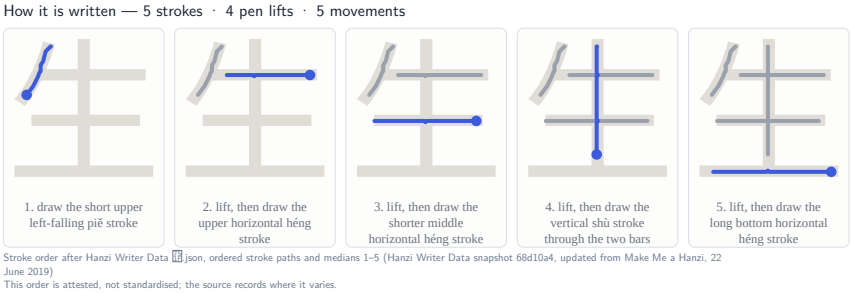
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.10 生 — five measured strokes

Say **student**.

Script — the shape



How 生 is written, stroke by stroke

Begin with the short left-fall. Add the upper horizontal and the shorter middle horizontal. Draw the vertical through their centres, then anchor everything with the long bottom horizontal. Five strokes; four lifts.

Your turn

Trace 生 once. Copy it once while saying **fall, two bars, through, base**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 生, pinned stroke paths and medians.

13.11 学生 — student on the page

Point to: 学, then 生

Say **study**, then **student**.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

学生 — *xuésheng* — **student**

Read it: the two-character word without pinyin
Keep the second syllable light.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *haewk*, “to learn”, and *srjaeng*, “life, birth” (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription). The pair is an old Chinese compound.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 学生 — finish all of 学 before beginning 生

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.12 Hear *dàxué* — university

Say **big**, then **study**.

What to know first

dàxué — **university; college**

Let *dà* fall, then let *xué* rise. Together they name a university or college. *Dàxué* is built from Middle Chinese *daH*, "big", and *haewk*, "learning".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.13 大学 — university on the page

Read 大 and 学 separately.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

大学 — *dàxué* — **university; college**

Now read the pair as one word: fall, then rise.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *daH* and *haewk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The pair is old, the title of a Confucian classic, the *Great Learning*; the sense "university" is modern.

Your turn

Look at 大学, cover it, and write it once from memory.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.14 Hear *dàxuésheng* — university student

Say **university**, then **student**.

What to know first

dàxuésheng — **university student**

Say three beats: falling *dà*, rising *xué*, light *sheng*. Do not repeat *xué*; the two familiar words overlap there.

Dàxuésheng is built from Middle Chinese *daH*, *haewk* and *srjaeng*: big, learning, life.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.15 大学生 — university student on the page

Read 大学, then 学生.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

大学生 — *dàxuésheng* — **university student**

Track three characters and three beats. The middle 学 belongs to the whole word only once.
All three pieces are inherited from Middle Chinese, *daH*, *haewk* and *srjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and Chinese joined them as university plus student.

Your turn

Look at 大学生, cover it, and write it once. Check one character at a time.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.16 Retrieve six size and school words

Write it: 大, 学, and 生 once each from memory

Your turn

Hear the six words in shuffled order and say each meaning. Then say each word from its English meaning. *Read it:* each character card

Write it: only the missed items

Repair one word at a time.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

13.17 Payoff — six school words in four skills

Write it: 大, 学, and 生 without a model

Your turn

1. **Listening:** hear six words in mixed order and choose every meaning.
2. **Speaking:** produce all six from their English meanings, with tones audible.
3. *Read it:* all six character cards without pinyin
4. **Writing:** hear all six. *Write it:* all six without a model

Pass each skill separately. Repair and retry only the failed skill. This is a school vocabulary checkpoint, not yet a full conversation about education.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 task outline and vocabulary.

Chapter 14

One small step into school

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (2) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 9 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 小, 小学 and 小学生, gaining only the three-stroke 小 before recombining it with the already secure 学 and 生.
>
> *One new glyph expands into three official Level 1 words, each checked independently in listening, speaking, unassisted reading and no-model writing.*

14.1 Hear *xiǎo* — small

Say **big** and **university**.

What to know first

xiǎo — **small; little**

Keep the voice low through the third tone: *xiǎo*. Work only with sound and meaning. Its three-stroke character comes next.

Xiǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjewX*, "small".

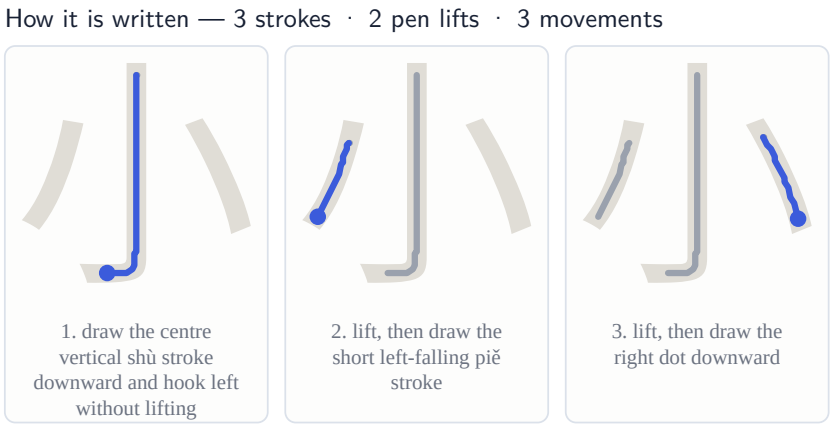
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.2 小 — centre, left, right

Say **small** in Mandarin.

Script — the shape



How 小 is written, stroke by stroke

Draw the centre vertical first and finish its hook without lifting. Add the short left-falling mark. Finish with the right dot, leaving air around the centre. Three strokes; two lifts.

Your turn

Trace 小 once. Copy it once while saying **centre, left, right**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 小, pinned stroke paths and medians.

14.3 小 — small on the page

Say **small**. *Point to:* the first stroke of 小

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

小 — *xiǎo* — **small; little**

Read it: the character without pinyin, then say it with a low third tone
小 is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjewX*, "small" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 小 — keep the side marks shorter than the centre stroke

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.4 Hear *xiǎoxué* — primary school

Say **small**, then **study**.

What to know first

xiǎoxué — **primary school; elementary school**

Keep *xiǎo* low, then let *xué* rise. No new character is hiding in this word.
Xiǎoxué is built from Middle Chinese *sjewX*, "small", and *haewk*, "learning".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.5 小学 — primary school on the page

Read 小, then 学.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

小学 — *xiǎoxué* — **primary school**

Read the pair as one word without pinyin: low, then rising.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjewX* and *haewk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Older texts use the pair for a child's first schooling; "primary school" is the modern sense.

Your turn

Look at 小学, cover it, and write it once from memory.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.6 Hear *xiǎoxuésheng* — primary-school student

Say **primary school**, then **student**.

What to know first

xiǎoxuésheng — **primary-school student**

Say three beats: low *xiǎo*, rising *xué*, light *sheng*. 学 appears only once where the two familiar words overlap.

Xiǎoxuésheng is built from Middle Chinese *sjewX*, *haewk* and *srjaeng*: small, learning, life.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.7 小学生 — primary-school student on the page

Read 小学, then point to 生.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

小学生 — *xiǎoxuésheng* — **primary-school student**

Track three characters and three beats. Read it once without pinyin. All three pieces are inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjewX*, *haewk* and *srjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and Chinese joined them as primary school plus student.

Your turn

Look at 小学生, cover it, and write it once. Check one character at a time.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.8 Retrieve three primary-school words

Write it: 小, 学, and 生 once each from memory

Your turn

Hear **small**, **primary school**, and **primary-school student** in mixed order. Say each. *Read it:* each Mandarin form

Write it: each one

Then contrast 大学 with 小学 and 大学生 with 小学生. Repair only the missed item.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

14.9 Payoff — three primary-school words in four skills

Write it: 小, 学, and 生 without a model

Your turn

1. **Listening:** hear the three forms in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking:** produce all three from their English meanings, with tones audible.
3. *Read it:* all three character cards without pinyin
4. **Writing:** hear all three. *Write it:* all three without a model

Pass each skill separately. Repair and retry only the failed skill.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 task outline and vocabulary.

Chapter 15

A wider school map

Modes: **voice** (13) **eyes** (2) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 17 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 中学, 中学生, 同学 and 上学 after gaining only 中 and 同 through source-verified, gently staged handwriting practice.
>
> *Four official Level 1 school words are retrieved across four spaced reviews, then checked independently in listening, speaking, unassisted reading and no-model writing.*

15.1 Hear *zhōng* — middle

Say **small** in Mandarin.

What to know first

zhōng — **middle; centre**

Hold one high, level tone: *zhōng*. Stay with sound and meaning. The written shape comes next.

Zhōng is inherited from Middle Chinese *trjuwng*, “middle”.

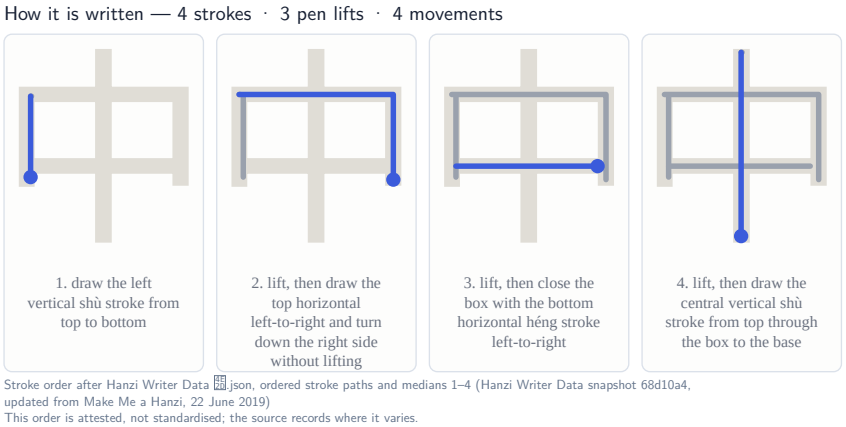
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.2 中 — close, then pass through

Say **middle** in Mandarin.

Script — the shape



How 中 is written, stroke by stroke

Reuse 口's three-stroke box: left side; joined top and right; closing bottom. Only then draw the long centre vertical through the box. Four strokes; three lifts.

Your turn

Trace 中 once. Copy it once while saying **box, close, through**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 中, pinned stroke paths and medians.

15.3 中 — middle on the page

Say **middle**. *Point to:* 中's last stroke

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

中 — *zhōng* — **middle; centre**

Read it: the character without pinyin, then hold its first tone level

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 中 — check that the box closes before the centre line

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.4 Hear *zhōngxué* — middle school

Say **middle**, then **study**.

What to know first

zhōngxué — **middle school**

Hold *zhōng* level, then let *xué* rise. Hear the whole school word before seeing its two characters.

Zhōngxué is built from Middle Chinese *trjuwng*, "middle", and *haewk*, "learning".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.5 中学 — middle school on the page

Read 中, then 学.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

中学 — *zhōngxué* — **middle school**

Read the pair without pinyin: level, then rising.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjuwng* and *haewk*

(Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); Chinese built the school name from them.

Your turn

Look at 中学, cover it, and write it once from memory.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.6 Retrieval 1 — middle and middle school

Say **middle** without looking.

Your turn

Hear **middle** and **middle school** in mixed order. Say each. *Read it:* each Mandarin form

Write it: each one, once

Repair only the missed item.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.7 Hear *zhōngxuésheng* — middle-school student

Say **middle school**, then **student**.

What to know first

zhōngxuésheng — **middle-school student**

Say three beats: level *zhōng*, rising *xué*, light *sheng*. The shared *xué* is spoken only once.

Zhōngxuésheng is built from Middle Chinese *trjuwng*, *haewk* and *srjaeng*: middle, learning, life.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.8 中学生 — middle-school student on the page

Read it: 中学, then point to 生

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

中学生 — *zhōngxuésheng* — **middle-school student**

Read it: all three characters once without pinyin
All three pieces are inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjuwng*, *haewk* and *srjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and Chinese joined them as middle school plus student.

Your turn

Hear *zhōngxuésheng*. *Write it:* 中学生 without looking — check one character at a time

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.9 Hear *tóngxué* — classmate

Say **study** in Mandarin.

What to know first

tóngxué — **classmate; schoolmate**

Let both syllables rise: *tóng-xué*. Keep working only with sound and meaning. The first character comes next.

Tóngxué is built from Middle Chinese *duwng*, "same, together", and *haewk*, "to learn".

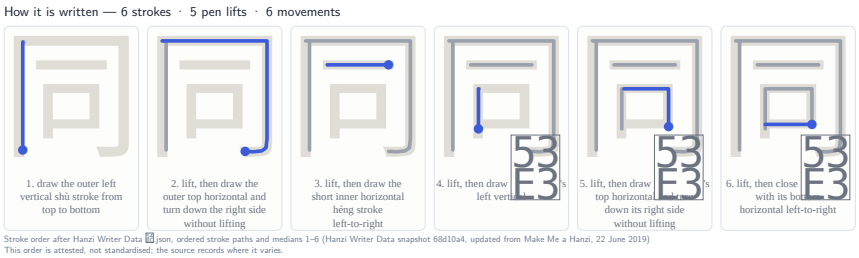
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.10 同 — frame, line, box

Say **classmate**, then air-write 口.

Script — the shape



How 同 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Draw the outer left side. Lift for the joined outer top and right side, ending with its small hook. Add the inner horizontal. Finish the familiar 口 inside: left, joined top-right, closing bottom. Six strokes; five lifts.

Your turn

Trace 同 once. Copy it once while saying **frame, line, box**.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 同, pinned stroke paths and medians.

15.11 同学 — classmate on the page

Read it: 同, then 学

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

同学 — *tóngxué* — **classmate; schoolmate**

Read it: the pair without pinyin
Both syllables rise.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *duwng*, "same, together", and *haewk*, "to learn" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). A classmate is someone who learns with you.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 同学 — keep the inner 口 inside 同's open-bottom outer frame

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.12 Retrieval 2 — school and people

Write it: 中 and 同 from memory

Your turn

Hear **middle school**, **middle-school student**, and **classmate** in mixed order. Say each. *Read it:* each Mandarin form
Write it: each one
Repair one word at a time.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.13 Hear *shàngxué* — go to school

Say **up / on**, then **study**.

What to know first

shàngxué — **go to school; attend school**

Drop firmly on *shàng*, then rise on *xué*. No new character is hiding in the word.

Shàngxué is built from Middle Chinese *dzyangX*, "to go up", and *haewk*, "learning".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.14 上学 — go to school on the page

Read 上, then 学.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

上学 — *shàngxué* — **go to school; attend school**

Read the pair without pinyin: falling, then rising.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *dzyangX*, "to go up", and *haewk*, "learning" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Look at 上学, cover it, and write it once from memory.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.15 Retrieval 3 — place, person, classmate, action

Write it: 中 and 同

Read it: 学

Your turn

Hear four meanings in mixed order: **middle school**, **middle-school student**, **classmate**, **go to school**. Say each. *Read it:* each Mandarin form

Write it: each one
Sort them as place, person, relationship, or action.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.16 Retrieval 4 — the full school ladder

Write it: 小, 中, and 大 from memory

Your turn

Write it: two three-item rows without a model — primary / middle / university; then primary-school / middle-school / university students
Read it: both rows aloud
Write it: 同学 and 上学 onto the rows, from their English meanings

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

15.17 Payoff — four school compounds in four skills

Write it: 中, 同, 上, 学, and 生 without a model

Your turn

1. **Listening:** hear the four words in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking:** produce all four from their English meanings, with tones audible.
3. *Read it:* all four character cards without pinyin
4. **Writing:** hear all four. *Write it:* all four without a model

Pass each skill separately. Repair and retry only the failed skill.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 task outline and vocabulary.

Chapter 16

Character or language?

Modes: **voice** (8) **eyes** (1) **pen** (6) **Hands-free start:** the first of 15 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 字, 汉字 and 汉语 after gaining 汉 and 语 through source-verified observation, tracing, guided copying and delayed recall.
>
> *Three identity words are retrieved across two expanding reviews, then checked independently in listening, speaking, unassisted reading and no-model writing.*

16.1 Hear *zì* — a written character

Say **middle school** in Mandarin.

What to know first

zì — **a written Chinese character**

You heard a light *zi* at the end of *míngzi*. Standing alone, this word has a sharp falling tone: *zì*. Stay with sound and meaning for this tiny step.

Zì is inherited from Middle Chinese *dziH*; an older sense of the word was "to bear and nurse children".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.2 字 — the familiar shape stands alone

Say **written character** in Mandarin.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

字 — *zì* — **a written Chinese character**

Hide the pinyin. Read 字 from its familiar roof-over-child shape, then say its falling tone. You are attaching a standalone word to writing you already know.
字 is inherited from Middle Chinese *dziH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The Guangyun quotes the Shuowen dictionary for an older sense, "to bear and nurse children"; "written character" came later.

Your turn

Look at 字 for three seconds. Cover it, wait five seconds, then write it once. Check only two things: roof before child, and six strokes.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.3 Hear *hànzì* — Chinese character

Say *zì* and its meaning.

What to know first

hànzì — **Chinese character; Han character**

The second half is your known *zì*, written character. The first half, *hàn*, labels it as Han Chinese. Hear two clean falling tones: *hàn-zì*. The new first character stays hidden until the next lesson.

Hànzì is built from Middle Chinese *xanH*, first a river's name and then the Han dynasty's, and *dziH*, "written character".

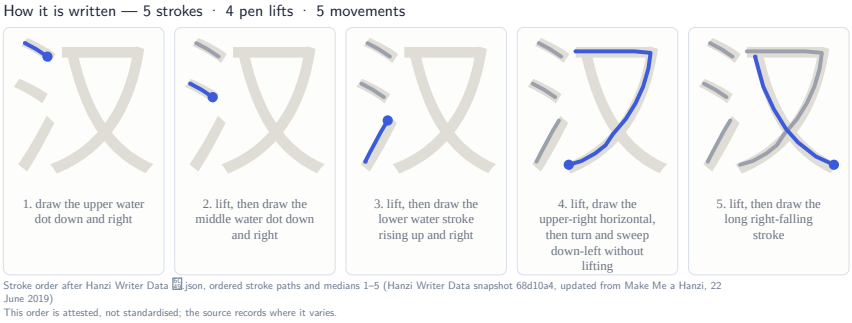
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.4 汉 — watch five strokes

Say **Chinese character**, then point to the new first half of 汉字.

Script — the shape



How 汉 is written, stroke by stroke

In 汉, write 氵 first. On the right, stroke four crosses right and turns down-left without lifting. Stroke five falls down-right. Five strokes; four lifts. Watch the crossing open into two different falling directions.

Your turn

Trace 汉 once, slowly. Say **dot, dot, rise; turn left; fall right**.

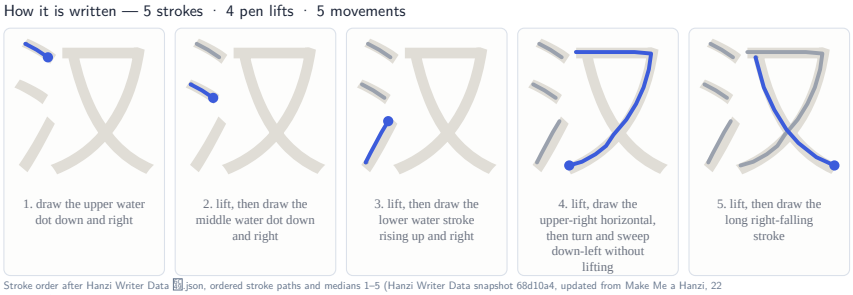
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 汉, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.5 汉 — copy with a five-part cue

Air-write 氵: dot, dot, rise.

Your turn



How 汉 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 汉 twice while the model remains visible. First say the five-part cue. On the second copy, pause after 氵 and check that the right side still has only two strokes.

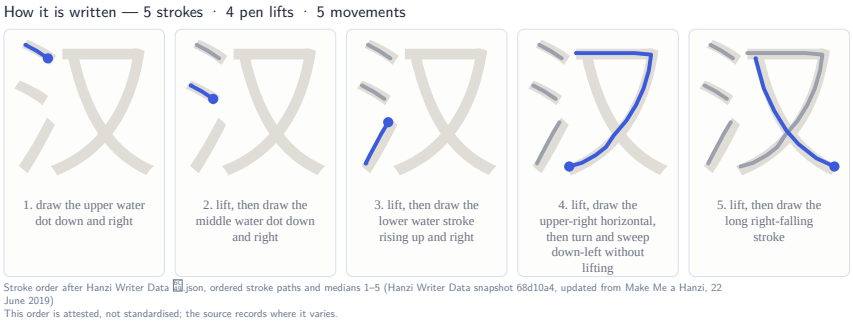
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 汉, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.6 汉 — hold the route briefly

Look at 汉 for five seconds. Cover it.

Your turn



How 汉 is written, stroke by stroke

Study 汉 for five seconds. Cover it. Say the five-part cue, wait five more seconds, then write once. Reveal the model and repair only the first wrong stroke; do not copy the whole character again unless needed.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 汉, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.7 汉字 — two known routes, one word

Say **Chinese character** in Mandarin.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

汉字 — *hànzì* — **Chinese character**

Read it: the two characters first without pinyin — Han Chinese + written character
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese. *xanH* was the name of a river (Guangyun); the Han dynasty took its name from that region, and Han came to mean Chinese. *dziH* is "written character".

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 汉字 — leave a small, even gap; do not merge the two squares

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.8 Hear *hànyǔ* — the Chinese language

Say **Chinese character** in Mandarin.

What to know first

hànyǔ — **the Chinese language; Mandarin**

Keep the known falling *hàn*. Then let *yǔ* dip in third tone. The new written half waits; today the contrast is heard: *hànzì* is a character, *hànyǔ* is the language.

Hànyǔ is built from Middle Chinese *xanH*, the Han river and dynasty, and *ngjoX*, "words, speech".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.9 Retrieval 1 — 字 and 汉字

Say **written character**. *Write it:* the same word, without a model

Your turn

Hear **written character** and **Chinese character** in mixed order. Say each answer. *Read it:* each Mandarin form without pinyin

Write it: each one without a model

Repair only the missed item.

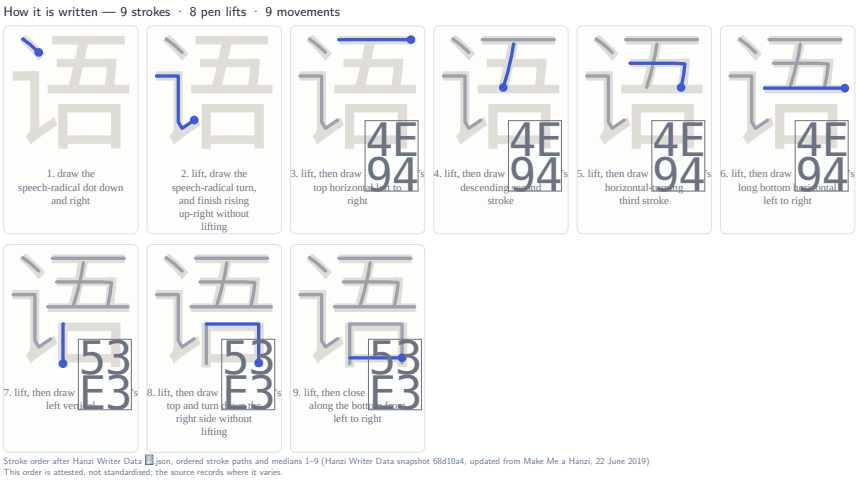
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.10 语 — speech, five, box

Air-write , then say *hànyǔ*.

Script — the shape



How 语 is written, stroke by stroke

Write 讠 first. On the right, build 五 from top to bottom, then close 口 at the base. Nine strokes; eight lifts. Keep the speech side narrow so the right side has room.

Your turn

Trace 语 once. Say **speech, five, box** as your hand crosses the three parts.

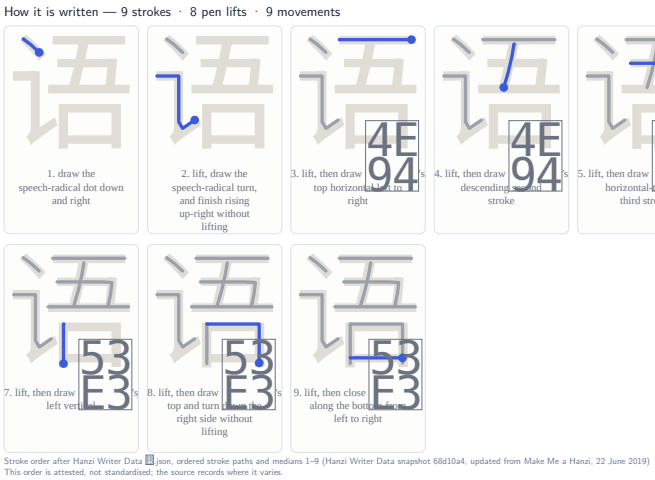
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 语, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.11 语 — copy, then fade

> Say **the Chinese language**, then point across 语 and say **speech, five, box**.

Your turn



How 语 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Copy 语 once beside the model. Cover it halfway. Copy again from the visible half, keeping 讠 narrow and the final 口 closed.

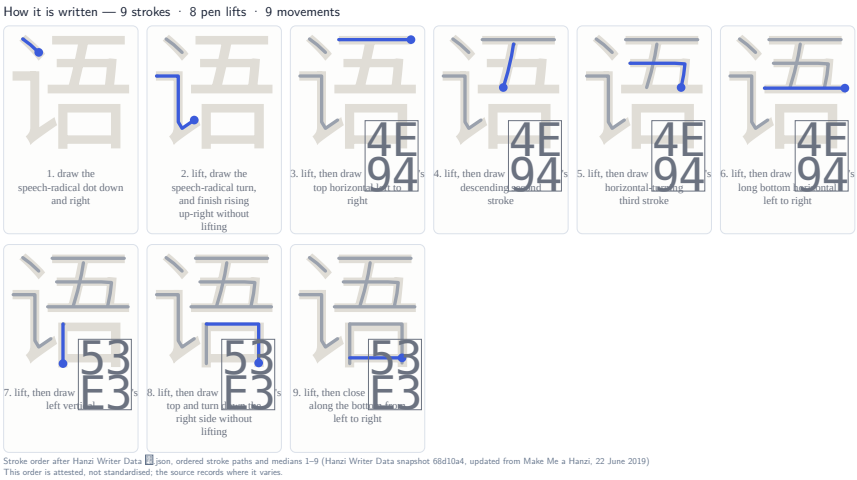
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 语, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.12 语 — wait, then write

Say **the Chinese language**.

Your turn



How 语 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Look at 语 for five seconds, then cover it.

Tap once for every lift while saying **speech, five, box**. Now write 语 without uncovering the model. Compare only after you finish.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 语, pinned stroke paths and medians.

16.13 汉语 — the language in writing

Say **the Chinese language** in Mandarin.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Read it: 汉语 first, before the explanation

汉语

It joins Han Chinese + language: *hànyǔ*, **the Chinese language**. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *xanH*, the river that gave the Han dynasty its name, and *ngjoX*, “words, speech” (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 汉语 — keep two separate squares
Read it: the whole word aloud

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.14 Retrieval 2 — character or language?

Say **the Chinese language**. *Write it:* **the Chinese language**, without a model

Your turn

Hear **written character**, **Chinese character**, and **Chinese language** in a mixed order. Say each answer. *Read it:* each answer
Write it: each answer — for the two 汉 compounds, listen for the ending before choosing 字 or 语

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

16.15 Checkpoint — 字, 汉字, 汉语

Write it: 汉 and 语 without a model

Your turn

1. **Listening:** hear the three words in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking:** produce all three from their English meanings, with tones audible.
3. *Read it:* 字, 汉语, 汉字 cold, then give each meaning
4. **Writing:** hear **Chinese character** and **Chinese language**. *Write it:* both without a model

Pass each skill separately. *Check:* the 字 or 语 ending only after both written words are complete

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

Chapter 17

Language or country?

Modes: **voice** (9) **eyes** (1) **pen** (7) **Hands-free start:** the first of 17 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 中文 and 中国, keep all five identity words distinct, and score listening, speaking, reading and writing separately.
>
> *Two new identity words and the three earlier forms return at expanding intervals before separate listening, speaking, cold reading and no-model writing scores.*

17.1 Hear *zhōngwén* — Chinese

> From the last chapter, say 汉语, 汉字, 字 for **Chinese language, Chinese character, written character**. Then say the sound of 中: *zhōng*.

What to know first

> *zhōngwén* — **Chinese; the Chinese language**

Keep the level first tone in *zhōng*. Let *wén* rise in second tone. The new second character stays hidden for now; this step is only sound and meaning.

Zhōngwén is built from Middle Chinese *trjuwng*, "middle", and *mjun*, "writing".

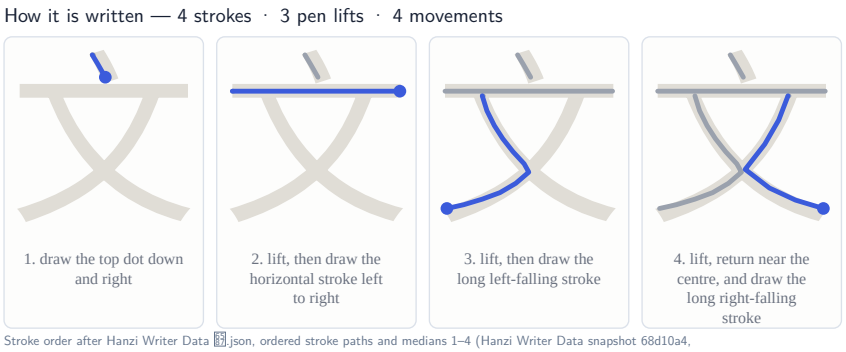
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.2 文 — watch four open strokes

Say **go to school** as *shàngxué* and write 谢 once from memory. Then say **Chinese language** as *zhōngwén*.

Script — the shape



How 文 is written, stroke by stroke

Write 文 in four separate strokes: top dot, horizontal bar, long fall left, long fall right. The last two strokes begin near the centre and open in opposite directions. Four strokes; three lifts.

Your turn

Trace 文 once. Say **dot, bar, left, right** as your hand moves.

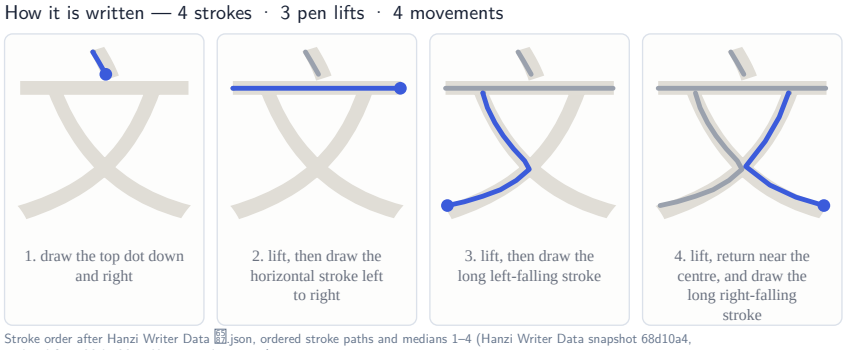
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 文, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.3 文 — copy with the route visible

Read 上学, say **thank you** in Mandarin, then air-write **dot, bar, left, right**.

Your turn



How 文 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 文 twice beside the model. On the second copy, pause after the bar and check that the two long falling strokes still open from the centre.

Your turn — Spaced Return

From the cues **thank you** and **go to school**, say 谢谢 and write 上学 once.

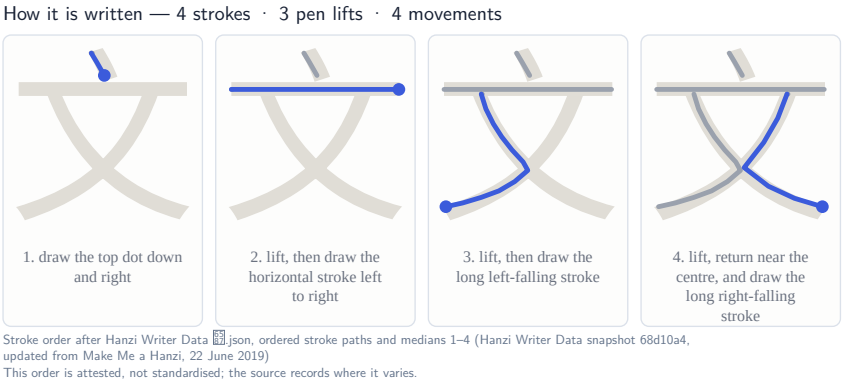
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 文, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.4 文 — wait, then open the two falls

Answer 谢谢 with 不谢.

Your turn



How 文 is written, stroke by stroke

Look at 文 for five seconds and cover it.

Say **dot, bar, left, right**, then write 文 once without the model. Reveal it only after the fourth stroke. Repair only the first mismatch.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **you are welcome** and write 不谢 without a model.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 文, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.5 中文 — two known squares

Run the two-line 谢谢 / 不谢 exchange. Then take one Chapter 15 school word by its English meaning and hear its Mandarin word. *Write it:* that word

Read it: that word aloud, then give its meaning

Finally say **Chinese language** as *zhōngwén*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Read it: 中文 first, before the explanation

中文

It joins China or middle + writing or language: *zhōngwén*, **Chinese**. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *trjuwng*, "middle", and *mjun*, "writing" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 中文 — keep the two squares separate and let 文 open at the base

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.6 Longer return — character or language?

Read it: 中文

Write it: 请, pointing to its 青 sound component, then **written character** without a model

Your turn

Hear **Chinese character** and **Chinese language** in mixed order. Say each. *Read it:* each Mandarin form without pinyin

Write it: each one

Listen for the ending before choosing 字 or 语.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.7 Hear *zhōngguó* — China

Say **please**, then say **Chinese language** as *zhōngwén*.

What to know first

zhōngguó — **China**

The first syllable stays *zhōng*. Change the rising ending: *wén* names writing or language; *guó* names a country. The new written ending waits one lesson.

Zhōngguó is built from Middle Chinese *trjuwng*, “middle”, and *kwok*, “state”.

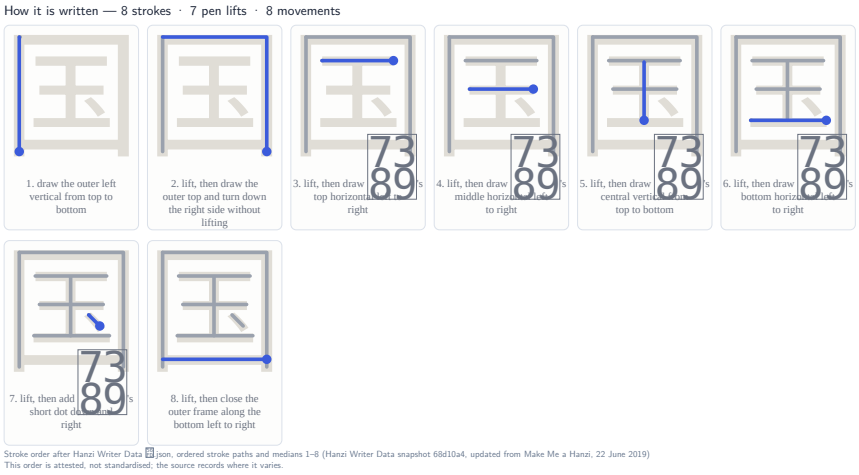
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.8 国 — frame, inside, close

Say **China**. Put 请 before a familiar request, then air-write the opening two strokes of a box without closing it.

Script — the shape



How 国 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Write 国 in eight strokes. Open the outer frame with its left side, then top-and-right. Finish every stroke of 玉 inside. Only then add the bottom bar that closes the frame. Eight strokes; seven lifts.

Your turn

Trace 国 once. Say **frame, three bars, upright, dot, close**. Keep the bottom open until the inner dot is finished.

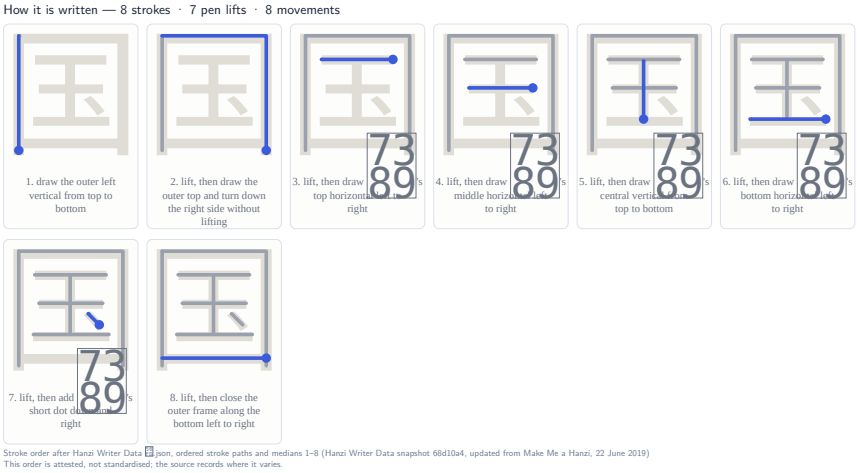
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 国, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.9 国 — copy with the frame open

Say the meaning of 人 and write 汉 once from memory. Then say **frame, inside, close**.

Your turn



How 国 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 国 twice beside the model. On the second copy, pause after the inner dot. Check that the outer bottom is still open; then close it with stroke eight.

Your turn — Spaced Return

From the cues **person** and **Han**, say 人 and write 汉 once without a model.

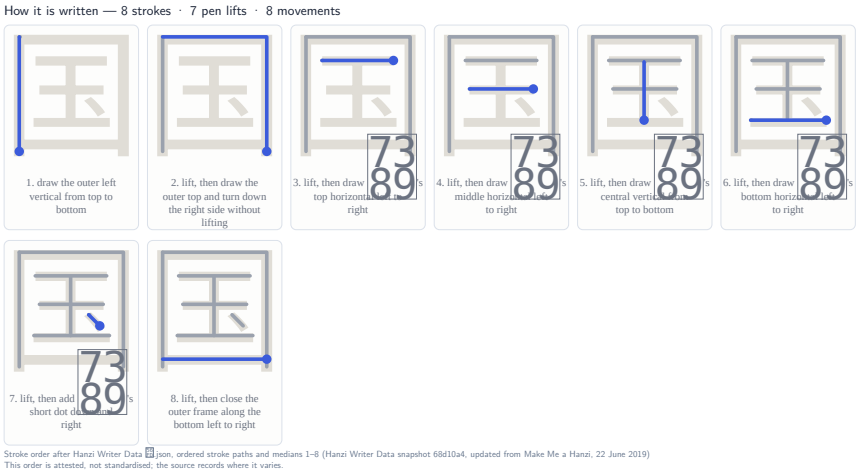
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 国, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.10 国 — wait before closing

Say what 女 means.

Your turn



How 国 is written, stroke by stroke

Look at 国 for five seconds and cover it.

Say **frame, inside, close**, then write 国 once without the model. Do not uncover it until the bottom bar is complete.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **woman** and write 女 without a model.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 国, pinned stroke paths and medians.

17.11 中国 — China in two squares

Say **son** as *érzi*, then say **China** as *zhōngguó*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Read it: 中国 first, before the explanation

中国

The shared 中 is followed by 国, country: *zhōngguó*, **China**. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjuwng* and *kwok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The pair is very old and first meant the central states, the realm at the middle; it became the country's name much later.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 中国 — in 国, finish the inner 玉 before closing the bottom

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.12 Retrieval 1 — language or country?

Write it: 儿 once from memory

Then say **Chinese language**. *Write it:* the same word, without a model

Your turn

Hear **Chinese language** and **China** in mixed order. Say each answer.
Read it: each Mandarin form without pinyin
Write it: each one — keep 中 and retrieve the correct ending

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.13 Longer return — the older three

Say **the Chinese language** with the 汉 beginning.

Your turn

Write it: without looking back, **written character**, **Chinese character**, and **Chinese language**

Read it: each answer aloud only after all three are complete

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.14 Listening score — five meanings

Say **daughter**, then say **Chinese language** with 中 and **China**.

Your turn

Keep the page covered. Hear the five Mandarin words in mixed order and give the English meaning of each. Then reverse the direction and say all five Mandarin forms. Score listening and speaking separately out of five.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.15 Reading score — no pinyin

Read it: 中国 and 中文 without saying their pinyin first

Your turn

Read it: five unpointed cards in a shuffled order — 汉语, 字, 中国, 汉字, 中文 — each cold, then give its meaning

Score one point per form; pronunciation help comes only after the reading score is recorded.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.16 Writing score — from sound, no model

Say what 家 means. Write 家, 汉, 语, 文, 国 without a model. Check only after all five are complete.

Your turn

First say what 家 means, then recover 汉, 语, 文, 国 once from their spoken syllables. Next hear **Chinese character**, **Chinese language with** 汉, **Chinese language with** 中, and **China** in mixed order. Write all four without a model. Score the four whole words first; then repair only a missed character.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

17.17 Payoff — five identity words

Write 家, 文, and 国 without a model, then name each aloud.

Your turn

1. **Listening, /5:** hear all five words in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking, /5:** produce all five from meaning cards, with tones audible.
3. **Reading, /5:** read 中国, 汉语, 字, 中文, 汉字 cold, without pinyin.
4. **Writing, /5:** hear all five meanings and write each form without a model.

Pass each skill separately. A miss in one column does not cancel the other three. For repair, revisit only the missed form and retry that skill.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

Chapter 18

Looking and reading

Modes: **voice** (12) **eyes** (5) **pen** (6) **Hands-free start:** the first of 23 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 看, 看见, 好看, 书 and 看书, and score listening, speaking, reading and writing separately.
>
> *Two carefully staged characters support five nearby meanings, expanding retrieval and separate listening, speaking, cold-reading and no-model writing scores.*

18.1 Hear *kàn* — look or watch

> Say **Chinese language** and **China** in Mandarin. Keep those answers separate. *Cover:* the cards, and put them away.

What to know first

> *kàn* — **“look at”; “watch”**

Start high and let the tone fall cleanly. The written form stays hidden in this first step so sound and meaning can settle before handwriting begins.

Kàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *khanH*, “to look”, also read *khan*.

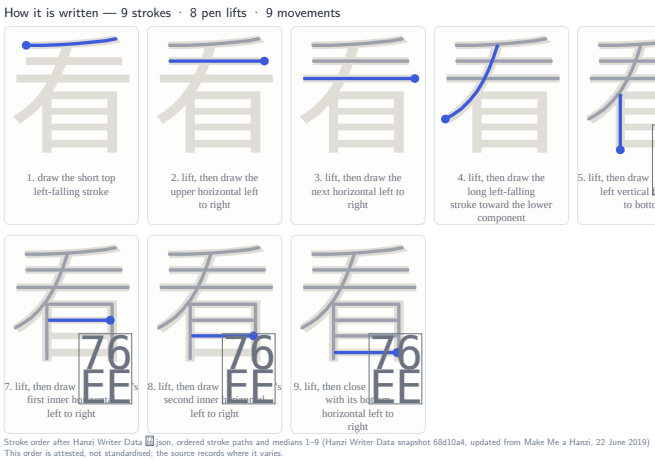
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.2 看 — a hand above an eye

Say **look or watch** as *kàn*. Then write the familiar 中 once and put it away before meeting the new shape.

Script — the shape



How 看 is written, stroke by stroke

Write 看 in nine strokes. Make the short top stroke first, then the two crossing strokes and the long left fall above. Finish with 目 below: left, top-and-right, two inner bars, bottom. Nine strokes; eight lifts.

Your turn

Trace 看 once. Say **hand above, eye below** while keeping the lower box wide enough for its two inner bars.

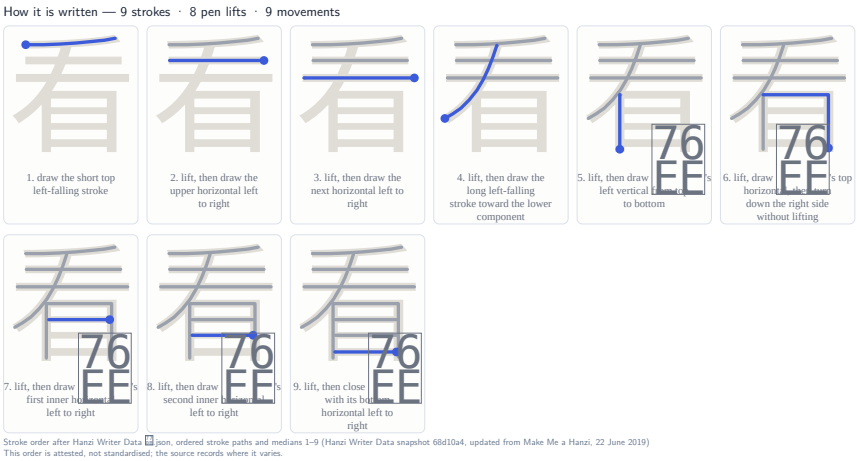
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 看, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.3 看 — copy hand above, eye below

Read 中文 and give its meaning. Then air-write **hand above, eye below**.

Your turn



How 看 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 看 twice beside the model. On the second copy, pause before 目 and check that the long falling stroke points toward the eye rather than through it.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **Chinese language with** 中 and write 中文 once without pinyin.

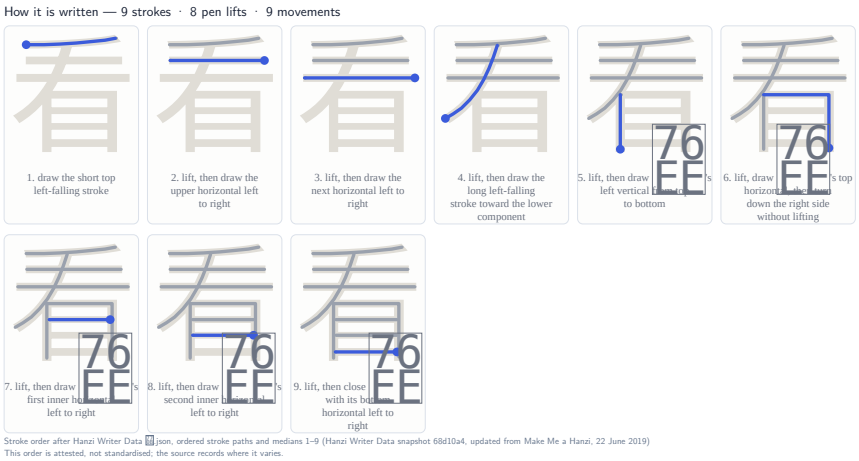
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 看, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.4 看 — wait, then recover the eye

Write 中国 from the meaning **China**.

Your turn



How 看 *is written, stroke by stroke*

Look at 看 for five seconds and cover it.

Say **hand above, eye below**, then write 看 once without the model. Reveal it only after all nine strokes. Repair only the first mismatch.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **China** once more and write 中国 without a model.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 看, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.5 看 — the familiar sound meets the shape

Say **look at or watch** in Mandarin.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

看 — *kàn* — **look at; watch**

Hide the pinyin. Read 看 from the hand-over-eye shape, say the falling tone, then give the meaning. One form now connects listening, speaking, reading, and writing.

看 is inherited from Middle Chinese, where the Guangyun lists it as *khan* and *khanH*, "to look" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); Mandarin *kàn* continues the second. The hand over the eye is the history of the character.

Your turn

Hear *kàn*. Wait three seconds, then write 看 once without a model.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.6 Hear *kànjiàn* — see

Say **look or watch** as *kàn*, then say **goodbye** as *zàijiàn*.

What to know first

kànjiàn — **see; catch sight of**

Both syllables fall. The familiar *jiàn* now follows *kàn*: you look and successfully perceive. Keep the characters hidden for this sound-first step.

Kànjiàn is built from Middle Chinese *khanH*, "to look", and *kenH*, "to see".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.7 看见 — looking reaches seeing

Say **see** as *kànjiàn*. *Write it:* 看

Point to: 见 in 再见

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

看见 — *kànjiàn* — **see; catch sight of**

Read it: the two known shapes from left to right

看 supplies looking; 见 marks the perceived result.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *khanH*, "look", and *kenH*, "see" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 看见 — leave a clear boundary between the nine-stroke 看 and the four-stroke 见

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.8 Hear *hǎokàn* — good-looking

Say **good**, **look**, and **see** as three separate Mandarin answers.

What to know first

hǎokàn — **good-looking; nice to look at**

Let *hǎo* dip, then let *kàn* fall. This is a description, not an instruction to look. The characters wait until the next tiny step.

Hǎokàn is built from Middle Chinese *xawX*, "good", and *khanH*, "to look".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.9 好看 — good to look at

Say **good-looking** as *hǎokàn*. Write 好 and 看 separately.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好看 — *hǎokàn* — **good-looking; nice to look at**

No new character is hiding here. Read 好, then 看, and let the literal pieces carry you to the whole meaning.

Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *xawX*, "good", and *khanH*, "look" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Copy 好看 once. Keep both characters full-sized instead of squeezing 看.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.10 Retrieval 1 — look, see, or good-looking?

Say **look**, **see**, and **good-looking** in that order.

Your turn

Hear the three meanings in mixed order. Listen for what comes beside *kàn* before deciding the whole meaning, then say each Mandarin answer. *Read it:* each Mandarin form without pinyin

Write it: each one

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.11 Hear *shū* — book

Say **look**, **see**, and **good-looking** in Mandarin.

What to know first

shū — **book**

Hold one level first tone. Do not add *kàn* yet; this step is only the object, **book**. Its four-stroke written form waits until the next lesson.

Shū is inherited from Middle Chinese *syo*, "writing".

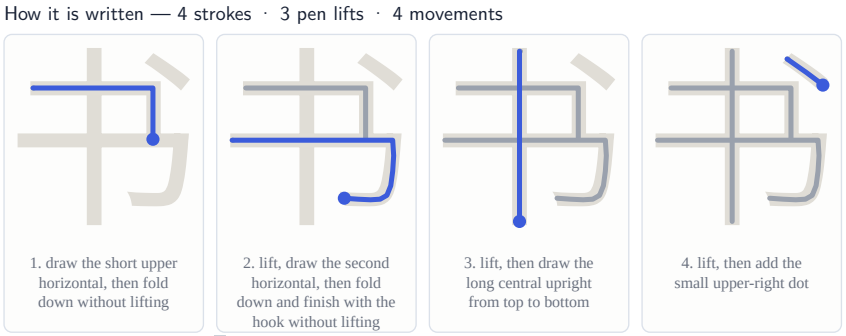
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.12 书 — two folds, upright, dot

Say **book** as *shū*, then write 看 once from memory.

Script — the shape



How 书 is written, stroke by stroke

Write 书 in four strokes: a short horizontal that folds down, a second horizontal that folds and hooks, the long central upright, then the small dot at the upper right. Four strokes; three lifts.

Your turn

Trace 书 once. Say **fold, hooked fold, upright, dot**. Let the upright pass through the middle instead of leaning toward the dot.

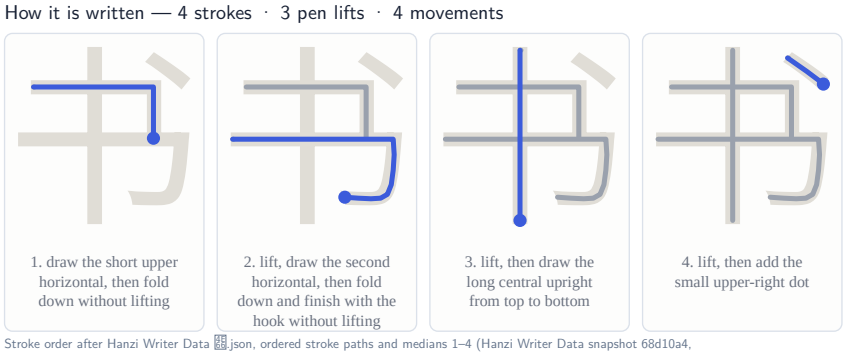
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 书, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.13 书 — copy the compact route

Read 看见 and give its meaning. Then air-write **fold, hooked fold, upright, dot**.

Your turn



How 书 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 书 twice beside the model. On the second copy, pause before the upright and check that both folds leave a clear central route.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **see** and write 看见 once without a model.

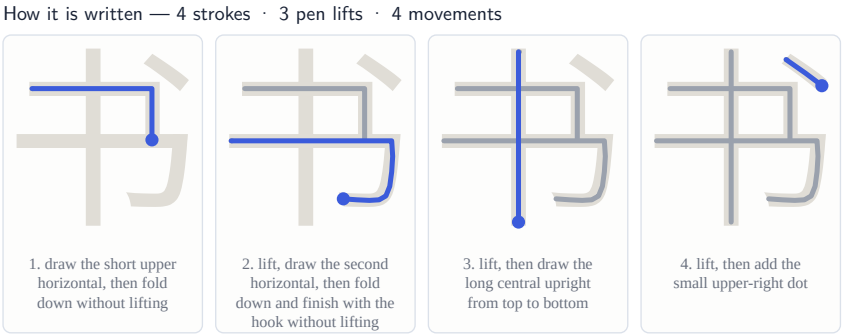
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 书, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.14 书 — wait, then place the dot

Write 好看 from the meaning **good-looking**.

Your turn



How 书 is written, stroke by stroke

Look at 书 for five seconds and cover it.

Say **fold, hooked fold, upright, dot**, then write 书 once without the model. Check only after the dot is in place.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **good-looking** and write 好看 without a model.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 书, pinned stroke paths and medians.

18.15 书 — the sound meets the shape

Say **book** in Mandarin.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

书 — *shū* — **book**

Cover: the pinyin
Read it: 书, hold the level first tone, then give its meaning
书 is inherited from Middle Chinese *syo*, "writing" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); "book" grew from it.

Your turn

Hear *shū*. Wait three seconds. *Write it:* 书 once, without a model

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.16 Hear *kànshū* — read a book

Say **look or watch**, then say **book**.

What to know first

kànshū — **read a book; read books**

Let *kàn* fall and keep *shū* level. Mandarin says **look-at + book** for the activity **read**. Keep the characters hidden for one more tiny step.

Kànshū is built from Middle Chinese *khanH*, "to look", and *syo*, "writing".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.17 看书 — look at a book, read

Say **read a book** as *kànshū*. Write 看 and 书 separately.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

看书 — *kànshū* — **read a book; read books**

Read the action first and its object second. No new character is hiding here: 看 + 书 gives the whole reading activity.
Both are inherited from Middle Chinese: *khanH*, "look", and *syo*, "writing, book" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Copy 看书 once. Keep the long upright in 书 centred after the denser 看.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.18 Retrieval 2 — the earlier three return

Say **read a book** in Mandarin, then set that word aside.

Your turn

Write it: without looking back, **look**, **see**, and **good-looking** from mixed meaning cards

Read it: each answer aloud only after all three are complete

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.19 Retrieval 1 — book or read a book?

Say **book**, then say **read a book**.

Your turn

Hear the two meanings in mixed order. Listen for *kàn* before deciding noun or activity, then say each answer. *Read it:* each Mandarin form without pinyin

Write it: each one

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.20 Listening score — five nearby meanings

Say **look** and **book** in Mandarin.

Your turn

Keep the page covered. Hear all five Mandarin forms in mixed order and give each meaning. Then reverse the direction and say all five Mandarin forms. Score listening and speaking separately out of five.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.21 Reading score — no pinyin

Read it: 看 and 书 without saying their pinyin first

Your turn

Read it: five unpointed cards in a shuffled order — 好看, 书, 看见, 看书, 看 — each cold, then give its meaning

Score one point per form before any pinyin help.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.22 Writing score — sound to Hanzi, no model

Write it: 看 and 书 from their spoken syllables — check only after both are complete

Your turn

Hear the five meanings in mixed order. *Write it:* all five forms without a model

Score each whole form first. Then repair only the first missed character or ordering choice.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

18.23 Payoff — looking and reading

Write 看 and 书 without a model, then name each aloud.

Your turn

1. **Listening, /5:** hear all five forms in mixed order and choose each meaning.
2. **Speaking, /5:** produce all five from meaning cards, with tones audible.
3. **Reading, /5:** read 看书, 好看, 书, 看见, 看 cold, without pinyin.
4. **Writing, /5:** hear all five meanings and write each form without a model.

Pass each skill separately. Repair only a missed form in the missed skill, then retry that column without cancelling the other three scores.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

Chapter 19

Asking

Modes: **voice** (12) **eyes** (2) **pen** (3) **Hands-free start:** the first of 17 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand, say, read and write 吗, 你好吗, 是吗 and 好不好, turn any statement I already own into a yes-or-no question by either of Mandarin's two patterns, and score listening, speaking, reading and writing separately.
>
> *Before this chapter the track could greet, name, count to five and say what it read, and could not ask a yes-or-no question about any of it. One character closes that and does more than its own weight:* 吗 *goes on the end of a finished sentence and changes nothing else, so every statement already taught becomes a question. The second pattern costs no character at all – it is* 不*, held since the negation lesson, placed between two copies of a word.*

19.1 Hear *ma* — the syllable that asks

> Say **look**, **book**, and **read a book** in Mandarin. Name your four scores from the looking-and-reading payoff, and which of the four was lowest.

What to know first

> *ma* — **the question particle**

Say it light, short and flat. It carries **no tone**, which makes it the first syllable in this book with none — every earlier one has been first, second, third or fourth. Give it none at all, and no stress either.

It also carries **no meaning** on its own. There is nothing to translate. What it does is turn the sentence in front of it into a question, and it does that without moving a single other word.

Hear *kàn shū* and then *kàn shū ma*. The words are identical and in the same order; only the light syllable at the end is new, and only the second one is asking.

Ma is usually explained as coming from Middle Chinese *mju*, "not have", said at the end of a question; the account is not settled.

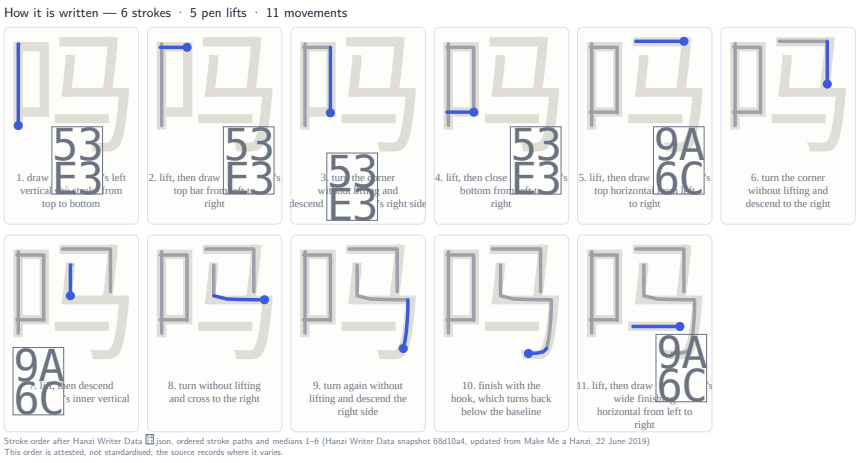
Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.2 吗 — the mouth, then the horse

Say the neutral question syllable. Then write 口 in three strokes, and write 书 once from memory.

Script — the shape



How 吗 is written, stroke by stroke

Write 吗 in six strokes, left part first and complete:

- 口 on the left, small and lifted toward the top: the left vertical, then the horizontal that turns down the right side without lifting, then the closing bottom bar. Three strokes, as you already write it.

- 马 on the right, which supplies only the sound: a horizontal that turns down, then a long stroke that turns twice and hooks, then one wide horizontal across the whole right side. Three strokes.

Six strokes, five lifts. The 口 shrinks to about a third of the square and sits high; the wide final horizontal is the widest thing in the character and runs almost to the right edge.

The left half is doing real work even though it is not saying anything: 口 means *mouth*, and it marks 吗 as one of a family of characters that exist only to be spoken.

Your turn

Trace 吗 once. Say **mouth, mouth, mouth — turn, turn-and-hook, long bar**. Finish the whole 口 before starting the right half, and keep it small.

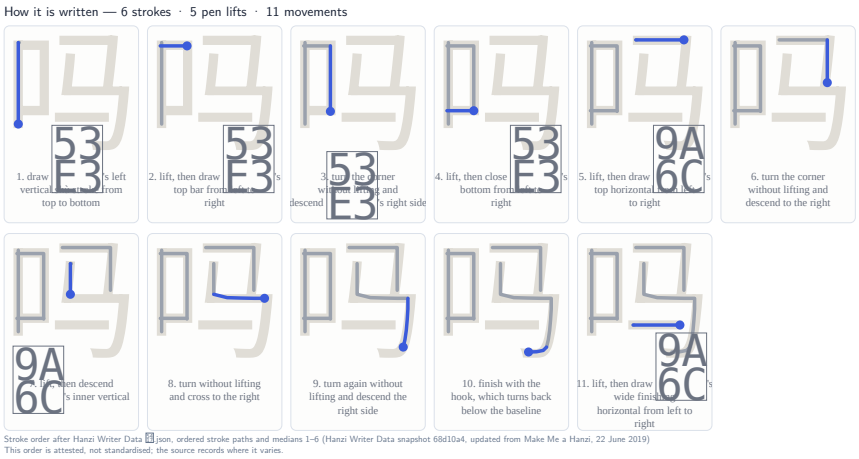
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 吗, pinned stroke paths and medians.

19.3 吗 — copy it, and keep the mouth small

Read 看书 and give its meaning. Then air-write **mouth, mouth, mouth — turn, turn-and-hook, long bar**. Say **see** and **primary school**, and write 看见.

Your turn



How 吗 is written, stroke by stroke

Copy 吗 twice beside the model. On the second copy, stop after the third stroke and check two things before going on: the 口 fills about a third of the width, and its bottom sits above the middle of the square.

Your turn — Spaced Return

Hear **read a book** and write 看书 once without a model.

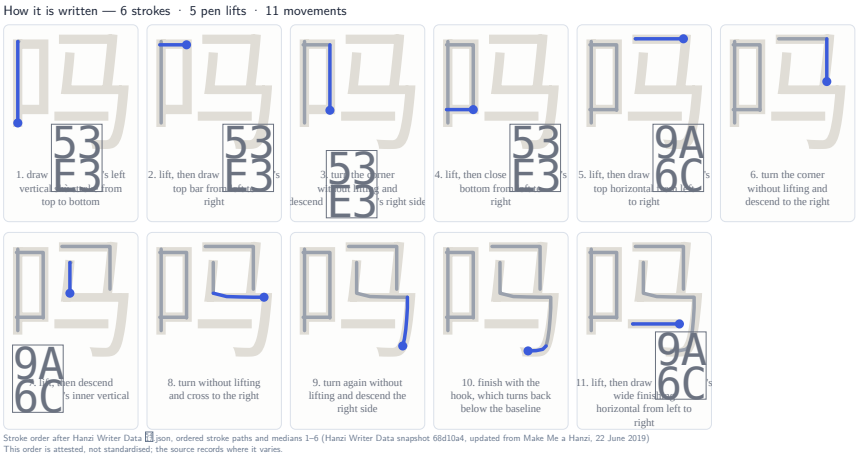
Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 吗, pinned stroke paths and medians.

19.4 吗 — wait, then write the bar

Say the neutral question syllable, then write 书 once from memory.

Your turn



How 吗 is written, stroke by stroke

Look at 吗 for five seconds. Cover it, wait five more, then write it once. Uncover and check the order: all three strokes of 口 before anything on the right.

Most characters give you a meaning to hang the shape on. This one does not — it means nothing by itself — so the route is all you have, and that is why it gets its own delay.

Before you move on

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 吗, pinned stroke paths and medians.

19.5 吗 — the sound meets the shape

Say the neutral question syllable. Then say **look** and **read a book**. Say **good-looking** and **primary-school pupil**. *Write it:* 小

Recall your four looking-and-reading scores.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

吗 — *ma* — **the question particle**

Cover: the pinyin

Read it: 吗, give it no tone at all, then say what it does rather than what it means
吗 is usually explained as coming from Middle Chinese *mju*, "not have" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), tagged onto the end of a question, and later written with this character for its sound. The account is common but not settled.

Grammar lens — one character, every statement

Put 吗 at the **end** of a statement and the statement becomes a yes-or-no question. Nothing else changes:

- 你看书 — *nǐ kàn shū* — you read books.
- 你看书吗 — *nǐ kàn shū ma* — **do** you read books?

Same words. Same order. One character added at the end.
That is worth stopping on, because it is not how English works: English moves words about and borrows a helper verb — *you read* becomes *do you read* — and Mandarin does neither. Every statement you can already make is now also a question you can ask, and there are no new words to learn to ask any of them.
Chinese closes both of those lines with a mark of its own — a small hollow circle for the statement and a question mark for the question. Neither mark is taught yet, so neither is printed here.

Your turn

Hear *ma*. Wait three seconds. *Write it:* 吗 once, without a model
Then take any sentence you own and put 吗 on the end of it.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.6 Hear *nǐ hǎo ma* — how are you

Say **hello**. Then say the neutral syllable that turns a statement into a question.

What to know first

nǐ hǎo ma — **how are you?**

The very first thing this book taught you, with the very newest thing on the end of it. No new word arrives here at all.

Two third tones in a row still slide the first one up, exactly as they do in *nǐ hǎo* on its own — the light *ma* on the end changes nothing about that.

Nǐ hǎo ma is the greeting with the question particle added; *hǎo* is inherited from Middle Chinese *xawX*, "good".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.7 你好吗 — the greeting, asked

Say **how are you**. *Write it:* 你 and 好, then 好看 too

Say what the 好 is doing in 好看.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你好吗 — *nǐ hǎo ma* — **how are you?**

Read it: the three known shapes from left to right
They are 你, 好, and the new 吗 on the end. Every one of them is a character you have already written.
That is the whole of what 吗 buys you. The book has been able to write 你好 since its first page and has never once been able to ask anything. One character, six strokes, and the greeting turns into a question.
Chinese built it from 你好 and 吗: *hǎo* is inherited from Middle Chinese *xawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and 吗 is usually traced, with some doubt, to *mju*, "not have".

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 你好吗 — keep the three characters the same size
吗 is not written smaller for meaning nothing.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.8 Retrieval 1 — greeting, or question?

Say **hello**, then **how are you**, and name the difference between them. Then say **book**, and recall your four scores from the primary-school payoff.

Your turn

Hear the two meanings in mixed order. Say each Mandarin answer, read its unpointed card, then write it. Look at the last character before deciding whether you were greeted or asked.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.9 Hear *shì ma* — is that so?

Say **to be**, then say **how are you**.

What to know first

shì ma — **is that so? really?**

Two syllables: the verb **to be**, falling hard, then the light question syllable. Nothing else.

This is the move you make when somebody tells you something and you want to show you heard it and to invite them to go on. English spends a whole phrase on it — *is that so*, *really*, *oh yes?* — and Mandarin spends two syllables, one of which you learned yesterday.

Say it with the voice going **down** on *shì* and staying light on *ma*. Said flat it checks a fact; said with the fall exaggerated it registers surprise.

Shì ma is built from *shì*, from Middle Chinese *dzyeX*, and the question particle *ma*.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.10 是吗 — checking what you were told

Say **is that so**. *Write it:* 是, finishing 日 before the lower body, then 书 and 中 as well

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

是吗 — *shì ma* — **is that so? really?**

Two known shapes, in the order you hear them: the nine-stroke 是, then the six-stroke 吗.
It is the shortest sentence in the book and it is a complete turn in a conversation. Somebody says something; you say 是吗; they keep going. Nothing about it is a fixed phrase to memorise — it is the yes-or-no rule applied to a one-word sentence.
Chinese built it from 是, inherited from Middle Chinese *dzyeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and the question particle 吗, whose origin is not settled.

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 是吗 — leave a clear boundary between the two characters, and keep 是 the wider of the pair

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.11 Hear *hǎo bu hǎo* — the question with the answer inside it

Say **good**, say **not**, and say **is that so**.

What to know first

hǎo bu hǎo — **is it good? all right?**

Three syllables and no new word in any of them: **good**, **not**, **good**.

This is Mandarin's **second** way of asking a yes-or-no question, and it is completely unlike the first. Where *ma* adds a syllable that means nothing, this one says the word, then denies it, then says it again — and hands the listener both possible answers so they can pick one.

The **bu** in the middle goes light and toneless when it is caught between two copies of the same word. Say *hǎo-bu-hǎo* with the stress on the first and last and the middle syllable almost swallowed.

Both questions ask the same thing. *ma* is the neutral one; this one presses a little harder for a decision, which is why it is the one you hear at the end of a suggestion.

Hǎo bu hǎo is built from two words inherited from Middle Chinese: *xawX*, "good", and *pjut*, "not".

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.12 好不好 — the question that needed no new character

Say **is it good**. *Write it:* 好 and 不, keeping all four strokes of 不 separate

Say **secondary school**.

Grammar lens — say it, deny it, say it again

好不好 — *hǎo bu hǎo* — is it good? all right?

Three known shapes, and the pattern behind them works on anything:

- 是不是 — *shì bu shì* — is it, or isn't it?
- 看不看 — *kàn bu kàn* — will you look, or won't you?

Take any word that can be denied, put 不 in the middle, and repeat it. That is the whole rule, and it needs no new character because you have had 不 since the negation lesson.

Mandarin now gives you **two** ways to ask a yes-or-no question, and this book hands you both in this one chapter:

- 看书吗 — the light syllable on the end
- 看不看书 — the word, denied, and said again

They mean the same thing. Neither moves a word, and neither borrows a helper verb the way English does.
Both would be written with a question mark of Chinese's own at the end. That mark is not taught yet, so it is left off here.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好不好 is a Chinese pattern, not a borrowing: both words are inherited from Middle Chinese, *xawX*, "good", and *pjut*, "not" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Write it: one copy of 好不好, then one more of your own — take a word you can write, put 不 in the middle, and write it again

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.13 Retrieval 2 — which question was that?

Say **how are you**, **is that so**, and **is it good**, in that order.
Then say **read a book**. *Write it:* 中学

Your turn

Hear the three meanings in mixed order. Say each Mandarin answer. *Read it:* each Mandarin form without pinyin

Decide which of the two question patterns each one uses — the light syllable on the end, or the word denied in the middle.

Write it: each one

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.14 Listening score — catch the question

Say the light syllable that turns a statement into a question, and say where it goes. *Read it:* 看书 and 看见 aloud

Your turn

No cards and no writing. Hear each of the three, six times over in mixed order, and say the English meaning aloud before the next one starts.

Score listening on its own. A miss here is not a reading miss and not a writing miss, and it is repaired by hearing the item again rather than by looking at it.

The light *ma* is the thing most often missed, because it is short, toneless and last. If you lose one, that is almost certainly the one.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.15 Reading score — no pinyin on the card

Write it: 吗 once from memory, then 是

Then say **secondary-school pupil**.

Your turn

Read it: the three cards cold — no pinyin is printed on any of them — and for each one, say it aloud, then give the English

Score reading on its own. Reading and hearing fail differently here: by ear the light *ma* is easy to lose, and on the page it is the most visible thing in the sentence because it is a whole character. The one you miss reading is more likely to be 好不好, where nothing is added and the clue is a repetition.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.16 Payoff — the book can ask

Say **hello**, **to be**, **good**, **not**, and the light question syllable.
Write it: 中学生

Your turn

Four passes over the same four items, scored separately:

- **Listening.** Hear each of the four and give its English.
- **Speaking.** Be given the English and say the Mandarin, tones and all.
- *Read it:* four unpointed cards cold, then give their meanings
- **Writing.** Hear each one. *Write it:* each one with no model

Record four numbers, not one. A reader who hears all four and writes none has a writing problem, and averaging the two hides it.

What you've built

Before this chapter the book had no way to ask a yes-or-no question at all. It could greet, name, count to five, say what it saw and say what it read, and it could not ask about any of it.
One character closed that, and it did more than its own weight: every statement this book has taught you is now also a question, because 吗 goes on the end of a finished sentence and changes nothing else. The second pattern, 好不好, needed no new character whatsoever — it is 不, which you have had for chapters, put between two copies of a word.

Before you move on

Source: Official HSK 3.0 syllabus, Level 1 vocabulary.

19.17 From cold, eight chapters on

Close everything. The opening exchange of this book, both voices, from memory. If it came back without effort, that is the point of this page; if it did not, that is the point of this page.

You'll want to know: what a second pass is for

The first four exchanges were practised once, in the chapter that taught them, and not since. That is long enough ago to be a real test rather than a rehearsal:

greet	both voices, 你好
negate	answering that it is not so
identify	answering that it is
part	再见

Retrieval after a gap is what makes something stay. Running them again the week you learned them proves only that you had not yet forgotten.

Script and tone, the two that were taught once

女 + 子 → 好

Build 好 from its two halves without looking, then say it in both tones — *hǎo*, good, and *hào*, to be fond of. Two words, one set of six strokes, and the only thing separating them is the tone.

Your turn — four skills, on old material

- *Listen:* to a greeting and an answer, and say which of the two answers came back
- *Say it:* the greeting exchange, both voices
- *Read it:* 你好 and 再见, aloud, with nothing beside them
- *Write it:* 好, from its two halves, with the page covered

Before you move on

Which two halves build 好? (**女 and 子**.) What separates *hǎo* from *hào*? (**The tone alone.**) Which exchange closes a meeting? (**再见**.) And why is this page eight chapters after the material rather than beside it? (**Because retrieval after a gap is what makes it stay.**)

Chapter 20

Six to Ten, and the Character That Was Already Here

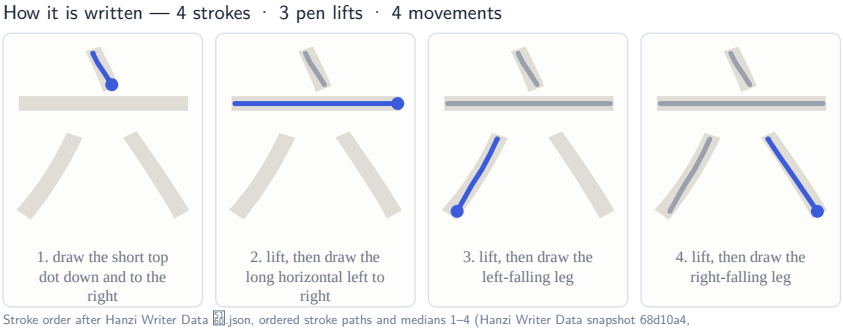
Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) ✓ **pen** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 11 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say, hear, read and write the Mandarin numbers one to ten with their tones, and write the five characters this chapter adds.
>
> *Five characters and twelve strokes finish a run the book abandoned at five seventeen chapters earlier – with 八 set against 人, and 十 finally taught on its own after thirteen chapters inside 早.*

20.1 六 — four strokes again, for six this time

Write 五. How many strokes, and how many does it mean?

Script — a dot, a bar, two legs



How 六 is written, stroke by stroke

六

Four strokes. For six. 五 had four for five; 六 has four for six. Whatever was left of the counting trick after chapter 3 is now gone for good.

The four strokes, in order:

1. the short **diǎn** dot at the top centre, down and to the right
2. the long **héng** horizontal beneath it, left to right
3. the left leg, a **piě** falling to the lower left
4. the right leg, a **nà** falling to the lower right

Top before bottom, then left before right — the two rules that have ordered every character in this book.

Hold on to strokes 3 and 4. On their own, without the dot and the bar, they are the character for **eight**, and you will write them again in two lessons.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 六 — dot, bar, left leg, right leg
- *Cover:* write it again from memory

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 六; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.2 六 — six, and the run starts again

Write it: 六

Then count aloud to five.

The sounds and tones in this word

六 *liù* means **six**.
liù is **fourth tone** — the sharp fall, the same shape as *sì*, four. Say them together and only the mouth changes: **sì, liù**.
The vowel is worth a moment. Pinyin writes *iu*, and what you say is closer to *ioū*: there is a faint **o** in the middle that the spelling does not print.

What you've built — the run starts again

This book taught 一 二 三 四 五 in chapter 3 and then stopped. For seventeen chapters it could name a family, a school and a greeting and could not count to six — could not give an age, a price, a floor or a date. 六 is where that starts being paid back.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

六 *liù* is inherited from Middle Chinese *ljuwk*, "six", which lost its final *k* in Mandarin (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). It is usually compared with Tibetan *drug*, a likely Sino-Tibetan cognate.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **sì**, **liù** — one fall, twice
- **yī èr sān sì wǔ liù** — the run, at speed

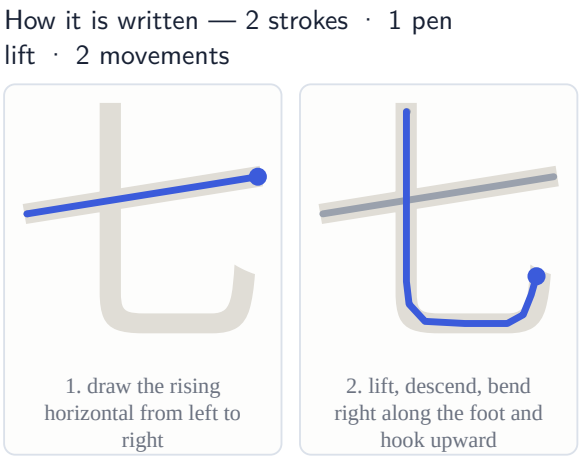
Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.3 七 — two strokes, for seven

Write 六 and say how many strokes it has.

Script — the second stroke does the work



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 七.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–2 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 七 is written, stroke by stroke

七

Two strokes. For seven. Six had four, seven has two — the stroke count is not merely useless now, it is running backwards.

The two strokes:

1. the **héng** horizontal, left to right, rising a little as it goes
2. the **shùwāngōu**: start high on the right, descend, bend along the foot to the right, and hook upward at the end

That second stroke is one continuous movement with two turns in it. Do not lift in the middle of it — a lift is what makes it two strokes instead of one, and seven would then be three.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 七 — the bar, then the turning stroke, unbroken
- *Count:* two strokes, not three

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 七; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.4 七 — seven

Write it: 七

Then say six.

The sounds and tones in this word

七 *qī* means **seven**.
qī is **first tone**, the high level one — the same shape as *yī*, one. Say them in a row and hold the pitch flat across both: **yī, qī**.
The **q** is the piece to work on, because English has no letter for it. Put the tongue where it goes for **y** in *yes*, then release the air the way you do for **ch**. It is not the *k* of *queen* and it is not an English *ch*; it is the tongue of one and the release of the other.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

七 *qī* is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshit*, "seven" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Mandarin turned its *tsh* into the *q* you are practising and dropped the final *t*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **yī**, **qī** — two high level tones

- **wǔ liù qī** — dip, fall, level

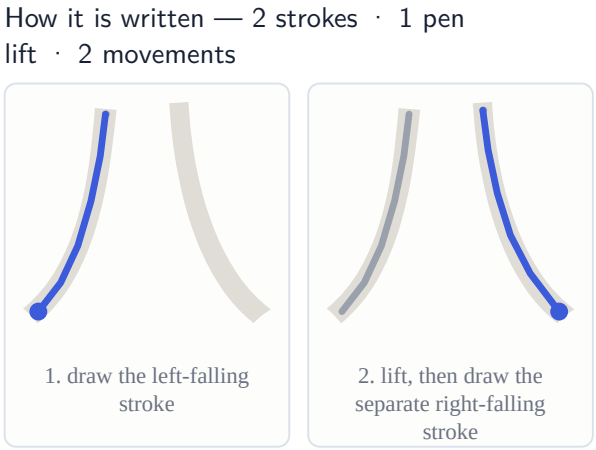
Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.5 八 — a character you have already written twice

Write 七, then write 六 and put a finger on its two legs.

Script — the gap is the character



How 八 is written, stroke by stroke

八

Two strokes. For eight.

1. the left leg, a **piě** falling to the lower left

2. lift, then the right leg, a **nà** falling to the lower right

You wrote both of them in 六 two lessons ago, under the dot and the bar. Take the dot and the bar away and what is left is eight.

And one more comparison, because it is the sharpest in the whole book: 人, *rén*, "person", is these same two strokes **joined at the top**. 八 is the same two strokes **parted**. The gap is the entire difference between a person and the number eight — which is why the first stroke of 八 begins below where 人's does, and why the two must never be allowed to touch.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 八 — left leg, lift, right leg, apart at the top
- *Contrast:* write 人 beside it and mark where they meet

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 八; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.6 八 — eight, and why it costs more

Write it: 八

Then say seven.

The sounds and tones in this word

八 *bā* means **eight**.
bā is **first tone**, high and level, like *qī*. The **b** is unaspirated: no puff of air, closer to an English *p* in *spin* than the *b* of *bin*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bā sounds close to *fā*, the first syllable of a word meaning to prosper or come into wealth. That resemblance is why eight is the number people pay extra for: on a car number plate, in a phone number, in the price of a flat on the eighth floor. The Beijing Olympics opened at eight seconds past eight on the eighth day of the eighth month.
A number can carry that much only in a language where numbers sound like other words, and this is the clearest case of it a beginner

will meet.
The word itself is inherited from Middle Chinese *peat*, "eight" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the luck rests on a likeness of sound, not on where the word comes from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **qī**, **bā** — two level tones
- **liù qī bā** — fall, level, level

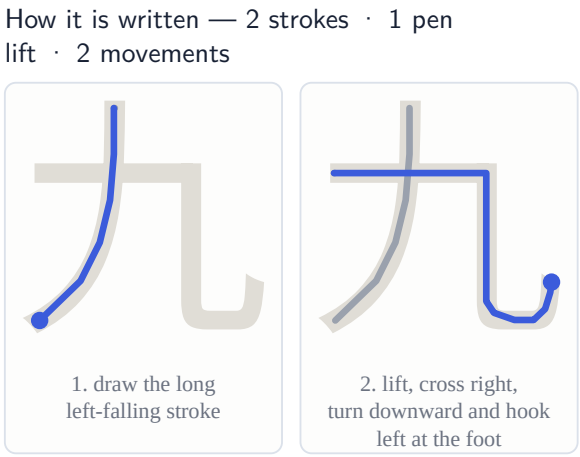
Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.7 九 — two strokes again

Write 八 and 七. How many strokes between them? Say why eight is the number people pay extra for.

Script — a fall and a turn



How 九 is written, stroke by stroke

九

Two strokes. For nine.

1. a long **piě**, falling from the upper right all the way to the lower left
2. lift, then the **héngzhéwāngōu**: cross the first stroke to the right, turn downward, and hook back to the left at the foot

Seven, eight and nine are two strokes each. **The last three single digits are the three quickest characters in this book to write**, and the three largest numbers you have. Whatever intuition said that bigger numbers need more ink is finished.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 九 — the long fall, then the crossing turn with its hook
- 七 八 九 in a row — six strokes for three numbers

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 九; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.8 九 — nine

Write it: 九

Then say eight.

The sounds and tones in this word

九 *jiǔ* means **nine**.
jiǔ is **third tone**, the low dip — so it joins *nǐ*, *hǎo* and *wǔ*. Say all four in a row and let the pitch stay low and creaky across every one.
The **j** is the unaspirated partner of the **q** in *qī*: same tongue position, no puff of air. Say **qī jiǔ** and the only difference is the breath.
Keep the dip in mind. Two third tones in a row do not both dip — the first one lifts — and nine is about to give this book its first pair of them.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

九 *jiǔ* is inherited from Middle Chinese *kjuwX*, "nine" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); Mandarin softened the *k* to *j*. It is usually compared with Tibetan *dgu*, a likely Sino-Tibetan cognate.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **nǐ hǎo wǔ jiǔ** — four dips
- **qī jiǔ** — the same tongue, one with breath and one without
- **qī bā jiǔ**

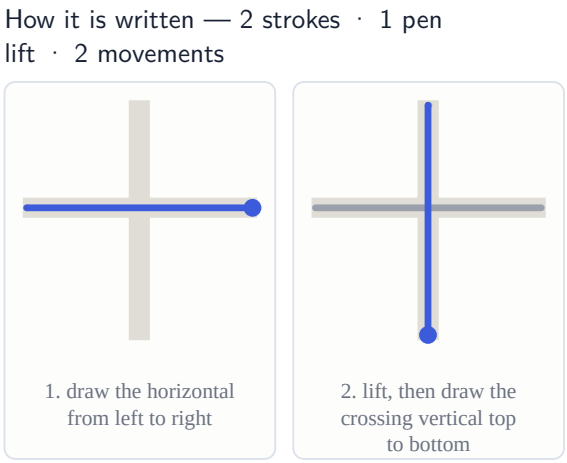
Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.9 十 — the character that was already here

Write 早, *zǎo*, morning. Say what sits under the sun in it.

Script — a bar and a post



How 十 is written, stroke by stroke

十

Two strokes. For ten.

1. the **héng** horizontal, left to right
2. lift, then the **shù** vertical, top to bottom, crossing it at the centre

You have written this before. It is the lower half of 早 — and the morning lesson said, in as many words, that on its own this piece is the character for ten, and then went on to something else. It has been sitting on the page for thirteen chapters waiting for a number to hang on.

Set it against 一, one: the same horizontal, with a post through it.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 十 — bar first, then post
- 早 and point at the 十 inside it

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 十; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.10 十 — ten

Write it: 十

Then say nine.

The sounds and tones in this word

十 *shí* means **ten**.
shí is **second tone**, the rise — the pitch starts in the middle and goes up, as if asking. It is the first number in the whole run of ten to use it. The **sh** curls the tongue back, further than an English *sh*. Keep the tip high and behind the ridge.
Say the whole run once: **yī èr sān sì wǔ liù qī bā jiǔ shí**. Level, fall, level, fall, dip, fall, level, level, dip, rise.

What you've built — the last of the ten

Ten is not simply the tenth word. It is the last one this book needs before **every number up to ninety-nine falls out of the ten it already has** — and the next chapter spends it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

十 *shí* is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzyip*, "ten", whose final *p* Mandarin lost (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **bā jiǔ shí** — level, dip, rise
- the whole run, one to ten, at speed

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

20.11 Payoff — one to ten

Say ten, then say why eight costs more.

Your turn

1. Count aloud one to ten, then ten to one.
2. Hear all ten named singly and out of order, and say each.
3. *Read it:* the ten characters printed shuffled — 九 三 十 六 一 八 四 七 二 五 — then say each with its tone
4. *Write it:* the five new ones from dictation — 六 七 八 九 十
5. Say the tone of each of the ten in order. Only one of them rises.
6. Say what 八 and 人 differ by, and what sits inside 早.

Five new characters cost **twelve strokes between them** — four, two, two, two and two. The single hardest thing in this chapter was not the writing; it was that the numbers had been left at five for seventeen chapters.

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 21

Ten Words, Ninety-Nine Numbers

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build any number from eleven to ninety-nine out of the ten words I already have, say a hundred, and read a price written in Arabic numerals.
>
> *One rule of order turns ten words into ninety-nine numbers,* 一百 *is where* 一*'s tone finally moves, and the digits chapter says which of 5 and* 五 *a price tag actually prints.*

21.1 十一 — eleven, and the teens in one line

Count one to ten, then say ten on its own.

You'll want to know first — ten, then one

十一 — *shíyī* — **eleven**

Ten, then one. That is all of it.

And it does not stop at eleven. 十五 is *shíwǔ*, ten-five, fifteen. 十九 is *shíjiǔ*, ten-nine, nineteen. English has *eleven*, *twelve*, *thirteen* — three separate shapes before the pattern starts — and German, Russian and Urdu each have their own nine irregular words to memorise here.

Mandarin has none. The teens are the numbers you already have, in the order you already say them. Nine numbers, no new vocabulary, no new characters, and nothing to learn but the order.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

十一 is a Chinese formation, ten and one, and both pieces are inherited from Middle Chinese: *dzyip*, "ten", and *'jit*, "one" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shíyī** — eleven
- *Build:* **shí** + **sān** → **shísān**, thirteen
- *Build:* **shí** + **bā** → **shíbā**, eighteen
- *Run through:* eleven to nineteen, straight through

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.2 二十 — twenty, and ninety-nine numbers from ten words

Say **shíyī**, and build seventeen.

You'll want to know first — turn the pair round

二十 — *èrshí* — **twenty**

十一 is ten-one, eleven. 二十 is two-ten, twenty. The same two words in the other order, and the order is the entire difference.

That gives every ten: 三十 thirty, 四十 forty, 九十 ninety. Put a unit on the end of one and you have everything between: 二十一, *èrshíyī*, twenty-one; 九十九, ninety-nine.

Ten words reach ninety-nine. English needs *eleven*, *twelve* and *thirteen* before its own pattern begins, and *twenty*, *thirty* and *fifty* are three more shapes again. Mandarin needs none of them.

The sounds and tones in this word

九十九, ninety-nine, looks like a drill for the rule you met with *nǐ hǎo*, and it is a drill for when that rule does not fire. *jiǔ* is third tone and so is the *jiǔ* at the end, but 十 *shí* stands between them, and it is second tone. A third tone lifts into a rise only before another third tone. Say it: **jiǔ-shí-jiǔ**. Both nines dip.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

二十 is a Chinese formation, two tens, made of words inherited from Middle Chinese: *nyijH*, "two", and *dzyip*, "ten" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

- *Say it:* **èrshí** — twenty
- *Build:* **sān** + **shí** → **sānshí**, thirty
- *Build:* **wǔ** + **shí** + **liù** → **wǔshíliù**, fifty-six
- *Say it:* **jiǔshíjiǔ** — ninety-nine, both nines dipping

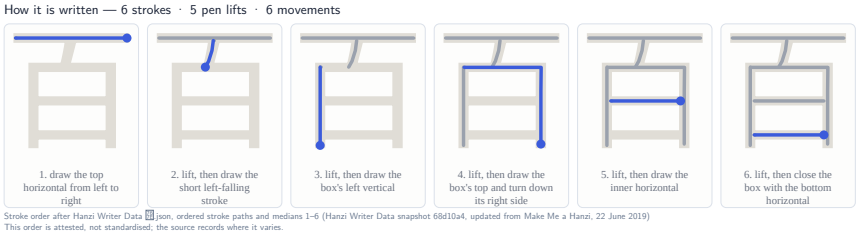
Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.3 百 — a hundred, on a box you have built before

Write 四 and 一.

Script — six strokes, five of them familiar



How 百 is written, stroke by stroke

百

Six strokes. For a hundred.

1. the top **héng** horizontal, left to right
2. lift, then the short **piě** below it, falling to the left
3. lift, then the **shù** vertical down the left side of the box
4. lift, then the **héngzhé**: across the top of the box and down its right side
5. lift, then the inner **héng** horizontal
6. lift, then the bottom **héng**, closing the box

Strokes 3 to 6 are the box of 四, built in the same order: the left side, then the top-and-right turn, then the inside, then the floor. **Outside before inside, and the box closes last** — the rule you used for 四 and 口.

Only strokes 1 and 2 are new, and stroke 1 is 一.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 百 — bar, short fall, then the box in 四's order
- 四 beside it and mark the four strokes they share

Before you move on

Sources: Hanzi Writer Data 百; Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.4 一百 — a hundred, and 一 moves

Write it: 百

Then say twenty.

The sounds and tones in this word

百 *bǎi* means **a hundred**, and it is almost always said with 一 in front of it: 一百, one hundred.
bǎi is **third tone**, the low dip, like *jiǔ* and *wǔ*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Counting on its own, 一 is **yī**, high and level. In 一百 it is not: you say **yìbǎi**, with a fall.
一 shifts its tone depending on what follows, exactly as 不 does — the behaviour this book named in its first chapter for a different word. Before a first, second or third tone, 一 falls: **yìbǎi**. Before a fourth tone it rises instead.
So the number that sounds simplest in the run is the one that changes most, and a hundred is where a learner meets it first.
Both words are inherited from Middle Chinese: *ʾjit*, "one", and *paek*, "hundred" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

- *Say it:* **yī** alone — level
- *Say it:* **yìbǎi** — falling, then dipping
- *Run through:* **shí, èrshí, yìbǎi** — ten, twenty, a hundred

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.5 5 and 五 — the same number, two registers

Say five, then say a hundred.

You'll want to know first — where each one is written

5 and 五 are both *wǔ*.

A reader who has spent this chapter learning 六 七 八 九 十 could still walk past a Chinese shop and read nothing on the price tag, because **a price is written in Arabic numerals**. So are dates, telephone numbers, bus numbers, floor numbers, addresses and the year.

The characters are not archaic. They are a different register, and both are current:

written with	where you meet it
5, **20**, **100**	prices, dates, phone numbers, addresses, anything counted
五, 二十, 一百	formal and legal text, cheque amounts, shop signs, set phrases, running prose

Both are read aloud **the same way** — you see **5** and you say *wǔ*. That is the useful part: the digits cost you nothing to learn and everything to ignore.

One convention worth carrying: on a bill or a cheque an amount is often written twice, once in digits and once in characters, because the characters are much harder to alter.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The digits are the Hindu-Arabic numerals, devised in India and carried west through Arabic; they came into everyday Chinese use only in modern times. 五 is the inherited word, from Middle Chinese *nguX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

- *Read it:* **5**, **10**, **20**, **99** aloud as *wǔ*, *shí*, *èrshí*, *jiǔshíjiǔ*
- *Write it:* each of those four in characters as well
- *Say it:* which of the two a price tag uses, and which a cheque uses

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.6 Payoff — ninety-nine numbers, and the price tag

Count one to ten, then say which of **5** and 五 a price tag uses.

Your turn

1. **Build, do not recall.** Say twelve, seventeen, thirty, forty-five, sixty-eight and eighty-one, from the ten words alone.
2. Say **jiǔshíjiǔ**, ninety-nine. 十 between the two 九 is second tone, so the first 九 keeps its low dip: the dip lifts only before another third tone.
3. Say **yìbǎi**, and say what happens to 一 in front of it.
4. *Read it:* **8**, **15**, **30**, **99** and **100** off a page, then say each aloud
5. *Write it:* 十一, 二十 and 一百 in characters
6. Give a floor number, an age and a price, each as a bare number.

Count what this cost: **five characters and one rule of order** — ten before a unit multiplies nothing, ten after a unit multiplies it. That order is worth more than every word in this chapter put together.

What is still out of reach: *yìqiān*, a thousand, and everything above it — and the measure word a Chinese number needs before an actual noun, which is a chapter of its own.

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

21.7 Close the numeral slice

Count one to ten, then say why eight costs more.

Your turn

The six new characters, alone, from spoken cues and with no number around them: 六 七 八 九 十 百.

Then put each back to work once.

1. *Write it:* the five single digits, and say the stroke count of each — four, two, two, two, two; twelve strokes for five numbers
2. *Write it:* 百, and mark the four strokes it shares with 四
3. *Write it:* 早, and mark the 十 inside it
4. *Write it:* 人 and 八 side by side, and say what separates them
5. Build six numbers between eleven and ninety-nine from the ten words.
6. *Read it:* a price in digits, then say it aloud in words

Say what the whole slice cost the hand: **six characters, fourteen strokes**, and one rule about the order of two of them.

Before you move on

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 22

The Grammar That Is Not There

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can state the four things Mandarin does not do — no verb endings, no agreement, no article, no separate nationality word — and name where somebody is from.
>
> *Four facts about Mandarin's shape and one join, and the whole chapter adds not a single character: three of the four are things a reader must stop doing, and the fourth puts* 中国 *and* 人 *together for the first time.*

22.1 看 — the verb that never changes

A new chapter, and it teaches no new character at all. Five retrievals first.

- *Recall:* say *liù qī bā jiǔ shí bǎi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *bǎi* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *yǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

You'll want to know: there is nothing to conjugate

> **A Mandarin verb has exactly one form. It never changes — not for who is doing it, not for how many of them there are, and not for when.**

You have been given 看 *kàn*, "to look", and you have used it in exactly one shape. That was not the lesson being brief. That is the whole verb.

我看书	*wǒ kàn shū* — I read
你看书	*nǐ kàn shū* — you read
人看书	*rén kàn shū* — people read

The verb is 看 three times. Nothing has been added, dropped or swapped.

This is worth stating out loud because of what a reader coming from English or Spanish does otherwise: they wait for the ending, decide the book has not reached it yet, and go on quietly expecting one. Spanish has *hablo, hablas, habla, hablamos, habláis, hablan.* English has three forms and an irregular verb for every occasion. **Mandarin has one shape and no exceptions.**

Every verb in this book behaves this way — 看, 是, 上学 — and so will every verb in every chapter after it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *wǒ kàn shū*, *nǐ kàn shū*, *rén kàn shū* — one verb, three sentences
- 我是学生 / 你是学生 — 是 does not move either

Before you move on

How many forms does a Mandarin verb have? (**One**.) What changes when the person changes? (**Nothing**.) And what should you stop waiting for? (**The ending** — there is not one.)

22.2 我是 — nothing agrees with anything

One lesson back, and the same fact from the other end.

- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *yìbǎi* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànjiàn* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *yǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *hànzì* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

You'll want to know: the subject changes nothing

> **The subject of a Mandarin sentence has no effect on the verb whatsoever.**

The last lesson said a verb has one form. This says the other half: nothing about the subject reaches it.

> 我是学生 *wǒ shì xuésheng* — I am a student. 你是学生 *nǐ shì xuésheng* — you are a student. 人是学生 *rén shì xuésheng* — people are students.

是 *shì* is the same 是 in all three. An English speaker has to pick *am*, *are* or *is*; a Spanish speaker has to pick *soy*, *eres*, *es*, *somos*, *sois* or *son*. You pick 是.

Grammar Lens: and nothing after the verb agrees either

The thing that comes AFTER 是 does not change either.

> 我是大学生 — I am a university student. 人是大学生 — people are university students.

大学生 is one word with one shape whether it names one person or a hundred. Spanish would need *estudiante* against *estudiantes*, and would then need the adjective to follow suit. Mandarin marks none of it.

So the whole of agreement, in Mandarin, is a thing you must not do. That is an unusual kind of lesson: what a Spanish learner

spends months getting right, a Mandarin learner has to be told to stop attempting. If you find yourself wondering which form to use, the answer is that there is only one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我是学生 — 你是学生 — 人是学生
- 我是大学生 — 人是大学生 — one shape, one and many

Before you move on

What does the subject do to the verb? (**Nothing**.) What does a plural subject do to the noun after 是? (**Nothing** — 大学生 has one shape.) So how much agreement is there in Mandarin? (**None at all**.)

22.3 书 — a book, the book, books

Two lessons in, and this one is about a word you have had since the reading chapter.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǔ* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànjiàn* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎokàn* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *yǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *hàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

You'll want to know: Mandarin has no article

> 书 *shū* means **a book**, **the book**, and **books**. Mandarin has no word for *a* and no word for *the*, and a bare noun says nothing about how many there are.

Which of the three it means is settled by what is going on around it, and by nothing in the word itself.

> 我看书 — I read *a* book. / I read *the* book. / I read books.

All three are the same sentence. If you need to say **one** book you can count it — that takes a measure word, which arrives in two chapters. If you need to say **this** book you can point at it, which needs a word this book has not taught yet. What you never need is an article, because there is not one to leave out.

This is the trap for an English or Spanish speaker, and it runs both ways. Arriving, they hunt for the missing *the* and try to supply it from their own language. Leaving, they drop English articles: *I read book.* Neither is a vocabulary problem. Mandarin does not mark the distinction here at all, and 书 on its own is complete.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我看书 — and mean it three ways
- 书 — a book, the book, books

Before you move on

What does 书 mean? (**A book, the book, and books** — all three.) How does Mandarin mark which one? (**It does not.**) What should an English speaker stop looking for? (**The article** — there is none.)

22.4 中国人 — where somebody is from

> The fourth lesson of a chapter that has added no character at all.

- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *shíyī èrshí jiǔshíjiǔ yìbǎi* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎokàn* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *hànzì* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

You'll want to know: country plus 人

中国人 *Zhōngguó rén* — **a Chinese person**.

Read it: 中国人 again and count what is new

中国 *Zhōngguó*, China, was taught in the country chapter. 人 *rén*, person, was the first character this book ever asked you to write. **Nothing here is new. The lesson is the join.**

我是中国人 *wǒ shì Zhōngguó rén* — I am Chinese. 你是中国人吗 *nǐ shì Zhōngguó rén ma* — are you Chinese?

That second sentence uses 吗 from the asking chapter, and it is one of the two or three questions a beginner is asked most often.

Grammar Lens: the rule, and how far it reaches

country + 人 = a person from that country.

That is the whole pattern, and it works on every country name without exception. Mandarin has no separate set of nationality words the way English has *China* → *Chinese*, *Spain* → *Spanish*, *France* → *French*, each with its own shape to learn. It has one noun and one suffix.

The same trick makes the language name, with 语 or 文 instead of 人 — and you already hold both: 汉语 and 中文 were taught in the language chapters. So one country word gives you the place, the people and the language.

Notice what Mandarin does **not** do here. It does not capitalise 中国人,

because it has no capitals at all. It does not agree the word with anything. And it does not distinguish *a Chinese person* from *Chinese people*: 中国人 is both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 中国人 — *Zhōngguó rén*
- 我是中国人
- 你是中国人吗

Before you move on

How do you say "a Chinese person"? (中国人.) How many new characters did that take? (**None** — 中国 and 人 were both already yours.) What is the rule? (**Country plus** 人.)

22.5 中国人 — 书 — 看: the chapter with no new character

The chapter closes. Five retrievals, then the four skills.

- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *liù qī bā jiǔ shí bǎi* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànshū* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *zì* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — four facts, no new strokes

A character costs this book a great deal: a stroke record checked against a source, a writing lesson, a reading lesson, and a regeneration of the font the book prints with. **This chapter cost none of that**, and it is worth saying what it bought.

1. **A verb has one form.** 我看书, 你看书, 人看书.
2. **Nothing agrees.** Not the verb with its subject, not what follows 是 with how many there are.
3. **There is no article.** 书 is a book, the book, and books.
4. **Country + 人 names a people.** 我是中国人

Three of those four are things you must *stop* doing rather than start, which is why no lesson had ever said them: an absence leaves no word to teach. The fourth is a join between two things the book had already given you and never let meet.
Listen. *Wǒ shì Zhōngguó rén. Nǐ ne — nǐ shì Zhōngguó rén ma?*
Speak. Say what you are, and ask the same question back with 吗.
Read it: 我是中国人 — 你是中国人吗
Write it: 中国人 — every stroke of it is one you have written before

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我是中国人
- *Say it:* 你是中国人吗
- *Write it:* 中国人

Before you move on

Name the four facts this chapter taught. (**One verb form; no agreement; no article; country plus 人.**) How many characters did it add? (**None.**) And which of the four is a thing to start doing rather than stop? (**Country plus 人.**)

Chapter 23

De — The Hinge

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say whose something is, put a whole description in front of the noun it describes, and open a sentence with its topic.
>
> *One character, eight strokes and no tone, doing three jobs — and the third of them, the topic slot, costs no character at all because it is an order rather than a word.*

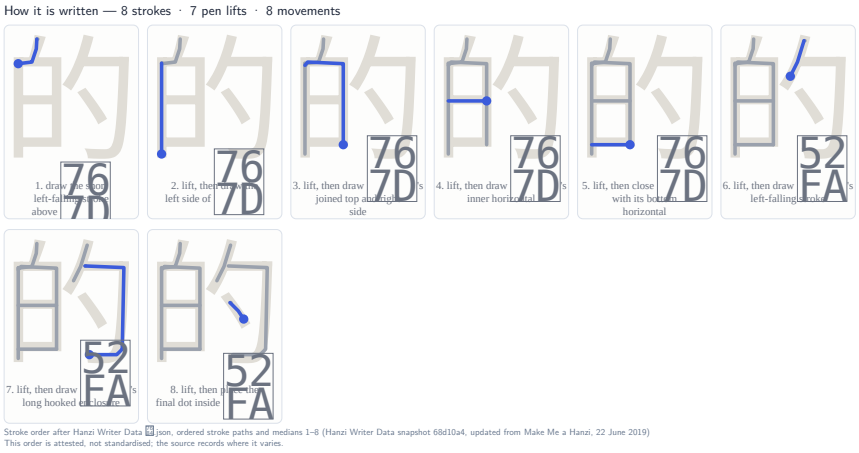
23.1 的 — eight strokes for the commonest character there is

A new chapter. Six retrievals, then the pen.

- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén — shū — kàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànshū* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn — kànjiàn — hǎokàn — shū — kànshū* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì — hànzì — hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more

- *Recall:* say *zhōngxué* — *zhōngxuésheng* — *tóngxué* — *shàngxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — a box on the left, a hook on the right



How 的 *is written, stroke by stroke*

的

Eight strokes, in two halves. The left half is 白 *bái*, "white"; the right half is 勺 *sháo*, a ladle. Finish the whole left half before the right one starts — the rule every two-part character in this book has followed.

The left half, 白, five strokes:

1. a short **piě** falling to the left, at the top
2. the **shù** down the left side of the box
3. the **héngzhé** across the top and down the right side, without lifting
4. the **héng** inside the box
5. the **héng** that closes its floor

That box is built exactly as 百's was, and for the same reason: **outside before inside, and the floor last.**

The right half, 勺, three strokes:

1. a **piě** falling to the left from the top
2. a long **héngzhégōu** down the right side, hooking left at the base
3. a single **diǎn** dot, placed last, inside the enclosure

The dot goes in last. Enclose, then fill. That is why it is stroke eight and not stroke six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 的 — 白 first, all five, then 勺's three
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and check the dot came last

Before you move on

How many strokes does 的 have, and how do they split? (**Eight** — five for 白, three for 勺.) Which stroke is the dot? (**The last one** — enclose, then fill.) Which character built its box the same way? (百.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 的, pinned stroke paths and medians.

23.2 的 — whose it is

One lesson back, and the character is already under your pen.

- *Recall:* say *de* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zhōngwén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *shàngxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

的 is said **de** — and that is the whole of it. **No tone at all.**
It is the third toneless word in this book, after 吗 and the 上 of 早上, and like them it is said light, short and low, leaning on the word in front of it. Do not give it a falling tone because it looks like a full character. It is a hinge, not a word.

Grammar Lens: owner + 的 + owned

owner + 的 + the thing owned.

我的书 *wǒ de shū* — my book 我的名字 *wǒ de míngzi* — my name 你的书 *nǐ de shū* — your book

That is the entire Mandarin possessive. Look at what is NOT there:

- **No agreement.** 的 never changes for the owner, the thing, or how many.
- **No separate word for "mine".** English needs *my* and *mine*; Spanish needs *mi*, *mío*, *mía*, *míos*, *mías*. Mandarin has 的.
- **No difference between one owner and several.** The same 的 does both.

You have had 我 since the chapter that taught you to say who you are, and it has had nothing to own until now.
One habit worth learning early: with family and with very close things, Mandarin **drops** 的 — a speaker says 我家, not 我的家. The closer the tie, the likelier the 的 falls away.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

的 is a borrowed spelling. The character's own Middle Chinese reading is *tek*, "bright; a target"; the particle is usually traced to a Tang-period particle written with another character, read *tejX*. The details are not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *wǒ de shū* — 我的书
- *wǒ de míngzi* — 我的名字
- *nǐ de shū* — 你的书

Before you move on

What tone does 的 carry? (**None**.) What is the order? (**Owner, 的, thing owned**.) And what does 的 do when the owner is plural? (**Nothing** — it never changes.)

23.3 看书的人 — the one who reads

One lesson back, and the same character doing a bigger job.

- *Recall:* say *de* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *nǐ hǎo ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *wén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *shàngxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: put the description in front

的 does not only join an owner to a thing. Put a whole clause in front of it and that clause describes the noun that follows.

> 看书的人 *kàn shū de rén* — the person **who reads books**
> 看书的学生 — the student **who reads books** 我看的书 *wǒ kàn de shū* — the book **I read**

Set the Mandarin order against the English. English says *the person who reads books*: noun first, description trailing after it. Mandarin says *reads-books* 的 *person*: **description first, noun last,**

always.
That is the single most important thing in this lesson, and it is not a word to learn — it is a direction to turn round. Everything that describes a noun in Mandarin goes in front of it, however long it gets, and 的 is the hinge that holds it there. English has one construction like this and it is short — *a well-read person* — and Mandarin uses that shape for all of them.
Notice that the 的 is the same 的 as the last lesson's, unchanged and toneless. Mandarin does not have one word for the possessive and another for the relative. It has this one hinge, and what goes in front of it decides which job it is doing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kàn shū de rén* — 看书的人
- *wǒ kàn de shū* — 我看的书
- 看书的学生

Before you move on

Where does a Mandarin description go? (**In front of the noun**, always.) Which word holds it there? (的.) Is it a different 的 from 我的书? (**No** — one hinge, two jobs.)

23.4 汉语 — 我看书: topic first, comment after

Four in, and this one names the shape the whole language prefers.

- *Recall:* say *kàn shū de rén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *nǐ hǎo ma* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shì ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance

- *Recall:* say *wén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *tóngxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: the topic comes first

Mandarin puts the thing being talked about first, and then says something about it. The first slot is the TOPIC, not necessarily the subject.

汉语 — 我看书 *Hànyǔ, wǒ kàn shū* — Chinese? I read it. 书 — 我看 *shū, wǒ kàn* — Books, I read. 我 — 中国人 *wǒ, Zhōngguó rén* — Me, I'm Chinese.

(Chinese writes a comma at that seam. This book has not taught a single punctuation mark — its own inventory reports the column empty — so the seam is printed here as a dash rather than smuggled in.)
In each of those the first word is not doing the verb. It is the subject *under discussion*, and the rest of the sentence is the remark about it. English can do this and treats it as informal — *me, I'd rather walk*; *that book, I've read*. Mandarin does it constantly and treats it as ordinary. It is why so much beginner Mandarin built on an English template sounds stiff: the learner keeps the doer in front when a Mandarin speaker would have put the topic there.
A useful consequence. Once the topic is set, everything afterwards can leave it out. A Mandarin speaker will not repeat 书 in the second half of *shū, wǒ kàn* — and will not supply a pronoun for it either. Where English needs *it*, Mandarin needs nothing, because the topic is still standing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 汉语 — 我看书
- 书 — 我看
- 我 — 中国人

Before you move on

What goes in the first slot of a Mandarin sentence? (**The topic** — what is being talked about.) Must it be the one doing the verb? (**No**.) What does the second half do about repeating it? (**Nothing** — it leaves it out.)

23.5 我的书 — 看书的人

The chapter closes on one character and the four skills.

- *Recall:* say *Hànyǔ, wǒ kàn shū* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén — shū — kàn* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shì ma* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎo bu hǎo* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *wén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *tóng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — the hinge

One character, eight strokes, no tone — and with it:

1. 我的书 — whose something is, with no agreement anywhere.
2. 看书的人 — a description standing in FRONT of what it describes.
3. 汉语 — 我看书 — a topic first, and a comment after it.

The third of those needed no character at all: it is an order, not a word. It is in this chapter because 的 is what makes the first slot worth filling.
Listen. *Wǒ de shū. Kàn shū de rén. Hànyǔ, wǒ kàn shū.*
Speak. Say whose the book is, then say who the reader is.

Read it: 我的名字 — 看书的学生 — 书 — 我看
Write it: 的 — 白 first, then 勺, and the dot last

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我的书 — 我的名字 — 你的书
- *Say it:* 看书的人 — 看书的学生
- *Write it:* 的

Before you move on

Name the three jobs this chapter gave 的 and its slot. (**Possession; a description in front of its noun; and the topic that opens a sentence**.) Which one cost no character? (**The topic** — it is an order, not a word.)

Chapter 24

Have, and Count

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) ↙ **pen** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

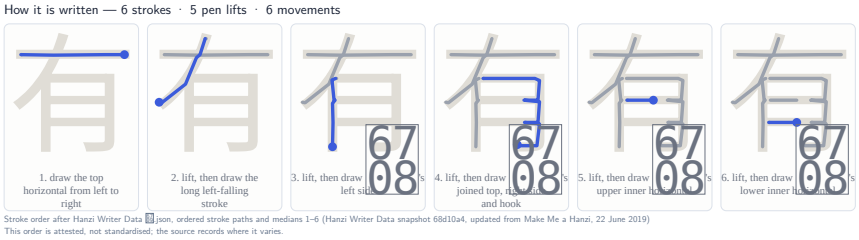
> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I have, say that there is something, and put a number against a noun with a measure word between them.
>
> *Nine strokes across two characters give the numerals something to count at last, and* 个 *is three strokes of which two are* 人.

24.1 有 — six strokes, and a moon underneath

A new chapter, and its first character is a verb the book has gone twenty-three chapters without.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ de shū — kàn shū de rén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *de* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎo bu hǎo* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma — nǐ hǎo ma — shì ma — hǎo bu hǎo* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zhōngwén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *tóngxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — two strokes on top, 月 beneath



How 有 is written, stroke by stroke

有

Six strokes. Two cross at the top; the remaining four build 月, the moon, underneath.

1. the **héng** across the top, left to right
2. the long **piě** from the top centre, falling to the lower left and running past everything below it

Horizontal before left-falling. You have written that order twice already, in 大 and in 六, and it decides these two.

Then 月:

1. the **shù** down the left side
2. the **héngzhégōu** across the top and down the right side, hooking left at the base — one stroke, two turns, no lift
3. the upper **héng** inside it
4. the lower **héng** inside it

Enclose, then fill: the two inner bars come after the walls, exactly as in 白 and 百 and 四.

One thing to watch. Stroke 2 is the longest in the character and it must reach the bottom-left corner, well past 月. A short one turns 有 into something that is not 有.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 有 — bar, long fall, then 月's four
- *Cover:* write it again, and check the long stroke reaches the corner

Before you move on

How many strokes does 有 have? (**Six**.) Which comes first, the horizontal or the falling stroke? (**The horizontal** — as in 大 and 六.) What sits underneath? (月, built walls-first.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 有, pinned stroke paths and medians.

24.2 有 — to have, and there is

One lesson back, and the character is already yours.

- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *de* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *liù* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *liù* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *xiǎo* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

有 *yǒu* is **third tone** — the dip, low and creaky, the same shape as the 好 you have said since your first day and the 五 you count with. Say them in a row and only the mouth changes: **hǎo, wǔ, yǒu.**

我有书 *wǒ yǒu shū* — I have a book. 我有名字 — I have a name.

Grammar Lens: the same verb says there is

有 is also how Mandarin says **there is** and **there are**. It is one verb doing both jobs, and no extra word is needed for the second:

> 有人 *yǒu rén* — there is somebody. / somebody's here. 有中国人 — there are Chinese people here.

English needs *have* for the first job and *there is* for the second; Spanish needs *tener* and *hay*. Mandarin needs 有.
And now the exception that every Mandarin course states early, because it is the only one of its kind:

> **有 is the one verb 不 cannot negate.**

不 has negated everything in this book so far — 不好, 不是, 不谢 — and it cannot negate this. The negative of 有 is *méi yǒu*, said with a different negator altogether, whose character this book has not yet taught. Hold the rule now and the writing later: **不有 is never Mandarin.**

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

有 *yǒu* is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjuwX*, "to have; to exist" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); both of its jobs are old ones.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hǎo, wǔ, yǒu* — three dips
- 我有书 我有名字
- 有人

Before you move on

What tone is 有? (**Third**, the dip.) What are its two jobs? (**To have**, and **there is**.) Which negator does it refuse? (不 — 有 takes *méi* instead.)

24.3 个 — three strokes, and you already write two of them

Two lessons in, and this character is nearly free.

- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *kàn shū de rén* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *qī* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *qī* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dà* — *dàjiā* — *xué* — *xuésheng* — *dàxué* — *dàxuésheng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — 人, and a line under it



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 个.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 个 is written, stroke by stroke

个

Three strokes, and the first two are a character you have written since the opening chapter.

1. the **piě**, falling from the peak to the lower left
2. the **nà**, falling from the same peak to the lower right
3. the **shù**, straight down from under the junction

Strokes 1 and 2 are 人 — the same pair, from the same peak, in the same order. All that is new is a vertical hung beneath it.

Keep the roof wide and the vertical dead centre. If the roof narrows, 个 starts to look like 人 with an accident underneath.

This is the cheapest character in the chapter and it does the most work in the one after it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 人 — then 个, which is 人 with a line under it
- *Cover:* write 个 from memory

Before you move on

How many strokes does 个 have? (**Three**.) Which character are the first two? (人.) And the third? (**A vertical, straight down from the junction**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 个, pinned stroke paths and medians.

24.4 个 — the word that goes between a number and a thing

One lesson back, and this is what the numerals were for.

- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *Hànyǔ, wǒ kàn shū* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *bā* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *bā* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance

- *Recall:* say *guó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dàxuésheng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: number + 个 + noun

In Mandarin a number cannot touch a noun. Something has to stand between them, and 个 is the one that fits almost everything.

Wrong: 三人 **Right:** 三个人 *sān ge rén* — three people **Right:** 一个学生 *yí ge xuésheng* — one student **Right:** 五个名字 — five names

You have been able to count to ninety-nine since the last chapter and there has been nothing to count. This is the missing piece, and it is one character.
English does this in a few places and does not notice: *three **head** of cattle*, *two **slices** of bread*, *a **pair** of trousers*. Mandarin does it **every time**, for every noun, without exception.

The sounds and tones in this word

个 is *gè*, **fourth tone** — the sharp fall, the same shape as 四 and 六. But in the middle of a count it usually goes **light and toneless**: *sān ge rén*, not *sān gè rén*. It behaves the way 吗 and 的 do — a small word leaning on its neighbours.
And one sandhi you already own comes back here. 一 is first tone alone, and before a fourth-tone syllable it rises: 一个 is *yí ge*, not *yī ge*. That is the same tone change the hundred lesson taught on 一百.
Mandarin has dozens of measure words, each tied to a shape or a kind of thing, and 个 is the general-purpose one. Use 个 when you do not know which is right, and you will be understood every time.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

个 is inherited from Middle Chinese *kaH*, "a single piece".

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sān ge rén* — 三个人
- *yí ge xuésheng* — 一个学生
- 五个名字

Before you move on

What has to stand between a number and a noun? (**A measure word** — 个 fits almost everything.) What is wrong with 三人? (**Nothing stands between the number and the noun**.) How is 一个 said? (***Yí ge*** — 一 rises before a fourth tone.)

24.5 我有一个名字

The chapter closes with the sentence its two characters were for.

- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ de shū — kàn shū de rén* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *jiǔ* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *jiǔ* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *guó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dàxué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — have, and count

Two characters this chapter, nine strokes between them, and here is the sentence they buy:

我有一个名字 *wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi* — I have a name.

Everything in it except 有 and 个 was already yours: 我 from the chapter where you said who you were, 一 from the counting chapter, 名字 from the naming one. The chapter did not add a sentence; it added the two words that let the sentence exist.

And the same nine strokes give:

> 有人 — there is somebody. 三个学生 — three students. 我有一个中国名字 — I have a Chinese name.

Listen. *Wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi. Yǒu rén. Sān ge xuésheng.*
Speak. Say what you have; then count three of something.
Read it: 我有一个名字 — 有人 — 三个学生
Write it: 有 — bar, long fall, 月; 个 — 人, then a line

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我有一个名字
- *Say it:* 有人 三个学生
- *Write it:* 有 个

Before you move on

Say "I have a name." (我有一个名字.) What does 有 do besides *have*? (**It says *there is*.**) And why can 三 not sit straight against 人? (**A number needs a measure word** — 三个人.)

Chapter 25

Le — Finished, and Changed

Modes: **voice** (4) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

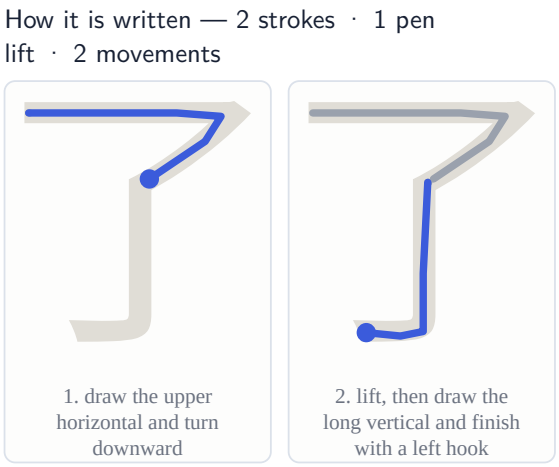
> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that an action is finished, that a situation has changed, and explain why neither of those is a tense.
>
> *Two strokes — fewer than any character in the book but* 一 *and* 二 *— and with them the first sentences in this track that are not happening now.*

25.1 了 — two strokes

A new chapter, and the smallest character in it does the most.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shí* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shí* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *guó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *sheng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — a turn, and a hook



How 了 is written, stroke by stroke

了

Two strokes. Only 一 and 二 have used fewer.

1. the **héngpiě**: start with a short flat run at the upper left, then let it fall away to the right — **one stroke, one turn, no lift**

2. the **shùgōu**: lift, come down from under that turn almost to the floor of the square, and flick left at the very end

The hook at the foot is not decoration; it is what tells 了 apart from a bare vertical. Finish it.

You have written a **héngzhé** — a horizontal that turns down — in every 口 since the fourth chapter. This is its cousin: the turn does not go straight down, it falls away.

Two strokes, and no tone. For a character that carries more grammar than any other in this book, it asks remarkably little of the hand.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 了 — the turn, then the hooked vertical
- *Cover:* write it again, and check the hook is there

Before you move on

How many strokes does 了 have? (**Two**.) Which characters use fewer? (**一 and 二**.) What must the second stroke end with? (**A hook to the left**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 了, pinned stroke paths and medians.

25.2 我看了书 — the thing is done

One lesson back, and the character is already under your pen.

- *Recall:* say *le* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yī èr sān sì wǔ liù qī bā jiǔ shí* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shíyī* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *xuésheng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: verb + 了 = finished

了 *le* — toneless, and placed **straight after the verb**. It says the action is **complete**.

我看书 — I read. / I'm reading. 我看了书 *wǒ kàn le shū* — I read it. I've read it. Done.

The verb did not move and did not change — the last chapter's rule holds. One small word went in behind it, and the event closed.

我有了名字 — I've got a name now. 你看了吗 *nǐ kàn le ma*

— have you read it?

That last one puts 了 and 吗 in the same sentence, each doing its own job at its own end: 了 sits behind the verb, 吗 at the very finish.

What you've built — the past this book could not reach

Until this line, **everything in this book happened in an eternal present.** Every sentence you could build was now, and there was no way to say a thing had already happened.
Spanish spends an imperfect, a preterite with two irregular sets, a present perfect and two participles on the same job. English has *read*, *have read*, *had read*, *was reading*. Mandarin has 了 and, when it needs one, a word for *yesterday*.
The verb still does not change. It never will. What changed is that a finished event can now be told apart from an unfinished one — and that is done by adding a particle, not by reshaping a word.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

了 is inherited from Middle Chinese *lewX*, "to finish" (Guangyun). As a verb it is still read *liǎo*, and the toneless particle is usually said to have grown out of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我看书 — 我看了书
- *wǒ yǒu le míngzi* — 我有了名字
- 你看了吗

Before you move on

Where does 了 go? (**Straight after the verb**.) What does it say? (**The action is finished**.) What happened to the verb when you added it? (**Nothing** — verbs never change.)

25.3 我是大学生了 — something has changed

One lesson back, and the same character in a different slot.

- *Recall:* say *le* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *èrshí* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *bǎi* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *xué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: 了 at the end says the situation is new

Put 了 at the very **end** of a sentence, after everything else, and it stops talking about the verb and starts talking about the situation:

> 我是大学生了 *wǒ shì dàxuéshēng le* — I'm a university student **now**. 有人了 — somebody's here **now**. 我看书了 — I'm reading now. *(I wasn't before)*

This 了 hangs off a whole finished sentence, not off any one word in it. That is why it goes last and why nothing may follow it.
The English word that keeps appearing in those translations is *now*, and it is not a translation of 了. It is what English has to reach for to carry what 了 does: *this was not so before, and it is so now.* Nothing in the Mandarin says *now.*

> 我是大学生 — I am a university student. *(a fact)* 我是大学生了 — I've become one. *(a change)*

Two slots, two jobs, one character. Behind the verb, 了 closes an action. At the end of the sentence, it opens a new state. This is what a language does when it refuses to inflect: it moves a small word around instead of reshaping a big one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我是大学生 — 我是大学生了
- 有人了
- 我看了书 — 我看书了

Before you move on

Where does this 了 go? (**At the very end of the sentence.**) What does it say? (**Something has changed.**) Is it the same character as the last lesson's? (**Yes** — same two strokes, different slot, different job.)

25.4 了 — aspect, and why it is not a tense

The chapter's fourth lesson, and it names what the other three were doing.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì dàxuéshēng le* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yìbǎi* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǔ* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *xué* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: Mandarin marks completion, not time

了 is not a past tense. It marks **aspect** — whether an event is complete — and says nothing at all about when it happened.

Here is the proof, and it is the reason this lesson exists:

> 我看了书 — I read the book. *(finished — could be an hour ago)* 我看了书你看吗 — I've finished the book; are you going to read it?

The second sentence is not in the past. 了 says the reading is **over**, and whether that was this morning or will be by tonight is settled by a time word, not by the verb and not by 了.
So Mandarin splits the job English and Spanish fuse.

when it happened	a time word — *yesterday*, *now*, *tomorrow*
whether it is finished	a particle — 了

An English verb carries both at once: *read* against *reads* against *have read*. A Spanish verb carries both and the person as well. Mandarin carries neither in the verb, because the verb does not change — the last chapter's rule, arriving where it matters most.
This is the single largest shape difference between Mandarin and the languages this book's reader is likeliest to arrive from, and 了 is where a beginner first meets it. 了 is one of several aspect particles; the others come later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我看了书
- 我看了书你看吗
- aspect is *whether it is finished*; tense is *when*

Before you move on

Is 了 a past tense? (**No** — it is aspect.) What does it actually mark? (**Whether the event is finished**.) What settles when something happened? (**A time word**, not the verb.)

25.5 我看了书

The chapter closes on two strokes.

- *Recall:* say *le* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shíyī èrshí jiǔshíjiǔ yìbǎi* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎo bu hǎo* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dàjiā* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — two strokes, and time itself

Before this chapter every sentence in this book happened now. After it:

1. 我看了书 — a finished action. 了 behind the verb.
2. 我是大学生了 — a changed state. 了 at the end.
3. **Neither is a tense.** Mandarin marks whether, not when.

Two strokes did that. Compare the price: the verb chapter needed a character each for 看 and 书, and neither of them changed what could be *said about time*.
Listen. *Wǒ kàn le shū. Wǒ shì dàxuéshēng le. Nǐ kàn le ma?*
Speak. Say you have read the book; then say you have become a student.
Read it: 我看了书 — 有人了 — 你看了吗
Write it: 了 — the turn, then the hook

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我看了书
- *Say it:* 我是大学生了

- *Say it:* 你看了吗
- *Write it:* 了

Before you move on

Name the two slots 了 uses and what each does. (**After the verb, the action is finished; at the end, the situation has changed**.) Is either one a tense? (**No** — both are aspect.) How many strokes? (**Two**.)

Chapter 26

Ne and Dui

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (1) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

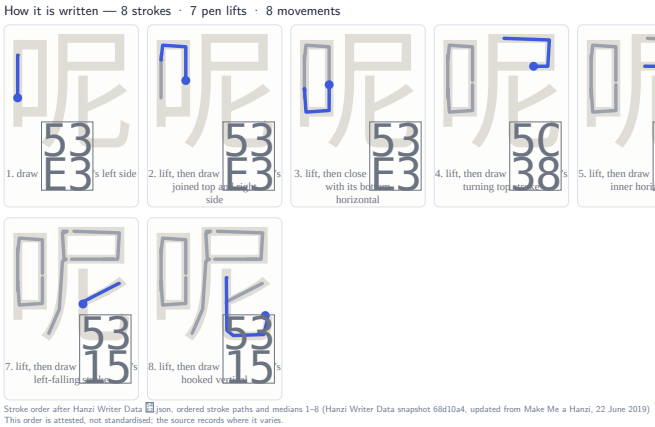
> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hand a question back with 呢, agree with what somebody has said, and ask whether something is right.
>
> *Thirteen strokes make the first two-sided exchange in this book:* 吗 *could ask, and until now nothing could hand the question back or agree with the answer.*

26.1 呢 — 吗's shape, a different sound

A new chapter, and its first character is one you half know.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ kàn le shū* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *le* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎo bu hǎo* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dà* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — the same mouth, a different right half



How 呢 *is written, stroke by stroke*

呢

Eight strokes, and the first three are ones you have written since the fourth chapter.

1. 口's **shù** down the left side
2. 口's **héngzhé** across the top and down the right
3. 口's **héng** closing the floor

That is the same 口, in the same order, set small and high in the upper-left third of the square — **exactly where 吗 puts it.** Finish it before the right half starts.

Then 尼 *ní*, which supplies only the sound:

1. the **héngzhé** across the top of the right half and down at its right
2. the **héng** beneath it
3. the long **piě**, falling from the top all the way down to the lower left, past the bottom of 口
4. a short **piě** inside, falling left
5. the **shùwāngōu**, turning along the base and finishing to the right

Stroke 6 is the one that carries the character. It starts high and reaches the lower-left corner, and everything after it tucks inside.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 口 — then 呢, mouth first
- *Cover:* write 吗 and 呢 side by side and compare the left halves

Before you move on

Which three strokes open 呢? (**口's** — vertical, turn, floor.) Which other character starts the same way? (吗.) Which stroke is the long one? (**The sixth**, falling to the lower left.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 呢, pinned stroke paths and medians.

26.2 呢 — and you?

One lesson back, and the character is under your pen.

- *Recall:* say *ne* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *le* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shì ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *dà* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Grammar Lens: put 呢 after a noun and it asks the last question again

呢 *ne* — toneless, placed after a noun or a pronoun. It repeats whatever question was on the table, about this one instead.

— 你是学生吗 — Are you a student? — 我是学生你呢 *nǐ ne* — I'm a student. **And you?**

你呢 is two syllables and a complete turn. Nothing has to be repeated:

呢 carries the whole of the previous question with it.

我是中国人你呢 我有一个名字你呢 我看了书你呢

Every one of those means something different, and 呢 is the same in all of them, because the question it asks is whichever one was already on the table.

What you've built — the second particle, and the pair

Keep 吗 and 呢 apart by what comes before them:

吗	after a **whole statement**	你是学生吗 — a yes-or-no question
呢	after a **noun**	你呢 — the last question, asked again

They cannot be swapped. 你吗 is not a question and 你是学生呢 is not the question you meant.

呢 is the second of Mandarin's particles this book has taught, and the third toneless word after 吗 and 的. **A Mandarin sentence's grammar lives in words like these** — small, unstressed, unchanging, and placed rather than inflected. That is what the reader is learning each time one arrives.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

呢 borrowed its character for the sound; where the particle itself comes from is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我是学生你呢
- 我是中国人你呢
- 你是学生吗 — 你呢 — hear the difference

Before you move on

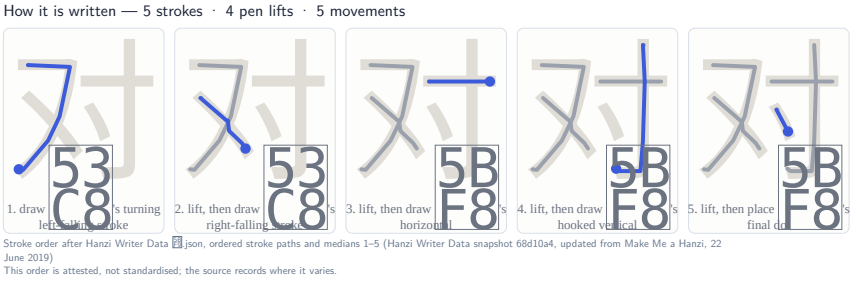
What does 呢 do? (**Asks the last question again, about somebody else.**) What comes before it? (**A noun** — 你呢.) And what comes before 吗? (**A whole statement.**)

26.3 对 — five strokes, and a hand on the left

Two lessons in, and this one is short.

- *Recall:* say *ne* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì dàxuéshēng le* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shì ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *zì* — *hànzì* — *hànyǔ* — *zhōngwén* — *zhōngguó* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *rén* — *nǚ* — *érzi* — *nǚ'ér* — *jiā* — *jiārén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — a hand, and a thumb's width



How 对 *is written, stroke by stroke*

对

Five strokes. Two on the left, three on the right.
The left half is 又, an old picture of a hand:

1. the **héngpiě** — a short flat start that turns and falls to the lower left, one stroke, no lift
2. the **nà**, crossing it and falling to the lower right

The right half is 寸:

1. the **héng** across the right half
2. the long **shùgōu** down through it, hooking left at the foot
3. the **diǎn** dot, placed last, to the left of the hook

The dot is the final stroke — the same rule 的 followed. And the left half is finished before the right begins, as always.

Hold on to strokes 1 and 2. That 又 opens 欢 two chapters from now, and you will not have to learn it twice.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 对 — 又's two, then 寸's three, dot last
- *Cover:* write it again from memory

Before you move on

How many strokes does 对 have? (**Five**.) Which stroke is the dot? (**The last**.) And which later character shares its left half? (欢.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 对, pinned stroke paths and medians.

26.4 对 — right, and the sound of agreeing

One lesson back, and this word does two jobs.

- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *le* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back

- *Recall:* say *nǐ hǎo ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *jiārén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

对 *duì* is **fourth tone** — the sharp fall, the same shape as 四, 六 and 个.

> 对 — Right. Correct. 不对 *bú duì* — Wrong. Not right. 对不对 *duì bu duì* — Right or not?

That last one is a shape you already own. The asking chapter taught 好不好, the verb-not-verb question, and 对不对 is the same pattern on a new word — no new grammar at all, one new syllable.
And the 不 in front of 对 rises: *bú duì*, not *bù duì*. That is the 不 sandhi the 是 chapter taught on 不是, working exactly as it did there, because 对 is fourth tone too.

Why it's said this way

On its own, 对 is what a Mandarin speaker says while somebody else is talking to show they are following and they agree. English uses *right*, *yeah*, *mm*; Mandarin uses 对, often doubled — 对对
Until this line, this book had no backchannel at all. You could greet, ask, count and name, and while somebody spoke to you there was nothing to say. That is not a small gap: a listener who makes no sound at all reads, in Mandarin as in English, as a listener who has not understood.

> — 你是中国人吗 — 对

Two syllables, and a whole exchange finished.
Careful with one thing. 对 agrees with a **statement**. It is not a general *yes*: asked a question with a verb in it, a Mandarin speaker answers by repeating the verb — 是 for a 是 question, 有 for a 有 question. 对 is for agreeing that what was said is so.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

对 is inherited from Middle Chinese *twojH*, glossed "to answer; to match" (Guangyun); "correct" is the later sense.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 对 不对 对不对
- 你是中国人吗 — 对
- 对对

Before you move on

What does 对 mean? (**Right, correct**.) What does it do on its own in a conversation? (**Shows you are following and agree**.) And how is 不对 said? (***Bú duì*** — 不 rises before a fourth tone.)

26.5 你呢 — 对不对

The chapter closes with an exchange rather than a word.

- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ kàn le shū* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *Zhōngguó rén* — *shū* — *kàn* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *nǐ hǎo ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *yán* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — a turn each way

Two characters, thirteen strokes, and here is what they buy — a conversation that goes both ways:

— 你是学生吗 — 对你呢 — 我是大学生了 — 对对

Every line of that is short, and none of it was sayable before this chapter. 吗 could ask; nothing could hand the question back, and nothing could agree.
呢 after a noun asks the last question again. 对 agrees with a statement. 吗 after a whole statement asks a yes-or-no question. Three particles, three slots, and not one of them changes shape.
Listen. *Nǐ shì xuésheng ma? — Duì. Nǐ ne?*
Speak. Answer, then hand it back with 你呢.
Read it: 你是学生吗 — 对 — 你呢
Write it: 呢 — 口 first; 对 — 又 first, dot last

Your turn

- *Say it:* 你是学生吗 — 对你呢
- *Say it:* 对不对 — 对
- *Write it:* 呢 对

Before you move on

Which particle hands the question back? (呢, after a noun.) Which word agrees with a statement? (对.) And which one turns a statement into a question? (吗, at the end.)

Chapter 27

Age, and And

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (2) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

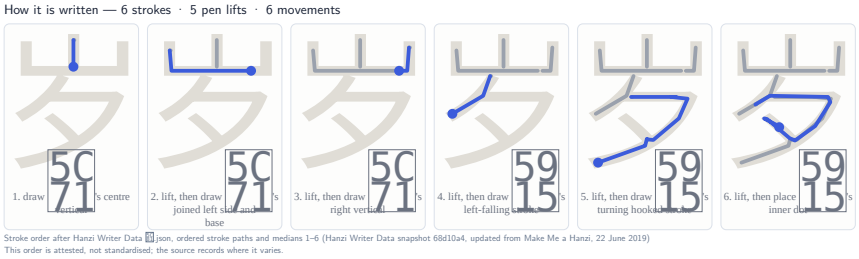
> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say how old I am in a sentence with no verb in it, and join two nouns with 和 while knowing it may not join two sentences.
>
> *岁 gives the numerals their first thing to measure, and 和 is the first joining word this track has ever had — one that teaches where it may not go.*

27.1 岁 — six strokes, and a rule that is not left-to-right

A new chapter, and its first character breaks a habit.

- *Recall:* say *nǐ ne — duì bu duì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *ne* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *de* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *shénme* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — a mountain, then an evening



How 岁 is written, stroke by stroke

岁

Six strokes, three on top and three beneath.

The top is 山 *shān*, a mountain — and it is written in an order the rules you have been given do not predict:

1. the **shù** down the **middle**
2. the **shùzhé** — down the left side, then turn and run along the base
3. the **shù** down the right side

Centre before the sides. Every character so far has gone top before bottom and left before right, and those two rules decide almost everything in Chinese writing. 山 is where they run out, and the answer is a third rule: when a shape has a clear middle and two wings, the middle goes first.

The bottom is 夕 *xī*, an evening:

1. a short **piě** falling to the lower left
2. the **héngzhégōu**, turning down and falling to the lower left with a hook
3. the **diǎn** dot laid across it

Top before bottom holds between the halves, as always.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 山 — middle first, then left, then right
- *Write it:* 岁 — 山 on top, 夕 beneath
- *Cover:* write 岁 from memory

Before you move on

How many strokes does 岁 have? (**Six**.) Which stroke of 山 comes first? (**The middle one**.) What sits underneath? (夕, an evening.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 岁, pinned stroke paths and medians.

27.2 岁 — how old you are

One lesson back, and the numerals finally do something.

- *Recall:* say *suì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *ne* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *de* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *ma* — **R3**, durable again, a second word from that distance
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *shénme* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

岁 *suì* is **fourth tone** — the sharp fall, like 四 and 对.
It counts **years of age**, and only that. It is not the word for a year on a calendar.

十八岁 *shíbā suì* — eighteen years old 二十岁 — twenty 九十九岁 — ninety-nine

Every one of those numbers came from the decimal chapter, and until this word there was nothing for them to measure.

Grammar Lens: the sentence with no verb in it

我十八岁 *wǒ shíbā suì* — I am eighteen.

Say that again and listen for the verb. **There is none.** No 是, no anything. Subject, number, 岁, stop.
English needs *am*. Spanish needs *tengo*. Mandarin puts an age straight after the person and is finished — and putting 是 in is a mistake a beginner makes for months: 我是十八岁 is wrong.
The question is built the same way, with 吗 doing what it always does:

你十八岁吗 — are you eighteen?

And now three things this book taught separately can be said in one breath:

我是中国人 — 我有一个名字 — 我十八岁

Name, nationality, age — the three pieces of personal information any beginner's paper asks for, and the last of them was waiting on this one character.
One habit worth knowing. Mandarin asks a small child's age with one question and an adult's with another, and both need words this book has not taught yet. What this lesson gives you is the answer, which is the half you are asked for.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

岁 is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjwejH*, "year" (Guangyun); Unihan also gives "age".

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *shíbā suì* — 十八岁
- 我十八岁 — and hear that there is no verb
- 你十八岁吗

Before you move on

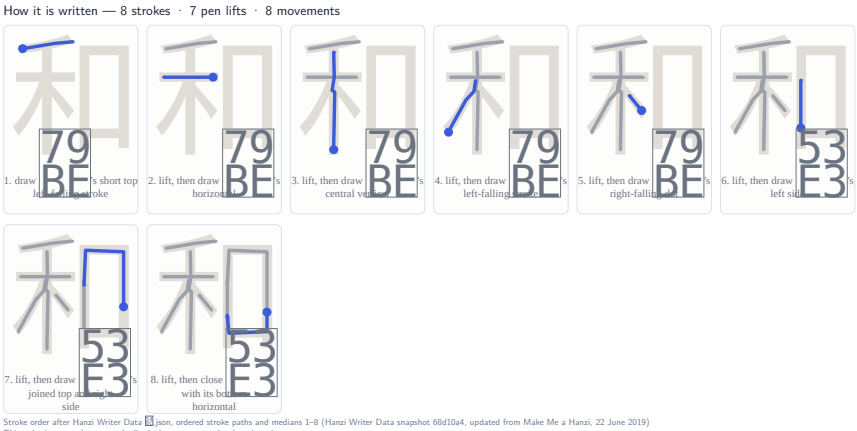
What does 岁 count? (**Years of age**.) What verb does 我十八岁 use? (**None** — there is no verb in it.) What is the commonest beginner's mistake here? (**Putting 是 in**.)

27.3 和 — eight strokes, and the right half is a mouth

Two lessons in, and three of these eight strokes are already yours.

- *Recall:* say *suì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn shū de rén* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *me* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — 禾 first, then 口



How 和 is written, stroke by stroke

和

Eight strokes, five on the left and three on the right — and the three on the right are 口, which you have written since the fourth chapter.

The left half is 禾 *hé*, standing grain:

1. a short **piě** at the very top, falling left
2. the **héng** beneath it
3. the long **shù** straight down the middle
4. a **piě** falling to the lower left
5. a **diǎn** closing to the lower right

Then 口, in its usual order:

1. the **shù** down its left side
2. the **héngzhé** across the top and down the right
3. the **héng** closing the floor

Left half complete before the right one starts, as always.

This is a **phono-semantic compound**, the kind the 请 lesson named: one part carries meaning and the other carries sound. Here the sounding half is unusually generous — 禾 is itself said *hé*, so the character tells you its own pronunciation outright.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 禾 — then 和, with 口 on the right
- *Cover:* write 和 from memory

Before you move on

How many strokes does 和 have? (**Eight** — five plus 口's three.) Which half supplies the sound? (禾, which is itself *hé*.) Which earlier character worked the same way? (请.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 和, pinned stroke paths and medians.

27.4 和 — and, between things only

One lesson back, and this word opens a column this book has never had.

- *Recall:* say *hé* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *Hànyǔ, wǒ kàn shū* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànjiàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *shén* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

和 *hé* is **second tone** — the rise, the same shape as 十 and 人.

> 你和我 *nǐ hé wǒ* — you and I 书和名字 — books and names 中国人和学生

It stands between the two things and joins them. Nothing agrees, nothing changes, and it is the same word however many things there are.

Grammar Lens: it joins nouns, and only nouns

> **和 joins two nouns. It does NOT join two sentences.**

This is the part an English or Spanish speaker gets wrong on the first day, because in their language one word does both:

> **Right:** 我和你 — you and I *(two nouns)* **Wrong:** 我看书和你看书 — not Mandarin at all

English says *I read and you read.* Spanish says *yo leo y tú lees.* Mandarin will not use 和 there at all. To join two statements it **puts them next to each other**, with a comma and no joining word:

> 我看书 — 你看书 — I read, and you read.

Mandarin writes a comma at that seam; this book prints a dash, because it has taught no punctuation. What matters is that **there is no joining word in it at all.** That is not a shortcut or a casual register — it is how Mandarin does it, and the words that DO join clauses are different words for different relations, *because*, *but*, *or*, none of which is 和 and none of which this book has yet taught.
So 和 is the first joining word in this track, and the first thing it teaches is where it may not go.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

和 is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwa*, "in harmony" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); its use as "and" is a later development, usually traced through "together with".

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nǐ hé wǒ* — 你和我
- 书和名字
- 我看书 — 你看书 — two sentences, no 和

Before you move on

What does 和 join? (**Two nouns**.) What does it never join? (**Two sentences**.) How does Mandarin join two statements instead? (**It puts them side by side**, with a comma.)

27.5 我十八岁 — 你和我

The chapter closes on two unrelated characters that each open a column.

- *Recall:* say *hé* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *nǐ ne — duì bu duì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back

- *Recall:* say *wǒ de shū — kàn shū de rén* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kànjiàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — an age, and a join

Two characters, fourteen strokes, and each one opens something the track has never had.
岁 gives the numerals something to measure. The decimal chapter reached ninety-nine and had nothing to count; 我十八岁 is the first sentence in this book that uses a number to say something true about a person — and it does it with no verb at all.
和 is the first joining word in the whole track. It joins two nouns and it refuses two sentences, and knowing the refusal is most of the lesson. Put them together with what you already have:

我是中国人 — 我有一个名字 — 我十八岁 你和我是学生

Listen. *Wǒ shíbā suì. Nǐ hé wǒ shì xuésheng.*
Speak. Give your age with no verb; then join two people with 和.
Read. 我十八岁 — 你和我是学生
Write. 岁 — 山 middle-first, then 夕. 和 — 禾, then 口.

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我十八岁
- *Say it:* 你和我是学生
- *Write it:* 岁 和

Before you move on

What verb does an age sentence use? (**None**.) What does 和 join, and what does it refuse? (**Nouns; sentences**.) Which stroke of 山 comes first? (**The middle one**.)

Chapter 28

Xihuan — What You Like

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) ↙ **pen** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

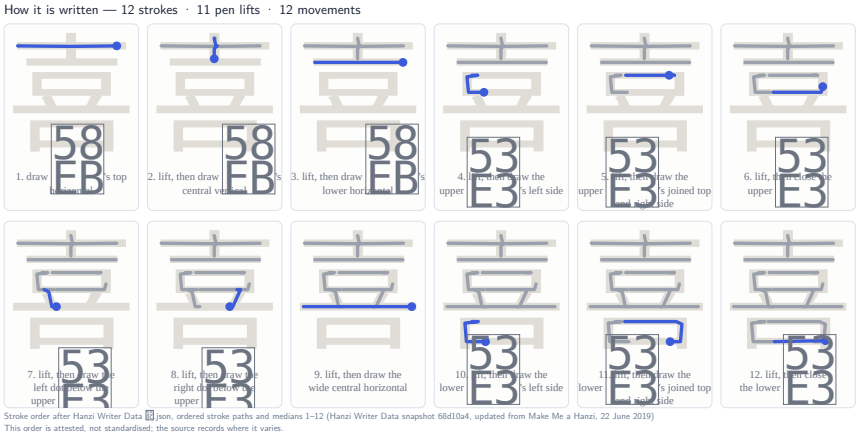
> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I like and do not like, and ask somebody else what they like.
>
> *Eighteen strokes and one verb, and the liking frame every other language in this series makes a beginner turn round: in Mandarin the liker is simply the subject.*

28.1 喜 — twelve strokes, stacked in four bands

A new chapter, and its first character is the tallest in the book.

- *Recall:* say *wǒ shíbā suì — nǐ hé wǒ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *suì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎokàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *míngzi* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — read it downwards, in four bands



How 喜 *is written, stroke by stroke*

喜

Twelve strokes — more than any character you have written. Do not count them. **Read the character downwards in four bands**, and every band is a shape you already know.

Band one — 士, three strokes. A long **héng** across the top, a **shù** down through it, a shorter **héng** beneath. That is 十 with a longer bar on top.

Band two — 口, three strokes. Left side, joined top-and-right, closing floor. The same mouth as always.

Band three — two short strokes, a small pair leaning apart under the 口.

Band four — one long héng, then 口 again. Stroke 9 is the widest stroke in the character, running edge to edge, and it carries everything above it. Then the lower 口, in its usual three.

3 + 3 + 2 + 1 + 3 = twelve.

Top before bottom, all the way down. Two 口, and both of them are written the way you have written 口 since 吗.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 士 — 口 — the small pair — the long bar — 口

- *Write it:* 喜, all twelve, downwards
- *Cover:* write it again and count the bands, not the strokes

Before you move on

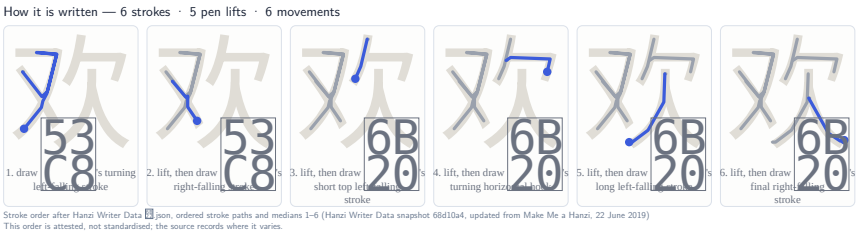
How many strokes does 喜 have? (**Twelve**.) How many bands? (**Four**.) How many of them are 口? (**Two** — the middle band and the last.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 喜, pinned stroke paths and medians.

28.2 欢 — six strokes, and two of them are already yours

One lesson back, and this one is short by comparison.

- *Recall:* say *xǐ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *suì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎokàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *zì* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

Script — 又 again, then 欠



How 欢 *is written, stroke by stroke*

欢

Six strokes, and the first two are ones you wrote one chapter ago. The left half is 又, the hand:

1. the **héngpiě** — a short flat start that turns and falls to the lower left
2. the **nà**, crossing it and falling to the lower right

That is exactly how 对 begins. Same pair, same order, same place in the square.

The right half is 欠 *qiàn*, a person with an open mouth:

1. a short **piě** at the top, falling left
2. the **hénggōu** — a horizontal that hooks down at its end
3. the long **piě**, falling from under the hook to the lower left
4. the **nà**, falling to the lower right and reaching furthest of all

Strokes 5 and 6 are the character's legs, and they must both reach out. Cramped, 欢 looks like something else; spread, it is unmistakable.

After 喜's twelve, six will feel like nothing.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 又 — the two strokes that also open 对
- *Write it:* 欢, all six
- *Cover:* write 对 and 欢 side by side and check the left halves match

Before you move on

How many strokes does 欢 have? (**Six**.) Which character shares its left half? (对.) Which two strokes are the legs? (**The fifth and sixth** — both must reach out.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 欢, pinned stroke paths and medians.

28.3 喜欢 — what you like

Two characters in, and now they say something.

- *Recall:* say *huān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *hé* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *kàn* — *kànjiàn* — *hǎokàn* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *míng* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

The sounds and tones in this word

喜欢 is *xǐhuan* — **third tone, then nothing.**
喜 is third tone, the dip. 欢 is first tone on its own — but inside this word it **loses its tone altogether** and goes light: *xǐ-huan*, not *xǐ-huān*. That is the same thing 早上 does to 上, and 名字 to 字.
Say it once slowly and once at speed: **xǐ huan**.

Grammar Lens: the liker is the subject, and that is all

person + 喜欢 + the thing liked.

我喜欢看书 *wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū* — I like reading. 我喜欢中国 — I like China. 你喜欢汉语吗 — do you like Chinese?

That is an ordinary sentence with an ordinary verb and an ordinary object, and saying so is the point. Spanish and Italian make a beginner turn the sentence round: Spanish says *me gusta el libro* — "the book pleases me" — and Italian says *mi piace*, with the liker in an object slot and the thing liked as the subject. Learners spend weeks on it. **Mandarin asks nothing of you here.** The person who likes goes in front, the verb does not change, and the thing liked follows. It is the same shape as 我看书.
And 不 works on it normally, which 有 did not:

我不喜欢看书 — I don't like reading.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

喜欢 is a Chinese compound of two words for joy, both inherited from Middle Chinese: *xiX*, "glad", and *xwan*, "joy" (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *xǐhuan* — 喜欢, and let 欢 go light
- 我喜欢看书
- 我不喜欢看书

Before you move on

What tones does 喜欢 carry? (**Third, then none** — 欢 goes light.)
Who goes in front of it? (**The person who likes** — no inversion.)
Does 不 negate it normally? (**Yes** — 我不喜欢.)

28.4 你喜欢什么 — what do you like?

Four in, and this lesson joins two chapters that never met.

- *Recall:* say *xǐhuan* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *hé* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *gè* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *wǒ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

You'll want to know: the question, and where 什么 sits

你喜欢什么 *nǐ xǐhuan shénme* — **what do you like?**

Four words, and all of them were already in the book except 喜欢.

Now notice where 什么 is. It is at the END, in exactly the slot the answer would occupy:

— 你喜欢什么 — what do you like? — 我喜欢书 — I like books.

Mandarin does not move a question word. English hauls *what* to the front and reshuffles everything behind it — *you like what* becomes *what do you like*, with a *do* invented on the way. Mandarin leaves 什么 exactly where the answer goes and changes nothing else. Question and answer have the same shape, word for word.

That is why no 吗 is needed here. 吗 makes a yes-or-no question; a sentence that already contains 什么 is a question, and adding 吗 would be wrong.

你喜欢汉语吗 — do you like Chinese? *(yes or no)* 你喜欢什么 — what do you like? *(name it)*

And the whole exchange, with the particle from the last chapter:

— 你喜欢什么 — 我喜欢看书你呢

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Chinese built the question from words it already had: *nǐ*, *xǐhuan*, from Middle Chinese *xiX* and *xwan*, and *shénme*, whose origin is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 你喜欢什么
- 我喜欢看书你呢
- 你喜欢汉语吗 — and hear why this one needs 吗

Before you move on

Where does 什么 stand? (**Where the answer goes** — at the end.) Does Mandarin move it to the front? (**No** — nothing moves.) Why is there no 吗? (**A sentence with 什么 in it is already a**

question.)

28.5 我喜欢看书

The last chapter of the tranche closes here.

- *Recall:* say *nǐ xǐhuan shénme* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shíbā suì — nǐ hé wǒ* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *shū* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more
- *Recall:* say *wǒ* — **R4**, recognition at distance, a second word from that far back

What you've built — liking, said plainly

Two characters, eighteen strokes, one verb — and with it a whole area of talk this book could not enter:

> 我喜欢看书 — I like reading. 我不喜欢看书 — I don't. 你喜欢什么 — what do you like? 你喜欢汉语吗 — do you like Chinese?

Nothing there is inverted, nothing agrees, nothing moves. The liker is the subject; the thing liked is the object; 什么 stands where the answer stands. Spanish and Italian both make you turn that round; Mandarin does not.
And now the whole tranche can be said in one breath, because every piece of it is yours:

> 我是中国人 — 我十八岁 — 我有一个名字 — 我喜欢看书 — 你呢

Listen. *Wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū. Nǐ xǐhuan shénme?*
Speak. Say what you like; ask what the other person likes; hand it back with 你呢.

Read it: 我喜欢看书 — 你喜欢什么
Write it: 喜 — four bands, twelve strokes; 欢 — 又, then 欠

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我喜欢看书 我不喜欢看书
- *Say it:* 你喜欢什么 — 我喜欢书你呢
- *Write it:* 喜 欢

Before you move on

Say "I like reading." (我喜欢看书.) Where does 什么 go in the question? (**At the end, where the answer goes**.) And what does Mandarin ask you to turn round here? (**Nothing at all**.)

Chapter 29

Reading — Characters, Words, and a First Passage

Modes: **eyes** (3) **Hands-free start:** none of the 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a Chinese character cold, find where a word ends when nothing marks it, and hold a whole passage without translating it character by character.
>
> *Thirty-four characters in a row with no new character in them, including the first line in the book whose meaning depends on the lines before it.*

29.1 (reading) — six characters, nothing said first

You have written every one of these. Not one is new.

What is new is that nobody is going to say them first.

Read this

人 书 看 有 和 十

Read down the list once. Do not count strokes — look at the whole character and let it arrive.
Again, and notice which came at once and which you had to take apart. Both are fine. The difference is what practice removes.

What to know first

In an alphabet a single letter is almost never a word. Here every one of these six is.

That changes what reading is. There is no sounding out: a character either lands whole or it does not land, and the only thing that moves it from the second to the first is having met it before.

Six is enough for one sitting, because six is already six words.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the six characters down the list, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many of the six were new? (**None.**)
How many of them are whole words? (**All six.**)

29.2 (reading) — six words, not six characters

The last lesson gave you six characters that were each a word. These are six words that are not each a character.

Every character in them is still one you have written.

Read this

中国人 我的书 看书的人 一个 十八岁 喜欢

Read it: the six words down once, without stopping
Read it: the six words again, and this time notice there is nothing between the characters
No space tells you where one word ends.

What to know first

看书的人 is four characters and one idea: the person who reads. You know all four, and knowing them is not the same as seeing where the join falls.

That is the work this lesson does. Mandarin writes no spaces, so a reader has to decide where a word ends, and the only tool for it is having met the word before.

喜欢 is the clearest case: two characters that mean nothing apart, and *to like* together.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the six words down the list, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many characters are in 看书的人? (**Four.**) How many words? (**One.**)
What tells you where a word ends? (**Nothing on the page** — only having met it.)

29.3 (reading) — the first passage

Six characters, then six words. Now ten lines.

Thirty-four characters, and not one of them is new.

Read this

我是中国人 我有一个名字 我看书 我喜欢看书 我十八岁 你呢 对不对 你好 谢谢 再见

Read it: the passage through once without stopping; do not translate as you go
Read it: the passage again, and this time notice that the passage turns at line six
The first five are about the writer. The last five are addressed to you.

What to know first

你呢 is two characters and does the work of a whole English sentence: *and what about you?* It only means that because of the five lines before it, which is the first time this book has asked a line to depend on what came earlier.

我十八岁 has no verb in it at all. Mandarin states an age by putting the number and 岁 straight after the person, and a reader who waits for a verb waits forever.

This is the first whole passage the book has asked you to hold at once, and it works because every character was paid for.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the passage aloud, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which line depends on the five before it? (你呢)
Which line has no verb? (我十八岁 — and it needs none.)

Chapter 30

How Are You?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask how somebody is and answer that I am fine, busy, tired or so-so.
>
> *The everyday way to ask how somebody is, and four answers to it, built on one new written character: 很, the plain link Mandarin puts in front of an adjective.*

30.1 zěnmeyàng — how are you doing?

A new chapter, and it opens with a question you can ask anybody you know.

- *Recall:* say *nǐ ne* — **R1**, the line that turned the passage one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *nǐ xǐhuan shénme* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu yí ge míngzi* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *zǎoshang hǎo* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more

The sounds and tones in this word

zěnmeyàng — **a dip, a light syllable, then a fall.**
zěn is third tone. *me* is the same toneless syllable that ends 什么. *yàng*

is fourth tone, and it carries the weight of the word.

nǐ zěnmeyàng — How are you doing?

Say it once slowly and once at speed: **zěn me yàng**.

Why it's said this way

You already have 你好吗 *nǐ hǎo ma*, and it is correct. It is the question textbooks open with.
Between people who know each other, the one you will hear far more often is *nǐ zěnmeyàng*: "how are things with you?" On its own, *zěnmeyàng* asks how something is, and putting 你 in front makes the something you.
So keep both. 你好吗 is the careful one; *nǐ zěnmeyàng* is the one a friend asks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Mandarin builds *zěnmeyàng* from three syllables. *me* is the light 么 from 什么, a character you know. The characters for *zěn* and *yàng* come later; this chapter keeps them to the ear.
No dictionary we use records an older form of *zěn* or *yàng*, so the history of the word is not settled, and where 么 comes from is not settled either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *zěnmeyàng* — dip, light, fall
- *nǐ zěnmeyàng*
- 你好吗, then the everyday one, *nǐ zěnmeyàng*

Before you move on

What tones does *zěnmeyàng* carry? (**Third, none, fourth.**) Which question would a friend ask you? (***nǐ zěnmeyàng*** — 你好吗 is the one textbooks open with.)

30.2 很 — the word in front of an adjective

The question is in place. This lesson gives you the word every answer needs.

- *Recall:* say *nǐ zěnmeyàng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *xǐhuan* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǒ de shū* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *hǎo* — **R4**, recognition at distance, the first word in this book

The sounds and tones in this word

很 is *hěn* — **third tone**, the dip, the same as 好.
Its pieces, in words: on the left, the person piece from 你 with one more left-falling stroke above it; on the right, a piece read *gěn*. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

Grammar Lens: no 是, and a plain 很 instead

我很好 *wǒ hěn hǎo* — I'm fine.

In Mandarin an adjective is the whole predicate: there is no 是 in "I am fine", and a plain 很 stands in front of 好 instead. Here 很 has lost most of its *very*, so 我很好 is "I'm fine", while a bare 我好 sounds like the start of a contrast — I am fine, but somebody else is not.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

很 is an old character: the Guangyun records it as *honX* (in Baxter's transcription), glossed "defiant". How that word came to mean "very" is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hěn* — dip it

- 我很好
- *nǐ zěnmeyàng* — 我很好

Before you move on

Does 是 go in front of an adjective? (**No — a plain 很 does.**)
What does 我很好 mean? (**I'm fine** — 很 has lost most of its *very*.)

30.3 很 — nine strokes, two pieces

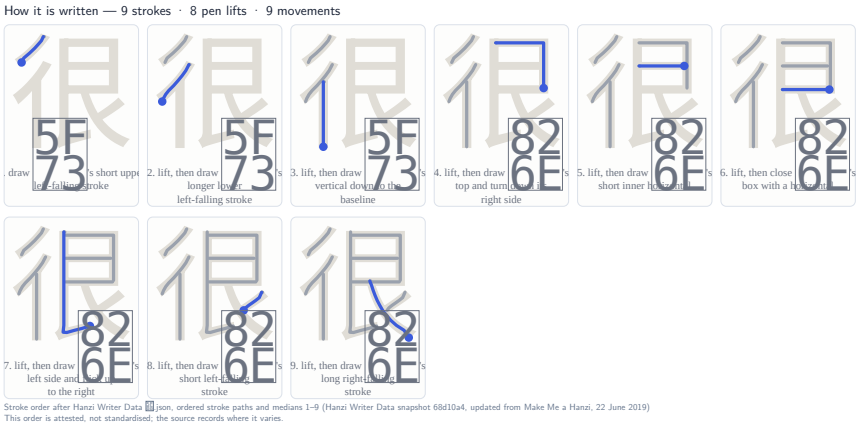
Three characters first, read cold, before the new piece arrives.

- *Recall:* say *hěn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *shíbā suì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back

人 亻 你

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, the person piece, *nǐ*

Script — two pieces, left before right



How 很 *is written, stroke by stroke*

很

Nine strokes, but two pieces. Do not count to nine. Read the character across, left piece first, the way you write 你.

The left piece, 彳, three strokes. Its lower two are the person piece 亻 you have written since 你: a left-falling stroke, then a vertical down to the foot. 彳 adds one more short left-falling stroke above them. So: a short fall, a longer fall, then the vertical.

The right piece, 艮, six strokes. A horizontal that turns down the right side of a box without lifting. A short horizontal inside it. A horizontal that closes the box. Then the left side, down to the foot, flicking up to the right. A short left-falling stroke on the right, and last the long right-falling stroke.

3 + 6 = nine, and the first three are a shape your hand already knows.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 亻, then 彳 — the same two strokes with one more fall above them
- *Write it:* 很, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes does 很 have? (**Nine**.) How many pieces? (**Two** — 彳, then 艮.) Which piece is the person piece with one stroke added? (**彳, on the left**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 很, pinned stroke paths and medians.

30.4 很好 — I'm fine

Nine strokes in your hand. Now they become an answer.

- *Recall:* say *hěn* — **R1**, the character one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back

- *Recall:* say *nǐ hǎo* — **R4**, recognition at distance, the first word in this book

The sounds and tones in this word

很好 is *hěn hǎo* — **two third tones side by side.**
You met this in the first chapter with 你好, and the same rule fires again: the first of the two rises. Spoken, it is *hén hǎo*. Written, it stays *hěn hǎo*, and the characters do not change at all.
Say it slowly once, then at speed, and let 很 rise into 好.

Why it's said this way

我很好 *wǒ hěn hǎo* — I'm fine.

That is the answer to *nǐ zěnmeyàng* and to 你好吗. It means "I'm fine", not "I'm very well": 很 is there because 好 is an adjective and wants it in front. Put weight on 很, and the *very* comes back.

Read this

我很好你呢

Five characters, and nothing on the page marks where one word stops. Find the words before reading on.
我 — 很好 — 你 — 呢. Four words; 很好 is the only one with two characters.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

很好 is built from 很 and 好. 好 is inherited from Middle Chinese *xawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); 很 is the character the Guangyun records as *honX*, "defiant", and how it came to mean "very" is not settled.

Your turn

- *Say it: hén hǎo* — let the first one rise
- *Say it: nǐ zěnmeyàng* — 我很好
- *Write it:* 很好

Before you move on

Which of the two syllables in 很好 rises when you say it? (**The first, 很.**)

30.5 máng — busy

One answer so far. This lesson adds a second, and it is not "fine".

- *Recall:* say *wǒ hěn hǎo* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *nǐ zěnmeyàng* — **R2**, the question that opened this chapter
- *Recall:* say *yǒu* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *zǎoshang* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more

The sounds and tones in this word

máng — **second tone**, rising, like a surprised "huh?". Its character comes later; this chapter keeps it to the ear.

Grammar Lens: the same shape as 我很好

máng is an adjective, so it works exactly like 好: no 是, a plain 很 in front.

> *wǒ hěn máng* — I'm busy. *zǎoshang wǒ hěn máng* — I'm busy in the mornings.

zǎoshang goes first, before the person: the time is what the sentence is about, then comes what happens in it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

máng is probably inherited from Middle Chinese *mang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where it is glossed "afraid". Flustered becoming busy is a likely path for the sense, but it is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *máng* — let it rise
- *wǒ hěn máng*
- *zǎoshang wǒ hěn máng*

Before you move on

What tone is *máng*? (**Second, rising.**) What goes in front of it? (**A plain 很**, as in front of 好.) Where does *zǎoshang* go? (**First, before the person.**)

30.6 lèi — tired

Busy all morning, and now you are tired. You step into a lift, and the panel reads:

九

Say it: jiǔ — the ninth floor, read off the wall, the way you first read floor numbers

- *Recall:* say *máng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *xǐhuan* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *yí ge* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back

The sounds and tones in this word

lèi — **fourth tone**, a short clean fall. Its character comes later; this chapter keeps it to the ear.

Grammar Lens: a statement, then 吗

lèi is an adjective too. Ask with 吗 on the end, and answer with 很:

nǐ lèi ma — Are you tired? *wǒ hěn lèi* — I'm tired.

The question is the statement with 吗 added; nothing moves.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The character for *lèi* is in the Guangyun, read *ljweX* and *ljweH* (Baxter's transcription), but glossed "accumulate" and "implicate". "Tired" is not among its senses there, so how the word came to mean it is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lèi* — fall
- *nǐ lèi ma*
- *wǒ hěn lèi*

Before you move on

What tone is *lèi*? (**Fourth, falling.**) How do you ask "are you tired?" (***nǐ lèi ma*** — the statement, then 吗.) And the lift panel? (九, ***jiǔ.***)

30.7 hái xíng — not bad

Fine, busy, tired. Most days are none of those, and this lesson is for them.

- *Recall:* say *lèi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *duì* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *nǐ hé wǒ* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *bù* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more

Read this

早上好 你好吗 我很好 你呢

Read it: the three lines aloud as one exchange, without stopping between them
The last line hands the question back. This lesson gives you a third way to answer it.

The sounds and tones in this word

hái xíng — **two rising tones.**
hái is "still"; *xíng* is "OK, it works". Together: "still OK" — not bad. Its characters come later; this chapter keeps the word to the ear.

hái xíng, nǐ ne — Not bad. And you?

Why it's said this way

很好 says things are good. *hái xíng* says they are all right, and it is the answer people give when they are not going to complain. Said with a shrug, it can mean "could be better".

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hái xíng is built from *hái* "still" and *xíng* "all right". Both characters are in the Guangyun (Baxter's transcription): the one for *hái* as *hwaen*, "return", and the one for *xíng* as *haeng*, "walk, go". How they came to mean "still" and "all right" is not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hái xíng* — rise, rise
- *hái xíng, nǐ ne*

Before you move on

What tones does *hái xíng* carry? (**Two rising tones.**) Which answer is between *hěn hǎo* and *hěn lèi*? (***hái xíng*** — not bad.)

30.8 nǐ zěnmeyàng — wǒ hěn hǎo

The chapter closes here, with a whole exchange.

- *Recall:* say *hái xíng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays
- *Recall:* say *wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū* — **R2**, the first real retrieval, five to fifteen lessons back
- *Recall:* say *wǒ shì zhōngguórén* — **R3**, durable, twenty to sixty lessons back
- *Recall:* say *zǎoshang hǎo* — **R4**, recognition at distance, eighty lessons back or more

The exchange

A: 早上好

zǎoshang hǎo — good morning.

B: 早上好 — *nǐ zěnmeyàng*

zǎoshang hǎo, nǐ zěnmeyàng — good morning. How are you doing?

A: 我很好 你呢

wǒ hěn hǎo, nǐ ne — I'm fine. And you?

B: *hái xíng, wǒ hěn máng* — not bad. I'm busy.

A: *nǐ lèi ma* — are you tired?

B: *hěn lèi, zàijiàn* — I am. Goodbye.

A: 再见

zàijiàn — goodbye.

The words whose characters this book has not written yet stay in pinyin; you know them by ear, and here the ear carries them. The morning greeting is one of the first things this book gave you, and this is the first exchange to carry on past it.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — four answers to one question

One question, *nǐ zěnmeyàng*, and four answers, every one of them with a plain 很 or none at all:

- *wǒ hěn hǎo* — I'm fine.
- *hái xíng* — not bad.
- *wǒ hěn máng* — I'm busy.
- *wǒ hěn lèi* — I'm tired.

Listen. *Nǐ zěnmeyàng?*
Speak. Answer it four ways, then hand it back with 你呢.
Write it: 很 — 彳 first, then 艮

Your turn

- *Say it: nǐ zěnmeyàng* — then answer with *hái xíng*
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我很好

Before you move on

Ask a friend how they are doing. (***nǐ zěnmeyàng.***) Say you are fine. (我很好 — and 很 rises into 好.) What goes in front of an adjective? (**A plain 很**, and no 是.)

Chapter 31

He, She and We

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say he, she, we, you all and they.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 31: I can say he, she, we, you all and they.*

31.1 tā — she; her

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for tired, then the Mandarin for not bad.

You'll want to know: tā

tā — "she; her".

tā shì wǒ de tóngxué — She's a classmate of mine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tā sounds exactly like the word for he. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: tā*
- *Say it: tā*, once more
- *Say it: tā shì wǒ de tóngxué* — She's a classmate of mine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for tired, then the Mandarin for not bad, then say *tā* again

Before you move on

What does tā mean? ("She; her".) Say it once more.

31.2 他 (tā) — he; him

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for not bad, then the Mandarin for she.

You'll want to know: 他

他 — *tā* — "he; him".

他是我的儿子 *tā shì wǒ de érzi* — He's my son.

The new character, in pieces: 他 — the person piece from 你 on the left, and on the right a three-stroke shape read yě. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

他 (*tā*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tha* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses it 'not I', the other person, and calls this the everyday form of the character. From somebody other than me to he is the usual explanation, but the step itself is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: tā*
- *Say it: tā*, once more
- *Say it: tā shì wǒ de érzi* — He's my son.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for not bad, then the Mandarin for she, then say *tā* again

Before you move on

What does 他 mean? ("He; him".) Say it once more.

31.3 他 — the person piece, then yě

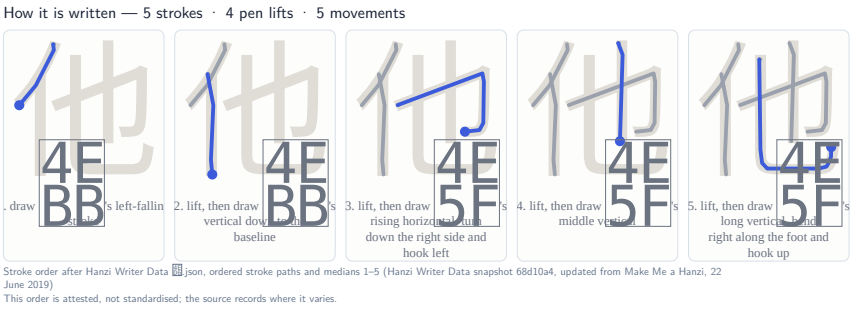
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *tā* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  亻 你

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — the person piece, *nǐ*

Script — the person piece, then yě



How 他 is written, stroke by stroke

他

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The left piece, 亻, two strokes. The same two as in 你: a left-falling stroke, then a vertical down to the foot.

The right piece, three strokes, read yě. A horizontal that runs right, turns down and hooks. A short vertical through the middle of it. Then a long vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up at the end.

2 + 3 = five, and the first two your hand already knows.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 他, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes does 他 have? (**Five**.) Which piece comes first? (**亻, the person piece, on the left**.) How does the last stroke end? (**It runs along the bottom and hooks up**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 他, pinned stroke paths and medians.

31.4 他们 (tāmen) — they; them

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for she, then the Mandarin for he.

You'll want to know: 他们

他们 — *tāmen* — "they; them".

他们是中国人 *tāmen shì Zhōngguó rén* — They're Chinese.

The new character, in pieces: 们 — the person piece on the left again, and on the right a three-stroke piece read mén, the word for door, which gives the sound. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

他们 (*tāmen*) is built from 他 'he' and the plural ending men, which goes on words for people. No dictionary we use records an older form of the ending, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: tāmen*
- *Say it: tāmen*, once more
- *Say it: tāmen shì Zhōngguó rén* — They're Chinese.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for she, then the Mandarin for he, then say *tāmen* again

Before you move on

What does 他们 mean? ("They; them".) Say it once more.

31.5 们 — the person piece, then a doorway

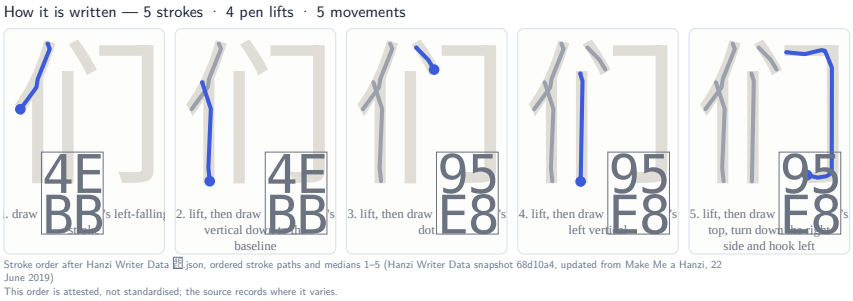
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *tāmen* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  他 你

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tā*, *nǐ*

Script — the person piece, then a doorway



How 们 is written, stroke by stroke

们

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, 亻, two strokes, exactly as in 他 and 你.

The right piece, a doorway, three strokes. A dot at the top left. A vertical down the left side. Then a horizontal across the top that turns down the right side and hooks in at the foot.

2 + 3 = five. The doorway is read mén, and alone it is the word for door; here it gives 们 its sound and loses its tone.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 们, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 们? (**Two** — 亻, then the doorway.) Which stroke of the doorway comes first? (**The dot**.) Which other character opens with the same two strokes? (他, and 你.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 们, pinned stroke paths and medians.

31.6 我们 (wǒmen) — we; us

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for he, then the Mandarin for they.

You'll want to know: 我们

我们 — *wǒmen* — "we; us".

wǒmen hái xíng — We're doing all right.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

我们 (*wǒmen*) is built from 我 'I' and the plural ending men. 我 is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary glosses as what you call yourself; no dictionary we use records an older form of the ending, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǒmen*
- *Say it: wǒmen*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen hái xíng* — We're doing all right.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for he, then the Mandarin for they, then say *wǒmen* again

Before you move on

What does 我们 mean? ("We; us".) Say it once more.

31.7 你们 (nǐmen) — you all; you (more than one)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for they, then the Mandarin for we.

You'll want to know: 你们

你们 — *nǐmen* — "you all; you (more than one)".

nǐmen zěnmeyàng — How are you all doing?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你们 (*nǐmen*) is built from 你 'you' and the plural ending men. No dictionary we use records an older form of either, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǐmen*
- *Say it: nǐmen*, once more
- *Say it: nǐmen zěnmeyàng* — How are you all doing?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for they, then the Mandarin for we, then say *nǐmen* again

Before you move on

What does 你们 mean? ("You all; you (more than one)".) Say it once more.

Chapter 32

Mum and Dad

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my parents, brothers and sisters.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 32: I can name my parents, brothers and sisters.*

32.1 妈妈 (māma) — mum; mother

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for we, then the Mandarin for you all.

You'll want to know: 妈妈

妈妈 — *māma* — "mum; mother".

> 我妈妈很好 *wǒ māma hěn hǎo* — My mum is well.

The new character, in pieces: 妈 — 女, the woman piece, on the left, and on the right a three-stroke piece read mǎ, the word for horse, which gives the sound as it does in 吗. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

妈妈 (*māma*) is written with a character the Guangyun records as *muX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'mother'. The modern sound is not what *muX* would regularly become, so whether

mā is inherited from it, or is a nursery word written with this character, is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: māma*
- *Say it: māma*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma hěn hǎo* — My mum is well.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for we, then the Mandarin for you all, then say *māma* again

Before you move on

What does 妈妈 mean? ("Mum; mother".) Say it once more.

32.2 妈 — the woman piece, then a horse

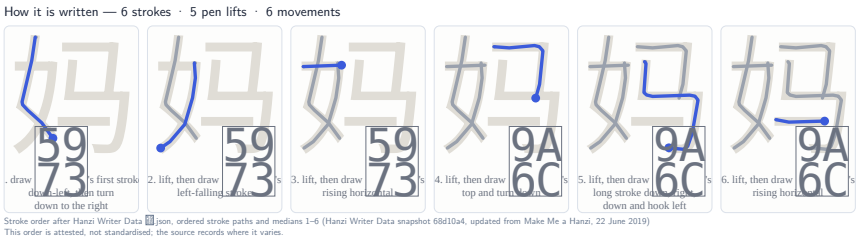
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *māma* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

女 吗

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *nǚ*, *ma*

Script — the woman piece, then a horse



How 妈 is written, stroke by stroke

妈

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, 女, three strokes, as you wrote it alone, but narrow: the fold that drops and turns, the long left-falling stroke, and last the horizontal, which here rises to the right so it does not cross into the next piece.

The right piece, the horse, three strokes. A horizontal that turns down. A vertical that folds right, folds down again and hooks at the foot. Then a rising stroke across the bottom.

3 + 3 = six. The same horse stands on the right of 吗, which is why the two sound alike.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 妈, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 妈? (**Two** — 女, then the horse.) What does the last stroke of 女 do here? (**It rises to the right**.) Which character you know has the same right piece? (吗.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 妈, pinned stroke paths and medians.

32.3 bàba — dad; father

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for you all, then the Mandarin for mum.

You'll want to know: bàba

bàba — "dad; father".

wǒ bàba xǐhuan kàn shū — My dad likes reading.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bàba is inherited from Middle Chinese *baX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where the character is glossed 'father'. Spoken, it is doubled, like the word for mum.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: bàba*
- *Say it: bàba*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bàba xǐhuan kàn shū* — My dad likes reading.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for you all, then the Mandarin for mum, then say *bàba* again

Before you move on

What does bàba mean? ("Dad; father".) Say it once more.

32.4 gēge — elder brother

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for mum, then the Mandarin for dad.

You'll want to know: gēge

gēge — "elder brother".

wǒ yǒu yí ge gēge — I've got an older brother.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gēge is inherited from Middle Chinese *ka* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary notes that the character was once written for 'song', and that in its own day people used it to call an

elder brother.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: gēge*
- *Say it: gēge*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǒu yí ge gēge* — I've got an older brother.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for mum, then the Mandarin for dad, then say *gēge* again

Before you move on

What does gēge mean? ("Elder brother".) Say it once more.

32.5 jiějie — elder sister

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dad, then the Mandarin for elder brother.

You'll want to know: jiějie

jiějie — "elder sister".

wǒ jiějie shì dàxuésheng — My older sister is at university.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiějie is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsjaeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where it is glossed as the word one people used for mother. How it came to mean elder sister is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiějie*
- *Say it: jiějie*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiějie shì dàxuésheng* — My older sister is at university.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dad, then the Mandarin for elder brother, then say *jiějie* again

Before you move on

What does jiějie mean? ("Elder sister".) Say it once more.

32.6 dìdi — younger brother

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for elder brother, then the Mandarin for elder sister.

You'll want to know: dìdi

dìdi — "younger brother".

wǒ dìdi bā suì — My little brother is eight.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìdi is inherited from Middle Chinese *dejX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as the brother born later.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìdi*
- *Say it: dìdi*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ dìdi bā suì* — My little brother is eight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for elder brother, then the Mandarin for elder sister, then say *dìdi* again

Before you move on

What does dìdi mean? ("Younger brother".) Say it once more.

Chapter 33

The Rest of the Family

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about men, women, sisters and children.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 33: I can talk about men, women, sisters and children.*

33.1 男 (nán) — male

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for elder sister, then the Mandarin for younger brother.

You'll want to know: 男

男 — *nán* — "male".

> 我有一个男同学 *wǒ yǒu yí ge nán tóngxué* — One of my classmates is a boy.

The new character, in pieces: 男 — a field on top, built like 日 with a cross inside, and below it a two-stroke piece meaning strength. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

男 (*nán*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *nom* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a man'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nán*
- *Say it: nán*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǒu yí ge nán tóngxué* — One of my classmates is a boy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for elder sister, then the Mandarin for younger brother, then say *nán* again

Before you move on

What does 男 mean? ("Male".) Say it once more.

33.2 男 — a field above, strength below

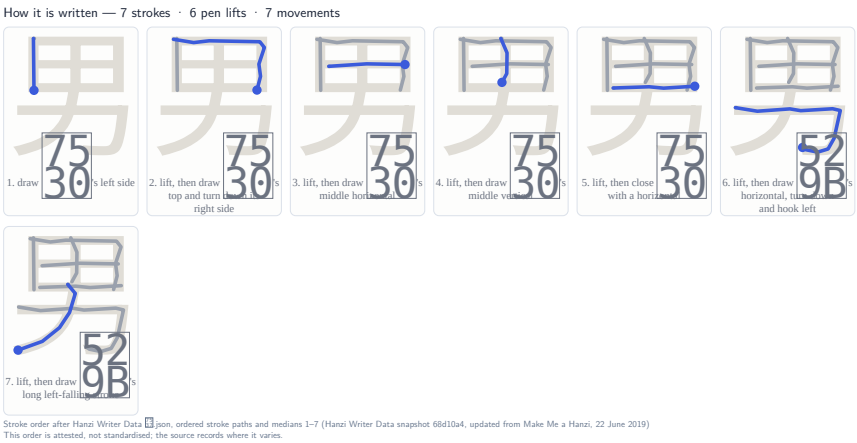
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *nán* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *kǒu*

Script — a field above, strength below



How 男 *is written, stroke by stroke*

男

Two pieces, top before bottom.

The top piece, a field, five strokes. A vertical down the left. A horizontal across the top that turns down the right side. The short horizontal across the middle. The short vertical down the middle. Then the horizontal that closes the bottom. It is 日 with a cross inside instead of a single bar.

The bottom piece, strength, two strokes. A horizontal that turns down and hooks to the left, then a long left-falling stroke through it.

5 + 2 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 男, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 男? (**Two** — the field, then strength.) Which character you know does the field look like? (日, with a cross inside.) Which stroke closes the field? (**The bottom horizontal,**

the fifth.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 男, pinned stroke paths and medians.

33.3 男人 (nánrén) — man

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for younger brother, then the Mandarin for male.

You'll want to know: 男人

男人 — *nánrén* — "man".

我家有三个男人 *wǒ jiā yǒu sān ge nánrén* — There are three men in my family.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

男人 (*nánrén*) is built from 男 'male' and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nom* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nánrén*
- *Say it: nánrén*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā yǒu sān ge nánrén* — There are three men in my family.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for younger brother, then the Mandarin for male, then say *nánrén* again

Before you move on

What does 男人 mean? ("Man".) Say it once more.

33.4 女人 (nǚrén) — woman

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for male, then the Mandarin for man.

You'll want to know: 女人

女人 — *nǚrén* — "woman".

我家有四个女人 *wǒ jiā yǒu sì ge nǚrén* — There are four women in my family.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

女人 (*nǚrén*) is built from 女 'female' and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nrjoX* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǚrén*
- *Say it: nǚrén*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā yǒu sì ge nǚrén* — There are four women in my family.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for male, then the Mandarin for man, then say *nǚrén* again

Before you move on

What does 女人 mean? ("Woman".) Say it once more.

33.5 mèimei — younger sister

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for man, then the Mandarin for woman.

You'll want to know: mèimei

mèimei — "younger sister".

> *wǒ mèimei shì xiǎoxuésheng* — My little sister is at primary school.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

mèimei is inherited from Middle Chinese *mwojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where it is glossed with the word for sisters.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: mèimei*
- *Say it: mèimei*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ mèimei shì xiǎoxuésheng* — My little sister is at primary school.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for man, then the Mandarin for woman, then say *mèimei* again

Before you move on

What does mèimei mean? ("Younger sister".) Say it once more.

33.6 háizi — child

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for woman, then the Mandarin for younger sister.

You'll want to know: háizi

háizi — "child".

> *tāmen yǒu sān ge háizi* — They have three children.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

háizi is built from hái 'child' and the noun ending zi. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *hoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a newborn child'; the ending is *tsiX*, 'child', the same piece as the one in 儿子.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: háizi*
- *Say it: háizi*, once more
- *Say it: tāmen yǒu sān ge háizi* — They have three children.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for woman, then the Mandarin for younger sister, then say *háizi* again

Before you move on

What does háizi mean? ("Child".) Say it once more.

Chapter 34

What You Are Called

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask somebody's name and family name, politely too.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 34: I can ask somebody's name and family name, politely too.*

34.1 叫 (jiào) — to be called; to call

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for younger sister, then the Mandarin for child.

You'll want to know: 叫

叫 — *jiào* — "to be called; to call".

> 你叫什么名字 *nǐ jiào shénme míngzi* — What's your name?

The new character, in pieces: 叫 — 口, the mouth piece, small on the left, and on the right two strokes: one that flicks up, and a long vertical. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

叫 (*jiào*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *kewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to call out'. The sense 'to be named' is not given there; from calling a person to what a person is called is a

likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiào*
- *Say it: jiào*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ jiào shénme míngzi* — What's your name?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for younger sister, then the Mandarin for child, then say *jiào* again

Before you move on

What does 叫 mean? ("To be called; to call".) Say it once more.

34.2 叫 — a small mouth, then two strokes

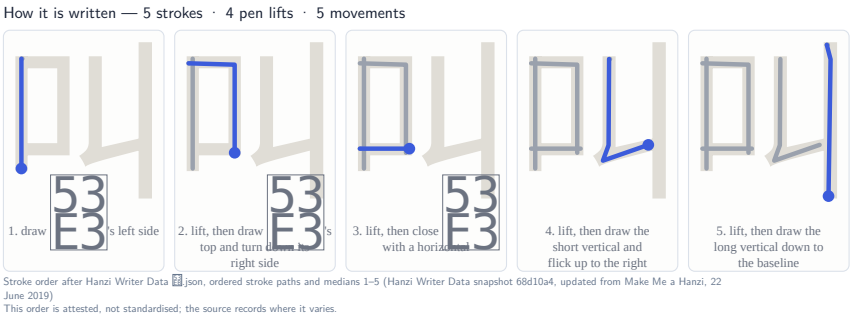
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *jiào* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  口 吗

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *ma*

Script — a small mouth, then two strokes



How 叫 is written, stroke by stroke

叫

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, 口, three strokes, as in 吗, small and set a little high: the left side, the top that turns down the right, the bottom that closes it.

The right piece, two strokes. A vertical that flicks up to the right at the foot. Then a long vertical, the tallest stroke in the character.

3 + 2 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 叫, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 叫? (**Two** — 口, then two strokes.) Which character you know has the same small 口 on the left? (吗.) Which stroke is last? (**The long vertical**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 叫, pinned stroke paths and medians.

34.3 nín — you (polite)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for child, then the Mandarin for to be called.

You'll want to know: nín

nín — "you (polite)".

nín jiào shénme míngzi — May I ask your name?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nín is the polite form of 你, for older people and strangers. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nín*
- *Say it: nín*, once more
- *Say it: nín jiào shénme míngzi* — May I ask your name?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for child, then the Mandarin for to be called, then say *nín* again

Before you move on

What does nín mean? ("You (polite)".) Say it once more.

34.4 xìng — to have the family name; family name

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be called, then the Mandarin for you (polite).

You'll want to know: xìng

xìng — "to have the family name; family name".

nǐ xìng shénme — What's your family name?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xìng is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjengH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'clan name'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: xìng*
- *Say it: xìng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xìng shénme* — What's your family name?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be called, then the Mandarin for you (polite), then say *xìng* again

Before you move on

What does xìng mean? ("To have the family name; family name".) Say it once more.

34.5 rènshi — to know someone; to recognise

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for you (polite), then the Mandarin for to have the family name.

You'll want to know: rènshi

rènshi — "to know someone; to recognise".

wǒ rènshi tā — I know him.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rènshi is built from two old words for knowing, both inherited from Middle Chinese: *nyinH*, which the Guangyun glosses with the second, and *syik*, 'to know' (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: rènshi*
- *Say it: rènshi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ rènshi tā* — I know him.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for you (polite), then the Mandarin for to have the family name, then say *rènshi* again

Before you move on

What does rènshi mean? ("To know someone; to recognise".) Say it once more.

34.6 péngyou — friend

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to have the family name, then the Mandarin for to know someone.

You'll want to know: péngyou

péngyou — "friend".

tā shì wǒ de péngyou — He's a friend of mine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

péngyou is built from two words for companions, both inherited from Middle Chinese: *bong* 'a band of companions' and *hjuwX* 'friend'

(Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as people of one mind.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: péngyou*
- *Say it: péngyou*, once more
- *Say it: tā shì wǒ de péngyou* — He's a friend of mine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to have the family name, then the Mandarin for to know someone, then say *péngyou* again

Before you move on

What does péngyou mean? ("Friend".) Say it once more.

Chapter 35

Who Does What

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what people do and where somebody lives.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 35: I can say what people do and where somebody lives.*

35.1 gōngzuò — to work; job

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to know someone, then the Mandarin for friend.

You'll want to know: gōngzuò

gōngzuò — "to work; job".

> *wǒ jiějie gōngzuò, wǒ shàngxué* — My sister works; I go to school.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gōngzuò is built from gōng 'craft' and zuò 'to do', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kuwng* and *tsak* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'office' and 'skill', the second 'to do'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: gōngzuò*
- *Say it: gōngzuò*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiějie gōngzuò, wǒ shàngxué* — My sister works; I go to school.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to know someone, then the Mandarin for friend, then say *gōngzuò* again

Before you move on

What does gōngzuò mean? ("To work; job".) Say it once more.

35.2 lǎo — old

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for friend, then the Mandarin for to work.

You'll want to know: lǎo

lǎo — "old".

tā shì wǒ de lǎo tóngxué — He's an old classmate of mine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *lawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'aged'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǎo*
- *Say it: lǎo*, once more
- *Say it: tā shì wǒ de lǎo tóngxué* — He's an old classmate of mine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for friend, then the Mandarin for to work, then say *lǎo* again

Before you move on

What does lǎo mean? ("Old".) Say it once more.

35.3 lǎoshī — teacher

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to work, then the Mandarin for old.

You'll want to know: lǎoshī

lǎoshī — "teacher".

wǒ māma shì lǎoshī — My mum is a teacher.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǎoshī is built from lǎo 'old, respected' and shī 'teacher', both inherited from Middle Chinese: *lawX*, glossed 'aged', and *srij*, glossed 'a model to follow' (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǎoshī*
- *Say it: lǎoshī*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ māma shì lǎoshī* — My mum is a teacher.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to work, then the Mandarin for old, then say *lǎoshī* again

Before you move on

What does lǎoshī mean? ("Teacher".) Say it once more.

35.4 xiānsheng — Mr; sir; husband

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for old, then the Mandarin for teacher.

You'll want to know: xiānsheng

xiānsheng — "Mr; sir; husband".

tā xiānsheng shì lǎoshī — Her husband is a teacher.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiānsheng is built from xiān 'before' and 生 'to be born, to grow', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sen* and *srjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). 'The one born first' is the usual explanation of how it came to mean an older man to respect, and then Mr or husband; the path is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiānsheng*
- *Say it: xiānsheng*, once more
- *Say it: tā xiānsheng shì lǎoshī* — Her husband is a teacher.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for old, then the Mandarin for teacher, then say *xiānsheng* again

Before you move on

What does xiānsheng mean? ("Mr; sir; husband".) Say it once more.

35.5 zhù — to live somewhere; to stay

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for teacher, then the Mandarin for sir.

You'll want to know: zhù

zhù — "to live somewhere; to stay".

tā zhù wǒ jiā — He's staying at our place.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhù is inherited from Middle Chinese *drjuH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to stop, to stay'. Staying somewhere becoming living there is a likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhù*
- *Say it: zhù*, once more
- *Say it: tā zhù wǒ jiā* — He's staying at our place.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for teacher, then the Mandarin for sir, then say *zhù* again

Before you move on

What does zhù mean? ("To live somewhere; to stay".) Say it once more.

Chapter 36

Where People Come From

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say where somebody comes from and ask which country.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 36: I can say where somebody comes from and ask which country.*

36.1 来 (lái) — to come

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sir, then the Mandarin for to live somewhere.

You'll want to know: 来

来 — *lái* — "to come".

> 妈妈来了 *māma lái le* — Mum's here.

The new character, in pieces: 来 — one piece built from the top down: a short bar, a dot and a short stroke under it, a long bar, a vertical through it, and two strokes spreading at the foot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

来 (*lái*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *loj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to arrive'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: lái*
- *Say it: lái*, once more
- *Say it: māma lái le* — Mum's here.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sir, then the Mandarin for to live somewhere, then say *lái* again

Before you move on

What does 来 mean? ("To come".) Say it once more.

36.2 来 — one piece, top to bottom

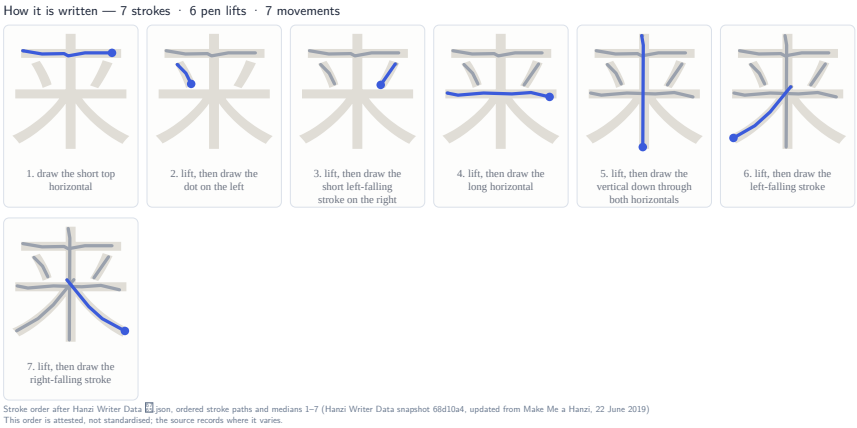
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *lái* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

大 十

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *dà*, *shí*

Script — one piece, top to bottom



How 来 is written, stroke by stroke

来

One piece, three layers, top to bottom.

The top layer, three strokes. A short horizontal. Under it, a dot on the left and a short left-falling stroke on the right, leaning in toward each other.

The middle, two strokes. A long horizontal, then the vertical through the middle of everything, from the very top, through both bars, to the foot.

The foot, two strokes. A left-falling stroke and a right-falling stroke, spreading out from the vertical like the legs of 大.

3 + 2 + 2 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 来, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many layers in 来? (**Three**.) Which comes first, the dot or the short left-falling stroke? (**The dot**.) Which character you know ends with the same two spreading strokes? (大.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 来, pinned stroke paths and medians.

36.3 Měiguó — America; the United States

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to live somewhere, then the Mandarin for to come.

You'll want to know: Měiguó

Měiguó — "America; the United States".

Měiguó hěn dà — America is huge.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Měiguó is built from měi 'beautiful' and 国 'country', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mijX* and *kwok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Měi is usually explained as standing for a syllable of the name America.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: Měiguó*
- *Say it: Měiguó*, once more
- *Say it: Měiguó hěn dà* — America is huge.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to live somewhere, then the Mandarin for to come, then say *Měiguó* again

Before you move on

What does Měiguó mean? ("America; the United States".) Say it once more.

36.4 Yīngguó — Britain; the United Kingdom

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to come, then the Mandarin for the United States.

You'll want to know: Yīngguó

Yīngguó — "Britain; the United Kingdom".

Yīngguó hěn xiǎo — Britain is quite small.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Yīngguó is built from yīng 'flower, fine' and 国 'country', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jaeng* and *kwok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Yīng is usually explained as standing for the first syllable of England.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *Yīngguó*
- *Say it:* *Yīngguó*, once more
- *Say it:* *Yīngguó hěn xiǎo* — Britain is quite small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to come, then the Mandarin for the United States, then say *Yīngguó* again

Before you move on

What does Yīngguó mean? ("Britain; the United Kingdom".) Say it once more.

36.5 Běijīng — Beijing

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the United States, then the Mandarin for the United Kingdom.

You'll want to know: Běijīng

Běijīng — "Beijing".

wǒmen lái Běijīng le — We've come to Beijing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

Běijīng is built from běi 'north' and jīng 'capital', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pok* and *kjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the northern capital.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: Běijīng*
- *Say it: Běijīng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen lái Běijīng le* — We've come to Beijing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the United States, then the Mandarin for the United Kingdom, then say *Běijīng* again

Before you move on

What does Běijīng mean? ("Beijing".) Say it once more.

36.6 nǎ — which

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the United Kingdom, then the Mandarin for Beijing.

You'll want to know: nǎ

nǎ — "which".

nǐ shì nǎ guó rén — Which country are you from?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nǎ has no older form in any dictionary we use, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǎ*
- *Say it: nǎ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ shì nǎ guó rén* — Which country are you from?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the United Kingdom, then the Mandarin for Beijing, then say *nǎ* again

Before you move on

What does nǎ mean? ("Which".) Say it once more.

36.7 Looking back: from He, She and We to Where People Come From

Say the Mandarin for she and he.

Your turn

- *Say it:* she, he, they, we, you all
- *Say it:* mum, dad, elder brother, elder sister, younger brother
- *Say it:* male, man, woman, younger sister, child
- *Say it:* to be called, you (polite), to have the family name, to know someone, friend
- *Say it:* to work, old, teacher, sir, to live somewhere
- *Say it:* to come, the United States, the United Kingdom, Beijing, which

- *Read it:* 他 们 妈 男 叫 来 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

She? (*tā.*) He? (他, *tā.*) They? (他们, *tāmen.*) We? (我们, *wǒmen.*) You all? (你们, *nǐmen.*) Mum? (妈妈, *māma.*) Dad? (*bàba.*) Elder brother? (*gēge.*) Elder sister? (*jiějie.*) Younger brother? (*dìdi.*) Male? (男, *nán.*) Man? (男人, *nánrén.*) Woman? (女人, *nǚrén.*) Younger sister? (*mèimei.*) Child? (*háizi.*) To be called? (叫, *jiào.*) You (polite)? (*nín.*) To have the family name? (*xìng.*) To know someone? (*rènshi.*) Friend? (*péngyou.*) To work? (*gōngzuò.*) Old? (*lǎo.*) Teacher? (*lǎoshī.*) Sir? (*xiānsheng.*) To live somewhere? (*zhù.*) To come? (来, *lái.*) The United States? (*Měiguó.*) The United Kingdom? (*Yīngguó.*) Beijing? (*Běijīng.*) Which? (*nǎ.*)

Chapter 37

This One and That One

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can point things out as this one, that one and which one.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 37: I can point things out as this one, that one and which one.*

37.1 这 (zhè) — this

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for Beijing, then the Mandarin for which.

You'll want to know: 这

这 — *zhè* — "this".

> 这是我的书 *zhè shì wǒ de shū* — This is my book.

The new character, in pieces: 这 — 文, from 中文, and a walking piece that runs under it from the left. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

这 (*zhè*) is written with an old character that the Guangyun records as *ngjenH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to meet'. That is a different word: *ngjenH* would not become zhè. How the character came to write the word for this is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhè*
- *Say it: zhè*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de shū* — This is my book.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for Beijing, then the Mandarin for which, then say *zhè* again

Before you move on

What does 这 mean? ("This".) Say it once more.

37.2 这 — 文, then the walking piece

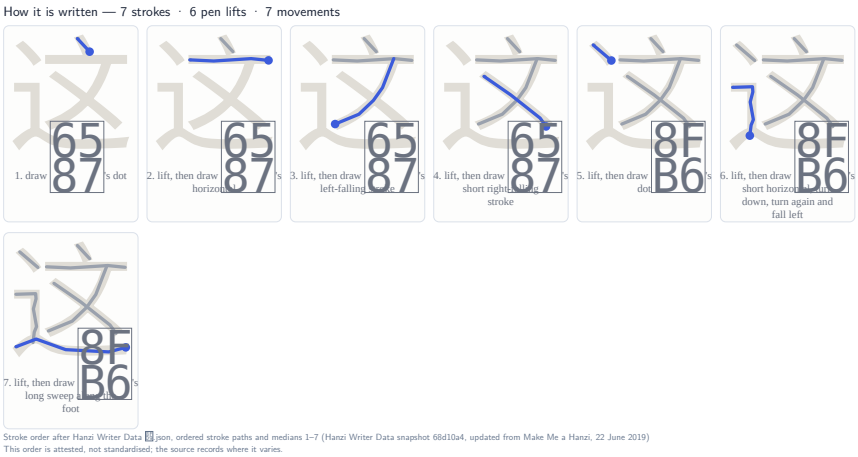
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *zhè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  文 书

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *wén*, *shū*

Script — 文, then the walking piece



How 这 *is written, stroke by stroke*

这

Two pieces, and the one underneath goes last. The walking piece wraps the bottom-left, but it is written after what it carries.

The top-right piece, 文, four strokes, as in 中文: a dot, a horizontal, a left-falling stroke and a right-falling stroke crossing it.

The walking piece, three strokes. A dot. A stroke that runs across, folds down and folds again, ending in a short fall. Then a long flat sweep along the bottom, under 文, out to the right.

4 + 3 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 这, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 这? (**Two** — 文, then the walking piece.)
Which goes first? (文, even though the walking piece is on the left.)
Which stroke is last? (**The long sweep along the bottom.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 这, pinned stroke paths and medians.

37.3 这个 (zhège) — this one

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for which, then the Mandarin for this.

You'll want to know: 这个

这个 — *zhège* — "this one".

这个人叫什么名字 *zhège rén jiào shénme míngzi* — What's this person's name?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

这个 (*zhège*) is built from 这 'this' and the measure word 个.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhège*
- *Say it: zhège*, once more
- *Say it: zhège rén jiào shénme míngzi* — What's this person's name?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for which, then the Mandarin for this, then say *zhège* again

Before you move on

What does 这个 mean? ("This one".) Say it once more.

37.4 那 (nà) — that

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for this, then the Mandarin for this one.

You'll want to know: 那

那 — *nà* — "that".

那是我的家 *nà shì wǒ de jiā* — That's my home.

The new character, in pieces: 那 — a four-stroke piece on the left, and on the right a two-stroke piece shaped like an ear. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

那 (*nà*) is an old character: the Guangyun records it as *na* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'how, what'. The sense 'that' is not given there, so how it came to mean that is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: nà*
- *Say it: nà*, once more
- *Say it: nà shì wǒ de jiā* — That's my home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for this, then the Mandarin for this one, then say *nà* again

Before you move on

What does 那 mean? ("That".) Say it once more.

37.5 那 — four strokes, then an ear

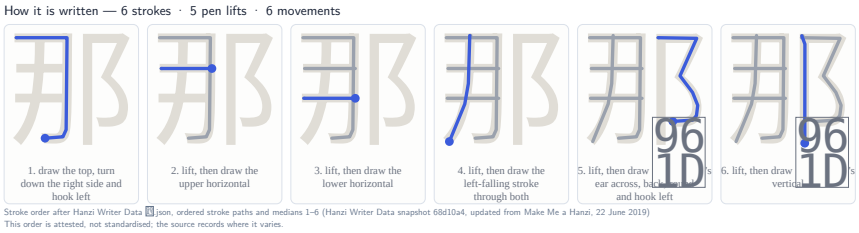
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *nà* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

这 二

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *zhè*, *èr*

Script — four strokes, then an ear



How 那 is written, stroke by stroke

那

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, four strokes. A horizontal that turns down and hooks. Two short horizontals inside it. Then a left-falling stroke from the top, down through them all.

The ear, two strokes. One stroke that runs right, loops down twice like a folded ear and hooks. Then a long vertical down its left edge.

4 + 2 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 那, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 那? (**Two** — four strokes, then the ear.) Which stroke of the left piece is last? (**The left-falling stroke through it all.**) Which is the last stroke of the character? (**The long vertical.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 那, pinned stroke paths and medians.

37.6 nǎge — which one

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for this one, then the Mandarin for that.

You'll want to know: nǎge

nǎge — "which one".

nǐ xǐhuan nǎge — Which one do you like?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nǎge is built from nǎ 'which' and the measure word 个.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǎge*
- *Say it: nǎge*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan nǎge* — Which one do you like?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for this one, then the Mandarin for that, then say *nǎge* again

Before you move on

What does nǎge mean? ("Which one".) Say it once more.

37.7 那个 (nàge) — that one

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for that, then the Mandarin for which one.

You'll want to know: 那个

那个 — *nàge* — "that one".

我喜欢那个 *wǒ xǐhuan nàge* — I like that one.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

那个 (*nàge*) is built from 那 'that' and the measure word 个.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: nàge*
- *Say it: nàge*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan nàge* — I like that one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for that, then the Mandarin for which one, then say *nàge* again

Before you move on

What does 那个 mean? ("That one".) Say it once more.

Chapter 38

Eating

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I eat and ask what somebody likes to eat.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 38: I can say what I eat and ask what somebody likes to eat.*

38.1 吃 (chī) — to eat

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for which one, then the Mandarin for that one.

You'll want to know: 吃

吃 — *chī* — "to eat".

> 你吃什么 *nǐ chī shénme* — What are you having?

The new character, in pieces: 吃 — 口, the mouth piece, on the left, and on the right three strokes: a short fall, a short bar, and one long stroke that runs across, drops and hooks up. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

吃 (*chī*) is probably inherited from Middle Chinese *khek*, which the Guangyun glosses 'to eat' and writes with a different character; there 吃 itself is *kj+t*, 'to stammer' (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

How the word and this character came together is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chī*
- *Say it: chī*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ chī shénme* — What are you having?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for which one, then the Mandarin for that one, then say *chī* again

Before you move on

What does 吃 mean? ("To eat".) Say it once more.

38.2 吃 — a mouth, then three strokes

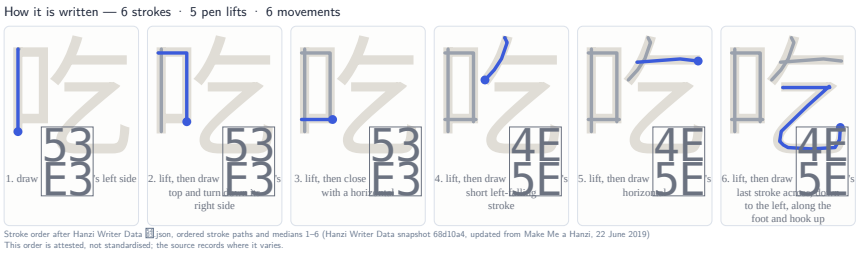
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chī* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  口 叫

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *jiào*

Script — a mouth, then three strokes



How 吃 is written, stroke by stroke

吃

Two pieces, left before right.
The left piece, 口, three strokes, small, as in 叫.
The right piece, three strokes. A short left-falling stroke. A short horizontal under it. Then one long stroke: across, down, bending right along the bottom and hooking up.
3 + 3 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 吃, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 吃? (**Two** — 口, then three strokes.) Which character from the last chapters also has a small 口 on the left? (叫.) How does the last stroke end? (**It hooks up**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 吃, pinned stroke paths and medians.

38.3 饭 (fàn) — cooked rice; meal

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for that one, then the Mandarin for to eat.

You'll want to know: 饭

饭 — *fàn* — "cooked rice; meal".

你吃饭了吗 *nǐ chī fàn le ma* — Have you eaten?

The new character, in pieces: 饭 — a three-stroke food piece on the left, and a four-stroke piece on the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

饭 (*fàn*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'cooked grain'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: fàn*
- *Say it: fàn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ chī fàn le ma* — Have you eaten?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for that one, then the Mandarin for to eat, then say *fàn* again

Before you move on

What does 饭 mean? ("Cooked rice; meal".) Say it once more.

38.4 饭 — the food piece, then four strokes

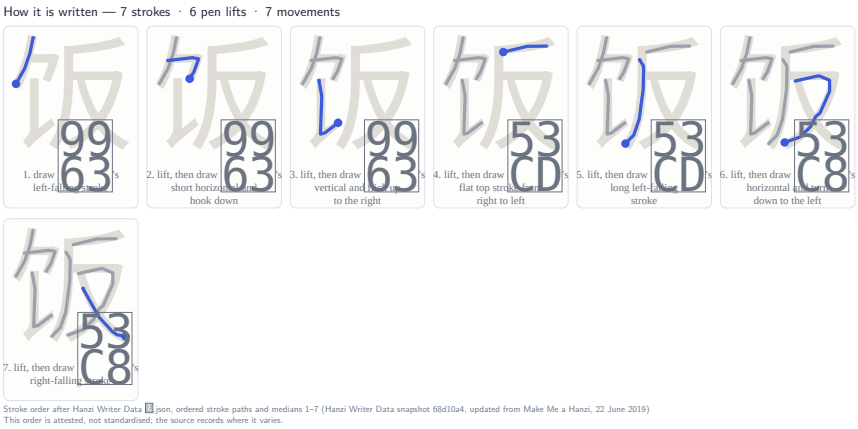
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *fàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  吃 了

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *chī*, *le*

Script — the food piece, then four strokes



How 饭 *is written, stroke by stroke*

饭

Two pieces, left before right.

The food piece, three strokes. A left-falling stroke. A short horizontal that hooks down at its end. A vertical that flicks up to the right at the foot.

The right piece, four strokes. A short left-falling stroke along the top. A long left-falling stroke down the left. A horizontal that turns and falls to the left. Then a right-falling stroke across it.

3 + 4 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 饭, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 饭? (**Two** — the food piece, then four strokes.)
How does the food piece end? (**With a vertical that flicks up**.)
Which stroke is last? (**The right-falling stroke**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 饭, pinned stroke paths and medians.

38.5 mǐfàn — cooked rice

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to eat, then the Mandarin for meal.

You'll want to know: mǐfàn

mǐfàn — "cooked rice".

wǒ xǐhuan chī mǐfàn — I like rice.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

mǐfàn is built from mǐ 'husked grain' and 饭 'cooked grain', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mejX* and *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǐfàn*
- *Say it: mǐfàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan chī mǐfàn* — I like rice.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to eat, then the Mandarin for meal, then say *mǐfàn* again

Before you move on

What does mǐfàn mean? ("Cooked rice".) Say it once more.

38.6 è — hungry

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for meal, then the Mandarin for cooked rice.

You'll want to know: è

è — "hungry".

wǒ hěn è — I'm starving.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

è is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'not full'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *è*
- *Say it:* *è*, once more
- *Say it:* *wǒ hěn è* — I'm starving.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for meal, then the Mandarin for cooked rice, then say *è* again

Before you move on

What does è mean? ("Hungry".) Say it once more.

38.7 cài — dish of food; vegetable

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cooked rice, then the Mandarin for hungry.

You'll want to know: cài

cài — "dish of food; vegetable".

nǐ xǐhuan chī shénme cài — What sort of food do you like?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cài is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as any plant that can be eaten.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: cài*
- *Say it: cài*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan chī shénme cài* — What sort of food do you like?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cooked rice, then the Mandarin for hungry, then say *cài* again

Before you move on

What does cài mean? ("Dish of food; vegetable".) Say it once more.

Chapter 39

Drinking

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I drink and ask somebody what they would like.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 39: I can say what I drink and ask somebody what they would like.*

39.1 喝 (hē) — to drink

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hungry, then the Mandarin for dish of food.

You'll want to know: 喝

喝 — *hē* — "to drink".

> 你喝什么 *nǐ hē shénme* — What would you like to drink?

The new character, in pieces: 喝 — 口 on the left; on the right 日 on top of a wrap with a small shape inside it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

喝 (*hē*) is an old character: the Guangyun records it as *xat* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to shout at'. The sense 'to drink' is not given there, so how it came to mean drink is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: hē*
- *Say it: hē*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ hē shénme* — What would you like to drink?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hungry, then the Mandarin for dish of food, then say *hē* again

Before you move on

What does 喝 mean? ("To drink".) Say it once more.

39.2 喝 — a mouth, a sun and a wrap

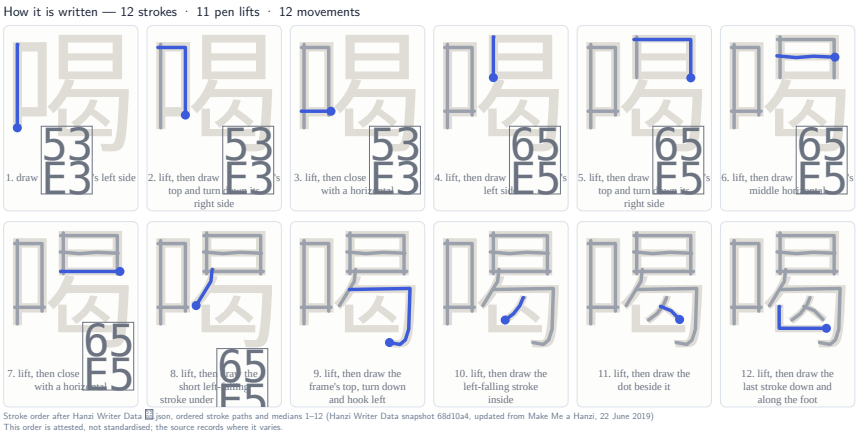
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *hē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

口 日 吃

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *rì*, *chī*

Script — a mouth, a sun and a wrap



How 喝 *is written, stroke by stroke*

喝

Three pieces: 口 on the left, then 日, then the wrap under it. Do not count to twelve; count three.

口, three strokes, small, as in 吃.

日, four strokes, short and wide, at the top right.

The wrap, five strokes. A short left-falling stroke. A horizontal that turns down and hooks, making a roof. Inside it, a small left-falling stroke and a dot. Then a corner stroke, down and along, closing them in.

3 + 4 + 5 = twelve, and the first seven are two shapes you know.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 喝, all twelve, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 喝? (**Three** — 口, 日, and the wrap.) How many strokes before the wrap starts? (**Seven**.) What goes inside the wrap? (**A small left-falling stroke and a dot**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 喝, pinned stroke paths and medians.

39.3 水 (shuǐ) — water

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dish of food, then the Mandarin for to drink.

You'll want to know: 水

水 — *shuǐ* — "water".

我喜欢喝水 *wǒ xǐhuan hē shuǐ* — I like drinking water.

The new character, in pieces: 水 — a hooked vertical down the middle, one stroke on its left that runs across and falls away, and two strokes on its right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

水 (*shuǐ*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *sywijX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as one of the five elements, the one of the north, and as 'level'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuǐ*
- *Say it: shuǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan hē shuǐ* — I like drinking water.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dish of food, then the Mandarin for to drink, then say *shuǐ* again

Before you move on

What does 水 mean? ("Water".) Say it once more.

39.4 水 — the middle first, then the sides

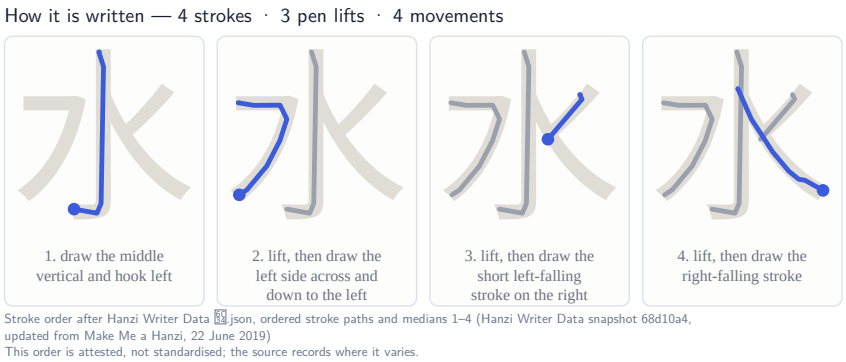
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shuǐ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

小 喝

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *xiǎo*, *hē*

Script — the middle first, then the sides



How 水 *is written, stroke by stroke*

水

One piece: the middle, then left, then right.

The middle, one stroke. A long vertical that hooks to the left at the foot, as in 小.

The left side, one stroke. A short horizontal that turns and falls away to the lower left.

The right side, two strokes. A short left-falling stroke toward the middle, then a long right-falling stroke out to the lower right.

1 + 1 + 2 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 水, all four, with the model in front of you

- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which stroke of 水 comes first? (**The hooked vertical down the middle.**) Which character you know also starts in the middle? (小.) How many strokes on the right? (**Two.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 水, pinned stroke paths and medians.

39.5 kě — thirsty

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to drink, then the Mandarin for water.

You'll want to know: kě

kě — "thirsty".

nǐ kě ma — Are you thirsty?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kě is inherited from Middle Chinese *khat* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'hunger and thirst'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: kě*
- *Say it: kě*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ kě ma* — Are you thirsty?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to drink, then the Mandarin for water, then say *kě* again

Before you move on

What does kě mean? (“Thirsty”.) Say it once more.

39.6 niúnǎi — milk

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for water, then the Mandarin for thirsty.

You’ll want to know: niúnǎi

niúnǎi — “milk”.

háizi xǐhuan hē niúnǎi — Children like milk.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

niúnǎi is built from niú ’cattle’ and nǎi ’milk’. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngjuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’a large beast’. The second is probably the word the Guangyun records as *nreaX*, glossed ’milk’, under another way of writing the character.

What you’ve built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: niúnǎi*
- *Say it: niúnǎi*, once more
- *Say it: háizi xǐhuan hē niúnǎi* — Children like milk.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for water, then the Mandarin for thirsty, then say *niúnǎi* again

Before you move on

What does niúnǎi mean? ("Milk".) Say it once more.

39.7 chá — tea

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for thirsty, then the Mandarin for milk.

You'll want to know: chá

chá — "tea".

nǐ hē chá ma — Would you like some tea?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chá is inherited from Middle Chinese *drae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as leaves gathered in spring and made into a drink.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chá*
- *Say it: chá*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ hē chá ma* — Would you like some tea?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for thirsty, then the Mandarin for milk, then say *chá* again

Before you move on

What does chá mean? ("Tea".) Say it once more.

Chapter 40

Fruit, Bread and Eggs

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I buy and name fruit, bread and eggs.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 40: I can say what I buy and name fruit, bread and eggs.*

40.1 买 (mǎi) — to buy

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for milk, then the Mandarin for tea.

You'll want to know: 买

买 — *mǎi* — "to buy".

你们买水吗 *nǐmen mǎi shuǐ ma* — Are you buying water?

The new character, in pieces: 买 — a lid with two dots under it, and below them a shape like 大 with its last stroke cut down to a dot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

买 (*mǎi*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *meaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to trade at market'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǎi*
- *Say it: mǎi*, once more
- *Say it: nǐmen mǎi shuǐ ma* — Are you buying water?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for milk, then the Mandarin for tea, then say *mǎi* again

Before you move on

What does 买 mean? ("To buy".) Say it once more.

40.2 买 — a lid, two dots, and a cut-down 大

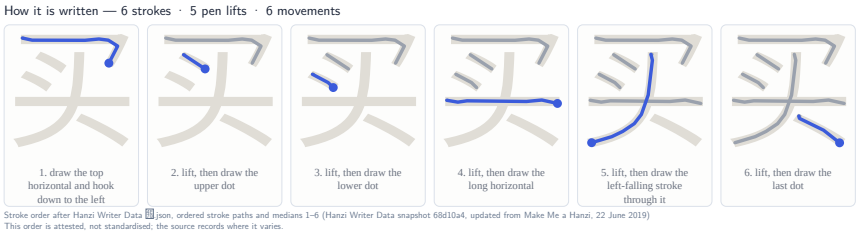
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *mǎi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

大 水

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *dà*, *shuǐ*

Script — a lid, two dots, and a cut-down 大



How 买 is written, stroke by stroke

买

Two pieces, top before bottom.

The top piece, three strokes. A horizontal that hooks down at its right end, like a lid. Then two dots under it, one above the other.

The bottom piece, three strokes. A long horizontal, a left-falling stroke through it, and a dot on the right. It is 大 with its last stroke cut down to a dot.

3 + 3 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 买, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 买? (**Two** — the lid with its dots, then the cut-down 大.) What is under the lid? (**Two dots**.) What is the last stroke? (**A dot**, where 大 has a long fall.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 买, pinned stroke paths and medians.

40.3 píngguǒ — apple

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for tea, then the Mandarin for to buy.

You'll want to know: píngguǒ

píngguǒ — "apple".

wǒ mǎi le sān ge píngguǒ — I bought three apples.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

píngguǒ is built from píng and guǒ 'fruit'. Guǒ is inherited from Middle Chinese *kwaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'fruit of a tree'; the first character is listed there as *bjaeng*, a name for

several plants, duckweed among them, and how it came to name the apple is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: píngguǒ*
- *Say it: píngguǒ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ mǎi le sān ge píngguǒ* — I bought three apples.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for tea, then the Mandarin for to buy, then say *píngguǒ* again

Before you move on

What does píngguǒ mean? ("Apple".) Say it once more.

40.4 shuǐguǒ — fruit

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to buy, then the Mandarin for apple.

You'll want to know: shuǐguǒ

shuǐguǒ — "fruit".

wǒ xǐhuan chī shuǐguǒ — I like fruit.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

Tone: *shuǐguǒ* is two third tones in a row, so *shuǐ* rises and only *guǒ* keeps the dip. The spelling does not show the change; your voice makes it.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuǐguǒ is built from 水 'water' and guǒ 'fruit', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sywijX* and *kwaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuǐguǒ*
- *Say it: shuǐguǒ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan chī shuǐguǒ* — I like fruit.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to buy, then the Mandarin for apple, then say *shuǐguǒ* again

Before you move on

What does shuǐguǒ mean? ("Fruit".) Say it once more.

40.5 miànbāo — bread

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for apple, then the Mandarin for fruit.

You'll want to know: miànbāo

miànbāo — "bread".

wǒ chī le yí ge miànbāo — I had a bread roll.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

miànbāo is built from miàn 'flour' and bāo 'to wrap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *menH* and *paew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: miànbāo*
- *Say it: miànbāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ chī le yí ge miànbāo* — I had a bread roll.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for apple, then the Mandarin for fruit, then say *miànbāo* again

Before you move on

What does miànbāo mean? ("Bread".) Say it once more.

40.6 jīdàn — egg

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for fruit, then the Mandarin for bread.

You'll want to know: jīdàn

jīdàn — "egg".

tā xǐhuan chī jīdàn — He likes eggs.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jīdàn is built from jī 'chicken' and dàn 'egg'. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *kej* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary calls the animal that knows the hour; no dictionary we use records an older form of the second, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: jīdàn*
- *Say it: jīdàn*, once more
- *Say it: tā xǐhuan chī jīdàn* — He likes eggs.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for fruit, then the Mandarin for bread, then say *jīdàn* again

Before you move on

What does jīdàn mean? ("Egg".) Say it once more.

Chapter 41

Paying

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask how much something costs and say how much I want.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 41: I can ask how much something costs and say how much I want.*

41.1 多少 (duōshao) — how much; how many

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bread, then the Mandarin for egg.

You'll want to know: 多少

多少 — *duōshao* — "how much; how many".

> 你买了多少 *nǐ mǎi le duōshao* — How many did you buy?

The new character, in pieces: 多 — one three-stroke piece twice, one above the other; 少 — 小, the small piece, without its hook, and one long sweep below it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

多少 (*duōshao*) is built from 多 'many' and 少 'few', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ta* and *syewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): many-few, asked as a question.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: duōshao*
- *Say it: duōshao*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ mǎi le duōshao* — How many did you buy?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bread, then the Mandarin for egg, then say *duōshao* again

Before you move on

What does 多少 mean? ("How much; how many".) Say it once more.

41.2 多 — the same three strokes, twice

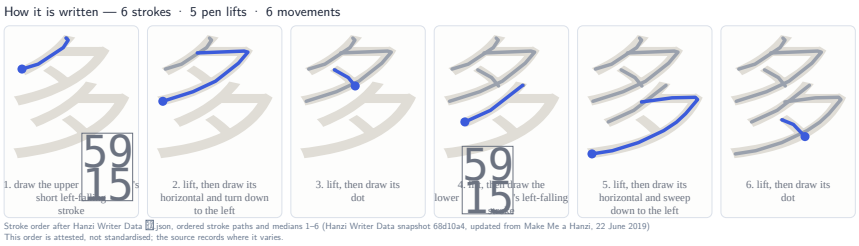
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *duōshao* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

了 买

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *le*, *mǎi*

Script — the same three strokes, twice



How 多 is written, stroke by stroke

多

One shape, twice: top, then bottom.

The shape, three strokes. A short left-falling stroke. A horizontal that turns and falls to the lower left. A dot inside the turn.

Make it again below, a little larger and a little to the right, so the two lean together.

3 + 3 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 多, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in one half of 多? (**Three**.) Which half is larger? (**The lower one**.) Where does the dot go? (**Inside the turn**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 多, pinned stroke paths and medians.

41.3 少 — 小 without its hook, and a sweep

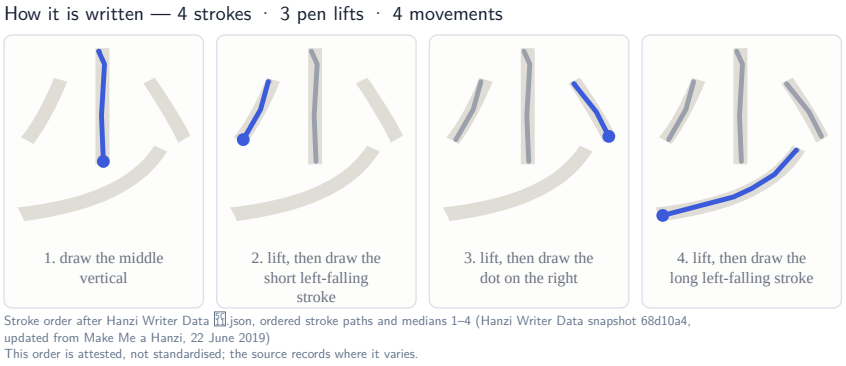
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *duōshao* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

小 买

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *xiǎo*, *mǎi*

Script — 小 without its hook, and a sweep



How 少 is written, stroke by stroke

少

One piece, built on 小.

Three strokes like 小. A vertical down the middle, but this time with no hook at the foot. A short stroke falling to the left. A dot on the right.

One more stroke. A long left-falling sweep from the right, under the vertical.

3 + 1 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 少, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which character you know is inside 少? (小.) What does the middle vertical lose? (**Its hook**.) Which stroke is last? (**The long sweep to the left**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 少, pinned stroke paths and medians.

41.4 qián — money

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for egg, then the Mandarin for how much.

You'll want to know: qián

qián — "money".

zhège duōshao qián — How much is this one?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qián is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzjen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'coin'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: qián*
- *Say it: qián*, once more
- *Say it: zhège duōshao qián* — How much is this one?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for egg, then the Mandarin for how much, then say *qián* again

Before you move on

What does qián mean? ("Money".) Say it once more.

41.5 kuài — yuan; lump

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for how much, then the Mandarin for money.

You'll want to know: kuài

kuài — "yuan; lump".

> *nàge shí kuài qián* — That one is ten yuan.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

kuài is the spoken word for the yuan: a price is a number, then *kuài*, then *qián*, which can be left off.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kuài is inherited from Middle Chinese *khwojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a clod of earth'. Its use for counting money is not given there, so how it took that job is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: kuài*
- *Say it: kuài*, once more
- *Say it: nàge shí kuài qián* — That one is ten yuan.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for how much, then the Mandarin for money, then say *kuài* again

Before you move on

What does kuài mean? ("Yuan; lump".) Say it once more.

41.6 tài — too; too much

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for money, then the Mandarin for yuan.

You'll want to know: tài

tài — "too; too much".

tài xiǎo le — That's too small.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
tài usually brings a *le* at the end of the sentence with it: *tài xiǎo le*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tài is inherited from Middle Chinese *thajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'extreme' and 'great'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: tài*
- *Say it: tài*, once more
- *Say it: tài xiǎo le* — That's too small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for money, then the Mandarin for yuan, then say *tài* again

Before you move on

What does tài mean? ("Too; too much".) Say it once more.

41.7 yào — to want; to ask for

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for yuan, then the Mandarin for too.

You'll want to know: yào

yào — "to want; to ask for".

nǐ yào duōshao — How many would you like?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yào is inherited from Middle Chinese *'jiewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to bind by agreement'. The sense 'to want' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: yào*
- *Say it: yào*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yào duōshao* — How many would you like?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for yuan, then the Mandarin for too, then say *yào* again

Before you move on

What does yào mean? ("To want; to ask for".) Say it once more.

Chapter 42

In the Shop

Modes: **voice** (6) **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what a shop sells and whether it is cheap or dear.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 42: I can say what a shop sells and whether it is cheap or dear.*

42.1 dōngxi — thing; things

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for too, then the Mandarin for to want.

You'll want to know: dōngxi

dōngxi — "thing; things".

> *nǐ mǎi shénme dōngxi* — What are you buying?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dōngxi is built from dōng 'east' and xī 'west', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tuwng* and *sej* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How east-and-west came to mean a thing is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: dōngxi*
- *Say it: dōngxi*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ mǎi shénme dōngxi* — What are you buying?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for too, then the Mandarin for to want, then say *dōngxi* again

Before you move on

What does dōngxi mean? ("Thing; things".) Say it once more.

42.2 mài — to sell

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to want, then the Mandarin for thing.

You'll want to know: mài

mài — "to sell".

tāmen mài shénme — What do they sell?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

mài is inherited from Middle Chinese *meaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to put goods out'. It differs from the word for buy only in its tone.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: mài*
- *Say it: mài*, once more
- *Say it: tāmen mài shénme* — What do they sell?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to want, then the Mandarin for thing, then say *mài* again

Before you move on

What does mài mean? ("To sell".) Say it once more.

42.3 shāngdiàn — shop

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for thing, then the Mandarin for to sell.

You'll want to know: shāngdiàn

shāngdiàn — "shop".

zhège shāngdiàn hěn xiǎo — This shop is tiny.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shāngdiàn is built from shāng, usually explained as 'trade', and diàn 'shop', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *syang* and *temH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary explains the second as a place where goods are kept and sold.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: shāngdiàn*
- *Say it: shāngdiàn*, once more
- *Say it: zhège shāngdiàn hěn xiǎo* — This shop is tiny.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for thing, then the Mandarin for to sell, then say *shāngdiàn* again

Before you move on

What does shāngdiàn mean? ("Shop".) Say it once more.

42.4 piányi — cheap

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to sell, then the Mandarin for shop.

You'll want to know: piányi

piányi — "cheap".

zhège hěn piányi — This one's cheap.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

piányi is built from two old words, both inherited from Middle Chinese: *bjien* 'at ease' and *ngje* 'fitting' (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The sense 'cheap' is not given there, so how the pair came to mean it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: piányi*
- *Say it: piányi*, once more
- *Say it: zhège hěn piányi* — This one's cheap.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to sell, then the Mandarin for shop, then say *piányi* again

Before you move on

What does piányi mean? ("Cheap".) Say it once more.

42.5 guì — expensive

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for shop, then the Mandarin for cheap.

You'll want to know: guì

guì — "expensive".

nàge tài guì le — That one's too expensive.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guì is inherited from Middle Chinese *kjw+jH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'honoured, high'. The price sense is not given there; from valued to costly is a likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: guì*
- *Say it: guì*, once more

- *Say it: nàge tài guì le* — That one's too expensive.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for shop, then the Mandarin for cheap, then say *guì* again

Before you move on

What does guì mean? ("Expensive".) Say it once more.

42.6 Looking back: from This One and That One to In the Shop

Say the Mandarin for this and this one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* this, this one, that, which one, that one
- *Say it:* to eat, meal, cooked rice, hungry, dish of food
- *Say it:* to drink, water, thirsty, milk, tea
- *Say it:* to buy, apple, fruit, bread, egg
- *Say it:* how much, money, yuan, too, to want
- *Say it:* thing, to sell, shop, cheap, expensive
- *Read it:* 这 那 吃 饭 喝 水 买 多 少 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

This? (这, *zhè.*) This one? (这个, *zhège.*) That? (那, *nà.*) Which one? (*nǎge.*) That one? (那个, *nàge.*) To eat? (吃, *chī.*) Meal? (饭, *fàn.*) Cooked rice? (*mǐfàn.*) Hungry? (*è.*) Dish of food? (*cài.*) To drink? (喝, *hē.*) Water? (水, *shuǐ.*) Thirsty? (*kě.*) Milk? (*niúnǎi.*) Tea? (*chá.*) To buy? (买, *mǎi.*) Apple? (*píngguǒ.*) Fruit? (*shuǐguǒ.*) Bread? (*miànbāo.*) Egg? (*jīdàn.*) How much? (多少, *duōshao.*) Money? (*qián.*) Yuan? (*kuài.*) Too? (*tài.*) To want? (*yào.*) Thing? (*dōngxi.*) To sell? (*mài.*) Shop? (*shāngdiàn.*) Cheap? (*piányi.*) Expensive? (*guì.*)

Chapter 43

Coming and Going

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say where I am going and that I am going home.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 43: I can say where I am going and that I am going home.*

43.1 去 (qù) — to go

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cheap, then the Mandarin for expensive.

You'll want to know: 去

去 — *qù* — "to go".

我去大学 *wǒ qù dàxué* — I'm going to the university.

The new character, in pieces: 去 — a shape like 十 standing on a long bar, and under it a two-stroke piece. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

去 (*qù*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *khjoH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to leave'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: qù*
- *Say it: qù*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù dàxué* — I'm going to the university.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cheap, then the Mandarin for expensive, then say *qù* again

Before you move on

What does 去 mean? ("To go".) Say it once more.

43.2 去 — a cross on a bar, and a corner below

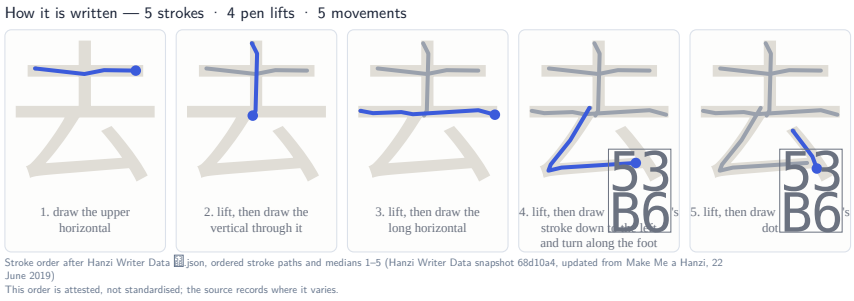
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *qù* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

十 大

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shí*, *dà*

Script — a cross on a bar, and a corner below



How 去 is written, stroke by stroke

去

Two pieces, top before bottom.

The top piece, three strokes. A short horizontal, a vertical through it, then a long horizontal under them: 十 standing on a wide base.

The bottom piece, two strokes. A stroke that falls to the left and turns out to the right, then a dot inside the turn.

3 + 2 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 去, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 去? (**Two**.) Which character you know is in the top piece? (十, on a long bar.) What is the last stroke? (**A dot**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 去, pinned stroke paths and medians.

43.3 huí — to go back; to return

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for expensive, then the Mandarin for to go.

You'll want to know: huí

huí — "to go back; to return".

wǒ huí jiā — I'm going home.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huí is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to turn'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: huí*
- *Say it: huí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ huí jiā* — I'm going home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for expensive, then the Mandarin for to go, then say *huí* again

Before you move on

What does huí mean? ("To go back; to return".) Say it once more.

43.4 zǒu — to walk; to leave

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go, then the Mandarin for to go back.

You'll want to know: zǒu

zǒu — "to walk; to leave".

wǒ zǒu le — I'm off.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zǒu is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to hurry'. The sense 'to walk' is not given there, so when it arrived is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zǒu*
- *Say it: zǒu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zǒu le* — I'm off.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go, then the Mandarin for to go back, then say *zǒu* again

Before you move on

What does zǒu mean? ("To walk; to leave".) Say it once more.

43.5 chūmén — to go out

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go back, then the Mandarin for to walk.

You'll want to know: chūmén

chūmén — "to go out".

māma chūmén le — Mum's gone out.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chūmén is built from chū 'to come forth' and mén 'door', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhwit* and *mwon* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chūmén*
- *Say it: chūmén*, once more

- *Say it: māma chūmén le* — Mum's gone out.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go back, then the Mandarin for to walk, then say *chūmén* again

Before you move on

What does chūmén mean? ("To go out".) Say it once more.

43.6 xuéxiào — school

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to walk, then the Mandarin for to go out.

You'll want to know: xuéxiào

xuéxiào — "school".

wǒmen qù xuéxiào — We're off to school.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xuéxiào is built from 学 'learning', inherited from Middle Chinese *haewk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and a second character the dictionary records as *haewH*, the title of an officer. The school sense is not given there, so how it came to mean school is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xuéxiào*
- *Say it: xuéxiào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen qù xuéxiào* — We're off to school.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to walk, then the Mandarin for to go out, then say *xuéxiào* again

Before you move on

What does xuéxiào mean? (“School”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 44

Places in Town

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name places in town and say how I get there.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 44: I can name places in town and say how I get there.*

44.1 车 (chē) — car; vehicle

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go out, then the Mandarin for school.

You'll want to know: 车

车 — *chē* — "car; vehicle".

> 你有车吗 *nǐ yǒu chē ma* — Have you got a car?

The new character, in pieces: 车 — four strokes: a bar, a stroke that falls and turns, a long bar, and a vertical through them. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

车 (*chē*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as a cart, first made, it says, by the Yellow Emperor.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chē*
- *Say it: chē*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yǒu chē ma* — Have you got a car?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go out, then the Mandarin for school, then say *chē* again

Before you move on

What does 车 mean? ("Car; vehicle".) Say it once more.

44.2 车 — four strokes, the vertical last

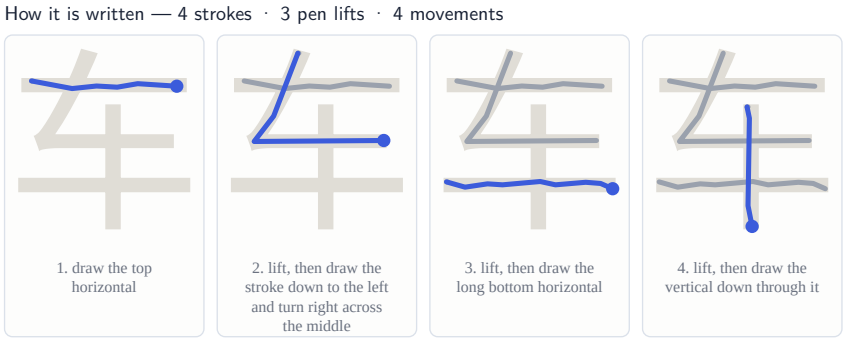
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

十 去

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shí*, *qù*

Script — four strokes, the vertical last



How 车 *is written, stroke by stroke*

车

One piece, four strokes.

A short horizontal at the top.

A stroke that falls to the left and turns right, along under the first bar.

A long horizontal across the bottom.

Last, the vertical, from the top bar down through everything to the foot.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 车, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 车? (**Four**.) Which stroke is last? (**The vertical**.) Which is the longest bar? (**The third stroke, along the bottom**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 车, pinned stroke paths and medians.

44.3 fàndiàn — restaurant

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for school, then the Mandarin for car.

You'll want to know: fàndiàn

fàndiàn — "restaurant".

wǒmen qù fàndiàn chī fàn — We're going out to a restaurant.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fàndiàn is built from 饭 'meal' and diàn 'shop', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjonH* and *temH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: fàndiàn*
- *Say it: fàndiàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen qù fàndiàn chī fàn* — We're going out to a restaurant.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for school, then the Mandarin for car, then say *fàndiàn* again

Before you move on

What does fàndiàn mean? ("Restaurant".) Say it once more.

44.4 yīyuàn — hospital

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for car, then the Mandarin for restaurant.

You'll want to know: yīyuàn

yīyuàn — "hospital".

wǒ māma qù yīyuàn le — My mum has gone to the hospital.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yīyuàn is built from yī 'healing' and yuàn 'courtyard', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'i* and *hjwenH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīyuàn*
- *Say it: yīyuàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma qù yīyuàn le* — My mum has gone to the hospital.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for car, then the Mandarin for restaurant, then say *yīyuàn* again

Before you move on

What does yīyuàn mean? ("Hospital".) Say it once more.

44.5 zuò — to sit; to travel by

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for restaurant, then the Mandarin for hospital.

You'll want to know: zuò

zuò — "to sit; to travel by".

wǒmen zuò chē qù — We're going by car.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zuò is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzwaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as bending the joints. Its use for travelling by car or bus is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuò*
- *Say it: zuò*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen zuò chē qù* — We're going by car.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for restaurant, then the Mandarin for hospital, then say *zuò* again

Before you move on

What does zuò mean? ("To sit; to travel by".) Say it once more.

44.6 chūzūchē — taxi

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hospital, then the Mandarin for to sit.

You'll want to know: chūzūchē

chūzūchē — "taxi".

chūzūchē hěn guì — Taxis are expensive.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chūzūchē is built from chūzū 'to rent out' and 车 'car'; its parts are inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyhwit*, *tsu* 'tax' and *tsyhae*

(Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chūzūchē*
- *Say it: chūzūchē*, once more
- *Say it: chūzūchē hěn guì* — Taxis are expensive.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hospital, then the Mandarin for to sit, then say *chūzūchē* again

Before you move on

What does chūzūchē mean? ("Taxi".) Say it once more.

Chapter 45

Today and Tomorrow

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say today, yesterday, tomorrow and now.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 45: I can say today, yesterday, tomorrow and now.*

45.1 天 (tiān) — day; sky

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to sit, then the Mandarin for taxi.

You'll want to know: 天

天 — *tiān* — "day; sky".

> 那天我们去大学了 *nà tiān wǒmen qù dàxué le* — That day we went to the university.

The new character, in pieces: 天 — 一 above 大: one more bar over the big piece. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

天 (*tiān*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the highest, with nothing above it', the sky. Its use for a day is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: tiān*
- *Say it: tiān*, once more
- *Say it: nà tiān wǒmen qù dàxué le* — That day we went to the university.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to sit, then the Mandarin for taxi, then say *tiān* again

Before you move on

What does 天 mean? ("Day; sky".) Say it once more.

45.2 天 — one more bar over 大

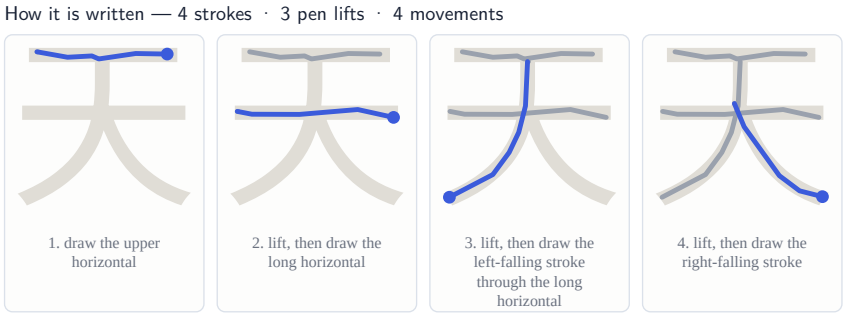
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *tiān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

一 大

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *yī*, *dà*

Script — one more bar over 大



How 天 is written, stroke by stroke

天

Two pieces your hand knows, top to bottom: 一, then 大.
一, one stroke, a short horizontal at the top.
大, three strokes: a longer horizontal, a left-falling stroke from above it, and a right-falling stroke.
1 + 3 = four. Keep the top bar shorter than the one under it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 天, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which two characters you know make 天? (**一 and 大.**) Which bar is longer? (**The lower one.**) How many strokes? (**Four.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 天, pinned stroke paths and medians.

45.3 今天 (jīntiān) — today

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for taxi, then the Mandarin for day.

You'll want to know: 今天

今天 — *jīntiān* — "today".

你们今天去吗 *nǐmen jīntiān qù ma* — Are you going today?

The new character, in pieces: 今 — 人 as a roof, a dot under it, and a stroke that runs across and turns down. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

今天 (*jīntiān*) is built from 今 'now' and 天 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kim* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses *kim* as the opposite of olden times.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: jīntiān*
- *Say it: jīntiān*, once more
- *Say it: nǐmen jīntiān qù ma* — Are you going today?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for taxi, then the Mandarin for day, then say *jīntiān* again

Before you move on

What does 今天 mean? ("Today".) Say it once more.

45.4 今 — a roof, a dot and a turn

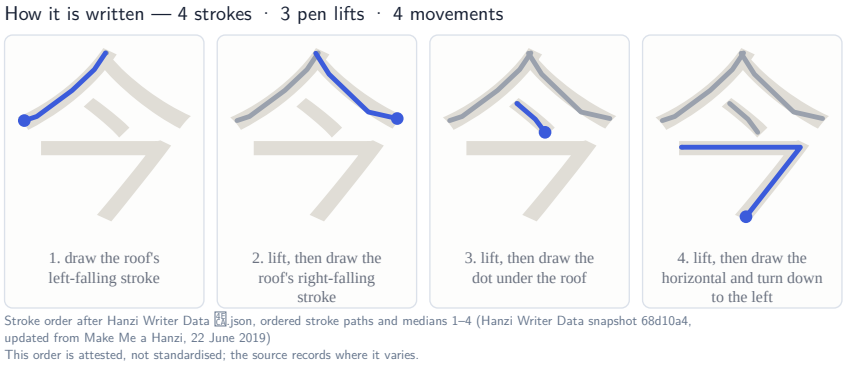
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *jīntiān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

人 个

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, *gè*

Script — a roof, a dot and a turn



How 今 is written, stroke by stroke

今

Top to bottom.

The roof, 人, two strokes, spread wide: a left-falling stroke, then a right-falling stroke, as in 个.

A dot in the middle, under the roof.

A stroke that runs across and turns down to the left, under the dot.

2 + 1 + 1 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 今, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which character you know is the roof of 今? (人.) Which other character has the same roof? (个.) What comes right after the roof? (**A dot**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 今, pinned stroke paths and medians.

45.5 zuótiān — yesterday

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for day, then the Mandarin for today.

You'll want to know: zuótiān

zuótiān — "yesterday".

zuótiān wǒ hěn lèi — I was really tired yesterday.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zuótiān is built from zuó 'the day before' and 天 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzak* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses *dzak* as the day one night back.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuótiān*
- *Say it: zuótiān*, once more
- *Say it: zuótiān wǒ hěn lèi* — I was really tired yesterday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for day, then the Mandarin for today, then say *zuótiān* again

Before you move on

What does zuótiān mean? ("Yesterday".) Say it once more.

45.6 xiànzài — now

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for today, then the Mandarin for yesterday.

You'll want to know: xiànzài

xiànzài — "now".

> *nǐ xiànzài máng ma* — Are you busy right now?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiànzài is built from xiàn 'to appear' and zài 'to be present', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *henH* and *dzojX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiànzài*
- *Say it: xiànzài*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xiànzài máng ma* — Are you busy right now?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for today, then the Mandarin for yesterday, then say *xiànzài* again

Before you move on

What does xiànzài mean? ("Now".) Say it once more.

45.7 míngtiān — tomorrow

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for yesterday, then the Mandarin for now.

You'll want to know: míngtiān

míngtiān — "tomorrow".

wǒ jīntiān hěn máng, míngtiān bù máng — I'm busy today, but not tomorrow.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

míngtiān is built from míng 'bright' and 天 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mjaeng* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: míngtiān*
- *Say it: míngtiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jīntiān hěn máng, míngtiān bù máng* — I'm busy today, but not tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for yesterday, then the Mandarin for now, then say *míngtiān* again

Before you move on

What does míngtiān mean? ("Tomorrow".) Say it once more.

Chapter 46

The Week

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the week, Monday, Sunday and the weekend.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 46: I can name the week, Monday, Sunday and the weekend.*

46.1 星期 (xīngqī) — week

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for now, then the Mandarin for tomorrow.

You'll want to know: 星期

星期 — *xīngqī* — "week".

> 一个星期有七天 *yí ge xīngqī yǒu qī tiān* — There are seven days in a week.

The new character, in pieces: 星 — 日 above 生; 期 — an eight-stroke piece on the left and a moon piece on the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

星期 (*xīngqī*) is built from 星 'star' and 期 'appointed time', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *seng* and *gi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription). How the pair came to mean a week is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīngqī*
- *Say it: xīngqī*, once more
- *Say it: yí ge xīngqī yǒu qī tiān* — There are seven days in a week.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for now, then the Mandarin for tomorrow, then say *xīngqī* again

Before you move on

What does 星期 mean? ("Week".) Say it once more.

46.2 星 — 日 above 生

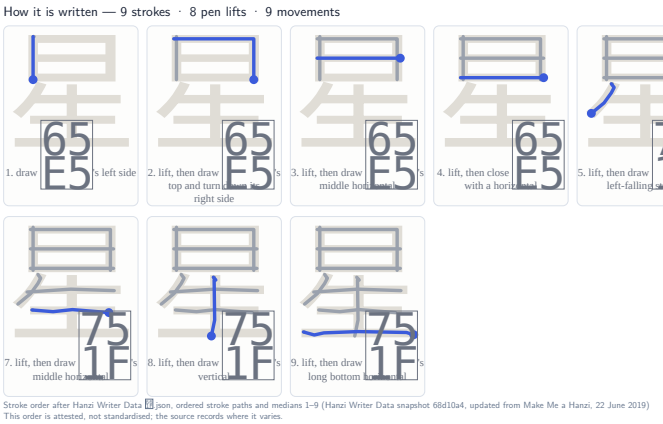
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xīngqī* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

日 生

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *shēng*

Script — 日 above 生



How 星 *is written, stroke by stroke*

星

Two pieces you know, top to bottom: 日, then 生.

日, four strokes, short and wide on top.

生, five strokes, as in 学生: a left-falling stroke, a horizontal, a shorter horizontal, the vertical through them, and the long bar at the foot.

4 + 5 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 星, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which two characters you know make 星? (日 **and** 生.) Which is on top? (日.) Which stroke of 生 is last? (**The long bar at the foot**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 星, pinned stroke paths and medians.

46.3 期 — eight strokes, then the moon

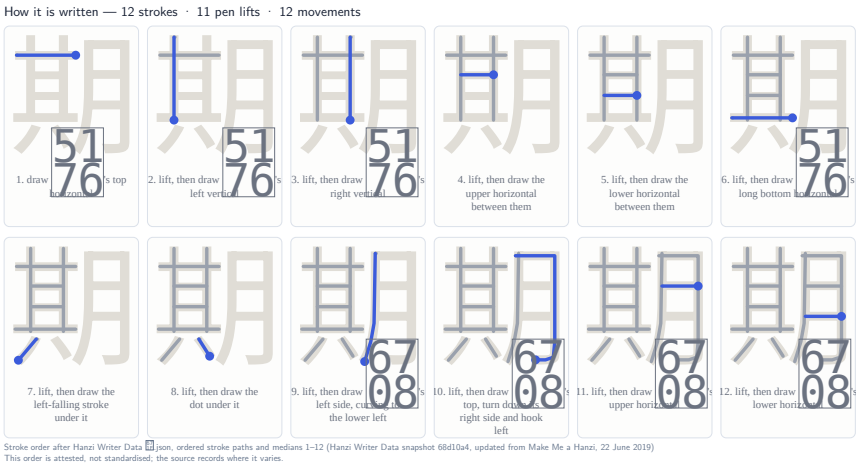
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xīngqī* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  有 日

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *yǒu*, *rì*

Script — eight strokes, then the moon



How 期 *is written, stroke by stroke*

期

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, eight strokes. A horizontal at the top. Two verticals down through it. Two short horizontals between them. A long horizontal across the foot. Then a left-falling stroke and a dot under it.

The moon, four strokes. A left-falling stroke down the left. A horizontal that turns down the right and hooks. Two short horizontals inside. It is the lower part of 有.

8 + 4 = twelve.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 期, all twelve, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 期? (**Two** — eight strokes, then the moon.) What is under the long bar of the left piece? (**A left-falling stroke and a dot**.) How does the moon begin? (**With a left-falling stroke**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 期, pinned stroke paths and medians.

46.4 星期一 (xīngqīyī) — Monday

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for tomorrow, then the Mandarin for week.

You'll want to know: 星期一

星期一 — *xīngqīyī* — "Monday".

今天星期一 *jīntiān xīngqīyī* — Today's Monday.

Tone: 一 keeps its first tone here, *yī*. It counts a day in order, and the change you know from *yìbǎi* does not apply.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

星期一 (*xīngqīyī*) is built from 星期 'week' and 一 'one': day one of the week.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīngqīyī*
- *Say it: xīngqīyī*, once more

- *Say it: jīntiān xīngqīyī* — Today's Monday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for tomorrow, then the Mandarin for week, then say *xīngqīyī* again

Before you move on

What does 星期一 mean? ("Monday".) Say it once more.

46.5 shíhou — time; moment

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for week, then the Mandarin for Monday.

You'll want to know: shíhou

shíhou — "time; moment".

nǐ shénme shíhou qù — When are you going?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shíhou is built from shí 'time' and hou 'to wait for', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyi* and *huwH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: shíhou*
- *Say it: shíhou*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ shénme shíhou qù* — When are you going?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for week, then the Mandarin for Monday, then say *shíhou* again

Before you move on

What does shíhou mean? ("Time; moment".) Say it once more.

46.6 zhōumò — weekend

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for Monday, then the Mandarin for moment.

You'll want to know: zhōumò

zhōumò — "weekend".

zhōumò wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū — At the weekend I like to read.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhōumò is built from zhōu 'week' and mò 'end'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *mat* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the tip of a tree' and 'end'. The first character is recorded there as *tsyuw*, 'a full circuit'; the sense week is not given, so how it came to name the week is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhōumò*
- *Say it: zhōumò*, once more
- *Say it: zhōumò wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū* — At the weekend I like to read.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for Monday, then the Mandarin for moment, then say *zhōumò* again

Before you move on

What does zhōumò mean? ("Weekend".) Say it once more.

46.7 星期天 (xīngqītiān) — Sunday

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for moment, then the Mandarin for weekend.

You'll want to know: 星期天

星期天 — *xīngqītiān* — "Sunday".

我喜欢星期天 *wǒ xǐhuan xīngqītiān* — Sunday is the day I like best.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

星期天 (*xīngqītiān*) is built from 星期 'week' and 天 'day'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīngqītiān*
- *Say it: xīngqītiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan xīngqītiān* — Sunday is the day I like best.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for moment, then the Mandarin for weekend, then say *xīngqītiān* again

Before you move on

What does 星期天 mean? ("Sunday".) Say it once more.

Chapter 47

Months and Years

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say this year, next year, the month and the date.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 47: I can say this year, next year, the month and the date.*

47.1 年 (nián) — year

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for weekend, then the Mandarin for Sunday.

You'll want to know: 年

年 — *nián* — "year".

> 一年有多少个星期 *yì nián yǒu duōshao ge xīngqī* — How many weeks are there in a year?

The new character, in pieces: 年 — six strokes: a short fall, two bars, a short vertical on the left, a long bar, and one long vertical through them. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

年 (*nián*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *nen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the grain is ripe'. One harvest a year

is the usual explanation of the sense, though the step is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: nián*
- *Say it: nián*, once more
- *Say it: yì nián yǒu duōshao ge xīngqī* — How many weeks are there in a year?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for weekend, then the Mandarin for Sunday, then say *nián* again

Before you move on

What does 年 mean? ("Year".) Say it once more.

47.2 年 — three bars and a long vertical

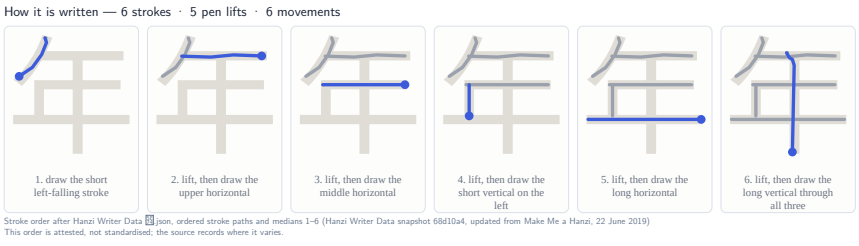
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *nián* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  生 十

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shēng*, *shí*

Script — three bars and a long vertical



How 年 is written, stroke by stroke

年

One piece, six strokes.
A short left-falling stroke at the top left.
Two horizontals, the upper one short, the one below it longer.
A short vertical down from the left end of the second bar.
A long horizontal across the bottom.
Last, the long vertical down through the middle, past the bottom bar.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 年, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 年? (**Six.**) What comes first? (**A short left-falling stroke.**) Which stroke is last? (**The long vertical through the middle.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 年, pinned stroke paths and medians.

47.3 yuè — month; moon

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for Sunday, then the Mandarin for year.

You'll want to know: yuè

yuè — "month; moon".

zhège yuè wǒ hěn máng — I'm busy this month.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yuè is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngjwot* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where the dictionary quotes an old saying that the moon is the essence of water.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: yuè*
- *Say it: yuè*, once more
- *Say it: zhège yuè wǒ hěn máng* — I'm busy this month.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for Sunday, then the Mandarin for year, then say *yuè* again

Before you move on

What does yuè mean? ("Month; moon".) Say it once more.

47.4 明年 (míngnián) — next year

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for year, then the Mandarin for month.

You'll want to know: 明年

明年 — *míngnián* — "next year".

明年我买车 *míngnián wǒ mǎi chē* — I'm buying a car next year.

The new character, in pieces: 明 — 日 on the left and, on the right, the moon piece, the word yuè from the lesson before. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

明年 (*míngnián*) is built from 明 'bright' and 年 'year', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mjaeng* and *nen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses *mjaeng* 'light'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: míngnián*
- *Say it: míngnián*, once more
- *Say it: míngnián wǒ mǎi chē* — I'm buying a car next year.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for year, then the Mandarin for month, then say *míngnián* again

Before you move on

What does 明年 mean? ("Next year".) Say it once more.

47.5 明 — the sun beside the moon

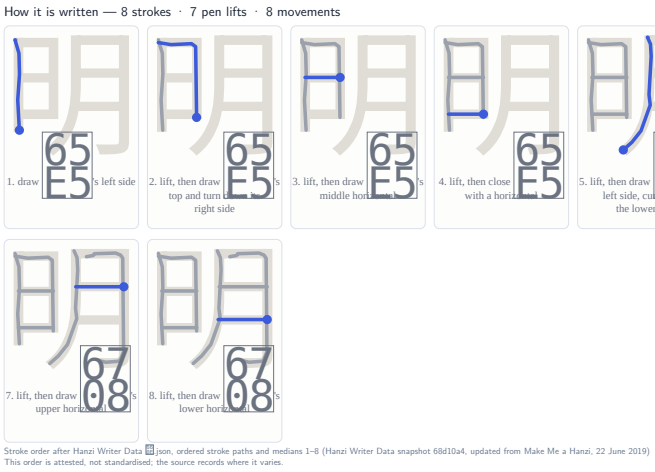
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *míngnián* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 期

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *qī*

Script — the sun beside the moon



How 明 *is written, stroke by stroke*

明

Two pieces, left before right: the sun, then the moon.

日**, four strokes**, narrow and set a little high on the left.

The moon, four strokes, as on the right of 期: a left-falling stroke, a horizontal that turns down and hooks, and two short horizontals inside.

4 + 4 = eight.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 明, all eight, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which two pieces make 明? (日 **and the moon.**) Which character from the last chapters has the same moon on the right? (期.) How many strokes? (**Eight.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 明, pinned stroke paths and medians.

47.6 今年 (jīnnián) — this year

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for month, then the Mandarin for next year.

You'll want to know: 今年

今年 — *jīnnián* — "this year".

我今年十八岁 *wǒ jīnnián shíbā suì* — I'm eighteen this year.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

今年 (*jīnnián*) is built from 今 'now' and 年 'year', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kim* and *nen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: jīnnián*
- *Say it: jīnnián*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jīnnián shíbā suì* — I'm eighteen this year.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for month, then the Mandarin for next year, then say *jīnnián* again

Before you move on

What does 今年 mean? ("This year".) Say it once more.

47.7 日期 (rìqī) — date

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for next year, then the Mandarin for this year.

You'll want to know: 日期

日期 — *rìqī* — "date".

请看日期 *qǐng kàn rìqī* — Please check the date.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

日期 (*rìqī*) is built from 日 'day' and 期 'appointed time', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyit* and *gi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: rìqī*
- *Say it: rìqī*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng kàn rìqī* — Please check the date.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for next year, then the Mandarin for this year, then say *rìqī* again

Before you move on

What does 日期 mean? ("Date".) Say it once more.

47.8 Looking back: from Coming and Going to Months and Years

Say the Mandarin for to go and to go back.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to go, to go back, to walk, to go out, school
- *Say it:* car, restaurant, hospital, to sit, taxi
- *Say it:* day, today, yesterday, now, tomorrow

- *Say it:* week, Monday, moment, weekend, Sunday
- *Say it:* year, month, next year, this year, date
- *Read it:* 去 车 天 今 星 期 年 明 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

To go? (去, *qù.*) To go back? (*huí.*) To walk? (*zǒu.*) To go out? (*chūmén.*) School? (*xuéxiào.*) Car? (车, *chē.*) Restaurant? (*fàndiàn.*) Hospital? (*yīyuàn.*) To sit? (*zuò.*) Taxi? (*chūzūchē.*) Day? (天, *tiān.*) Today? (今天, *jīntiān.*) Yesterday? (*zuótiān.*) Now? (*xiànzài.*) Tomorrow? (*míngtiān.*) Week? (星期, *xīngqī.*) Monday? (星期一, *xīngqīyī.*) Moment? (*shíhou.*) Weekend? (*zhōumò.*) Sunday? (星期天, *xīngqītiān.*) Year? (年, *nián.*) Month? (*yuè.*) Next year? (明年, *míngnián.*) This year? (今年, *jīnnián.*) Date? (日期, *rìqī.*)

Chapter 48

Telling the Time

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask the time and say it to the half hour and the minute.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 48: I can ask the time and say it to the half hour and the minute.*

48.1 点 (diǎn) — o'clock; dot

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for this year, then the Mandarin for date.

You'll want to know: 点

点 — *diǎn* — "o'clock; dot".

> 我们明天八点去 *wǒmen míngtiān bā diǎn qù* — We're going at eight tomorrow.

The new character, in pieces: 点 — a small vertical and bar on top of 口, standing over four dots. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

点 (*diǎn*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *temX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a dot made with the brush'. Its use for the hours is not given there, so how it took that job is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: diǎn*
- *Say it: diǎn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen míngtiān bā diǎn qù* — We're going at eight tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for this year, then the Mandarin for date, then say *diǎn* again

Before you move on

What does 点 mean? ("O'clock; dot".) Say it once more.

48.2 点 — a mark on 口, over four dots

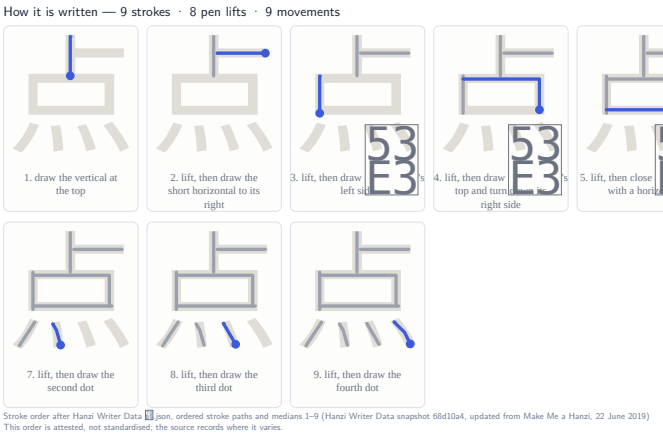
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *diǎn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

口 明

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *míng*

Script — a mark on 口, over four dots



How 点 is written, stroke by stroke

点

Three pieces, top to bottom.

Two strokes on top. A short vertical, then a short horizontal from its middle out to the right.

口, three strokes, wide, under them.

Four dots along the bottom, left to right; the first leans left, the other three lean right.

2 + 3 + 4 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 点, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 点? (**Three**.) Which character you know is in the middle? (口.) How many dots at the bottom? (**Four**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 点, pinned stroke paths and medians.

48.3 fēn — minute; to divide

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for date, then the Mandarin for o'clock.

You'll want to know: fēn

fēn — "minute; to divide".

bā diǎn shí fēn — Ten past eight.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fēn is inherited from Middle Chinese *pjun* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to divide'. Its use for minutes is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: fēn*
- *Say it: fēn*, once more
- *Say it: bā diǎn shí fēn* — Ten past eight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for date, then the Mandarin for o'clock, then say *fēn* again

Before you move on

What does fēn mean? ("Minute; to divide".) Say it once more.

48.4 bàn — half

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for o'clock, then the Mandarin for minute.

You'll want to know: bàn

bàn — "half".

bā diǎn bàn — Half past eight.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *panH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a thing divided in the middle'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: bàn*
- *Say it: bàn*, once more
- *Say it: bā diǎn bàn* — Half past eight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for o'clock, then the Mandarin for minute, then say *bàn* again

Before you move on

What does bàn mean? ("Half".) Say it once more.

48.5 jǐ — how many; a few

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for minute, then the Mandarin for half.

You'll want to know: jǐ

jǐ — "how many; a few".

xiànzài jǐ diǎn — What time is it?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
jǐ asks for a small number, as in *jǐ diǎn*; *duōshao* asks for any amount.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jǐ is inherited from Middle Chinese *kj+jX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'how many'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: jǐ*
- *Say it: jǐ*, once more
- *Say it: xiànzài jǐ diǎn* — What time is it?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for minute, then the Mandarin for half, then say *jǐ* again

Before you move on

What does jǐ mean? ("How many; a few".) Say it once more.

48.6 děng — to wait; to wait for

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for half, then the Mandarin for how many.

You'll want to know: děng

děng — "to wait; to wait for".

wǒ děng nǐ — I'll wait for you.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

děng is inherited from Middle Chinese *tongX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'equal, of a kind'. The sense 'to wait' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: děng*
- *Say it: děng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ děng nǐ* — I'll wait for you.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for half, then the Mandarin for how many, then say *děng* again

Before you move on

What does děng mean? ("To wait; to wait for".) Say it once more.

Chapter 49

A Day from Morning to Night

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the parts of the day and greet somebody in the evening.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 49: I can name the parts of the day and greet somebody in the evening.*

49.1 上午 (shàngwǔ) — morning (before noon)

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for how many, then the Mandarin for to wait.

You'll want to know: 上午

上午 — *shàngwǔ* — "morning (before noon)".

> 上午十点我去大学 *shàngwǔ shí diǎn wǒ qù dàxué* — At ten in the morning I go to the university.

The new character, in pieces: 午 — the top of 年: a short fall, two bars and a vertical. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

上午 (*shàngwǔ*) is built from 上 'upper, earlier' and 午 'noon', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangH* and *nguX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary gives *nguX* as the name of one of the branches of the old calendar.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngwǔ*
- *Say it: shàngwǔ*, once more
- *Say it: shàngwǔ shí diǎn wǒ qù dàxué* — At ten in the morning I go to the university.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for how many, then the Mandarin for to wait, then say *shàngwǔ* again

Before you move on

What does 上午 mean? ("Morning (before noon)".) Say it once more.

49.2 午 — the top of 年

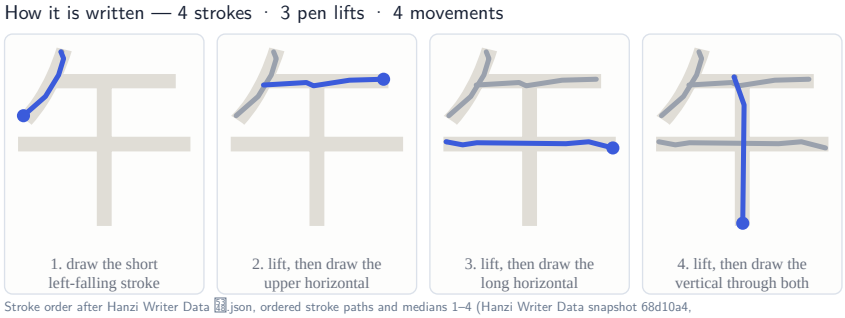
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shàngwǔ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  年 十

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *nián*, *shí*

Script — the top of 午



How 午 is written, stroke by stroke

午

One piece, four strokes.
A short left-falling stroke at the top left.
A shorter horizontal, then **a long horizontal** under it.
Last, the vertical down through the middle of both bars.
It is 年 with its short vertical and bottom bar left out.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 午, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which character you know begins like 午? (年.) How many strokes? (**Four**.) Which bar is longer? (**The lower one**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 午, pinned stroke paths and medians.

49.3 中午 (zhōngwǔ) — noon

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to wait, then the Mandarin for before noon.

You'll want to know: 中午

中午 — *zhōngwǔ* — "noon".

中午我们吃饭 *zhōngwǔ wǒmen chī fàn* — We have lunch at noon.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

中午 (*zhōngwǔ*) is built from 中 'middle' and 午 'noon', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjuwng* and *nguX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhōngwǔ*
- *Say it: zhōngwǔ*, once more
- *Say it: zhōngwǔ wǒmen chī fàn* — We have lunch at noon.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to wait, then the Mandarin for before noon, then say *zhōngwǔ* again

Before you move on

What does 中午 mean? ("Noon".) Say it once more.

49.4 晚上 (wǎnshang) — evening

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for before noon, then the Mandarin for noon.

You'll want to know: 晚上

晚上 — *wǎnshang* — "evening".

晚上我看书 *wǎnshang wǒ kàn shū* — I read in the evenings.

The new character, in pieces: 晚 — 日 on the left and a seven-stroke piece on the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

晚上 (*wǎnshang*) is built from 晚 'dusk' and the light ending shang, as in 早上. 晚 is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjonX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'dusk'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǎnshang*
- *Say it: wǎnshang*, once more
- *Say it: wǎnshang wǒ kàn shū* — I read in the evenings.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for before noon, then the Mandarin for noon, then say *wǎnshang* again

Before you move on

What does 晚上 mean? ("Evening".) Say it once more.

49.5 晚 — 日, then seven strokes

The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *wǎnshang* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 多

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *duō*

Script — 日, then seven strokes



How 晚 *is written, stroke by stroke*

晚

Two pieces, left before right.
日**, four strokes**, narrow on the left.

The right piece, seven strokes. A short left-falling stroke and a short stroke that runs across and falls, like the top of 多. A vertical, a horizontal that turns down, and a horizontal under it to close a small box. Then a left-falling stroke, and a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up.

4 + 7 = eleven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 晚, all eleven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 晚? (**Two** — 日, then seven strokes.) Which character you know starts the right piece the same way? (多.) How

does the last stroke end? (**It hooks up**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 晚, pinned stroke paths and medians.

49.6 xiàwǔ — afternoon

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for noon, then the Mandarin for evening.

You'll want to know: xiàwǔ

xiàwǔ — "afternoon".

xiàwǔ wǒ hěn máng — I'm busy in the afternoon.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàwǔ is built from xià 'lower, after' and 午 'noon', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *nguX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàwǔ*
- *Say it: xiàwǔ*, once more
- *Say it: xiàwǔ wǒ hěn máng* — I'm busy in the afternoon.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for noon, then the Mandarin for evening, then say *xiàwǔ* again

Before you move on

What does xiàwǔ mean? ("Afternoon".) Say it once more.

49.7 晚上好 (wǎnshang hǎo) — good evening

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for evening, then the Mandarin for afternoon.

You'll want to know: 晚上好

晚上好 — *wǎnshang hǎo* — "good evening".

大家晚上好 *dàjiā wǎnshang hǎo* — Good evening, everyone.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

晚上好 (*wǎnshang hǎo*) is built from 晚上 'evening' and 好 'good', the same shape as 早上好.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǎnshang hǎo*
- *Say it: wǎnshang hǎo*, once more
- *Say it: dàjiā wǎnshang hǎo* — Good evening, everyone.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for evening, then the Mandarin for afternoon, then say *wǎnshang hǎo* again

Before you move on

What does 晚上好 mean? ("Good evening".) Say it once more.

Chapter 50

Sleeping and Waking

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say when I sleep, get up and rest, and ask about health.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 50: I can say when I sleep, get up and rest, and ask about health.*

50.1 shuìjiào — to sleep; to go to bed

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for afternoon, then the Mandarin for good evening.

You'll want to know: shuìjiào

shuìjiào — "to sleep; to go to bed".

> *wǒ qù shuìjiào* — I'm off to bed.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuìjiào is built from shuì 'to sleep' and jiào 'sleep', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyweH* and *kaewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second with this very pair.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuìjiào*
- *Say it: shuìjiào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù shuìjiào* — I'm off to bed.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for afternoon, then the Mandarin for good evening, then say *shuìjiào* again

Before you move on

What does shuìjiào mean? ("To sleep; to go to bed".) Say it once more.

50.2 qǐchuáng — to get up

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for good evening, then the Mandarin for to sleep.

You'll want to know: qǐchuáng

qǐchuáng — "to get up".

wǒ qī diǎn qǐchuáng — I get up at seven.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qǐchuáng is built from qǐ 'to rise' and chuáng 'bed', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khiX* and *dzrjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: qǐchuáng*
- *Say it: qǐchuáng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qī diǎn qǐchuáng* — I get up at seven.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for good evening, then the Mandarin for to sleep, then say *qǐchuáng* again

Before you move on

What does qǐchuáng mean? ("To get up".) Say it once more.

50.3 xiūxi — to rest

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to sleep, then the Mandarin for to get up.

You'll want to know: xiūxi

xiūxi — "to rest".

xīngqītiān wǒ xiūxi — On Sunday I take it easy.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiūxi is built from xiū 'to rest' and xi 'to stop, to breathe', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xjuw* and *sik* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiūxi*
- *Say it: xiūxi*, once more

- *Say it: xīngqītiān wǒ xiūxi* — On Sunday I take it easy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to sleep, then the Mandarin for to get up, then say *xiūxi* again

Before you move on

What does xiūxi mean? ("To rest".) Say it once more.

50.4 shēntǐ — body; health

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to get up, then the Mandarin for to rest.

You'll want to know: shēntǐ

shēntǐ — "body; health".

nǐ shēntǐ hǎo ma — How's your health?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shēntǐ is built from shēn 'body, self' and tǐ 'body', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *syin* and *thejX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: shēntǐ*
- *Say it: shēntǐ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ shēntǐ hǎo ma* — How's your health?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to get up, then the Mandarin for to rest, then say *shēntǐ* again

Before you move on

What does shēntǐ mean? (“Body; health”.) Say it once more.

50.5 bìng — to fall ill; illness

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to rest, then the Mandarin for health.

You’ll want to know: bìng

bìng — “to fall ill; illness”.

wǒ māma bìng le — My mum is ill.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bìng is inherited from Middle Chinese *bjaengH* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’worry, pain’ and ’an illness grown worse’.

What you’ve built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: bìng*
- *Say it: bìng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma bìng le* — My mum is ill.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to rest, then the Mandarin for health, then say *bìng* again

Before you move on

What does bìng mean? (“To fall ill; illness”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 51

How You Feel

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I am happy, afraid, cold or hot.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 51: I can say I am happy, afraid, cold or hot.*

51.1 gāoxìng — happy; glad

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for health, then the Mandarin for to fall ill.

You'll want to know: gāoxìng

gāoxìng — "happy; glad".

> *wǒ hěn gāoxìng* — I'm so pleased.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gāoxìng is built from gāo 'high' and xìng 'mood', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kaw* and *xingH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'high'; it gives the second reading no gloss of its own, so 'mood' is the usual explanation, not a settled one.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: gāoxìng*
- *Say it: gāoxìng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ hěn gāoxìng* — I'm so pleased.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for health, then the Mandarin for to fall ill, then say *gāoxìng* again

Before you move on

What does gāoxìng mean? ("Happy; glad".) Say it once more.

51.2 pà — to be afraid of; to fear

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to fall ill, then the Mandarin for happy.

You'll want to know: pà

pà — "to be afraid of; to fear".

nǐ pà shénme — What are you afraid of?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

pà is inherited from Middle Chinese *phaeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to fear'.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: pà*
- *Say it: pà*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ pà shénme* — What are you afraid of?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to fall ill, then the Mandarin for happy, then say *pà* again

Before you move on

What does pà mean? ("To be afraid of; to fear".) Say it once more.

51.3 lěng — cold

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for happy, then the Mandarin for to be afraid.

You'll want to know: lěng

lěng — "cold".

jīntiān hěn lěng — It's cold today.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lěng is inherited from Middle Chinese *lengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'cold'.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: lěng*
- *Say it: lěng*, once more

- *Say it: jīntiān hěn lěng* — It's cold today.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for happy, then the Mandarin for to be afraid, then say *lěng* again

Before you move on

What does lěng mean? ("Cold".) Say it once more.

51.4 rè — hot

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be afraid, then the Mandarin for cold.

You'll want to know: rè

rè — "hot".

zhōngwǔ hěn rè — It's hot at midday.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rè is inherited from Middle Chinese *nyet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as burning, as if by fire.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: rè*
- *Say it: rè*, once more
- *Say it: zhōngwǔ hěn rè* — It's hot at midday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be afraid, then the Mandarin for cold, then say *rè* again

Before you move on

What does rè mean? (“Hot”.) Say it once more.

51.5 kū — to cry; to weep

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cold, then the Mandarin for hot.

You’ll want to know: kū

kū — “to cry; to weep”.

háizi kū le — The child started crying.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kū is inherited from Middle Chinese *khuwk* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’a sound of grief’.

What you’ve built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: kū*
- *Say it: kū*, once more
- *Say it: háizi kū le* — The child started crying.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cold, then the Mandarin for hot, then say *kū* again

Before you move on

What does kū mean? (“To cry; to weep”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 52

Head, Hands and Feet

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my head, hands, feet, eyes and ears.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 52: I can name my head, hands, feet, eyes and ears.*

52.1 手 (shǒu) — hand

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hot, then the Mandarin for to cry.

You'll want to know: 手

手 — *shǒu* — "hand".

> 我的手很小 *wǒ de shǒu hěn xiǎo* — My hands are small.

The new character, in pieces: 手 — a short fall, two bars, and a vertical that hooks at the foot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

手 (*shǒu*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *syuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed with the pair 'hand and foot'.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: shǒu*
- *Say it: shǒu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de shǒu hěn xiǎo* — My hands are small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hot, then the Mandarin for to cry, then say *shǒu* again

Before you move on

What does 手 mean? ("Hand".) Say it once more.

52.2 手 — a fall, two bars, a hook

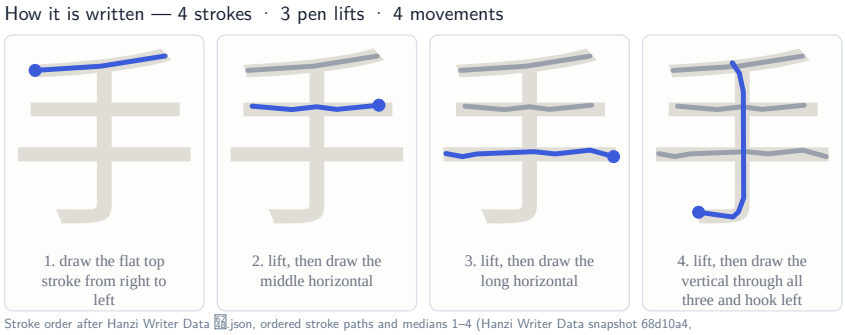
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shǒu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  看 小

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kàn*, *xiǎo*

Script — a fall, two bars, a hook



How 手 is written, stroke by stroke

手

One piece, four strokes, top to bottom.
A short left-falling stroke across the top, from right to left.
Two horizontals, the lower one longer.
Last, a vertical down through both bars, hooking to the left at the foot.

The top of 看 is this hand, squeezed flat over the eye.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 手, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 手? (**Four**.) Which way does the first stroke fall? (**To the left**.) Which character you know has a hand on top? (看.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 手, pinned stroke paths and medians.

52.3 tóu — head

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to cry, then the Mandarin for hand.

You'll want to know: tóu

tóu — "head".

tā de tóu hěn dà — He's got a big head.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tóu is inherited from Middle Chinese *duw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'head'.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: tóu*
- *Say it: tóu*, once more
- *Say it: tā de tóu hěn dà* — He's got a big head.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to cry, then the Mandarin for hand, then say *tóu* again

Before you move on

What does tóu mean? ("Head".) Say it once more.

52.4 jiǎo — foot

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hand, then the Mandarin for head.

You'll want to know: jiǎo

jiǎo — "foot".

wǒ de jiǎo hěn lěng — My feet are cold.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *kjak* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as the part that tucks back when you sit; whether that meant the leg or the foot is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiǎo*
- *Say it: jiǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de jiǎo hěn lěng* — My feet are cold.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hand, then the Mandarin for head, then say *jiǎo* again

Before you move on

What does jiǎo mean? ("Foot".) Say it once more.

52.5 yǎnjing — eye

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for head, then the Mandarin for foot.

You'll want to know: yǎnjing

yǎnjing — "eye".

tā de yǎnjing hěn hǎokàn — She has lovely eyes.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǎnjing is built from yǎn 'eye' and jing 'eyeball', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngeanX* and *tsjeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǎnjing*
- *Say it: yǎnjing*, once more
- *Say it: tā de yǎnjing hěn hǎokàn* — She has lovely eyes.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for head, then the Mandarin for foot, then say *yǎnjing* again

Before you move on

What does yǎnjing mean? ("Eye".) Say it once more.

52.6 ěrduo — ear

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for foot, then the Mandarin for eye.

You'll want to know: ěrduo

ěrduo — "ear".

háizi de ěrduo hěn xiǎo — The child's ears are tiny.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ěrduo is built from ěr 'ear' and duo, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyiX* and *twaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as what hears and the second as something hanging from a tree; the second probably names the soft lobe that hangs, though that is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: ěrduo*
- *Say it: ěrduo*, once more
- *Say it: háizi de ěrduo hěn xiǎo* — The child's ears are tiny.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for foot, then the Mandarin for eye, then say *ěrduo* again

Before you move on

What does ěrduo mean? ("Ear".) Say it once more.

52.7 Looking back: from Telling the Time to Head, Hands and Feet

Say the Mandarin for o'clock and minute.

Your turn

- *Say it:* o'clock, minute, half, how many, to wait
- *Say it:* before noon, noon, evening, afternoon, good evening
- *Say it:* to sleep, to get up, to rest, health, to fall ill
- *Say it:* happy, to be afraid, cold, hot, to cry
- *Say it:* hand, head, foot, eye, ear

- *Read it:* 点 午 晚 手 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

O'clock? (点, *diǎn.*) Minute? (*fēn.*) Half? (*bàn.*) How many? (*jǐ.*) To wait? (*děng.*) Before noon? (上午, *shàngwǔ.*) Noon? (中午, *zhōngwǔ.*) Evening? (晚上, *wǎnshang.*) Afternoon? (*xiàwǔ.*) Good evening? (晚上好, *wǎnshang hǎo.*) To sleep? (*shuìjiào.*) To get up? (*qǐchuáng.*) To rest? (*xiūxi.*) Health? (*shēntǐ.*) To fall ill? (*bìng.*) Happy? (*gāoxìng.*) To be afraid? (*pà.*) Cold? (*lěng.*) Hot? (*rè.*) To cry? (*kū.*) Hand? (手, *shǒu.*) Head? (*tóu.*) Foot? (*jiǎo.*) Eye? (*yǎnjing.*) Ear? (*ěrduo.*)

Chapter 53

Speaking and Hearing

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I understand or not, and ask somebody to speak slowly.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 53: I can say that I understand or not, and ask somebody to speak slowly.*

53.1 说 (shuō) — to say; to speak

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for eye, then the Mandarin for ear.

You'll want to know: 说

说 — *shuō* — "to say; to speak".

> 他说你的手很好看 *tā shuō nǐ de shǒu hěn hǎokàn* — He says you have lovely hands.

The new character, in pieces: 说 — 讠 , the speech piece, on the left; on the right a dot and a short fall, then 口, then two legs. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

说 (*shuō*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *sywet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to tell'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuō*
- *Say it: shuō*, once more
- *Say it: tā shuō nǐ de shǒu hěn hǎokàn* — He says you have lovely hands.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for eye, then the Mandarin for ear, then say *shuō* again

Before you move on

What does 说 mean? ("To say; to speak".) Say it once more.

53.2 说 — the speech piece, then a mouth with legs

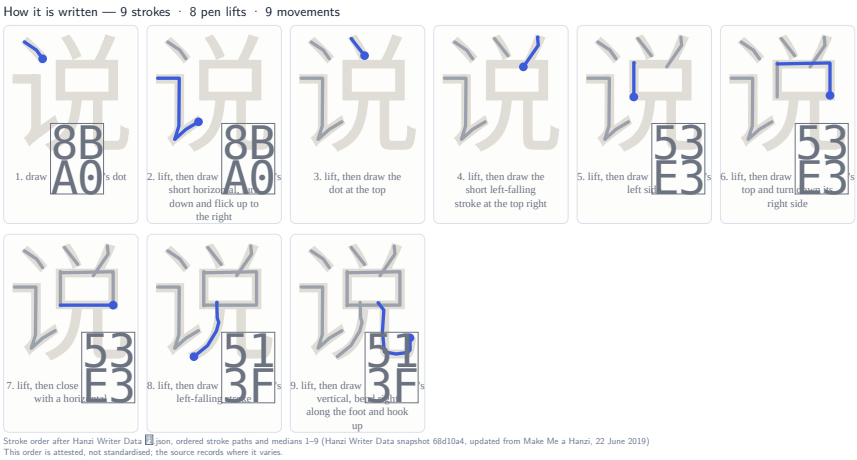
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shuō* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

讠 请

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — the speech piece, *qǐng*

Script — the speech piece, then a mouth with legs



How 说 *is written, stroke by stroke*

说

Two pieces, left before right.

The speech piece, 讠, two strokes, as in 请: a dot, then a short horizontal that turns down and finishes rising to the upper right, all one stroke.

The right piece, seven strokes, top to bottom. A dot and a short left-falling stroke, leaning in toward each other. 口 under them. Then two legs: a left-falling stroke, and a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up.

2 + 7 = nine, and five of them are 讠 and 口.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 说, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 说? (**Two** — 讠, then the right side.) Which character you know is in the middle of the right side? (口.) How

does the last stroke end? (**It hooks up**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 说, pinned stroke paths and medians.

53.3 话 (huà) — words; speech

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for ear, then the Mandarin for to say.

You'll want to know: 话

话 — *huà* — "words; speech".

他说中国话 *tā shuō Zhōngguó huà* — He speaks Chinese.

The new character, in pieces: 话 — 讠 on the left; on the right a short fall, a bar and a vertical, standing on 口. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

话 (*huà*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwaejH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'talk'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: huà*
- *Say it: huà*, once more
- *Say it: tā shuō Zhōngguó huà* — He speaks Chinese.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for ear, then the Mandarin for to say, then say *huà* again

Before you move on

What does 话 mean? ("Words; speech".) Say it once more.

53.4 话 — the speech piece, then a mouth

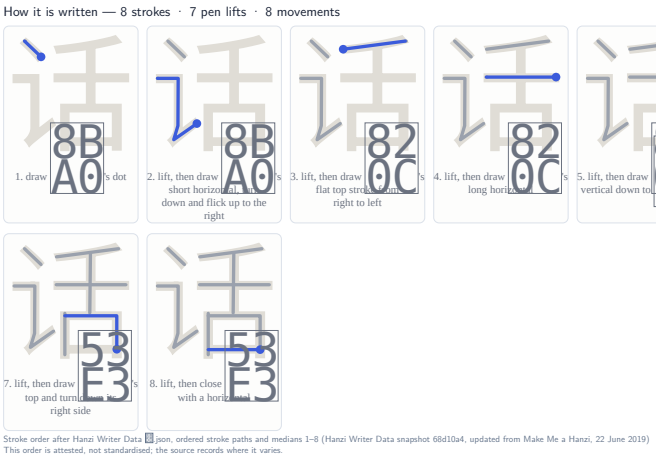
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *huà* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  说 语

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shuō*, *yǔ*

Script — the speech piece, then a mouth



How 话 *is written, stroke by stroke*

话

Two pieces, left before right.
The speech piece, 讠, two strokes, as in 说.
The right piece, six strokes, top to bottom. A short left-falling stroke along the top. A long horizontal. A vertical down from the top through the bar. Then 口 at the foot.
2 + 3 + 3 = eight.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 话, all eight, with the model in front of you

- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 话? (**Two** — 讠 , then the right side.) What does the right side stand on? (口.) Which character did your hand write a moment ago, with the same left piece? (说.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 话, pinned stroke paths and medians.

53.5 tīng — to listen; to hear

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to say, then the Mandarin for spoken words.

You'll want to know: tīng

tīng — "to listen; to hear".

nǐ tīng wǒ shuō — Listen to me.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tīng is inherited from Middle Chinese *theng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to listen'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: tīng*
- *Say it: tīng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ tīng wǒ shuō* — Listen to me.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to say, then the Mandarin for spoken words, then say *tīng* again

Before you move on

What does tīng mean? (“To listen; to hear”.) Say it once more.

53.6 dǒng — to understand

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for spoken words, then the Mandarin for to listen.

You’ll want to know: dǒng

dǒng — “to understand”.

wǒ bù dǒng — I don’t understand.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dǒng has no older form in any dictionary we use, so its history is not settled.

What you’ve built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǒng*
- *Say it: dǒng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù dǒng* — I don’t understand.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for spoken words, then the Mandarin for to listen, then say *dǒng* again

Before you move on

What does dǒng mean? (“To understand”.) Say it once more.

53.7 màn — slow

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to listen, then the Mandarin for to understand.

You'll want to know: màn

màn — "slow".

tā shuō huà hěn màn — He speaks slowly.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

màn is inherited from Middle Chinese *maenH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'lazy, haughty'. The sense 'slow' is not given there; from lazy to slow is a likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: màn*
- *Say it: màn*, once more
- *Say it: tā shuō huà hěn màn* — He speaks slowly.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to listen, then the Mandarin for to understand, then say *màn* again

Before you move on

What does màn mean? ("Slow".) Say it once more.

Chapter 54

Learning

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I study, read and ask about in class.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 54: I can say what I study, read and ask about in class.*

54.1 xuéxí — to study; to learn

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to understand, then the Mandarin for slow.

You'll want to know: xuéxí

xuéxí — "to study; to learn".

> *wǒ xuéxí hànyǔ* — I'm learning Chinese.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xuéxí is built from 学 'to learn' and xí 'to practise', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haewk* and *zip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses *zip* with the first.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: xuéxí*
- *Say it: xuéxí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xuéxí hànyǔ* — I'm learning Chinese.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to understand, then the Mandarin for slow, then say *xuéxí* again

Before you move on

What does xuéxí mean? ("To study; to learn".) Say it once more.

54.2 xiě — to write

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for slow, then the Mandarin for to learn.

You'll want to know: xiě

xiě — "to write".

wǒ xiě hànzì — I'm practising characters.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiě is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjaeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to remove' and 'to copy out a book'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiě*
- *Say it: xiě*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiě hànzì* — I'm practising characters.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for slow, then the Mandarin for to learn, then say *xiě* again

Before you move on

What does xiě mean? ("To write".) Say it once more.

54.3 dú — to read aloud; to study

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to learn, then the Mandarin for to write.

You'll want to know: dú

dú — "to read aloud; to study".

wǒ xǐhuan dú shū — I love reading.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dú is inherited from Middle Chinese *duwk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to recite'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: dú*
- *Say it: dú*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan dú shū* — I love reading.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to learn, then the Mandarin for to write, then say *dú* again

Before you move on

What does dú mean? ("To read aloud; to study".) Say it once more.

54.4 wèn — to ask

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to write, then the Mandarin for to read aloud.

You'll want to know: wèn

wèn — "to ask".

wǒ wèn lǎoshī — I'll ask the teacher.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wèn is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjunH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to inquire'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: wèn*
- *Say it: wèn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ wèn lǎoshī* — I'll ask the teacher.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to write, then the Mandarin for to read aloud, then say *wèn* again

Before you move on

What does wèn mean? (“To ask”.) Say it once more.

54.5 kè — lesson; class

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to read aloud, then the Mandarin for to ask.

You’ll want to know: kè

kè — “lesson; class”.

jīntiān yǒu hànyǔ kè — There’s a Chinese class today.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kè is inherited from Middle Chinese *khwaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’a tax’ and ’a test’. The sense ’lesson’ is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you’ve built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: kè*
- *Say it: kè*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān yǒu hànyǔ kè* — There’s a Chinese class today.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to read aloud, then the Mandarin for to ask, then say *kè* again

Before you move on

What does kè mean? (“Lesson; class”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 55

What You Love

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I would like to do and what I love.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 55: I can say what I would like to do and what I love.*

55.1 想 (xiǎng) — to want to; to think; to miss

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to ask, then the Mandarin for lesson.

You'll want to know: 想

想 — *xiǎng* — "to want to; to think; to miss".

> 我想说中国话 *wǒ xiǎng shuō Zhōngguó huà* — I'd like to speak Chinese.

The new character, in pieces: 想 — a tree piece and an eye piece side by side, over a heart piece. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

xiǎng before another verb says what you would like to do: *wǒ xiǎng shuō*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

想 (*xiǎng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to think'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiǎng*
- *Say it: xiǎng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng shuō Zhōngguó huà* — I'd like to speak Chinese.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to ask, then the Mandarin for lesson, then say *xiǎng* again

Before you move on

What does 想 mean? ("To want to; to think; to miss".) Say it once more.

55.2 想 — a tree and an eye, over a heart

The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xiǎng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  看 说

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kàn*, *shuō*

Script — a tree and an eye, over a heart



How 想 *is written, stroke by stroke*

想

Three pieces: the tree, then the eye, then the heart below. Count three, not thirteen.

The tree, four strokes, narrow on the top left: a horizontal, a vertical through it, a left-falling stroke, and a dot.

The eye, five strokes, on the top right: a vertical, a horizontal that turns down, and three short horizontals inside, the last one closing it. It is the box at the bottom of 看.

The heart, four strokes, wide underneath: a dot, a long curve that sweeps right and hooks up, then two more dots.

4 + 5 + 4 = thirteen.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 想, all thirteen, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 想? (**Three** — the tree, the eye, the heart.) Which character you know has the same eye in it? (看.) What does the heart begin with? (**A dot**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 想, pinned stroke paths and medians.

55.3 ài — to love

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for lesson, then the Mandarin for to want to.

You'll want to know: ài

ài — "to love".

wǒ ài nǐ — I love you.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ài is inherited from Middle Chinese *'ojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to cherish'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: ài*
- *Say it: ài*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ ài nǐ* — I love you.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for lesson, then the Mandarin for to want to, then say *ài* again

Before you move on

What does ài mean? ("To love".) Say it once more.

55.4 diànyǐng — film; movie

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to want to, then the Mandarin for to love.

You'll want to know: diànyǐng

diànyǐng — "film; movie".

wǒ xǐhuan kàn diànyǐng — I like going to the cinema.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diànyǐng is built from diàn 'lightning', now 'electricity', and yǐng 'shadow', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *denH* and *'jaengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): electric shadows.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: diànyǐng*
- *Say it: diànyǐng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan kàn diànyǐng* — I like going to the cinema.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to want to, then the Mandarin for to love, then say *diànyǐng* again

Before you move on

What does diànyǐng mean? ("Film; movie".) Say it once more.

55.5 chànggē — to sing

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to love, then the Mandarin for film.

You'll want to know: chànggē

chànggē — "to sing".

tā xǐhuan chànggē — She loves singing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chànggē is built from chàng 'to strike up a song' and gē 'song', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhangH* and *ka* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chànggē*
- *Say it: chànggē*, once more
- *Say it: tā xǐhuan chànggē* — She loves singing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to love, then the Mandarin for film, then say *chànggē* again

Before you move on

What does chànggē mean? ("To sing".) Say it once more.

55.6 kāfēi — coffee

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for film, then the Mandarin for to sing.

You'll want to know: kāfēi

kāfēi — "coffee".

nǐ hē kāfēi ma — Do you drink coffee?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kāfēi is borrowed from a European word for coffee; it is usually traced to English *coffee*, though the path is not documented in what we can open.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: kāfēi*
- *Say it: kāfēi*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ hē kāfēi ma* — Do you drink coffee?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for film, then the Mandarin for to sing, then say *kāfēi* again

Before you move on

What does kāfēi mean? ("Coffee".) Say it once more.

Chapter 56

Free Time

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I do for fun: play, sport, running and laughing.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 56: I can say what I do for fun: play, sport, running and laughing.*

56.1 wán — to play; to have fun

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to sing, then the Mandarin for coffee.

You'll want to know: wán

wán — "to play; to have fun".

> *háizi xǐhuan wán* — Children love to play.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wán is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngwanH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to toy with'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: wán*
- *Say it: wán*, once more
- *Say it: háizi xǐhuan wán* — Children love to play.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to sing, then the Mandarin for coffee, then say *wán* again

Before you move on

What does wán mean? ("To play; to have fun".) Say it once more.

56.2 dǎqiú — to play ball

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for coffee, then the Mandarin for to play.

You'll want to know: dǎqiú

dǎqiú — "to play ball".

xīngqītiān wǒmen dǎqiú — We play ball on Sunday.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dǎqiú is built from dǎ 'to strike' and qiú 'ball', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *taengX* and *gjuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), though dǎ is not the sound *taengX* would regularly give. The dictionary glosses *gjuw* as 'fine jade', and under another way of writing it as a ball of fur that is struck.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎqiú*
- *Say it: dǎqiú*, once more
- *Say it: xīngqītiān wǒmen dǎqiú* — We play ball on Sunday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for coffee, then the Mandarin for to play, then say *dǎqiú* again

Before you move on

What does dǎqiú mean? ("To play ball".) Say it once more.

56.3 yùndòng — sport; exercise

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to play, then the Mandarin for to play ball.

You'll want to know: yùndòng

yùndòng — "sport; exercise".

wǒ xǐhuan yùndòng — I like sport.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yùndòng is built from yùn 'to move round, to carry' and dòng 'to move', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjunH* and *duwngX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The sense 'sport' is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yùndòng*
- *Say it: yùndòng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan yùndòng* — I like sport.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to play, then the Mandarin for to play ball, then say *yùndòng* again

Before you move on

What does yùndòng mean? ("Sport; exercise".) Say it once more.

56.4 pǎobù — to run; to jog

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to play ball, then the Mandarin for sport.

You'll want to know: pǎobù

pǎobù — "to run; to jog".

wǒ zǎoshang pǎobù — I go for a run in the mornings.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

pǎobù is built from pǎo 'to run' and bù 'step', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *baew* and *buH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses *baew* as a foot pawing the ground.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: pǎobù*
- *Say it: pǎobù*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ zǎoshang pǎobù* — I go for a run in the mornings.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to play ball, then the Mandarin for sport, then say *pǎobù* again

Before you move on

What does pǎobù mean? ("To run; to jog".) Say it once more.

56.5 xiào — to laugh; to smile

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sport, then the Mandarin for to run.

You'll want to know: xiào

xiào — "to laugh; to smile".

tā xiào le — She laughed.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiào is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'glad, joyful'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiào*
- *Say it: xiào*, once more
- *Say it: tā xiào le* — She laughed.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sport, then the Mandarin for to run, then say *xiào* again

Before you move on

What does xiào mean? (“To laugh; to smile”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 57

At Home

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my house, my room and the things in it, and say here.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 57: I can name my house, my room and the things in it, and say here.*

57.1 fángzi — house

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to run, then the Mandarin for to laugh.

You'll want to know: fángzi

fángzi — "house".

> *zhè shì wǒ de fángzi* — This is my house.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fángzi is built from fáng 'room' and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjang* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: fángzi*
- *Say it: fángzi*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de fángzi* — This is my house.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to run, then the Mandarin for to laugh, then say *fángzi* again

Before you move on

What does fángzi mean? ("House".) Say it once more.

57.2 fángjiān — room

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to laugh, then the Mandarin for house.

You'll want to know: fángjiān

fángjiān — "room".

wǒ de fángjiān hěn xiǎo — My room is small.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fángjiān is built from fáng 'room' and jiān 'space between', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjang* and *kean* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary lists the second under an older form of the character, glossed 'a gap'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: fángjiān*
- *Say it: fángjiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de fángjiān hěn xiǎo* — My room is small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to laugh, then the Mandarin for house, then say *fángjiān* again

Before you move on

What does fángjiān mean? ("Room".) Say it once more.

57.3 zhuōzi — table

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for house, then the Mandarin for room.

You'll want to know: zhuōzi

zhuōzi — "table".

wǒ de zhuōzi hěn dà — My desk is big.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhuōzi is built from zhuō and the noun ending zi. The Guangyun lists the first character as *traewk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), an old way of writing a word for 'high'; the table sense is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhuōzi*
- *Say it: zhuōzi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de zhuōzi hěn dà* — My desk is big.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for house, then the Mandarin for room, then say *zhuōzi* again

Before you move on

What does zhuōzi mean? ("Table".) Say it once more.

57.4 yǐzi — chair

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for room, then the Mandarin for table.

You'll want to know: yǐzi

yǐzi — "chair".

zhè shì háizi de yǐzi — This is the child's chair.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǐzi is built from yǐ and the noun ending zi. The Guangyun records the first character as *'jeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and in a second reading as the name of a tree; the chair sense is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǐzi*
- *Say it: yǐzi*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì háizi de yǐzi* — This is the child's chair.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for room, then the Mandarin for table, then say *yǐzi* again

Before you move on

What does yǐzi mean? ("Chair".) Say it once more.

57.5 这儿 (zhèr) — here

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for table, then the Mandarin for chair.

You'll want to know: 这儿

这儿 — *zhèr* — "here".

你想来这儿吗 *nǐ xiǎng lái zhèr ma* — Would you like to come here?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

这儿 (*zhèr*) is built from 这 'this' and 儿, the ending that runs into the syllable before it as an r.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhèr*
- *Say it: zhèr*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xiǎng lái zhèr ma* — Would you like to come here?

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for table, then the Mandarin for chair, then say *zhèr* again

Before you move on

What does 这儿 mean? ("Here".) Say it once more.

57.6 Looking back: from Speaking and Hearing to At Home

Say the Mandarin for to say and spoken words.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to say, spoken words, to listen, to understand, slow
- *Say it:* to learn, to write, to read aloud, to ask, lesson
- *Say it:* to want to, to love, film, to sing, coffee
- *Say it:* to play, to play ball, sport, to run, to laugh
- *Say it:* house, room, table, chair, here
- *Read it:* 说 话 想 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

To say? (说, *shuō.*) Spoken words? (话, *huà.*) To listen? (*tīng.*) To understand? (*dǒng.*) Slow? (*màn.*) To learn? (*xuéxí.*) To write? (*xiě.*) To read aloud? (*dú.*) To ask? (*wèn.*) Lesson? (*kè.*) To want to? (想, *xiǎng.*) To love? (*ài.*) Film? (*diànyǐng.*) To sing? (*chànggē.*) Coffee? (*kāfēi.*) To play? (*wán.*) To play ball? (*dǎqiú.*) Sport? (*yùndòng.*) To run? (*pǎobù.*) To laugh? (*xiào.*) House? (*fángzi.*) Room? (*fángjiān.*) Table? (*zhuōzi.*) Chair? (*yǐzi.*) Here? (这儿, *zhèr.*)

57.7 At Home — once more

Say the Mandarin for house and room.

Your turn

- *Say it:* house, room, table, chair, here

Before you move on

House? (*fángzi.*) Room? (*fángjiān.*) Table? (*zhuōzi.*) Chair? (*yǐzi.*) Here? (这儿, *zhèr.*)

Chapter 58

Things You Carry

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my phone, my bag, my computer, a cup and my clothes.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 58: I can name my phone, my bag, my computer, a cup and my clothes.*

58.1 手机 (shǒujī) — mobile phone

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for chair, then the Mandarin for here.

You'll want to know: 手机

手机 — *shǒujī* — "mobile phone".

> 这是我的手机 *zhè shì wǒ de shǒujī* — This is my phone.

The new character, in pieces: 机 — the tree piece on the left, the one at the top left of 想, and on the right a two-stroke piece read jǐ, as in the word for how many. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

手机 (*shǒujī*) is built from 手 'hand' and 机 'machine'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *kj+j* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains as the catch that sets off

a crossbow. From that catch to any machine is the usual explanation, but the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: shǒujī*
- *Say it: shǒujī*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de shǒujī* — This is my phone.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for chair, then the Mandarin for here, then say *shǒujī* again

Before you move on

What does 手机 mean? ("Mobile phone".) Say it once more.

58.2 机 — the tree piece, then jǐ

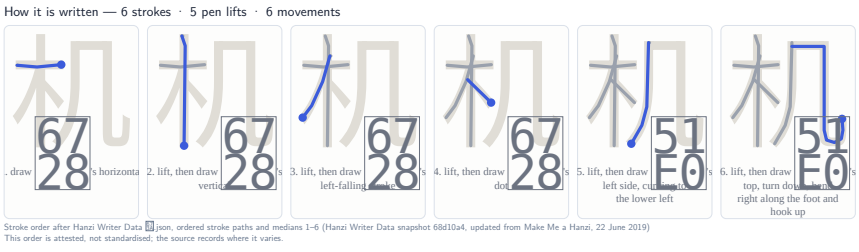
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shǒujī* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  手 想

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shǒu*, *xiǎng*

Script — the tree piece, then jǐ



How 机 is written, stroke by stroke

机

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The tree piece, four strokes, narrow on the left, as at the top left of 想: a horizontal, a vertical down through it, a left-falling stroke, and a dot.

The right piece, two strokes, read jǐ, as in the word for how many: a left-falling stroke down the left side, then one stroke that runs across the top, turns down, bends right along the bottom and hooks up.

4 + 2 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 机, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 机? (**Two** — the tree piece, then jǐ.) Which character you know has the same tree piece? (想.) How does the last stroke end? (**It runs along the bottom and hooks up**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 机, pinned stroke paths and medians.

58.3 bāo — bag

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for here, then the Mandarin for mobile phone.

You'll want to know: bāo

bāo — "bag".

wǒ xiǎng mǎi yí ge bāo — I'd like to buy a bag.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bāo is inherited from Middle Chinese *paew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to wrap'. The sense 'bag' is not given there; a thing that wraps is the likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: bāo*
- *Say it: bāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng mǎi yí ge bāo* — I'd like to buy a bag.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for here, then the Mandarin for mobile phone, then say *bāo* again

Before you move on

What does bāo mean? ("Bag".) Say it once more.

58.4 diànnǎo — computer

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for mobile phone, then the Mandarin for bag.

You'll want to know: diànnǎo

diànnǎo — "computer".

wǒ xǐhuan wán diànnǎo — I like playing on the computer.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diànnǎo is built from diàn 'lightning', now 'electricity', and nǎo 'brain', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *denH* and *nawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): an electric brain.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: diànnǎo*
- *Say it: diànnǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan wán diànnǎo* — I like playing on the computer.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for mobile phone, then the Mandarin for bag, then say *diànnǎo* again

Before you move on

What does diànnǎo mean? ("Computer".) Say it once more.

58.5 bēizi — cup; glass

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bag, then the Mandarin for computer.

You'll want to know: bēizi

bēizi — "cup; glass".

zhè shì nǐ de bēizi ma — Is this your cup?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bēizi is built from bēi and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pwoj* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary explains the first, through an older book, as a kind of vessel.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: bēizi*
- *Say it: bēizi*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì nǐ de bēizi ma* — Is this your cup?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bag, then the Mandarin for computer, then say *bēizi* again

Before you move on

What does bēizi mean? ("Cup; glass".) Say it once more.

58.6 yīfu — clothes

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for computer, then the Mandarin for cup.

You'll want to know: yīfu

yīfu — "clothes".

wǒ xǐhuan mǎi yīfu — I love buying clothes.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yīfu is built from yī and fu, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'j+j* and *bjuwk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as the garment worn on the upper body, and lists 'clothes' among the senses of the second.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīfu*
- *Say it: yīfu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan mǎi yīfu* — I love buying clothes.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for computer, then the Mandarin for cup, then say *yīfu* again

Before you move on

What does yīfu mean? ("Clothes".) Say it once more.

Chapter 59

Clothes

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I wear: shoes, a hat and trousers, and that they look nice.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 59: I can say what I wear: shoes, a hat and trousers, and that they look nice.*

59.1 chuān — to wear; to put on

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cup, then the Mandarin for clothes.

You'll want to know: chuān

chuān — "to wear; to put on".

> *míngtiān nǐ chuān shénme* — What are you wearing tomorrow?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chuān is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyhwen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to go through' and 'a hole'. Wearing is not given there; putting arms and legs through clothes is the usual explanation, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chuān*
- *Say it: chuān*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān nǐ chuān shénme* — What are you wearing tomorrow?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cup, then the Mandarin for clothes, then say *chuān* again

Before you move on

What does chuān mean? ("To wear; to put on".) Say it once more.

59.2 xié — shoe

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for clothes, then the Mandarin for to wear.

You'll want to know: xié

xié — "shoe".

wǒ de jiǎo hěn dà xié hěn xiǎo — My feet are big and the shoes are small.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xié is inherited from Middle Chinese *heaj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'shoe'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xié*
- *Say it: xié*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de jiǎo hěn dà xié hěn xiǎo* — My feet are big and the shoes are small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for clothes, then the Mandarin for to wear, then say *xié* again

Before you move on

What does xié mean? ("Shoe".) Say it once more.

59.3 màozi — hat; cap

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to wear, then the Mandarin for shoe.

You'll want to know: màozi

màozi — "hat; cap".

wǒ de tóu hěn dà màozi tài xiǎo le — My head's big; the hat is too small.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

màozi is built from mào and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mawH* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a covering for the head.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: màozi*
- *Say it: màozi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de tóu hěn dà màozi tài xiǎo le* — My head's big; the hat is too small.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to wear, then the Mandarin for shoe, then say *màozi* again

Before you move on

What does màozi mean? ("Hat; cap".) Say it once more.

59.4 kùzi — trousers

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for shoe, then the Mandarin for hat.

You'll want to know: kùzi

kùzi — "trousers".

zhè shì wǒ gēge de kùzi — These are my brother's trousers.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kùzi is built from kù and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khuH* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary lists the first under a variant form of the character and explains it, through an older book, as a garment for the shins.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: kùzi*
- *Say it: kùzi*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ gēge de kùzi* — These are my brother's trousers.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for shoe, then the Mandarin for hat, then say *kùzi* again

Before you move on

What does kùzi mean? ("Trousers".) Say it once more.

59.5 piàoliang — pretty; good-looking

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hat, then the Mandarin for trousers.

You'll want to know: piàoliang

piàoliang — "pretty; good-looking".

tā de yǎnjing hěn piàoliang — She has beautiful eyes.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

piàoliang is built from piào and liang, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *phjiewH* and *ljangH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as beating silk floss in water and the second as 'bright'; how the pair came to mean pretty is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: piàoliang*
- *Say it: piàoliang*, once more
- *Say it: tā de yǎnjing hěn piàoliang* — She has beautiful eyes.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hat, then the Mandarin for trousers, then say *piàoliang* again

Before you move on

What does piàoliang mean? ("Pretty; good-looking".) Say it once more.

Chapter 60

Colours

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name white, red, black and blue, and ask about colours.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 60: I can name white, red, black and blue, and ask about colours.*

60.1 白 (bái) — white; pale

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for trousers, then the Mandarin for pretty.

You'll want to know: 白

白 — *bái* — "white; pale".

> 他的手很白 *tā de shǒu hěn bái* — His hands are very pale.

The new character, in pieces: 白 — a short fall on top of 日. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

白 (*bái*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *baek* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the colour of the west', the direction that the old scheme of five colours paired with white.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: bái*
- *Say it: bái*, once more
- *Say it: tā de shǒu hěn bái* — His hands are very pale.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for trousers, then the Mandarin for pretty, then say *bái* again

Before you move on

What does 白 mean? ("White; pale".) Say it once more.

60.2 白 — a short fall over 日

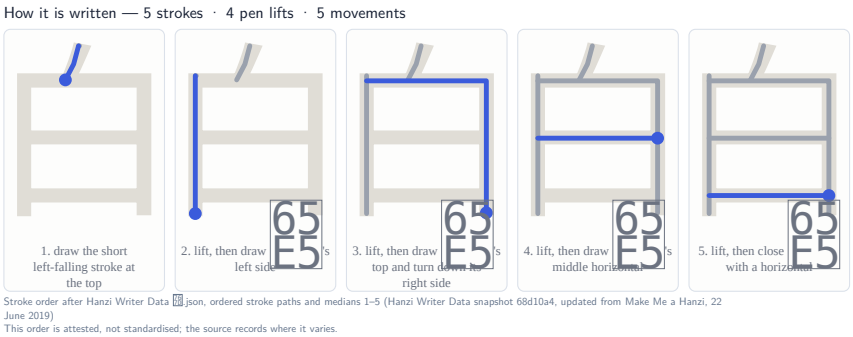
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *bái* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

日 百

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *bǎi*

Script — a short fall over 日



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–5 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 白 is written, stroke by stroke

白

Two pieces, top to bottom.
A short left-falling stroke at the top, from the right down to the left.
日, four strokes, the same four your hand makes in 日: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, the middle bar, and the bar that closes the bottom.
1 + 4 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 白, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 白? (**Five**.) What comes before 日? (**A short fall at the top**.) Which number you know has 白 under its top bar? (百.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 白, pinned stroke paths and medians.

60.3 yánsè — colour

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pretty, then the Mandarin for white.

You'll want to know: yánsè

yánsè — "colour".

wǒ ài zhège yánsè — I love this colour.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yánsè is built from yán 'face' and sè, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngaen* and *srik* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the second with the whole word, 'colour'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yánsè*
- *Say it: yánsè*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ ài zhège yánsè* — I love this colour.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pretty, then the Mandarin for white, then say *yánsè* again

Before you move on

What does yánsè mean? ("Colour".) Say it once more.

60.4 hóng — red

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for white, then the Mandarin for colour.

You'll want to know: hóng

hóng — "red".

zhège píngguǒ hěn hóng — This apple is really red.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hóng is inherited from Middle Chinese *huwng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a colour'; which colour is not said there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: hóng*
- *Say it: hóng*, once more
- *Say it: zhège píngguǒ hěn hóng* — This apple is really red.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for white, then the Mandarin for colour, then say *hóng* again

Before you move on

What does hóng mean? ("Red".) Say it once more.

60.5 hēi — black; dark

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for colour, then the Mandarin for red.

You'll want to know: hēi

hēi — "black; dark".

nàge fángjiān hěn hēi — That room is dark.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hēi is inherited from Middle Chinese *xok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the colour of the north', which the old scheme of five colours paired with black.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: hēi*
- *Say it: hēi*, once more
- *Say it: nàge fángjiān hěn hēi* — That room is dark.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for colour, then the Mandarin for red, then say *hēi* again

Before you move on

What does hēi mean? ("Black; dark".) Say it once more.

60.6 lán — blue

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for red, then the Mandarin for black.

You'll want to know: lán

lán — "blue".

tā de yǎnjing hěn lán — Her eyes are very blue.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lán is inherited from Middle Chinese *lam* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a plant for dye'. The colour is not given there; blue as the colour of that dye is the likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: lán*
- *Say it: lán*, once more

- *Say it: tā de yǎnjing hěn lán* — Her eyes are very blue.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for red, then the Mandarin for black, then say *lán* again

Before you move on

What does lán mean? (“Blue”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 61

Long and Short

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say long, short, tall, short of height, and new.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 61: I can say long, short, tall, short of height, and new.*

61.1 长 (cháng) — long

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for black, then the Mandarin for blue.

You'll want to know: 长

长 — *cháng* — "long".

> *jīntiān de diànyǐng hěn cháng* — Today's film is a long one.

The new character, in pieces: 长 — four strokes: a short fall, a long bar, a vertical that flicks up at the foot, and a sweep down to the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

长 (*cháng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *drjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'lasting', 'far' and 'for ever'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: cháng*
- *Say it: cháng*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān de diànyǐng hěn cháng* — Today's film is a long one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for black, then the Mandarin for blue, then say *cháng* again

Before you move on

What does 长 mean? ("Long".) Say it once more.

61.2 长 — four strokes in one piece

The word first, then the character inside it.

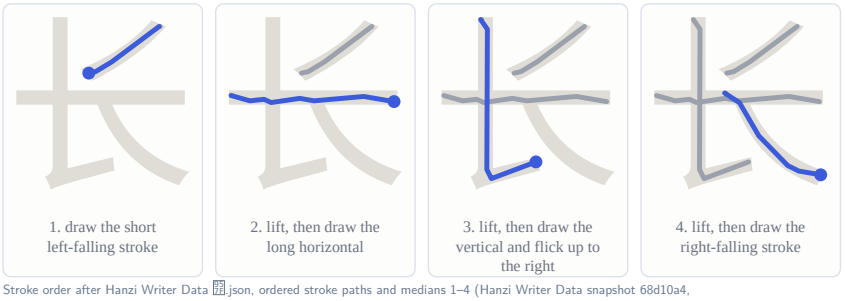
- *Recall:* say *cháng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

大 八

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *dà*, *bā*

Script — four strokes in one piece

How it is written — 4 strokes · 3 pen lifts · 4 movements



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data .json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–4 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 长 is written, stroke by stroke

长

One piece, four strokes.
A short left-falling stroke at the top right, falling toward the left.
A long horizontal across the middle.
A vertical from the top left, down through the bar, that turns and flicks up to the right at the foot.
A long stroke falling to the right, from the bar down to the bottom right.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 长, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 长? (**Four**.) Which stroke flicks up at the foot? (**The vertical, the third**.) Which way does the last one fall? (**Down to the right**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 长, pinned stroke paths and medians.

61.3 duǎn — short in length; brief

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for blue, then the Mandarin for long.

You'll want to know: duǎn

duǎn — "short in length; brief".

wǒ de kùzi hěn duǎn — My trousers are short.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

duǎn is inherited from Middle Chinese *twanX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'hurried' and 'not long'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: duǎn*
- *Say it: duǎn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de kùzi hěn duǎn* — My trousers are short.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for blue, then the Mandarin for long, then say *duǎn* again

Before you move on

What does duǎn mean? ("Short in length; brief".) Say it once more.

61.4 gāo — tall; high

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for long, then the Mandarin for short in length.

You'll want to know: gāo

gāo — "tall; high".

wǒ gēge hěn gāo tā xǐhuan yùndòng — My brother is tall, and he loves sport.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gāo is inherited from Middle Chinese *kaw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'up', 'lofty' and 'far'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: gāo*
- *Say it: gāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ gēge hěn gāo tā xǐhuan yùndòng* — My brother is tall, and he loves sport.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for long, then the Mandarin for short in length, then say *gāo* again

Before you move on

What does gāo mean? ("Tall; high".) Say it once more.

61.5 ǎi — short in height; low

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for short in length, then the Mandarin for tall.

You'll want to know: ǎi

ǎi — "short in height; low".

wǒ mèimei hěn ǎi — My little sister is short.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ǎi is inherited from Middle Chinese *'eaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'short to look at'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: ǎi*
- *Say it: ǎi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ mèimei hěn ǎi* — My little sister is short.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for short in length, then the Mandarin for tall, then say *ǎi* again

Before you move on

What does ǎi mean? ("Short in height; low".) Say it once more.

61.6 xīn — new

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for tall, then the Mandarin for short in height.

You'll want to know: xīn

xīn — "new".

zhè shì wǒ de xīn shǒujī — This is my new phone.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xīn is inherited from Middle Chinese *sin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'new, as against old'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīn*
- *Say it: xīn*, once more

- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de xīn shǒujī* — This is my new phone.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for tall, then the Mandarin for short in height, then say *xīn* again

Before you move on

What does xīn mean? (“New”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 62

Fast, Far and Near

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say fast, old, far and near, and say that I know something.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 62: I can say fast, old, far and near, and say that I know something.*

62.1 快 (kuài) — fast; quick

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for short in height, then the Mandarin for new.

You'll want to know: 快

快 — *kuài* — "fast; quick".

> 我的手机很快 *wǒ de shǒujī hěn kuài* — My phone is fast.

The new character, in pieces: 快 — on the left the heart piece from the foot of 想, standing upright, and on the right a four-stroke piece read guài. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

快 (*kuài*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *khwaejH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to one's liking' and 'glad'. The sense 'fast' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: kuài*
- *Say it: kuài*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de shǒujī hěn kuài* — My phone is fast.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for short in height, then the Mandarin for new, then say *kuài* again

Before you move on

What does 快 mean? ("Fast; quick".) Say it once more.

62.2 快 — the upright heart, then guài

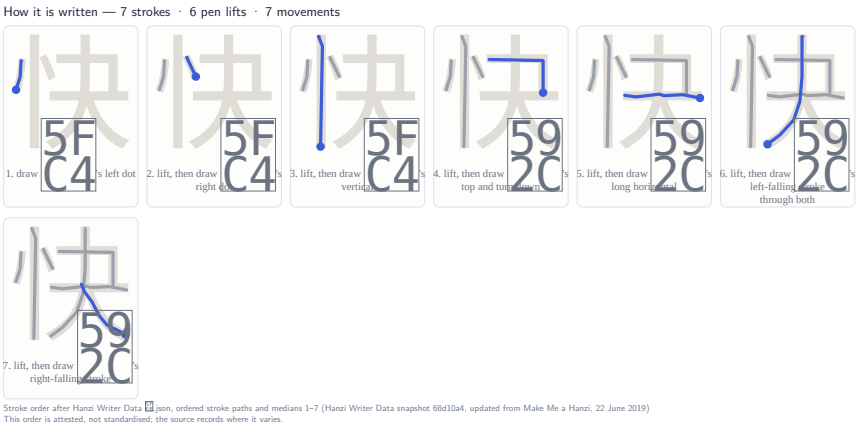
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *kuài* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  想 大

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *xiǎng*, *dà*

Script — the upright heart, then guài



How 快 *is written, stroke by stroke*

快

Two pieces, left before right.

The upright heart piece, three strokes: a short dot on the left, a short dot on the right, then a long vertical down between them: the heart piece from the foot of 想, standing upright.

The right piece, four strokes, read guài: a horizontal that turns down at its right end, a long horizontal across, a long left-falling stroke from the top down through the bars, and a stroke falling to the right.

3 + 4 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 快, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 快? (**Two**.) Which dot comes first? (**The left one**.) How many strokes on the right side? (**Four**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 快, pinned stroke paths and medians.

62.3 jiù — old (of things); no longer new

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for new, then the Mandarin for fast.

You'll want to know: jiù

jiù — "old (of things); no longer new".

wǒ de chē hěn jiù — My car is old.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiù is inherited from Middle Chinese *gjuwH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'former, of old'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiù*
- *Say it: jiù*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de chē hěn jiù* — My car is old.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for new, then the Mandarin for fast, then say *jiù* again

Before you move on

What does jiù mean? ("Old (of things); no longer new".) Say it once more.

62.4 yuǎn — far

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for fast, then the Mandarin for no longer new.

You'll want to know: yuǎn

yuǎn — "far".

Běijīng hěn yuǎn — Beijing is a long way away.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yuǎn is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjwonX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'distant'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yuǎn*
- *Say it: yuǎn*, once more
- *Say it: Běijīng hěn yuǎn* — Beijing is a long way away.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for fast, then the Mandarin for no longer new, then say *yuǎn* again

Before you move on

What does yuǎn mean? ("Far".) Say it once more.

62.5 jìn — near; close

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for no longer new, then the Mandarin for far.

You'll want to know: jìn

jìn — "near; close".

wǒ jiā hěn jìn — My home is close by.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jìn is inherited from Middle Chinese *gj+nX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'pressing close' and 'almost'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: jìn*
- *Say it: jìn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā hěn jìn* — My home is close by.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for no longer new, then the Mandarin for far, then say *jìn* again

Before you move on

What does jìn mean? ("Near; close".) Say it once more.

62.6 zhīdào — to know a fact; to be aware

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for far, then the Mandarin for near.

You'll want to know: zhīdào

zhīdào — "to know a fact; to be aware".

wǒ zhīdào nǐ xiǎng shuō shénme — I know what you want to say.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhīdào is built from zhī 'to perceive' and dào 'the way', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *trje* and *dawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How the pair came to mean knowing a fact is not

settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhīdào*
- *Say it: zhīdào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zhīdào nǐ xiǎng shuō shénme* — I know what you want to say.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for far, then the Mandarin for near, then say *zhīdào* again

Before you move on

What does zhīdào mean? ("To know a fact; to be aware".) Say it once more.

Chapter 63

On the Phone

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer the phone, ask for a number and say what I am looking for.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 63: I can answer the phone, ask for a number and say what I am looking for.*

63.1 电话 (diànhuà) — telephone; phone call

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for near, then the Mandarin for to know a fact.

You'll want to know: 电话

电话 — *diànhuà* — "telephone; phone call".

> **你有电话吗** *nǐ yǒu diànhuà ma* — Have you got a phone?

The new character, in pieces: **电** — **日** with one long stroke running down through its middle, bending right along the bottom and hooking up. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

电话 (*diànhuà*) is built from **电** 'lightning', now 'electricity', and **话** 'talk', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *denH* and *hwaejH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): electric talk.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: diànhuà*
- *Say it: diànhuà*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yǒu diànhuà ma* — Have you got a phone?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for near, then the Mandarin for to know a fact, then say *diànhuà* again

Before you move on

What does 电话 mean? ("Telephone; phone call".) Say it once more.

63.2 电 — 日 with a long tail

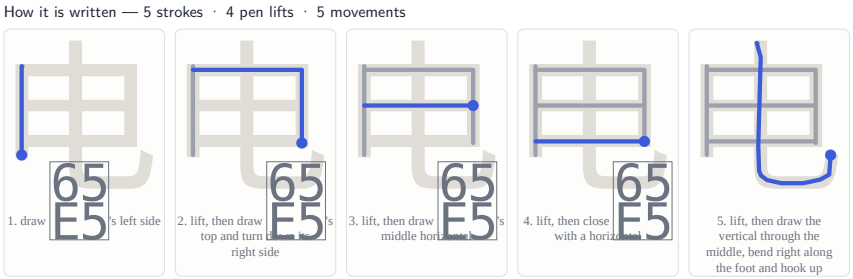
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *diànhuà* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 话

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *huà*

Script — 日 with a long tail



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–5 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 电 is written, stroke by stroke

电

Two parts: the box first, then the tail.

日, four strokes: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, the middle bar, and the bottom bar.

The tail, one stroke: from above the top of the box, a vertical straight down through the middle, bending right along the bottom and hooking up at the end.

4 + 1 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 电, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 电? (**Five**.) Which character you know is inside it? (日.) Where does the last stroke start? (**Above the box, and it runs down through the middle**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 电, pinned stroke paths and medians.

63.3 打电话 (dǎ diànhuà) — to phone; to make a phone call

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to know a fact, then the Mandarin for telephone.

You'll want to know: 打电话

打电话 — *dǎ diànhuà* — "to phone; to make a phone call".

我想打电话 *wǒ xiǎng dǎ diànhuà* — I'd like to make a phone call.

The new character, in pieces: 打 — the hand piece, a narrow 手, on the left, and on the right a two-stroke piece read dīng. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

打电话 (*dǎ diànhuà*) is built from dǎ 'to strike' and 电话 'telephone'. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *taengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to strike', though dǎ is not the sound *taengX* would regularly give. Making a call is not among its senses there, so how the verb came to do it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎ diànhuà*
- *Say it: dǎ diànhuà*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng dǎ diànhuà* — I'd like to make a phone call.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to know a fact, then the Mandarin for telephone, then say *dǎ diànhuà* again

Before you move on

What does 打电话 mean? ("To phone; to make a phone call".) Say it once more.

63.4 打 — the hand piece, then dīng

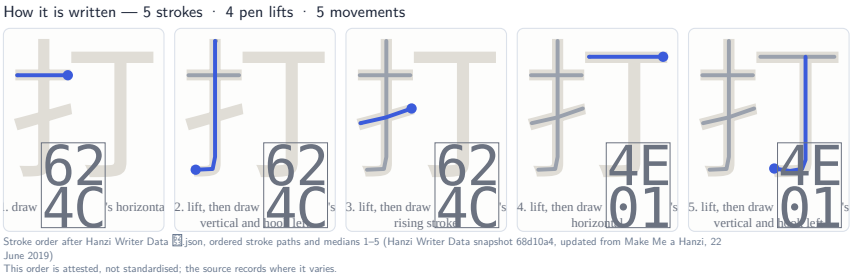
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *dǎ diànhuà* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  手 电

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shǒu*, *diàn*

Script — the hand piece, then dīng



How 打 *is written, stroke by stroke*

打

Two pieces, left before right.

The hand piece, three strokes, a narrow form of 手: a short horizontal, a vertical through it that hooks to the left at the foot, then a stroke that rises from the lower left up across the vertical.

The right piece, two strokes, read dīng: a horizontal across the top, then a vertical down from its middle that hooks to the left.

3 + 2 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 打, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 打? (**Two**.) Which character you know is the hand piece a narrow form of? (手.) Which way does the rising stroke run? (**From the lower left up to the right**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 打, pinned stroke paths and medians.

63.5 wéi — hello on the phone

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for telephone, then the Mandarin for to phone.

You'll want to know: wéi

wéi — "hello on the phone".

> *wéi nǐ tīng wǒ shuō* — Hello? Listen to me.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
On the phone it is said with a rising tone, as a question: wéi?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wéi is the call you answer the phone with. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: wéi*
- *Say it: wéi*, once more
- *Say it: wéi nǐ tīng wǒ shuō* — Hello? Listen to me.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for telephone, then the Mandarin for to phone, then say *wéi* again

Before you move on

What does wéi mean? ("Hello on the phone".) Say it once more.

63.6 hàomǎ — number (of a phone, a room); identifying number

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to phone, then the Mandarin for hello on the phone.

You'll want to know: hàomǎ

hàomǎ — "number (of a phone, a room); identifying number".

> *nǐ de diànhuà hàomǎ shì duōshao* — What's your phone number?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hàomǎ is built from hào and mǎ, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hawH* and *maeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as a call or a command and the second as agate, a stone like jade; how the pair came to mean a number is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: hàomǎ*
- *Say it: hàomǎ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ de diànhuà hàomǎ shì duōshao* — What's your phone number?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to phone, then the Mandarin for hello on the phone, then say *hàomǎ* again

Before you move on

What does hàomǎ mean? ("Number (of a phone, a room); identifying number".) Say it once more.

63.7 zhǎo — to look for

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hello on the phone, then the Mandarin for identifying number.

You'll want to know: zhǎo

zhǎo — "to look for".

nǐ zhǎo shénme — What are you looking for?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǎo is the everyday verb for looking for something. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǎo*
- *Say it: zhǎo*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ zhǎo shénme* — What are you looking for?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hello on the phone, then the Mandarin for identifying number, then say *zhǎo* again

Before you move on

What does zhǎo mean? ("To look for".) Say it once more.

63.8 Looking back: from Things You Carry to On the Phone

Say the Mandarin for mobile phone and bag.

Your turn

- *Say it:* mobile phone, bag, computer, cup, clothes
- *Say it:* to wear, shoe, hat, trousers, pretty

- *Say it:* white, colour, red, black, blue
- *Say it:* long, short in length, tall, short in height, new
- *Say it:* fast, no longer new, far, near, to know a fact
- *Say it:* telephone, to phone, hello on the phone, identifying number, to look for
- *Read it:* 机 白 长 快 电 打 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Mobile phone? (手机, *shǒujī.*) Bag? (*bāo.*) Computer? (*diànnǎo.*) Cup? (*bēizi.*) Clothes? (*yīfu.*) To wear? (*chuān.*) Shoe? (*xié.*) Hat? (*màozi.*) Trousers? (*kùzi.*) Pretty? (*piàoliang.*) White? (白, *bái.*) Colour? (*yánsè.*) Red? (*hóng.*) Black? (*hēi.*) Blue? (*lán.*) Long? (长, *cháng.*) Short in length? (*duǎn.*) Tall? (*gāo.*) Short in height? (*ǎi.*) New? (*xīn.*) Fast? (快, *kuài.*) No longer new? (*jiù.*) Far? (*yuǎn.*) Near? (*jìn.*) To know a fact? (*zhīdào.*) Telephone? (电话, *diànhuà.*) To phone? (打电话, *dǎ diànhuà.*) Hello on the phone? (*wéi.*) Identifying number? (*hàomǎ.*) To look for? (*zhǎo.*)

Chapter 64

Asking for Help

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say sorry, ask for help, borrow something and give it back.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 64: I can say sorry, ask for help, borrow something and give it back.*

64.1 对不起 (duìbuqǐ) — sorry

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for identifying number, then the Mandarin for to look for.

You'll want to know: 对不起

对不起 — *duìbuqǐ* — "sorry".

> *duìbuqǐ wǒ bù dǒng nǐ de huà* — Sorry, I don't understand what you're saying.

The new character, in pieces: 起 — the walking piece read zǒu along the left and the bottom, carrying a three-stroke piece read jǐ, 'self', on its back: not the jǐ of 机. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

Its middle syllable loses its tone: duìbuqǐ, with bu light between two full syllables.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

对不起 (*duìbuqǐ*) is built from 对 'to answer, to match', 不 'not' and 起 'to rise', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *twojH*, *pjut* and *khiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). 'Not able to face you' is the usual explanation, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: duìbuqǐ*
- *Say it: duìbuqǐ*, once more
- *Say it: duìbuqǐ wǒ bù dǒng nǐ de huà* — Sorry, I don't understand what you're saying.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for identifying number, then the Mandarin for to look for, then say *duìbuqǐ* again

Before you move on

What does 对不起 mean? ("Sorry".) Say it once more.

64.2 起 — the walking piece, carrying jǐ

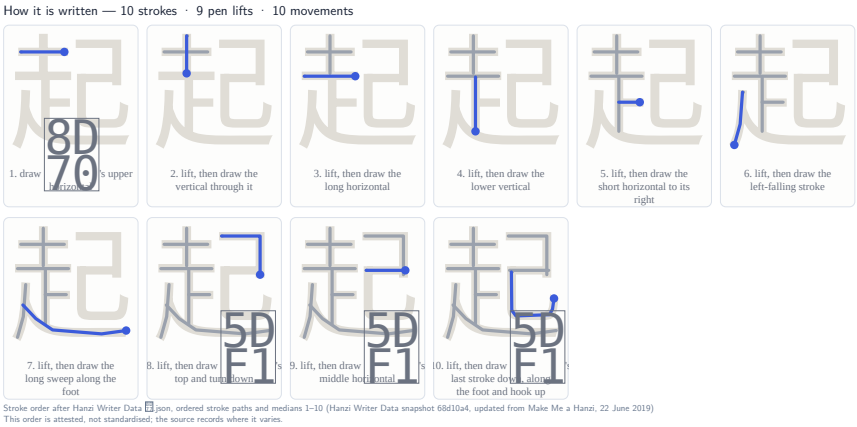
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *duìbuqǐ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  对 不

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *duì*, *bù*

Script — the walking piece, carrying jǐ



How 起 *is written, stroke by stroke*

起

Two pieces: the walking piece first, then the piece on its back.

The walking piece, seven strokes, read zǒu, as in the word for to walk: a short horizontal, a vertical down through it, a longer horizontal; then below, a short vertical with a short bar to its right, a left-falling stroke, and last a long stroke that sweeps right along the whole bottom.

The right piece, three strokes, read jǐ, 'self', not the jǐ of 机, sitting on the sweep: a horizontal that turns down, a short horizontal, then a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up.

7 + 3 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 起, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 起? (**Two** — the walking piece and jǐ.) Which stroke runs under the whole character? (**The long sweep, the seventh.**) Which character comes before it in 对不起? (不.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 起, pinned stroke paths and medians.

64.3 bāng — to help

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to look for, then the Mandarin for sorry.

You'll want to know: bāng

bāng — "to help".

nǐ bāng wǒ xiě hǎo bu hǎo — Will you help me write it?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bāng is inherited from Middle Chinese *pang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to mend shoes'. The sense 'to help' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: bāng*
- *Say it: bāng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ bāng wǒ xiě hǎo bu hǎo* — Will you help me write it?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to look for, then the Mandarin for sorry, then say *bāng* again

Before you move on

What does bāng mean? ("To help".) Say it once more.

64.4 bāngmáng — to help out; to do a favour

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sorry, then the Mandarin for to help.

You'll want to know: bāngmáng

bāngmáng — "to help out; to do a favour".

wǒ xiǎng bāngmáng — I'd like to help.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bāngmáng is built from bāng 'to help' and máng 'busy', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pang* and *mang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses *mang* as 'afraid', so the sense busy is not given there; helping with what keeps somebody busy is the likely picture, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: bāngmáng*
- *Say it: bāngmáng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng bāngmáng* — I'd like to help.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sorry, then the Mandarin for to help, then say *bāngmáng* again

Before you move on

What does bāngmáng mean? ("To help out; to do a favour".) Say it once more.

64.5 jiè — to borrow; to lend

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to help, then the Mandarin for to do a favour.

You'll want to know: jiè

jiè — "to borrow; to lend".

wǒ jiè le tā de shū — I borrowed his book.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiè is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsjaeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to borrow'; today the same word also lends.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiè*
- *Say it: jiè*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiè le tā de shū* — I borrowed his book.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to help, then the Mandarin for to do a favour, then say *jiè* again

Before you move on

What does jiè mean? ("To borrow; to lend".) Say it once more.

64.6 huán — to give back

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to do a favour, then the Mandarin for to borrow.

You'll want to know: huán

huán — "to give back".

wǒ míngtiān huán nǐ — I'll give it back tomorrow.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The same character is read hái in hái xíng; here, giving something back, it is huán.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huán is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwaen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to return' and 'to go back'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: huán*
- *Say it: huán*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ míngtiān huán nǐ* — I'll give it back tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to do a favour, then the Mandarin for to borrow, then say *huán* again

Before you move on

What does huán mean? ("To give back".) Say it once more.

Chapter 65

Excuse Me

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say excuse me, ask politely, and ask somebody to open or shut something.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 65: I can say excuse me, ask politely, and ask somebody to open or shut something.*

65.1 门 (mén) — door; gate

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to borrow, then the Mandarin for to give back.

You'll want to know: 门

门 — *mén* — "door; gate".

> 这是我家的门 *zhè shì wǒ jiā de mén* — This is the door to my home.

The new character, in pieces: 门 — a dot, a post down the left, and a frame that turns down the right and hooks: the right-hand piece of 们. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

门 (*mén*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *mwon* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary says its old character is made of two door leaves.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: mén*
- *Say it: mén*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ jiā de mén* — This is the door to my home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to borrow, then the Mandarin for to give back, then say *mén* again

Before you move on

What does 门 mean? ("Door; gate".) Say it once more.

65.2 门 — a dot, a post, a frame

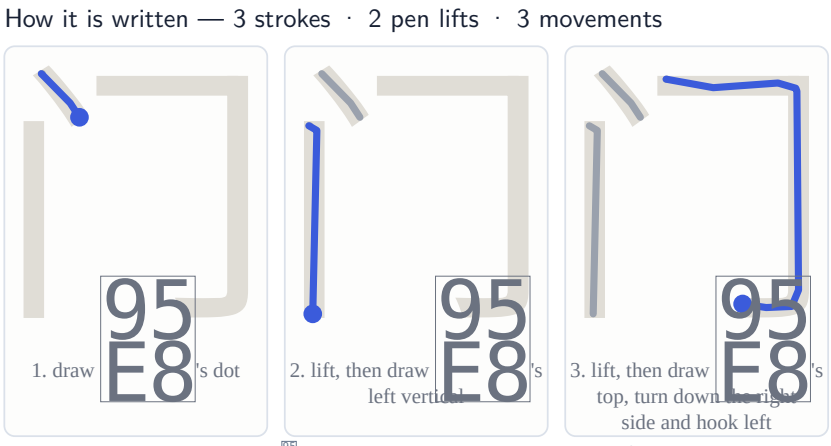
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *mén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  们 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *men*, *kǒu*

Script — a dot, a post, a frame



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 95E8.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 丶冂 is written, stroke by stroke

丶冂

One piece, three strokes, the same three as on the right of 冏.
A dot at the top left.
A vertical down the left side, the door post.
A horizontal that turns down the right side and hooks to the left at the foot.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 丶冂, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 丶冂? (**Three**.) Which character you know has it on the right? (冏.) How does the last stroke end? (**It hooks to the left**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 门, pinned stroke paths and medians.

65.3 请问 (qǐngwèn) — excuse me, may I ask

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to give back, then the Mandarin for door.

You'll want to know: 请问

请问 — *qǐngwèn* — "excuse me, may I ask".

请问这是你的手机吗 *qǐngwèn zhè shì nǐ de shǒujī ma* — Excuse me, is this your phone?

The new character, in pieces: 问 — 门 with 口 inside it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

请问 (*qǐngwèn*) is built from 请 'please' and 问 'to ask', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tshjengX* and *mjunH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary already glosses the first as 'to beg, to ask'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: qǐngwèn*
- *Say it: qǐngwèn*, once more
- *Say it: qǐngwèn zhè shì nǐ de shǒujī ma* — Excuse me, is this your phone?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to give back, then the Mandarin for door, then say *qǐngwèn* again

Before you move on

What does 请问 mean? ("Excuse me, may I ask".) Say it once more.

65.4 问 — 门 with 口 inside

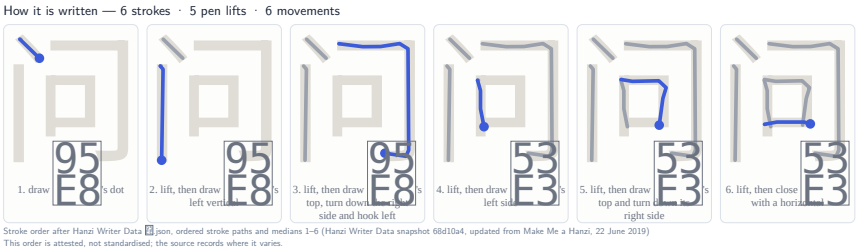
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *qǐngwèn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  门 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *mén*, *kǒu*

Script — 门 with 口 inside



How 问 *is written, stroke by stroke*

问

Two pieces: the door first, then the mouth inside it.

门**, three strokes**: the dot, the left post, the frame that turns down and hooks.

口**, three strokes**, small and inside: the left side, the top that turns down, the bottom that closes it.

3 + 3 = six, and both pieces are already yours.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 问, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 问? (**Two** — 门, then 口.) Which goes first? (门**, the frame**.) Where does 口 sit? (**Inside the door**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 问, pinned stroke paths and medians.

65.5 bù hǎoyìsi — excuse me; sorry to trouble you

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for door, then the Mandarin for may I ask.

You'll want to know: bù hǎoyìsi

bù hǎoyìsi — "excuse me; sorry to trouble you".

bù hǎoyìsi wǒ xiǎng wèn nǐ — Excuse me, could I ask you something?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

bù keeps its own falling tone here, because hǎo after it is a third tone, not a fourth.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bù hǎoyìsi is built from bù 'not', hǎo 'good' and yìsi 'meaning', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjut*, *xawX*, *'iH* and *si* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the last two as 'intention' and 'to think of'. 'Not a good feeling' is the literal sense; how it became an apology is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: bù hǎoyìsi*
- *Say it: bù hǎoyìsi*, once more
- *Say it: bù hǎoyìsi wǒ xiǎng wèn nǐ* — Excuse me, could I ask you something?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for door, then the Mandarin for may I ask, then say *bù hǎoyìsi* again

Before you move on

What does bù hǎoyìsi mean? ("Excuse me; sorry to trouble you".) Say it once more.

65.6 kāi — to open; to switch on

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for may I ask, then the Mandarin for excuse me.

You'll want to know: kāi

kāi — "to open; to switch on".

shāngdiàn jiǔ diǎn kāi — The shop opens at nine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kāi is inherited from Middle Chinese *khoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to open, to undo'.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: kāi*
- *Say it: kāi*, once more
- *Say it: shāngdiàn jiǔ diǎn kāi* — The shop opens at nine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for may I ask, then the Mandarin for excuse me, then say *kāi* again

Before you move on

What does kāi mean? ("To open; to switch on".) Say it once more.

65.7 guān — to shut; to close; to switch off

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for excuse me, then the Mandarin for to open.

You'll want to know: guān

guān — "to shut; to close; to switch off".

qǐng guān mén — Please shut the door.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guān is inherited from Middle Chinese *kwaen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains, through an older book, as a wooden bar held across a door. Shutting is probably what the bar does, but the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for asking politely.

Your turn

- *Say it: guān*
- *Say it: guān*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng guān mén* — Please shut the door.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for excuse me, then the Mandarin for to open, then say *guān* again

Before you move on

What does guān mean? ("To shut; to close; to switch off".) Say it once more.

Chapter 66

The Weather

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what the weather is like: rain, snow and wind.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 66: I can say what the weather is like: rain, snow and wind.*

66.1 天气 (tiānqì) — weather

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to open, then the Mandarin for to shut.

You'll want to know: 天气

天气 — *tiānqì* — "weather".

> 今天天气很好 *jīntiān tiānqì hěn hǎo* — The weather is lovely today.

The new character, in pieces: 气 — a short fall, two short bars, and a long stroke that turns, slants out and hooks. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

天气 (*tiānqì*) is built from 天 'sky' and 气 'breath', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *then* and *khj+jH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription): the breath of the sky.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: tiānqì*
- *Say it: tiānqì*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān tiānqì hěn hǎo* — The weather is lovely today.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to open, then the Mandarin for to shut, then say *tiānqì* again

Before you move on

What does 天气 mean? ("Weather".) Say it once more.

66.2 气 — a fall, two bars, a hook

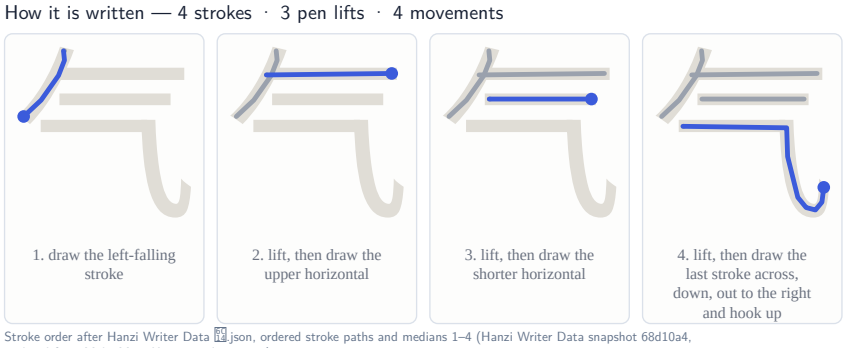
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *tiānqì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  天 手

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tiān*, *shǒu*

Script — a fall, two bars, a hook



How 气 is written, stroke by stroke

气

One piece, four strokes.
A short left-falling stroke at the top left.
Two short horizontals under it, the second a little lower and shorter.
A long horizontal that turns down, slants out to the right and hooks up at the end.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 气, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 气? (**Four**.) How many short bars? (**Two**.) How does the last stroke end? (**It slants out and hooks up**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 气, pinned stroke paths and medians.

66.3 雨 (yǔ) — rain

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to shut, then the Mandarin for weather.

You'll want to know: 雨

雨 — *yǔ* — "rain".

> 请问明天有雨吗 *qǐngwèn míngtiān yǒu yǔ ma* — Excuse me, will it rain tomorrow?

The new character, in pieces: 雨 — a lid, a frame with a line down its middle, and four drops inside. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

雨 (*yǔ*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjuX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary explains, through an older book, as water coming down from the clouds.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǔ*
- *Say it: yǔ*, once more
- *Say it: qǐngwèn míngtiān yǒu yǔ ma* — Excuse me, will it rain tomorrow?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to shut, then the Mandarin for weather, then say *yǔ* again

Before you move on

What does 雨 mean? ("Rain".) Say it once more.

66.4 雨 — a lid, a frame and four drops

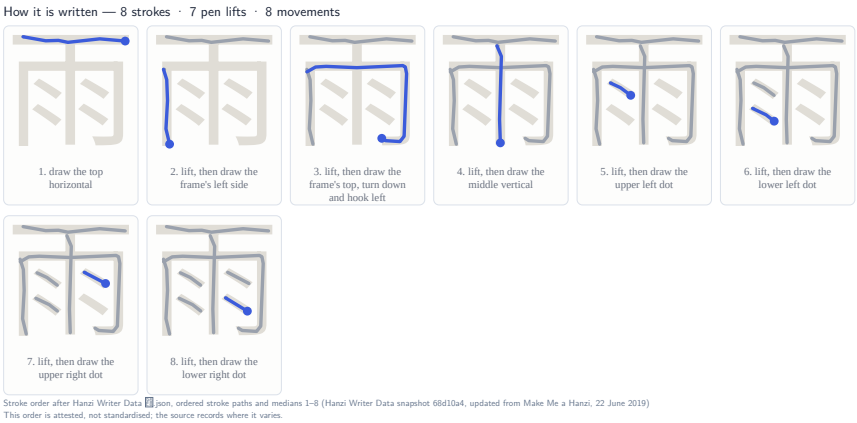
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yǔ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  天 气

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tiān*, *qì*

Script — a lid, a frame and four drops



How 雨 *is written, stroke by stroke*

雨

One piece, built from the top down.
A horizontal across the top, the lid.
A frame, two strokes: a short vertical down the left, then a horizontal that turns down the right side and hooks to the left.
A vertical down the middle from the lid.
Four dots, two on the left of the middle line, then two on the right.
1 + 2 + 1 + 4 = eight.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 雨, all eight, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 雨? (**Eight**.) What comes last? (**The four dots, the left pair first**.) Which stroke hooks? (**The right side of the frame**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 雨, pinned stroke paths and medians.

66.5 xiàyǔ — to rain

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for weather, then the Mandarin for rain.

You'll want to know: xiàyǔ

xiàyǔ — "to rain".

xiàyǔ wǒmen bù dǎqiú — It's raining, so we're not playing ball.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàyǔ is built from xià 'to come down' and 雨 'rain', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *hjuX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): rain comes down.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàyǔ*
- *Say it: xiàyǔ*, once more
- *Say it: xiàyǔ wǒmen bù dǎqiú* — It's raining, so we're not playing ball.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for weather, then the Mandarin for rain, then say *xiàyǔ* again

Before you move on

What does xiàyǔ mean? ("To rain".) Say it once more.

66.6 xuě — snow

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for rain, then the Mandarin for to rain.

You'll want to know: xuě

xuě — "snow".

> *xuě hěn dà wǒ de ěrduo hěn lěng* — It's snowing hard and my ears are freezing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xuě is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjwet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'frozen rain'.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: xuě*
- *Say it: xuě*, once more
- *Say it: xuě hěn dà wǒ de ěrduo hěn lěng* — It's snowing hard and my ears are freezing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for rain, then the Mandarin for to rain, then say *xuě* again

Before you move on

What does xuě mean? ("Snow".) Say it once more.

66.7 fēng — wind

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to rain, then the Mandarin for snow.

You'll want to know: fēng

fēng — "wind".

> *tiānqì bù hǎo fēng hěn dà* — The weather's bad: the wind is strong.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fēng is inherited from Middle Chinese *pjuwng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary quotes an old book calling the wind the messenger of sky and earth.

What you've built

One more word for saying how you are.

Your turn

- *Say it: fēng*
- *Say it: fēng*, once more
- *Say it: tiānqì bù hǎo fēng hěn dà* — The weather's bad: the wind is strong.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to rain, then the Mandarin for snow, then say *fēng* again

Before you move on

What does fēng mean? ("Wind".) Say it once more.

Chapter 67

Animals

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name horses, dogs, cats, birds and fish.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 67: I can name horses, dogs, cats, birds and fish.*

67.1 马 (mǎ) — horse

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for snow, then the Mandarin for wind.

You'll want to know: 马

马 — *mǎ* — "horse".

> 我喜欢白马 *wǒ xǐhuan bái mǎ* — I love white horses.

The new character, in pieces: 马 — a turn, a zigzag that hooks, and a bar along the bottom: the right-hand piece of 吗 and 妈. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

马 (*mǎ*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *maeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary explains its old character as the shape of a head, a mane, a tail and four legs.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǎ*
- *Say it: mǎ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan bái mǎ* — I love white horses.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for snow, then the Mandarin for wind, then say *mǎ* again

Before you move on

What does 马 mean? ("Horse".) Say it once more.

67.2 马 — a turn, a zigzag, a base

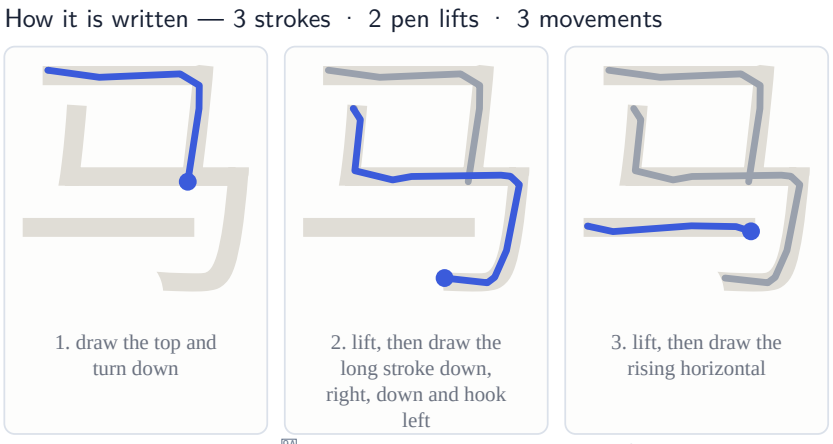
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *mǎ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  吗 妈

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *ma*, *mā*

Script — a turn, a zigzag, a base



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 马.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 马 is written, stroke by stroke

马

One piece, three strokes.

A horizontal that turns down at its right end.

A vertical that turns right, then turns down again and hooks to the left at the foot, all in one stroke.

A horizontal along the bottom, rising a little to the right.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 马, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 马? (**Three.**) Which stroke turns without lifting? (**The second.**) Which characters you know have it on the right? (**吗 and 妈.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 马, pinned stroke paths and medians.

67.3 gǒu — dog

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for wind, then the Mandarin for horse.

You'll want to know: gǒu

gǒu — "dog".

nǐ xǐhuan gǒu ma — Do you like dogs?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gǒu is inherited from Middle Chinese *kuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'dog'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: gǒu*
- *Say it: gǒu*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan gǒu ma* — Do you like dogs?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for wind, then the Mandarin for horse, then say *gǒu* again

Before you move on

What does gǒu mean? ("Dog".) Say it once more.

67.4 māo — cat

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for horse, then the Mandarin for dog.

You'll want to know: māo

māo — "cat".

wǒ jiā yǒu māo — We've got a cat at home.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

māo is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the animal that catches mice', though māo is not the sound *mjew* would regularly give.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: māo*
- *Say it: māo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā yǒu māo* — We've got a cat at home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for horse, then the Mandarin for dog, then say *māo* again

Before you move on

What does māo mean? ("Cat".) Say it once more.

67.5 niǎo — bird

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dog, then the Mandarin for cat.

You'll want to know: niǎo

niǎo — "bird".

wǒ xǐhuan kàn niǎo — I love watching birds.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

niǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *tewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed, through an older book, as the name for all long-tailed birds. Why the modern word begins with n is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: niǎo*
- *Say it: niǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan kàn niǎo* — I love watching birds.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dog, then the Mandarin for cat, then say *niǎo* again

Before you move on

What does niǎo mean? ("Bird".) Say it once more.

67.6 yú — fish

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cat, then the Mandarin for bird.

You'll want to know: yú

yú — "fish".

wǒ xǐhuan chī yú — I love eating fish.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yú is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngjo* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed, through an older book, as a water creature.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yú*
- *Say it: yú*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan chī yú* — I love eating fish.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cat, then the Mandarin for bird, then say *yú* again

Before you move on

What does yú mean? ("Fish".) Say it once more.

Chapter 68

Out of Town

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name mountains, stars, grass, flowers and the sun.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 68: I can name mountains, stars, grass, flowers and the sun.*

68.1 山 (shān) — mountain; hill

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bird, then the Mandarin for fish.

You'll want to know: 山

山 — *shān* — "mountain; hill".

> 我喜欢山 *wǒ xǐhuan shān* — I love the mountains.

The new character, in pieces: 山 — three peaks standing on one base. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

山 (*shān*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *srean* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary quotes an old book saying the mountain brings forth all things.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: shān*
- *Say it: shān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan shān* — I love the mountains.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bird, then the Mandarin for fish, then say *shān* again

Before you move on

What does 山 mean? ("Mountain; hill".) Say it once more.

68.2 山 — three peaks on a base

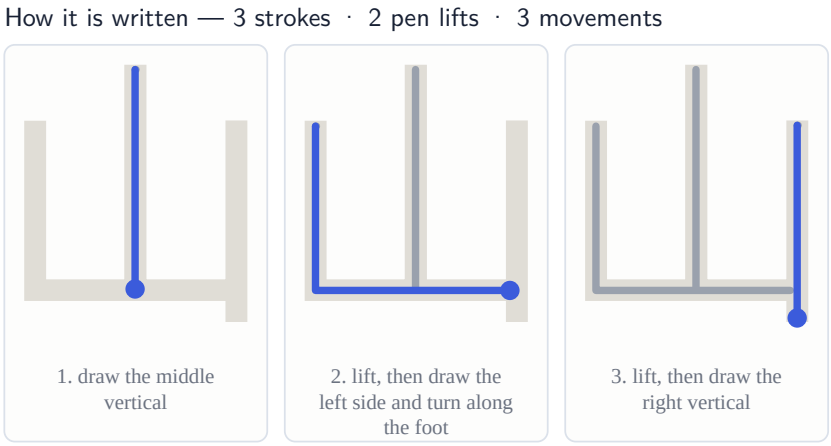
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

岁 中

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *suì*, *zhōng*

Script — three peaks on a base



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 59.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 山 is written, stroke by stroke

山

One piece, three strokes, the middle first.
The tall vertical in the middle.
A vertical down the left that turns and runs right along the bottom.
A vertical down the right, standing on the base.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 山, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 山? (**Three**.) Which stroke comes first? (**The middle one**.) Which character you know has it on top? (岁.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 山, pinned stroke paths and medians.

68.3 星星 (xīngxing) — star

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for fish, then the Mandarin for mountain.

You'll want to know: 星星

星星 — *xīngxing* — "star".

天气很好晚上有星星 *tiānqì hěn hǎo wǎnshang yǒu xīngxing* — Fine weather: there'll be stars tonight.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

星星 (*xīngxing*) is built from 星 'star' said twice, the second time light. 星 is inherited from Middle Chinese *seng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīngxing*
- *Say it: xīngxing*, once more
- *Say it: tiānqì hěn hǎo wǎnshang yǒu xīngxing* — Fine weather: there'll be stars tonight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for fish, then the Mandarin for mountain, then say *xīngxing* again

Before you move on

What does 星星 mean? ("Star".) Say it once more.

68.4 cǎo — grass

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for mountain, then the Mandarin for star.

You'll want to know: cǎo

cǎo — "grass".

zhèr de cǎo hěn gāo — The grass here is tall.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed, through an older book, as all the plants that grow.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: cǎo*
- *Say it: cǎo*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr de cǎo hěn gāo* — The grass here is tall.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for mountain, then the Mandarin for star, then say *cǎo* again

Before you move on

What does cǎo mean? ("Grass".) Say it once more.

68.5 huā — flower

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for star, then the Mandarin for grass.

You'll want to know: huā

huā — "flower".

māma xǐhuan huā — Mum loves flowers.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huā is inherited from Middle Chinese *xwae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary notes as the everyday form, in common use, of an older word for blossom.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: huā*
- *Say it: huā*, once more
- *Say it: māma xǐhuan huā* — Mum loves flowers.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for star, then the Mandarin for grass, then say *huā* again

Before you move on

What does huā mean? ("Flower".) Say it once more.

68.6 tàiyang — sun

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for grass, then the Mandarin for flower.

You'll want to know: tàiyang

tàiyang — "sun".

jīntiān de tàiyang hěn dà — The sun is strong today.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tàiyang is built from tài 'great' and yang, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *thajH* and *yang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the second as the yang of yin and yang, 'high and

bright': the great bright one.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: tàiyang*
- *Say it: tàiyang*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān de tàiyang hěn dà* — The sun is strong today.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for grass, then the Mandarin for flower, then say *tàiyang* again

Before you move on

What does tàiyang mean? ("Sun".) Say it once more.

Chapter 69

Meals

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the meals of the day, say who cooks and say it tastes good.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 69: I can name the meals of the day, say who cooks and say it tastes good.*

69.1 做饭 (zuòfàn) — to cook

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for flower, then the Mandarin for the sun.

You'll want to know: 做饭

做饭 — *zuòfàn* — "to cook".

> 我妈妈喜欢做饭 *wǒ māma xǐhuan zuòfàn* — My mum loves cooking.

The new character, in pieces: 做 — 亻 on the left, 十 over 口 in the middle, and on the right a four-stroke piece like a hand striking. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

做饭 (*zuòfàn*) is built from 做 'to do, to make' and 饭 'meal'. 饭 is inherited from Middle Chinese *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription); 做 has no reading in any dictionary we use, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuòfàn*
- *Say it: zuòfàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma xǐhuan zuòfàn* — My mum loves cooking.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for flower, then the Mandarin for the sun, then say *zuòfàn* again

Before you move on

What does 做饭 mean? ("To cook".) Say it once more.

69.2 做 — the person, gǔ, and a striking hand

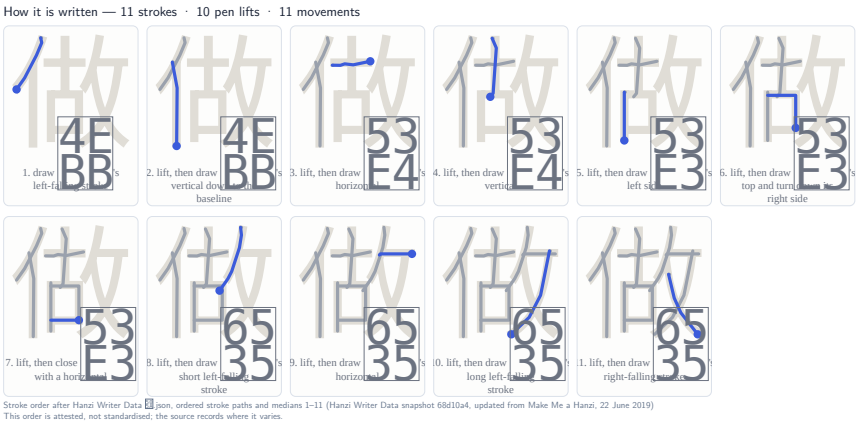
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *zuòfàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  他 十 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tā*, *shí*, *kǒu*

Script — the person, gǔ, and a striking hand



How 做 *is written, stroke by stroke*

做

Three pieces, left to right. Count three, not eleven.

亻**, two strokes**, as in 你 and 他.

The middle piece, five strokes, read gǔ: 十, a horizontal and a vertical, standing on a small 口.

The right piece, four strokes: a short left-falling stroke, a short horizontal, a long left-falling stroke, and a long stroke falling to the right.

2 + 5 + 4 = eleven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 做, all eleven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 做? (**Three.**) What sits in the middle? (**十 on 口.**) How does it end? (**With a stroke falling to the right.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 做, pinned stroke paths and medians.

69.3 早饭 (zǎofàn) — breakfast

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the sun, then the Mandarin for to cook.

You'll want to know: 早饭

早饭 — *zǎofàn* — "breakfast".

我七点吃早饭 *wǒ qī diǎn chī zǎofàn* — I have breakfast at seven.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

早饭 (*zǎofàn*) is built from zǎo 'morning' and 饭 'meal', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsawX* and *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zǎofàn*
- *Say it: zǎofàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qī diǎn chī zǎofàn* — I have breakfast at seven.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the sun, then the Mandarin for to cook, then say *zǎofàn* again

Before you move on

What does 早饭 mean? ("Breakfast".) Say it once more.

69.4 午饭 (wǔfàn) — lunch

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to cook, then the Mandarin for breakfast.

You'll want to know: 午饭

午饭 — *wǔfàn* — "lunch".

你吃午饭了吗 *nǐ chī wǔfàn le ma* — Have you had lunch?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

午饭 (*wǔfàn*) is built from 午 'noon' and 饭 'meal', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nguX* and *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǔfàn*
- *Say it: wǔfàn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ chī wǔfàn le ma* — Have you had lunch?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to cook, then the Mandarin for breakfast, then say *wǔfàn* again

Before you move on

What does 午饭 mean? ("Lunch".) Say it once more.

69.5 晚饭 (wǎnfàn) — dinner; supper

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for breakfast, then the Mandarin for lunch.

You'll want to know: 晚饭

晚饭 — *wǎnfàn* — "dinner; supper".

今天晚饭吃什么 *jīntiān wǎnfàn chī shénme* — What's for dinner tonight?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

晚饭 (*wǎnfàn*) is built from wǎn 'evening' and 饭 'meal', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mjonX* and *bjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǎnfàn*
- *Say it: wǎnfàn*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān wǎnfàn chī shénme* — What's for dinner tonight?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for breakfast, then the Mandarin for lunch, then say *wǎnfàn* again

Before you move on

What does 晚饭 mean? ("Dinner; supper".) Say it once more.

69.6 好吃 (hǎochī) — tasty; good to eat

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for lunch, then the Mandarin for dinner.

You'll want to know: 好吃

好吃 — *hǎochī* — "tasty; good to eat".

我妈妈做饭很好吃 *wǒ māma zuòfàn hěn hǎochī* — My mum's cooking is delicious.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好吃 (*hǎochī*) is built from 好 'good' and 吃 'to eat': good to eat. 好 is inherited from Middle Chinese *xawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); 吃 is probably the *khek* the dictionary writes with

another character and glosses 'to eat', though chī is not the sound *khek* would regularly give.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: hǎochī*
- *Say it: hǎochī*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma zuòfàn hěn hǎochī* — My mum's cooking is delicious.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for lunch, then the Mandarin for dinner, then say *hǎochī* again

Before you move on

What does 好吃 mean? ("Tasty; good to eat".) Say it once more.

69.7 Looking back: from Asking for Help to Meals

Say the Mandarin for sorry and to help.

Your turn

- *Say it:* sorry, to help, to do a favour, to borrow, to give back
- *Say it:* door, may I ask, excuse me, to open, to shut
- *Say it:* weather, rain, to rain, snow, wind
- *Say it:* horse, dog, cat, bird, fish
- *Say it:* mountain, star, grass, flower, the sun
- *Say it:* to cook, breakfast, lunch, dinner, tasty
- *Read it:* 起 门 问 气 雨 马 山 做 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Sorry? (对不起, *duìbuqǐ.*) To help? (*bāng.*) To do a favour? (*bāngmáng.*) To borrow? (*jiè.*) To give back? (*huán.*) Door? (门, *mén.*) May I ask? (请问, *qǐngwèn.*) Excuse me? (*bù hǎoyìsi.*) To open? (*kāi.*) To shut? (*guān.*) Weather? (天气, *tiānqì.*) Rain? (雨, *yǔ.*) To rain? (*xiàyǔ.*) Snow? (*xuě.*) Wind? (*fēng.*) Horse? (马, *mǎ.*) Dog? (*gǒu.*) Cat? (*māo.*) Bird? (*niǎo.*) Fish? (*yú.*) Mountain? (山, *shān.*) Star? (星星, *xīngxing.*) Grass? (*cǎo.*) Flower? (*huā.*) The sun? (*tàiyang.*) To cook? (做饭, *zuòfàn.*) Breakfast? (早饭, *zǎofàn.*) Lunch? (午饭, *wǔfàn.*) Dinner? (晚饭, *wǎnfàn.*) Tasty? (好吃, *hǎochī.*)

Chapter 70

More to Eat

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name meat, buns, noodles, dumplings and soup.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 70: I can name meat, buns, noodles, dumplings and soup.*

70.1 ròu — meat

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dinner, then the Mandarin for tasty.

You'll want to know: ròu

ròu — "meat".

> *wǒ bù chī ròu* — I don't eat meat.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ròu is inherited from Middle Chinese *nyuwk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed with the pair 'bone and flesh'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: ròu*
- *Say it: ròu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù chī ròu* — I don't eat meat.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dinner, then the Mandarin for tasty, then say *ròu* again

Before you move on

What does ròu mean? ("Meat".) Say it once more.

70.2 bāozi — steamed bun

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for tasty, then the Mandarin for meat.

You'll want to know: bāozi

bāozi — "steamed bun".

wǒ chī le sān ge bāozi — I ate three buns.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bāozi is built from bāo 'to wrap', the same bāo as the word for bag, and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *paew* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a filling wrapped in dough.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: bāozi*
- *Say it: bāozi*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ chī le sān ge bāozi* — I ate three buns.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for tasty, then the Mandarin for meat, then say *bāozi* again

Before you move on

What does bāozi mean? ("Steamed bun".) Say it once more.

70.3 miàntiáo — noodles

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for meat, then the Mandarin for steamed bun.

You'll want to know: miàntiáo

miàntiáo — "noodles".

wǒ xǐhuan chī miàntiáo — I love noodles.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

miàntiáo is built from miàn 'flour' and tiáo 'a twig, a strip', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *menH* and *dew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): strips of flour.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: miàntiáo*
- *Say it: miàntiáo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan chī miàntiáo* — I love noodles.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for meat, then the Mandarin for steamed bun, then say *miàntiáo* again

Before you move on

What does miàntiáo mean? (“Noodles”.) Say it once more.

70.4 jiǎozi — dumpling

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for steamed bun, then the Mandarin for noodles.

You’ll want to know: jiǎozi

jiǎozi — “dumpling”.

xīngqītiān wǒmen chī jiǎozi — We have dumplings on Sunday.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiǎozi is built from jiǎo and the noun ending zi, which is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription). The first has no reading in any dictionary we use, so its history is not settled.

What you’ve built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiǎozi*
- *Say it: jiǎozi*, once more
- *Say it: xīngqītiān wǒmen chī jiǎozi* — We have dumplings on Sunday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for steamed bun, then the Mandarin for noodles, then say *jiǎozi* again

Before you move on

What does jiǎozi mean? (“Dumpling”.) Say it once more.

70.5 tāng — soup

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for noodles, then the Mandarin for dumpling.

You'll want to know: tāng

tāng — "soup".

nǐ hē tāng ma — Would you like some soup?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tāng is inherited from Middle Chinese *thang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'hot water'. Soup is not given there; from hot water to soup is the likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: tāng*
- *Say it: tāng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ hē tāng ma* — Would you like some soup?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for noodles, then the Mandarin for dumpling, then say *tāng* again

Before you move on

What does tāng mean? ("Soup".) Say it once more.

Chapter 71

Tastes

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say a drink is nice, food is sweet, hot or salty, and order a meal.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 71: I can say a drink is nice, food is sweet, hot or salty, and order a meal.*

71.1 好喝 (hǎohē) — nice to drink

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dumpling, then the Mandarin for soup.

You'll want to know: 好喝

好喝 — *hǎohē* — "nice to drink".

> *zhèr de chá hěn hǎohē* — The tea here is lovely.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好喝 (*hǎohē*) is built from 好 'good' and 喝 'to drink', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xawX* and *xat* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as 'to shout at', and the drinking sense is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: hǎohē*
- *Say it: hǎohē*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr de chá hěn hǎohē* — The tea here is lovely.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dumpling, then the Mandarin for soup, then say *hǎohē* again

Before you move on

What does 好喝 mean? ("Nice to drink".) Say it once more.

71.2 tián — sweet

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for soup, then the Mandarin for nice to drink.

You'll want to know: tián

tián — "sweet".

nǐ de kāfēi hěn tián — Your coffee is very sweet.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tián is inherited from Middle Chinese *dem* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'sweet'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: tián*
- *Say it: tián*, once more

- *Say it: nǐ de kāfēi hěn tián* — Your coffee is very sweet.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for soup, then the Mandarin for nice to drink, then say *tián* again

Before you move on

What does tián mean? ("Sweet".) Say it once more.

71.3 là — spicy; hot

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for nice to drink, then the Mandarin for sweet.

You'll want to know: là

là — "spicy; hot".

zhèr de cài hěn là — The food here is really spicy.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

là is inherited from Middle Chinese *lat* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'pungent'; the dictionary writes it with a variant form of the character.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: là*
- *Say it: là*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr de cài hěn là* — The food here is really spicy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for nice to drink, then the Mandarin for sweet, then say *là* again

Before you move on

What does là mean? ("Spicy; hot".) Say it once more.

71.4 xián — salty

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sweet, then the Mandarin for spicy.

You'll want to know: xián

xián — "salty".

jīntiān de tāng hěn xián — Today's soup is salty.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xián is inherited from Middle Chinese *heam* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'not bland'; the dictionary writes it with the traditional form of the character.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: xián*
- *Say it: xián*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān de tāng hěn xián* — Today's soup is salty.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sweet, then the Mandarin for spicy, then say *xián* again

Before you move on

What does xián mean? ("Salty".) Say it once more.

71.5 diǎncài — to order food

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for spicy, then the Mandarin for salty.

You'll want to know: diǎncài

diǎncài — "to order food".

wǒ xiǎng diǎncài — I'd like to order.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diǎncài is built from 点 'a dot, to mark' and cài 'dish', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *temX* and *tshojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as any plant fit to eat. Marking the dishes you want is the likely picture, but the step is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: diǎncài*
- *Say it: diǎncài*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng diǎncài* — I'd like to order.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for spicy, then the Mandarin for salty, then say *diǎncài* again

Before you move on

What does diǎncài mean? ("To order food".) Say it once more.

Chapter 72

Getting About

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about trains, driving, planes, roads and arriving.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 72: I can talk about trains, driving, planes, roads and arriving.*

72.1 火车 (huǒchē) — train

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for salty, then the Mandarin for to order food.

You'll want to know: 火车

火车 — *huǒchē* — "train".

> 这儿的火车很长 *zhèr de huǒchē hěn cháng* — The trains here are long.

The new character, in pieces: 火 — a dot on each side, and 人 between them. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

火车 (*huǒchē*) is built from 火 'fire' and 车 'vehicle', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xwaX* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription): a fire carriage, from the days of steam.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: huǒchē*
- *Say it: huǒchē*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr de huǒchē hěn cháng* — The trains here are long.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for salty, then the Mandarin for to order food, then say *huǒchē* again

Before you move on

What does 火车 mean? ("Train".) Say it once more.

72.2 火 — two sparks around 人

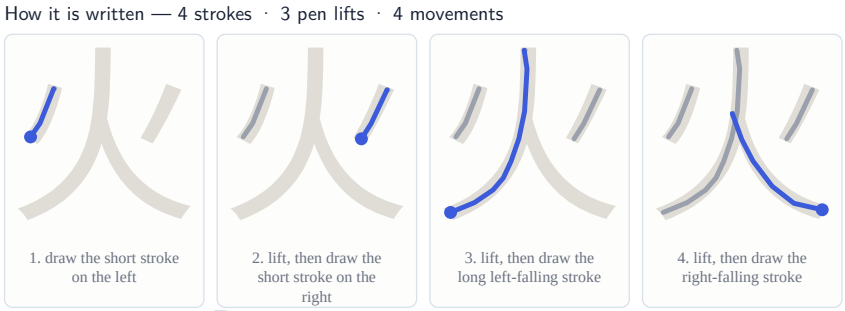
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *huǒchē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

人 大

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, *dà*

Script — two sparks around 人



How 火 is written, stroke by stroke

火

One piece, four strokes.

A short dot on the left, slanting down to the right.

A short left-falling stroke on the right, falling toward the middle.

人**, two strokes**: a long left-falling stroke from the top down to the lower left, then a long stroke falling to the right from its middle.

2 + 2 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 火, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 火? (**Four**.) Which character you know is its last two strokes? (人.) What comes first? (**The dot on the left**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 火, pinned stroke paths and medians.

72.3 开车 (kāichē) — to drive

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to order food, then the Mandarin for train.

You'll want to know: 开车

开车 — *kāichē* — "to drive".

> 明天我们开车去看山 *míngtiān wǒmen kāichē qù kàn shān* — Tomorrow we're driving out to see the mountains.

The new character, in pieces: 开 — two bars, with two legs down through them. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

开车 (*kāichē*) is built from 开 'to open' and 车 'vehicle', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khoj* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Driving is not among the senses of the first there; opening up, setting going, is the likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: kāichē*
- *Say it: kāichē*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān wǒmen kāichē qù kàn shān* — Tomorrow we're driving out to see the mountains.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to order food, then the Mandarin for train, then say *kāichē* again

Before you move on

What does 开车 mean? ("To drive".) Say it once more.

72.4 开 — two bars, two legs

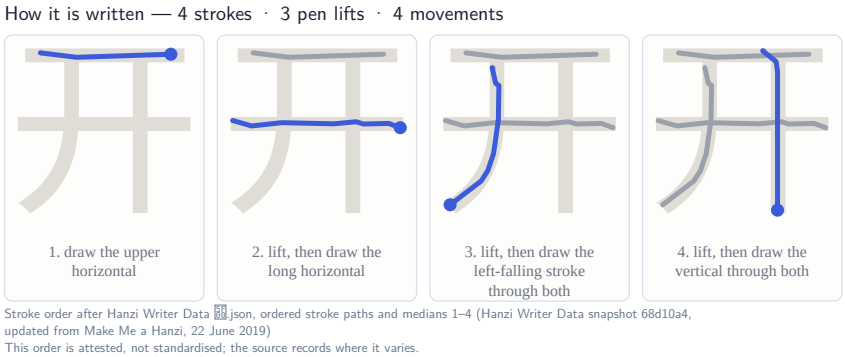
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *kāichē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

二 车

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *èr*, *chē*

Script — two bars, two legs



How 开 is written, stroke by stroke

开

One piece, four strokes, the bars first.
A short horizontal on top, then **a long horizontal** below it.
A left-falling stroke from the upper bar, down through the lower one to the bottom left.
A vertical on the right, straight down through both bars.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 开, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 开? (**Four**.) Which come first, the bars or the legs? (**The bars**.) Which leg is straight? (**The right one**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 开, pinned stroke paths and medians.

72.5 fēijī — aeroplane

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for train, then the Mandarin for to drive.

You'll want to know: fēijī

fēijī — "aeroplane".

wǒmen zuò fēijī qù Běijīng — We're flying to Beijing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fēijī is built from fēi 'to fly' and 机 'machine', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pj+j* and *kj+j* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a flying machine.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: fēijī*
- *Say it: fēijī*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen zuò fēijī qù Běijīng* — We're flying to Beijing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for train, then the Mandarin for to drive, then say *fēijī* again

Before you move on

What does fēijī mean? ("Aeroplane".) Say it once more.

72.6 lù — road; way

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to drive, then the Mandarin for aeroplane.

You'll want to know: lù

lù — "road; way".

lù hěn yuǎn — It's a long way.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lù is inherited from Middle Chinese *luH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'road'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: lù*
- *Say it: lù*, once more
- *Say it: lù hěn yuǎn* — It's a long way.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to drive, then the Mandarin for aeroplane, then say *lù* again

Before you move on

What does lù mean? ("Road; way".) Say it once more.

72.7 dào — to arrive; to reach

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for aeroplane, then the Mandarin for road.

You'll want to know: dào

dào — "to arrive; to reach".

huǒchē hěn màn shí diǎn dào — The train is slow; it gets in at ten.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dào is inherited from Middle Chinese *tawH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to reach'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: dào*
- *Say it: dào*, once more
- *Say it: huǒchē hěn màn shí diǎn dào* — The train is slow; it gets in at ten.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for aeroplane, then the Mandarin for road, then say *dào* again

Before you move on

What does dào mean? ("To arrive; to reach".) Say it once more.

Chapter 73

At the Station

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say get on and get off, and name the station, the airport and tickets.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 73: I can say get on and get off, and name the station, the airport and tickets.*

73.1 下车 (xiàchē) — to get off (a bus or train)

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for road, then the Mandarin for to arrive.

You'll want to know: 下车

下车 — *xiàchē* — "to get off (a bus or train)".

> 我们下车吃饭 *wǒmen xiàchē chī fàn* — Let's get off and eat.

The new character, in pieces: 下 — a bar, a vertical hanging from it, and a dot to the right: 上 turned over. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

下车 (*xiàchē*) is built from 下 'to go down' and 车 'vehicle', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàchē*
- *Say it: xiàchē*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen xiàchē chī fàn* — Let's get off and eat.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for road, then the Mandarin for to arrive, then say *xiàchē* again

Before you move on

What does 下车 mean? ("To get off (a bus or train)".) Say it once more.

73.2 下 — a bar, a vertical, a dot

The word first, then the character inside it.

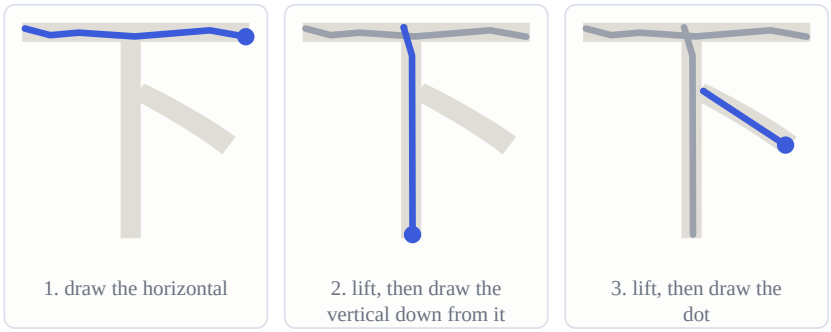
- *Recall:* say *xiàchē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

上 车

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shàng*, *chē*

Script — a bar, a vertical, a dot

How it is written — 3 strokes · 2 pen lifts · 3 movements



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 汉字.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 下 is written, stroke by stroke

下

One piece, three strokes.
A long horizontal across the top.
A vertical hanging down from its middle.
A dot to the right of the vertical, slanting down to the right.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 下, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 下? (**Three.**) Which character you know is it turned over? (上.) Where does the dot go? (**To the right of the vertical.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 下, pinned stroke paths and medians.

73.3 上车 (shàngchē) — to get on (a bus or train)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to arrive, then the Mandarin for to get off.

You'll want to know: 上车

上车 — *shàngchē* — "to get on (a bus or train)".

下雨快上车 *xiàyǔ kuài shàngchē* — It's raining: quick, get in!

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

上车 (*shàngchē*) is built from 上 'to go up' and 车 'vehicle', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangX* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngchē*
- *Say it: shàngchē*, once more
- *Say it: xiàyǔ kuài shàngchē* — It's raining: quick, get in!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to arrive, then the Mandarin for to get off, then say *shàngchē* again

Before you move on

What does 上车 mean? ("To get on (a bus or train)".) Say it once more.

73.4 huǒchēzhàn — railway station

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to get off, then the Mandarin for to get on.

You'll want to know: huǒchēzhàn

huǒchēzhàn — "railway station".

> *huǒchēzhàn hěn yuǎn* — The station is a long way off.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huǒchēzhàn is built from 火车 'train' and zhàn 'a stop', inherited from Middle Chinese *treamH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary glosses as the everyday word for standing alone. The sense 'station' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: huǒchēzhàn*
- *Say it: huǒchēzhàn*, once more
- *Say it: huǒchēzhàn hěn yuǎn* — The station is a long way off.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to get off, then the Mandarin for to get on, then say *huǒchēzhàn* again

Before you move on

What does huǒchēzhàn mean? ("Railway station".) Say it once more.

73.5 jīchǎng — airport

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to get on, then the Mandarin for railway station.

You'll want to know: jīchǎng

jīchǎng — "airport".

> *wǒ qù jīchǎng* — I'm going to the airport.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jīchǎng is built from 机 'machine' and chǎng 'open ground', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kj+j* and *drjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as a threshing floor. The machine here is the plane.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: jīchǎng*
- *Say it: jīchǎng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù jīchǎng* — I'm going to the airport.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to get on, then the Mandarin for railway station, then say *jīchǎng* again

Before you move on

What does jīchǎng mean? ("Airport".) Say it once more.

73.6 piào — ticket

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for railway station, then the Mandarin for airport.

You'll want to know: piào

piào — "ticket".

wǒ mǎi le piào — I've bought the tickets.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

piào is written with a character the Guangyun records, under an older form, as *phjiew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'flying fire'. That is probably a different word: the ticket sense is not given there, and *phjiew* would regularly give piāo, not piào. How the character came to write the word for ticket is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: piào*
- *Say it: piào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ mǎi le piào* — I've bought the tickets.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for railway station, then the Mandarin for airport, then say *piào* again

Before you move on

What does piào mean? ("Ticket".) Say it once more.

Chapter 74

Visiting

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask a guest in, welcome them and introduce people.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 74: I can ask a guest in, welcome them and introduce people.*

74.1 进 (jìn) — to come in; to enter

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for airport, then the Mandarin for ticket.

You'll want to know: 进

进 — *jìn* — "to come in; to enter".

> 他进门了 *tā jìn mén le* — He's come in at the door.

The new character, in pieces: 进 — a four-stroke piece read jǐng, a well, on the road piece of 这. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

进 (*jìn*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsinH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'forward' and 'to advance'.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: jìn*
- *Say it: jìn*, once more
- *Say it: tā jìn mén le* — He's come in at the door.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for airport, then the Mandarin for ticket, then say *jìn* again

Before you move on

What does 进 mean? ("To come in; to enter".) Say it once more.

74.2 进 — jǐng on the road piece

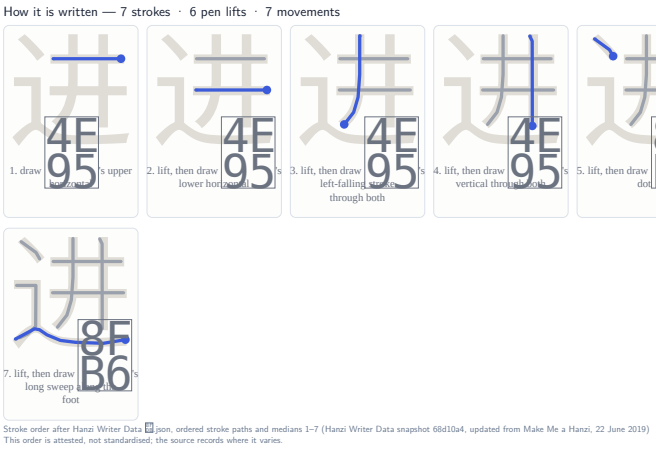
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *jìn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  开 这

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kāi*, *zhè*

Script — jǐng on the road piece



How 进 *is written, stroke by stroke*

进

Two pieces: jǐng first, the road last, though the road runs up the left and under.

Jǐng, four strokes: two horizontals, then a left-falling stroke and a vertical down through them, the same four as 开.

The road piece, three strokes, as in 这: a dot, then a stroke that turns and turns again, then a long sweep along the bottom to the right.

4 + 3 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 进, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 进? (**Two**.) Which character you know has the same first four strokes? (开.) Which character has the same road piece? (这.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 进, pinned stroke paths and medians.

74.3 客人 (kèrén) — guest

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for ticket, then the Mandarin for to come in.

You'll want to know: 客人

客人 — *kèrén* — "guest".

客人来了快开门 *kèrén lái le kuài kāi mén* — The guests are here: quick, open the door!

The new character, in pieces: 客 — the roof of 家, a walking foot under it, and 口 at the bottom. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

客人 (*kèrén*) is built from 客 'guest' and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khaek* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: kèrén*
- *Say it: kèrén*, once more
- *Say it: kèrén lái le kuài kāi mén* — The guests are here: quick, open the door!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for ticket, then the Mandarin for to come in, then say *kèrén* again

Before you move on

What does 客人 mean? ("Guest".) Say it once more.

74.4 客 — under the roof, a foot and 口

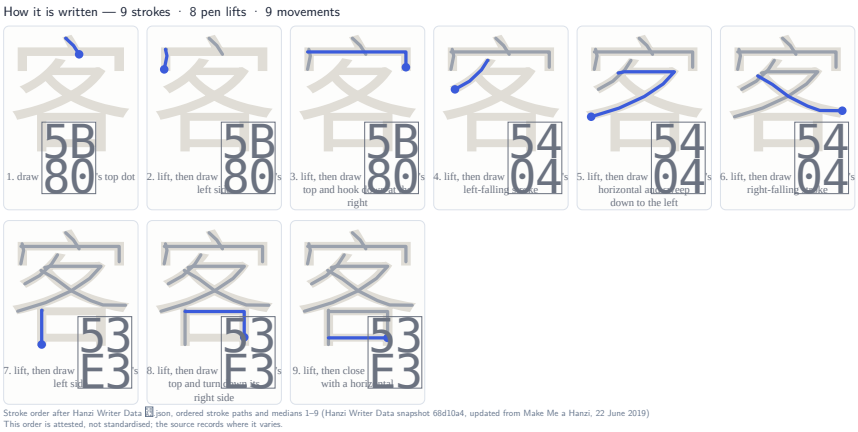
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *kèrén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

家 字 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *jiā*, *zì*, *kǒu*

Script — under the roof, a foot and 口



How 客 *is written, stroke by stroke*

客

Three pieces, top to bottom.

The roof, three strokes, as on 家 and 字: a dot, a short stroke down the left, and a horizontal that turns down and hooks.

The walking foot, three strokes: a short left-falling stroke, a horizontal that turns into a long left-falling stroke, and a long stroke falling to the right.

口, three strokes, at the bottom.

3 + 3 + 3 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 客, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 客? (**Three**.) Which characters you know have the same roof? (家 **and** 字.) What sits at the bottom? (口.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 客, pinned stroke paths and medians.

74.5 门口 (ménkǒu) — doorway; entrance

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to come in, then the Mandarin for guest.

You'll want to know: 门口

门口 — *ménkǒu* — "doorway; entrance".

门口有一个客人 *ménkǒu yǒu yí ge kèrén* — There's a guest at the door.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

门口 (*ménkǒu*) is built from 门 'door' and 口 'mouth', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mwon* and *khuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the mouth of the door, where you go in.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: ménkǒu*
- *Say it: ménkǒu*, once more
- *Say it: ménkǒu yǒu yí ge kèrén* — There's a guest at the door.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to come in, then the Mandarin for guest, then say *ménkǒu* again

Before you move on

What does 门口 mean? ("Doorway; entrance".) Say it once more.

74.6 huānyíng — welcome

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for guest, then the Mandarin for doorway.

You'll want to know: huānyíng

huānyíng — "welcome".

huānyíng nǐ lái wǒ jiā — Welcome to my home!

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huānyíng is built from huān 'glad' and yíng 'to go to meet', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xwan* and *ngjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): glad to meet you.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: huānyíng*
- *Say it: huānyíng*, once more
- *Say it: huānyíng nǐ lái wǒ jiā* — Welcome to my home!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for guest, then the Mandarin for doorway, then say *huānyíng* again

Before you move on

What does huānyíng mean? (“Welcome”.) Say it once more.

74.7 jièshào — to introduce

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for doorway, then the Mandarin for welcome.

You’ll want to know: jièshào

jièshào — “to introduce”.

qǐng nǐ jièshào nǐ de jiārén — Tell us about your family, please.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jièshào is built from jiè and shào, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *keajH* and *dzyewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as ’to help’ and the second as ’to carry on’; how the pair came to mean introducing somebody is not settled.

What you’ve built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: jièshào*
- *Say it: jièshào*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng nǐ jièshào nǐ de jiārén* — Tell us about your family, please.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for doorway, then the Mandarin for welcome, then say *jièshào* again

Before you move on

What does jièshào mean? ("To introduce".) Say it once more.

74.8 Looking back: from More to Eat to Visiting

Say the Mandarin for meat and steamed bun.

Your turn

- *Say it:* meat, steamed bun, noodles, dumpling, soup
- *Say it:* nice to drink, sweet, spicy, salty, to order food
- *Say it:* train, to drive, aeroplane, road, to arrive
- *Say it:* to get off, to get on, railway station, airport, ticket
- *Say it:* to come in, guest, doorway, welcome, to introduce
- *Read it:* 火 开 下 进 客 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Meat? (*ròu.*) Steamed bun? (*bāozi.*) Noodles? (*miàntiáo.*) Dumpling? (*jiǎozi.*) Soup? (*tāng.*) Nice to drink? (好喝, *hǎohē.*) Sweet? (*tián.*) Spicy? (*là.*) Salty? (*xián.*) To order food? (*diǎncài.*) Train? (火车, *huǒchē.*) To drive? (开车, *kāichē.*) Aeroplane? (*fēijī.*) Road? (*lù.*) To arrive? (*dào.*) To get off? (下车, *xiàchē.*) To get on? (上车, *shàngchē.*) Railway station? (*huǒchēzhàn.*) Airport? (*jīchǎng.*) Ticket? (*piào.*) To come in? (进, *jìn.*) Guest? (客人, *kèrén.*) Doorway? (门口, *ménkǒu.*) Welcome? (*huānyíng.*) To introduce? (*jièshào.*)

Chapter 75

Celebrating

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can wish somebody a happy birthday and give a present.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 75: I can wish somebody a happy birthday and give a present.*

75.1 快乐 (kuàilè) — joyful; happy

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for welcome, then the Mandarin for to introduce.

You'll want to know: 快乐

快乐 — *kuàilè* — "joyful; happy".

> 我们很快乐 *wǒmen hěn kuàilè* — We're very happy.

The new character, in pieces: 乐 — a nearly flat fall, a turn, and then 小 with its middle hooked. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

快乐 (*kuàilè*) is built from 快 and 乐, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khwaejH* and *lak* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as 'glad' and the second as 'joy': gladness twice over.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: kuàilè*
- *Say it: kuàilè*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen hěn kuàilè* — We're very happy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for welcome, then the Mandarin for to introduce, then say *kuàilè* again

Before you move on

What does 快乐 mean? ("Joyful; happy".) Say it once more.

75.2 乐 — a fall, a turn, and 小

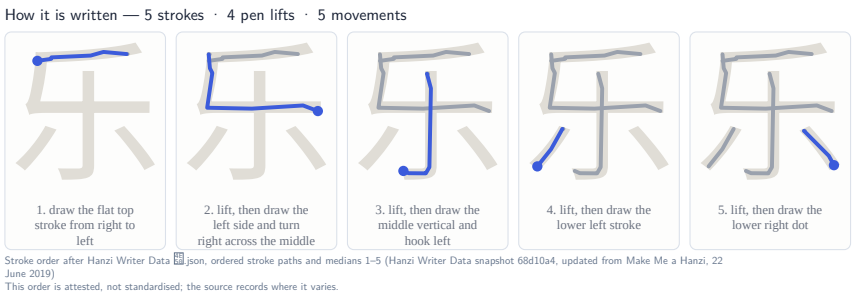
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *kuàilè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

小 快

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *xiǎo*, *kuài*

Script — a fall, a turn, and 小



How 乐 is written, stroke by stroke

乐

One piece, five strokes.
A left-falling stroke across the top, from right to left, nearly flat.
A vertical that turns right, under the left end of the first stroke.
Then the three strokes of 小: the vertical down the middle that hooks to the left, a dot falling left, a dot falling right.
2 + 3 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 乐, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 乐? (**Five**.) Which character you know are its last three? (小.) Which way does the first stroke run? (**From right to left, nearly flat**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 乐, pinned stroke paths and medians.

75.3 生日 (shēngrì) — birthday

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to introduce, then the Mandarin for joyful.

You'll want to know: 生日

生日 — *shēngrì* — "birthday".

明天是我的生日 *míngtiān shì wǒ de shēngrì* — Tomorrow is my birthday.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

生日 (*shēngrì*) is built from 生 'to be born' and 日 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *srjaeng* and *nyit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: shēngrì*
- *Say it: shēngrì*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān shì wǒ de shēngrì* — Tomorrow is my birthday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to introduce, then the Mandarin for joyful, then say *shēngrì* again

Before you move on

What does 生日 mean? ("Birthday".) Say it once more.

75.4 dàngāo — cake

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for joyful, then the Mandarin for birthday.

You'll want to know: dàngāo

dàngāo — "cake".

māma de dàngāo hěn hǎochī — Mum's cake is delicious.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dàngāo is built from dàn 'egg', the dàn of jīdàn, and gāo 'cake'. No dictionary we use records an older form of the first, so its history is not settled; the second is probably the *kaw* that the Guangyun writes with another form of the character (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed with a word for gruel.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: dàngāo*
- *Say it: dàngāo*, once more
- *Say it: māma de dàngāo hěn hǎochī* — Mum's cake is delicious.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for joyful, then the Mandarin for birthday, then say *dàngāo* again

Before you move on

What does dàngāo mean? ("Cake".) Say it once more.

75.5 lǐwù — present; gift

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for birthday, then the Mandarin for cake.

You'll want to know: lǐwù

lǐwù — "present; gift".

wǒ mǎi le yí ge lǐwù — I've bought a present.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǐwù is built from lǐ 'rite, courtesy' and wù 'thing', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *lejX* and *mjut* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a thing given out of courtesy.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǐwù*
- *Say it: lǐwù*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ mǎi le yí ge lǐwù* — I've bought a present.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for birthday, then the Mandarin for cake, then say *lǐwù* again

Before you move on

What does lǐwù mean? ("Present; gift".) Say it once more.

75.6 sòng — to give as a present; to see off

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cake, then the Mandarin for present.

You'll want to know: sòng

sòng — "to give as a present; to see off".

wǒmen sòng shénme lǐwù — What present shall we give?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

sòng is inherited from Middle Chinese *suwngH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to send off'; giving a present is sending something off with somebody.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: sòng*
- *Say it: sòng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen sòng shénme lǐwù* — What present shall we give?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cake, then the Mandarin for present, then say *sòng* again

Before you move on

What does sòng mean? (“To give as a present; to see off”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 76

Parting

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say see you soon, see you tomorrow, good night and bye-bye.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 76: I can say see you soon, see you tomorrow, good night and bye-bye.*

76.1 一会儿 (yíhuìr) — a little while; in a moment

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for present, then the Mandarin for to give as a present.

You'll want to know: 一会儿

一会儿 — *yíhuìr* — "a little while; in a moment".

> 我一会儿打电话 *wǒ yíhuìr dǎ diànhuà* — I'll ring in a little while.

The new character, in pieces: 会 — 人 spread as a roof, two bars, and a bend with a dot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

yī changes its tone here, rising to yí before the falling huì: yíhuìr.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一会儿 (*yíhuìr*) is built from 一 'one', huì and the ending r, inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jit*, *hwajH* and *nye* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses huì as 'to come together'; how

the phrase came to mean a short while is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: yíhuìr*
- *Say it: yíhuìr*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yíhuìr dǎ diànhuà* — I'll ring in a little while.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for present, then the Mandarin for to give as a present, then say *yíhuìr* again

Before you move on

What does 一会儿 mean? ("A little while; in a moment".) Say it once more.

76.2 会 — 人 over two bars and a bend

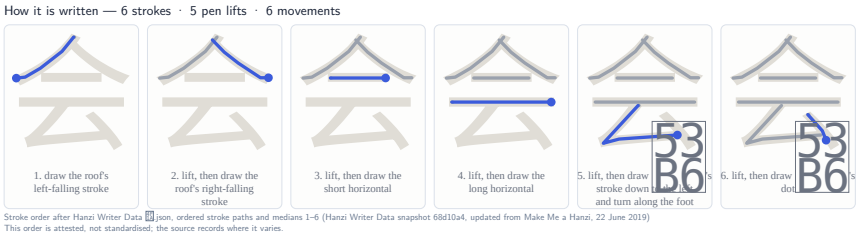
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yíhuìr* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

人 今 去

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, *jīn*, *qù*

Script — 人 over two bars and a bend



How 会 is written, stroke by stroke

会

Three parts, top to bottom.
人, two strokes, spread wide as a roof, as on 今.
Two horizontals under it, the lower one longer.
A stroke that falls left and turns right along the bottom, then **a dot**: the same two strokes that end 去.
2 + 2 + 2 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 会, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 会? (**Six**.) Which character you know is on top? (人.) What comes last? (**A dot**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 会, pinned stroke paths and medians.

76.3 明天见 (míngtiān jiàn) — see you tomorrow

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to give as a present, then the Mandarin for a little while.

You'll want to know: 明天见

明天见 — *míngtiān jiàn* — "see you tomorrow".

下雨我们明天见 *xiàyǔ wǒmen míngtiān jiàn* — It's raining: let's meet tomorrow.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

明天见 (*míngtiān jiàn*) is built from 明天 'tomorrow' and 见 'to see', the 见 of 再见.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: míngtiān jiàn*
- *Say it: míngtiān jiàn*, once more
- *Say it: xiàyǔ wǒmen míngtiān jiàn* — It's raining: let's meet tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to give as a present, then the Mandarin for a little while, then say *míngtiān jiàn* again

Before you move on

What does 明天见 mean? ("See you tomorrow".) Say it once more.

76.4 再说 (zàishuō) — to leave it till later

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a little while, then the Mandarin for see you tomorrow.

You'll want to know: 再说

再说 — *zàishuō* — "to leave it till later".

对不起一会儿再说 *duìbuqǐ yíhuìr zàishuō* — Sorry: let's talk about it in a bit.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

再说 (*zàishuō*) is built from 再 'again' and 说 'to say', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsojH* and *sywet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): say it again, another time.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: zàishuō*
- *Say it: zàishuō*, once more
- *Say it: duìbuqǐ yíhuìr zàishuō* — Sorry: let's talk about it in a bit.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a little while, then the Mandarin for see you tomorrow, then say *zàishuō* again

Before you move on

What does **再说** mean? ("To leave it till later".) Say it once more.

76.5 wǎn'ān — good night

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for see you tomorrow, then the Mandarin for to leave it till later.

You'll want to know: wǎn'ān

wǎn'ān — "good night".

māma wǎn'ān — Mum, good night.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wǎn'ān is built from wǎn 'evening' and ān 'peace', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mjonX* and *'an* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as 'calm, at rest'.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǎn'ān*
- *Say it: wǎn'ān*, once more

- *Say it: māma wǎn'ān* — Mum, good night.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for see you tomorrow, then the Mandarin for to leave it till later, then say *wǎn'ān* again

Before you move on

What does wǎn'ān mean? ("Good night".) Say it once more.

76.6 bàibai — bye-bye

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to leave it till later, then the Mandarin for good night.

You'll want to know: bàibai

bàibai — "bye-bye".

bàibai míngtiān jiàn — Bye, see you tomorrow!

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bàibai is borrowed from English *bye-bye*, written with a character read bài, 'to bow', for the sound.

What you've built

One more word for times and partings.

Your turn

- *Say it: bàibai*
- *Say it: bàibai*, once more
- *Say it: bàibai míngtiān jiàn* — Bye, see you tomorrow!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to leave it till later, then the Mandarin for good night, then say *bàibai* again

Before you move on

What does bàibai mean? (“Bye-bye”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 77

Thanks and Replies

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer thanks, thank people warmly and say really and very.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 77: I can answer thanks, thank people warmly and say really and very.*

77.1 不客气 (bú kèqi) — you're welcome; don't mention it

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for good night, then the Mandarin for bye-bye.

You'll want to know: 不客气

不客气 — *bú kèqi* — "you're welcome; don't mention it".

> 不客气请进 *bú kèqi qǐng jìn* — Don't mention it. Do come in!

bù changes its tone here, rising to bú before the falling kè: bú kèqi.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

不客气 (*bú kèqi*) is built from 不 'not' and kèqi 'polite, formal', from Middle Chinese *khaek* 'guest' and *khj+jH* 'breath' (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): no need to be formal.

What you've built

One more word for thanking and answering thanks.

Your turn

- *Say it: bú kèqi*
- *Say it: bú kèqi*, once more
- *Say it: bú kèqi qǐng jìn* — Don't mention it. Do come in!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for good night, then the Mandarin for bye-bye, then say *bú kèqi* again

Before you move on

What does 不客气 mean? ("You're welcome; don't mention it".) Say it once more.

77.2 máfan — to trouble; to bother

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bye-bye, then the Mandarin for don't mention it.

You'll want to know: máfan

máfan — "to trouble; to bother".

bù hǎoyìsi máfan nǐ — Sorry to trouble you.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

máfan is built from má and fán, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mae* and *bjon* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as hemp and the second as 'toil'; how the pair came to mean putting somebody to trouble is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for thanking and answering thanks.

Your turn

- *Say it: máfan*
- *Say it: máfan*, once more
- *Say it: bù hǎoyìsi máfan nǐ* — Sorry to trouble you.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bye-bye, then the Mandarin for don't mention it, then say *máfan* again

Before you move on

What does máfan mean? ("To trouble; to bother".) Say it once more.

77.3 gǎnxiè — to thank (warmly)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for don't mention it, then the Mandarin for to trouble somebody.

You'll want to know: gǎnxiè

gǎnxiè — "to thank (warmly)".

gǎnxiè dàjiā — Thank you, everyone.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gǎnxiè is built from gǎn 'to be moved' and 谢 'to thank', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *komX* and *zjaeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for thanking and answering thanks.

Your turn

- *Say it: gǎnxiè*
- *Say it: gǎnxiè*, once more
- *Say it: gǎnxiè dàjiā* — Thank you, everyone.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for don't mention it, then the Mandarin for to trouble somebody, then say *gǎnxiè* again

Before you move on

What does gǎnxiè mean? ("To thank (warmly)".) Say it once more.

77.4 fēicháng — extremely; very

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to trouble somebody, then the Mandarin for to thank.

You'll want to know: fēicháng

fēicháng — "extremely; very".

fēicháng gǎnxiè — Thank you so much.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fēicháng is built from fēi 'not' and cháng, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pj+j* and *dzyang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as 'it is not so'; the second as 'usual' is not given there, so 'out of the ordinary' is likely but not settled.

What you've built

One more word for thanking and answering thanks.

Your turn

- *Say it: fēicháng*
- *Say it: fēicháng*, once more
- *Say it: fēicháng gǎnxiè* — Thank you so much.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to trouble somebody, then the Mandarin for to thank, then say *fēicháng* again

Before you move on

What does fēicháng mean? ("Extremely; very".) Say it once more.

77.5 zhēn — really; truly

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to thank, then the Mandarin for extremely.

You'll want to know: zhēn

zhēn — "really; truly".

nǐ zhēn hǎo — You're so kind.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhēn is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'true, as against false'.

What you've built

One more word for thanking and answering thanks.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhēn*
- *Say it: zhēn*, once more

- *Say it: nǐ zhēn hǎo* — You're so kind.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to thank, then the Mandarin for extremely, then say *zhēn* again

Before you move on

What does zhēn mean? ("Really; truly".) Say it once more.

Chapter 78

Age and Growing Up

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 3 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask how old somebody is and talk about growing up and years ago.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 78: I can ask how old somebody is and talk about growing up and years ago.*

78.1 多大 (duō dà) — how old (asking a person's age)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for extremely, then the Mandarin for really.

You'll want to know: 多大

多大 — *duō dà* — "how old (asking a person's age)".

> 生日快乐你今年多大 *shēngrì kuàilè nǐ jīnnián duō dà* — Happy birthday! How old are you now?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

多大 (*duō dà*) is built from 多 'much' and 大 'big': how big, said of a person's years.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: duō dà*
- *Say it: duō dà*, once more
- *Say it: shēngrì kuàilè nǐ jīnnián duō dà* — Happy birthday! How old are you now?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for extremely, then the Mandarin for really, then say *duō dà* again

Before you move on

What does 多大 mean? ("How old (asking a person's age)".) Say it once more.

78.2 长大 (zhǎngdà) — to grow up

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for really, then the Mandarin for how old.

You'll want to know: 长大

长大 — *zhǎngdà* — "to grow up".

他们长大了 *tāmen zhǎngdà le* — They've grown up.

The character you wrote for cháng, long, is read zhǎng here, to grow.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

长大 (*zhǎngdà*) is built from zhǎng 'to grow' and 大 'big', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjangX* and *dajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as 'big' and 'elder'; growing is not given there, so how it got that sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǎngdà*
- *Say it: zhǎngdà*, once more
- *Say it: tāmen zhǎngdà le* — They've grown up.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for really, then the Mandarin for how old, then say *zhǎngdà* again

Before you move on

What does 长大 mean? ("To grow up".) Say it once more.

78.3 前 (qián) — before; ago; front

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for how old, then the Mandarin for to grow up.

You'll want to know: 前

前 — *qián* — "before; ago; front".

三年前我八岁 *sān nián qián wǒ bā suì* — Three years ago I was eight.

The new character, in pieces: 前 — two horns over a bar, the moon piece read yuè on the left, and a blade of two verticals on the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

前 (*qián*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'before, first'.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: qián*
- *Say it: qián*, once more
- *Say it: sān nián qián wǒ bā suì* — Three years ago I was eight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for how old, then the Mandarin for to grow up, then say *qián* again

Before you move on

What does 前 mean? ("Before; ago; front".) Say it once more.

78.4 前 — horns, a bar, the moon and a blade

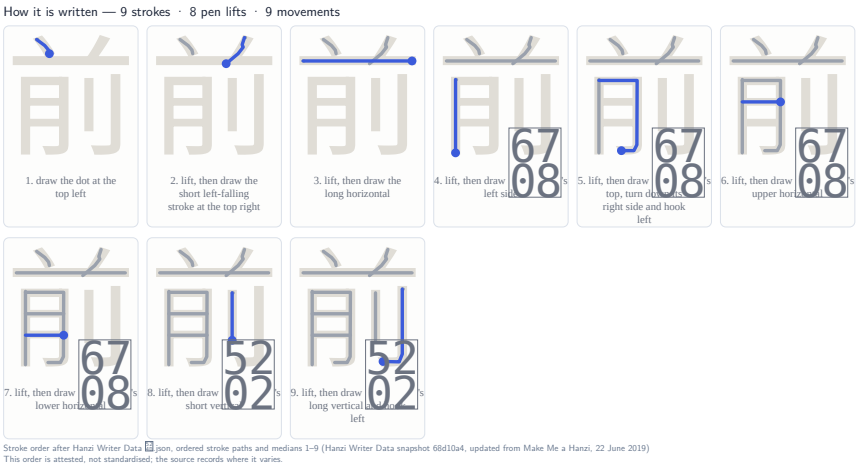
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *qián* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  三 年

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *sān*, *nián*

Script — horns, a bar, the moon and a blade



How 前 *is written, stroke by stroke*

前

Two horns, two strokes: a dot on the left, a short left-falling stroke on the right.

A long horizontal under them.

The moon piece, four strokes, read yuè as in the word for month: a left side that falls down, a top that turns down the right side and hooks, and two short bars inside.

The blade, two strokes: a short vertical, then a long vertical that hooks to the left.

2 + 1 + 4 + 2 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 前, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 前? (**Nine.**) What comes after the horns? (**The long bar.**) Which stroke hooks last? (**The long vertical on the right.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 前, pinned stroke paths and medians.

78.5 niánjì — age (of a person)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to grow up, then the Mandarin for ago.

You'll want to know: niánjì

niánjì — "age (of a person)".

nǐ bàba duō dà niánjì — How old is your father?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

niánjì is built from 年 'year' and jì, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nen* and *kiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as a span of twelve years.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: niánjì*
- *Say it: niánjì*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ bàba duō dà niánjì* — How old is your father?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to grow up, then the Mandarin for ago, then say *niánjì* again

Before you move on

What does niánjì mean? ("Age (of a person)".) Say it once more.

78.6 xiǎoshíhou — in childhood; when one was little

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for ago, then the Mandarin for age.

You'll want to know: xiǎoshíhou

xiǎoshíhou — "in childhood; when one was little".

wǒ xiǎoshíhou hěn xǐhuan xiào — As a child I laughed a lot.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiǎoshíhou is built from 小 'small' and shíhou 'time', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjewX*, *dzyi* and *huwH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the time when you were small.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiǎoshíhou*
- *Say it: xiǎoshíhou*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎoshíhou hěn xǐhuan xiào* — As a child I laughed a lot.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for ago, then the Mandarin for age, then say *xiǎoshíhou* again

Before you move on

What does xiǎoshíhou mean? (“In childhood; when one was little”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 79

At School

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about classes, the classroom, homework and exams.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 79: I can talk about classes, the classroom, homework and exams.*

79.1 上课 (shàngkè) — to have class; to start class

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for age, then the Mandarin for in childhood.

You'll want to know: 上课

上课 — *shàngkè* — "to have class; to start class".

> 今天有汉语课我们一会儿上课 *jīntiān yǒu hànyǔ kè wǒmen yíhuìr shàngkè* — There's a Chinese class today; it starts in a moment.

The new character, in pieces: 课 — 讠 on the left, and on the right guǒ, the fruit of shuǐguǒ: a box over the tree piece. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

上课 (*shàngkè*) is built from 上 'to go up to' and 课 'lesson', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangX* and *khwaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the second as 'a tax' and 'a test'; the sense lesson is not given there.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngkè*
- *Say it: shàngkè*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān yǒu hànyǔ kè wǒmen yíhuìr shàngkè* — There's a Chinese class today; it starts in a moment.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for age, then the Mandarin for in childhood, then say *shàngkè* again

Before you move on

What does 上课 mean? ("To have class; to start class".) Say it once more.

79.2 课 — the speech piece, then guǒ

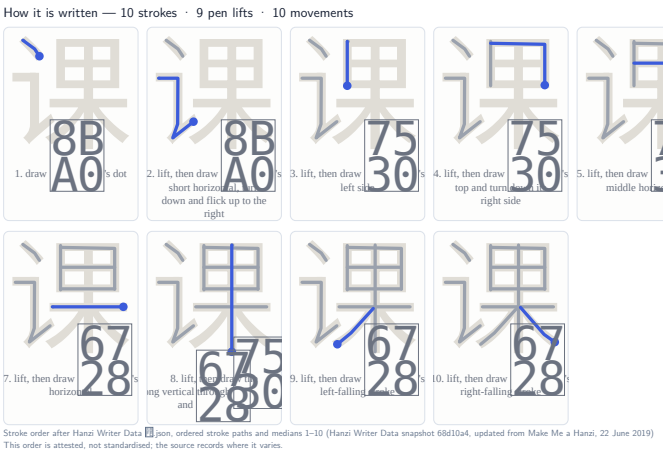
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shàngkè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

讠 说

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — the speech piece, *shuō*

Script — the speech piece, then guǒ



How 课 *is written, stroke by stroke*

课

Two pieces, left before right.
讠**, two strokes**, as in 说 and 话.
Guǒ, eight strokes: a box like 日, its left side, the top that turns down, the middle bar and the bar that closes it; then a long horizontal, a vertical down through the box and the bar, a left-falling stroke and a stroke falling to the right.
2 + 8 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 课, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 课? (**Two.**) Which characters you know start the same way? (**说 and 话.**) What runs down through the box? (**The vertical, the eighth stroke.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 课, pinned stroke paths and medians.

79.3 下课 (xiàkè) — to finish class

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for in childhood, then the Mandarin for to start class.

You'll want to know: 下课

下课 — *xiàkè* — "to finish class".

十二点前我们下课 *shí'èr diǎn qián wǒmen xiàkè* — We finish class before twelve.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

下课 (*xiàkè*) is built from 下 'to go down from' and 课 'lesson', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *khwaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); lesson is not among the senses the dictionary gives the second.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàkè*
- *Say it: xiàkè*, once more
- *Say it: shí'èr diǎn qián wǒmen xiàkè* — We finish class before twelve.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for in childhood, then the Mandarin for to start class, then say *xiàkè* again

Before you move on

What does 下课 mean? ("To finish class".) Say it once more.

79.4 jiàoshì — classroom

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to start class, then the Mandarin for to finish class.

You'll want to know: jiàoshì

jiàoshì — "classroom".

> *wǒmen de jiàoshì hěn dà* — Our classroom is big.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiàoshì is built from jiào 'to teach' and shì 'room', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kaewH* and *syit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiàoshì*
- *Say it: jiàoshì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen de jiàoshì hěn dà* — Our classroom is big.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to start class, then the Mandarin for to finish class, then say *jiàoshì* again

Before you move on

What does jiàoshì mean? ("Classroom".) Say it once more.

79.5 zuòyè — homework

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to finish class, then the Mandarin for classroom.

You'll want to know: zuòyè

zuòyè — "homework".

> *jīntiān de zuòyè shì dú hànzì* — Today's homework is reading characters aloud.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zuòyè is built from zuò 'to do' and yè 'task', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsak* and *ngjaep* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuòyè*
- *Say it: zuòyè*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān de zuòyè shì dú hànzì* — Today's homework is reading characters aloud.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to finish class, then the Mandarin for classroom, then say *zuòyè* again

Before you move on

What does zuòyè mean? ("Homework".) Say it once more.

79.6 kǎoshì — to take an exam

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for classroom, then the Mandarin for homework.

You'll want to know: kǎoshì

kǎoshì — "to take an exam".

míngtiān kǎoshì jīntiān wǒ xuéxí — The exam is tomorrow, so today I'm studying.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kǎoshì is built from kǎo and shì, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khawX* and *syiH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as 'to check' and the second as 'to use'; the sense 'exam' is not given there.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: kǎoshì*
- *Say it: kǎoshì*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān kǎoshì jīntiān wǒ xuéxí* — The exam is tomorrow, so today I'm studying.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for classroom, then the Mandarin for homework, then say *kǎoshì* again

Before you move on

What does kǎoshì mean? ("To take an exam".) Say it once more.

79.7 Looking back: from Celebrating to At School

Say the Mandarin for joyful and birthday.

Your turn

- *Say it:* joyful, birthday, cake, present, to give as a present
- *Say it:* a little while, see you tomorrow, to leave it till later, good night, bye-bye
- *Say it:* don't mention it, to trouble somebody, to thank, extremely, really

- *Say it:* how old, to grow up, ago, age, in childhood
- *Say it:* to start class, to finish class, classroom, homework, to take an exam
- *Read it:* 乐 会 前 课 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Joyful? (快乐, *kuàilè.*) Birthday? (生日, *shēngrì.*) Cake? (*dàngāo.*) Present? (*lǐwù.*) To give as a present? (*sòng.*) A little while? (一会儿, *yíhuìr.*) See you tomorrow? (明天见, *míngtiān jiàn.*) To leave it till later? (再说, *zàishuō.*) Good night? (*wǎn'ān.*) Bye-bye? (*bàibai.*) Don't mention it? (不客气, *bú kèqi.*) To trouble somebody? (*máfan.*) To thank? (*gǎnxiè.*) Extremely? (*fēicháng.*) Really? (*zhēn.*) How old? (多大, *duō dà.*) To grow up? (长大, *zhǎngdà.*) Ago? (前, *qián.*) Age? (*niánjì.*) In childhood? (*xiǎoshíhou.*) To start class? (上课, *shàngkè.*) To finish class? (下课, *xiàkè.*) Classroom? (*jiàoshì.*) Homework? (*zuòyè.*) To take an exam? (*kǎoshì.*)

Chapter 80

Jobs

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say who goes to work where: workers, drivers, doctors and companies.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 80: I can say who goes to work where: workers, drivers, doctors and companies.*

80.1 shàngbān — to go to work

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for homework, then the Mandarin for to take an exam.

You'll want to know: shàngbān

shàngbān — "to go to work".

> *wǒ jiǔ diǎn shàngbān* — I start work at nine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shàngbān is built from 上 'to go up to' and bān, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangX* and *paen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary explains the second, through an older book, as dividing up jade tallies; a shift of work is a likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngbān*
- *Say it: shàngbān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiǔ diǎn shàngbān* — I start work at nine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for homework, then the Mandarin for to take an exam, then say *shàngbān* again

Before you move on

What does shàngbān mean? ("To go to work".) Say it once more.

80.2 gōngrén — worker

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to take an exam, then the Mandarin for to go to work.

You'll want to know: gōngrén

gōngrén — "worker".

wǒ bàba shì gōngrén — My dad is a worker.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gōngrén is built from gōng 'craft, work' and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kuwng* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: gōngrén*
- *Say it: gōngrén*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bàba shì gōngrén* — My dad is a worker.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to take an exam, then the Mandarin for to go to work, then say *gōngrén* again

Before you move on

What does gōngrén mean? ("Worker".) Say it once more.

80.3 sījī — driver

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go to work, then the Mandarin for worker.

You'll want to know: sījī

sījī — "driver".

tā shì chūzūchē sījī — He's a taxi driver.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

sījī is built from sī 'to be in charge' and 机 'machine', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *si* and *kj+j* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the one in charge of the machine.

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: sījī*
- *Say it: sījī*, once more

- *Say it: tā shì chūzūchē sījī* — He's a taxi driver.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go to work, then the Mandarin for worker, then say *sījī* again

Before you move on

What does sījī mean? ("Driver".) Say it once more.

80.4 yīshēng — doctor

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for worker, then the Mandarin for driver.

You'll want to know: yīshēng

yīshēng — "doctor".

wǒ māma shì yīshēng — My mum is a doctor.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yīshēng is built from yī 'healing' and 生, as in 学生 and in xiānsheng, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'i* and *srjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīshēng*
- *Say it: yīshēng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ māma shì yīshēng* — My mum is a doctor.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for worker, then the Mandarin for driver, then say *yīshēng* again

Before you move on

What does yīshēng mean? (“Doctor”.) Say it once more.

80.5 gōngsī — company; firm

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for driver, then the Mandarin for doctor.

You’ll want to know: gōngsī

gōngsī — “company; firm”.

wǒ de gōngsī hěn dà — My company is big.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gōngsī is built from gōng ’public, shared’ and sī ’to manage’, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kuwng* and *si* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription).

What you’ve built

One more word about people.

Your turn

- *Say it: gōngsī*
- *Say it: gōngsī*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de gōngsī hěn dà* — My company is big.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for driver, then the Mandarin for doctor, then say *gōngsī* again

Before you move on

What does gōngsī mean? (“Company; firm”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 81

The City

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about cities and places, say inside and beside, and talk about abroad.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 81: I can talk about cities and places, say inside and beside, and talk about abroad.*

81.1 里 (lǐ) — inside; in

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for doctor, then the Mandarin for company.

You'll want to know: 里

里 — *lǐ* — "inside; in".

山里有马 *shān lǐ yǒu mǎ* — There are horses up in the hills.

The new character, in pieces: 里 — 日 with a vertical running down through it, standing on two bars. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

里 (*lǐ*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *liX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'inside' and, through an older book, 'the inside of a garment'.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǐ*
- *Say it: lǐ*, once more
- *Say it: shān lǐ yǒu mǎ* — There are horses up in the hills.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for doctor, then the Mandarin for company, then say *lǐ* again

Before you move on

What does 里 mean? ("Inside; in".) Say it once more.

81.2 里 — 日, a line through it, two bars

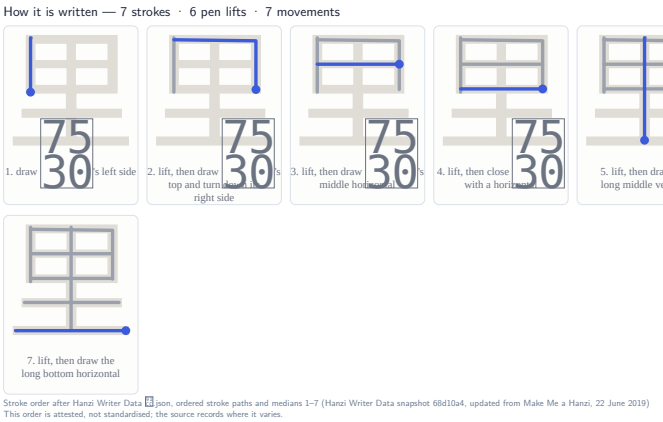
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *lǐ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 家

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *jiā*

Script — 日, a line through it, two bars



How 里 *is written, stroke by stroke*

里

One piece, built from the top down.

日**, four strokes**: the left side, the top that turns down, the middle bar, the bottom bar.

A vertical down the middle, through 日 and on below it.

Two horizontals, a short one across the vertical, then a long one along the bottom.

4 + 1 + 2 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 里, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 里? (**Seven.**) Which character you know is at the top? (日.) Which bar is longest? (**The last, along the bottom.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 里, pinned stroke paths and medians.

81.3 chéngshì — city

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for company, then the Mandarin for inside.

You'll want to know: chéngshì

chéngshì — "city".

Běijīng shì yí ge dà chéngshì — Beijing is a big city.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chéngshì is built from chéng 'city walls' and shì 'market', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyeng* and *dzyiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: chéngshì*
- *Say it: chéngshì*, once more
- *Say it: Běijīng shì yí ge dà chéngshì* — Beijing is a big city.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for company, then the Mandarin for inside, then say *chéngshì* again

Before you move on

What does chéngshì mean? ("City".) Say it once more.

81.4 dìfang — place

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for inside, then the Mandarin for city.

You'll want to know: dìfang

dìfang — "place".

zhège dìfang hěn hǎo — This is a nice place.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìfang is built from dì 'land' and fāng 'quarter, region', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dijH* and *pjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìfang*
- *Say it: dìfang*, once more
- *Say it: zhège dìfang hěn hǎo* — This is a nice place.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for inside, then the Mandarin for city, then say *dìfang* again

Before you move on

What does dìfang mean? ("Place".) Say it once more.

81.5 wàiguó — foreign country; abroad

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for city, then the Mandarin for place.

You'll want to know: wàiguó

wàiguó — "foreign country; abroad".

tā shì wàiguó rén — He's a foreigner.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wàiguó is built from wài 'outside' and 国 'country', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngwajH* and *kwok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàiguó*
- *Say it: wàiguó*, once more
- *Say it: tā shì wàiguó rén* — He's a foreigner.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for city, then the Mandarin for place, then say *wàiguó* again

Before you move on

What does wàiguó mean? ("Foreign country; abroad".) Say it once more.

81.6 pángbiān — side; beside

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for place, then the Mandarin for abroad.

You'll want to know: pángbiān

pángbiān — "side; beside".

wǒ jiā pángbiān yǒu yí ge shāngdiàn — There's a shop next to my home.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

pángbiān is built from páng 'side' and biān 'edge', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bang* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: pángbiān*
- *Say it: pángbiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā pángbiān yǒu yí ge shāngdiàn* — There's a shop next to my home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for place, then the Mandarin for abroad, then say *pángbiān* again

Before you move on

What does pángbiān mean? ("Side; beside".) Say it once more.

Chapter 82

Behind, Left and Right

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say after, left, right, in the middle and opposite.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 82: I can say after, left, right, in the middle and opposite.*

82.1 hòu — after; behind; later

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for abroad, then the Mandarin for beside.

You'll want to know: hòu

hòu — "after; behind; later".

> *sān tiān hòu wǒmen qù Běijīng* — In three days we're going to Beijing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hòu is inherited from Middle Chinese *huwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed with the pair 'before and after'; the dictionary writes it with the traditional form of the character.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: hòu*
- *Say it: hòu*, once more
- *Say it: sān tiān hòu wǒmen qù Běijīng* — In three days we're going to Beijing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for abroad, then the Mandarin for beside, then say *hòu* again

Before you move on

What does hòu mean? ("After; behind; later".) Say it once more.

82.2 zuǒbian — the left; on the left

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for beside, then the Mandarin for after.

You'll want to know: zuǒbian

zuǒbian — "the left; on the left".

zuǒbian shì wǒ de fángjiān — My room is on the left.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zuǒbian is built from zuǒ 'left' and bian 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsaX* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuǒbian*
- *Say it: zuǒbian*, once more
- *Say it: zuǒbian shì wǒ de fángjiān* — My room is on the left.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for beside, then the Mandarin for after, then say *zuǒbian* again

Before you move on

What does zuǒbian mean? ("The left; on the left".) Say it once more.

82.3 yòubian — the right; on the right

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for after, then the Mandarin for the left side.

You'll want to know: yòubian

yòubian — "the right; on the right".

yòubian shì shāngdiàn — The shop is on the right.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yòubian is built from yòu 'right' and bian 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuwX* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: yòubian*
- *Say it: yòubian*, once more

- *Say it: yòubian shì shāngdiàn* — The shop is on the right.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for after, then the Mandarin for the left side, then say *yòubian* again

Before you move on

What does yòubian mean? ("The right; on the right".) Say it once more.

82.4 zhōngjiān — the middle; between

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the left side, then the Mandarin for the right side.

You'll want to know: zhōngjiān

zhōngjiān — "the middle; between".

zhōngjiān nàge shì wǒ — The one in the middle is me.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhōngjiān is built from 中 'middle' and jiān 'a gap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *trjuwng* and *kean* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary lists the second under an older form of the character.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhōngjiān*
- *Say it: zhōngjiān*, once more
- *Say it: zhōngjiān nàge shì wǒ* — The one in the middle is me.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the left side, then the Mandarin for the right side, then say *zhōngjiān* again

Before you move on

What does zhōngjiān mean? ("The middle; between".) Say it once more.

82.5 duìmiàn — opposite; across from

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the right side, then the Mandarin for the middle.

You'll want to know: duìmiàn

duìmiàn — "opposite; across from".

wǒ jiā duìmiàn yǒu yí ge fàndiàn — There's a restaurant across from my home.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

duìmiàn is built from 对 'to face' and miàn 'face', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *twojH* and *mjienH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): face to face.

What you've built

One more word for meeting people.

Your turn

- *Say it: duìmiàn*
- *Say it: duìmiàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jiā duìmiàn yǒu yí ge fàndiàn* — There's a restaurant across from my home.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the right side, then the Mandarin for the middle, then say *duìmiàn* again

Before you move on

What does duìmiàn mean? (“Opposite; across from”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 83

Running Late

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask if somebody is free, and say early, right away, too late and late.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 83: I can ask if somebody is free, and say early, right away, too late and late.*

83.1 shíjiān — time; free time

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the middle, then the Mandarin for opposite.

You'll want to know: shíjiān

shíjiān — "time; free time".

> *nǐ míngtiān yǒu shíjiān ma* — Are you free tomorrow?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shíjiān is built from shí 'time' and jiān 'a gap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyi* and *kean* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first with another word for a time, and lists the second under an older form of the character.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: shíjiān*
- *Say it: shíjiān*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ míngtiān yǒu shíjiān ma* — Are you free tomorrow?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the middle, then the Mandarin for opposite, then say *shíjiān* again

Before you move on

What does shíjiān mean? ("Time; free time".) Say it once more.

83.2 早 (zǎo) — early

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for opposite, then the Mandarin for time to spare.

You'll want to know: 早

早 — *zǎo* — "early".

明天的火车很早 *míngtiān de huǒchē hěn zǎo* — Tomorrow's train leaves early.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

早 (*zǎo*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'morning'. Early is not given there; from morning to early is the likely step, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zǎo*
- *Say it: zǎo*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān de huǒchē hěn zǎo* — Tomorrow's train leaves early.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for opposite, then the Mandarin for time to spare, then say *zǎo* again

Before you move on

What does 早 mean? ("Early".) Say it once more.

83.3 马上 (mǎshàng) — at once; right away

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for time to spare, then the Mandarin for early.

You'll want to know: 马上

马上 — *mǎshàng* — "at once; right away".

家里人马上来 *jiā lǐ rén mǎshàng lái* — The family will be here any minute.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

马上 (*mǎshàng*) is built from 马 'horse' and 上 'on', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *maeX* and *dzyangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). 'On horseback', so already on the way, is the usual explanation, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǎshàng*
- *Say it: mǎshàng*, once more

- *Say it: jiā lǐ rén mǎshàng lái* — The family will be here any minute.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for time to spare, then the Mandarin for early, then say *mǎshàng* again

Before you move on

What does 马上 mean? ("At once; right away".) Say it once more.

83.4 láibují — to run out of time

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for early, then the Mandarin for right away.

You'll want to know: láibují

láibují — "to run out of time".

xiànzài qù láibují le — It's too late to go now.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

Its middle syllable loses its tone: láibují, with bu light between two full syllables.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

láibují is built from 来 'to come', 不 'not' and jí 'to reach', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *loj*, *pjut* and *gip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): coming, but not reaching in time.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: láibují*
- *Say it: láibují*, once more
- *Say it: xiànzài qù láibují le* — It's too late to go now.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for early, then the Mandarin for right away, then say *láibují* again

Before you move on

What does láibují mean? ("To run out of time".) Say it once more.

83.5 chídào — to be late; to arrive late

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for right away, then the Mandarin for to run out of time.

You'll want to know: chídào

chídào — "to be late; to arrive late".

duìbuqǐ wǒ chídào le — Sorry I'm late.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chídào is built from chí 'slow' and dào 'to arrive', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *drij* and *tawH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: chídào*
- *Say it: chídào*, once more
- *Say it: duìbuqǐ wǒ chídào le* — Sorry I'm late.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for right away, then the Mandarin for to run out of time, then say *chídào* again

Before you move on

What does chídào mean? (“To be late; to arrive late”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 84

Doing Things Together

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can arrange to meet, chat, take part and get ready together.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 84: I can arrange to meet, chat, take part and get ready together.*

84.1 一起 (yìqǐ) — together

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to run out of time, then the Mandarin for to be late.

You'll want to know: 一起

一起 — *yìqǐ* — "together".

> 三年前我们一起上学 *sān nián qián wǒmen yìqǐ shàngxué* — Three years ago we were at school together.

yī changes its tone here, falling to yì before the dipping qǐ: yìqǐ.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一起 (*yìqǐ*) is built from 一 'one' and 起 'to rise', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jit* and *khiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Rising as one is a likely picture, but how the pair came to mean together is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: yìqǐ*
- *Say it: yìqǐ*, once more
- *Say it: sān nián qián wǒmen yìqǐ shàngxué* — Three years ago we were at school together.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to run out of time, then the Mandarin for to be late, then say *yìqǐ* again

Before you move on

What does 一起 mean? ("Together".) Say it once more.

84.2 jiànmiàn — to meet up; to see each other

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be late, then the Mandarin for together.

You'll want to know: jiànmiàn

jiànmiàn — "to meet up; to see each other".

wǒmen xīngqītiān jiànmiàn — We're meeting on Sunday.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiànmiàn is built from 见 'to see' and miàn 'face', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kenH* and *mjienH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): to see each other's face.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiànmiàn*
- *Say it: jiànmiàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen xīngqītiān jiànmiàn* — We're meeting on Sunday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be late, then the Mandarin for together, then say *jiànmiàn* again

Before you move on

What does jiànmiàn mean? ("To meet up; to see each other".) Say it once more.

84.3 liáotiān — to chat

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for together, then the Mandarin for to meet up.

You'll want to know: liáotiān

liáotiān — "to chat".

wǒmen hē chá liáotiān — We drink tea and chat.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

liáotiān is built from liáo and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *lew* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as a helping word; how the pair came to mean chatting is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: liáotiān*
- *Say it: liáotiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen hē chá liáotiān* — We drink tea and chat.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for together, then the Mandarin for to meet up, then say *liáotiān* again

Before you move on

What does liáotiān mean? ("To chat".) Say it once more.

84.4 cānjiā — to take part in; to join

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to meet up, then the Mandarin for to chat.

You'll want to know: cānjiā

cānjiā — "to take part in; to join".

nǐ xiǎng cānjiā ma — Would you like to join in?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cānjiā is built from cān 'to attend' and jiā 'to add', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tshom* and *kae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: cānjiā*
- *Say it: cānjiā*, once more

- *Say it: nǐ xiǎng cānjiā ma* — Would you like to join in?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to meet up, then the Mandarin for to chat, then say *cānjiā* again

Before you move on

What does cānjiā mean? ("To take part in; to join".) Say it once more.

84.5 zhǔnbèi — to get ready; to prepare

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to chat, then the Mandarin for to take part.

You'll want to know: zhǔnbèi

zhǔnbèi — "to get ready; to prepare".

wǒ zhǔnbèi chànggē — I'm getting ready to sing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǔnbèi is built from zhǔn 'level, a standard' and bèi 'to have ready', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsywinX* and *bijH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǔnbèi*
- *Say it: zhǔnbèi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zhǔnbèi chànggē* — I'm getting ready to sing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to chat, then the Mandarin for to take part, then say *zhǔnbèi* again

Before you move on

What does zhǔnbèi mean? ("To get ready; to prepare".) Say it once more.

84.6 Looking back: from Jobs to Doing Things Together

Say the Mandarin for to go to work and worker.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to go to work, worker, driver, doctor, company
- *Say it:* inside, city, place, abroad, beside
- *Say it:* after, the left side, the right side, the middle, opposite
- *Say it:* time to spare, early, right away, to run out of time, to be late
- *Say it:* together, to meet up, to chat, to take part, to get ready
- *Read it:* 里 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

To go to work? (*shàngbān.*) Worker? (*gōngrén.*) Driver? (*sījī.*) Doctor? (*yīshēng.*) Company? (*gōngsī.*) Inside? (里, *lǐ.*) City? (*chéngshì.*) Place? (*dìfang.*) Abroad? (*wàiguó.*) Beside? (*pángbiān.*) After? (*hòu.*) The left side? (*zuǒbian.*) The right side? (*yòubian.*) The middle? (*zhōngjiān.*) Opposite? (*duìmiàn.*) Time to spare? (*shíjiān.*) Early? (早, *zǎo.*) Right away? (马上, *mǎshàng.*) To run out of time? (*láibují.*) To be late? (*chídào.*) Together? (一起, *yìqǐ.*) To meet up? (*jiànmiàn.*) To chat? (*liáotiān.*) To take part? (*cānjiā.*) To get ready? (*zhǔnbèi.*)

84.7 Doing Things Together — once more

Say the Mandarin for together and to meet up.

Your turn

- *Say it:* together, to meet up, to chat, to take part, to get ready

Before you move on

Together? (一起, *yìqǐ.*) To meet up? (*jiànmiàn.*) To chat? (*liáotiān.*) To take part? (*cānjiā.*) To get ready? (*zhǔnbèi.*)

Chapter 85

Where Things Are

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say where people and things are, and write 在.
>
> *Saying where people and things are with* 在*, here and there, inside and outside, built on one new written character:* 在*.*

85.1 在 (zài) — at, in; to be somewhere

A new chapter, and it opens with the word that puts people and things in places.

- *Recall:* say *zhǔnbèi*, to get ready — **R1**, the last word you met
- *Recall:* say 这儿 — *zhèr*, here — **R3**, durable, from the chapter on home
- *Recall:* say *pángbiān*, beside — **R2**, a few chapters back

You'll want to know: 在

在 — *zài* — "to be at; in, at".

妈妈在家吗 *māma zài jiā ma* — Is Mum at home?

我在这儿 *wǒ zài zhèr* — I'm here.

The next lesson puts the character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

在 (*zài*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzojX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to dwell' and 'to exist'.

What you've built

The place comes straight after 在: 妈妈, 在, 家. English needs *is* and *at*; Mandarin needs 在 alone.
That is the whole sentence pattern of the chapter: a person or a thing, then 在, then the place.

Your turn

- *Say it: zài*
- *Say it:* 妈妈在家吗 — *māma zài jiā ma* — Is Mum at home?
- *Say it:* 我在这儿 — *wǒ zài zhèr* — I'm here.
- *Recall:* say *zhǔnbèi* and *pángbiān*, then *zài* again

Before you move on

What does 在 mean? ("To be at; in, at".) Where does the place go? (**Straight after** 在.)

85.2 在 — the top of 有, a vertical, then 土

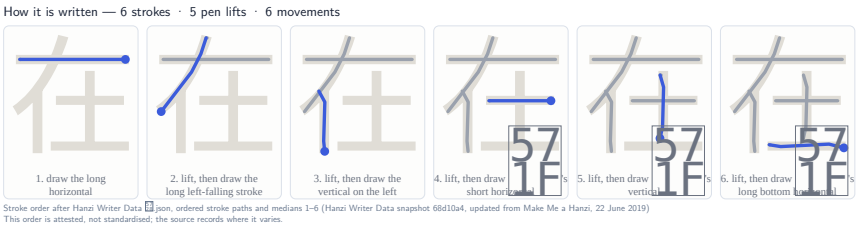
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *zài* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  有 里 十

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *yǒu*, *lǐ*, *shí*

Script — the top of 有, a vertical, then 土



How 在 is written, stroke by stroke

在

Three pieces, and two of them you already write.

The top of 有, two strokes: a long horizontal, then a long left-falling stroke from above it, down to the lower left.

A short vertical under them, on the left, down from the falling stroke.

土, three strokes: a short horizontal, a vertical down through it, and a long bar along the foot. It is 十 standing on a bar.

2 + 1 + 3 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 在, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 在? (**Six.**) Which character you know opens the same way? (有.) Which bar is longest? (**The last, along the foot.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 在, pinned stroke paths and medians.

85.3 那儿 (nàr) — there

Before the new one: the character from the last lesson, then a word it pairs with.

- *Read it:* 在家, aloud — *zài jiā*, at home
- *Recall:* say 这儿 — *zhèr*, here

You'll want to know: 那儿

那儿 — *nàr* — "there".

他在那儿 *tā zài nàr* — He's over there.

我在这儿 *wǒ zài zhèr* — I'm here.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

那儿 (*nàr*) is built from 那 'that' and 儿, the ending that runs into the syllable before it as an r: the same two pieces as 这儿. The Guangyun records 那 as *na* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'how, what'; how it came to mean 'that' is not settled.

What you've built

这儿 and 那儿, here and there, answer most of the place questions this chapter asks. Both take the r ending, and both follow 在.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nàr*
- *nàr*, once more
- 他在那儿 — *tā zài nàr* — He's over there.
- 我在这儿 你在那儿 — *wǒ zài zhèr, nǐ zài nàr* — I'm here, you're there.

Before you move on

What does 那儿 mean? ("There".) And here? (这儿.) Say both once more.

85.4 lǐbian — inside

Before the new one: last lesson's word, and a character you write.

- *Recall:* say 那儿 — *nàr*, there
- *Read it:* 里, aloud — *lǐ*, inside
- *Recall:* say *chéngshì*, a city

You'll want to know: lǐbian

lǐbian — "inside; in".

shū zài bāo lǐbian — The book is in the bag.

Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǐbian is built from lǐ 'inside', the 里 you write, and bian 'side', the syllable that ends *zuǒbian* and *pángbiān*. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *liX* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the inside of a garment' and 'an edge; a side'.

What you've built

lǐbian comes after the thing whose inside it names: *bāo lǐbian*, inside the bag. Put 在 in front and it is a place: *zài bāo lǐbian*.
里 on its own does the same job in a quicker sentence, as in *shān lǐ*.
lǐbian can also stand alone: *zài lǐbian*, inside.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǐbian*
- *Say it: lǐbian*, once more
- *Say it: shū zài bāo lǐbian* — The book is in the bag.
- *Say it: tā zài lǐbian* — He's inside.
- *Recall:* say *nàr* and *chéngshì*, then *lǐbian* again

Before you move on

What does *lǐbian* mean? (“Inside; in”.) Which written character does it open with? (里.)

85.5 wàibian — outside

Before the new one: say the word for inside, then two words you have had for a while.

- *Recall:* say *lǐbian*, inside — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *wàiguó*, abroad — **R2**, a few chapters back
- *Recall:* say *zuǒbian* and *yòubian*, left and right — **R2**

You’ll want to know: wàibian

wàibian — “outside”.

tā zài wàibian — She’s outside.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wàibian is built from wài ’outside’, the wài of *wàiguó*, and bian ’side’. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngwajH* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), *ngwajH* glossed ’the outside’ and ’far’.

What you’ve built

lǐbian and *wàibian*, inside and outside, beside the pair you already own, *zuǒbian* and *yòubian*: one ending, bian, makes all four, and all four follow 在.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàibian*
- *Say it: wàibian*, once more
- *Say it: tā zài wàibian* — She’s outside.

- *Say it: māo zài wàibian* — The cat's outside.
- *Recall:* say *lǐbian* and *wàiguó*, then *wàibian* again

Before you move on

What does *wàibian* mean? ("Outside".) And inside? (***lǐbian***.)

85.6 我在这儿 — 你在那儿

The chapter closes here, with two people placing themselves and their things.

- *Recall:* say *wàibian*, outside — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *yìqǐ*, together — **R2**, the first real retrieval
- *Recall:* say *jiànmiàn*, to meet up — **R2**

The exchange

A: 我在家 你呢

wǒ zài jiā, nǐ ne — I'm at home. And you?

B: *wǒ zài xuéxiào* — I'm at school.

A: 你的书呢

nǐ de shū ne — Where's your book?

B: *zài bāo lǐbian* — In my bag.

A: *māo ne* — And the cat?

B: *māo zài wàibian* — The cat's outside.

A: 他呢

tā ne — And him?

B: 他在那儿

tā zài nàr — He's over there.

nǐ de shū ne asks where the book is: 呢 after a thing, with nothing else, means *and where is it?* The answer drops the book and starts at 在.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — one pattern, four places

One pattern, a person or a thing, then 在, then the place:

- 我在这儿 *wǒ zài zhèr* — I'm here.
- 他在那儿 *tā zài nàr* — he's there.
- *shū zài bāo lǐbian* — the book is in the bag.
- *māo zài wàibian* — the cat is outside.

Listen. *Nǐ de shǒujī ne?*
Speak. Place yourself, then somebody you know, then your phone.
Write it: 在 — the top of 有, a short vertical, then 十 on a long bar

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我在家 你呢 — *wǒ zài jiā, nǐ ne* — I'm at home. And you?
- *Say it:* 你的书呢 — *nǐ de shū ne* — Where's your book?
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我在这儿

Before you move on

Say you are at home. (我在家.) Say the book is in the bag. (*shū zài bāo lǐbian.*) Ask where somebody's book is, with three characters. (你的书呢.)

Chapter 86

Where Is It?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask where something is and understand the answer.
>
> *Asking where with* 哪儿 *and placing the answer in the same slot, on top of, under, and the question every traveller needs, built on one new written character:* 哪*.*

86.1 哪儿 (nǎr) — where?

A new chapter, and it opens with the question the last one kept answering.

- *Recall:* say 我在这儿 — *wǒ zài zhèr*, then 他在那儿 — *tā zài nàr* — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *wàibian*, outside — **R1**
- *Recall:* say *nǐ shì nǎ guó rén*, which country are you from — **R4**, from the chapter on where people come from
- *Recall:* say *liáotiān*, to chat — **R2**

You'll want to know: 哪儿

哪儿 — *nǎr* — "where?".

你在哪儿 *nǐ zài nǎr* — Where are you?

我在那儿 *wǒ zài nàr* — I'm over there.

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

哪儿 (*nǎr*) is built from 哪 'which', the *nǎ* of *nǐ shì nǎ guó rén*, and the r ending 儿. 哪 has no reading in the Guangyun: no dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

The answer goes where the question word was, and nothing else moves: 你在哪儿 — 我在那儿. Only the tone tells the two words apart: *nǎr*, with the dip, asks; *nàr*, with the fall, answers.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǎr* — the dip
- *Say it: nàr* — the fall
- *Say it:* 你在哪儿 — *nǐ zài nǎr* — Where are you?
- *Say it:* 我在那儿 — *wǒ zài nàr* — I'm over there.
- *Recall:* say *liáotiān*, then ask where somebody is

Before you move on

What does 哪儿 ask? ("Where?".) What tells *nǎr* from *nàr*? (**The tone: the dip asks, the fall answers**.)

86.2 哪 — 口 beside the whole of 那

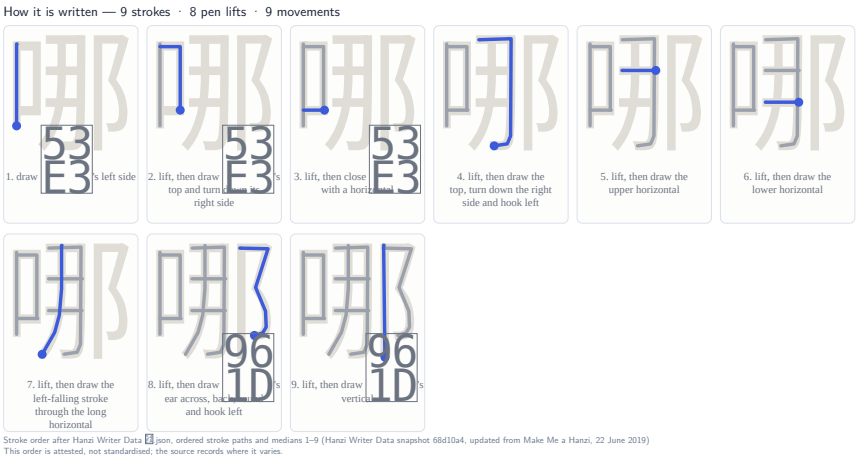
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *nǎr* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  口 那

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *nà*

Script — 口 beside the whole of 那



How 哪 *is written, stroke by stroke*

哪

Two characters you own, side by side. Nothing in it is new.

口, three strokes, small, on the left: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, the bottom bar.

那, six strokes, whole, as you write it alone: the hooked turn across the top and down the right, the upper bar, the lower bar, the left-falling stroke through them, then the ear on the right, across, back, round and hooking, and its long vertical.

3 + 6 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 哪, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 哪? (**Nine**.) Which two characters sit side by side? (**口 and 那**.) What tells 哪 from 那 when you say them? (**The tone: *nǎ* dips, *nà* falls**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 哪, pinned stroke paths and medians.

86.3 shàngbian — on top; above

Before the new one: read the question from the last lesson, then two words for things at home.

- *Read it:* 你在哪儿, aloud — *nǐ zài nǎr*
- *Recall:* say *zhuōzi*, a table
- *Recall:* say *zhōngjiān*, the middle

You'll want to know: shàngbian

shàngbian — "on top; above".

shū zài zhuōzi shàngbian — The book is on the table.

Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shàngbian is built from shàng 'above', the 上 you write, and bian 'side'. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangH* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The Guangyun glosses *dzyangH* as 'ruler', not 'above', so the plain sense 'on top' is assumed here rather than quoted.

What you've built

A thing, then the place word after it: *zhuōzi shàngbian*, on top of the table. With 在 in front it answers 哪儿.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngbian*
- *Say it: shàngbian*, once more
- *Say it: shū zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — The book is on the table.

- *Say it:* 我的手机在哪儿 — *wǒ de shǒujī zài nǎr* — Where's my phone?
- *Recall:* say *zhōngjiān*, then *shàngbian* again

Before you move on

What does *shàngbian* mean? ("On top; above".) Which written character does it open with? (上.)

86.4 xiàbian — under; below

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words you have had for a while.

- *Recall:* say *shàngbian*, on top — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *yǐzi*, a chair — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *duìmiàn*, opposite — **R2**

You'll want to know: xiàbian

xiàbian — "under; below".

māo zài yǐzi xiàbian — The cat is under the chair.

Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàbian is built from xià 'below', the 下 you write, and bian 'side'. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *haeX* glossed 'to go down' and 'the bottom'.

What you've built

shàngbian and *xiàbian*, on top and under: the pair you write as 上 and 下, with the same ending as *lǐbian* and *wàibian*.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàbian*
- *Say it: xiàbian*, once more
- *Say it: māo zài yǐzi xiàbian* — The cat is under the chair.
- *Say it: shū zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — The book is on the table.
- *Recall:* say *duìmiàn*, then *xiàbian* again

Before you move on

What does *xiàbian* mean? ("Under; below".) And on top? (***shàngbian***.)

86.5 xǐshǒujiān — toilet; washroom

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then the polite opener you will need with it.

- *Recall:* say *xiàbian*, under — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 请问 — *qǐngwèn*, excuse me, may I ask
- *Recall:* say *fángjiān*, a room

You'll want to know: xǐshǒujiān

xǐshǒujiān — "toilet; washroom".

qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr — Excuse me, where is the toilet?

Its first and last characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xǐshǒujiān is built from xǐ 'to wash', shǒu 'hand', the 手 you write, and jiān 'room', the jiān of *fángjiān*. All three are inherited from Middle Chinese, *sejX*, *syuwX* and *kean* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The Guangyun glosses *sejX* 'to wash' and *kean* 'a gap; between'; 'a room' is a later sense of jiān.

What you've built

qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr may be the most useful sentence in the chapter: a polite opener, the thing, 在, and the question word in the place slot.

Your turn

- *Say it: xǐshǒujiān*
- *Say it: xǐshǒujiān*, once more
- *Say it: qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr* — Excuse me, where is the toilet?
- *Recall:* say *xiàbian* and *fángjiān*, then *xǐshǒujiān* again

Before you move on

What does *xǐshǒujiān* mean? ("Toilet; washroom".) Ask where it is, politely. (*qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr.*)

86.6 你在哪儿 — 我在那儿

The chapter closes here, with a phone that is not where it should be.

- *Recall:* say *xǐshǒujiān*, the toilet — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *cānjiā*, to take part — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *lǐbian*, inside — **R2**, from the chapter before

The exchange

A: 我的手机呢

wǒ de shǒujī ne — Where's my phone?

B: *zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — On the table.

A: *bú zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — It isn't on the table.

B: *zài yǐzi xiàbian* — Under the chair, then.

A: 对 谢谢

duì, xièxie — Yes. Thanks.

A: *qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr* — Excuse me, where's the toilet?

B: 在那儿

zài nàr — Over there.

A: 你在哪儿

nǐ zài nǎr — And where will you be?

B: *wǒ zài wàibian* — Outside.

Every answer starts at 在, or drops even that. The thing being looked for was named once, and the rest of the exchange leaves it out.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — one question, any answer

One question, 你在哪儿 *nǐ zài nǎr*, and the answer slots into the same place:

- 我在那儿 *wǒ zài nàr* — over there.
- *zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — on the table.
- *zài yǐzi xiàbian* — under the chair.

Listen. *Nǐ de shǒujī zài nǎr?*
Speak. Answer it three ways, then ask it back.
Write it: 哪 — 口 first, then 那

Your turn

- *Say it: qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr* — Excuse me, where's the toilet?
- *Say it:* 我的手机呢 — *wǒ de shǒujī ne* — Where's my phone?

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 你在哪儿

Before you move on

Ask somebody where they are. (你在哪儿.) Ask politely where the toilet is. (*qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr.*) Which tone asks, *nǎr* or *nàr*? (**The dip, *nǎr***.)

Chapter 87

Is There Any?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) ↙ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what there is and is not, and that something did not happen.
>
> *Saying what there is and is not with* 没有*, telling* 不 *from* 没*, and naming a bed, a light, a key and a fridge, built on one new written character:* 没.

87.1 没有 (méiyǒu) — not have; there is no

A new chapter, and it opens with the other half of a word you have used since the first chapters.

- *Recall:* say 你在哪儿 — *nǐ zài nǎr*, and answer it — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *xǐshǒujiān*, the toilet — **R1**
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu shíjiān*, I have time

You'll want to know: 没有

没有 — *méiyǒu* — "not have; there is no".

我没有手机 *wǒ méiyǒu shǒujī* — I don't have a phone.

这儿没有人 *zhèr méiyǒu rén* — There's nobody here.

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

没有 (*méiyǒu*) is built from 没 'not' and 有 'to have'. 有 is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). 没 is there as *mwot*, glossed 'to sink'; the Guangyun does not give 'not', and the regular sound change from *mwot* gives mò, not méi, so how 没 came to mean 'not' and to be said méi is not settled.

What you've built

有 has its own negative, and it is 没, not 不: 没有. Both jobs of 有 go with it, 'to have' and 'there is': 我没有手机, 这儿没有人.

Your turn

- *Say it: méiyǒu*
- *Say it: méiyǒu*, once more
- *Say it:* 我没有手机 — *wǒ méiyǒu shǒujī* — I don't have a phone.
- *Say it:* 这儿没有人 — *zhèr méiyǒu rén* — There's nobody here.
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yǒu shíjiān*, then turn it round: *wǒ méiyǒu shíjiān*

Before you move on

What does 没有 mean? ("Not have; there is no".) Which negative goes with 有? (没.)

87.2 没 — water, a small roof, and 又

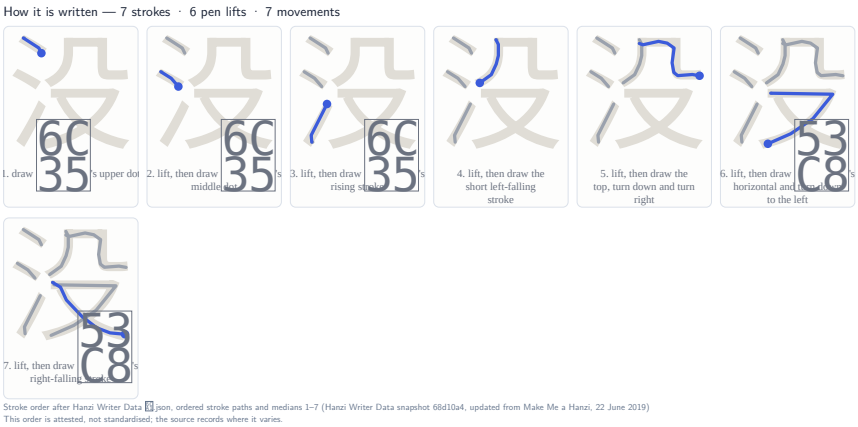
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *méiyǒu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  汉 对

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *hàn*, *duì*

Script — water, a small roof, and 又



How 没 is written, stroke by stroke

没

Three pieces, left before right, top before bottom.

The water piece 氵, three strokes, as 汉 opens: two dots, then a stroke rising to the right.

A small roof, two strokes: a short left-falling stroke, then a horizontal that turns down and runs out to the right.

又, two strokes, under the roof, as 对 opens: across and falling to the left, then the long stroke falling to the right.

3 + 2 + 2 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 没, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 没? (**Seven.**) Which character opens with the same water piece? (汉.) Which shape sits under the roof? (**又, as in 对.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 没, pinned stroke paths and medians.

87.3 不 — 没: two words for not

Two words for 'not', and this lesson sorts them.

- *Read it:* 没有, aloud — *méiyǒu*
- *Recall:* say 不 — *bù*, not
- *Recall:* say 好不好 — *hǎo bu hǎo*, is that all right?

Grammar Lens: 不 for now and for habit, 没 for what did not happen

不 says no about now, about habit, and about what you will or won't do. 没 says something did not happen.

我不去 *wǒ bú qù* — I'm not going; I don't go. 我没去 *wǒ méi qù* — I didn't go.

Same verb, same person; the negative alone moves the sentence from a decision to a report. 不 before the fall of 去 is *bú*, as in *bú shì*. And 有 takes 没 every time, which is how the question works:

你有没有手机 *nǐ yǒu méiyǒu shǒujī* — Do you have a phone?

It is the same yes-or-no shape as 好不好: the verb, its negative, the verb again. The answer is 有 or 没有.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 我不去 — *wǒ bú qù* — I'm not going.
- 我没去 — *wǒ méi qù* — I didn't go.
- 你有没有手机 — *nǐ yǒu méiyǒu shǒujī* — Do you have a phone?
- 没有 — *méiyǒu* — No, I don't.

Before you move on

Which negative says something did not happen? (没.) Which one says you won't? (不.) How do you ask whether somebody has a phone? (你有没有手机.)

87.4 chuáng — bed

Before the new one: the two negatives, then two words for home.

- *Recall:* say 我没去 — *wǒ méi qù*, I didn't go
- *Recall:* say *fángjiān*, a room — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *qǐchuáng*, to get up — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: chuáng

chuáng — "bed".

fángjiān lǐ yǒu chuáng ma — Is there a bed in the room?

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chuáng is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzrjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a bed of slats'. It is the chuáng of *qǐchuáng*: to rise from the bed.

What you've built

fángjiān lǐ yǒu chuáng ma is 有 in its 'there is' job: the place first, then 有, then the thing. The answer is 有 or 没有.

Your turn

- *Say it: chuáng*
- *Say it: chuáng*, once more
- *Say it: fángjiān lǐ yǒu chuáng ma* — Is there a bed in the room?
- *Say it:* 没有 — *méiyǒu* — No, there isn't.

- *Recall:* say *qǐchuáng*, then *chuáng* again

Before you move on

What does *chuáng* mean? ("Bed".) Which word you know ends with it? (***qǐchuáng***, to get up.)

87.5 dēng — lamp; light

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then the two verbs that go with this one.

- *Recall:* say *chuáng*, bed — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *kāi*, to switch on — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *guān*, to switch off — **R3**

You'll want to know: dēng

dēng — "lamp; light".

kāi dēng — Switch on the light.

guān dēng — Switch off the light.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dēng is inherited from Middle Chinese *tong* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a lamp'.

What you've built

kāi and *guān* open and shut doors, and the same two verbs switch a light on and off.

Your turn

- *Say it: dēng*
- *Say it: dēng*, once more

- *Say it: kāi dēng* — Switch on the light.
- *Say it: guān dēng* — Switch off the light.
- *Recall:* say *chuáng*, then *dēng* again

Before you move on

What does *dēng* mean? (“Lamp; light”.) Switch it on. (*kāi dēng*.)

87.6 yàoshi — key

Before the new one: last lesson’s word, then two words for coming in.

- *Recall:* say *dēng*, a light — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 门 — *mén*, a door
- *Recall:* say 进 — *jìn*, to come in

You’ll want to know: yàoshi

yàoshi — “key”.

wǒ méiyǒu yàoshi — I don’t have a key.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yàoshi is built from two words inherited from Middle Chinese, *yak* and *dzye* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’a bolt’ and ’a spoon’. The Guangyun does not give the pair as ’key’, so how the two came together is not settled.

What you’ve built

wǒ méiyǒu yàoshi: 没有 in its ’not have’ job, with nothing between it and the thing.

Your turn

- *Say it: yàoshi*
- *Say it: yàoshi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ méiyǒu yàoshi* — I don't have a key.
- *Say it: mén*, then *yàoshi*
- *Recall:* say *dēng*, then *yàoshi* again

Before you move on

What does *yàoshi* mean? ("Key".) Say you don't have one. (*wǒ méiyǒu yàoshi.*)

87.7 bīngxiāng — fridge

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then a drink, then a word for hurrying.

- *Recall:* say *yàoshi*, a key — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *niúnǎi*, milk — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say 马上 — *mǎshàng*, right away — **R2**

You'll want to know: bīngxiāng

bīngxiāng — "fridge; refrigerator".

bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi — There's milk in the fridge.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bīngxiāng is built from bīng 'ice' and xiāng 'a box', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ping* and *sjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'frozen water' and 'a box; a chest'. The pair names a machine the Guangyun never saw: the compound is modern.

What you've built

The place first, then 有, then the thing: *bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi.* The 里 after *bīngxiāng* is the one you write, and it means inside.

Your turn

- *Say it: bīngxiāng*
- *Say it: bīngxiāng*, once more
- *Say it: bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi* — There's milk in the fridge.
- *Say it: bīngxiāng lǐ méiyǒu shuǐ* — There's no water in the fridge.
- *Recall:* say *yàoshi* and *mǎshàng*, then *bīngxiāng* again

Before you move on

What does *bīngxiāng* mean? ("Fridge".) Say there is milk in it. (*bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi.*)

87.8 你有没有 — 没有

The chapter closes here, with a guest shown to a room.

- *Recall:* say *bīngxiāng*, a fridge — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *chídào*, to be late — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *láibují*, to run out of time — **R2**

The exchange

A: *zhè shì nǐ de fángjiān* — This is your room.

B: 谢谢

xièxie — Thanks.

B: *fángjiān lǐ yǒu dēng ma* — Is there a light in the room?

A: *yǒu, zài mén pángbiān* — Yes, by the door.

B: *nǐ yǒu méiyǒu yàoshi* — Have you got a key?

A: 没有

méiyǒu — No, I haven't.

A: *bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi* — There's milk in the fridge.

B: 我不喝

wǒ bù hē — I don't drink it.

Two kinds of no in one room: 没有, there isn't any, and 我不喝, I don't drink it. The first reports, the second refuses.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — four things, and what is missing

A bed, a light, a key and a fridge, and two ways to say a thing is not there:

- *nǐ yǒu méiyǒu yàoshi* — 没有 *méiyǒu*
- *fángjiān lǐ yǒu chuáng ma* — 没有 *méiyǒu*

Listen. *Nǐ yǒu méiyǒu shǒujī?*
Speak. Answer it with 有, then with 没有, then say what your room has.
Write it: 没 — 氵 first, then the small roof, then the crossing pair that opens 对

Your turn

- *Say it: nǐ yǒu méiyǒu yàoshi* — Have you got a key?
- *Say it:* 没有 — *méiyǒu* — No.
- *Say it: kāi dēng* — Switch on the light.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我没有手机

Before you move on

Say you don't have a phone. (我没有手机.) Say you didn't go. (我没去.) Say there is milk in the fridge. (*bīngxiāng lǐ yǒu niúnǎi*.)

Chapter 88

Two Cups of Tea

Modes: **voice** (7) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count things with 两 and the right measure word.
>
> *Counting things with* 两 *and four measure words beyond* 个*, and the tone* 一 *takes before each, built on one new written character:* 两*.*

88.1 两 (liǎng) — two of something

A new chapter, and it opens with a second word for two.

- *Recall:* say *nǐ yǒu méiyǒu yàoshi*, and answer *méiyǒu* — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say 一个人 — *yí ge rén*, one person
- *Recall:* say 二 — *èr*, two, as you count

You'll want to know: 两

两 — *liǎng* — "two (of something)".

> 两个人 *liǎng ge rén* — two people

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

两 (*liǎng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *ljangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where it names a weight and, quoting an older dictionary, 'twice'. 'Two of a thing' grew from those senses by a step the Guangyun does not show.

What you've built

Counting aloud, two is 二: *yī, èr, sān*. In front of a measure word it is 两: 两个人, two people. *èr ge rén* is not said.

Your turn

- *Say it: liǎng*
- *Say it: liǎng*, once more
- *Say it:* 两个人 — *liǎng ge rén* — two people
- *Say it:* 一 二 三 — *yī èr sān* — counting: one, two, three
- *Recall:* say *yí ge rén*, then *liǎng ge rén*

Before you move on

When is two 两? (**In front of a measure word:** 两个人.) And when is it 二? (**Counting: *yī, èr, sān***.)

88.2 两 — a bar, a frame, two small 人

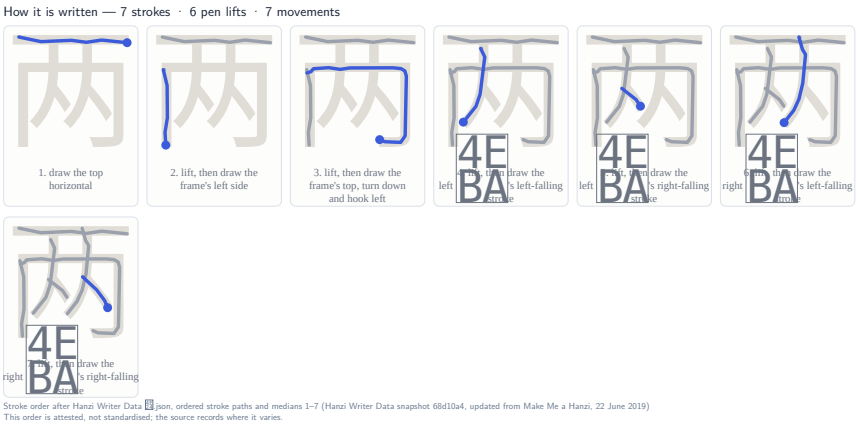
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *liǎng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

一 人

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *yī*, *rén*

Script — a bar, a frame, two small 人



How 两 *is written, stroke by stroke*

两

A bar on top, then a frame, then what the frame holds.

The top bar, one stroke, across.

The frame, two strokes: a short vertical on the left, then a horizontal that turns down the right side and hooks to the left.

Two small 人, four strokes, the left one first: each a left-falling stroke and a short stroke falling to the right, rising through the top of the frame.

1 + 2 + 4 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 两, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 两? (**Seven**.) What does the frame hold? (**Two small 人**.) Which comes first, the frame or the two 人? (**The frame**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 两, pinned stroke paths and medians.

88.3 yī → yí ge, yì tiān: the tone 一 takes

Before the measure words, the sound that changes in front of them.

- *Read it:* 两个人, aloud — *liǎng ge rén*
- *Recall:* say 一百 — *yìbǎi*, a hundred
- *Recall:* say 一起 — *yìqǐ*, together

The sounds and tones in this word

一 has three spoken tones, and the next syllable picks one.
Counting, and inside numbers and dates, it stays level: *yī, èr, sān*; 星期一 *xīngqīyī*.
Before a fourth tone it rises: 一个 *yí ge*. 个 is fourth tone, even when it is said light.
Before the other three tones it falls: 一天 *yì tiān*, 一年 *yì nián*, 一百 *yìbǎi*.
This book writes the tone you say, as it writes *bú shì* for 不是.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *yī, èr, sān* — level
- 一个 — *yí ge* — rising, before a fourth tone
- 一天 — *yì tiān* — falling, before a first tone
- 一年 — *yì nián* — falling, before a second tone
- 一百 — *yìbǎi* — falling, before a third tone

Before you move on

What does 一 do before a fourth tone? (**It rises: *yí ge***.) Before the other tones? (**It falls: *yì tiān***.) And counting? (**It stays level: *yī***.)

88.4 bēi — a cup of, a glass of

Before the new one: the tone of 一, then two words that go with this one.

- *Recall:* say 一个 — *yí ge*, then 一天 — *yì tiān*
- *Recall:* say *chá*, tea — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *bēizi*, a cup — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: bēi

bēi — "a cup of; a glass of", a measure word.

liǎng bēi chá — two cups of tea

yì bēi shuǐ — a glass of water

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bēi is inherited from Middle Chinese *pwoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed through an older book as a cup. It is the bēi of *bēizi*; as a measure word it counts what a cup holds.

What you've built

A measure word counts by the container: *liǎng bēi chá*, two cups' worth. 一 before its level tone falls: *yì bēi*.

Your turn

- *Say it: bēi*
- *Say it: bēi*, once more
- *Say it: liǎng bēi chá* — two cups of tea
- *Say it: yì bēi shuǐ* — a glass of water
- *Recall:* say *bēizi*, then *bēi* again

Before you move on

What does *bēi* count? (**Cups and glasses of something**.) Ask for two cups of tea. (*liǎng bēi chá*.)

88.5 běn — counting books

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then the thing this one counts.

- *Recall:* say *liǎng bēi chá*, two cups of tea — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 书 — *shū*, a book

You'll want to know: běn

běn — a measure word for books.

yì běn shū — a book

wǒ yǒu liǎng běn shū — I have two books.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

běn is inherited from Middle Chinese *pwonX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the root; the beginning'. Counting books with it is a later use the Guangyun does not record.

What you've built

个 counts almost anything; *běn* is the word a speaker reaches for with books. 一 before its dip falls: *yì běn*.

Your turn

- *Say it: běn*
- *Say it: běn*, once more
- *Say it: yì běn shū* — a book

- *Say it: wǒ yǒu liǎng běn shū* — I have two books.
- *Recall:* say *liǎng bēi chá*, then *liǎng běn shū*

Before you move on

What does *běn* count? (**Books**.) Say you have two. (*wǒ yǒu liǎng běn shū*.)

88.6 zhāng — counting flat things

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two flat things.

- *Recall:* say *yì běn shū*, a book — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *piào*, a ticket — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *chuáng*, a bed — **R1**, from the chapter before

You'll want to know: zhāng

zhāng — a measure word for flat things: tables, beds, tickets.

yì zhāng zhuōzi — a table

liǎng zhāng piào — two tickets

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhāng is inherited from Middle Chinese *trjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to stretch out; to spread'. Counting things that lie spread flat is a later use, not given there.

What you've built

A table, a bed, a ticket: things with a flat top or a flat face take *zhāng*.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhāng*
- *Say it: zhāng*, once more
- *Say it: liǎng zhāng piào* — two tickets
- *Say it: yì zhāng chuáng* — a bed
- *Recall:* say *yì běn shū*, then *yì zhāng zhuōzi*

Before you move on

What does *zhāng* count? (**Flat things: tables, beds, tickets**.)
Ask for two tickets. (*liǎng zhāng piào.*)

88.7 zhī — counting animals

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two animals.

- *Recall:* say *liǎng zhāng piào*, two tickets — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *māo*, a cat — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *gǒu*, a dog — **R3**

You'll want to know: zhī

zhī — a measure word for animals, and for one of a pair.

liǎng zhī māo — two cats

yì zhī shǒu — one hand

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhī is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyek* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'one'; the Guangyun, quoting an older dictionary, describes the old character as a hand holding a single bird.

What you've built

Cats, dogs, birds: animals take *zhī*. So does one of a pair, such as a hand: *yì zhī shǒu*.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhī*
- *Say it: zhī*, once more
- *Say it: liǎng zhī māo* — two cats
- *Say it: wǒ jiā yǒu yì zhī gǒu* — We have a dog at home.
- *Recall:* say *liǎng zhāng piào*, then *liǎng zhī māo*

Before you move on

What does *zhī* count? (**Animals, and one of a pair**.) Say two cats. (*liǎng zhī māo*.)

88.8 两个人

The chapter closes here, with two people looking for a table.

- *Recall:* say *liǎng zhī māo*, two cats — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *shàngbian*, on top — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *jǐ*, how many — **R4**, recognition at distance

The exchange

A: *nǐmen jǐ ge rén* — How many of you are there?

B: 两个人

liǎng ge rén — Two.

A: 你们喝什么

nǐmen hē shénme — What will you drink?

B: *liǎng bēi chá* — Two cups of tea.

A: *hǎo, nà zhāng zhuōzi* — Fine. That table, then.

B: *nàr yǒu liǎng zhī māo* — There are two cats there.

A: *zhuōzi shàngbian yǒu yì běn shū* — And there's a book on the table.

Every count has its measure word: 个 for people, *bēi* for tea, *zhāng* for the table, *zhī* for the cats, *běn* for the book. And every two is 两.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — a number, a measure word, a thing

Every count has three parts, in this order: the number, the measure word, the thing.

- 两个人 *liǎng ge rén* — two people
- *yì bēi shuǐ* — a glass of water
- *yì běn shū* — a book
- *liǎng zhāng piào* — two tickets
- *liǎng zhī māo* — two cats

Listen. *Nǐ yǒu jǐ běn shū?*
Speak. Count what is on your table, with the right measure word for each.
Write it: 两 — the bar, the frame, then the two small 人

Your turn

- *Say it:* 两个人 — *liǎng ge rén* — two people
- *Say it: liǎng bēi chá* — two cups of tea
- *Say it: yí ge, yì běn, yì zhāng, yì zhī* — and listen to 一 move

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 两个人

Before you move on

Two people? (两个人.) Two cups of tea? (*liǎng bēi chá.*) A book? (*yì běn shū.*) Two cats? (*liǎng zhī māo.*)

Chapter 89

Give Me That

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name everyday actions: give, do, put, bring, stand.
>
> *Five everyday actions, give, do, put, bring and stand, and* 给我 *as a request, built on one new written character:* 给.

89.1 给 (gěi) — to give; to, for

A new chapter, and it opens with the verb that hands things over.

- *Recall:* say 两个人 — *liǎng ge rén*, two people
- *Recall:* say *liǎng zhī māo*, two cats — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *sòng*, to give as a present — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: 给

给 — *gěi* — "to give; to, for".

> 妈妈给我一个手机 *māma gěi wǒ yí ge shǒujī* — Mum gives me a phone.
>
> 给我 *gěi wǒ* — Give it to me.

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

给 (*gěi*) is in the Guangyun as *kip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to supply'. That reading regularly gives jǐ, still heard in a few written words; how the everyday gěi came about is not settled.

What you've built

The person comes first, then the thing: 给, 我, 一个手机. On its own, 给我 is a request: give me. *sòng* gives a present; 给 gives anything at all.

Your turn

- *Say it: gěi*
- *Say it: gěi*, once more
- *Say it:* 妈妈给我一个手机 — *māma gěi wǒ yí ge shǒujī* — Mum gives me a phone.
- *Say it:* 给我 — *gěi wǒ* — Give it to me.
- *Recall:* say *sòng*, then *gěi* again

Before you move on

What does 给 mean? ("To give; to, for".) Which comes first after 给, the person or the thing? (**The person**.)

89.2 给 — the silk piece, then 合

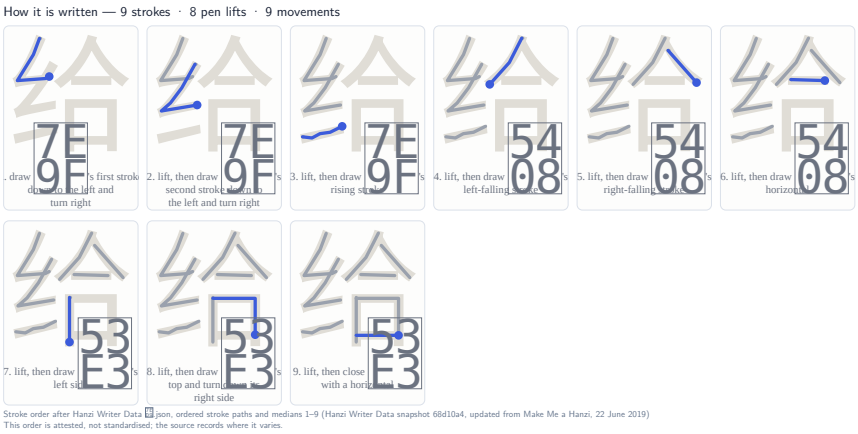
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *gěi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

人 一 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, *yī*, *kǒu*

Script — the silk piece, then 合



How 给 *is written, stroke by stroke*

给

Two pieces, left before right. The left piece is the one new shape.

The silk piece 纟, three strokes: a stroke that falls to the left and turns right, a second, longer one the same way, then a stroke rising to the right.

合, six strokes: a roof like 人, a left-falling stroke and a right-falling one; a short horizontal under it; then 口.

3 + 6 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 给, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 给? (**Nine.**) Which piece is new? (**The silk piece, on the left.**) What sits at the foot of the right piece? (口.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 给, pinned stroke paths and medians.

89.3 做 (zuò) — to do; to make

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then a word you already write.

- *Read it:* 给你, aloud — *gěi nǐ*, here you are
- *Recall:* say 做饭 — *zuòfàn*, to cook
- *Recall:* say *wǒmen zuò chē qù*, we're going by car

You'll want to know: 做

做 — *zuò* — "to do; to make".

你做什么 *nǐ zuò shénme* — What are you doing?

妈妈做饭 *māma zuò fàn* — Mum cooks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

做 (*zuò*) has no reading in the Guangyun: no dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

You have written 做 since 做饭. *zuò* 'to sit', as in *zuò chē*, sounds the same and is a different word with a different character.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuò*
- *Say it: zuò*, once more
- *Say it:* 你做什么 — *nǐ zuò shénme* — What are you doing?
- *Say it:* 妈妈做饭 — *māma zuò fàn* — Mum cooks.
- *Recall:* say *zuò chē*, then 做饭, and hear the same sound twice

Before you move on

What does 做 mean? ("To do; to make".) Is it the *zuò* of *zuò chē*? (**No: same sound, another word**.)

89.4 fàng — to put; to place

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then a bag and a table.

- *Recall:* say 你做什么 — *nǐ zuò shénme*
- *Recall:* say *bāo*, a bag — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *zhuōzi shàngbian*, on the table — **R2**

You'll want to know: fàng

fàng — "to put; to place".

fàng zài zhèr — Put it here.

fàng zài zhuōzi shàngbian — Put it on the table.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fàng is inherited from Middle Chinese *pjangH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to drive out; to send away'. 'To put down' is a later sense the Guangyun does not give.

What you've built

fàng, then 在, then the place: the place words of the last two chapters all fit after it.

Your turn

- *Say it: fàng*
- *Say it: fàng*, once more
- *Say it: fàng zài zhèr* — Put it here.

- *Say it: fàng zài bāo lǐbian* — Put it in the bag.
- *Recall:* say *zuò*, then *fàng* again

Before you move on

What does *fàng* mean? ("To put; to place".) Put it here. (*fàng zài zhèr*.)

89.5 dài — to bring; to take along

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two things you take out with you.

- *Recall:* say *fàng zài zhèr*, put it here — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 手机 — *shǒujī*, a phone
- *Recall:* say *yàoshi*, a key

You'll want to know: dài

dài — "to bring; to take along".

nǐ dài shǒujī le ma — Have you brought your phone?

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dài is inherited from Middle Chinese *tajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a belt; a sash'. How a belt became 'to carry along' is not given there, so the step is not settled.

What you've built

nǐ dài shǒujī le ma: 了 after the verb says it is done, and 吗 makes the question. The answer is *dài le*, or *méi dài*.

Your turn

- *Say it: dài*
- *Say it: dài*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ dài shǒujī le ma* — Have you brought your phone?
- *Say it: méi dài* — No, I haven't.
- *Recall:* say *yàoshi*, then *dài* again

Before you move on

What does *dài* mean? ("To bring; to take along".) Say you didn't bring it. (*méi dài*.)

89.6 zhàn — to stand

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two places.

- *Recall:* say *dài*, to bring — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *huǒchēzhàn*, a railway station — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say 门口 — *ménkǒu*, the doorway

You'll want to know: zhàn

zhàn — "to stand".

qǐng zhàn zài zhèr — Please stand here.

tā zhàn zài ménkǒu — He's standing in the doorway.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *treamH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'in common speech, to stand alone'. The same word and character end *huǒchēzhàn*, a railway station.

What you've built

zhàn takes 在 and a place, as *fàng* does: *zhàn zài ménkǒu*, standing in the doorway.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhàn*
- *Say it: zhàn*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng zhàn zài zhèr* — Please stand here.
- *Say it: tā zhàn zài ménkǒu* — He's standing in the doorway.
- *Recall:* say *huǒchēzhàn*, then *zhàn* again

Before you move on

What does *zhàn* mean? ("To stand".) Where else have you heard it? (**At the end of *huǒchēzhàn***.)

89.7 给我

The chapter closes here, with somebody getting out of the door.

- *Recall:* say *zhàn*, to stand — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *zhǔnbèi*, to get ready — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *chūmén*, to go out — **R4**, recognition at distance

The exchange

A: 你做什么

nǐ zuò shénme — What are you doing?

B: *wǒ zhǔnbèi chūmén* — I'm getting ready to go out.

A: *nǐ dài yàoshi le ma* — Have you got your key?

B: *dài le. shǒujī ne* — Yes. Where's my phone?

A: *zài zhuōzi shàngbian. gěi nǐ* — On the table. Here you are.

B: *xièxie. fàng zài bāo lǐbian* — Thanks. In the bag it goes.

A: *qǐng zhàn zài ménkǒu, wǒ kànkan* — Stand in the doorway, let me look at you.

Five actions in one doorway: do, bring, give, put and stand. 给你, here you are, is 给 handing something over as it is said.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — five actions

Five verbs, and the three that take a place take it with 在:

- 给我 *gěi wǒ* — give it to me
- 你做什么 *nǐ zuò shénme* — what are you doing?
- *fàng zài zhèr* — put it here
- *nǐ dài shǒujī le ma* — have you brought your phone?
- *qǐng zhàn zài zhèr* — please stand here

Listen. *Gěi wǒ nǐ de shǒujī.*
Speak. Hand it over with 给你, then say where you put it.
Write it: 给 — the silk piece first, then the roof, the bar and 口

Your turn

- *Say it:* 给我 — *gěi wǒ* — Give it to me.
- *Say it:* 给你 — *gěi nǐ* — Here you are.
- *Say it: nǐ dài yàoshi le ma* — Have you got your key?
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 给你

Before you move on

Hand something over. (给你.) Ask what somebody is doing. (你做什么.) Tell somebody to put it here. (*fàng zài zhèr.*) Ask whether they brought their key. (*nǐ dài yàoshi le ma.*)

Chapter 90

What I Can Do

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I can do and ask whether I may.
>
> *Three ways to say can:* 会 *for what you have learned,* 能 *for what you are able or allowed to do, kěyǐ for asking permission, built on one new written character:* 能.

90.1 会 (huì) — can, having learned how

A new chapter, and it opens with what you have learned to do.

- *Recall:* say 给你 — *gěi nǐ*, here you are
- *Recall:* say *qǐng zhàn zài zhèr*, please stand here — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *sījī*, a driver — **R2**

You'll want to know: 会

会 — *huì* — "can (having learned how)".

> 我会开车 *wǒ huì kāichē* — I can drive.
>
> 我会说汉语 *wǒ huì shuō Hànyǔ* — I can speak Chinese.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

会 (*huì*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to come together'. The sense 'can' is not given there, so how it got it is not settled.

What you've built

会 + a verb says you have learned to do it: driving, a language, a skill. A *sījī huì kāichē*: a driver can drive. You have written 会 since 一会儿; this is another word in the same character.

Your turn

- *Say it: huì*
- *Say it: huì*, once more
- *Say it:* 我会开车 — *wǒ huì kāichē* — I can drive.
- *Say it:* 我会说汉语 — *wǒ huì shuō Hànyǔ* — I can speak Chinese.
- *Recall:* say *sījī*, then say a driver can drive: *sījī huì kāichē*

Before you move on

What does 会 say? (**That you have learned how**.) Say you can drive. (我会开车.)

90.2 能 (néng) — can; able, allowed

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words about being ill.

- *Recall:* say 我会开车 — *wǒ huì kāichē*
- *Recall:* say *bìng*, to fall ill — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *yīshēng*, a doctor — **R2**

You'll want to know: 能

能 — *néng* — "can; to be able to; to be allowed to".

我能去吗 *wǒ néng qù ma* — Can I go?

wǒ bìng le, bù néng qù — I'm ill, I can't go.

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

能 (*néng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *nong* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'skilled; good at work'.

What you've built

会 is a skill you have learned. 能 is being able right now, or being allowed: you 会 drive, but ill you 不能.

Your turn

- *Say it: néng*
- *Say it: néng*, once more
- *Say it:* 我能去吗 — *wǒ néng qù ma* — Can I go?
- *Say it: wǒ bìng le, bù néng qù* — I'm ill, I can't go.
- *Recall:* say *yīshēng*, then *néng* again

Before you move on

What does 能 say? (**Able now, or allowed**.) And 会? (**Learned how**.)

90.3 能 — 厶 over the moon piece, then two 匕

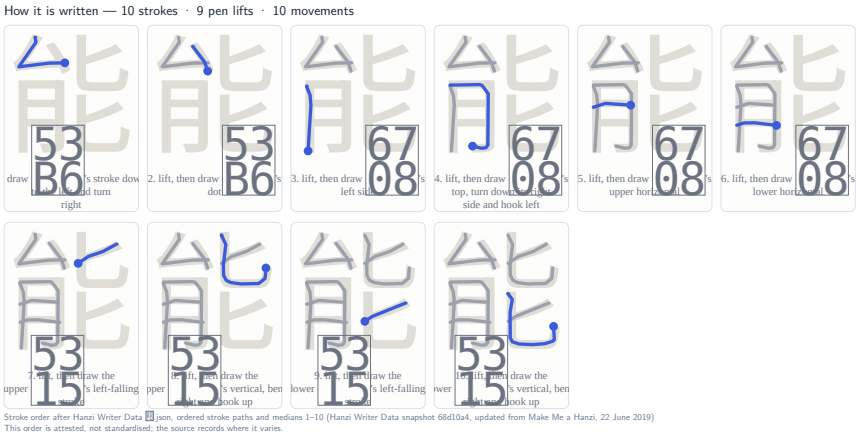
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *néng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

明 前

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *míng*, *qián*

Script — 厶 over the moon piece, then two 匕



How 能 *is written, stroke by stroke*

能

The whole left side first, top to bottom, then the right.

厶, two strokes: a stroke that falls to the left and turns right, then a dot.

The moon piece 月, four strokes, as it stands in 明 and 前: the left side, the top that turns down and hooks, two short bars inside.

Two 匕, two strokes each, the upper one first: a short left-falling stroke, then a vertical that bends right along its foot and hooks up.

2 + 4 + 4 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 能, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 能? (**Ten.**) Which piece do you know from 明? (**The moon piece, 月.**) Which side is written first? (**The left, all of it.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 能, pinned stroke paths and medians.

90.4 kěyǐ — may; can, with permission

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words you will need with this one.

- *Read it:* 我能去吗, aloud — *wǒ néng qù ma*
- *Recall:* say *zuò*, to sit — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *gōngrén*, a worker — **R2**

You'll want to know: kěyǐ

kěyǐ — "may; can (with permission)".

wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma — May I sit here?

Two dips in a row: spoken, the first one rises, *kéyǐ*. It is written *kěyǐ*. Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kěyǐ is built from kě 'may' and yǐ 'to use', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khaX* and *yiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to permit' and 'to use'.

What you've built

会 learned, 能 able or allowed, *kěyǐ* permitted. Asking whether you may, *kěyǐ* is the polite one; the answer is *kěyǐ*, or *bù kěyǐ*.

Your turn

- *Say it: kěyǐ* — and hear it as *kéyǐ*
- *Say it: kěyǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma* — May I sit here?
- *Say it: kěyǐ* — yes, you may
- *Recall:* say *gōngrén*, then *kěyǐ* again

Before you move on

What does *kěyǐ* ask? (**Whether you may**.) How is it said? (***kéyǐ***, the first dip rising.)

90.5 yóuyǒng — to swim

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two kinds of exercise.

- *Recall:* say *kěyǐ*, may — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *yùndòng*, sport — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *pǎobù*, to run — **R4**

You'll want to know: yóuyǒng

yóuyǒng — "to swim".

nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma — Can you swim?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yóuyǒng is built from yóu 'to float' and yǒng 'to swim under water', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yuw* and *hjwaengH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). *hjwaengH* would regularly give yòng, with a fall; why the modern word dips is not settled.

What you've built

Swimming is learned, so it takes 会: *nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma.* 能 asks whether you are able today: *jīntiān nǐ néng yóuyǒng ma.*

Your turn

- *Say it: yóuyǒng*
- *Say it: yóuyǒng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma* — Can you swim?
- *Say it: wǒ bú huì yóuyǒng* — I can't swim.

- *Recall:* say *pǎobù*, then *yóuyǒng* again

Before you move on

What does *yóuyǒng* mean? ("To swim".) Which can goes with it, 会 or 能? (**会, a skill you learn**.)

90.6 我会开车

The chapter closes here, with three ways to say can in one conversation.

- *Recall:* say *yóuyǒng*, to swim — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *shàngbān*, to go to work — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *gōngsī*, a company — **R2**

The exchange

A: 你会开车吗

nǐ huì kāichē ma — Can you drive?

B: 会

huì — I can.

A: 你明天能开车吗

nǐ míngtiān néng kāichē ma — Can you drive tomorrow?

B: *bù néng, wǒ míngtiān shàngbān* — No, I'm at work tomorrow.

A: *nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma* — Can you swim?

B: 不会

bú huì — I can't.

A: *wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma* — May I sit here?

B: *kěyǐ* — Yes, please.

The answer to each is the verb alone: 会, 不能, 不会, *kěyǐ*. Mandarin answers yes or no by saying the verb again.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — three cans

- 我会开车 *wǒ huì kāichē* — I have learned to drive.
- 我明天不能开车 *wǒ míngtiān bù néng kāichē* — tomorrow I'm not able to.
- *wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma* — may I sit here?

Listen. *Nǐ huì shuō Hànyǔ ma?*
Speak. Answer it, then say one thing you cannot do today, and ask permission for something.
Write it: 能 — the whole left side first, then the two hooked pieces on the right

Your turn

- *Say it:* 你会开车吗 — *nǐ huì kāichē ma* — Can you drive?
- *Say it:* 你明天能开车吗 — *nǐ míngtiān néng kāichē ma* — Can you drive tomorrow?
- *Say it: wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma* — May I sit here?
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我能去吗

Before you move on

Say you can drive. (我会开车.) Ask whether you can go. (我能去吗.) Ask whether you may sit here. (*wǒ kěyǐ zuò zhèr ma.*) Which can is a skill? (会.)

Chapter 91

What I'd Like

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) ↙ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I want and what I do not want.
>
> *Saying what you would like, what you need and what you do not want, and asking for a little, built on one new written character:* 要.

91.1 想要 (xiǎngyào) — to want; would like

A new chapter, and it opens with a word for wanting, softer than the one you know.

- *Recall:* say 我会开车 — *wǒ huì kāichē*
- *Recall:* say *nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma*, can you swim — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yào zhège*, I want this one — **R4**, from the chapter on money
- *Recall:* say 我想去 — *wǒ xiǎng qù*, I'd like to go

You'll want to know: 想要

想要 — *xiǎngyào* — "to want; would like".

> 我想要一个手机 *wǒ xiǎngyào yí ge shǒujī* — I'd like a phone.

The next lesson puts the second character in your hand: it is the *yào* you have said since the chapter on money.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

想要 (*xiǎngyào*) is built from 想 'to think of; to want to' and *yào* 'to want', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjangX* and *'jiewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to think' and 'to bind by agreement'. 'To want' is not given there for *yào*, so how it got that sense is not settled.

What you've built

想 + a verb: you would like to do it, 我想去. *yào* + a thing: you want it. 想要 + a thing says the same as *yào*, more gently.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiǎngyào*
- *Say it: xiǎngyào*, once more
- *Say it:* 我想要一个手机 — *wǒ xiǎngyào yí ge shǒujī* — I'd like a phone.
- *Say it:* 我想去 — *wǒ xiǎng qù* — I'd like to go.
- *Recall:* say *wǒ yào zhège*, then say it more gently with 想要

Before you move on

What does 想要 take, a thing or a verb? (**A thing:** 想要一个手机.) And 想 alone? (**A verb:** 我想去.)

91.2 要 — the top of 西, then 女

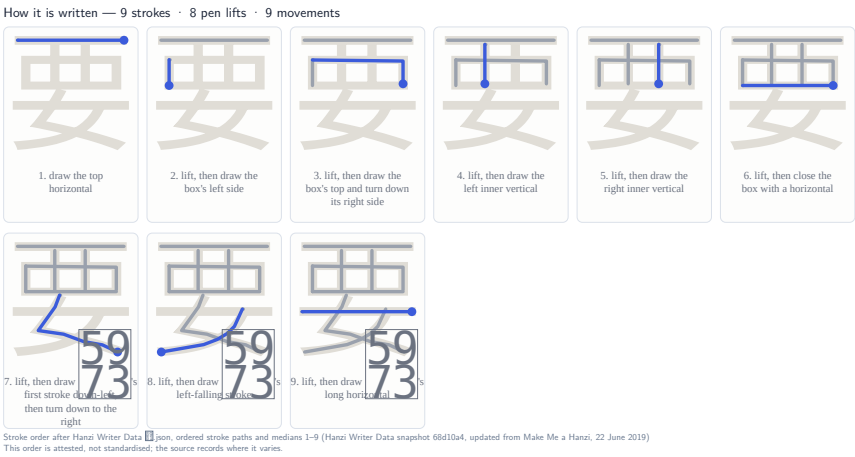
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xiǎngyào* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  女 妈

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *nǚ*, *mā*

Script — the top of 西, then 女



How 要 is written, stroke by stroke

要

Two pieces, top before bottom, and the bottom one you have written since 好.

覀, six strokes: the top bar; then a box, its left side and its top turning down the right side; two short verticals inside it; then the bar that closes the box.

女, three strokes, wide under it: the stroke that falls left and turns down to the right, the left-falling stroke, then the long bar.

6 + 3 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 要, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 要? (**Nine**.) Which character you know sits at the foot? (女.) When is the box closed? (**Before 女 begins**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 要, pinned stroke paths and medians.

91.3 不要 (bú yào) — don't; do not want

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words with the same rising 不.

- *Read it:* 我想要, aloud — *wǒ xiǎngyào*
- *Recall:* say 不是 — *bú shì*
- *Recall:* say 不客气 — *bú kèqi*, you're welcome

You'll want to know: 不要

不要 — *bú yào* — "don't; do not want".

我不要 *wǒ bú yào* — I don't want it.

不要说 *bú yào shuō* — Don't say it.

不 before the fall of 要 rises: *bú yào*, as in *bú shì*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

不要 (*bú yào*) is built from 不 'not' and 要 'to want', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjut* and *'jiewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

Two jobs. 我不要: I don't want it. 不要 + a verb: don't do it. The second is how Mandarin tells somebody not to.

Your turn

- *Say it: bú yào*
- *Say it: bú yào*, once more
- *Say it:* 我不要 — *wǒ bú yào* — I don't want it.
- *Say it:* 不要说 — *bú yào shuō* — Don't say it.
- *Recall:* say *bú kèqi*, then *bú yào*, and hear the same rise

Before you move on

What are the two jobs of 不要? (**I don't want it, and don't do it**.) Which tone does 不 take here? (**It rises: *bú***.)

91.4 xūyào — to need

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two things a tired person needs.

- *Recall:* say 不要说 — *bú yào shuō*, don't say it
- *Recall:* say *xiūxi*, to rest — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *bāngmáng*, to help out — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: xūyào

xūyào — "to need".

wǒ xūyào xiūxi — I need a rest.

nǐ xūyào bāngmáng ma — Do you need a hand?

Its first character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xūyào is built from xū and yào 'to want', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sju* and *'jiewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The Guangyun glosses *sju* only as the name of a hexagram, so 'to need' is not given there.

What you've built

想要 is what you would like; *xūyào* is what you cannot do without.

Your turn

- *Say it: xūyào*
- *Say it: xūyào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xūyào xiūxi* — I need a rest.

- *Say it: nǐ xūyào bāngmáng ma* — Do you need a hand?
- *Recall:* say *xiūxi*, then *xūyào* again

Before you move on

What does *xūyào* mean? ("To need".) Which is softer, *xūyào* or 想要? (**想要, what you would like**.)

91.5 一点儿 (yìdiǎnr) — a little

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then water, then the tone of 一.

- *Recall:* say *xūyào*, to need — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 水 — *shuǐ*, water
- *Recall:* say 一天 — *yì tiān*, a day, with 一 falling

You'll want to know: 一点儿

一点儿 — *yìdiǎnr* — "a little; a bit".

我要一点儿水 *wǒ yào yìdiǎnr shuǐ* — I'd like a little water.

一 before the dip of 点 falls: *yì*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一点儿 (*yìdiǎnr*) is built from 一 'one', 点 'a dot' and the r ending 儿: a dot's worth. 一 and 点 are inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jit* and *temX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *temX* glossed 'a dot; a stroke of the brush'.

What you've built

一点儿 goes after the verb and before the thing: 要, 一点儿, 水.

Your turn

- *Say it: yìdiǎnr*
- *Say it: yìdiǎnr*, once more
- *Say it:* 我要一点儿水 — *wǒ yào yìdiǎnr shuǐ* — I'd like a little water.
- *Say it:* 我想要一点儿 — *wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr* — I'd like a little.
- *Recall:* say *xūyào*, then *yìdiǎnr* again

Before you move on

What does 一点儿 mean? ("A little".) Where does it go? (**After the verb, before the thing**.)

91.6 我想要一点儿水

The chapter closes here, with a host and a guest.

- *Recall:* say *yìdiǎnr*, a little — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *chá*, tea — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *lèi*, tired — **R4**

The exchange

A: 你想喝什么

nǐ xiǎng hē shénme — What would you like to drink?

B: 我想要一点儿水

wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr shuǐ — I'd like a little water.

A: *nǐ yào chá ma* — Would you like tea?

B: 不要 谢谢

bú yào, xièxie — No, thank you.

A: *nǐ xūyào xiūxi ma* — Do you need a rest?

B: *bù, wǒ bú lèi* — No, I'm not tired.

Four ways of wanting: 想 + a verb, 想要 + a thing, *yào* + a thing, *xūyào* for a need. And one way of refusing that is still polite: 不要, 谢谢.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — wanting, needing, refusing

- 我想要一点儿水 *wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr shuǐ* — I'd like a little water.
- 我要这个 *wǒ yào zhège* — I want this one.
- *wǒ xūyào xiūxi* — I need a rest.
- 不要 谢谢 *bú yào, xièxie* — no, thank you.

Listen. *Nǐ yào shénme?*
Speak. Ask for a little of something, then turn something down politely.
Write it: 要 — the box under its bar first, then 女

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我想要一点儿水 — *wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr shuǐ* — I'd like a little water.
- *Say it:* 不要 谢谢 — *bú yào, xièxie* — No, thank you.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我要一点儿水

Before you move on

Ask for a little water. (我要一点儿水.) Turn down tea politely. (不要 谢谢.) Say you need a rest. (*wǒ xūyào xiūxi.*)

Chapter 92

Me Too

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can order at a table and say 'me too'.
>
> *Ordering at a table, the menu, the waiter and anything else, and 'me too' with 也, built on one new written character: 也.*

92.1 也 (yě) — also; too

A new chapter, and it opens with the word you need when somebody else has ordered first.

- *Recall:* say 我想要一点儿水 — *wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr shuǐ*
- *Recall:* say 一点儿 — *yìdiǎnr*, a little
- *Recall:* say 他是学生 — *tā shì xuésheng*, he's a student

You'll want to know: 也

也 — *yě* — "also; too".

> 我也要 *wǒ yě yào* — Me too; I'd like one too.
>
> 他也是学生 *tā yě shì xuésheng* — He's a student too.

The next lesson puts the character in your hand. You have written it before, as the right half of 他.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

也 (*yě*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *yaeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a particle that closes a sentence'. 'Also' is not given there, so how it came to mean 'also' is not settled.

What you've built

也 goes in front of the verb: 我也要, 他也是学生. English puts *too* at the end; Mandarin does not.

Your turn

- *Say it: yě*
- *Say it: yě*, once more
- *Say it:* 我也要 — *wǒ yě yào* — Me too.
- *Say it:* 他也是学生 — *tā yě shì xuésheng* — He's a student too.
- *Recall:* say *wǒ xiǎngyào yìdiǎnr shuǐ*, then answer it for yourself with 我也要

Before you move on

What does 也 mean? ("Also; too".) Where does it go? (**In front of the verb:** 我也要.)

92.2 也 — the right half of 他

The word first, then the character inside it.

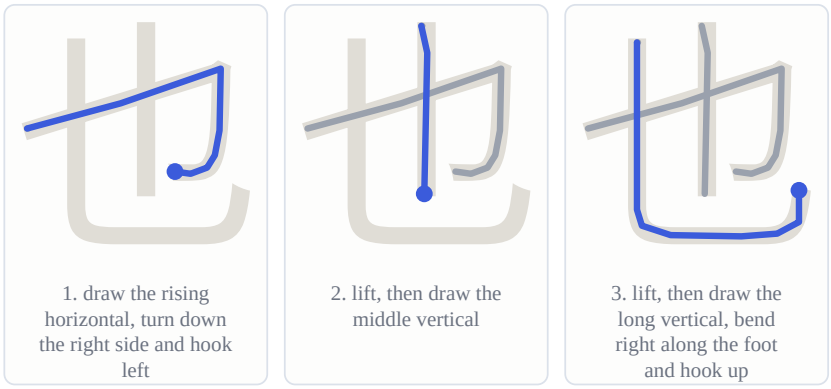
- *Recall:* say *yě* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  他 他们

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tā*, *tāmen*

Script — the right half of 他

How it is written — 3 strokes · 2 pen lifts · 3 movements



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 也.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 也 is written, stroke by stroke

也

One piece, and your hand already knows it: the right half of 他, stroke for stroke.

A hooked turn: a horizontal that rises a little, turns down the right side and hooks to the left.

A short vertical from above it, down through it.

The long bend: down the left from above the horizontal, along the foot to the right, and a hook up at the end.

Three strokes.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 也, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 也? (**Three**.) Where have you written them before? (**On the right of 他**.) Which stroke ends with a hook up? (**The last, the long bend**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 也, pinned stroke paths and medians.

92.3 càidān — menu

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words for food.

- *Read it:* 我也要, aloud — *wǒ yě yào*
- *Recall:* say *cài*, a dish — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *diǎncài*, to order food — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: càidān

càidān — "menu".

qǐng gěi wǒ càidān — The menu, please.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

càidān is built from cài 'a dish', the *cài* you know, and dān, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tshojH* and *tan* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'greens fit to eat' and 'single'. A sheet that lists the dishes is the modern sense of the pair.

What you've built

qǐng gěi wǒ càidān: 请, then 给 + the person + the thing, the pattern of the chapter on giving.

Your turn

- *Say it: càidān*
- *Say it: càidān*, once more

- *Say it: qǐng gěi wǒ càidān* — The menu, please.
- *Recall:* say *diǎncài*, then *càidān* again

Before you move on

What does *càidān* mean? (“Menu”.) Ask for it. (*qǐng gěi wǒ càidān.*)

92.4 fúwùyuán — waiter; attendant

Before the new one: last lesson’s word, then a place to eat, then a guest.

- *Recall:* say *càidān*, the menu — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *fàndiàn*, a restaurant — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say 客人 — *kèrén*, a guest

You’ll want to know: fúwùyuán

fúwùyuán — “waiter; attendant”.

fúwùyuán, wǒ yào càidān — Excuse me, the menu, please.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fúwùyuán is built from fú ’to serve’, wù ’a task’ and yuán, all inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjuwk*, *mjuH* and *hjwen* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’to serve’, ’affairs’ and ’a number of things’. ’A member of staff’ is a later sense of yuán.

What you’ve built

In a restaurant or a shop, *fúwùyuán* is also how you call the person serving: say it, then what you want.

Your turn

- *Say it: fúwùyuán*
- *Say it: fúwùyuán*, once more
- *Say it: fúwùyuán, wǒ yào càidān* — Excuse me, the menu, please.
- *Recall:* say *fàndiàn*, then *fúwùyuán* again

Before you move on

What does *fúwùyuán* mean? ("Waiter; attendant".) Call one and ask for the menu. (*fúwùyuán, wǒ yào càidān.*)

92.5 biéde — something else; other

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then the particle at the end of this one.

- *Recall:* say *fúwùyuán*, a waiter — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *dōngxi*, things — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say 我的书 — *wǒ de shū*, my book

You'll want to know: biéde

biéde — "something else; other".

nǐ yào biéde ma — Would you like anything else?

wǒ xiǎngyào biéde dōngxi — I'd like something else.

Its first character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

biéde is built from bié 'other; apart' and de, the 的 you write. bié is inherited from Middle Chinese *bjet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'different; to part'; where de comes from is not settled.

What you've built

nǐ yào biéde ma is the waiter's question; *bú yào, xièxie* is the answer when you have all you need.

Your turn

- *Say it: biéde*
- *Say it: biéde*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yào biéde ma* — Would you like anything else?
- *Say it:* 不要 谢谢 — *bú yào, xièxie* — No, thank you.
- *Recall:* say *dōngxi*, then *biéde* again

Before you move on

What does *biéde* mean? ("Something else; other".) Answer the waiter's question politely. (不要 谢谢.)

92.6 我也要

The chapter closes here, at a table for two.

- *Recall:* say *biéde*, something else — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *jiǎozi*, dumplings — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *xūyào*, to need — **R2**

The exchange

A: *fúwùyuán, qǐng gěi wǒmen càidān* — Excuse me, could we have the menu?

B: 好 你们喝什么

hǎo, nǐmen hē shénme — Of course. What will you drink?

A: 我要水

wǒ yào shuǐ — Water for me.

C: 我也要

wǒ yě yào — Me too.

B: *nǐmen yào biéde ma* — Anything else?

A: *wǒ yào jiǎozi* — Dumplings for me.

C: *wǒ yě yào jiǎozi* — Dumplings for me too.

B: 好

hǎo — Right you are.

Ordering is *yào* and the thing; agreeing is 也 in front of it. Nobody says *I* would like: 我要 does the job.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — ordering at a table

- *qǐng gěi wǒmen càidān* — the menu, please.
- 我要水 *wǒ yào shuǐ* — water for me.
- 我也要 *wǒ yě yào* — me too.
- *nǐmen yào biéde ma* — anything else?

Listen. *Nǐmen hē shénme?*
Speak. Order a drink, then agree with somebody else's order using 也.
Write it: 也 — the hooked turn, the short vertical, the long bend

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我也要 — *wǒ yě yào* — Me too.
- *Say it:* 请给我们水 — *qǐng gěi wǒmen shuǐ* — Water for us, please.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, every part
- *Write it:* 我也要

Before you move on

Say me too. (我也要.) Ask for the menu. (*qǐng gěi wǒ càidān.*) Call the waiter. (*fúwùyuán.*) Where does 也 go? (**In front of the verb**.)

Chapter 93

Too Much

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say something is too much, or a bit too much.
>
> *Too much with* 太 … 了*, a bit too much with* 有点儿*, great with* 太好了*, and clean and dirty, built on one new written character:* 太.

93.1 太好了 (tài hǎo le) — great!

A new chapter, and it opens with a sound you have made since the chapter on money.

- *Recall:* say 我也要 — *wǒ yě yào*, me too
- *Recall:* say *nǐ yào biéde ma*, anything else — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *tài guì le*, too expensive — **R4**, from the chapter on money

You'll want to know: 太好了

太好了 — *tài hǎo le* — "great!; that's wonderful".

> 我们明天去 太好了 *wǒmen míngtiān qù, tài hǎo le* — We're going tomorrow? Great!

The next lesson puts the first character in your hand. It is the *tài* you have said since *tài guì le*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

太好了 (*tài hǎo le*) is built from 太 'too; extremely', 好 'good' and 了. 太 and 好 are inherited from Middle Chinese, *thajH* and *xawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *thajH* glossed 'extreme; great'.

What you've built

tài … le around an adjective says too much: *tài guì le*, too expensive. Around 好 it is not 'too good'. It is the everyday 'great!'

Your turn

- *Say it: tài hǎo le*
- *Say it: tài hǎo le*, once more, as if you meant it
- *Say it:* 我们明天去 太好了 — *wǒmen míngtiān qù, tài hǎo le* — We're going tomorrow? Great!
- *Recall:* say *tài guì le*, then *tài hǎo le*, and hear one complaint and one delight

Before you move on

What does 太好了 mean? ("Great!".) Is it 'too good'? (**No: *tài … le* around 好 is plain delight**.)

93.2 太 — 大, then a dot

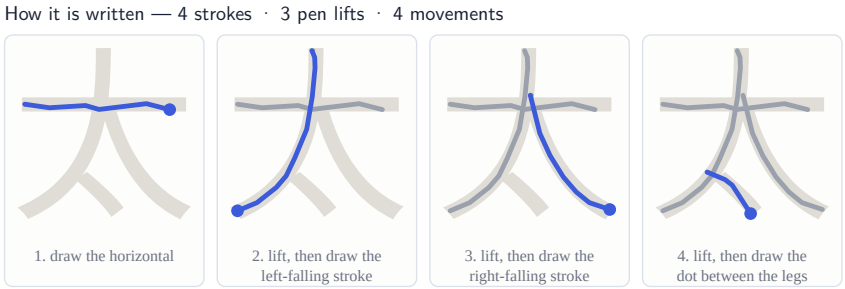
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *tài hǎo le* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

大 天

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *dà*, *tiān*

Script — 大, then a dot



How 太 is written, stroke by stroke

太

大 with one stroke added, and the added stroke comes last.

大, three strokes: the bar, the left-falling stroke through it, the right-falling stroke from the crossing.

One dot, between the two legs.

3 + 1 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 太, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 太? (**Four**.) Which character is inside it? (大.) Where does the dot go? (**Between the legs, last**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 太, pinned stroke paths and medians.

93.3 有点儿 (yǒudiǎnr) — a bit, and not in a good way

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words this one is made from.

- *Read it:* 太好了, aloud — *tài hǎo le*
- *Recall:* say 一点儿 — *yìdiǎnr*, a little
- *Recall:* say *lěng*, cold — **R4**, recognition at distance

You'll want to know: 有点儿

有点儿 — *yǒudiǎnr* — "a bit (of something unwanted); rather".

有点儿大 *yǒudiǎnr dà* — It's a bit big.

太大了 *tài dà le* — It's too big.

Two dips in a row: spoken, the first rises, *yóudiǎnr*. It is written *yǒudiǎnr*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

有点儿 (*yǒudiǎnr*) is built from 有 'to have', 点 'a dot' and the r ending: having a dot of it. 有 and 点 are inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuwX* and *temX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

有点儿 + an adjective is a mild complaint: *yǒudiǎnr lěng*, it's a bit cold. 很 is neutral; 太 … 了 is strong. And 一点儿 is a different job: it goes after a verb, 要一点儿水.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *yǒudiǎnr* — and hear it as *yóudiǎnr*
- *Say it:* 有点儿大 — *yǒudiǎnr dà* — It's a bit big.
- *Say it:* 太大了 — *tài dà le* — It's too big.
- *Say it:* *yǒudiǎnr lěng* — It's a bit cold.
- *Recall:* say *yào yìdiǎnr shuǐ*, then *yǒudiǎnr dà*, and hear the two jobs

Before you move on

What does 有点儿 say about an adjective? (**A bit, and not welcome.**) Which is stronger, 有点儿大 or 太大了? (太大了.)

93.4 gānjìng — clean

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then a room, then 很.

- *Recall:* say 有点儿大 — *yǒudiǎnr dà*
- *Recall:* say *fángjiān*, a room — **R2**
- *Recall:* say 很好 — *hěn hǎo*, fine

You'll want to know: gānjìng

gānjìng — "clean".

fángjiān hěn gānjìng — The room is clean.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gānjìng is built from gān 'dry' and jìng, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kan* and *dzjengH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'dry' and 'without dirt'.

What you've built

An adjective takes a plain 很 where English has *is*: *fángjiān hěn gānjìng*. No 是.

Your turn

- *Say it: gānjìng*
- *Say it: gānjìng*, once more
- *Say it: fángjiān hěn gānjìng* — The room is clean.
- *Say it: fángjiān bù gānjìng* — The room isn't clean.
- *Recall:* say *yǒudiǎnr dà*, then *gānjìng* again

Before you move on

What does *gānjìng* mean? (“Clean”.) What goes in front of it, 是 or 很? (很.)

93.5 zāng — dirty

Before the new one: last lesson’s word, then two things that get dirty.

- *Recall:* say *gānjìng*, clean — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *xié*, shoes — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *yīfu*, clothes — **R3**

You’ll want to know: zāng

zāng — “dirty”.

xié tài zāng le — The shoes are too dirty.

yīfu yǒudiǎnr zāng — The clothes are a bit dirty.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The older character for *zāng* is in the Guangyun as *tsangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), but only inside a two-character word for a sturdy body, and that reading would give zǎng, not zāng. No dictionary we use records the word ’dirty’ in an older form, so the history of *zāng* is not settled.

What you’ve built

gānjìng and *zāng*, clean and dirty, and three strengths for each: 很, 有点儿, 太 … 了.

Your turn

- *Say it: zāng*

- *Say it: zāng*, once more
- *Say it: xié tài zāng le* — The shoes are too dirty.
- *Say it: yīfu yǒudiǎnr zāng* — The clothes are a bit dirty.
- *Recall:* say *gānjìng*, then *zāng* again

Before you move on

What does *zāng* mean? ("Dirty".) Say the shoes are too dirty. (*xié tài zāng le.*)

93.6 太大了

The chapter closes here, with two people shopping and not finding it.

- *Recall:* say *zāng*, dirty — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *zěnmeyàng*, how is it — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *piányi*, cheap — **R4**

The exchange

A: *zhège zěnmeyàng* — How's this one?

B: 太大了

tài dà le — Too big.

A: 那个呢

nàge ne — And that one?

B: 有点儿小

yǒudiǎnr xiǎo — A bit small.

A: 这个很好看

zhège hěn hǎokàn — This one's nice.

B: *yǒudiǎnr zāng* — It's a bit dirty.

A: 我们去吃饭

wǒmen qù chī fàn — Let's go and eat, then.

B: 太好了

tài hǎo le — Great!

Three strengths of complaint, 有点儿, 很 and 太 … 了, and one delight to finish: 太好了.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — three strengths

- 很大 *hěn dà* — big; a plain statement.
- 有点儿大 *yǒudiǎnr dà* — a bit big, and I'd rather it wasn't.
- 太大了 *tài dà le* — too big.
- 太好了 *tài hǎo le* — great!

Listen. *Fángjiān zěnmeyàng?*
Speak. Answer it three ways: *gānjìng*, a bit dirty, too dirty.
Write it: 太 — 大, then the dot

Your turn

- *Say it:* 太大了 — *tài dà le* — Too big.
- *Say it:* 有点儿小 — *yǒudiǎnr xiǎo* — A bit small.
- *Say it: fángjiān hěn gānjìng* — The room is clean.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 太好了

Before you move on

Say it is too big. (太大了.) Say it is a bit small. (有点儿小.) Say great. (太好了.) Say the room is clean. (*fángjiān hěn gānjìng.*)

Chapter 94

All the Same

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can describe people and things, and say 'all of them'.
>
> *Describing people, young, fat, thin, the same or not, and saying all of them with* 都*, built on one new written character:* 都.

94.1 都 (dōu) — all; both

A new chapter, and it opens with the word that gathers people together.

- *Recall:* say 太大了 — *tài dà le*, too big
- *Recall:* say *xié tài zāng le*, the shoes are too dirty — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say 大家 — *dàjiā*, everyone

You'll want to know: 都

都 — *dōu* — "all; both".

我们都是学生 *wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng* — We're all students.

他们都很好 *tāmen dōu hěn hǎo* — They're all fine.

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

都 (*dōu*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tu* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'all together', and also 'a capital city', the sense said dū today. The regular change from *tu* gives dū; why the word for 'all' is said dōu is not settled.

What you've built

都 goes in front of the verb or the adjective and looks back at the people before it: 我们都, all of us. With two people it means both.

Your turn

- *Say it: dōu*
- *Say it: dōu*, once more
- *Say it:* 我们都是学生 — *wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng* — We're all students.
- *Say it:* 他们都很好 — *tāmen dōu hěn hǎo* — They're all fine.
- *Recall:* say *dàjiā*, then *dōu* again

Before you move on

What does 都 mean? ("All; both".) Where does it go? (**In front of the verb, after the people**.)

94.2 都 — 者, then the ear on the right

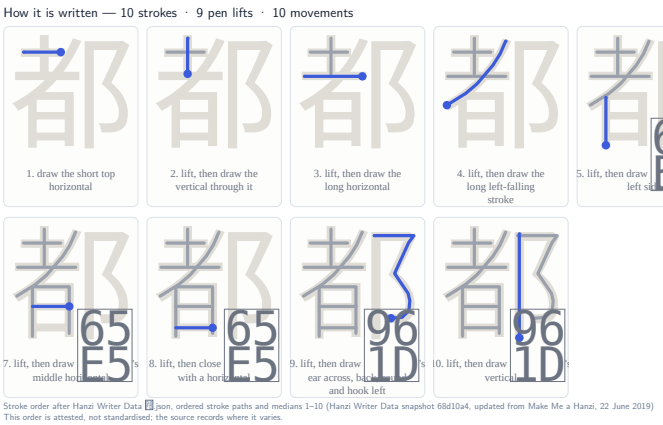
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *dōu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 那 在

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *nà*, *zài*

Script — 者, then the ear on the right



How 都 *is written, stroke by stroke*

都

Two pieces, left before right, and every stroke in them is one you have made.

者, eight strokes: first the foot of 在, a short bar, a vertical through it, then the long bar; then a long left-falling stroke from the upper right; then 日 under them.

The ear piece, two strokes, on the right, as 那 ends: across, back, round and hooking; then the long vertical.

8 + 2 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 都, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 都? (**Ten.**) Which character ends the left piece? (日.) Where have you written the ear piece? (**On the right of 那.**)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 都, pinned stroke paths and medians.

94.3 yíyàng — the same

Before the new one: read a line with two characters you have written in the last two chapters, then the tone of 一.

- *Read it:* 他们也都很好, aloud — *tāmen yě dōu hěn hǎo*, they're all fine too
- *Recall:* say 一个 — *yí ge*, with 一 rising

You'll want to know: yíyàng

yíyàng — "the same; alike".

wǒmen bù yíyàng — We're not the same.

wǒmen yíyàng dà — We're the same age.

一 before the fall of yàng rises: *yí*. Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yíyàng is built from yī 'one' and yàng 'a pattern; a kind': one pattern. yī is inherited from Middle Chinese *'jit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); yàng has no reading in the Guangyun, so no dictionary we use records an older form of it, and its history is not settled.

What you've built

In *tāmen yě dōu hěn hǎo*, 也 comes before 都: too, and all of them. *yíyàng* + an adjective says how two things match: *yíyàng dà*, the same size or the same age.

Your turn

- *Say it: yíyàng*
- *Say it: yíyàng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen bù yíyàng* — We're not the same.
- *Say it: wǒmen yíyàng dà* — We're the same age.
- *Recall:* say *yí ge*, then *yíyàng*, and hear the same rise

Before you move on

What does *yíyàng* mean? (“The same”.) Which comes first, 也 or 都? (也: 也都.)

94.4 niánqīng — young

Before the new one: last lesson’s word, then two words about age and people.

- *Recall:* say *yíyàng*, the same — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *niánjì*, age — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *lǎoshī*, a teacher — **R4**, recognition at distance

You’ll want to know: niánqīng

niánqīng — “young”.

wǒ de lǎoshī hěn niánqīng — My teacher is very young.

Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

niánqīng is built from nián ’year’, the 年 you write, and qīng ’light’, not heavy: light in years. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *nen* and *khjieng* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), *khjieng* glossed ’light in weight’.

What you’ve built

niánqīng is said of grown people; a child is *xiǎo*. *lǎo*, old, is its opposite.

Your turn

- *Say it: niánqīng*
- *Say it: niánqīng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de lǎoshī hěn niánqīng* — My teacher is very young.
- *Recall:* say *niánjì*, then *niánqīng* again

Before you move on

What does *niánqīng* mean? ("Young".) Which written character does it open with? (年.)

94.5 pàng — fat; plump

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then an animal and something to eat.

- *Recall:* say *niánqīng*, young — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *māo*, a cat — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *dàngāo*, a cake — **R2**

You'll want to know: pàng

pàng — "fat; plump".

māo tài pàng le — The cat's too fat.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The character for *pàng* is in the Guangyun as *phanH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'half of a sacrificial animal'. That reading would give pàn, not pàng, and the sense is not 'fat', so the history of *pàng* is not settled.

What you've built

pàng is a word for people and animals, and said of a person it is blunt: a cat can hear *tài pàng le* without offence.

Your turn

- *Say it: pàng*
- *Say it: pàng*, once more
- *Say it: māo tài pàng le* — The cat's too fat.

- *Say it: māo yǒudiǎnr pàng* — The cat's a bit plump.
- *Recall:* say *dàngāo*, then *pàng* again

Before you move on

What does *pàng* mean? ("Fat; plump".) Say the cat is too fat. (*māo tài pàng le.*)

94.6 shòu — thin; slim

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then tall and short.

- *Recall:* say *pàng*, fat — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *gāo*, tall — **R3**, durable
- *Recall:* say *ǎi*, short — **R3**

You'll want to know: shòu

shòu — "thin; slim".

tā hěn gāo, hěn shòu — He's tall and thin.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shòu is inherited from Middle Chinese *srjuwH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed, through an older dictionary, 'lean'.

What you've built

pàng and *shòu*, *gāo* and *ǎi*: two pairs that describe a body, each with a plain 很.

Your turn

- *Say it: shòu*
- *Say it: shòu*, once more
- *Say it: tā hěn gāo, hěn shòu* — He's tall and thin.
- *Recall:* say *pàng*, then *shòu*, the pair

Before you move on

What does *shòu* mean? ("Thin; slim".) And its opposite? (***pàng***.)

94.7 我们都是学生

The chapter closes here, with a photograph of a class.

- *Recall:* say *shòu*, thin — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 同学 — *tóngxué*, a classmate — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *gānjìng*, clean — **R2**

The exchange

A: 他们都是你的同学吗

tāmen dōu shì nǐ de tóngxué ma — Are they all your classmates?

B: 对 我们都是学生

duì, wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng — Yes, we're all students.

A: *nǐmen dōu hěn niánqīng* — You're all so young.

B: *wǒmen yíyàng dà* — We're the same age.

A: 那个男人呢

nàge nánrén ne — And that man?

B: *tā shì wǒmen de lǎoshī, tā hěn gāo, hěn shòu* — He's our teacher. He's tall and thin.

A: *nǐ de māo hěn pàng* — Your cat's fat.

B: 也很大

yě hěn dà — And big.

都 gathers everybody before it into one: 他们都, 我们都, 你们都. *yíyàng* matches them up; *gāo*, *shòu* and *pàng* tell them apart.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — describing people

- 我们都是学生 *wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng* — we're all students.
- *wǒmen yíyàng dà* — we're the same age.
- *tā hěn gāo, hěn shòu* — he's tall and thin.
- 他们也都很好 *tāmen yě dōu hěn hǎo* — they're all fine too.

Listen. *Nǐmen dōu shì xuésheng ma?*
Speak. Describe two people you know, then say what they have in common with 都.
Write it: 都 — the left piece first, closed by its 日, then the ear on the right

Your turn

- *Say it:* 我们都是学生 — *wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng* — We're all students.
- *Say it:* 他们也都很好 — *tāmen yě dōu hěn hǎo* — They're all fine too.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 我们都是学生

Before you move on

Say you are all students. (我们都是学生.) Say you are the same age. (*wǒmen yíyàng dà.*) Say somebody is young. (*tā hěn niánqīng.*) Which comes first, 也 or 都? (也.)

Chapter 95

Why?

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask why.
>
> *Asking why with* 为什么*, and three everyday answers to it, being busy, the traffic and forgetting, built on one new written character:* 为*.*

95.1 为什么 (wèishénme) — why?

A new chapter, and it opens with the question that wants a reason.

- *Recall:* say 我们都是学生 — *wǒmen dōu shì xuésheng*
- *Recall:* say *tā hěn shòu*, he's thin — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *chídào*, to be late — **R2**

You'll want to know: 为什么

为什么 — *wèishénme* — "why?".

> 你为什么不去 *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — Why aren't you going?

The next lesson puts the new character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

为什么 (*wèishénme*) is built from 为 'for' and 什么 'what': for what? 为 is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjweH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to help'; 'for' is the sense of acting on somebody's behalf, which the gloss does not spell out. Where 什么 comes from is not settled.

What you've built

为什么 sits after the person and before the verb: 你, 为什么, 不去. 不 before the fall of 去 rises: *bú qù*.

Your turn

- *Say it: wèishénme*
- *Say it: wèishénme*, once more
- *Say it:* 你为什么不去 — *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — Why aren't you going?
- *Say it: nǐ wèishénme chídào* — Why are you late?
- *Recall:* say *chídào*, then ask why

Before you move on

What does 为什么 ask? ("Why?".) Where does it go? (**After the person, before the verb**.)

95.2 为 — a dot, a long fall, the hook of 男, a dot

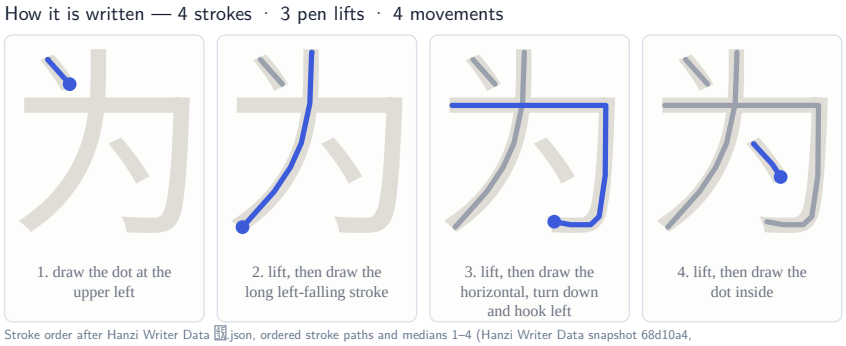
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *wèishénme* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  男 点

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *nán*, *diǎn*

Script — a dot, a long fall, the hook of 男, a dot



How 为 is written, stroke by stroke

为

Four strokes, and the long one in the middle is a stroke your hand knows from the foot of 男.

A dot at the upper left.

A long left-falling stroke from the top, down to the lower left.

The hooked turn: across, down the right side, hooking to the left, as at the foot of 男.

A dot inside, last.

Four strokes.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 为, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 为? (**Four**.) Where have you made the hooked turn before? (**At the foot of 男**.) Which stroke is last? (**The dot inside**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 为, pinned stroke paths and medians.

95.3 yǒushì — to have something on

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words for a full day.

- *Read it:* 为什么, aloud — *wèishénme*
- *Recall:* say *máng*, busy — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say 今天 — *jīntiān*, today

You'll want to know: yǒushì

yǒushì — "to have something on; to be busy".

wǒ jīntiān yǒushì — I've got something on today.

Its second character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǒushì is built from yǒu 'to have', the 有 you write, and shì 'a matter'. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuwX* and *dzriH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The Guangyun glosses *dzriH* 'to employ; to set up', and 'a matter' is the everyday sense, not the gloss.

What you've built

yǒushì is the polite reason that gives nothing away: something has come up. *máng* says you are busy; *yǒushì* says there is a particular thing.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǒushì*
- *Say it: yǒushì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ jīntiān yǒushì* — I've got something on today.
- *Recall:* say *máng*, then *yǒushì* again

Before you move on

What does *yǒushì* mean? ("To have something on".) Which written character does it open with? (有.)

95.4 dǔchē — a traffic jam

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words for the road.

- *Recall:* say *yǒushì*, to have something on — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 车 — *chē*, a car
- *Recall:* say *lù*, a road — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: dǔchē

dǔchē — "traffic jam; to be stuck in traffic".

zǎoshang dǔchē — There's a jam in the mornings.

Its first character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dǔchē is built from dǔ 'to block' and chē 'a vehicle', the 车 you write. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *tuX* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the Guangyun glosses *tuX* as 'a wall', and 'to block' is assumed from that, not quoted.

What you've built

dǔchē is a verb as well as a noun: *zǎoshang dǔchē*, the traffic jams in the morning. No 有 needed.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǔchē*
- *Say it: dǔchē*, once more

- *Say it: zǎoshang dǔchē* — There's a jam in the mornings.
- *Recall:* say *lù*, then *dǔchē* again

Before you move on

What does *dǔchē* mean? ("A traffic jam".) Which written character does it end with? (车.)

95.5 wàng — to forget

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words you might forget.

- *Recall:* say *dǔchē*, a traffic jam — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *zuòyè*, homework — **R2**
- *Recall:* say 马上 — *mǎshàng*, right away

You'll want to know: wàng

wàng — "to forget".

wǒ wàng le — I forgot.

wǒ wàng le wǒ de yàoshi — I forgot my key.

Its character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wàng is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjangH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to leave behind; to forget'.

What you've built

wàng le: with 了 after it, the forgetting has already happened, which is how it is almost always said.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàng*
- *Say it: wàng le*
- *Say it: wǒ wàng le* — I forgot.
- *Say it: wǒ wàng le wǒ de yàoshi* — I forgot my key.
- *Recall:* say *zuòyè*, then say you forgot it

Before you move on

What does *wàng* mean? ("To forget".) Say you forgot. (*wǒ wàng le.*)

95.6 你为什么不去

The chapter closes here, with one person asking why three times.

- *Recall:* say *wàng*, to forget — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *láibují*, to run out of time — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *zuòyè*, homework — **R1**

The exchange

A: *nǐ wèishénme chídào* — Why are you late?

B: *zǎoshang dǔchē* — The traffic this morning.

A: 你明天去吗

nǐ míngtiān qù ma — Are you going tomorrow?

B: 我不去

wǒ bú qù — I'm not going.

A: 为什么

wèishénme — Why?

B: *wǒ yǒushì* — I've got something on.

A: *nǐ de zuòyè ne* — And your homework?

B: *wǒ wàng le* — I forgot.

为什么 can stand alone as a whole question, as A's fifth line does. Each answer here is a reason with nothing in front of it; the next chapter gives the word that introduces one.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — asking why

- 你为什么不去 *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — why aren't you going?
- 为什么 *wèishénme* — why?
- *wǒ yǒushì* — something has come up.
- *zǎoshang dǔchē* — the traffic this morning.

Listen. *Nǐ wèishénme bù chī fàn?*
Speak. Answer it with any reason you have, then ask somebody why.
Write it: 为 — the dot, the long fall, the hooked turn, the dot inside

Your turn

- *Say it:* 你为什么不去 — *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — Why aren't you going?
- *Say it: wǒ wàng le* — I forgot.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 为什么

Before you move on

Ask why somebody is not going. (你为什么不去.) Say something has come up. (*wǒ yǒushì.*) Blame the traffic. (*zǎoshang dǔchē.*) Say

you forgot. (*wǒ wàng le.*)

Chapter 96

Because

Modes: **voice** (4) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give one reason with 因为.
> *Giving one reason with* 因为*, and what follows from it with suǒyǐ, built on one new written character:* 因.

96.1 因为 (yīnwèi) — because

A new chapter, and it opens with the answer to the last one's question.

- *Recall:* say 你为什么不去 — *nǐ wèishénme bú qù*
- *Recall:* say *wǒ wàng le*, I forgot — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *dǔchē*, a traffic jam — **R1**

You'll want to know: 因为

因为 — *yīnwèi* — "because".

> 我不去 因为我没有车 *wǒ bú qù, yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu chē* — I'm not going, because I don't have a car.

The next lesson puts the first character in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

因为 (*yīnwèi*) is built from 因 'to follow from' and 为 'for'. 因 is inherited from Middle Chinese *'jin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to rely on; to follow from'.

What you've built

One reason, in one clause, after what it explains: 我不去, 因为我没有车. It can also come first: 因为我没有车, 我不去.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīnwèi*
- *Say it: yīnwèi*, once more
- *Say it:* 我不去 因为我没有车 — *wǒ bú qù, yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu chē* — I'm not going, because I don't have a car.
- *Say it:* 因为我没有车 我不去 — *yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu chē, wǒ bú qù* — Because I don't have a car, I'm not going.
- *Recall:* say *nǐ wèishénme bú qù*, then answer it with 因为

Before you move on

What does 因为 mean? ("Because".) Which question does it answer? (为什么.)

96.2 因 — 大 inside the frame of 国

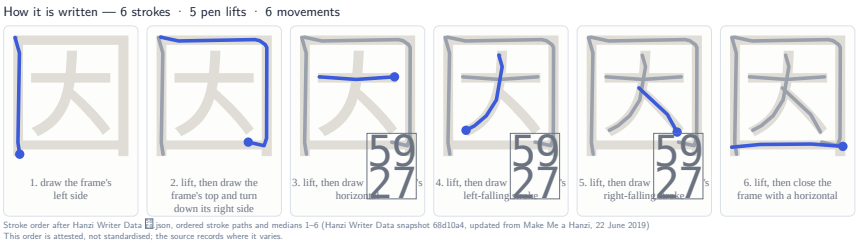
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yīnwèi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

国 大

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *guó, dà*

Script — 大 inside the frame of 国



How 因 is written, stroke by stroke

因

A frame and what it holds, and the frame is closed last, after its contents, as in 国.

The frame, two strokes first: its left side, then its top turning down the right side.

大, three strokes, inside: the bar, the left-falling stroke, the short right-falling stroke.

The bottom bar, last, closing the frame.

2 + 3 + 1 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 因, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 因? (**Six.**) What is inside the frame? (大.) When is the frame closed? (**Last, as in 国.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 因, pinned stroke paths and medians.

96.3 suǒyǐ — so; therefore

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then two words, one of which ends like this one.

- *Read it:* 因为, aloud — *yīnwèi*
- *Recall:* say *lèi*, tired — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *kěyǐ*, may — **R2**

You'll want to know: suǒyǐ

suǒyǐ — "so; therefore".

yīnwèi wǒ hěn lèi, suǒyǐ wǒ bú qù — I'm tired, so I'm not going.

Two dips in a row: spoken, the first rises, *suóyǐ*. It is written *suǒyǐ*. Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

suǒyǐ is built from suǒ 'a place; that which' and yǐ 'to use', the yǐ of *kěyǐ*. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *srjoX* and *yiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *srjoX* glossed 'a place'. The regular change from *srjoX* would give shǔ, not suǒ, so why it is said suǒ is not settled.

What you've built

因为 gives the reason, *suǒyǐ* what follows from it. Mandarin often says both: *yīnwèi …, suǒyǐ …*. Either half can also stand alone.

Your turn

- *Say it: suǒyǐ* — and hear it as *suóyǐ*
- *Say it: yīnwèi wǒ hěn lèi, suǒyǐ wǒ bú qù* — I'm tired, so I'm not going.
- *Recall:* say *kěyǐ*, then *suǒyǐ*, and hear the same yǐ

Before you move on

What does *suǒyǐ* mean? ("So; therefore".) Which half gives the reason, 因为 or *suǒyǐ*? (因为.)

96.4 shūfu — comfortable; well

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words about health.

- *Recall:* say *suǒyǐ*, so — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *shēntǐ*, health — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *bìng*, to fall ill — **R2**

You'll want to know: shūfu

shūfu — "comfortable; well".

wǒ bù shūfu — I'm not feeling well.

zhège yǐzi hěn shūfu — This chair is comfortable.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shūfu is built from shū 'to stretch; to ease' and fu, the fu of *yīfu*. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *syo* and *bjuwk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *syo* glossed 'slow; to stretch out'.

What you've built

wǒ bù shūfu is the gentle way to say you are unwell, and a reason nobody argues with: *yīnwèi wǒ bù shūfu*.

Your turn

- *Say it: shūfu*
- *Say it: shūfu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù shūfu* — I'm not feeling well.
- *Say it: zhège yǐzi hěn shūfu* — This chair is comfortable.
- *Recall:* say *bìng*, then *shūfu* again

Before you move on

What does *shūfu* mean? ("Comfortable; well".) Say you are not feeling well. (*wǒ bù shūfu.*)

96.5 为什么 — 因为

The chapter closes here, with every why answered.

- *Recall:* say *shūfu*, comfortable — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *è*, hungry — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say 上课 — *shàngkè*, to go to class — **R2**

The exchange

A: 你为什么不吃饭

nǐ wèishénme bù chī fàn — Why aren't you eating?

B: *yīnwèi wǒ bú è* — Because I'm not hungry.

A: 你为什么不去上课

nǐ wèishénme bú qù shàngkè — Why aren't you going to class?

B: *yīnwèi wǒ bù shūfu, suǒyǐ wǒ bú qù* — I'm not feeling well, so I'm not going.

A: 你明天能来吗

nǐ míngtiān néng lái ma — Can you come tomorrow?

B: 能

néng — I can.

为什么 asks; 因为 answers, with one reason in one clause; *suǒyǐ* carries the reason on to what happens.

Read this

Read it: the exchange through once without stopping, then answer the question below

What you've built — a question and its reason

- 你为什么不去 *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — why aren't you going?
- 因为我没有车 *yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu chē* — because I don't have a car.
- *yīnwèi wǒ hěn lèi, suǒyǐ wǒ bú qù* — I'm tired, so I'm not going.

Listen. *Nǐ wèishénme xuéxí Hànyǔ?*
Speak. Answer it with 因为 and one reason of your own.
Write it: 因 — the frame's two sides, 大 inside, then the bar that closes it

Your turn

- *Say it:* 你为什么不去 — *nǐ wèishénme bú qù* — Why aren't you going?
- *Say it:* 因为我没有车 — *yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu chē* — Because I don't have a car.
- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both parts
- *Write it:* 因为

Before you move on

Give a reason with no car in it. (因为我没有车.) Say you are not well, so you are not going. (*yīnwèi wǒ bù shūfu, suǒyǐ wǒ bú qù.*) Which question does 因为 answer? (为什么.)

Chapter 97

My Day in Characters

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a short day in characters and write one line of my own.
>
> *Complete ZH-W97-my-own-line: one line of your own Chinese about where you are, what you want and for how long, chosen rather than copied, with every word you have not written in pinyin.*

97.1 小时 (xiǎoshí) — hour

A new chapter, and it opens with a word for measuring a day.

- *Recall:* say 为什么, then answer it with 因为 — *wèishénme*, *yīnwèi*
- *Recall:* say *wǒ bù shūfu*, I'm not feeling well — **R1**, the chapter you have finished
- *Recall:* say *shíhou*, a time; a moment — **R4**, recognition at distance
- *Recall:* say *xiǎoshíhou*, in childhood — **R3**, durable

You'll want to know: 小时

小时 — *xiǎoshí* — "hour".

一个小时 *yí ge xiǎoshí* — an hour

The next lesson puts the second character in your hand. It is the shí of *shíhou* and *xiǎoshíhou*.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

小时 (*xiǎoshí*) is built from 小 'small' and 时 'time'. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjewX* and *dzyi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *dzyi* glossed 'a season; a time'.

What you've built

一 before 个 rises: *yí ge xiǎoshí*, an hour. Before the other tones it falls: *yì tiān*, a day; *yì nián*, a year. Time words count with 一 as often as anything does.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiǎoshí*
- *Say it: xiǎoshí*, once more
- *Say it:* 一个小时 — *yí ge xiǎoshí* — an hour
- *Say it:* 一天 — *yì tiān* — a day
- *Say it:* 一年 — *yì nián* — a year
- *Recall:* say *shíhou*, then *xiǎoshí*, and hear the same shí

Before you move on

What does 小时 mean? ("Hour".) Say an hour, and listen to 一. (*yí ge xiǎoshí*: 一 rises before 个.)

97.2 时 — 日, then the right half of 对

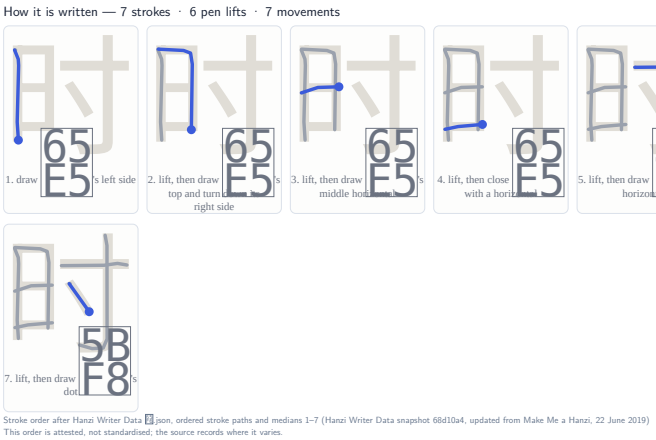
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xiǎoshí* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 对

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *duì*

Script — 日, then the right half of 对



How 时 *is written, stroke by stroke*

时

Two pieces you own, side by side.

日**, four strokes**, narrow, on the left: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, the middle bar, the bottom bar.

The right half of 对**, three strokes**: the bar, the vertical that hooks to the left at its foot, then the dot.

4 + 3 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 时, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 时? (**Seven**.) Which character is on the left? (日.) Where have you written the right half? (**At the end of** 对.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 时, pinned stroke paths and medians.

97.3 měitiān — every day

Before the new one: read the last lesson's character, then a day with 一 in front of it.

- *Read it:* 两个小时, aloud — *liǎng ge xiǎoshí*, two hours
- *Recall:* say 一天 — *yì tiān*, a day, with 一 falling

You'll want to know: měitiān

měitiān — "every day".

wǒ měitiān hē chá — I drink tea every day.

Its first character comes later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

měitiān is built from měi 'each' and tiān 'day', the 天 you write. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *mwojX* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the Guangyun glosses *mwojX* 'frequently', and 'each' is assumed from that, not quoted.

What you've built

A time word goes early, after the person and before the verb: 我, *měitiān*, *hē chá*. *yì tiān* is one day; *měitiān* is every day.

Your turn

- *Say it: měitiān*
- *Say it: měitiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ měitiān hē chá* — I drink tea every day.
- *Recall:* say *yì tiān*, then *měitiān*

Before you move on

What does *měitiān* mean? ("Every day".) Where does it go? (**After the person, before the verb**.)

97.4 yǐhòu — after; afterwards

Before the new one: last lesson's word, then two words for school and after.

- *Recall:* say *měitiān*, every day — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say 下课 — *xiàkè*, to finish class
- *Recall:* say *hòu*, after; behind — **R2**

You'll want to know: yǐhòu

yǐhòu — "after; afterwards".

xiàkè yǐhòu, wǒ qù chī fàn — After class I go and eat.

yí ge xiǎoshí yǐhòu — an hour later

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǐhòu is built from yǐ, the yǐ of *kěyǐ*, and hòu 'after', the *hòu* you know. Both are inherited from Middle Chinese, *yiX* and *huwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), *huwX* glossed 'after, in order'.

What you've built

yǐhòu comes after the thing it follows: *xiàkè yǐhòu*, after class; *yí ge xiǎoshí yǐhòu*, an hour later.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǐhòu*
- *Say it: yǐhòu*, once more
- *Say it: xiàkè yǐhòu, wǒ qù chī fàn* — After class I go and eat.
- *Say it: yí ge xiǎoshí yǐhòu* — an hour later
- *Recall:* say *hòu*, then *yǐhòu*

Before you move on

What does *yǐhòu* mean? ("After; afterwards".) Where does it go? (**After the thing it follows: *xiàkè yǐhòu*.**)

97.5 (reading) — a Sunday at home

Fifty-seven characters in a row, and every one is a character you write.

- *Recall:* say *xiàkè yǐhòu*, after class — **R1**, one lesson back
- *Recall:* say *jiàoshì*, a classroom — **R3**, durable

  上课 下课

Read it: both aloud, with nothing said first — *shàngkè*, *xiàkè*

Read this

今天是星期天 我和妈妈都在家 妈妈做饭 我看书 我想喝水
也想吃饭 妈妈说 饭太多了 我说 太好了 下午两点 我们去买
书 因为我很喜欢看书

Read it: the passage through once without stopping; do not translate as you go
Read it: the passage again, and this time notice where the day turns: the line with the time in it

Read this

jīntiān shì xīngqītiān wǒ hé māma dōu zài jiā māma zuò
fàn wǒ kàn shū wǒ xiǎng hē shuǐ yě xiǎng chī fàn māma
shuō fàn tài duō le wǒ shuō tài hǎo le xiàwǔ liǎng diǎn
wǒmen qù mǎi shū yīnwèi wǒ hěn xǐhuan kàn shū

One line per clause, and no punctuation, as this book prints Chinese: the line breaks carry the pauses. 饭太多了 is 太 … 了 as a complaint, too much rice; 太好了 a line later is the same frame as delight.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the passage aloud, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

Who is at home? (我和妈妈: the writer and Mum.) Why do they go to buy books? (因为我很喜欢看书.) Which line is a complaint, and which a delight? (饭太多了**, then** 太好了.)

97.6 My own line — the first Chinese with no model

Everything you have written so far had something to reach for: a model to trace, a word somebody said, a sentence printed above the space.

This does not. You choose the words, from a supply that is closed: what this book has given you.

- *Recall:* say 两个小时 — *liǎng ge xiǎoshí*, two hours

Writing — controlled composition

Write **one line** of your own about your day. Three parts, in your own words: where you are, with 在; what you want, with 想要 or 要; and for how long, with 一个小时 or 两个小时. If you want a second thing, 也 brings it in, in front of its verb.

Some words you will want have characters you have not written yet: *měitiān*, every day; *yǐhòu*, after. Write those in pinyin, inside the line, with their tone marks. This task allows that, and it allows nothing else: a character you can read but have not learned to write is not one you produce, so it goes in pinyin too.

Three checks belong to the hand. Write each character in the stroke order you learned: 时 is 日 first, narrow, then the hooked vertical and the dot. Give every character **the same size of square**, two-stroke 了 as much as ten-stroke 都. And leave a space between clauses: no Chinese comma or full stop, as this book prints them.

Write the line. Then read it back, and check that every pinyin word has its tone marks before you check anything else.

Before you move on

Which words did you write in pinyin? (**Any whose characters you have not written: *měitiān*, *yǐhòu*.**)
Which piece of 时 comes first? (日, narrow, on the left.)
And what did you choose here that the earlier lessons chose for you? (**The words.**)

Chapter 98

With a Clock

Modes: **voice** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** both lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can fill a short form and write a short message against a clock.
>
> *Complete ZH-R98-review-final-98: one dialogue across the A1 core, where, what there is, how many, giving, can, want, too, all, why and because, after a five-field form and a short message under this book's own three-minute clock.*

98.1 The same writing, with a clock

You wrote your own line with as long as you liked.

A task you can only do untimed is not yet a task you can do.

A friend has sent you a message:

> 你在哪儿 你想要什么

Read it: the message aloud — *nǐ zài nǎr, nǐ xiǎngyào shénme*

Writing — timed production

What is official, and what is not. This book's A1 target is project-defined: aligned to HSK 3.0 Level 1, a match this book makes, not one the HSK publishes. Because the current trial pairs no speaking paper with Level 1, the complete A1 target adds independently scored speaking and productive writing, and at A1 the candidate writes a small form and a short

message. No HSK timing is given here; the clock below is **this book's own**, not a published one.

Set a **three-minute timer**. Fill five fields first. Every label is written in characters you write:

- 名字
- 多大
- 家在哪儿
- 喜欢什么
- 想要什么

Then, before the timer rings, write back to your friend: **20 to 30 characters**, saying where you are, what you want, and one reason with 因为. This task allows pinyin for a word whose characters you have not written; it goes inside the message, and only characters count toward the 20 to 30. Do not look a character up.

Speed is where stroke order shows. A character written in the order you learned keeps its shape when you hurry. When the timer rings, **stop**, even mid-character.

Before you move on

Spend **at most one minute** checking, and do not rewrite the timed answer. Did your reason start with 因为? Did every field get an answer?
Now the rule worth carrying out of this lesson. In this book, writing is its own paper, scored out of 100, with 60 to pass, and it is not averaged against reading, listening or speaking. A high reading score cannot make up for writing that is not there.

98.2 The A1 core — once more

The last lesson of the A1 core: one conversation that uses every chapter of it.

- *Recall:* say 你在哪儿, and answer it — **R2**
- *Recall:* say *yí ge xiǎoshí yǐhòu*, an hour later — **R1**

Your turn

A: 你在哪儿

nǐ zài nǎr — Where are you?

B: 我在家

wǒ zài jiā — At home.

A: *nǐ jiā yǒu méiyǒu bīngxiāng* — Have you got a fridge at home?

B: 有

yǒu — Yes.

A: 给我一点儿水

gěi wǒ yìdiǎnr shuǐ — Give me a little water, then.

B: *gěi nǐ, liǎng bēi* — Here you are: two glasses.

A: 太好了

tài hǎo le — Great!

B: *nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma* — Can you swim?

A: 会 我也想去

huì, wǒ yě xiǎng qù — I can, and I'd like to come too.

B: 我们都去吗

wǒmen dōu qù ma — Are we all going?

A: 我妈妈不去

wǒ māma bú qù — My mum isn't going.

B: 为什么

wèishénme — Why?

A: *yīnwèi tā bù shūfu* — Because she isn't feeling well.

B: *wǒ měitiān yóuyǒng liǎng ge xiǎoshí* — I swim for two hours every day.

A: *yí ge xiǎoshí yǐhòu qù* — Let's go in an hour, then.

- *Read it:* the lines printed in characters aloud, then the rest
- *Say it:* the whole dialogue, both parts
- *Say it:* B's lines again, with your own answers

Before you move on

Where? (哪儿.) Not have? (没有.) Two of something? (两.) Give? (给.) Can? (会, 能, *kěyǐ*.) Want? (想要.) Too? (也.) Great? (太好了.) All? (都.) Why? (为什么.) Because? (因为.) An hour? (一个小时.)

Chapter 99

Getting Washed

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say wash, brush my teeth, wash my face, have a shower and comb my hair.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 99: I can say wash, brush my teeth, wash my face, have a shower and comb my hair.*

99.1 洗 (xǐ) — to wash

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for every day, then the Mandarin for after.

You'll want to know: 洗

洗 — *xǐ* — "to wash".

> 我去洗手 *wǒ qù xǐ shǒu* — I'm going to wash my hands.

The new character, in pieces: 洗 — the water piece of 汉 on the left; on the right a six-stroke piece read xiān, the first syllable of xiānsheng. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

洗 (*xǐ*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *sejX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to wash and bathe'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *xǐ*
- *Say it:* *xǐ*, once more
- *Say it:* *wǒ qù xǐ shǒu* — I'm going to wash my hands.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for every day, then the Mandarin for after, then say *xǐ* again

Before you move on

What does 洗 mean? ("To wash".) Say it once more.

99.2 洗 — the water piece, then xiān

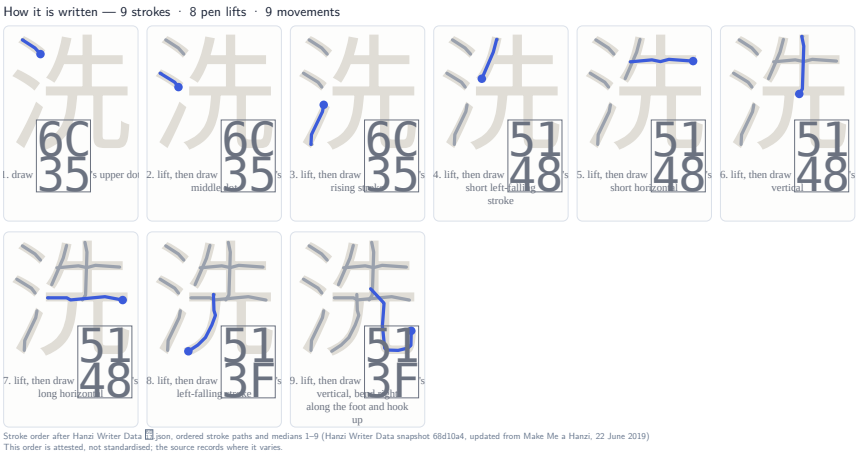
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xǐ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  汉 没 儿

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *hàn*, *méi*, *ér*

Script — the water piece, then xiān



How 洗 *is written, stroke by stroke*

洗

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The water piece, three strokes, as in 汉 and 没: a dot, a second dot under it, then a stroke that rises from the bottom left.

The right piece, xiān, six strokes: a short left-falling stroke, a horizontal, a vertical down through it, a long horizontal; then a left-falling stroke, and a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up, as at the foot of 儿.

3 + 6 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 洗, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 洗? (**Two** — the water piece, then xiān.)
Which characters you know have the same water piece? (汉 and 没.)
What does the last stroke look like? (**The right stroke of** 儿.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 洗, pinned stroke paths and medians.

99.3 shuāyá — to brush one's teeth

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for after, then the Mandarin for to wash.

You'll want to know: shuāyá

shuāyá — "to brush one's teeth".

wǒ měitiān zǎoshang shuāyá — I brush my teeth every morning.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuāyá is built from shuā 'to brush' and yá 'tooth', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *srwaet* and *ngae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to brush and wipe' and 'teeth'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuāyá*
- *Say it: shuāyá*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ měitiān zǎoshang shuāyá* — I brush my teeth every morning.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for after, then the Mandarin for to wash, then say *shuāyá* again

Before you move on

What does shuāyá mean? ("To brush one's teeth".) Say it once more.

99.4 xǐliǎn — to wash one's face

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to wash, then the Mandarin for to brush one's teeth.

You'll want to know: xǐliǎn

xǐliǎn — "to wash one's face".

nǐ xǐliǎn le ma — Have you washed your face?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

Two third tones in a row: xǐ is said with a rising tone before liǎn, though both are written with the third tone.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xǐliǎn is built from 洗 'to wash' and liǎn 'face'. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *sejX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary has the second only as *leamX*, the name of a kind of stew, so how it came to mean face is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: xǐliǎn*
- *Say it: xǐliǎn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐliǎn le ma* — Have you washed your face?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to wash, then the Mandarin for to brush one's teeth, then say *xǐliǎn* again

Before you move on

What does xǐliǎn mean? ("To wash one's face".) Say it once more.

99.5 xǐzǎo — to have a shower; to have a bath

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to brush one's teeth, then the Mandarin for to wash one's face.

You'll want to know: xǐzǎo

xǐzǎo — "to have a shower; to have a bath".

wǒ wǎnshang xǐzǎo — I have a shower in the evening.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
Two third tones again: xǐ rises before zǎo, and is still written xǐ.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xǐzǎo is built from 洗 and zǎo, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sejX* and *tsawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'to wash and bathe' and the second with the first: to wash.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: xǐzǎo*
- *Say it: xǐzǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ wǎnshang xǐzǎo* — I have a shower in the evening.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to brush one's teeth, then the Mandarin for to wash one's face, then say *xǐzǎo* again

Before you move on

What does xǐzǎo mean? ("To have a shower; to have a bath".) Say it once more.

99.6 shūtóu — to comb one's hair

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to wash one's face, then the Mandarin for to have a shower.

You'll want to know: shūtóu

shūtóu — "to comb one's hair".

wǒ zǎoshang shūtóu — I comb my hair in the morning.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shūtóu is built from shū 'to comb' and tóu 'head', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *srjo* and *duw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a comb, for putting the hair in order.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: shūtóu*
- *Say it: shūtóu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zǎoshang shūtóu* — I comb my hair in the morning.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to wash one's face, then the Mandarin for to have a shower, then say *shūtóu* again

Before you move on

What does shūtóu mean? ("To comb one's hair".) Say it once more.

Chapter 100

Around Town

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the bank, the supermarket, the park, the library and the post office.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 100: I can name the bank, the supermarket, the park, the library and the post office.*

100.1 yínháng — bank

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to have a shower, then the Mandarin for to comb one's hair.

You'll want to know: yínháng

yínháng — "bank".

> *yínháng zài nǎr* — Where's the bank?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yínháng is built from yín 'silver' and háng 'a row', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngin* and *hang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). Háng is usually explained as a row of shops and then a trade; the step is not given there, so how the pair came to mean a bank is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: yínháng*
- *Say it: yínháng*, once more
- *Say it: yínháng zài nǎr* — Where's the bank?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to have a shower, then the Mandarin for to comb one's hair, then say *yínháng* again

Before you move on

What does yínháng mean? ("Bank".) Say it once more.

100.2 chāoshì — supermarket

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to comb one's hair, then the Mandarin for bank.

You'll want to know: chāoshì

chāoshì — "supermarket".

wǒ qù chāoshì mǎi shuǐguǒ — I'm off to the supermarket for some fruit.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chāoshì is built from chāo and shì 'market', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *trhjew* and *dzyiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to leap'; 'super' is its sense in this modern word.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: chāoshì*
- *Say it: chāoshì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù chāoshì mǎi shuǐguǒ* — I'm off to the supermarket for some fruit.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to comb one's hair, then the Mandarin for bank, then say *chāoshì* again

Before you move on

What does chāoshì mean? ("Supermarket".) Say it once more.

100.3 gōngyuán — park

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bank, then the Mandarin for supermarket.

You'll want to know: gōngyuán

gōngyuán — "park".

wǒmen qù gōngyuán wán — We're going to the park to play.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gōngyuán is built from gōng 'public' and yuán 'garden', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kuwng* and *hjwon* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a garden for everyone.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: gōngyuán*
- *Say it: gōngyuán*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen qù gōngyuán wán* — We're going to the park to play.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bank, then the Mandarin for supermarket, then say *gōngyuán* again

Before you move on

What does gōngyuán mean? ("Park".) Say it once more.

100.4 túshūguǎn — library

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for supermarket, then the Mandarin for park.

You'll want to know: túshūguǎn

túshūguǎn — "library".

wǒ qù túshūguǎn kàn shū — I'm going to the library to read.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

túshūguǎn is built from tú 'picture', 书 'book' and guǎn 'hall', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *du*, *syo* and *kwanH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'to plan' and the last as a lodging house for guests.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: túshūguǎn*
- *Say it: túshūguǎn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù túshūguǎn kàn shū* — I'm going to the library to read.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for supermarket, then the Mandarin for park, then say *túshūguǎn* again

Before you move on

What does túshūguǎn mean? ("Library".) Say it once more.

100.5 yóujú — post office

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for park, then the Mandarin for library.

You'll want to know: yóujú

yóujú — "post office".

yóujú zài yínháng pángbiān — The post office is next to the bank.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yóujú is built from yóu 'post' and jú 'office', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuw* and *gjowk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a lodge on the border and the second as a government office.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: yóujú*
- *Say it: yóujú*, once more
- *Say it: yóujú zài yínháng pángbiān* — The post office is next to the bank.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for park, then the Mandarin for library, then say *yóujú* again

Before you move on

What does yóujú mean? ("Post office".) Say it once more.

Chapter 101

In the Kitchen

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the kitchen, cabbage, chopsticks, plates and a knife.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 101: I can name the kitchen, cabbage, chopsticks, plates and a knife.*

101.1 chúfáng — kitchen

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for library, then the Mandarin for post office.

You'll want to know: chúfáng

chúfáng — "kitchen".

> *māma zài chúfáng* — Mum's in the kitchen.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chúfáng is built from chú and fáng 'room', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *drju* and *bjang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as the house where food is cooked.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: chúfáng*
- *Say it: chúfáng*, once more
- *Say it: māma zài chúfáng* — Mum's in the kitchen.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for library, then the Mandarin for post office, then say *chúfáng* again

Before you move on

What does chúfáng mean? ("Kitchen".) Say it once more.

101.2 白菜 (báicài) — Chinese cabbage

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for post office, then the Mandarin for kitchen.

You'll want to know: 白菜

白菜 — *báicài* — "Chinese cabbage".

我去洗白菜 *wǒ qù xǐ báicài* — I'll go and wash the cabbage.

The new character, in pieces: 菜 — the grass piece on top, three strokes; under it a hand reaching down, four strokes; and at the foot the tree piece of 机, standing alone. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

白菜 (*báicài*) is built from 白 'white' and 菜 'vegetable', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *baek* and *tshojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary says every plant that can be eaten is called *tshojH*; the white one is probably named for its pale stalks.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: báicài*
- *Say it: báicài*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù xǐ báicài* — I'll go and wash the cabbage.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for post office, then the Mandarin for kitchen, then say *báicài* again

Before you move on

What does 白菜 mean? ("Chinese cabbage".) Say it once more.

101.3 菜 — the grass piece, a hand, the tree piece

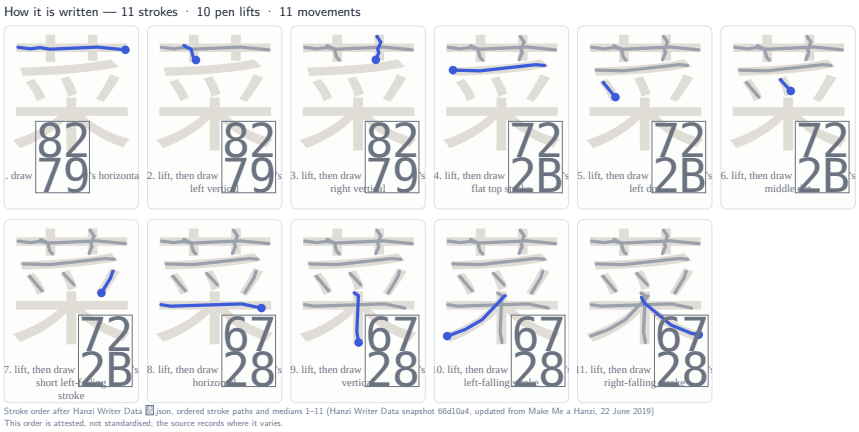
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *báicài* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  机 白

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *jī*, *bái*

Script — the grass piece, a hand, the tree piece



How 菜 *is written, stroke by stroke*

菜

Three pieces, top to bottom. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The grass piece, three strokes: a horizontal across the top, then two short verticals through it, left before right.

The hand, four strokes: a left-falling stroke across, two dots under it, left then middle, and a short left-falling stroke on the right.

The tree piece, four strokes, full width at the foot: a horizontal, a vertical down through it, a left-falling stroke and a long right-falling one.

3 + 4 + 4 = eleven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 菜, all eleven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 菜? (**Three** — the grass piece, a hand, the tree piece.) Which character you know has the tree piece? (机, on its left.) How does 菜 end? (**With a long right-falling stroke**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 菜, pinned stroke paths and medians.

101.4 kuàizi — chopsticks

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for kitchen, then the Mandarin for cabbage.

You'll want to know: kuàizi

kuàizi — "chopsticks".

wǒ de kuàizi ne — Where are my chopsticks?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kuàizi is built from kuài and the noun ending zi. The ending is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); no dictionary we use records an older form of the first, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: kuàizi*
- *Say it: kuàizi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de kuàizi ne* — Where are my chopsticks?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for kitchen, then the Mandarin for cabbage, then say *kuàizi* again

Before you move on

What does kuàizi mean? ("Chopsticks".) Say it once more.

101.5 pánzi — plate; dish

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cabbage, then the Mandarin for chopsticks.

You'll want to know: pánzi

pánzi — "plate; dish".

zhège pánzi hěn gānjìng — This plate is nice and clean.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

pánzi is built from pán and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ban* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as the name of a vessel.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: pánzi*
- *Say it: pánzi*, once more
- *Say it: zhège pánzi hěn gānjìng* — This plate is nice and clean.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cabbage, then the Mandarin for chopsticks, then say *pánzi* again

Before you move on

What does pánzi mean? ("Plate; dish".) Say it once more.

101.6 dāo — knife

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for chopsticks, then the Mandarin for plate.

You'll want to know: dāo

dāo — "knife".

dāo zài zhuōzi shàngbian — The knife is on the table.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dāo is inherited from Middle Chinese *taw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary glosses as a weapon, a blade for cutting things down. In the kitchen it is the knife.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: dāo*
- *Say it: dāo*, once more
- *Say it: dāo zài zhuōzi shàngbian* — The knife is on the table.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for chopsticks, then the Mandarin for plate, then say *dāo* again

Before you move on

What does dāo mean? ("Knife".) Say it once more.

Chapter 102

Something to Drink

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for a drink: juice, cola or beer, and a biscuit.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 102: I can ask for a drink: juice, cola or beer, and a biscuit.*

102.1 yǐnliào — drink; soft drink

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for plate, then the Mandarin for knife.

You'll want to know: yǐnliào

yǐnliào — "drink; soft drink".

> *nǐ xiǎng hē shénme yǐnliào* — What would you like to drink?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǐnliào is built from yǐn 'to drink' and liào, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'imX* and *lew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the second 'to measure' and lists it with a departing tone too, *lewH*, the one liào continues; how the pair came to mean a drink is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǐnliào*
- *Say it: yǐnliào*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xiǎng hē shénme yǐnliào* — What would you like to drink?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for plate, then the Mandarin for knife, then say *yǐnliào* again

Before you move on

What does yǐnliào mean? ("Drink; soft drink".) Say it once more.

102.2 guǒzhī — fruit juice

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for knife, then the Mandarin for soft drink.

You'll want to know: guǒzhī

guǒzhī — "fruit juice".

wǒ yào yì bēi guǒzhī — A glass of juice for me, please.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guǒzhī is built from guǒ 'fruit' and zhī 'juice', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kwaX* and *tsyip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the fruit of a tree' and 'liquid'.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: guǒzhī*
- *Say it: guǒzhī*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yào yì bēi guǒzhī* — A glass of juice for me, please.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for knife, then the Mandarin for soft drink, then say *guǒzhī* again

Before you move on

What does guǒzhī mean? ("Fruit juice".) Say it once more.

102.3 kělè — cola

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for soft drink, then the Mandarin for juice.

You'll want to know: kělè

kělè — "cola".

tāmen dōu hē kělè — They all drink cola.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kělè is borrowed from the name of a cola drink, usually traced to English *cola*; its two syllables are written with the characters for kě 'may' and lè 'joy', chosen for their sound.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: kělè*
- *Say it: kělè*, once more

- *Say it: tāmen dōu hē kělè* — They all drink cola.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for soft drink, then the Mandarin for juice, then say *kělè* again

Before you move on

What does kělè mean? ("Cola".) Say it once more.

102.4 píjiǔ — beer

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for juice, then the Mandarin for cola.

You'll want to know: píjiǔ

píjiǔ — "beer".

wǒ bù hē píjiǔ — I don't drink beer.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

píjiǔ is built from pí and jiǔ 'alcoholic drink'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsjuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the first is borrowed for its sound from a European word for beer, usually traced to English *beer*.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: píjiǔ*
- *Say it: píjiǔ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù hē píjiǔ* — I don't drink beer.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for juice, then the Mandarin for cola, then say *píjiǔ* again

Before you move on

What does píjiǔ mean? (“Beer”.) Say it once more.

102.5 bǐnggān — biscuit; cracker

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cola, then the Mandarin for beer.

You’ll want to know: bǐnggān

bǐnggān — “biscuit; cracker”.

wǒ xiǎngyào yí kuài bǐnggān — I’d like a biscuit.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bǐnggān is built from bǐng, a flat cake, and gān ’dry’, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjiengX* and *kan* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription); gān is the gān of gānjìng ’clean’.

What you’ve built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: bǐnggān*
- *Say it: bǐnggān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎngyào yí kuài bǐnggān* — I’d like a biscuit.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cola, then the Mandarin for beer, then say *bǐnggān* again

Before you move on

What does bǐnggān mean? (“Biscuit; cracker”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 103

Using Things

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say use, take, throw away and repair, and say something is broken.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 103: I can say use, take, throw away and repair, and say something is broken.*

103.1 用 (yòng) — to use

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for beer, then the Mandarin for biscuit.

You'll want to know: 用

用 — *yòng* — "to use".

> 我用水洗菜 *wǒ yòng shuǐ xǐ cài* — I wash the vegetables in water.

The new character, in pieces: 用 — the frame of the moon piece in 明, open at the foot, with two bars inside and a vertical down the middle. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

用 (*yòng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *yowngH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to employ' and 'by means of'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: yòng*
- *Say it: yòng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yòng shuǐ xǐ cài* — I wash the vegetables in water.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for beer, then the Mandarin for biscuit, then say *yòng* again

Before you move on

What does 用 mean? ("To use".) Say it once more.

103.2 用 — the moon frame, two bars, a vertical

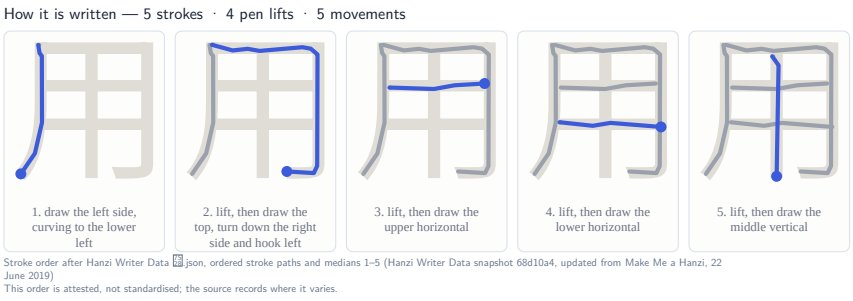
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yòng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

明 能

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *míng*, *néng*

Script — the moon frame, two bars, a vertical



How 用 is written, stroke by stroke

用

The frame, two strokes, as on the right of 明: a left-falling stroke down the left side, then a stroke across the top that turns down the right side and hooks.

Two horizontals inside, one above the other.

A vertical down the middle, from the top through both bars to the foot.

2 + 2 + 1 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 用, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 用? (**Five**.) Which character you know has the same frame? (明, on its right.) Which stroke comes last? (**The vertical down the middle**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 用, pinned stroke paths and medians.

103.3 ná — to take; to hold

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for biscuit, then the Mandarin for to use.

You'll want to know: ná

ná — "to take; to hold".

nǐ ná wǒ de yàoshi le ma — Did you take my keys?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ná is probably inherited from Middle Chinese *nrae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which the dictionary lists under an older form of the character, glossed 'to pull'. That the two are one word is likely;

how 'to pull' became 'to take' is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: ná*
- *Say it: ná*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ ná wǒ de yàoshi le ma* — Did you take my keys?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for biscuit, then the Mandarin for to use, then say *ná* again

Before you move on

What does ná mean? ("To take; to hold".) Say it once more.

103.4 rēng — to throw; to throw away

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to use, then the Mandarin for to take hold of.

You'll want to know: rēng

rēng — "to throw; to throw away".

bú yào rēng wǒ de shū — Don't throw my books away.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rēng is inherited from Middle Chinese *nying* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to pull'. The regular change from *nying* gives réng, with a rising tone, not the level rēng of today, and throwing is not given there; how the word came to its sound and sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: rēng*
- *Say it: rēng*, once more
- *Say it: bú yào rēng wǒ de shū* — Don't throw my books away.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to use, then the Mandarin for to take hold of, then say *rēng* again

Before you move on

What does rēng mean? ("To throw; to throw away".) Say it once more.

103.5 xiū — to repair; to fix

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to take hold of, then the Mandarin for to throw away.

You'll want to know: xiū

xiū — "to repair; to fix".

tā huì xiū diànnǎo — He knows how to fix computers.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiū is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to put in order' and 'to adorn'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiūn*
- *Say it: xiū*, once more
- *Say it: tā huì xiū diànnǎo* — He knows how to fix computers.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to take hold of, then the Mandarin for to throw away, then say *xiū* again

Before you move on

What does xiū mean? ("To repair; to fix".) Say it once more.

103.6 huài — broken; bad

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to throw away, then the Mandarin for to repair.

You'll want to know: huài

huài — "broken; bad".

wǒ de shǒujī huài le — My phone's broken.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huài is inherited from Middle Chinese *hweajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to break of itself'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: huài*
- *Say it: huài*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ de shǒujī huài le* — My phone's broken.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to throw away, then the Mandarin for to repair, then say *huài* again

Before you move on

What does huài mean? ("Broken; bad".) Say it once more.

Chapter 104

On the Desk

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a notebook, a pen, a pencil, paper and a dictionary.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 104: I can name a notebook, a pen, a pencil, paper and a dictionary.*

104.1 本子 (běnzi) — notebook

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to repair, then the Mandarin for broken.

You'll want to know: 本子

本子 — *běnzi* — "notebook".

> 我能用你的本子吗 *wǒ néng yòng nǐ de běnzi ma* — Could I use your notebook?

The new character, in pieces: 本 — the tree piece of 机, standing alone, with a short bar across its foot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

本子 (*běnzi*) is built from 本 and the noun ending 子, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pwonX* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'root' and explains its

shape as a tree with a mark at its foot; how it came to mean a book is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: běnzi*
- *Say it: běnzi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ néng yòng nǐ de běnzi ma* — Could I use your notebook?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to repair, then the Mandarin for broken, then say *běnzi* again

Before you move on

What does 本子 mean? ("Notebook".) Say it once more.

104.2 本 — the tree piece, and a bar at its foot

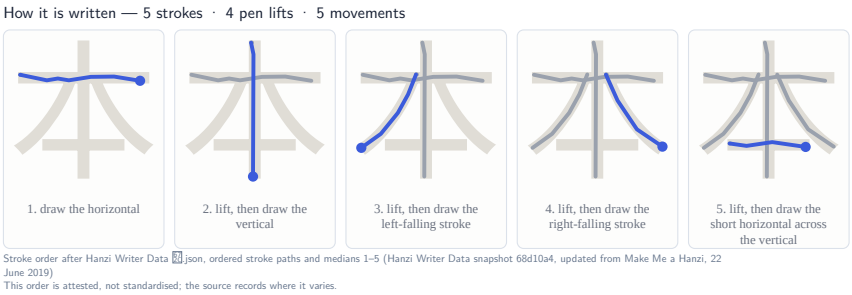
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *běnzi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  机 子

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *jī*, *zǐ*

Script — the tree piece, and a bar at its foot



How 本 *is written, stroke by stroke*

本

The tree piece, four strokes, as on the left of 机 but full width: a horizontal, a vertical down through it, a left-falling stroke and a long right-falling one.

A short horizontal across the vertical, low down: the mark at the root.

4 + 1 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 本, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 本? (**Five.**) Where is the short bar? (**Low down, across the vertical.**) Which character you know has the same tree piece? (机.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 本, pinned stroke paths and medians.

104.3 bǐ — pen

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for broken, then the Mandarin for notebook.

You'll want to know: bǐ

bǐ — "pen".

nǐ yǒu bǐ ma — Have you got a pen?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bǐ is inherited from Middle Chinese *pit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), the writing brush; the dictionary repeats a story that a general of the Qin dynasty made the first one.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: bǐ*
- *Say it: bǐ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yǒu bǐ ma* — Have you got a pen?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for broken, then the Mandarin for notebook, then say *bǐ* again

Before you move on

What does bǐ mean? ("Pen".) Say it once more.

104.4 qiānbǐ — pencil

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for notebook, then the Mandarin for pen.

You'll want to know: qiānbǐ

qiānbǐ — "pencil".

wǒ yòng qiānbǐ xiě zì — I write with a pencil.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qiānbǐ is built from qiān 'lead' and bǐ 'pen', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ywen* and *pit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a grey-blue metal. The regular change from *ywen* gives yuán, not qiān; how the word came to its sound is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiānbǐ*
- *Say it: qiānbǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yòng qiānbǐ xiě zì* — I write with a pencil.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for notebook, then the Mandarin for pen, then say *qiānbǐ* again

Before you move on

What does qiānbǐ mean? ("Pencil".) Say it once more.

104.5 zhǐ — paper

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pen, then the Mandarin for pencil.

You'll want to know: zhǐ

zhǐ — "paper".

qǐng gěi wǒ yì zhāng zhǐ — Could I have a sheet of paper, please?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǐ is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyeX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), where the dictionary says paper is as smooth as a whetstone, and that in the Later Han it was made from old fishing nets and tree bark.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǐ*
- *Say it: zhǐ*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng gěi wǒ yì zhāng zhǐ* — Could I have a sheet of paper, please?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pen, then the Mandarin for pencil, then say *zhǐ* again

Before you move on

What does zhǐ mean? ("Paper".) Say it once more.

104.6 cídiǎn — dictionary

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pencil, then the Mandarin for paper.

You'll want to know: cídiǎn

cídiǎn — "dictionary".

wǒ yǒu yì běn hànyǔ cídiǎn — I've got a Chinese dictionary.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cídiǎn is built from cí 'words' and diǎn 'a standard work', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *zi* and *tenX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as a law and a classic.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: cídiǎn*
- *Say it: cídiǎn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǒu yì běn hànyǔ cídiǎn* — I've got a Chinese dictionary.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pencil, then the Mandarin for paper, then say *cídiǎn* again

Before you move on

What does cídiǎn mean? ("Dictionary".) Say it once more.

104.7 Looking back: from Getting Washed to On the Desk

Say the Mandarin for to wash and to brush one's teeth.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to wash, to brush one's teeth, to wash one's face, to have a shower, to comb one's hair
- *Say it:* bank, supermarket, park, library, post office
- *Say it:* kitchen, cabbage, chopsticks, plate, knife
- *Say it:* soft drink, juice, cola, beer, biscuit
- *Say it:* to use, to take hold of, to throw away, to repair, broken

- *Say it:* notebook, pen, pencil, paper, dictionary
- *Read it:* 洗 菜 用 本 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

To wash? (洗, *xǐ.*) To brush one's teeth? (*shuāyá.*) To wash one's face? (*xǐliǎn.*) To have a shower? (*xǐzǎo.*) To comb one's hair? (*shūtóu.*) Bank? (*yínháng.*) Supermarket? (*chāoshì.*) Park? (*gōngyuán.*) Library? (*túshūguǎn.*) Post office? (*yóujú.*) Kitchen? (*chúfáng.*) Cabbage? (白菜, *báicài.*) Chopsticks? (*kuàizi.*) Plate? (*pánzi.*) Knife? (*dāo.*) Soft drink? (*yǐnliào.*) Juice? (*guǒzhī.*) Cola? (*kělè.*) Beer? (*píjiǔ.*) Biscuit? (*bǐnggān.*) To use? (用, *yòng.*) To take hold of? (*ná.*) To throw away? (*rēng.*) To repair? (*xiū.*) Broken? (*huài.*) Notebook? (本子, *běnzi.*) Pen? (*bǐ.*) Pencil? (*qiānbǐ.*) Paper? (*zhǐ.*) Dictionary? (*cídiǎn.*)

Chapter 105

In the Bathroom

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a towel, a toothbrush, toothpaste, soap and a mirror.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 105: I can name a towel, a toothbrush, toothpaste, soap and a mirror.*

105.1 máojīn — towel

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for paper, then the Mandarin for dictionary.

You'll want to know: máojīn

máojīn — "towel".

> *wǒ de máojīn hěn gānjìng* — My towel is clean.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

máojīn is built from máo and jīn, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *maw* and *kin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as hair and fur and explains the second as a cloth worn on the head. How the pair came to mean a towel is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: máojīn*
- *Say it: máojīn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de máojīn hěn gānjìng* — My towel is clean.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for paper, then the Mandarin for dictionary, then say *máojīn* again

Before you move on

What does máojīn mean? ("Towel".) Say it once more.

105.2 yáshuā — toothbrush

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dictionary, then the Mandarin for towel.

You'll want to know: yáshuā

yáshuā — "toothbrush".

wǒ de yáshuā zài nǎr — Where's my toothbrush?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yáshuā is built from yá 'tooth' and shuā 'brush', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngae* and *srwaet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the two parts of shuāyá, the other way round, make the thing.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: yáshuā*
- *Say it: yáshuā*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de yáshuā zài nǎr* — Where's my toothbrush?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dictionary, then the Mandarin for towel, then say *yáshuā* again

Before you move on

What does yáshuā mean? ("Toothbrush".) Say it once more.

105.3 yágāo — toothpaste

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for towel, then the Mandarin for toothbrush.

You'll want to know: yágāo

yágāo — "toothpaste".

méiyǒu yágāo le — We're out of toothpaste.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yágāo is built from yá 'tooth' and gāo 'paste', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngae* and *kaw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as fat or grease.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: yágāo*
- *Say it: yágāo*, once more

- *Say it: méiyǒu yágāo le* — We're out of toothpaste.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for towel, then the Mandarin for toothbrush, then say *yágāo* again

Before you move on

What does yágāo mean? ("Toothpaste".) Say it once more.

105.4 féizào — soap

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for toothbrush, then the Mandarin for toothpaste.

You'll want to know: féizào

féizào — "soap".

yòng féizào xǐ shǒu — Wash your hands with soap.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

féizào is built from féi 'fat' and zào, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bj+j* and *dzawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'fleshy', and the second as black silk, among other senses; how the pair came to mean soap is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: féizào*
- *Say it: féizào*, once more
- *Say it: yòng féizào xǐ shǒu* — Wash your hands with soap.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for toothbrush, then the Mandarin for toothpaste, then say *féizào* again

Before you move on

What does féizào mean? (“Soap”.) Say it once more.

105.5 jìngzi — mirror

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for toothpaste, then the Mandarin for soap.

You’ll want to know: jìngzi

jìngzi — “mirror”.

xǐshǒujiān lǐ yǒu jìngzi ma — Is there a mirror in the toilets?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jìngzi is built from jìng ’mirror’ and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kjaengH* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription); the dictionary’s entry tells of a mirror sent as a gift to a king of old.

What you’ve built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: jìngzi*
- *Say it: jìngzi*, once more
- *Say it: xǐshǒujiān lǐ yǒu jìngzi ma* — Is there a mirror in the toilets?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for toothpaste, then the Mandarin for soap, then say *jìngzi* again

Before you move on

What does jìngzi mean? (“Mirror”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 106

Stops and Stations

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for the station, and talk about the metro, buses and bikes.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 106: I can ask for the station, and talk about the metro, buses and bikes.*

106.1 车站 (chēzhàn) — station; stop

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for soap, then the Mandarin for mirror.

You'll want to know: 车站

车站 — *chēzhàn* — "station; stop".

> 车站在哪儿 *chēzhàn zài nǎr* — Where's the station?

The new character, in pieces: 站 — on the left a five-stroke piece read lì, 'to stand'; on the right a vertical with a short bar to its right, over 口. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

车站 (*chēzhàn*) is built from 车 'vehicle' and 站 'to stand', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhae* and *treamH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as an

everyday word for standing alone. A place where vehicles stand is the usual explanation, but the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: chēzhàn*
- *Say it: chēzhàn*, once more
- *Say it: chēzhàn zài nǎr* — Where's the station?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for soap, then the Mandarin for mirror, then say *chēzhàn* again

Before you move on

What does 车站 mean? ("Station; stop".) Say it once more.

106.2 站 — the standing piece, then a mark over 口

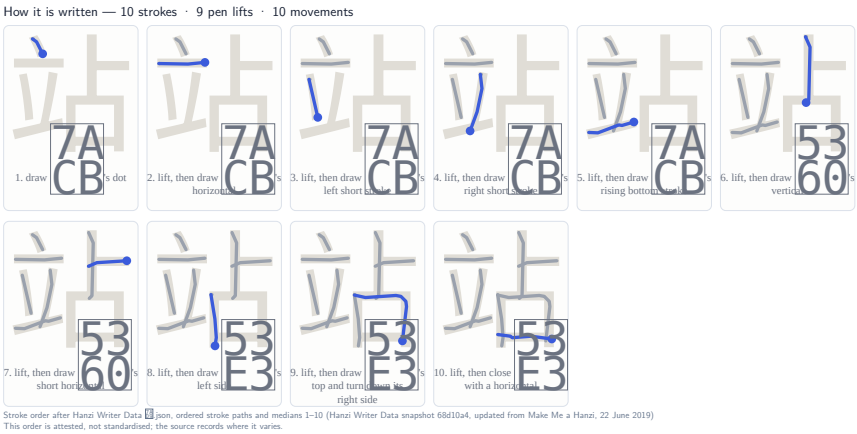
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chēzhàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  车 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *chē*, *kǒu*

Script — the standing piece, then a mark over 口



How 站 *is written, stroke by stroke*

站

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The standing piece, lì, five strokes: a dot at the top, a horizontal, a dot on the left and a short left-falling stroke on the right, and a stroke along the bottom that rises to the right.

The right piece, five strokes: a vertical with a short horizontal to its right; then 口 below, as you write it alone: the left side, the top that turns down, the bottom.

5 + 5 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 站, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 站? (**Two** — the standing piece, then the mark over 口.) What is the standing piece read? (*lì*.) Which piece you know ends 站? (口.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 站, pinned stroke paths and medians.

106.3 dìtiě — underground; metro

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for mirror, then the Mandarin for station.

You'll want to know: dìtiě

dìtiě — "underground; metro".

wǒmen zuò dìtiě qù — We'll take the metro.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìtiě is built from dì 'ground' and tiě 'iron', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dijH* and *thet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as black metal. The railway under the ground is a modern sense.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìtiě*
- *Say it: dìtiě*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen zuò dìtiě qù* — We'll take the metro.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for mirror, then the Mandarin for station, then say *dìtiě* again

Before you move on

What does dìtiě mean? ("Underground; metro".) Say it once more.

106.4 gōngjiāochē — city bus

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for station, then the Mandarin for metro.

You'll want to know: gōngjiāochē

gōngjiāochē — "city bus".

gōngjiāochē lái le — Here comes the bus.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gōngjiāochē is built from gōng 'public', jiāo 'to cross' and 车 'vehicle', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *kuwng*, *kaew* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The bus is a modern sense of the whole.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: gōngjiāochē*
- *Say it: gōngjiāochē*, once more
- *Say it: gōngjiāochē lái le* — Here comes the bus.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for station, then the Mandarin for metro, then say *gōngjiāochē* again

Before you move on

What does gōngjiāochē mean? ("City bus".) Say it once more.

106.5 zìxíngchē — bicycle

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for metro, then the Mandarin for bus.

You'll want to know: zìxíngchē

zìxíngchē — "bicycle".

> *zhè shì wǒ de zìxíngchē* — This is my bike.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zìxíngchē is built from zì 'self', xíng 'to go' and 车 'vehicle', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzijH*, *haeng* and *tsyhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses *haeng* 'to walk' and *dzijH* 'from'; the bicycle is a modern sense of the whole.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: zìxíngchē*
- *Say it: zìxíngchē*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de zìxíngchē* — This is my bike.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for metro, then the Mandarin for bus, then say *zìxíngchē* again

Before you move on

What does zìxíngchē mean? ("Bicycle".) Say it once more.

106.6 qí — to ride (a bike or a horse)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bus, then the Mandarin for bicycle.

You'll want to know: qí

qí — "to ride (a bike or a horse)".

> *wǒ qí zìxíngchē qù xuéxiào* — I ride my bike to school.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qí is inherited from Middle Chinese *gje* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to sit astride a horse'.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: qí*
- *Say it: qí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qí zìxíngchē qù xuéxiào* — I ride my bike to school.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bus, then the Mandarin for bicycle, then say *qí* again

Before you move on

What does qí mean? ("To ride (a bike or a horse)".) Say it once more.

Chapter 107

On the Move

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say jump, climb, carry, stop and leave.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 107: I can say jump, climb, carry, stop and leave.*

107.1 tiào — to jump

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bicycle, then the Mandarin for to ride.

You'll want to know: tiào

tiào — "to jump".

> *wǒ de gǒu hěn xǐhuan tiào* — My dog loves jumping.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tiào is inherited from Middle Chinese *dew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to leap'. The regular change from *dew* gives tiáo, with a rising tone, not the falling tiào of today; how it came to its tone is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: tiào*
- *Say it: tiào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de gǒu hěn xǐhuan tiào* — My dog loves jumping.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bicycle, then the Mandarin for to ride, then say *tiào* again

Before you move on

What does tiào mean? ("To jump".) Say it once more.

107.2 pá — to climb; to crawl

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to ride, then the Mandarin for to jump.

You'll want to know: pá

pá — "to climb; to crawl".

wǒmen míngtiān qù pá shān — We're going up into the hills tomorrow.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

pá is inherited from Middle Chinese *bae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to scratch'; how it came to mean to climb is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: pá*
- *Say it: pá*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen míngtiān qù pá shān* — We're going up into the hills tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to ride, then the Mandarin for to jump, then say *pá* again

Before you move on

What does pá mean? ("To climb; to crawl".) Say it once more.

107.3 bān — to move house; to move (something heavy)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to jump, then the Mandarin for to climb.

You'll want to know: bān

bān — "to move house; to move (something heavy)".

nǐ néng bāng wǒ bān zhuōzi ma — Can you help me move the table?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bān has no older form on record under this character. The dictionary lists the same sound, *pan* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), under an older character glossed 'to transport', which is probably the same word, though that is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: bān*
- *Say it: bān*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ néng bāng wǒ bān zhuōzi ma* — Can you help me move the table?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to jump, then the Mandarin for to climb, then say *bān* again

Before you move on

What does bān mean? ("To move house; to move (something heavy)".) Say it once more.

107.4 tíng — to stop; to park

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to climb, then the Mandarin for to move house.

You'll want to know: tíng

tíng — "to stop; to park".

chē tíng le — The car has stopped.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tíng is inherited from Middle Chinese *deng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to rest', 'to settle' and 'to stop'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: tíng*
- *Say it: tíng*, once more
- *Say it: chē tíng le* — The car has stopped.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to climb, then the Mandarin for to move house, then say *tíng* again

Before you move on

What does tíng mean? ("To stop; to park".) Say it once more.

107.5 líkāi — to leave a place

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to move house, then the Mandarin for to stop.

You'll want to know: líkāi

líkāi — "to leave a place".

wǒmen jǐ diǎn líkāi — What time are we leaving?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

líkāi is built from lí 'to part' and 开 'to open', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *lje* and *khoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary says parting at a short distance is *lje*, at a long one is another word.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: líkāi*
- *Say it: líkāi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen jǐ diǎn líkāi* — What time are we leaving?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to move house, then the Mandarin for to stop, then say *líkāi* again

Before you move on

What does líkāi mean? ("To leave a place".) Say it once more.

Chapter 108

Trying It On

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask to try something on, change it, and talk about pairs, sizes and fit.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 108: I can ask to try something on, change it, and talk about pairs, sizes and fit.*

108.1 试 (shì) — to try; to try on

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to stop, then the Mandarin for to leave a place.

You'll want to know: 试

试 — *shì* — "to try; to try on".

> 这个能试吗 *zhège néng shì ma* — Can I try this one on?

The new character, in pieces: 试 — the speech piece of 说 on the left; on the right six strokes: a horizontal across the top, a small three-stroke piece low under it, and a long stroke that slants down and hooks, with a dot at its top right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

试 (*shì*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *syiH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to use'. Trying a thing by putting it to use is

the usual explanation, but the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: shì*
- *Say it: shì*, once more
- *Say it: zhège néng shì ma* — Can I try this one on?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to stop, then the Mandarin for to leave a place, then say *shì* again

Before you move on

What does 试 mean? ("To try; to try on".) Say it once more.

108.2 试 — the speech piece, then a slanting hook

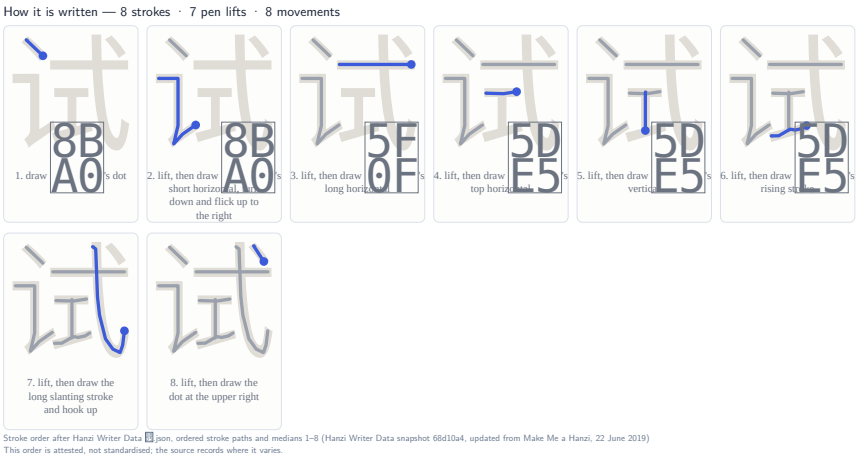
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  说 请

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shuō*, *qǐng*

Script — the speech piece, then a slanting hook



How 试 *is written, stroke by stroke*

试

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The speech piece, two strokes, as in 说: a dot, then a stroke across that turns down and rises.

The right piece, six strokes: a horizontal across the top; then, low on the left, a short horizontal, a vertical and a stroke that rises to the right; then one long stroke that slants down to the right and hooks up; and last a dot at the top right.

2 + 6 = eight.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 试, all eight, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 试? (**Two** — the speech piece, then the right piece.) Which characters you know start with the same piece? (说, 请, 课.) Which stroke comes last? (**The dot at the top right**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 试, pinned stroke paths and medians.

108.3 huàn — to change; to exchange

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to leave a place, then the Mandarin for to try on.

You'll want to know: huàn

huàn — "to change; to exchange".

wǒ xiǎng huàn yí ge — I'd like to change it for another one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwanH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to exchange'.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: huàn*
- *Say it: huàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng huàn yí ge* — I'd like to change it for another one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to leave a place, then the Mandarin for to try on, then say *huàn* again

Before you move on

What does huàn mean? ("To change; to exchange".) Say it once more.

108.4 shuāng — a pair of (a measure word)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to try on, then the Mandarin for to exchange.

You'll want to know: shuāng

shuāng — "a pair of (a measure word)".

wǒ xiǎng mǎi yì shuāng xié — I'd like to buy a pair of shoes.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuāng is inherited from Middle Chinese *sraewng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a pair, two of a kind'.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuāng*
- *Say it: shuāng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng mǎi yì shuāng xié* — I'd like to buy a pair of shoes.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to try on, then the Mandarin for to exchange, then say *shuāng* again

Before you move on

What does shuāng mean? ("A pair of (a measure word)".) Say it once more.

108.5 大小 (dàxiǎo) — size

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to exchange, then the Mandarin for a pair of.

You'll want to know: 大小

大小 — *dàxiǎo* — "size".

> 我试了大小很好 *wǒ shì le dàxiǎo hěn hǎo* — I've tried it on, and the size is fine.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

大小 (*dàxiǎo*) is built from 大 'big' and 小 'small', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *daH* and *sjewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): how big or small a thing is.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: dàxiǎo*
- *Say it: dàxiǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ shì le dàxiǎo hěn hǎo* — I've tried it on, and the size is fine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to exchange, then the Mandarin for a pair of, then say *dàxiǎo* again

Before you move on

What does 大小 mean? ("Size".) Say it once more.

108.6 héshì — right; suitable; a good fit

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a pair of, then the Mandarin for size.

You'll want to know: héshì

héshì — "right; suitable; a good fit".

> *zhè shuāng xié hěn héshì* — These shoes fit well.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

héshì is built from hé and shì, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hop* and *syek* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'to agree, to match' and the second 'good', among other senses.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: héshì*
- *Say it: héshì*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shuāng xié hěn héshì* — These shoes fit well.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a pair of, then the Mandarin for size, then say *héshì* again

Before you move on

What does héshì mean? ("Right; suitable; a good fit".) Say it once more.

Chapter 109

Screens

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about going online, the television, photos, charging and downloading.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 109: I can talk about going online, the television, photos, charging and downloading.*

109.1 上网 (shàngwǎng) — to go online

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for size, then the Mandarin for a good fit.

You'll want to know: 上网

上网 — *shàngwǎng* — "to go online".

> *nǐ měitiān shàngwǎng ma* — Do you go online every day?

The new character, in pieces: 网 — a frame open at the foot, like the outside of 两, with two small crosses inside. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

上网 (*shàngwǎng*) is built from 上 'to go up, to get on' and wǎng 'net', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyangX* and *mjangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary describes the net as knotted

cord for hunting and fishing. Getting on to the net is a modern sense.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: shàngwǎng*
- *Say it: shàngwǎng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ měitiān shàngwǎng ma* — Do you go online every day?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for size, then the Mandarin for a good fit, then say *shàngwǎng* again

Before you move on

What does 上网 mean? ("To go online".) Say it once more.

109.2 网 — the frame of 两, and two crosses

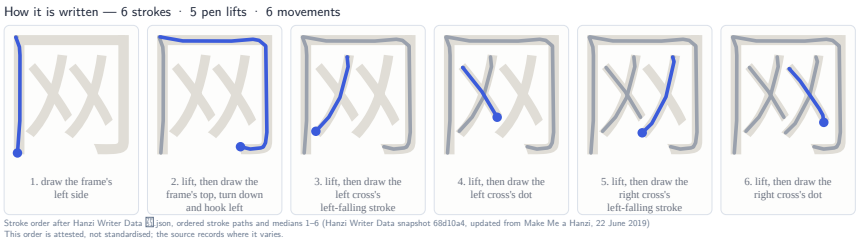
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shàngwǎng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  两 上

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *liǎng*, *shàng*

Script — the frame of 两, and two crosses



How 网 is written, stroke by stroke

网

The frame, two strokes, as in 两: a vertical down the left, then a stroke across the top that turns down the right side and hooks.

Two small crosses inside, two strokes each, left before right: a left-falling stroke, then a dot across it.

2 + 2 + 2 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 网, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 网? (**Six.**) Where have you written its frame? (**In 两.**) What is inside? (**Two small crosses, left one first.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 网, pinned stroke paths and medians.

109.3 diànshì — television

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a good fit, then the Mandarin for to go online.

You'll want to know: diànshì

diànshì — "television".

wǒ wǎnshang kàn diànshì — I watch TV in the evening.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diànshì is built from 电 'electricity' and shì 'to look', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *denH* and *dzyijH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as lightning. A modern

word.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: diànshì*
- *Say it: diànshì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ wǎnshang kàn diànshì* — I watch TV in the evening.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a good fit, then the Mandarin for to go online, then say *diànshì* again

Before you move on

What does diànshì mean? ("Television".) Say it once more.

109.4 zhàopiàn — photo; photograph

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go online, then the Mandarin for television.

You'll want to know: zhàopiàn

zhàopiàn — "photo; photograph".

zhè shì wǒ jiārén de zhàopiàn — This is a photo of my family.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhàopiàn is built from zhào and piàn, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyewH* and *phenH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'bright' and the second as a piece of split wood. The photo is a modern sense of the pair.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhàopiàn*
- *Say it: zhàopiàn*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ jiārén de zhàopiàn* — This is a photo of my family.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go online, then the Mandarin for television, then say *zhàopiàn* again

Before you move on

What does zhàopiàn mean? ("Photo; photograph".) Say it once more.

109.5 chōngdiàn — to charge a battery

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for television, then the Mandarin for photo.

You'll want to know: chōngdiàn

chōngdiàn — "to charge a battery".

wǒ de shǒujī xūyào chōngdiàn — My phone needs charging.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chōngdiàn is built from chōng 'to fill' and 电 'electricity', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhuwng* and *denH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): to fill with electricity. A modern word.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: chōngdiàn*
- *Say it: chōngdiàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de shǒujī xūyào chōngdiàn* — My phone needs charging.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for television, then the Mandarin for photo, then say *chōngdiàn* again

Before you move on

What does chōngdiàn mean? ("To charge a battery".) Say it once more.

109.6 xiàzài — to download

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for photo, then the Mandarin for to charge a battery.

You'll want to know: xiàzài

xiàzài — "to download".

nǐ xiàzài le ma — Have you downloaded it?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàzài is built from 下 'down' and zài 'to carry', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeX* and *dzojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to go down' and 'to transport'. A modern word.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàzài*
- *Say it: xiàzài*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xiàzài le ma* — Have you downloaded it?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for photo, then the Mandarin for to charge a battery, then say *xiàzài* again

Before you move on

What does xiàzài mean? ("To download".) Say it once more.

Chapter 110

Things I Can Do

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I speak a foreign language, play the piano, paint and dance.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 110: I can say I speak a foreign language, play the piano, paint and dance.*

110.1 外语 (wàiyǔ) — foreign language

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to charge a battery, then the Mandarin for to download.

You'll want to know: 外语

外语 — *wàiyǔ* — "foreign language".

> 我上网学外语 *wǒ shàngwǎng xué wàiyǔ* — I learn foreign languages online.

The new character, in pieces: 外 — on the left the three-stroke top half of 多; on the right a vertical with a dot beside it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

外语 (*wàiyǔ*) is built from 外 'outside' and 语 'speech', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngwajH* and *ngjoX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription): the speech from outside.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàiyǔ*
- *Say it: wàiyǔ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ shàngwǎng xué wàiyǔ* — I learn foreign languages online.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to charge a battery, then the Mandarin for to download, then say *wàiyǔ* again

Before you move on

What does 外语 mean? ("Foreign language".) Say it once more.

110.2 外 — the top of 多, then a vertical and a dot

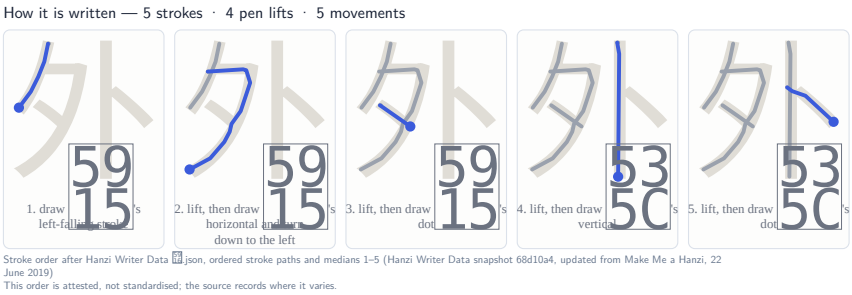
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *wàiyǔ* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  多 语

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *duō*, *yǔ*

Script — the top of 多, then a vertical and a dot



How 外 is written, stroke by stroke

外

Two pieces, left before right.

The left piece, three strokes, the top half of 多: a short left-falling stroke, a stroke across that turns and sweeps down to the left, and a dot inside.

The right piece, two strokes: a long vertical, and a dot to its right.

3 + 2 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 外, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 外? (**Five.**) Where have you written its left piece? (**At the top of 多.**) What is on the right? (**A vertical and a dot.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 外, pinned stroke paths and medians.

110.3 gāngqín — piano

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to download, then the Mandarin for foreign language.

You'll want to know: gāngqín

gāngqín — "piano".

tā jiā yǒu gāngqín — Her family has a piano.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gāngqín is built from gāng 'steel' and qín, a stringed instrument, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kang* and *gim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary describes the second as an instrument of five strings, later seven. The piano is a modern sense of the pair.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: gāngqín*
- *Say it: gāngqín*, once more
- *Say it: tā jiā yǒu gāngqín* — Her family has a piano.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to download, then the Mandarin for foreign language, then say *gāngqín* again

Before you move on

What does gāngqín mean? ("Piano".) Say it once more.

110.4 tán — to play an instrument; to pluck

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for foreign language, then the Mandarin for piano.

You'll want to know: tán

tán — "to play an instrument; to pluck".

wǒ huì tán gāngqín — I can play the piano.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tán is inherited from Middle Chinese *dan* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to shoot' and named in a game of flicking pieces. Playing an instrument is not given there, so how the word came to that sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: tán*
- *Say it: tán*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ huì tán gāngqín* — I can play the piano.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for foreign language, then the Mandarin for piano, then say *tán* again

Before you move on

What does tán mean? ("To play an instrument; to pluck".) Say it once more.

110.5 huàhuà — to paint pictures; to draw

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for piano, then the Mandarin for to play an instrument.

You'll want to know: huàhuà

huàhuà — "to paint pictures; to draw".

> *háizi xǐhuan huàhuà* — Children love painting.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huàhuà is built from huà 'to paint' and its object huà 'a picture', one word used twice, inherited from Middle Chinese *hweaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary explains painting as laying the five colours on the likeness of things.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: huàhuà*
- *Say it: huàhuà*, once more
- *Say it: háizi xǐhuan huàhuà* — Children love painting.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for piano, then the Mandarin for to play an instrument, then say *huàhuà* again

Before you move on

What does huàhuà mean? ("To paint pictures; to draw".) Say it once more.

110.6 tiàowǔ — to dance

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to play an instrument, then the Mandarin for to paint pictures.

You'll want to know: tiàowǔ

tiàowǔ — "to dance".

nǐ xǐhuan tiàowǔ ma — Do you like dancing?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tiàowǔ is built from tiào 'to leap' and wǔ 'dance', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dew* and *mjuX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as song and dance.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: tiàowǔ*
- *Say it: tiàowǔ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan tiàowǔ ma* — Do you like dancing?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to play an instrument, then the Mandarin for to paint pictures, then say *tiàowǔ* again

Before you move on

What does tiàowǔ mean? ("To dance".) Say it once more.

110.7 Looking back: from In the Bathroom to Things I Can Do

Say the Mandarin for towel and toothbrush.

Your turn

- *Say it:* towel, toothbrush, toothpaste, soap, mirror
- *Say it:* station, metro, bus, bicycle, to ride

- *Say it:* to jump, to climb, to move house, to stop, to leave a place
- *Say it:* to try on, to exchange, a pair of, size, a good fit
- *Say it:* to go online, television, photo, to charge a battery, to download
- *Say it:* foreign language, piano, to play an instrument, to paint pictures, to dance
- *Read it:* 站 试 网 外 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Towel? (*máojīn.*) Toothbrush? (*yáshuā.*) Toothpaste? (*yágāo.*) Soap? (*féizào.*) Mirror? (*jìngzi.*) Station? (车站, *chēzhàn.*) Metro? (*dìtiě.*) Bus? (*gōngjiāochē.*) Bicycle? (*zìxíngchē.*) To ride? (*qí.*) To jump? (*tiào.*) To climb? (*pá.*) To move house? (*bān.*) To stop? (*tíng.*) To leave a place? (*líkāi.*) To try on? (试, *shì.*) To exchange? (*huàn.*) A pair of? (*shuāng.*) Size? (大小, *dàxiǎo.*) A good fit? (*héshì.*) To go online? (上网, *shàngwǎng.*) Television? (*diànshì.*) Photo? (*zhàopiàn.*) To charge a battery? (*chōngdiàn.*) To download? (*xiàzài.*) Foreign language? (外语, *wàiyǔ.*) Piano? (*gāngqín.*) To play an instrument? (*tán.*) To paint pictures? (*huàhuà.*) To dance? (*tiàowǔ.*)

Chapter 111

In Front and Behind

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say in front, behind, nearby and at the crossing, and say where to turn.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 111: I can say in front, behind, nearby and at the crossing, and say where to turn.*

111.1 前边 (qiánbian) — in front; ahead

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to paint pictures, then the Mandarin for to dance.

You'll want to know: 前边

前边 — *qiánbian* — "in front; ahead".

> 前边是火车站 *qiánbian shì huǒchēzhàn* — The railway station is up ahead.

The new character, in pieces: 边 — lì, the foot of 男, inside the walking piece that runs down the left and along the foot of 这 and 进. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

前边 (*qiánbian*) is built from 前 'front' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzen* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'first, before' and the second 'an edge'.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiánbian*
- *Say it: qiánbian*, once more
- *Say it: qiánbian shì huǒchēzhàn* — The railway station is up ahead.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to paint pictures, then the Mandarin for to dance, then say *qiánbian* again

Before you move on

What does 前边 mean? ("In front; ahead".) Say it once more.

111.2 边 — the foot of 男, inside the walking piece

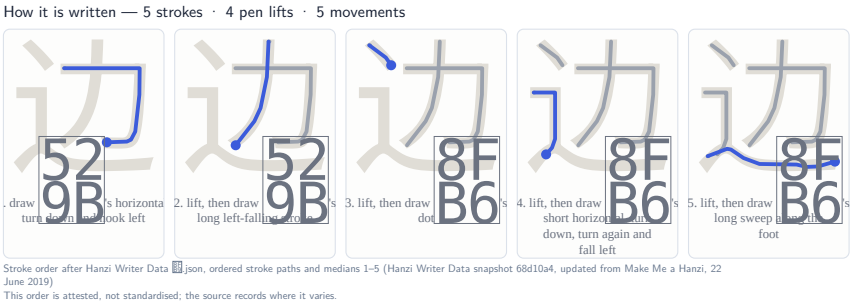
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *qiánbian* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  男 这 进

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *nán*, *zhè*, *jìn*

Script — the foot of 男, inside the walking piece



How 边 *is written, stroke by stroke*

边

The inside first, two strokes, the foot of 男: a stroke across that turns down and hooks, then a left-falling stroke through it.

The walking piece, three strokes, written last, as in 这 and 进: a dot, a small zigzag down the left, and a long flat sweep along the foot.

2 + 3 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 边, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which comes first in 边, the inside or the walking piece? (**The inside**.) Where have you written that inside piece? (**At the foot of** 男.) Which characters you know end with the walking piece? (这 and 进.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 边, pinned stroke paths and medians.

111.3 hòubian — behind; at the back

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to dance, then the Mandarin for in front.

You'll want to know: hòubian

hòubian — "behind; at the back".

> *xuéxiào hòubian yǒu yí ge gōngyuán* — There's a park behind the school.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hòubian is built from hòu 'behind' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *huwX* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: hòubian*
- *Say it: hòubian*, once more
- *Say it: xuéxiào hòubian yǒu yí ge gōngyuán* — There's a park behind the school.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to dance, then the Mandarin for in front, then say *hòubian* again

Before you move on

What does hòubian mean? ("Behind; at the back".) Say it once more.

111.4 fùjìn — nearby; in the area

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for in front, then the Mandarin for at the back.

You'll want to know: fùjìn

fùjìn — "nearby; in the area".

fùjìn yǒu yínháng ma — Is there a bank near here?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fùjìn is built from fù 'to attach' and jìn 'near', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjuH* and *gj+nX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: fùjìn*
- *Say it: fùjìn*, once more
- *Say it: fùjìn yǒu yínháng ma* — Is there a bank near here?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for in front, then the Mandarin for at the back, then say *fùjìn* again

Before you move on

What does fùjìn mean? ("Nearby; in the area".) Say it once more.

111.5 lùkǒu — crossroads; junction

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for at the back, then the Mandarin for nearby.

You'll want to know: lùkǒu

lùkǒu — "crossroads; junction".

yínháng zài lùkǒu — The bank is at the crossroads.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lùkǒu is built from lù 'road' and □ 'mouth', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *luH* and *khuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the mouth of a road.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: lùkǒu*
- *Say it: lùkǒu*, once more
- *Say it: yínháng zài lùkǒu* — The bank is at the crossroads.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for at the back, then the Mandarin for nearby, then say *lùkǒu* again

Before you move on

What does lùkǒu mean? ("Crossroads; junction".) Say it once more.

111.6 guǎi — to turn a corner

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for nearby, then the Mandarin for crossroads.

You'll want to know: guǎi

guǎi — "to turn a corner".

zhèr néng guǎi ma — Can we turn here?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guǎi is inherited from Middle Chinese *kweaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed as a stick, a thing for the hands and feet, probably a crutch; how it came to mean turning a corner is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: guǎi*
- *Say it: guǎi*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr néng guǎi ma* — Can we turn here?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for nearby, then the Mandarin for crossroads, then say *guǎi* again

Before you move on

What does guǎi mean? ("To turn a corner".) Say it once more.

Chapter 112

Way In, Way Out

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say the words on signs for the way out, the way in, push, pull and the stairs.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 112: I can say the words on signs for the way out, the way in, push, pull and the stairs.*

112.1 出口 (chūkǒu) — exit; way out

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for crossroads, then the Mandarin for to turn a corner.

You'll want to know: 出口

出口 — *chūkǒu* — "exit; way out".

> 出口在前边 *chūkǒu zài qiánbian* — The way out is up ahead.

The new character, in pieces: 出 — two halves like 山, one on top of the other, with one long vertical down through both. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

出口 (*chūkǒu*) is built from 出 'to go out' and 口 'mouth, opening', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhwit* and *khuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the opening you go out by.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: chūkǒu*
- *Say it: chūkǒu*, once more
- *Say it: chūkǒu zài qiánbian* — The way out is up ahead.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for crossroads, then the Mandarin for to turn a corner, then say *chūkǒu* again

Before you move on

What does 出口 mean? ("Exit; way out".) Say it once more.

112.2 出 — two halves like 山, one long vertical

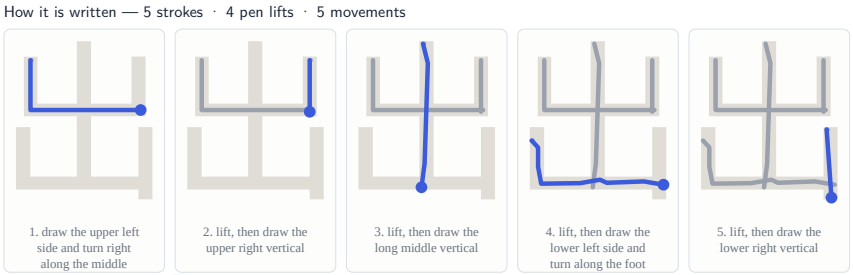
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chūkǒu* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  山 口

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shān*, *kǒu*

Script — two halves like 山, one long vertical



How 出 is written, stroke by stroke

出

The top half, two strokes: a short vertical that turns right along its foot, then the short vertical on the right.

The long vertical, down the middle, through the top half and on into the bottom one.

The bottom half, two strokes, wider: a vertical that turns right along the foot, then the vertical on the right.

2 + 1 + 2 = five. Unlike 山, the middle vertical comes third.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 出, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 出? (**Five**.) Which stroke comes third? (**The long vertical down the middle**.) Which character you know does it look like, twice? (山.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 出, pinned stroke paths and medians.

112.3 rùkǒu — entrance; way in

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to turn a corner, then the Mandarin for exit.

You'll want to know: rùkǒu

rùkǒu — "entrance; way in".

rùkǒu zài nàr — The way in is over there.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rùkǒu is built from rù 'to go in' and 口 'opening', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyip* and *khuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'inside, to take in' and 'mouth'.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: rùkǒu*
- *Say it: rùkǒu*, once more
- *Say it: rùkǒu zài nàr* — The way in is over there.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to turn a corner, then the Mandarin for exit, then say *rùkǒu* again

Before you move on

What does rùkǒu mean? ("Entrance; way in".) Say it once more.

112.4 tuī — to push

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for exit, then the Mandarin for entrance.

You'll want to know: tuī

tuī — "to push".

qǐng tuī mén — Push the door, please.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tuī is inherited from Middle Chinese *thwoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the character 'to push' under a second reading, *tsyhwij*, and lists *thwoj* beside it; tuī continues *thwoj*.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: tuī*
- *Say it: tuī*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng tuī mén* — Push the door, please.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for exit, then the Mandarin for entrance, then say *tuī* again

Before you move on

What does tuī mean? ("To push".) Say it once more.

112.5 lā — to pull

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for entrance, then the Mandarin for to push.

You'll want to know: lā

lā — "to pull".

bú yào tuī qǐng lā — Don't push, pull.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lā is inherited from Middle Chinese *lop* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to break' and 'to crush'. The regular change from *lop* would give là, not lā, and pulling is not given there; how the word came to its sound and sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: lā*
- *Say it: lā*, once more
- *Say it: bú yào tuī qǐng lā* — Don't push, pull.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for entrance, then the Mandarin for to push, then say *lā* again

Before you move on

What does lā mean? ("To pull".) Say it once more.

112.6 lóutī — stairs; staircase

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to push, then the Mandarin for to pull.

You'll want to know: lóutī

lóutī — "stairs; staircase".

lóutī zài ménkǒu pángbiān — The stairs are next to the doorway.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lóutī is built from lóu and tī, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *luw* and *thej* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a house built on a house' and 'wooden steps'.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: lóutī*
- *Say it: lóutī*, once more

- *Say it: lóutī zài ménkǒu pángbiān* — The stairs are next to the doorway.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to push, then the Mandarin for to pull, then say *lóutī* again

Before you move on

What does lóutī mean? (“Stairs; staircase”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 113

Cooking

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say cut, boil, stir-fry, roast and fry.

Complete the last lesson of chapter 113: I can say cut, boil, stir-fry, roast and fry.

113.1 qiē — to cut; to slice

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pull, then the Mandarin for stairs.

You'll want to know: qiē

qiē — "to cut; to slice".

wǒ qiē cài — I'll chop the vegetables.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qiē is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to cut' and 'to carve'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiē*
- *Say it: qiē*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qiē cài* — I'll chop the vegetables.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pull, then the Mandarin for stairs, then say *qiē* again

Before you move on

What does qiē mean? ("To cut; to slice".) Say it once more.

113.2 zhǔ — to boil; to cook in water

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for stairs, then the Mandarin for to slice.

You'll want to know: zhǔ

zhǔ — "to boil; to cook in water".

wǒmen zhǔ jiǎozi — We're boiling dumplings.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǔ is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsyoX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), listed under a variant form of the character and glossed 'to cook'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǔ*
- *Say it: zhǔ*, once more

- *Say it: wǒmen zhǔ jiǎozi* — We're boiling dumplings.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for stairs, then the Mandarin for to slice, then say *zhǔ* again

Before you move on

What does zhǔ mean? ("To boil; to cook in water".) Say it once more.

113.3 chǎo — to stir-fry

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to slice, then the Mandarin for to boil.

You'll want to know: chǎo

chǎo — "to stir-fry".

nǐ huì chǎo cài ma — Can you stir-fry vegetables?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsrhaewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to roast dry'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: chǎo*
- *Say it: chǎo*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ huì chǎo cài ma* — Can you stir-fry vegetables?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to slice, then the Mandarin for to boil, then say *chǎo* again

Before you move on

What does chǎo mean? (“To stir-fry”.) Say it once more.

113.4 kǎo — to roast; to bake

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to boil, then the Mandarin for to stir-fry.

You’ll want to know: kǎo

kǎo — “to roast; to bake”.

wǒmen kǎo miànbāo — We’re making toast.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kǎo is the everyday word for roasting and baking. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you’ve built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: kǎo*
- *Say it: kǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen kǎo miànbāo* — We’re making toast.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to boil, then the Mandarin for to stir-fry, then say *kǎo* again

Before you move on

What does kǎo mean? (“To roast; to bake”.) Say it once more.

113.5 jiān — to fry (in a little oil)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to stir-fry, then the Mandarin for to roast.

You'll want to know: jiān

jiān — "to fry (in a little oil)".

wǒ huì jiān jīdàn — I can fry an egg.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiān is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsjen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to cook until done'. Frying in a little oil is the sense today; the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiān*
- *Say it: jiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ huì jiān jīdàn* — I can fry an egg.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to stir-fry, then the Mandarin for to roast, then say *jiān* again

Before you move on

What does jiān mean? ("To fry (in a little oil)".) Say it once more.

Chapter 114

Paying

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for the bill, pay in cash or by card, and get my change.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 114: I can ask for the bill, pay in cash or by card, and get my change.*

114.1 mǎidān — to pay the bill

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to roast, then the Mandarin for to fry.

You'll want to know: mǎidān

mǎidān — "to pay the bill".

> *fúwùyuán mǎidān* — Excuse me, the bill, please!

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

mǎidān is built from 买 'to buy' and dān, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *meaX* and *tan* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'single'. Paying the bill is a modern sense, and how the pair came to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǎidān*
- *Say it: mǎidān*, once more
- *Say it: fúwùyuán mǎidān* — Excuse me, the bill, please!
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to roast, then the Mandarin for to fry, then say *mǎidān* again

Before you move on

What does mǎidān mean? ("To pay the bill".) Say it once more.

114.2 fù — to pay

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to fry, then the Mandarin for to pay the bill.

You'll want to know: fù

fù — "to pay".

wǒ fù qián — I'll pay.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fù is inherited from Middle Chinese *pjuH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to give'.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: fù*
- *Say it: fù*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ fù qián* — I'll pay.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to fry, then the Mandarin for to pay the bill, then say *fù* again

Before you move on

What does fù mean? ("To pay".) Say it once more.

114.3 xiànjīn — cash

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pay the bill, then the Mandarin for to pay.

You'll want to know: xiànjīn

xiànjīn — "cash".

nǐ yǒu xiànjīn ma — Have you got any cash?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiànjīn is built from xiàn and jīn 'gold, money', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *henH* and *kim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to show'; it is the xiàn of xiànzài 'now', and money there and then is the likely sense of the pair, though it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiànjīn*
- *Say it: xiànjīn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ yǒu xiànjīn ma* — Have you got any cash?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pay the bill, then the Mandarin for to pay, then say *xiànjīn* again

Before you move on

What does xiànjīn mean? ("Cash".) Say it once more.

114.4 shuākǎ — to pay by card

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pay, then the Mandarin for cash.

You'll want to know: shuākǎ

shuākǎ — "to pay by card".

wǒ kěyǐ shuākǎ ma — Can I pay by card?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
kěyǐ is said kéyǐ: two third tones, and the first rises.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuākǎ is built from shuā 'to brush, to swipe' and kǎ 'card'. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *srwaet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the second is borrowed, usually traced to English *card*.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuākǎ*
- *Say it: shuākǎ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ kěyǐ shuākǎ ma* — Can I pay by card?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pay, then the Mandarin for cash, then say *shuākǎ* again

Before you move on

What does shuākǎ mean? ("To pay by card".) Say it once more.

114.5 zhǎoqián — to give change

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for cash, then the Mandarin for to pay by card.

You'll want to know: zhǎoqián

zhǎoqián — "to give change".

tā méiyǒu zhǎoqián — He didn't give me my change.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǎoqián is built from zhǎo 'to look for' and qián 'money'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzjen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); no dictionary we use records an older form of the first, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǎoqián*
- *Say it: zhǎoqián*, once more
- *Say it: tā méiyǒu zhǎoqián* — He didn't give me my change.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for cash, then the Mandarin for to pay by card, then say *zhǎoqián* again

Before you move on

What does zhǎoqián mean? ("To give change".) Say it once more.

Chapter 115

Careful!

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say be careful, no smoking, pay attention and dangerous.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 115: I can say be careful, no smoking, pay attention and dangerous.*

115.1 小心 (xiǎoxīn) — to be careful; to mind (something)

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pay by card, then the Mandarin for to give change.

You'll want to know: 小心

小心 — *xiǎoxīn* — "to be careful; to mind (something)".

> 出门小心车 *chūmén xiǎoxīn chē* — Mind the traffic when you go out.

The new character, in pieces: 心 — four strokes: a dot, a long hook lying along the bottom, and two dots, the foot of 想. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

小心 (*xiǎoxīn*) is built from 小 'small' and 心 'heart', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjewX* and *sim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How a small heart came to mean care is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiǎoxīn*
- *Say it: xiǎoxīn*, once more
- *Say it: chūmén xiǎoxīn chē* — Mind the traffic when you go out.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pay by card, then the Mandarin for to give change, then say *xiǎoxīn* again

Before you move on

What does 小心 mean? ("To be careful; to mind (something)".) Say it once more.

115.2 心 — a dot, a lying hook, two dots

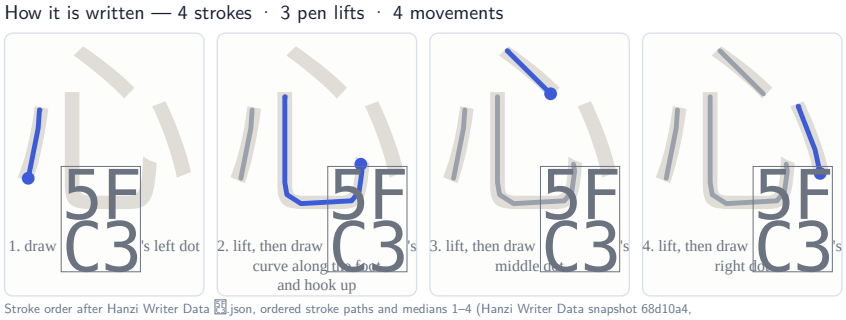
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *xiǎoxīn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  想 小

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *xiǎng*, *xiǎo*

Script — a dot, a lying hook, two dots



How 忄 is written, stroke by stroke

忄

A dot on the left, slanting down.

A long hook lying along the bottom, curving up at the right and hooking in.

Two dots above it, the middle one, then the right one.

1 + 1 + 2 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 忄, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 忄? (**Four**.) Which stroke is the long one? (**The hook lying along the bottom, second**.) Where have you written it before? (**At the foot of 想**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 忄, pinned stroke paths and medians.

115.3 xīyān — to smoke

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to give change, then the Mandarin for to be careful.

You'll want to know: xīyān

xīyān — "to smoke".

nǐ xīyān ma — Do you smoke?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xīyān is built from xī 'to breathe in' and yān 'smoke', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xip* and *'en* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: xīyān*
- *Say it: xīyān*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xīyān ma* — Do you smoke?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to give change, then the Mandarin for to be careful, then say *xīyān* again

Before you move on

What does xīyān mean? ("To smoke".) Say it once more.

115.4 jìnzhǐ — to forbid; no (on signs)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be careful, then the Mandarin for to smoke.

You'll want to know: jìnzhǐ

jìnzhǐ — "to forbid; no (on signs)".

zhèr jìnzhǐ xīyān — No smoking here.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jìnzhǐ is built from jìn and zhǐ, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kimH* and *tsyiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), and the dictionary glosses both 'to stop'.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: jìnzhǐ*
- *Say it: jìnzhǐ*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr jìnzhǐ xīyān* — No smoking here.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be careful, then the Mandarin for to smoke, then say *jìnzhǐ* again

Before you move on

What does jìnzhǐ mean? ("To forbid; no (on signs)".) Say it once more.

115.5 zhùyì — to pay attention; to take care

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to smoke, then the Mandarin for to forbid.

You'll want to know: zhùyì

zhùyì — "to pay attention; to take care".

qǐng zhùyì nǐ de bāo — Please keep an eye on your bag.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhùyì is built from zhù 'to pour into' and yì 'mind', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyuH* and *'iH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription): to pour the mind into something.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhùyì*
- *Say it: zhùyì*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng zhùyì nǐ de bāo* — Please keep an eye on your bag.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to smoke, then the Mandarin for to forbid, then say *zhùyì* again

Before you move on

What does zhùyì mean? ("To pay attention; to take care".) Say it once more.

115.6 wēixiǎn — dangerous

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to forbid, then the Mandarin for to pay attention.

You'll want to know: wēixiǎn

wēixiǎn — "dangerous".

zhèr hěn wēixiǎn — It's dangerous here.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wēixiǎn is built from wēi and xiǎn, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngjwe* and *xjemX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'unsafe' and 'perilous, hard to pass'. The regular change from *ngjwe* gives wéi, with a rising tone; the level wēi of today is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: wēixiǎn*
- *Say it: wēixiǎn*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr hěn wēixiǎn* — It's dangerous here.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to forbid, then the Mandarin for to pay attention, then say *wēixiǎn* again

Before you move on

What does wēixiǎn mean? ("Dangerous".) Say it once more.

Chapter 116

Things I Carry

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I have my wallet, passport, watch and umbrella, and say I have lost something.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 116: I can say I have my wallet, passport, watch and umbrella, and say I have lost something.*

116.1 qiánbāo — wallet; purse

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pay attention, then the Mandarin for dangerous.

You'll want to know: qiánbāo

qiánbāo — "wallet; purse".

> *wǒ de qiánbāo zài bāo lǐ* — My wallet's in my bag.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qiánbāo is built from qián 'money' and bāo 'to wrap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzjen* and *paew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiánbāo*
- *Say it: qiánbāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de qiánbāo zài bāo lǐ* — My wallet's in my bag.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pay attention, then the Mandarin for dangerous, then say *qiánbāo* again

Before you move on

What does qiánbāo mean? ("Wallet; purse".) Say it once more.

116.2 hùzhào — passport

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dangerous, then the Mandarin for wallet.

You'll want to know: hùzhào

hùzhào — "passport".

nǐ dài hùzhào le ma — Have you brought your passport?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hùzhào is built from hù 'to protect' and zhào 'bright', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *huH* and *tsyewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The passport is a modern sense of the pair, and how it came to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: hùzhào*
- *Say it: hùzhào*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ dài hùzhào le ma* — Have you brought your passport?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dangerous, then the Mandarin for wallet, then say *hùzhào* again

Before you move on

What does hùzhào mean? ("Passport".) Say it once more.

116.3 shǒubiǎo — wristwatch

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for wallet, then the Mandarin for passport.

You'll want to know: shǒubiǎo

shǒubiǎo — "wristwatch".

nǐ de shǒubiǎo hěn hǎokàn — Your watch is lovely.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
Two third tones: shǒu rises before biǎo, and is still written shǒu.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shǒubiǎo is built from 手 'hand' and biǎo, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *syuwX* and *pjewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'to make clear' and 'an outer garment'. The watch is a modern sense, and how biǎo came to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: shǒubiǎo*
- *Say it: shǒubiǎo*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ de shǒubiǎo hěn hǎokàn* — Your watch is lovely.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for wallet, then the Mandarin for passport, then say *shǒubiǎo* again

Before you move on

What does shǒubiǎo mean? ("Wristwatch".) Say it once more.

116.4 yǔsǎn — umbrella

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for passport, then the Mandarin for wristwatch.

You'll want to know: yǔsǎn

yǔsǎn — "umbrella".

xiàyǔ le nǐ dài yǔsǎn le ma — It's raining; have you got an umbrella?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
Two third tones: yǔ rises before sǎn, and is still written yǔ.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǔsǎn is built from 雨 'rain' and sǎn, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuX* and *sanX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as a canopy.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǔsǎn*
- *Say it: yǔsǎn*, once more
- *Say it: xiàyǔ le nǐ dài yǔsǎn le ma* — It's raining; have you got an umbrella?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for passport, then the Mandarin for wristwatch, then say *yǔsǎn* again

Before you move on

What does yǔsǎn mean? ("Umbrella".) Say it once more.

116.5 diū — to lose (a thing)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for wristwatch, then the Mandarin for umbrella.

You'll want to know: diū

diū — "to lose (a thing)".

wǒ de yàoshi diū le — I've lost my keys.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diū is the everyday verb for losing a thing. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I have and can do.

Your turn

- *Say it: diū*
- *Say it: diū*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ de yàoshi diū le* — I've lost my keys.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for wristwatch, then the Mandarin for umbrella, then say *diū* again

Before you move on

What does diū mean? ("To lose (a thing)".) Say it once more.

116.6 Looking back: from In Front and Behind to Things I Carry

Say the Mandarin for in front and at the back.

Your turn

- *Say it:* in front, at the back, nearby, crossroads, to turn a corner
- *Say it:* exit, entrance, to push, to pull, stairs
- *Say it:* to slice, to boil, to stir-fry, to roast, to fry
- *Say it:* to pay the bill, to pay, cash, to pay by card, to give change
- *Say it:* to be careful, to smoke, to forbid, to pay attention, dangerous
- *Say it:* wallet, passport, wristwatch, umbrella, to lose
- *Read it:* 边 出 心 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

In front? (前边, *qiánbian.*) At the back? (*hòubian.*) Nearby? (*fùjìn.*) Crossroads? (*lùkǒu.*) To turn a corner? (*guǎi.*) Exit? (出口, *chūkǒu.*) Entrance? (*rùkǒu.*) To push? (*tuī.*) To pull? (*lā.*) Stairs? (*lóutī.*) To slice? (*qiē.*) To boil? (*zhǔ.*) To stir-fry? (*chǎo.*) To roast? (*kǎo.*) To fry? (*jiān.*) To pay the bill? (*mǎidān.*) To pay? (*fù.*) Cash? (*xiànjīn.*) To pay by card? (*shuākǎ.*) To give change? (*zhǎoqián.*) To be careful? (小心, *xiǎoxīn.*) To smoke? (*xīyān.*) To forbid? (*jìnzhǐ.*) To pay attention? (*zhùyì.*) Dangerous? (*wēixiǎn.*) Wallet? (*qiánbāo.*) Passport? (*hùzhào.*) Wristwatch? (*shǒubiǎo.*) Umbrella? (*yǔsǎn.*) To lose? (*diū.*)

Chapter 117

Which Way?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say east, south, west and north, and ask which way to go.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 117: I can say east, south, west and north, and ask which way to go.*

117.1 dōngbian — the east; on the east side

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for umbrella, then the Mandarin for to lose.

You'll want to know: dōngbian

dōngbian — "the east; on the east side".

> *chēzhàn zài dōngbian* — The station is on the east side.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dōngbian is built from dōng 'east' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tuwng* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary calls the east the direction of spring, and repeats an old reading of the character as the sun inside a tree.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: dōngbian*
- *Say it: dōngbian*, once more
- *Say it: chēzhàn zài dōngbian* — The station is on the east side.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for umbrella, then the Mandarin for to lose, then say *dōngbian* again

Before you move on

What does dōngbian mean? ("The east; on the east side".) Say it once more.

117.2 nánbian — the south; on the south side

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to lose, then the Mandarin for the east.

You'll want to know: nánbian

nánbian — "the south; on the south side".

gōngyuán zài nánbian — The park is to the south.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nánbian is built from nán 'south' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nom* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary calls the south the direction of fire.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: nánbian*
- *Say it: nánbian*, once more
- *Say it: gōngyuán zài nánbian* — The park is to the south.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to lose, then the Mandarin for the east, then say *nánbian* again

Before you move on

What does nánbian mean? ("The south; on the south side".) Say it once more.

117.3 xībian — the west; on the west side

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the east, then the Mandarin for the south.

You'll want to know: xībian

xībian — "the west; on the west side".

xībian yǒu shān — There are hills to the west.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xībian is built from xī 'west' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sej* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary calls the west the direction of autumn, and explains the character as a bird settling on its nest when the sun is in the west.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: xībian*
- *Say it: xībian*, once more
- *Say it: xībian yǒu shān* — There are hills to the west.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the east, then the Mandarin for the south, then say *xībian* again

Before you move on

What does xībian mean? ("The west; on the west side".) Say it once more.

117.4 běibian — the north; on the north side

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the south, then the Mandarin for the west.

You'll want to know: běibian

běibian — "the north; on the north side".

Běijīng zài Zhōngguó de běibian — Beijing is in the north of China.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

běibian is built from běi 'north' and 边 'side', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pok* and *pen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: běibian*
- *Say it: běibian*, once more
- *Say it: Běijīng zài Zhōngguó de běibian* — Beijing is in the north of China.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the south, then the Mandarin for the west, then say *běibian* again

Before you move on

What does běibian mean? ("The north; on the north side".) Say it once more.

117.5 fāngxiàng — direction; way

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the west, then the Mandarin for the north.

You'll want to know: fāngxiàng

fāngxiàng — "direction; way".

chēzhàn zài nǎge fāngxiàng — Which way is the station?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fāngxiàng is built from fāng 'side, region' and xiàng 'to face', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjang* and *xjangH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the side you face.

What you've built

One more word for asking where things are.

Your turn

- *Say it: fāngxiàng*
- *Say it: fāngxiàng*, once more
- *Say it: chēzhàn zài nǎge fāngxiàng* — Which way is the station?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the west, then the Mandarin for the north, then say *fāngxiàng* again

Before you move on

What does fāngxiàng mean? ("Direction; way".) Say it once more.

Chapter 118

Sending Things

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can post a parcel, talk about letters and text messages, and say receive.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 118: I can post a parcel, talk about letters and text messages, and say receive.*

118.1 bāoguǒ — parcel; package

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the north, then the Mandarin for direction.

You'll want to know: bāoguǒ

bāoguǒ — "parcel; package".

> *zhège bāoguǒ shì nǐ de ma* — Is this parcel yours?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bāoguǒ is built from bāo and guǒ, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *paew* and *kwaX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'to wrap, to bind', and gives the pair itself as the gloss of the first.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: bāoguǒ*
- *Say it: bāoguǒ*, once more
- *Say it: zhège bāoguǒ shì nǐ de ma* — Is this parcel yours?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the north, then the Mandarin for direction, then say *bāoguǒ* again

Before you move on

What does bāoguǒ mean? ("Parcel; package".) Say it once more.

118.2 jì — to post; to send by post

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for direction, then the Mandarin for parcel.

You'll want to know: jì

jì — "to post; to send by post".

wǒ qù yóujú jì bāoguǒ — I'm going to the post office to send a parcel.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jì is inherited from Middle Chinese *kjeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to entrust to someone'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: jì*
- *Say it: jì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ qù yóujú jì bāoguǒ* — I'm going to the post office to send a parcel.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for direction, then the Mandarin for parcel, then say *jì* again

Before you move on

What does jì mean? ("To post; to send by post".) Say it once more.

118.3 xìn — letter (in the post)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for parcel, then the Mandarin for to post.

You'll want to know: xìn

xìn — "letter (in the post)".

wǒ xiǎng gěi péngyou xiě xìn — I'd like to write to a friend.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xìn is inherited from Middle Chinese *sinH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'trust' and 'proof'; how it came to mean a letter is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: xìn*
- *Say it: xìn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng gěi péngyou xiě xìn* — I'd like to write to a friend.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for parcel, then the Mandarin for to post, then say *xìn* again

Before you move on

What does xìn mean? ("Letter (in the post)".) Say it once more.

118.4 duǎnxìn — text message

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to post, then the Mandarin for letter.

You'll want to know: duǎnxìn

duǎnxìn — "text message".

wǒ gěi māma xiě duǎnxìn — I'm writing a text to my mum.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

duǎnxìn is built from duǎn 'short' and xìn 'letter', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *twanX* and *sinH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a short letter.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: duǎnxìn*
- *Say it: duǎnxìn*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ gěi māma xiě duǎnxìn* — I'm writing a text to my mum.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to post, then the Mandarin for letter, then say *duǎnxìn* again

Before you move on

What does duǎnxìn mean? ("Text message".) Say it once more.

118.5 shōu — to receive; to accept

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for letter, then the Mandarin for text message.

You'll want to know: shōu

shōu — "to receive; to accept".

tā bù shōu qián — He won't take any money.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shōu is inherited from Middle Chinese *syuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to gather in' and 'to seize'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: shōu*
- *Say it: shōu*, once more
- *Say it: tā bù shōu qián* — He won't take any money.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for letter, then the Mandarin for text message, then say *shōu* again

Before you move on

What does shōu mean? (“To receive; to accept”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 119

Bags and Boxes

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a schoolbag, a suitcase, a box, a carrier bag and luggage.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 119: I can name a schoolbag, a suitcase, a box, a carrier bag and luggage.*

119.1 书包 (shūbāo) — schoolbag

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for text message, then the Mandarin for to receive.

You'll want to know: 书包

书包 — *shūbāo* — "schoolbag".

> 我的书包里有两本书 *wǒ de shūbāo lǐ yǒu liǎng běn shū* — There are two books in my schoolbag.

The new character, in pieces: 包 — a wrapping stroke that bends round from the top, and inside it three strokes: a turn, a short bar, and a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

书包 (*shūbāo*) is built from 书 'book' and 包 'to wrap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *syo* and *paew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a wrapper for books.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: shūbāo*
- *Say it: shūbāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de shūbāo lǐ yǒu liǎng běn shū* — There are two books in my schoolbag.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for text message, then the Mandarin for to receive, then say *shūbāo* again

Before you move on

What does 书包 mean? ("Schoolbag".) Say it once more.

119.2 包 — a wrapping stroke, and three strokes inside

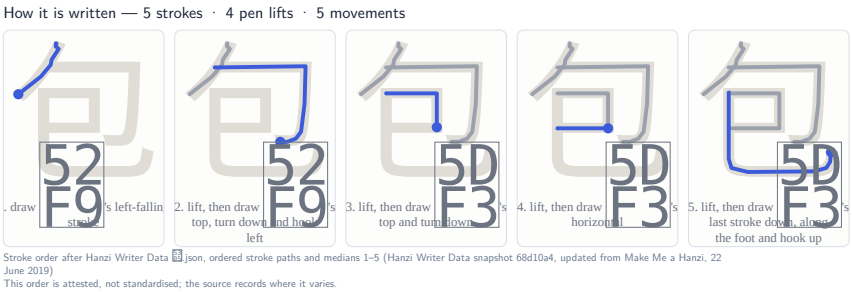
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *shūbāo* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  书 也

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shū*, *yě*

Script — a wrapping stroke, and three strokes inside



How 包 *is written, stroke by stroke*

包

The wrapping piece, two strokes: a short left-falling stroke, then a stroke across that turns down the right side and hooks.

The inside, three strokes: a stroke across that turns down, a short horizontal under it, and a vertical that bends right along the bottom and hooks up, out past the wrapping, as the last stroke of 也 does.

2 + 3 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 包, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 包? (**Five**.) Which piece comes first, the wrapping or the inside? (**The wrapping**.) Which character you know ends with the same stroke? (也.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 包, pinned stroke paths and medians.

119.3 xiāngzi — box; suitcase; trunk

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to receive, then the Mandarin for schoolbag.

You'll want to know: xiāngzi

xiāngzi — "box; suitcase; trunk".

> *zhège xiāngzi tài dà le* — This suitcase is too big.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiāngzi is built from xiāng and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sjang* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a box or a hamper.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiāngzi*
- *Say it: xiāngzi*, once more
- *Say it: zhège xiāngzi tài dà le* — This suitcase is too big.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to receive, then the Mandarin for schoolbag, then say *xiāngzi* again

Before you move on

What does xiāngzi mean? ("Box; suitcase; trunk".) Say it once more.

119.4 hézi — box; small case

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for schoolbag, then the Mandarin for suitcase.

You'll want to know: hézi

hézi — "box; small case".

hézi lǐ yǒu shénme — What's in the box?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hézi is built from hé and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hop* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a dish with a lid.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: hézi*
- *Say it: hézi*, once more
- *Say it: hézi lǐ yǒu shénme* — What's in the box?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for schoolbag, then the Mandarin for suitcase, then say *hézi* again

Before you move on

What does hézi mean? ("Box; small case".) Say it once more.

119.5 dàizi — bag; sack

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for suitcase, then the Mandarin for small box.

You'll want to know: dàizi

dàizi — "bag; sack".

nǐ xūyào dàizi ma — Do you need a bag?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dàizi is built from dài and the noun ending zi, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dojH* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a kind of sack.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: dàizi*
- *Say it: dàizi*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xūyào dàizi ma* — Do you need a bag?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for suitcase, then the Mandarin for small box, then say *dàizi* again

Before you move on

What does dàizi mean? ("Bag; sack".) Say it once more.

119.6 xíngli — luggage

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for small box, then the Mandarin for carrier bag.

You'll want to know: xíngli

xíngli — "luggage".

nǐ de xíngli zài nǎr — Where's your luggage?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xíngli is built from xíng 'to go' and lǐ 'plum', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeng* and *liX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary lists the pair itself under the second, but how 'plum'

came into a word for luggage is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday things.

Your turn

- *Say it: xíngli*
- *Say it: xíngli*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ de xíngli zài nǎr* — Where's your luggage?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for small box, then the Mandarin for carrier bag, then say *xíngli* again

Before you move on

What does xíngli mean? ("Luggage".) Say it once more.

Chapter 120

Takeaway

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can order a takeaway, give my address, ask to take food home, and ask for dim sum.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 120: I can order a takeaway, give my address, ask to take food home, and ask for dim sum.*

120.1 wàimài — takeaway; food delivered

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for carrier bag, then the Mandarin for luggage.

You'll want to know: wàimài

wàimài — "takeaway; food delivered".

> *wǒmen jīntiān wǎnshang chī wàimài* — We're having a takeaway tonight.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wàimài is built from 外 'outside' and mài 'to sell', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngwajH* and *meaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): food sold to be eaten somewhere else.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàimài*
- *Say it: wàimài*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen jīntiān wǎnshang chī wàimài* — We're having a takeaway tonight.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for carrier bag, then the Mandarin for luggage, then say *wàimài* again

Before you move on

What does wàimài mean? ("Takeaway; food delivered".) Say it once more.

120.2 dìng — to make a booking; to order

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for luggage, then the Mandarin for takeaway.

You'll want to know: dìng

dìng — "to make a booking; to order".

wǒ xiǎng dìng yí ge fángjiān — I'd like to book a room.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìng is inherited from Middle Chinese *dengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to discuss and settle', which regularly gives dìng. Booking is the sense today, probably by way of settling an arrangement, but the step is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìng*
- *Say it: dìng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng dìng yí ge fángjiān* — I'd like to book a room.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for luggage, then the Mandarin for takeaway, then say *dìng* again

Before you move on

What does dìng mean? ("To make a booking; to order".) Say it once more.

120.3 dìzhǐ — address

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for takeaway, then the Mandarin for to make a booking.

You'll want to know: dìzhǐ

dìzhǐ — "address".

nǐ jiā de dìzhǐ shì shénme — What's your home address?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìzhǐ is built from dì 'ground' and zhǐ 'site', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dijH* and *tsyiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as the foundation of a building.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìzhǐ*
- *Say it: dìzhǐ*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ jiā de dìzhǐ shì shénme* — What's your home address?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for takeaway, then the Mandarin for to make a booking, then say *dìzhǐ* again

Before you move on

What does dìzhǐ mean? ("Address".) Say it once more.

120.4 打包 (dǎbāo) — to pack food to take away

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to make a booking, then the Mandarin for address.

You'll want to know: 打包

打包 — *dǎbāo* — "to pack food to take away".

我想打包 *wǒ xiǎng dǎbāo* — Could I take this away?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

打包 (*dǎbāo*) is built from 打 'to strike, to do' and 包 'to wrap', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *taengX* and *paew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to strike'; dǎ is not the sound *taengX* would regularly give, and its everyday sense of doing is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎbāo*
- *Say it: dǎbāo*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng dǎbāo* — Could I take this away?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to make a booking, then the Mandarin for address, then say *dǎbāo* again

Before you move on

What does 打包 mean? ("To pack food to take away".) Say it once more.

120.5 点心 (diǎnxin) — dim sum; light snacks and pastries

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for address, then the Mandarin for to pack food to take away.

You'll want to know: 点心

点心 — *diǎnxin* — "dim sum; light snacks and pastries".

我们去外边吃点心 *wǒmen qù wàibian chī diǎnxin* — We're going out for dim sum.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

点心 (*diǎnxin*) is built from 点 'a dot, a little' and 心 'heart', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *temX* and *sim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a dot made with the brush. How the pair came to mean a light snack is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for asking for what I want.

Your turn

- *Say it: diǎnxin*
- *Say it: diǎnxin*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen qù wàibian chī diǎnxin* — We're going out for dim sum.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for address, then the Mandarin for to pack food to take away, then say *diǎnxin* again

Before you move on

What does 点心 mean? ("Dim sum; light snacks and pastries".) Say it once more.

Chapter 121

Teaching and Practising

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say teach, practise, answer and revise, and say something is wrong.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 121: I can say teach, practise, answer and revise, and say something is wrong.*

121.1 jiāo — to teach

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to pack food to take away, then the Mandarin for dim sum.

You'll want to know: jiāo

jiāo — "to teach".

> *tā jiāo wǒ hànyǔ* — She teaches me Chinese.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiāo is inherited from Middle Chinese *kaewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to teach'; the dictionary also lists the character with a level tone, *kaew*, glossed 'to imitate', and the level jiāo of the verb matches that one.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiāo*
- *Say it: jiāo*, once more
- *Say it: tā jiāo wǒ hànyǔ* — She teaches me Chinese.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to pack food to take away, then the Mandarin for dim sum, then say *jiāo* again

Before you move on

What does jiāo mean? ("To teach".) Say it once more.

121.2 liànxí — to practise

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for dim sum, then the Mandarin for to teach.

You'll want to know: liànxí

liànxí — "to practise".

wǒ měitiān liànxí shuō hànyǔ — I practise speaking Chinese every day.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

liànxí is built from liàn and xí, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *lenH* and *zip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as white boiled silk and the second 'to learn', explaining it as flying again and again.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: liànxí*
- *Say it: liànxí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ měitiān liànxí shuō hànyǔ* — I practise speaking Chinese every day.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for dim sum, then the Mandarin for to teach, then say *liànxí* again

Before you move on

What does liànxí mean? ("To practise".) Say it once more.

121.3 huídá — to answer

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to teach, then the Mandarin for to practise.

You'll want to know: huídá

huídá — "to answer".

qǐng nǐ huídá — Please answer.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huídá is built from huí 'to turn back' and dá 'to respond', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *hwoj* and *top* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'to match'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: huídá*
- *Say it: huídá*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng nǐ huídá* — Please answer.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to teach, then the Mandarin for to practise, then say *huídá* again

Before you move on

What does huídá mean? ("To answer".) Say it once more.

121.4 fùxí — to revise; to go over again

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to practise, then the Mandarin for to answer.

You'll want to know: fùxí

fùxí — "to revise; to go over again".

wǒ wǎnshang fùxí hànyǔ — I go over my Chinese in the evening.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fùxí is built from fù 'again' and xí 'to learn', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjuwk* and *zip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): to learn again. The dictionary glosses the first 'to return, to repeat' and lists it with a departing tone too, *bjuwH*, glossed 'again': fù continues that one, since the regular change from *bjuwk* gives fú.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: fùxí*
- *Say it: fùxí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ wǎnshang fùxí hànyǔ* — I go over my Chinese in the evening.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to practise, then the Mandarin for to answer, then say *fùxí* again

Before you move on

What does fùxí mean? ("To revise; to go over again".) Say it once more.

121.5 cuò — wrong; mistaken

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to answer, then the Mandarin for to revise.

You'll want to know: cuò

cuò — "wrong; mistaken".

zhège hànzì cuò le — This character is wrong.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cuò is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshak* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'mixed' and 'crossing slantwise'; how it came to mean wrong is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: cuò*
- *Say it: cuò*, once more
- *Say it: zhège hànzì cuò le* — This character is wrong.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to answer, then the Mandarin for to revise, then say *cuò* again

Before you move on

What does cuò mean? ("Wrong; mistaken".) Say it once more.

Chapter 122

Opening Hours

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say open for business, start, finish, discount and timetable.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 122: I can say open for business, start, finish, discount and timetable.*

122.1 yíngyè — to be open for business

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to revise, then the Mandarin for wrong.

You'll want to know: yíngyè

yíngyè — "to be open for business".

> *shāngdiàn jǐ diǎn yíngyè* — What time does the shop open?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yíngyè is built from yíng and yè, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yweng* and *ngjaep* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to build, to plan' and 'affairs'.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: yíngyè*
- *Say it: yíngyè*, once more
- *Say it: shāngdiàn jǐ diǎn yíngyè* — What time does the shop open?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to revise, then the Mandarin for wrong, then say *yíngyè* again

Before you move on

What does yíngyè mean? ("To be open for business".) Say it once more.

122.2 kāishǐ — to begin; to start

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for wrong, then the Mandarin for to be open for business.

You'll want to know: kāishǐ

kāishǐ — "to begin; to start".

wǒmen jǐ diǎn kāishǐ — What time do we start?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kāishǐ is built from 开 'to open' and shǐ 'beginning', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khoj* and *syiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: kāishǐ*
- *Say it: kāishǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen jǐ diǎn kāishǐ* — What time do we start?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for wrong, then the Mandarin for to be open for business, then say *kāishǐ* again

Before you move on

What does kāishǐ mean? ("To begin; to start".) Say it once more.

122.3 jiéshù — to come to an end; to finish

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be open for business, then the Mandarin for to begin.

You'll want to know: jiéshù

jiéshù — "to come to an end; to finish".

kè jǐ diǎn jiéshù — What time does the lesson finish?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiéshù is built from jié 'to tie' and shù 'to bind', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ket* and *syowk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiéshù*
- *Say it: jiéshù*, once more

- *Say it: kè jǐ diǎn jiéshù* — What time does the lesson finish?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be open for business, then the Mandarin for to begin, then say *jiéshù* again

Before you move on

What does jiéshù mean? ("To come to an end; to finish".) Say it once more.

122.4 shíkèbiǎo — timetable

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to begin, then the Mandarin for to come to an end.

You'll want to know: shíkèbiǎo

shíkèbiǎo — "timetable".

wǒ yǒu yì zhāng huǒchē shíkèbiǎo — I've got a train timetable.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shíkèbiǎo is built from 时 'time', kè 'a notch, a quarter of an hour' and biǎo 'table', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyi*, *khok* and *pjewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'to carve' and the third 'to make clear'.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: shíkèbiǎo*
- *Say it: shíkèbiǎo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǒu yì zhāng huǒchē shíkèbiǎo* — I've got a train timetable.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to begin, then the Mandarin for to come to an end, then say *shíkèbiǎo* again

Before you move on

What does shíkèbiǎo mean? ("Timetable".) Say it once more.

122.5 dǎzhé — to give a discount; to be on sale

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to come to an end, then the Mandarin for timetable.

You'll want to know: dǎzhé

dǎzhé — "to give a discount; to be on sale".

zhège xīngqī dǎzhé — Things are on sale this week.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dǎzhé is built from 打 'to strike, to do' and zhé, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *taengX* and *tsyet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'to bend and break'. How the pair came to mean a discount is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for signs and notices.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎzhé*
- *Say it: dǎzhé*, once more
- *Say it: zhège xīngqī dǎzhé* — Things are on sale this week.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to come to an end, then the Mandarin for timetable, then say *dǎzhé* again

Before you move on

What does dǎzhé mean? ("To give a discount; to be on sale".) Say it once more.

122.6 Looking back: from Which Way? to Opening Hours

Say the Mandarin for the east and the south.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the east, the south, the west, the north, direction
- *Say it:* parcel, to post, letter, text message, to receive
- *Say it:* schoolbag, suitcase, small box, carrier bag, luggage
- *Say it:* takeaway, to make a booking, address, to pack food to take away, dim sum
- *Say it:* to teach, to practise, to answer, to revise, wrong
- *Say it:* to be open for business, to begin, to come to an end, timetable, to give a discount
- *Read it:* 包 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

The east? (*dōngbian.*) The south? (*nánbian.*) The west? (*xībian.*) The north? (*běibian.*) Direction? (*fāngxiàng.*) Parcel? (*bāoguǒ.*) To post? (*jì.*) Letter? (*xìn.*) Text message? (*duǎnxìn.*) To receive? (*shōu.*) Schoolbag? (书包, *shūbāo.*) Suitcase? (*xiāngzi.*) Small box? (*hézi.*) Carrier bag? (*dàizi.*) Luggage? (*xíngli.*) Takeaway? (*wàimài.*) To make a booking? (*dìng.*) Address? (*dìzhǐ.*) To pack food to take away? (打包, *dǎbāo.*) Dim sum? (点心, *diǎnxin.*) To teach? (*jiāo.*) To practise? (*liànxí.*) To answer? (*huídá.*) To revise? (*fùxí.*) Wrong? (*cuò.*) To be open for business? (*yíngyè.*) To begin? (*kāishǐ.*) To come to an end? (*jiéshù.*) Timetable? (*shíkèbiǎo.*) To give a discount? (*dǎzhé.*)

122.7 Opening Hours — once more

Say the Mandarin for to be open for business and to begin.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to be open for business, to begin, to come to an end, timetable, to give a discount

Before you move on

To be open for business? (*yíngyè.*) To begin? (*kāishǐ.*) To come to an end? (*jiéshù.*) Timetable? (*shíkèbiǎo.*) To give a discount? (*dǎzhé.*)

Chapter 123

What People Are Like

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that someone is clever, serious, lovable, warm or caring.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 123: I can say that someone is clever, serious, lovable, warm or caring.*

123.1 cōngming — clever; bright

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for timetable, then the Mandarin for to give a discount.

You'll want to know: cōngming

cōngming — "clever; bright".

> *wǒ mèimei hěn cōngming* — My little sister is very bright.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cōngming is built from *cōng* and *míng*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tshuwng* and *mjaeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to hear' and 'to discern', and the second 'bright'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: cōngming*
- *Say it: cōngming*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ mèimei hěn cōngming* — My little sister is very bright.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for timetable, then the Mandarin for to give a discount, then say *cōngming* again

Before you move on

What does cōngming mean? ("Clever; bright".) Say it once more.

123.2 rènzhēn — conscientious; serious

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to give a discount, then the Mandarin for clever.

You'll want to know: rènzhēn

rènzhēn — "conscientious; serious".

tā gōngzuò hěn rènzhēn — He takes his work seriously.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rènzhēn is built from *rèn* 'to recognise' and *zhēn* 'true', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyinH* and *tsyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How the pair came to mean conscientious is not given there, so it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: rènzhēn*
- *Say it: rènzhēn*, once more
- *Say it: tā gōngzuò hěn rènzhēn* — He takes his work seriously.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to give a discount, then the Mandarin for clever, then say *rènzhēn* again

Before you move on

What does rènzhēn mean? ("Conscientious; serious".) Say it once more.

123.3 kě'ài — cute; lovable

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for clever, then the Mandarin for conscientious.

You'll want to know: kě'ài

kě'ài — "cute; lovable".

zhè zhī māo hěn kě'ài — This cat is so cute.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kě'ài is built from *kě*, glossed 'to permit', and *ài* 'to love', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khaX* and *'ojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): worth loving.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: kě'ài*
- *Say it: kě'ài*, once more
- *Say it: zhè zhī māo hěn kě'ài* — This cat is so cute.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for clever, then the Mandarin for conscientious, then say *kě'ài* again

Before you move on

What does kě'ài mean? ("Cute; lovable".) Say it once more.

123.4 rèqíng — warm; welcoming

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for conscientious, then the Mandarin for lovable.

You'll want to know: rèqíng

rèqíng — "warm; welcoming".

wǒ de lǎoshī hěn rèqíng — My teacher is very warm.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rèqíng is built from *rè* 'hot' and *qíng* 'feeling', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyet* and *dzjeng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary explains the second, after an older book, as the breath in a person that has desires.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: rèqíng*
- *Say it: rèqíng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de lǎoshī hěn rèqíng* — My teacher is very warm.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for conscientious, then the Mandarin for lovable, then say *rèqíng* again

Before you move on

What does rèqíng mean? ("Warm; welcoming".) Say it once more.

123.5 guānxīn — to care about

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for lovable, then the Mandarin for warm-hearted.

You'll want to know: guānxīn

guānxīn — "to care about".

māma hěn guānxīn wǒ — Mum really cares about me.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guānxīn is built from *guān*, the word for shutting, and *xīn* 'heart', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kwaen* and *sim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first as the bar that shuts a door; how the pair came to mean caring is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: guānxīn*
- *Say it: guānxīn*, once more
- *Say it: māma hěn guānxīn wǒ* — Mum really cares about me.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for lovable, then the Mandarin for warm-hearted, then say *guānxīn* again

Before you move on

What does guānxīn mean? ("To care about".) Say it once more.

Chapter 124

Tall and Handsome

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can talk about height, hair, good and bad looks, and family likeness.

Complete the last lesson of chapter 124: I can talk about height, hair, good and bad looks, and family likeness.

124.1 个子 (gèzi) — height; build (of a person)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for warm-hearted, then the Mandarin for to care about.

You'll want to know: 个子

个子 — *gèzi* — "height; build (of a person)".

wǒ gēge gèzi hěn gāo — My brother is tall.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

个子 (*gèzi*) is built from 个, the measure word, and the noun ending 子, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kaH* and *tsiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How the pair came to mean a person's height is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: gèzi*
- *Say it: gèzi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ gēge gèzi hěn gāo* — My brother is tall.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for warm-hearted, then the Mandarin for to care about, then say *gèzi* again

Before you move on

What does 个子 mean? ("Height; build (of a person)".) Say it once more.

124.2 tóufa — hair (on the head)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to care about, then the Mandarin for a person's height.

You'll want to know: tóufa

tóufa — "hair (on the head)".

tā de tóufa hěn cháng — Her hair is long.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tóufa is built from *tóu* 'head' and *fa*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *duw* and *pjot* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which glosses the second 'the hair of the head'. In the word it loses its tone.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: tóufa*
- *Say it: tóufa*, once more
- *Say it: tā de tóufa hěn cháng* — Her hair is long.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to care about, then the Mandarin for a person's height, then say *tóufa* again

Before you move on

What does tóufa mean? ("Hair (on the head)".) Say it once more.

124.3 shuài — handsome

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a person's height, then the Mandarin for hair.

You'll want to know: shuài

shuài — "handsome".

nǐ gēge hěn shuài — Your brother is handsome.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuài is inherited from Middle Chinese *srwijH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a commander of troops'. The sense handsome is not given there, and how it came is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuài*
- *Say it: shuài*, once more

- *Say it: nǐ gēge hěn shuài* — Your brother is handsome.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a person's height, then the Mandarin for hair, then say *shuài* again

Before you move on

What does shuài mean? ("Handsome".) Say it once more.

124.4 nánkàn — ugly

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hair, then the Mandarin for handsome.

You'll want to know: nánkàn

nánkàn — "ugly".

wǒ de xié hěn nánkàn — My shoes are ugly.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nánkàn is built from *nán* 'hard' and 看 'to look at', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nan* and *khanH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): hard to look at.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: nánkàn*
- *Say it: nánkàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de xié hěn nánkàn* — My shoes are ugly.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hair, then the Mandarin for handsome, then say *nánkàn* again

Before you move on

What does nánkàn mean? (“Ugly”.) Say it once more.

124.5 xiàng — to resemble; to take after

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for handsome, then the Mandarin for ugly.

You’ll want to know: xiàng

xiàng — “to resemble; to take after”.

wǒ xiàng wǒ bàba — I take after my dad.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàng is inherited from Middle Chinese *zjangX* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription), glossed ’to be like’.

What you’ve built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàng*
- *Say it: xiàng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiàng wǒ bàba* — I take after my dad.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for handsome, then the Mandarin for ugly, then say *xiàng* again

Before you move on

What does xiàng mean? (“To resemble; to take after”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 125

Angry and Worried

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give a feeling as a reason: angry, worried, at ease, anxious or upset.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 125: I can give a feeling as a reason: angry, worried, at ease, anxious or upset.*

125.1 生气 (shēngqì) — to get angry

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for ugly, then the Mandarin for to resemble.

You'll want to know: 生气

生气 — *shēngqì* — "to get angry".

> 因为我没有来他生气了 *yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu lái tā shēngqì le* — He got angry because I didn't come.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

生气 (*shēngqì*) is built from 生 'to grow' and 气 'breath', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *srjaeng* and *khj+jH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The sense angry is not given there, so how the pair came to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: shēngqì*
- *Say it: shēngqì*, once more
- *Say it: yīnwèi wǒ méiyǒu lái tā shēngqì le* — He got angry because I didn't come.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for ugly, then the Mandarin for to resemble, then say *shēngqì* again

Before you move on

What does 生气 mean? ("To get angry".) Say it once more.

125.2 dānxīn — to worry

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to resemble, then the Mandarin for to get angry.

You'll want to know: dānxīn

dānxīn — "to worry".

nǐ bú yào dānxīn — Don't you worry.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dānxīn is built from *dān* 'to carry on the shoulder' and *xīn* 'heart', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tam* and *sim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The pair is not given there; a load carried in the heart is the plain picture, but the step is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: dānxīn*
- *Say it: dānxīn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ bú yào dānxīn* — Don't you worry.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to resemble, then the Mandarin for to get angry, then say *dānxīn* again

Before you move on

What does dānxīn mean? ("To worry".) Say it once more.

125.3 fàngxīn — to stop worrying; to be at ease

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to get angry, then the Mandarin for to worry.

You'll want to know: fàngxīn

fàngxīn — "to stop worrying; to be at ease".

nǐ fàngxīn wǒ hěn hǎo — Don't worry, I'm fine.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fàngxīn is built from *fàng*, the word for putting things down, and *xīn* 'heart', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjangH* and *sim* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'to drive out' and 'to send away'.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: fàngxīn*
- *Say it: fàngxīn*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ fàngxīn wǒ hěn hǎo* — Don't worry, I'm fine.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to get angry, then the Mandarin for to worry, then say *fàngxīn* again

Before you move on

What does fàngxīn mean? ("To stop worrying; to be at ease".) Say it once more.

125.4 zháojí — anxious; in a hurry

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to worry, then the Mandarin for to be at ease.

You'll want to know: zháojí

zháojí — "anxious; in a hurry".

wǒ hěn zháojí yīnwèi wǒ yǒushì — I'm in a rush, because I've got something on.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zháojí is built from *zháo* and *jí*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *drjak* and *kip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to attach to' and the second 'urgent' and 'narrow'; how the pair came to mean anxious is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: zháojí*
- *Say it: zháojí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ hěn zháojí yīnwèi wǒ yǒushì* — I'm in a rush, because I've got something on.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to worry, then the Mandarin for to be at ease, then say *zháojí* again

Before you move on

What does zháojí mean? ("Anxious; in a hurry".) Say it once more.

125.5 nánguò — sad; upset

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be at ease, then the Mandarin for anxious.

You'll want to know: nánguò

nánguò — "sad; upset".

tā de gǒu bìng le tā hěn nánguò — His dog is ill, and he's very upset.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nánguò is built from *nán* 'hard' and *guò* 'to pass', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nan* and *kwaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): hard to get through. The pair is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: nánguò*
- *Say it: nánguò*, once more
- *Say it: tā de gǒu bìng le tā hěn nánguò* — His dog is ill, and he's very upset.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be at ease, then the Mandarin for anxious, then say *nánguò* again

Before you move on

What does nánguò mean? ("Sad; upset".) Say it once more.

Chapter 126

Often and Sometimes

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 3 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say how often I do things, what I did before and what I did a moment ago.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 126: I can say how often I do things, what I did before and what I did a moment ago.*

126.1 chángcháng — often

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for anxious, then the Mandarin for upset.

You'll want to know: chángcháng

chángcháng — "often".

wǒ chángcháng hē chá — I often drink tea.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chángcháng says *cháng* twice. It is inherited from Middle Chinese *dzyang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which glosses it as a length of two fathoms and as an official title. The sense 'usual' is not given there, so how it came to mean often is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: chángcháng*
- *Say it: chángcháng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ chángcháng hē chá* — I often drink tea.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for anxious, then the Mandarin for upset, then say *chángcháng* again

Before you move on

What does chángcháng mean? ("Often".) Say it once more.

126.2 yǒushíhou — sometimes

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for upset, then the Mandarin for often.

You'll want to know: yǒushíhou

yǒushíhou — "sometimes".

wǒ yǒushíhou qù Běijīng — Sometimes I go to Beijing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǒushíhou is built from 有 'there is' and *shíhou* 'time', all three parts inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuwX*, *dzyi* and *huwH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): there are times.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǒushíhou*
- *Say it: yǒushíhou*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǒushíhou qù Běijīng* — Sometimes I go to Beijing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for upset, then the Mandarin for often, then say *yǒushíhou* again

Before you move on

What does yǒushíhou mean? (“Sometimes”.) Say it once more.

126.3 以前 (yǐqián) — before; in the past

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for often, then the Mandarin for sometimes.

You’ll want to know: 以前

以前 — *yǐqián* — “before; in the past”.

以前我不会说汉语 *yǐqián wǒ bú huì shuō hànyǔ* — I couldn’t speak Chinese before.

The new character, in pieces: 以 — four strokes: a vertical that flicks up at its foot, a dot beside it, then a long stroke falling to the left and a dot at the lower right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

以前 (*yǐqián*) is built from 以, glossed ’to use’ and ’with’, and 前 ’before’, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yiX* and *dzen* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription).

What you’ve built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǐqián*
- *Say it: yǐqián*, once more
- *Say it: yǐqián wǒ bú huì shuō hànyǔ* — I couldn't speak Chinese before.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for often, then the Mandarin for sometimes, then say *yǐqián* again

Before you move on

What does 以前 mean? ("Before; in the past".) Say it once more.

126.4 以 — four strokes in two pairs

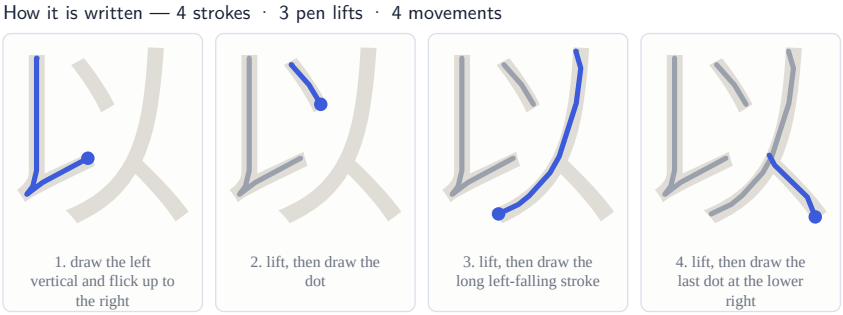
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yǐqián* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  前 会

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *qián*, *huì*

Script — four strokes in two pairs



How 以 is written, stroke by stroke

以

Two pieces, left before right. Count the pieces, not the strokes.

The left piece, two strokes. A vertical that runs down and flicks up to the right at its foot, then a short dot to the right of it, falling to the lower right.

The right piece, two strokes. A long left-falling stroke from the top right, sweeping down toward the foot of the first stroke, then a dot at the lower right, falling to the lower right.

2 + 2 = four.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 以, all four, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 以? (**Four**.) Which stroke flicks up? (**The first, at its foot**.) Which way does the long one fall? (**Down to the left**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 以, pinned stroke paths and medians.

126.5 gāngcái — a moment ago

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sometimes, then the Mandarin for in the past.

You'll want to know: gāngcái

gāngcái — "a moment ago".

gāngcái wǒ zài xǐshǒujiān — A moment ago I was in the toilet.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gāngcái is built from *gāng* and *cái*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kang* and *dzoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'strong', and lists the second, under an older way of writing it, as 'barely', a different word from the *cái* of talent; how the pair came to mean a moment ago is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: gāngcái*
- *Say it: gāngcái*, once more
- *Say it: gāngcái wǒ zài xǐshǒujiān* — A moment ago I was in the toilet.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sometimes, then the Mandarin for in the past, then say *gāngcái* again

Before you move on

What does gāngcái mean? ("A moment ago".) Say it once more.

126.6 yǐjīng — already

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for in the past, then the Mandarin for a moment ago.

You'll want to know: yǐjīng

yǐjīng — "already".

wǒ yǐjīng chī fàn le — I've already eaten.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǐjīng is built from *yǐ* and *jīng*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yiX* and *keng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to stop' and 'finished', a different word from the 以 of 以前, and the second 'constant' and 'the warp of cloth'; how the pair came to mean already is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǐjīng*
- *Say it: yǐjīng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ yǐjīng chī fàn le* — I've already eaten.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for in the past, then the Mandarin for a moment ago, then say *yǐjīng* again

Before you move on

What does yǐjīng mean? ("Already".) Say it once more.

Chapter 127

These and Those

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say these, those, which ones, some, and like this.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 127: I can say these, those, which ones, some, and like this.*

127.1 这些 (zhèxiē) — these

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a moment ago, then the Mandarin for already.

You'll want to know: 这些

这些 — *zhèxiē* — "these".

> 这些是我以前的书 *zhèxiē shì wǒ yǐqián de shū* — These are my old books.

The new character, in pieces: 些 — on top a four-stroke piece and a two-stroke piece side by side, and under them the two bars of 二. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

这些 (*zhèxiē*) is built from 这 'this' and 些 'a few'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's

transcription), glossed 'a little'.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhèxiē*
- *Say it: zhèxiē*, once more
- *Say it: zhèxiē shì wǒ yǐqián de shū* — These are my old books.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a moment ago, then the Mandarin for already, then say *zhèxiē* again

Before you move on

What does 这些 mean? ("These".) Say it once more.

127.2 些 — two small pieces over 二

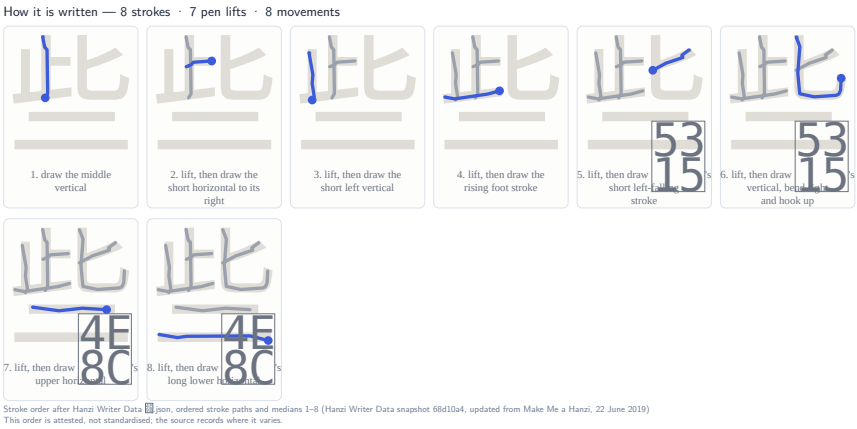
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *zhèxiē* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  这 二

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *zhè*, *èr*

Script — two small pieces over 二



How 些 is written, stroke by stroke

些

Three pieces: two side by side on top, then 二 underneath.

The top left piece, four strokes. A short vertical, a short horizontal from its middle to the right, a shorter vertical to the left of the first, then a stroke along the foot that rises to the right.

The top right piece, two strokes. A short left-falling stroke, then a vertical that bends to the right along the bottom and hooks up.

二, two strokes: the short bar, then the long one beneath it.

4 + 2 + 2 = eight.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 些, all eight, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 些? (**Three**.) Which character you know sits at the bottom? (二.) How does the sixth stroke end? (**It bends right along the bottom and hooks up**.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 些, pinned stroke paths and medians.

127.3 那些 (nàxiē) — those

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for already, then the Mandarin for these.

You'll want to know: 那些

那些 — *nàxiē* — "those".

那些人是我以前的同学 *nàxiē rén shì wǒ yǐqián de tóngxué* — Those people are my old classmates.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

那些 (*nàxiē*) is built from 那 'that' and 些 'a few', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *na* and *sjae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'how, what', not 'that', and the second 'a little'.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: nàxiē*
- *Say it: nàxiē*, once more
- *Say it: nàxiē rén shì wǒ yǐqián de tóngxué* — Those people are my old classmates.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for already, then the Mandarin for these, then say *nàxiē* again

Before you move on

What does 那些 mean? ("Those".) Say it once more.

127.4 哪些 (nǎxiē) — which ones

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for these, then the Mandarin for those.

You'll want to know: 哪些

哪些 — *nǎxiē* — "which ones".

你喜欢哪些书 *nǐ xǐhuan nǎxiē shū* — Which books do you like?

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

哪些 (*nǎxiē*) is built from 哪 'which' and 些 'a few'. The second is inherited from Middle Chinese *sjae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); no dictionary we use records an older form of the first, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: nǎxiē*
- *Say it: nǎxiē*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan nǎxiē shū* — Which books do you like?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for these, then the Mandarin for those, then say *nǎxiē* again

Before you move on

What does 哪些 mean? ("Which ones".) Say it once more.

127.5 一些 (yìxiē) — some; a few

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for those, then the Mandarin for which ones.

You'll want to know: 一些

一些 — *yìxiē* — "some; a few".

我想喝一些水 *wǒ xiǎng hē yìxiē shuǐ* — I'd like to drink some water.

The tone of 一 changes here: yī is said yì before the first tone of xiē.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一些 (*yìxiē*) is built from 一 'one' and 些 'a few', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jit* and *sjae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: yìxiē*
- *Say it: yìxiē*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng hē yìxiē shuǐ* — I'd like to drink some water.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for those, then the Mandarin for which ones, then say *yìxiē* again

Before you move on

What does 一些 mean? ("Some; a few".) Say it once more.

127.6 zhèyàng — like this; this way

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for which ones, then the Mandarin for a few.

You'll want to know: zhèyàng

zhèyàng — "like this; this way".

nǐ kěyǐ zhèyàng zuò — You can do it this way.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhèyàng is built from 这 'this' and *yàng* 'a pattern', the *yàng* of *yíyàng*. No dictionary we use records an older form of either part in these

senses, so the history of the pair is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhèyàng*
- *Say it: zhèyàng*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ kěyǐ zhèyàng zuò* — You can do it this way.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for which ones, then the Mandarin for a few, then say *zhèyàng* again

Before you move on

What does zhèyàng mean? ("Like this; this way".) Say it once more.

Chapter 128

Music

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about music: songs, the piano and the guitar, and what sounds good.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 128: I can talk about music: songs, the piano and the guitar, and what sounds good.*

128.1 音乐 (yīnyuè) — music

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a few, then the Mandarin for like this.

You'll want to know: 音乐

音乐 — *yīnyuè* — "music".

我喜欢音乐 *wǒ xǐhuan yīnyuè* — I love music.

The new character, in pieces: 音 — on top a five-stroke piece — a dot, a short bar, two short strokes leaning toward each other, and a long bar — and under it 日. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

音乐 (*yīnyuè*) is built from 音 'sound' and 乐, here said *yuè*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'im* and *ngaewk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second with the

whole word, 'music'.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīnyuè*
- *Say it: yīnyuè*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan yīnyuè* — I love music.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a few, then the Mandarin for like this, then say *yīnyuè* again

Before you move on

What does 音乐 mean? ("Music".) Say it once more.

128.2 音 — five strokes over 日

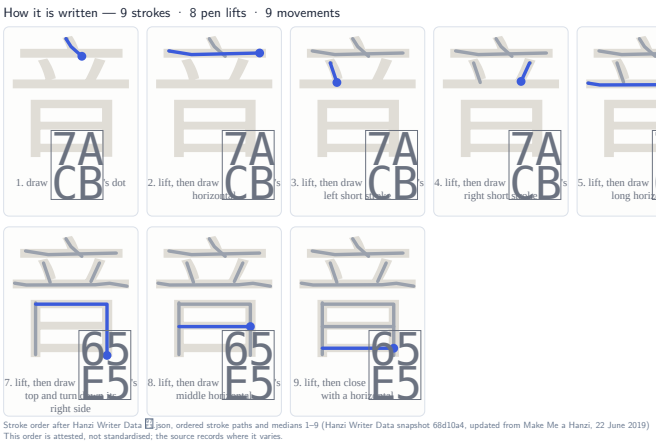
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yīnyuè* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  日 乐

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rì*, *lè*

Script — five strokes over 日



How 音 *is written, stroke by stroke*

音

Two pieces, top to bottom.

The top piece, five strokes. A dot at the top, a short horizontal under it, a short stroke on the left falling to the lower right, a short stroke on the right falling to the lower left, then a long horizontal across the whole width.

日, four strokes, the four your hand makes in 日: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, the middle bar, and the bar that closes the bottom.

5 + 4 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 音, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 音? (**Two**.) Which stroke ends the top piece? (**The long horizontal**.) What sits underneath? (日.)

Source: Hanzi Writer Data 音, pinned stroke paths and medians.

128.3 gē — song

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for like this, then the Mandarin for music.

You'll want to know: gē

gē — "song".

wǒ xǐhuan Zhōngguó gē — I love Chinese songs.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gē is inherited from Middle Chinese *ka* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary quotes an older book: the voice of a person is called song.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: gē*
- *Say it: gē*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan Zhōngguó gē* — I love Chinese songs.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for like this, then the Mandarin for music, then say *gē* again

Before you move on

What does gē mean? ("Song".) Say it once more.

128.4 hǎotīng — pleasant to hear

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for music, then the Mandarin for song.

You'll want to know: hǎotīng

hǎotīng — "pleasant to hear".

Zhōngguó yīnyuè hěn hǎotīng — Chinese music is lovely to listen to.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

hǎotīng is built from 好 'good' and *tīng* 'to listen', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *xawX* and *theng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), the same shape as 好看 and 好吃.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: hǎotīng*
- *Say it: hǎotīng*, once more
- *Say it: Zhōngguó yīnyuè hěn hǎotīng* — Chinese music is lovely to listen to.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for music, then the Mandarin for song, then say *hǎotīng* again

Before you move on

What does hǎotīng mean? ("Pleasant to hear".) Say it once more.

128.5 音乐会 (yīnyuèhuì) — concert

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for song, then the Mandarin for pleasant to hear.

You'll want to know: 音乐会

音乐会 — *yīnyuèhuì* — "concert".

> 明天晚上我们去音乐会 *míngtiān wǎnshang wǒmen qù yīnyuèhuì* — Tomorrow evening we're going to a concert.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

音乐会 (*yīnyuèhuì*) is built from 音乐 'music' and 会 'a gathering', all three parts inherited from Middle Chinese, *'im*, *ngaewk* and *hwajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the last 'to come together'.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīnyuèhuì*
- *Say it: yīnyuèhuì*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān wǎnshang wǒmen qù yīnyuèhuì* — Tomorrow evening we're going to a concert.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for song, then the Mandarin for pleasant to hear, then say *yīnyuèhuì* again

Before you move on

What does 音乐会 mean? ("Concert".) Say it once more.

128.6 jítā — guitar

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pleasant to hear, then the Mandarin for concert.

You'll want to know: jítā

jítā — "guitar".

wǒ xiǎng xué jítā — I'd like to learn the guitar.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jítā is usually traced to English *guitar*; its two characters were chosen for their sound, the first a word for lucky and the second the 他 of 'he'.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: jítā*
- *Say it: jítā*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng xué jítā* — I'd like to learn the guitar.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pleasant to hear, then the Mandarin for concert, then say *jítā* again

Before you move on

What does jítā mean? ("Guitar".) Say it once more.

128.7 Looking back: from What People Are Like to Music

Say the Mandarin for clever and conscientious.

Your turn

- *Say it:* clever, conscientious, lovable, warm-hearted, to care about
- *Say it:* a person's height, hair, handsome, ugly, to resemble

- *Say it:* to get angry, to worry, to be at ease, anxious, upset
- *Say it:* often, sometimes, in the past, a moment ago, already
- *Say it:* these, those, which ones, a few, like this
- *Say it:* music, song, pleasant to hear, concert, guitar
- *Read it:* 以 些 音 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Clever? (*cōngming.*) Conscientious? (*rènzhēn.*) Lovable? (*kě'ài.*) Warm-hearted? (*rèqíng.*) To care about? (*guānxīn.*) A person's height? (个子, *gèzi.*) Hair? (*tóufa.*) Handsome? (*shuài.*) Ugly? (*nánkàn.*) To resemble? (*xiàng.*) To get angry? (生气, *shēngqì.*) To worry? (*dānxīn.*) To be at ease? (*fàngxīn.*) Anxious? (*zháojí.*) Upset? (*nánguò.*) Often? (*chángcháng.*) Sometimes? (*yǒushíhou.*) In the past? (以前, *yǐqián.*) A moment ago? (*gāngcái.*) Already? (*yǐjīng.*) These? (这些, *zhèxiē.*) Those? (那些, *nàxiē.*) Which ones? (哪些, *nǎxiē.*) A few? (一些, *yìxiē.*) Like this? (*zhèyàng.*) Music? (音乐, *yīnyuè.*) Song? (*gē.*) Pleasant to hear? (*hǎotīng.*) Concert? (音乐会, *yīnyuèhuì.*) Guitar? (*jítā.*)

Chapter 129

Quiet and Noisy

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say a place is quiet, noisy, lively or handy, and that something is interesting.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 129: I can say a place is quiet, noisy, lively or handy, and that something is interesting.*

129.1 ānjìng — quiet

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for concert, then the Mandarin for guitar.

You'll want to know: ānjìng

ānjìng — "quiet".

> *wǒ de fángjiān hěn ānjìng* — My room is quiet.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ānjìng is built from *ān* 'peaceful' and *jìng* 'calm', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'an* and *dzjengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second with the first.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: ānjìng*
- *Say it: ānjìng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de fángjiān hěn ānjìng* — My room is quiet.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for concert, then the Mandarin for guitar, then say *ānjìng* again

Before you move on

What does ānjìng mean? ("Quiet".) Say it once more.

129.2 吵 (chǎo) — noisy

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for guitar, then the Mandarin for quiet.

You'll want to know: 吵

吵 — *chǎo* — "noisy".

他的音乐太吵了 *tā de yīnyuè tài chǎo le* — His music is far too loud.

The new character, in pieces: 吵 — 口 on the left and 少 on the right. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

吵 (*chǎo*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tsrhaewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'sound', a different word from the *chǎo* of stir-frying, which has the same old form. The dictionary notes that the character first had another reading, *mjiewX*, glossed 'the call of a pheasant'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: chǎo*
- *Say it: chǎo*, once more
- *Say it: tā de yīnyuè tài chǎo le* — His music is far too loud.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for guitar, then the Mandarin for quiet, then say *chǎo* again

Before you move on

What does 吵 mean? ("Noisy".) Say it once more.

129.3 吵 — 口, then 少

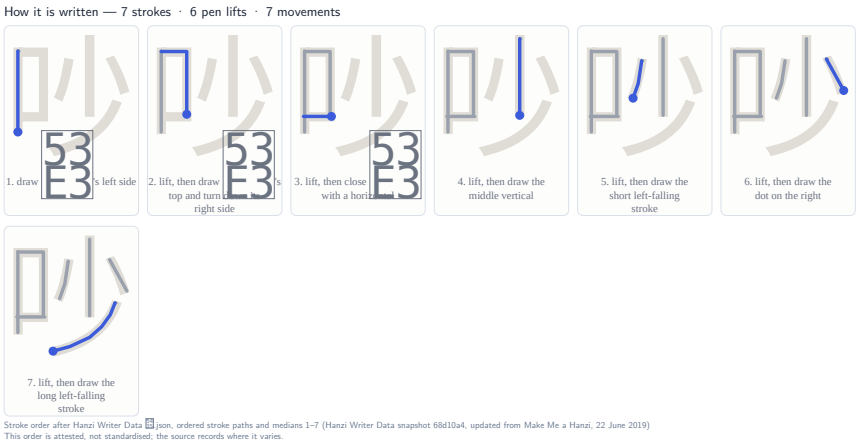
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chǎo* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

口 少

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *kǒu*, *shǎo*

Script — 口, then 少



How 吵 is written, stroke by stroke

吵

Two pieces, left before right, and both are old friends.

口**, three strokes**, small and narrow on the left: the left side, the top that turns down the right side, and the bar that closes the bottom.

少**, four strokes**, on the right: the vertical down the middle, the short stroke on its left, the dot on its right, then the long left-falling stroke that sweeps under them.

3 + 4 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 吵, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of 吵? (口 **and** 少.) Which side is narrow? (**The left,** 口.) What does the last stroke do? (**It sweeps down to the left under** 少.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 吵, pinned stroke paths and medians.

129.4 rènao — lively; bustling

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for quiet, then the Mandarin for noisy.

You'll want to know: rènao

rènao — "lively; bustling".

Běijīng hěn rènao — Beijing is a lively place.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

rènao is built from *rè* 'hot' and *nao*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nyet* and *nraewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'not quiet' and 'to stir up'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: rènao*
- *Say it: rènao*, once more
- *Say it: Běijīng hěn rènao* — Beijing is a lively place.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for quiet, then the Mandarin for noisy, then say *rènao* again

Before you move on

What does rènao mean? ("Lively; bustling".) Say it once more.

129.5 fāngbiàn — convenient; handy

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for noisy, then the Mandarin for bustling.

You'll want to know: fāngbiàn

fāngbiàn — "convenient; handy".

> *zhèr mǎi dōngxi hěn fāngbiàn* — Shopping here is easy.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fāngbiàn is built from *fāng* and *biàn*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjang* and *bjienH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'the four quarters' and 'a method', and the second 'advantageous'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: fāngbiàn*
- *Say it: fāngbiàn*, once more
- *Say it: zhèr mǎi dōngxi hěn fāngbiàn* — Shopping here is easy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for noisy, then the Mandarin for bustling, then say *fāngbiàn* again

Before you move on

What does fāngbiàn mean? ("Convenient; handy".) Say it once more.

129.6 yǒuyìsi — interesting

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for bustling, then the Mandarin for convenient.

You'll want to know: yǒuyìsi

yǒuyìsi — "interesting".

> *xué hànyǔ hěn yǒuyìsi* — Learning Chinese is interesting.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yǒuyìsi is built from 有 'to have' and *yìsi* 'meaning', the *yìsi* of *bù hǎoyìsi*: to have meaning. The parts are inherited from Middle Chinese, *hjuwX*, *'iH* and *si* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: yǒuyìsi*
- *Say it: yǒuyìsi*, once more
- *Say it: xué hànyǔ hěn yǒuyìsi* — Learning Chinese is interesting.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for bustling, then the Mandarin for convenient, then say *yǒuyìsi* again

Before you move on

What does yǒuyìsi mean? ("Interesting".) Say it once more.

Chapter 130

Feeling Ill

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I am ill, have a cold or a fever, or that something hurts, and go to the doctor.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 130: I can say I am ill, have a cold or a fever, or that something hurts, and go to the doctor.*

130.1 病人 (bìngrén) — patient; sick person

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for convenient, then the Mandarin for interesting.

You'll want to know: 病人

病人 — *bìngrén* — "patient; sick person".

> 病人想喝水 *bìngrén xiǎng hē shuǐ* — The patient would like some water.

The new character, in pieces: 病 — outside, the sickbed piece of five strokes: a dot, a bar, a long fall down the left, then a dot and a rising stroke on the left side; inside it, five strokes: a bar, a box with a hooked right side, and a small 人 in the box. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

病人 (*bìngrén*) is built from 病 'illness' and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjaengH* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'grief' and 'suffering', and quotes an older book: an illness grown worse.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: bìngrén*
- *Say it: bìngrén*, once more
- *Say it: bìngrén xiǎng hē shuǐ* — The patient would like some water.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for convenient, then the Mandarin for interesting, then say *bìngrén* again

Before you move on

What does 病人 mean? ("Patient; sick person".) Say it once more.

130.2 病 — the sickbed piece around a box
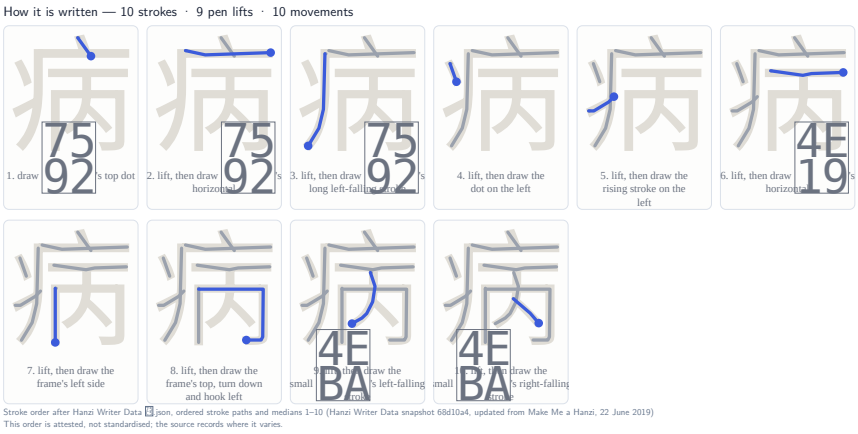
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *bìngrén* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

人 男

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *rén*, *nán*

Script — the sickbed piece around a box



How 病 *is written, stroke by stroke*

病

Two pieces: the sickbed piece outside, a boxed piece inside.

The sickbed piece, five strokes. A dot at the top, a horizontal under it, a long left-falling stroke down the left side, then on the left a short dot and a short stroke rising to the right.

The inside piece, five strokes. A horizontal across the top; a short vertical, the left side of the box; a horizontal that turns down the right side and hooks; then a small 人 from the top bar into the box: its left-falling stroke, then its dot.

5 + 5 = ten.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 病, all ten, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 病? (**Two** — the sickbed piece and the boxed piece.) What sits on the left of the sickbed piece? (**A dot and a**

rising stroke.) What is inside the box? (**A small 人**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 病, pinned stroke paths and medians.

130.3 gǎnmào — to catch a cold; a cold

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for interesting, then the Mandarin for a sick person.

You'll want to know: gǎnmào

gǎnmào — "to catch a cold; a cold".

wǒ gǎnmào le — I've caught a cold.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gǎnmào is built from *gǎn* and *mào*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *komX* and *mawH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to move' and the second 'to cover' and 'to wade'; how the pair came to mean a cold is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: gǎnmào*
- *Say it: gǎnmào*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ gǎnmào le* — I've caught a cold.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for interesting, then the Mandarin for a sick person, then say *gǎnmào* again

Before you move on

What does gǎnmào mean? ("To catch a cold; a cold".) Say it once more.

130.4 fāshāo — to have a fever

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a sick person, then the Mandarin for to catch a cold.

You'll want to know: fāshāo

fāshāo — "to have a fever".

wǒ fāshāo le wǒ xiǎng shuìjiào — I've got a temperature and I want to sleep.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fāshāo is built from *fā* 'to start' and *shāo* 'to burn', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjot* and *syew* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: fāshāo*
- *Say it: fāshāo*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ fāshāo le wǒ xiǎng shuìjiào* — I've got a temperature and I want to sleep.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a sick person, then the Mandarin for to catch a cold, then say *fāshāo* again

Before you move on

What does fāshāo mean? ("To have a fever".) Say it once more.

130.5 téng — sore; painful

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to catch a cold, then the Mandarin for to have a fever.

You'll want to know: téng

téng — "sore; painful".

wǒ de tóu hěn téng — My head really hurts.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

téng is inherited from Middle Chinese *downg* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'pain'. The regular sound change would give *tóng*, not *téng*; why the vowel differs is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: téng*
- *Say it: téng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de tóu hěn téng* — My head really hurts.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to catch a cold, then the Mandarin for to have a fever, then say *téng* again

Before you move on

What does téng mean? ("Sore; painful".) Say it once more.

130.6 看病 (kànbìng) — to see a doctor

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to have a fever, then the Mandarin for sore.

You'll want to know: 看病

看病 — *kànbìng* — "to see a doctor".

我病了我去看病 *wǒ bìng le wǒ qù kànbìng* — I'm ill, so I'm off to the doctor.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

看病 (*kànbìng*) is built from 看 'to look at' and 病 'illness', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *khanH* and *bjaengH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): to have an illness looked at.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: kànbìng*
- *Say it: kànbìng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bìng le wǒ qù kànbìng* — I'm ill, so I'm off to the doctor.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to have a fever, then the Mandarin for sore, then say *kànbìng* again

Before you move on

What does 看病 mean? ("To see a doctor".) Say it once more.

Chapter 131

Four Seasons

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the four seasons and ask which one someone likes.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 131: I can name the four seasons and ask which one someone likes.*

131.1 春天 (chūntiān) — spring

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for sore, then the Mandarin for to see a doctor.

You'll want to know: 春天

春天 — *chūntiān* — "spring".

> 我喜欢春天 *wǒ xǐhuan chūntiān* — I love spring.

The new character, in pieces: 春 — the three bars of 三, a 人 whose two strokes spread across them, and 日 underneath. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

春天 (*chūntiān*) is built from 春 'spring' and 天 'sky, day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhwin* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'the head of the four seasons'.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: chūntiān*
- *Say it: chūntiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan chūntiān* — I love spring.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for sore, then the Mandarin for to see a doctor, then say *chūntiān* again

Before you move on

What does 春天 mean? ("Spring".) Say it once more.

131.2 春 — 三 and 人 over 日

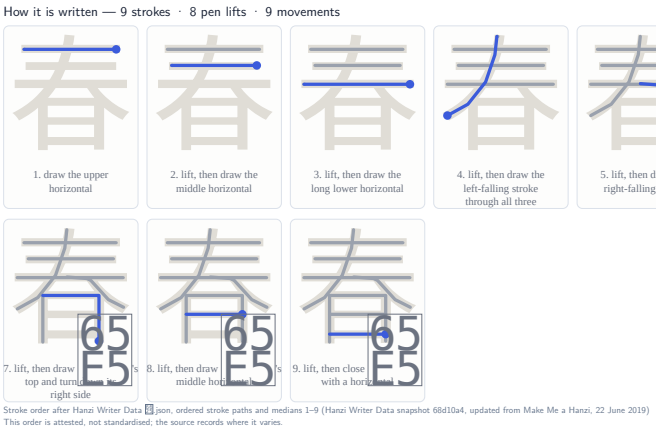
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *chūntiān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

三 人 日

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *sān*, *rén*, *rì*

Script — 三 and 人 over 日



How 春 is written, stroke by stroke

春

Three pieces you know, top to bottom, the first two woven together.

The three bars of 三: two shorter bars, then a long third one.

人**, two strokes**, spread wide across the bars: the left-falling stroke from above the top bar down to the lower left, then the right-falling stroke from the middle out to the lower right.

日**, four strokes**, small, under the spread of 人.

3 + 2 + 4 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 春, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 春? (**Nine.**) Which bar is the longest? (**The third.**) What sits at the bottom? (日.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 春, pinned stroke paths and medians.

131.3 xiàtiān — summer

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to see a doctor, then the Mandarin for spring.

You'll want to know: xiàtiān

xiàtiān — "summer".

Běijīng de xiàtiān hěn rè — Summers in Beijing are hot.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xiàtiān is built from *xià* 'summer' and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *haeH* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary lists the first under the words 'spring and summer'.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: xiàtiān*
- *Say it: xiàtiān*, once more
- *Say it: Běijīng de xiàtiān hěn rè* — Summers in Beijing are hot.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to see a doctor, then the Mandarin for spring, then say *xiàtiān* again

Before you move on

What does xiàtiān mean? ("Summer".) Say it once more.

131.4 qiūtiān — autumn

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for spring, then the Mandarin for summer.

You'll want to know: qiūtiān

qiūtiān — "autumn".

> *qiūtiān bù lěng yě bú rè* — Autumn is neither cold nor hot.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qiūtiān is built from *qiū* 'autumn' and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tshjuw* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary quotes an older book for the first: the time when grain is ripe.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiūtiān*
- *Say it: qiūtiān*, once more
- *Say it: qiūtiān bù lěng yě bú rè* — Autumn is neither cold nor hot.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for spring, then the Mandarin for summer, then say *qiūtiān* again

Before you move on

What does qiūtiān mean? ("Autumn".) Say it once more.

131.5 dōngtiān — winter

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for summer, then the Mandarin for autumn.

You'll want to know: dōngtiān

dōngtiān — "winter".

> *dōngtiān wǒ bù xiǎng chūmén* — In winter I don't feel like going out.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dōngtiān is built from *dōng* 'winter' and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *towng* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'the last of the four seasons'.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: dōngtiān*
- *Say it: dōngtiān*, once more
- *Say it: dōngtiān wǒ bù xiǎng chūmén* — In winter I don't feel like going out.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for summer, then the Mandarin for autumn, then say *dōngtiān* again

Before you move on

What does dōngtiān mean? ("Winter".) Say it once more.

131.6 jìjié — season

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for autumn, then the Mandarin for winter.

You'll want to know: jìjié

jìjié — "season".

> *nǐ xǐhuan nǎge jìjié* — Which season do you like?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jìjié is built from *jì* and *jié*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kjwijH* and *tset* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'the youngest of brothers' and the second, after an older book, 'the joint of a bamboo'; how the pair came to mean a season is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: jìjié*
- *Say it: jìjié*, once more
- *Say it: nǐ xǐhuan nǎge jìjié* — Which season do you like?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for autumn, then the Mandarin for winter, then say *jìjié* again

Before you move on

What does jìjié mean? ("Season".) Say it once more.

Chapter 132

Thousands

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count in thousands and ten thousands, say zero, and say how many in all.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 132: I can count in thousands and ten thousands, say zero, and say how many in all.*

132.1 千 (qiān) — thousand

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for winter, then the Mandarin for season.

You'll want to know: 千

千 — *qiān* — "thousand".

> 我们大学有三千个学生 *wǒmen dàxué yǒu sānqiān ge xuésheng* — Our university has three thousand students.

The new character, in pieces: 千 — a short fall over 十. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

千 (*qiān*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'ten hundreds'.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: qiān*
- *Say it: qiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen dàxué yǒu sānqiān ge xuésheng* — Our university has three thousand students.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for winter, then the Mandarin for season, then say *qiān* again

Before you move on

What does 千 mean? ("Thousand".) Say it once more.

132.2 千 — a short fall over 十

The word first, then the character inside it.

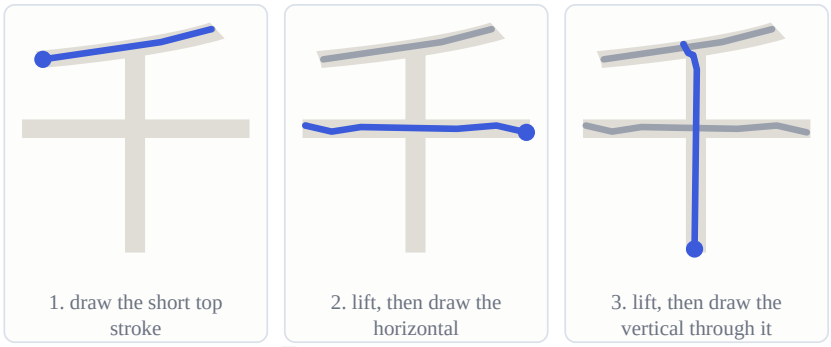
- *Recall:* say *qiān* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

十 百

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *shí*, *bǎi*

Script — a short fall over 十

How it is written — 3 strokes · 2 pen lifts · 3 movements



1. draw the short top stroke
2. lift, then draw the horizontal
3. lift, then draw the vertical through it

Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 33.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–3 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 千 is written, stroke by stroke

千

Two pieces, top to bottom.
A short left-falling stroke at the top, from the right down to the left.
十**, two strokes**: the horizontal across, then the vertical down through it.
1 + 2 = three.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 千, all three, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 千? (**Three**.) Which number you know sits under the fall? (十.) Which comes first, the bar or the vertical? (**The bar**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 千, pinned stroke paths and medians.

132.3 wàn — ten thousand

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for season, then the Mandarin for thousand.

You'll want to know: wàn

wàn — "ten thousand".

wǒ xiǎng yǒu yíwàn kuài qián — I wish I had ten thousand yuan.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
The tone of 一 changes: yī is said yí before the fourth tone of wàn.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

wàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjonH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses this short way of writing the character 'ten thousands'; under its longer way of writing it gives the name of a dance and of an insect.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: wàn*
- *Say it: wàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xiǎng yǒu yíwàn kuài qián* — I wish I had ten thousand yuan.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for season, then the Mandarin for thousand, then say *wàn* again

Before you move on

What does wàn mean? ("Ten thousand".) Say it once more.

132.4 líng — zero

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for thousand, then the Mandarin for ten thousand.

You'll want to know: líng

líng — "zero".

tā yìbǎi líng yī suì le — He is a hundred and one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

líng is inherited from Middle Chinese *leng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to fall' and, after an older book, 'a gentle rain'. The sense zero is not given there; how it came is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: líng*
- *Say it: líng*, once more
- *Say it: tā yìbǎi líng yī suì le* — He is a hundred and one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for thousand, then the Mandarin for ten thousand, then say *líng* again

Before you move on

What does líng mean? ("Zero".) Say it once more.

132.5 yígòng — altogether; in all

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for ten thousand, then the Mandarin for zero.

You'll want to know: yígòng

yígòng — "altogether; in all".

> *wǒmen yígòng yǒu wǔ ge rén* — There are five of us in all.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
The tone of 一 changes: yī is said yí before the fourth tone of gòng.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yígòng is built from 一 'one' and *gòng*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'jit* and *gjowngH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which glosses the second 'together' and 'all'.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: yígòng*
- *Say it: yígòng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen yígòng yǒu wǔ ge rén* — There are five of us in all.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for ten thousand, then the Mandarin for zero, then say *yígòng* again

Before you move on

What does yígòng mean? ("Altogether; in all".) Say it once more.

132.6 shǔ — to count

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for zero, then the Mandarin for in all.

You'll want to know: shǔ

shǔ — "to count".

> *wǒ shǔ le yígòng yǒu bā ge* — I counted: there are eight in all.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shǔ is inherited from Middle Chinese *srjuX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which quotes an older book: 'to reckon'.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: shǔ*
- *Say it: shǔ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ shǔ le yígòng yǒu bā ge* — I counted: there are eight in all.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for zero, then the Mandarin for in all, then say *shǔ* again

Before you move on

What does shǔ mean? ("To count".) Say it once more.

Chapter 133

Housework

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I clean, tidy up, wipe and throw things away.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 133: I can say I clean, tidy up, wipe and throw things away.*

133.1 打扫 (dǎsǎo) — to clean (a room); to sweep

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for in all, then the Mandarin for to count.

You'll want to know: 打扫

打扫 — *dǎsǎo* — "to clean (a room); to sweep".

> 今天我们一起打扫 *jīntiān wǒmen yìqǐ dǎsǎo* — Today we're cleaning up together.

The new character, in pieces: 扫 — the hand piece on the left, as in 打, and on the right three strokes: a bar that turns down, and two bars inside it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

Two third tones: dǎsǎo is said dásǎo, the first rising.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

打扫 (*dǎsǎo*) is built from 打 'to strike', here 'to do', and *sǎo* 'to sweep', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *taengX* and *sawX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The regular sound change from *taengX* would not give the everyday *dǎ*; why is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎsǎo*
- *Say it: dǎsǎo*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān wǒmen yìqǐ dǎsǎo* — Today we're cleaning up together.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for in all, then the Mandarin for to count, then say *dǎsǎo* again

Before you move on

What does 打扫 mean? ("To clean (a room); to sweep".) Say it once more.

133.2 扫 — the hand piece, then three bars

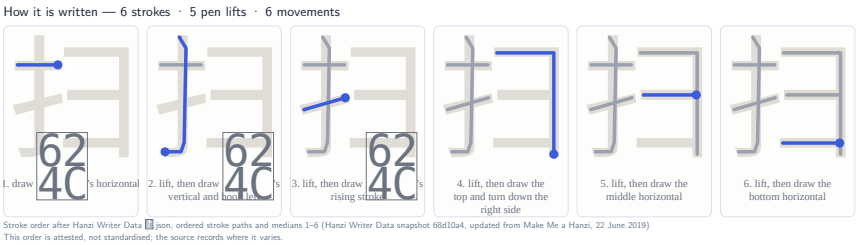
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *dǎsǎo* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  打 手

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *dǎ*, *shǒu*

Script — the hand piece, then three bars



How 扫 is written, stroke by stroke

扫

Two pieces, left before right.

The hand piece, three strokes, as in 打: a horizontal, a vertical that hooks to the left at its foot, then a stroke that rises to the right across it.

The right piece, three strokes. A horizontal that turns down at its right end, a horizontal across the middle, then a horizontal along the foot, which runs out past the right side.

3 + 3 = six.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 扫, all six, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

Which piece of 扫 comes from 打? (**The hand piece, on the left.**) How many strokes on the right? (**Three.**) Which bar runs out past the side? (**The bottom one.**)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 扫, pinned stroke paths and medians.

133.3 jiāwù — housework

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to count, then the Mandarin for to clean (a room).

You'll want to know: jiāwù

jiāwù — "housework".

wǒ bù xǐhuan zuò jiāwù — I don't like doing housework.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiāwù is built from 家 'home' and *wù* 'affairs', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kae* and *mjuH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiāwù*
- *Say it: jiāwù*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù xǐhuan zuò jiāwù* — I don't like doing housework.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to count, then the Mandarin for to clean (a room), then say *jiāwù* again

Before you move on

What does jiāwù mean? ("Housework".) Say it once more.

133.4 shōushi — to tidy up

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to clean (a room), then the Mandarin for housework.

You'll want to know: shōushi

shōushi — "to tidy up".

jīntiān wǒ shōushi fángjiān — Today I'm tidying my room.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shōushi is built from *shōu* 'to gather' and *shi*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *syuw* and *dzyip* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second with this very word, and with 'to pick up'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: shōushi*
- *Say it: shōushi*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān wǒ shōushi fángjiān* — Today I'm tidying my room.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to clean (a room), then the Mandarin for housework, then say *shōushi* again

Before you move on

What does shōushi mean? ("To tidy up".) Say it once more.

133.5 cā — to wipe

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for housework, then the Mandarin for to tidy up.

You'll want to know: cā

cā — "to wipe".

wǒ cā zhuōzi nǐ cā yǐzi — I'll wipe the table; you wipe the chairs.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cā No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: cā*
- *Say it: cā*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ cā zhuōzi nǐ cā yǐzi* — I'll wipe the table; you wipe the chairs.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for housework, then the Mandarin for to tidy up, then say *cā* again

Before you move on

What does cā mean? ("To wipe".) Say it once more.

133.6 dié — to fold

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to tidy up, then the Mandarin for to wipe.

You'll want to know: dié

dié — "to fold".

wǒ dié yīfu nǐ shōushi fángjiān — I'll fold the clothes; you tidy the room.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dié is inherited from Middle Chinese *dep* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'layered' and 'to pile up'; folding, a cloth laid in layers, is the likely step, though it is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: dié*
- *Say it: dié*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ dié yīfu nǐ shōushi fángjiān* — I'll fold the clothes; you tidy the room.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to tidy up, then the Mandarin for to wipe, then say *dié* again

Before you move on

What does dié mean? ("To fold".) Say it once more.

Chapter 134

Heavy and Soft

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say a thing is heavy, soft, hard, empty or full.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 134: I can say a thing is heavy, soft, hard, empty or full.*

134.1 重 (zhòng) — heavy

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to wipe, then the Mandarin for to fold.

You'll want to know: 重

重 — *zhòng* — "heavy".

> 这个太重了 *zhège tài zhòng le* — This one is too heavy.

The new character, in pieces: 重 — a short fall and a long bar on top, and under them 里, its vertical running up through the bar. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

重 (*zhòng*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *drjowngX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'much', 'thick' and 'careful'. 'Heavy' is not among the glosses, so the step to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhòng*
- *Say it: zhòng*, once more
- *Say it: zhège tài zhòng le* — This one is too heavy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to wipe, then the Mandarin for to fold, then say *zhòng* again

Before you move on

What does 重 mean? ("Heavy".) Say it once more.

134.2 重 — a fall and a bar over 里

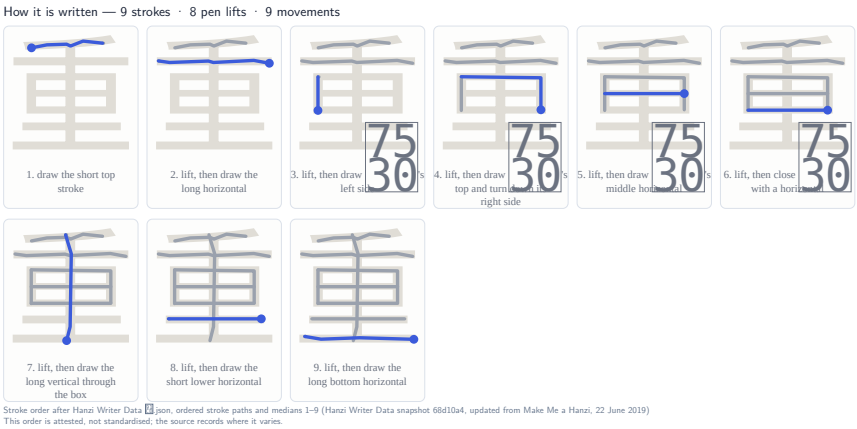
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *zhòng* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  里 千

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *lǐ*, *qiān*

Script — a fall and a bar over 里



How 重 *is written, stroke by stroke*

重

Two pieces, top to bottom.

A short left-falling stroke, from the right down to the left, then **a long horizontal** across the whole width, as 千 begins.

里, seven strokes, in the order your hand knows: the box (its left side, the top that turns down the right side, the middle bar, the bar that closes it), then the vertical, which here starts above the long bar and runs down through it and the box, then the two bars of the foot, the lower one longer.

2 + 7 = nine.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 重, all nine, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

What sits under the long bar of 重? (里.) Where does the vertical start? (**Above the long bar**.) Which is the last stroke? (**The long bar at the foot**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 重, pinned stroke paths and medians.

134.3 ruǎn — soft

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to fold, then the Mandarin for heavy.

You'll want to know: ruǎn

ruǎn — "soft".

zhè zhāng chuáng hěn ruǎn — This bed is soft.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

ruǎn is inherited from Middle Chinese *nywenX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'soft', under an older way of writing the character.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: ruǎn*
- *Say it: ruǎn*, once more
- *Say it: zhè zhāng chuáng hěn ruǎn* — This bed is soft.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to fold, then the Mandarin for heavy, then say *ruǎn* again

Before you move on

What does ruǎn mean? ("Soft".) Say it once more.

134.4 yìng — hard; stiff

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for heavy, then the Mandarin for soft.

You'll want to know: yìng

yìng — "hard; stiff".

zhège miànbāo tài yìng le — This bread is too hard.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yìng is inherited from Middle Chinese *ngeangH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'firm and sturdy'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: yìng*
- *Say it: yìng*, once more
- *Say it: zhège miànbāo tài yìng le* — This bread is too hard.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for heavy, then the Mandarin for soft, then say *yìng* again

Before you move on

What does yìng mean? ("Hard; stiff".) Say it once more.

134.5 kōng — empty

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for soft, then the Mandarin for hard to the touch.

You'll want to know: kōng

kōng — "empty".

bīngxiāng shì kōng de — The fridge is empty.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

kōng is inherited from Middle Chinese *khuwng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'empty, hollow'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: kōng*
- *Say it: kōng*, once more
- *Say it: bīngxiāng shì kōng de* — The fridge is empty.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for soft, then the Mandarin for hard to the touch, then say *kōng* again

Before you move on

What does kōng mean? ("Empty".) Say it once more.

134.6 mǎn — full

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hard to the touch, then the Mandarin for empty.

You'll want to know: mǎn

mǎn — "full".

wǒ de bēizi mǎn le — My cup is full.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

mǎn is inherited from Middle Chinese *manX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'full' and 'to fill'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: mǎn*
- *Say it: mǎn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de bēizi mǎn le* — My cup is full.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hard to the touch, then the Mandarin for empty, then say *mǎn* again

Before you move on

What does mǎn mean? ("Full".) Say it once more.

134.7 Looking back: from Quiet and Noisy to Heavy and Soft

Say the Mandarin for quiet and noisy.

Your turn

- *Say it:* quiet, noisy, bustling, convenient, interesting
- *Say it:* a sick person, to catch a cold, to have a fever, sore, to see a doctor
- *Say it:* spring, summer, autumn, winter, season
- *Say it:* thousand, ten thousand, zero, in all, to count
- *Say it:* to clean (a room), housework, to tidy up, to wipe, to fold
- *Say it:* heavy, soft, hard to the touch, empty, full
- *Read it:* 吵 病 春 千 扫 重 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Quiet? (*ānjìng.*) Noisy? (吵, *chǎo.*) Bustling? (*rènao.*) Convenient? (*fāngbiàn.*) Interesting? (*yǒuyìsi.*) A sick person? (病人, *bìngrén.*) To catch a cold? (*gǎnmào.*) To have a fever? (*fāshāo.*) Sore? (*téng.*) To see a doctor? (看病, *kànbìng.*) Spring? (春天, *chūntiān.*) Summer? (*xiàtiān.*) Autumn? (*qiūtiān.*) Winter? (*dōngtiān.*) Season? (*jìjié.*) Thousand? (千, *qiān.*) Ten thousand? (*wàn.*) Zero? (*líng.*) In all? (*yígòng.*) To count? (*shǔ.*) To clean (a room)? (打扫, *dǎsǎo.*) Housework? (*jiāwù.*) To tidy up? (*shōushi.*) To wipe? (*cā.*) To fold? (*dié.*) Heavy? (重, *zhòng.*) Soft? (*ruǎn.*) Hard to the touch? (*yìng.*) Empty? (*kōng.*) Full? (*mǎn.*)

Chapter 135

Sport

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about football, basketball, matches and working out.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 135: I can talk about football, basketball, matches and working out.*

135.1 zúqiú — football; soccer

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for empty, then the Mandarin for full.

You'll want to know: zúqiú

zúqiú — "football; soccer".

> *wǒ xǐhuan zúqiú* — I love football.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zúqiú is built from *zú* 'foot' and *qiú* 'ball', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsjowk* and *gjuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses *gjuw* as 'fine jade', and under another way of writing it as a ball of fur that is struck.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: zúqiú*
- *Say it: zúqiú*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan zúqiú* — I love football.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for empty, then the Mandarin for full, then say *zúqiú* again

Before you move on

What does zúqiú mean? ("Football; soccer".) Say it once more.

135.2 lánqiú — basketball

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for full, then the Mandarin for football.

You'll want to know: lánqiú

lánqiú — "basketball".

wǒ gēge hěn gāo tā xǐhuan lánqiú — My brother is tall, and he loves basketball.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lánqiú is built from *lán* 'basket' and *qiú* 'ball'. The first is inherited from Middle Chinese *lam* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'a basket', a different word from the *lán* of blue; the second is the *qiú* of football.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: lánqiú*
- *Say it: lánqiú*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ gēge hěn gāo tā xǐhuan lánqiú* — My brother is tall, and he loves basketball.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for full, then the Mandarin for football, then say *lánqiú* again

Before you move on

What does lánqiú mean? ("Basketball".) Say it once more.

135.3 tī — to kick

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for football, then the Mandarin for basketball.

You'll want to know: tī

tī — "to kick".

wǒmen qù tī zúqiú — We're off to play football.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tī The character is in the Guangyun as *thek* (in Baxter's transcription), but only in the name of a beast; the verb is not given there. No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: tī*
- *Say it: tī*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen qù tī zúqiú* — We're off to play football.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for football, then the Mandarin for basketball, then say *tī* again

Before you move on

What does tī mean? ("To kick".) Say it once more.

135.4 bǐsài — match; competition

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for basketball, then the Mandarin for to kick.

You'll want to know: bǐsài

bǐsài — "match; competition".

jīntiān yǒu zúqiú bǐsài — There's a football match today.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bǐsài is built from *bǐ* 'to compare' and *sài*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjijX* and *sojH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the second 'to repay'; how the pair came to mean a match is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: bǐsài*
- *Say it: bǐsài*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān yǒu zúqiú bǐsài* — There's a football match today.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for basketball, then the Mandarin for to kick, then say *bǐsài* again

Before you move on

What does bǐsài mean? ("Match; competition".) Say it once more.

135.5 duànliàn — to exercise; to work out

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to kick, then the Mandarin for a match.

You'll want to know: duànliàn

duànliàn — "to exercise; to work out".

wǒ xǐhuan zǎoshang duànliàn — I like working out in the morning.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

duànliàn is built from *duàn* 'to forge iron' and *liàn* 'to refine metal', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *twanH* and *lenH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The pair said of the body is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: duànliàn*
- *Say it: duànliàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan zǎoshang duànliàn* — I like working out in the morning.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to kick, then the Mandarin for a match, then say *duànliàn* again

Before you move on

What does duànliàn mean? ("To exercise; to work out".) Say it once more.

Chapter 136

Because of the Weather

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give the weather as a reason: sunny, overcast, windy, thundery or cool.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 136: I can give the weather as a reason: sunny, overcast, windy, thundery or cool.*

136.1 qíngtiān — sunny day; fine weather

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a match, then the Mandarin for to work out.

You'll want to know: qíngtiān

qíngtiān — "sunny day; fine weather".

> *jīntiān shì qíngtiān wǒ xiǎng chūmén* — It's a sunny day, so I feel like going out.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qíngtiān is built from *qíng* 'clear' and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzjeng* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'the sky clearing'.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: qíngtiān*
- *Say it: qíngtiān*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān shì qíngtiān wǒ xiǎng chūmén* — It's a sunny day, so I feel like going out.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a match, then the Mandarin for to work out, then say *qíngtiān* again

Before you move on

What does qíngtiān mean? ("Sunny day; fine weather".) Say it once more.

136.2 yīntiān — overcast day

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to work out, then the Mandarin for a sunny day.

You'll want to know: yīntiān

yīntiān — "overcast day".

jīntiān shì yīntiān yǒudiǎnr lěng — It's overcast today, and a bit cold.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yīntiān is built from *yīn* 'shade, dark' and 天 'sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *'im* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The first has the same old form as the 音 of 音乐 but is a different word.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: yīntiān*
- *Say it: yīntiān*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān shì yīntiān yǒudiǎnr lěng* — It's overcast today, and a bit cold.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to work out, then the Mandarin for a sunny day, then say *yīntiān* again

Before you move on

What does yīntiān mean? ("Overcast day".) Say it once more.

136.3 guāfēng — to be windy

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a sunny day, then the Mandarin for an overcast day.

You'll want to know: guāfēng

guāfēng — "to be windy".

wàibian guāfēng le — It's got windy outside.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guāfēng is built from *guā* 'to scrape' and *fēng* 'wind', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kwaet* and *pjuwng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). For the wind the first was once written with another character, which has no Guangyun reading, so how scraping came into the word is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: guāfēng*
- *Say it: guāfēng*, once more
- *Say it: wàibian guāfēng le* — It's got windy outside.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a sunny day, then the Mandarin for an overcast day, then say *guāfēng* again

Before you move on

What does guāfēng mean? ("To be windy".) Say it once more.

136.4 dǎléi — to thunder

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for an overcast day, then the Mandarin for to be windy.

You'll want to know: dǎléi

dǎléi — "to thunder".

dǎléi le wǒmen bù chūmén le — It's thundering, so we're staying in.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dǎléi is built from 扌丁 'to strike' and *léi* 'thunder', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *taengX* and *lwoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), though dǎ is not the sound *taengX* would regularly give. The dictionary explains the second, after an older book, as yin and yang pressing on each other.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: dǎléi*
- *Say it: dǎléi*, once more
- *Say it: dǎléi le wǒmen bù chūmén le* — It's thundering, so we're staying in.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for an overcast day, then the Mandarin for to be windy, then say *dǎléi* again

Before you move on

What does dǎléi mean? ("To thunder".) Say it once more.

136.5 liángkuai — pleasantly cool

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be windy, then the Mandarin for to thunder.

You'll want to know: liángkuai

liángkuai — "pleasantly cool".

qiūtiān hěn liángkuai — Autumn is nice and cool.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

liángkuai is built from *liáng* 'cool' and 快, glossed 'to one's liking', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ljang* and *khwaejH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): cool and pleasant.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: liángkuai*
- *Say it: liángkuai*, once more
- *Say it: qiūtiān hěn liángkuai* — Autumn is nice and cool.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be windy, then the Mandarin for to thunder, then say *liángkuai* again

Before you move on

What does liángkuai mean? ("Pleasantly cool".) Say it once more.

Chapter 137

Holidays

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about festivals, the Spring Festival, the New Year and time off.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 137: I can talk about festivals, the Spring Festival, the New Year and time off.*

137.1 节日 (jiérì) — festival

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to thunder, then the Mandarin for pleasantly cool.

You'll want to know: 节日

节日 — *jiérì* — "festival".

> 今天是什么节日 *jīntiān shì shénme jiérì* — What festival is it today?

The new character, in pieces: 节 — the grass piece on top, a bar crossed by two short verticals, and under it a bar that turns down into a hook, with a long vertical through it. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

节日 (*jiérì*) is built from 节 'a joint' and 日 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tset* and *nyit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription);

the dictionary quotes an older book for the first: the joint of a bamboo. A festival as a joint in the year is the likely image, though it is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiérì*
- *Say it: jiérì*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān shì shénme jiérì* — What festival is it today?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to thunder, then the Mandarin for pleasantly cool, then say *jiérì* again

Before you move on

What does 节日 mean? ("Festival".) Say it once more.

137.2 节 — the grass piece over a hook

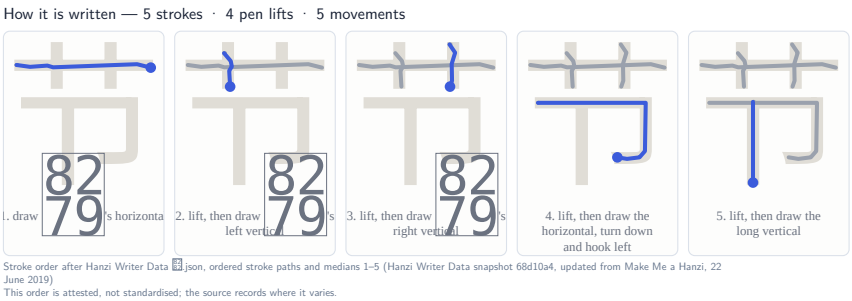
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *jiérì* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  菜 日

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *cài*, *rì*

Script — the grass piece over a hook



How 节 *is written, stroke by stroke*

节

Two pieces, top to bottom.

The grass piece, three strokes, as on top of 菜: a horizontal across, then a short vertical on the left and a short vertical on the right, both crossing it.

The lower piece, two strokes. A horizontal that turns down and ends in a hook to the left, then a long vertical down through it to the foot.

3 + 2 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 节, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many pieces in 节? (**Two**.) How many strokes in the grass piece? (**Three**.) Which stroke is the last? (**The long vertical**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 节, pinned stroke paths and medians.

137.3 春节 (Chūnjié) — the Spring Festival; Chinese New Year

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pleasantly cool, then the Mandarin for festival.

You'll want to know: 春节

春节 — *Chūnjié* — "the Spring Festival; Chinese New Year".

春节前大家都打扫 *Chūnjié qián dàjiā dōu dǎsǎo* — Before the festival, everybody cleans the house.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

春节 (*Chūnjié*) is built from 春 'spring' and 节 'festival', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyhwin* and *tset* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the festival at the head of spring.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: Chūnjié*
- *Say it: Chūnjié*, once more
- *Say it: Chūnjié qián dàjiā dōu dǎsǎo* — Before the festival, everybody cleans the house.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pleasantly cool, then the Mandarin for festival, then say *Chūnjié* again

Before you move on

What does 春节 mean? ("The Spring Festival; Chinese New Year".) Say it once more.

137.4 guònián — to celebrate the New Year

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for festival, then the Mandarin for Chinese New Year.

You'll want to know: guònián

guònián — "to celebrate the New Year".

> *guònián wǒmen chī jiǎozi* — We eat dumplings to see in the new year.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guònián is built from *guò* 'to pass' and 年 'year', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kwaH* and *nen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The pair is not given there; seeing the year through is the plain picture, but how it came to mean celebrating is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: guònián*
- *Say it: guònián*, once more
- *Say it: guònián wǒmen chī jiǎozi* — We eat dumplings to see in the new year.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for festival, then the Mandarin for Chinese New Year, then say *guònián* again

Before you move on

What does guònián mean? ("To celebrate the New Year".) Say it once more.

137.5 fàngjià — to have time off; to go on holiday

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for Chinese New Year, then the Mandarin for to celebrate the New Year.

You'll want to know: fàngjià

fàngjià — "to have time off; to go on holiday".

míngtiān wǒmen fàngjià — We're off tomorrow.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fàngjià is built from *fàng* 'to let go' and *jià* 'leave', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjangH* and *kaeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which glosses the second 'to borrow' and 'leave from duty'.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: fàngjià*
- *Say it: fàngjià*, once more
- *Say it: míngtiān wǒmen fàngjià* — We're off tomorrow.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for Chinese New Year, then the Mandarin for to celebrate the New Year, then say *fàngjià* again

Before you move on

What does fàngjià mean? ("To have time off; to go on holiday".) Say it once more.

137.6 jiàqī — holidays; time off

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to celebrate the New Year, then the Mandarin for to have time off.

You'll want to know: jiàqī

jiàqī — "holidays; time off".

> *fàngjià le jiàqī nǐ xiǎng qù nǎr* — We're on holiday now; where would you like to go?

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiàqī is built from *jià* 'leave' and 期 'a set time', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kaeH* and *gi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiàqī*
- *Say it: jiàqī*, once more
- *Say it: fàngjià le jiàqī nǐ xiǎng qù nǎr* — We're on holiday now; where would you like to go?
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to celebrate the New Year, then the Mandarin for to have time off, then say *jiàqī* again

Before you move on

What does jiàqī mean? ("Holidays; time off".) Say it once more.

Chapter 138

Every and Other

Modes: **voice** (5) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say every, myself, other people, all and the others.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 138: I can say every, myself, other people, all and the others.*

138.1 每 (měi) — every; each

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to have time off, then the Mandarin for the holidays.

You'll want to know: 每

每 — *měi* — "every; each".

> 我们每个星期六都打扫 *wǒmen měi ge xīngqīliù dōu dǎsǎo* — We clean the house every Saturday.

The new character, in pieces: 每 — a short fall and a short bar on top, then a box: a vertical that turns right along the bottom, a bar that turns down the right side and hooks, a dot, a long bar across, and a dot. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

每 (*měi*) is inherited from Middle Chinese *mwojX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'frequently' and as a particle. 'Every' is not among the glosses, so how it got that sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: měi*
- *Say it: měi*, once more
- *Say it: wǒmen měi ge xīngqīliù dōu dǎsǎo* — We clean the house every Saturday.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to have time off, then the Mandarin for the holidays, then say *měi* again

Before you move on

What does 每 mean? ("Every; each".) Say it once more.

138.2 每 — a fall and a bar over a dotted box

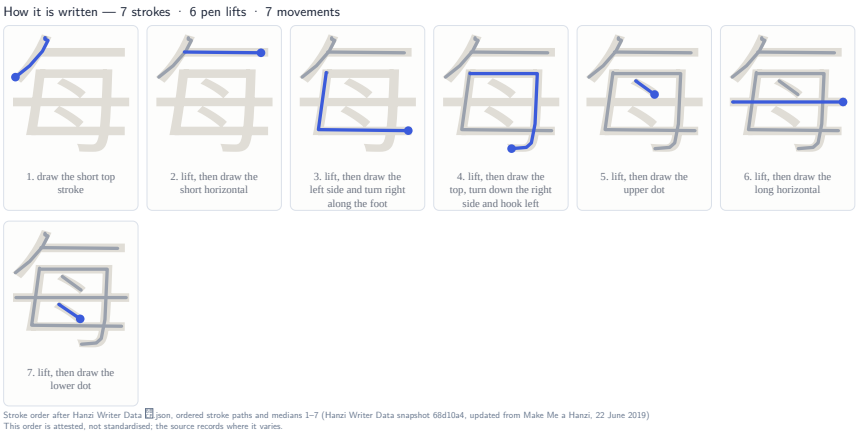
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *měi* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

  天 个

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *tiān*, *gè*

Script — a fall and a bar over a dotted box



How 每 is written, stroke by stroke

每

Two pieces, top to bottom.

The top, two strokes. A short left-falling stroke, then a short horizontal running right from it.

The box, five strokes. A vertical that runs down the left and turns right along the bottom; a horizontal across the top that turns down the right side, past the bottom, and hooks to the left; a dot inside the upper half; a long horizontal across the middle, out past both sides; then a dot inside the lower half.

2 + 5 = seven.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 每, all seven, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 每? (**Seven.**) Which stroke runs out past both sides? (**The long horizontal across the middle.**) Where are the

two dots? (**Inside the box, one above that bar and one below it**.)
Source: Hanzi Writer Data 每, pinned stroke paths and medians.

138.3 zìjǐ — oneself

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the holidays, then the Mandarin for each.

You'll want to know: zìjǐ

zìjǐ — "oneself".

wǒ zìjǐ zuòfàn — I cook for myself.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zìjǐ is built from *zì* 'from' and *jǐ* 'self', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzijH* and *kiX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which glosses the second 'one's own body'.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: zìjǐ*
- *Say it: zìjǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zìjǐ zuòfàn* — I cook for myself.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the holidays, then the Mandarin for each, then say *zìjǐ* again

Before you move on

What does zìjǐ mean? ("Oneself".) Say it once more.

138.4 biérén — other people

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for each, then the Mandarin for oneself.

You'll want to know: biérén

biérén — "other people".

wǒ de shū wǒ bù xiǎng gěi biérén — I don't want to give my books to anyone else.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

biérén is built from *bié* 'different', as in *biéde*, and 人 'person', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjet* and *nyin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: biérén*
- *Say it: biérén*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ de shū wǒ bù xiǎng gěi biérén* — I don't want to give my books to anyone else.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for each, then the Mandarin for oneself, then say *biérén* again

Before you move on

What does biérén mean? ("Other people".) Say it once more.

138.5 suǒyǒu — all; every

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for oneself, then the Mandarin for other people.

You'll want to know: suǒyǒu

suǒyǒu — "all; every".

> *suǒyǒu de rén dōu lái le* — Everyone has come.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
Two third tones: suǒyǒu is said suóyǒu, the first rising.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

suǒyǒu is built from *suǒ* 'a place', the *suǒ* of *suǒyǐ*, and 有 'to have', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *srjoX* and *hjuwX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How the pair came to mean all is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: suǒyǒu*
- *Say it: suǒyǒu*, once more
- *Say it: suǒyǒu de rén dōu lái le* — Everyone has come.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for oneself, then the Mandarin for other people, then say *suǒyǒu* again

Before you move on

What does suǒyǒu mean? ("All; every".) Say it once more.

138.6 qítā — other; the others

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for other people, then the Mandarin for every single.

You'll want to know: qítā

qítā — "other; the others".

> *wǒ xǐhuan zhège qítā de wǒ bú yào* — I like this one; I don't want the others.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

qítā is built from *qí*, which the dictionary lists as a particle, and 他, glossed 'not I', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *gi* and *tha* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for pointing things out.

Your turn

- *Say it: qítā*
- *Say it: qítā*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan zhège qítā de wǒ bú yào* — I like this one; I don't want the others.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for other people, then the Mandarin for every single, then say *qítā* again

Before you move on

What does qítā mean? ("Other; the others".) Say it once more.

Chapter 139

Colours and Shapes

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name green, yellow, grey and pink, and say that something is round.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 139: I can name green, yellow, grey and pink, and say that something is round.*

139.1 lǜ — green

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for every single, then the Mandarin for the others.

You'll want to know: lǜ

lǜ — "green".

> *chūntiān de cǎo hěn lǜ* — In spring the grass is very green.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǜ is inherited from Middle Chinese *ljowk* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the colour of blue and yellow'. The regular sound change would give *lù*; why the everyday word is *lǜ* is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǜ*
- *Say it: lǜ*, once more
- *Say it: chūntiān de cǎo hěn lǜ* — In spring the grass is very green.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for every single, then the Mandarin for the others, then say *lǜ* again

Before you move on

What does lǜ mean? ("Green".) Say it once more.

139.2 huáng — yellow

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the others, then the Mandarin for green.

You'll want to know: huáng

huáng — "yellow".

zhège píngguǒ shì huáng de — This apple is a yellow one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huáng is inherited from Middle Chinese *hwang* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the colour of the centre'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: huáng*
- *Say it: huáng*, once more
- *Say it: zhège píngguǒ shì huáng de* — This apple is a yellow one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the others, then the Mandarin for green, then say *huáng* again

Before you move on

What does huáng mean? ("Yellow".) Say it once more.

139.3 huī — grey

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for green, then the Mandarin for yellow.

You'll want to know: huī

huī — "grey".

wǒ de māo shì huī de — My cat is a grey one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

huī is inherited from Middle Chinese *xwoj* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), which quotes an older book: 'dead fire', that is, ash. The colour of ash is the likely step to grey, though it is not given there.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: huī*
- *Say it: huī*, once more

- *Say it: wǒ de māo shì huī de* — My cat is a grey one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for green, then the Mandarin for yellow, then say *huī* again

Before you move on

What does huī mean? ("Grey".) Say it once more.

139.4 yuán — round

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for yellow, then the Mandarin for grey.

You'll want to know: yuán

yuán — "round".

zhè zhāng zhuōzi shì yuán de — This table is a round one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yuán is inherited from Middle Chinese *hjwen* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the form of heaven'. The plain sense round is not among the glosses, so the step is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: yuán*
- *Say it: yuán*, once more
- *Say it: zhè zhāng zhuōzi shì yuán de* — This table is a round one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for yellow, then the Mandarin for grey, then say *yuán* again

Before you move on

What does yuán mean? (“Round”.) Say it once more.

139.5 fěnhóng — pink

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for grey, then the Mandarin for round.

You’ll want to know: fěnhóng

fěnhóng — “pink”.

tā de màozi shì fěnhóng de — Her hat is a pink one.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fěnhóng is built from *fěn* ’powder’ and *hóng* ’red’, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjunX* and *huwng* (Guangyun, in Baxter’s transcription): red as pale as face powder. The dictionary glosses the first with a powder made by burning lead.

What you’ve built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: fěnhóng*
- *Say it: fěnhóng*, once more
- *Say it: tā de màozi shì fěnhóng de* — Her hat is a pink one.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for grey, then the Mandarin for round, then say *fěnhóng* again

Before you move on

What does fěnhóng mean? (“Pink”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 140

First and Half

Modes: **voice** (6) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** the first 2 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say first, half, how many times, the most, and work a sum out.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 140: I can say first, half, how many times, the most, and work a sum out.*

140.1 dìyī — first

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for round, then the Mandarin for pink.

You'll want to know: dìyī

dìyī — "first".

zhè shì wǒ de dìyī ge shǒujī — This is my first phone.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

— keeps its first tone here: in a number that gives an order, yī does not change its tone.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

dìyī is built from *dì* 'order, rank' and — 'one', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dejH* and *'jit* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: dìyī*
- *Say it: dìyī*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ de dìyī ge shǒujī* — This is my first phone.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for round, then the Mandarin for pink, then say *dìyī* again

Before you move on

What does dìyī mean? ("First".) Say it once more.

140.2 一半 (yíbàn) — one half; half (of something)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for pink, then the Mandarin for first.

You'll want to know: 一半

一半 — *yíbàn* — "one half; half (of something)".

两千的一半是一千 *liǎngqiān de yíbàn shì yìqiān* — Half of two thousand is one thousand.

The new character, in pieces: 半 — two short dots on top, two bars, and a long vertical down through them. The next lesson puts it in your hand.

The tone of 一 changes: yī is said yí before the fourth tone of bàn.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

一半 (*yíbàn*) is built from 一 'one' and 半, inherited from Middle Chinese *'jit* and *panH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'a thing divided in the middle', the *bàn* of half past.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: yíbàn*
- *Say it: yíbàn*, once more
- *Say it: liǎngqiān de yíbàn shì yìqiān* — Half of two thousand is one thousand.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for pink, then the Mandarin for first, then say *yíbàn* again

Before you move on

What does 一半 mean? ("One half; half (of something)".) Say it once more.

140.3 半 — two dots, two bars, one vertical

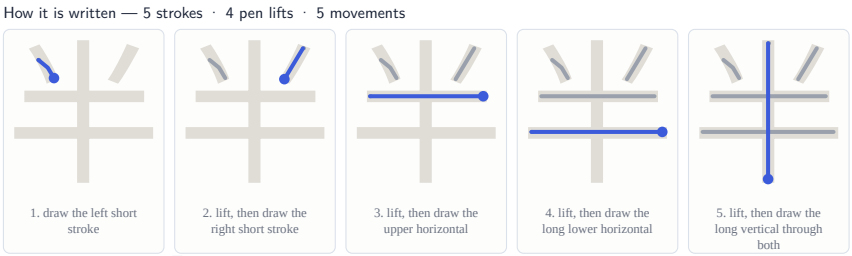
The word first, then the character inside it.

- *Recall:* say *yíbàn* — **R1**, one lesson back, before it decays

二 千

Read it: each one aloud, with nothing said first — *èr*, *qiān*

Script — two dots, two bars, one vertical



Stroke order after Hanzi Writer Data 半.json, ordered stroke paths and medians 1–5 (Hanzi Writer Data snapshot 68d10a4, updated from Make Me a Hanzi, 22 June 2019)
This order is attested, not standardised; the source records where it varies.

How 半 is written, stroke by stroke

半

One piece, five strokes.

Two short dots at the top, leaning toward each other: the left one falls to the lower right, the right one to the lower left.

Two horizontals, short over long, the two bars of 二.

A long vertical from above the shorter bar, straight down through both to the foot.

2 + 2 + 1 = five.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 半, all five, with the model in front of you
- *Cover:* write it again from memory, and count the pieces, not the strokes

Before you move on

How many strokes in 半? (**Five**.) Which way do the two dots lean? (**Toward each other**.) What comes last? (**The long vertical**.) Source: Hanzi Writer Data 半, pinned stroke paths and medians.

140.4 cì — time (one occurrence)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for first, then the Mandarin for one half.

You'll want to know: cì

cì — "time (one occurrence)".

zhè shì wǒ dìyī cì lái Běijīng — This is my first time in Beijing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

cì is inherited from Middle Chinese *tshijH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'order, sequence' and 'a halt on a journey'.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: cì*
- *Say it: cì*, once more
- *Say it: zhè shì wǒ dìyī cì lái Běijīng* — This is my first time in Beijing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for first, then the Mandarin for one half, then say *cì* again

Before you move on

What does cì mean? ("Time (one occurrence)".) Say it once more.

140.5 zuì — most

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for one half, then the Mandarin for one occurrence.

You'll want to know: zuì

zuì — "most".

wǒ zuì xǐhuan chūntiān — Spring is my favourite.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zuì is inherited from Middle Chinese *tswajH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'utmost'.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: zuì*
- *Say it: zuì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zuì xǐhuan chūntiān* — Spring is my favourite.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for one half, then the Mandarin for one occurrence, then say *zuì* again

Before you move on

What does zuì mean? ("Most".) Say it once more.

140.6 suàn — to calculate; to work out

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for one occurrence, then the Mandarin for most.

You'll want to know: suàn

suàn — "to calculate; to work out".

wǒ suàn le yígòng shì sānshí kuài — I've worked it out: thirty yuan in all.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

suàn is inherited from Middle Chinese *swanX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the number of things'. The regular sound change would give a third tone, *suǎn*, not *suàn*; why is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for counting.

Your turn

- *Say it: suàn*
- *Say it: suàn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ suàn le yígòng shì sānshí kuài* — I've worked it out: thirty yuan in all.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for one occurrence, then the Mandarin for most, then say *suàn* again

Before you move on

What does suàn mean? ("To calculate; to work out".) Say it once more.

140.7 Looking back: from Sport to First and Half

Say the Mandarin for football and basketball.

Your turn

- *Say it:* football, basketball, to kick, a match, to work out
- *Say it:* a sunny day, an overcast day, to be windy, to thunder, pleasantly cool
- *Say it:* festival, Chinese New Year, to celebrate the New Year, to have time off, the holidays
- *Say it:* each, oneself, other people, every single, the others
- *Say it:* green, yellow, grey, round, pink
- *Say it:* first, one half, one occurrence, most, to calculate
- *Read it:* 节 每 半 — each one aloud, then a word that holds it

Before you move on

Football? (*zúqiú.*) Basketball? (*lánqiú.*) To kick? (*tī.*) A match? (*bǐsài.*) To work out? (*duànliàn.*) A sunny day? (*qíngtiān.*) An

overcast day? (*yīntiān.*) To be windy? (*guāfēng.*) To thunder? (*dǎléi.*) Pleasantly cool? (*liángkuai.*) Festival? (节日, *jiérì.*) Chinese New Year? (春节, *Chūnjié.*) To celebrate the New Year? (*guònián.*) To have time off? (*fàngjià.*) The holidays? (*jiàqī.*) Each? (每, *měi.*) Oneself? (*zìjǐ.*) Other people? (*biérén.*) Every single? (*suǒyǒu.*) The others? (*qítā.*) Green? (*lǜ.*) Yellow? (*huáng.*) Grey? (*huī.*) Round? (*yuán.*) Pink? (*fěnhóng.*) First? (*dìyī.*) One half? (一半, *yíbàn.*) One occurrence? (*cì.*) Most? (*zuì.*) To calculate? (*suàn.*)

Chapter 141

Travel and Fun

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about travelling, games, going round the shops, walks and fishing.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 141: I can talk about travelling, games, going round the shops, walks and fishing.*

141.1 lǚyóu — to travel; to tour

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for most, then the Mandarin for to calculate.

You'll want to know: lǚyóu

lǚyóu — "to travel; to tour".

> *wǒ xǐhuan lǚyóu* — I love travelling.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lǚyóu is built from *lǚ* and *yóu*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ljoX* and *yuw* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'a body of troops' and the second 'to float, to roam', the *yóu* of *yóuyǒng*. 'Journey' for the first is not given there; how it got that sense is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: lǚyóu*
- *Say it: lǚyóu*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ xǐhuan lǚyóu* — I love travelling.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for most, then the Mandarin for to calculate, then say *lǚyóu* again

Before you move on

What does lǚyóu mean? ("To travel; to tour".) Say it once more.

141.2 yóuxì — game

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to calculate, then the Mandarin for to travel.

You'll want to know: yóuxì

yóuxì — "game".

wǒ érzi hěn xǐhuan wán yóuxì — My son loves playing games.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yóuxì is built from *yóu* 'to roam' and *xì* 'to play, to tease', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yuw* and *xjeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: yóuxì*
- *Say it: yóuxì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ érzi hěn xǐhuan wán yóuxì* — My son loves playing games.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to calculate, then the Mandarin for to travel, then say *yóuxì* again

Before you move on

What does yóuxì mean? ("Game".) Say it once more.

141.3 guàngjiē — to stroll the shops; to go window-shopping

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to travel, then the Mandarin for a game.

You'll want to know: guàngjiē

guàngjiē — "to stroll the shops; to go window-shopping".

zhōumò wǒmen qù guàngjiē — At the weekend we're going round the shops.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

guàngjiē is built from *guàng* and *jiē* 'street', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kjwangX* and *kea* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'the look of walking'; the regular sound change would give it a third tone, so the fourth tone of *guàng* is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: guàngjiē*
- *Say it: guàngjiē*, once more
- *Say it: zhōumò wǒmen qù guàngjiē* — At the weekend we're going round the shops.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to travel, then the Mandarin for a game, then say *guàngjiē* again

Before you move on

What does guàngjiē mean? ("To stroll the shops; to go window-shopping".) Say it once more.

141.4 sànbù — to take a walk

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a game, then the Mandarin for to stroll the shops.

You'll want to know: sànbù

sànbù — "to take a walk".

wǎnfàn yǐhòu wǒmen qù sànbù — After dinner we go for a walk.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

sànbù is built from *sàn* 'to scatter, to spread out' and *bù* 'step', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *sanH* and *buH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): steps let loose.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: sànbù*
- *Say it: sànbù*, once more
- *Say it: wǎnfàn yǐhòu wǒmen qù sànbù* — After dinner we go for a walk.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a game, then the Mandarin for to stroll the shops, then say *sànbù* again

Before you move on

What does sànbù mean? ("To take a walk".) Say it once more.

141.5 diàoyú — to go fishing

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to stroll the shops, then the Mandarin for to take a walk.

You'll want to know: diàoyú

diàoyú — "to go fishing".

wǒ bàba xǐhuan diàoyú — My dad loves fishing.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

diàoyú is built from *diào* 'to angle' and *yú* 'fish', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tewH* and *ngjo* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first with this very word, 'to fish'.

What you've built

One more word for what I like.

Your turn

- *Say it: diàoyú*
- *Say it: diàoyú*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bàba xǐhuan diàoyú* — My dad loves fishing.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to stroll the shops, then the Mandarin for to take a walk, then say *diàoyú* again

Before you move on

What does diàoyú mean? ("To go fishing".) Say it once more.

Chapter 142

More Housework

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about mopping, rubbish, drying things in the sun, sorting things out and watering the plants.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 142: I can talk about mopping, rubbish, drying things in the sun, sorting things out and watering the plants.*

142.1 tuōdì — to mop the floor

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to take a walk, then the Mandarin for to go fishing.

You'll want to know: tuōdì

tuōdì — "to mop the floor".

> *wǒ měitiān tuōdì* — I mop the floor every day.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tuōdì is built from *tuō* 'to drag' and *dì* 'ground', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tha* and *dijH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'to drag' under an older way of writing it, and notes that it is popularly written the modern way; *tha* is also the old form of the word for he, a different word.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: tuōdì*
- *Say it: tuōdì*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ měitiān tuōdì* — I mop the floor every day.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to take a walk, then the Mandarin for to go fishing, then say *tuōdì* again

Before you move on

What does tuōdì mean? ("To mop the floor".) Say it once more.

142.2 lājī — rubbish

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to go fishing, then the Mandarin for to mop the floor.

You'll want to know: lājī

lājī — "rubbish".

ménkǒu yǒu lājī — There's rubbish by the door.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

lājī No dictionary we use records an older form, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: lājī*
- *Say it: lājī*, once more
- *Say it: ménkǒu yǒu lājī* — There's rubbish by the door.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to go fishing, then the Mandarin for to mop the floor, then say *lājī* again

Before you move on

What does lājī mean? ("Rubbish".) Say it once more.

142.3 shài — to dry in the sun

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to mop the floor, then the Mandarin for rubbish.

You'll want to know: shài

shài — "to dry in the sun".

jīntiān shì qíngtiān wǒmen shài yīfu — It's a sunny day, so we're putting the washing out to dry.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shài is inherited from Middle Chinese *sreaH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'to sun, to expose to the sun'.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: shài*
- *Say it: shài*, once more

- *Say it: jīntiān shì qíngtiān wǒmen shài yīfu* — It's a sunny day, so we're putting the washing out to dry.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to mop the floor, then the Mandarin for rubbish, then say *shài* again

Before you move on

What does shài mean? ("To dry in the sun".) Say it once more.

142.4 zhěnglǐ — to sort out; to put in order

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for rubbish, then the Mandarin for to dry in the sun.

You'll want to know: zhěnglǐ

zhěnglǐ — "to sort out; to put in order".

wǒ zhěnglǐ le wǒ de shū — I've sorted out my books.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.
Two third tones: zhěnglǐ is said zhénglǐ, the first rising.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhěnglǐ is built from *zhěng* 'straight, even' and *lǐ* 'to put in order', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsyengX* and *liX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary quotes an older book for the second: to work jade.

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhěnglǐ*
- *Say it: zhěnglǐ*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ zhěnglǐ le wǒ de shū* — I've sorted out my books.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for rubbish, then the Mandarin for to dry in the sun, then say *zhěnglǐ* again

Before you move on

What does zhěnglǐ mean? ("To sort out; to put in order".) Say it once more.

142.5 jiāohuā — to water the plants

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to dry in the sun, then the Mandarin for to sort out.

You'll want to know: jiāohuā

jiāohuā — "to water the plants".

jīntiān nǐ jiāohuā wǒ tuōdì — Today you water the plants and I'll mop the floor.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiāohuā is built from *jiāo* 'to pour water on' and *huā* 'flower', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kew* and *xwae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for everyday actions.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiāohuā*
- *Say it: jiāohuā*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān nǐ jiāohuā wǒ tuōdì* — Today you water the plants and I'll mop the floor.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to dry in the sun, then the Mandarin for to sort out, then say *jiāohuā* again

Before you move on

What does jiāohuā mean? ("To water the plants".) Say it once more.

Chapter 143

Clock Words

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say seconds and minutes, the minutes before the hour, and when things begin and end.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 143: I can say seconds and minutes, the minutes before the hour, and when things begin and end.*

143.1 miǎo — second (of time)

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to sort out, then the Mandarin for to water the plants.

You'll want to know: miǎo

miǎo — "second (of time)".

> *qǐng děng wǔ miǎo* — Please wait five seconds.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

miǎo is inherited from Middle Chinese *mjiewX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'the beard of grain'. The tiny unit of time is not given there; the step from something very fine is the likely one, but it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: miǎo*
- *Say it: miǎo*, once more
- *Say it: qǐng děng wǔ miǎo* — Please wait five seconds.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to sort out, then the Mandarin for to water the plants, then say *miǎo* again

Before you move on

What does miǎo mean? ("Second (of time)".) Say it once more.

143.2 fēnzhōng — minute (a length of time)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to water the plants, then the Mandarin for second (of time).

You'll want to know: fēnzhōng

fēnzhōng — "minute (a length of time)".

shí fēnzhōng yǐhòu wǒmen zǒu — We're leaving in ten minutes.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

fēnzhōng is built from *fēn*, the minute of the clock, and *zhōng* 'bell', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *pjun* and *tsyowng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second as a musical instrument.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: fēnzhōng*
- *Say it: fēnzhōng*, once more
- *Say it: shí fēnzhōng yǐhòu wǒmen zǒu* — We're leaving in ten minutes.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to water the plants, then the Mandarin for second (of time), then say *fēnzhōng* again

Before you move on

What does fēnzhōng mean? ("Minute (a length of time)".) Say it once more.

143.3 chà — to be short of; to (before the hour)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for second (of time), then the Mandarin for minute (a length of time).

You'll want to know: chà

chà — "to be short of; to (before the hour)".

xiànzài chà wǔ fēn bā diǎn — It's five to eight now.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

chà is inherited from Middle Chinese, where the Guangyun lists several readings; *tsrhae* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription) is glossed 'to choose' and 'amiss'. None of them gives the fourth tone of *chà* by the regular sound change, so how this reading came is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: chà*
- *Say it: chà*, once more
- *Say it: xiànzài chà wǔ fēn bā diǎn* — It's five to eight now.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for second (of time), then the Mandarin for minute (a length of time), then say *chà* again

Before you move on

What does chà mean? ("To be short of; to (before the hour)".) Say it once more.

143.4 zhǔnshí — on time; punctual

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for minute (a length of time), then the Mandarin for to be short of.

You'll want to know: zhǔnshí

zhǔnshí — "on time; punctual".

huǒchē hěn zhǔnshí — The trains run on time.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

zhǔnshí is built from *zhǔn* 'level, a standard', the *zhǔn* of *zhǔnbèi*, and 时 'time', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *tsywinX* and *dzyi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): true to the time.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhǔnshí*
- *Say it: zhǔnshí*, once more
- *Say it: huǒchē hěn zhǔnshí* — The trains run on time.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for minute (a length of time), then the Mandarin for to be short of, then say *zhǔnshí* again

Before you move on

What does zhǔnshí mean? ("On time; punctual".) Say it once more.

143.5 半天 (bàntiān) — a long while; half a day

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to be short of, then the Mandarin for punctual.

You'll want to know: 半天

半天 — *bàntiān* — "a long while; half a day".

wǒ děng le bàntiān — I waited for ages.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

半天 (*bàntiān*) is built from 半 'half' and 天 'day', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *panH* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): half a day, and in everyday talk, often with a sigh, a long while.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: bàntiān*
- *Say it: bàntiān*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ děng le bàntiān* — I waited for ages.

- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to be short of, then the Mandarin for punctual, then say *bàntiān* again

Before you move on

What does 半天 mean? ("A long while; half a day".) Say it once more.

Chapter 144

Easy and Important

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say a thing is important, easy, simple or special, and what I think of it.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 144: I can say a thing is important, easy, simple or special, and what I think of it.*

144.1 重要 (zhòngyào) — important

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for punctual, then the Mandarin for a long while.

You'll want to know: 重要

重要 — *zhòngyào* — "important".

> 每天喝水很重要 *měitiān hē shuǐ hěn zhòngyào* — Drinking water every day is important.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

重要 (*zhòngyào*) is built from 重 'heavy' and 要, glossed 'to bind, to agree', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *drjowngX* and *'jiewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). How the pair came to mean important is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: zhòngyào*
- *Say it: zhòngyào*, once more
- *Say it: měitiān hē shuǐ hěn zhòngyào* — Drinking water every day is important.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for punctual, then the Mandarin for a long while, then say *zhòngyào* again

Before you move on

What does 重要 mean? ("Important".) Say it once more.

144.2 róngyì — easy

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a long while, then the Mandarin for important.

You'll want to know: róngyì

róngyì — "easy".

hànzì bù róngyì — Chinese characters aren't easy.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

róngyì is built from *róng* 'to hold' and *yì* 'easy', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yowng* and *yeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the second 'hard and easy' and 'simple'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: róngyì*
- *Say it: róngyì*, once more
- *Say it: hànzì bù róngyì* — Chinese characters aren't easy.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a long while, then the Mandarin for important, then say *róngyì* again

Before you move on

What does róngyì mean? ("Easy".) Say it once more.

144.3 jiǎndān — simple

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for important, then the Mandarin for easy.

You'll want to know: jiǎndān

jiǎndān — "simple".

zhège hěn jiǎndān — This one's simple.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

jiǎndān is built from *jiǎn* 'brief' and *dān* 'single', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *keanX* and *tan* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first as a slip of bamboo for writing on, and 'brief'.

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: jiǎndān*
- *Say it: jiǎndān*, once more
- *Say it: zhège hěn jiǎndān* — This one's simple.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for important, then the Mandarin for easy, then say *jiǎndān* again

Before you move on

What does jiǎndān mean? ("Simple".) Say it once more.

144.4 tèbié — special; especially

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for easy, then the Mandarin for simple.

You'll want to know: tèbié

tèbié — "special; especially".

zhège dìfang hěn tèbié — This place is special.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

tèbié is built from *tè* 'alone' and *bié* 'different', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *dok* and *bjet* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: tèbié*
- *Say it: tèbié*, once more

- *Say it: zhège dìfang hěn tèbié* — This place is special.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for easy, then the Mandarin for simple, then say *tèbié* again

Before you move on

What does tèbié mean? ("Special; especially".) Say it once more.

144.5 juéde — to find (that); to feel; to think (that)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for simple, then the Mandarin for special.

You'll want to know: juéde

juéde — "to find (that); to feel; to think (that)".

wǒ juéde hànyǔ hěn yǒuyìsi — I find Chinese interesting.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

juéde is built from *jué*, glossed 'to understand' and 'to wake', and *de*, from a word glossed 'to get', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *kaewk* and *tok* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for describing things.

Your turn

- *Say it: juéde*
- *Say it: juéde*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ juéde hànyǔ hěn yǒuyìsi* — I find Chinese interesting.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for simple, then the Mandarin for special, then say *juéde* again

Before you move on

What does juéde mean? (“To find (that); to feel; to think (that)”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 145

Late Again

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give reasons for being late: the train, the alarm clock, a lie-in.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 145: I can give reasons for being late: the train, the alarm clock, a lie-in.*

145.1 yuányīn — reason; cause

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for special, then the Mandarin for to find (that).

You'll want to know: yuányīn

yuányīn — "reason; cause".

> *wǒ bù zhīdào shì shénme yuányīn* — I don't know what the reason is.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yuányīn is built from *yuán* and 因 'because', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *ngjwon* and *'jin* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription). The dictionary glosses the first 'a broad plain' and the second 'to follow from'; how the first came to mean origin is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: yuányīn*
- *Say it: yuányīn*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bù zhīdào shì shénme yuányīn* — I don't know what the reason is.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for special, then the Mandarin for to find (that), then say *yuányīn* again

Before you move on

What does yuányīn mean? ("Reason; cause".) Say it once more.

145.2 晚点 (wǎndiǎn) — to run behind schedule; to be late (of a train or plane)

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to find (that), then the Mandarin for a reason.

You'll want to know: 晚点

晚点 — *wǎndiǎn* — "to run behind schedule; to be late (of a train or plane)".

> 火车晚点了半个小时 *huǒchē wǎndiǎn le bàn ge xiǎoshí* — The train was half an hour late.

Two third tones: wǎndiǎn is said wándiǎn, the first rising.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

晚点 (*wǎndiǎn*) is built from 晚 and 点, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *mjonX* and *temX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'dusk' and 'a dot'. Late against the hour is the sense of the pair, which the dictionary does not give.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: wǎndiǎn*
- *Say it: wǎndiǎn*, once more
- *Say it: huǒchē wǎndiǎn le bàn ge xiǎoshí* — The train was half an hour late.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to find (that), then the Mandarin for a reason, then say *wǎndiǎn* again

Before you move on

What does 晚点 mean? ("To run behind schedule; to be late (of a train or plane)".) Say it once more.

145.3 nàozhōng — alarm clock

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for a reason, then the Mandarin for to run behind schedule.

You'll want to know: nàozhōng

nàozhōng — "alarm clock".

wǒ méiyǒu nàozhōng suǒyǐ wǒ chídào le — I haven't got an alarm clock, so I was late.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

nàozhōng is built from *nào* 'to stir up', the *nao* of *rènao*, and *zhōng* 'bell', the *zhōng* of *fēnzhōng*, both inherited from Middle Chinese, *nraewH* and *tsyowng* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): a bell that stirs you up.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: nàozhōng*
- *Say it: nàozhōng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ méiyǒu nàozhōng suǒyǐ wǒ chídào le* — I haven't got an alarm clock, so I was late.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for a reason, then the Mandarin for to run behind schedule, then say *nàozhōng* again

Before you move on

What does nàozhōng mean? ("Alarm clock".) Say it once more.

145.4 shuì lǎnjiào — to sleep in; to lie in

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to run behind schedule, then the Mandarin for alarm clock.

You'll want to know: shuì lǎnjiào

shuì lǎnjiào — "to sleep in; to lie in".

jīntiān shì xīngqītiān wǒ xiǎng shuì lǎnjiào — It's Sunday, so I want a lie-in.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

shuì lǎnjiào is built from *shuì* 'to sleep', *lǎn* 'lazy' and *jiào* 'a sleep', all inherited from Middle Chinese, *dzyweH*, *lanX* and *kaewH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the last with the word *shuìjiào* itself.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: shuì lǎnjiào*
- *Say it: shuì lǎnjiào*, once more
- *Say it: jīntiān shì xīngqītiān wǒ xiǎng shuì lǎnjiào* — It's Sunday, so I want a lie-in.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to run behind schedule, then the Mandarin for alarm clock, then say *shuì lǎnjiào* again

Before you move on

What does shuì lǎnjiào mean? ("To sleep in; to lie in".) Say it once more.

145.5 gǎnkuài — quickly; hurry

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for alarm clock, then the Mandarin for to lie in.

You'll want to know: gǎnkuài

gǎnkuài — "quickly; hurry".

bā diǎn shàngkè wǒmen gǎnkuài zǒu — Class is at eight, so let's hurry.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

gǎnkuài is built from *gǎn* 'to hurry' and 快 'fast'. 快 is inherited from Middle Chinese *khwaejH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); no dictionary we use records an older form of the first, so its history is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for giving reasons.

Your turn

- *Say it: gǎnkuài*
- *Say it: gǎnkuài*, once more
- *Say it: bā diǎn shàngkè wǒmen gǎnkuài zǒu* — Class is at eight, so let's hurry.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for alarm clock, then the Mandarin for to lie in, then say *gǎnkuài* again

Before you move on

What does gǎnkuài mean? ("Quickly; hurry".) Say it once more.

Chapter 146

Day and Night

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about the daytime, the night, the middle of the night, waking up and what I usually do.
>
> *Complete the last lesson of chapter 146: I can talk about the daytime, the night, the middle of the night, waking up and what I usually do.*

146.1 白天 (báitiān) — daytime

> Before the new one: say the Mandarin for to lie in, then the Mandarin for hurry.

You'll want to know: 白天

白天 — *báitiān* — "daytime".

> 白天这儿很吵 *báitiān zhèr hěn chǎo* — It's noisy here in the daytime.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

白天 (*báitiān*) is built from 白 'white' and 天 'day, sky', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *baek* and *then* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the white, light part of the day.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: báitiān*
- *Say it: báitiān*, once more
- *Say it: báitiān zhèr hěn chǎo* — It's noisy here in the daytime.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for to lie in, then the Mandarin for hurry, then say *báitiān* again

Before you move on

What does 白天 mean? ("Daytime".) Say it once more.

146.2 yèli — at night

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for hurry, then the Mandarin for daytime.

You'll want to know: yèli

yèli — "at night".

yèli hěn lěng — It's cold at night.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

yèli is built from *yè* 'night' and 里 'inside', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *yaeH* and *liX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription); the dictionary glosses the first 'dusk' and 'a time to rest'.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: yèli*
- *Say it: yèli*, once more

- *Say it: yèli hěn lěng* — It's cold at night.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for hurry, then the Mandarin for daytime, then say *yèli* again

Before you move on

What does yèli mean? ("At night".) Say it once more.

146.3 bànyè — the middle of the night

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for daytime, then the Mandarin for at night.

You'll want to know: bànyè

bànyè — "the middle of the night".

wǒ bànyè è le — I got hungry in the middle of the night.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

bànyè is built from 半 'half' and *yè* 'night', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *panH* and *yaeH* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription).

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: bànyè*
- *Say it: bànyè*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bànyè è le* — I got hungry in the middle of the night.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for daytime, then the Mandarin for at night, then say *bànyè* again

Before you move on

What does bànyè mean? ("The middle of the night".) Say it once more.

146.4 xǐng — to wake up

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for at night, then the Mandarin for the middle of the night.

You'll want to know: xǐng

xǐng — "to wake up".

wǒ bànyè xǐng le yīnwèi wàibian hěn chǎo — I woke up in the middle of the night because it was noisy outside.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

xǐng is inherited from Middle Chinese *sengX* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription), glossed 'drunkenness passing off', that is, sobering up. Waking from sleep is not given there, so how the word came to it is not settled.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: xǐng*
- *Say it: xǐng*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ bànyè xǐng le yīnwèi wàibian hěn chǎo* — I woke up in the middle of the night because it was noisy outside.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for at night, then the Mandarin for the middle of the night, then say *xǐng* again

Before you move on

What does xǐng mean? ("To wake up".) Say it once more.

146.5 píngshí — usually; ordinarily

Before the new one: say the Mandarin for the middle of the night, then the Mandarin for to wake up.

You'll want to know: píngshí

píngshí — "usually; ordinarily".

wǒ píngshí qī diǎn qǐchuáng — I usually get up at seven.

Its characters come later; for now it is a word for the ear.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

píngshí is built from *píng* 'level, even' and 时 'time', both inherited from Middle Chinese, *bjaeng* and *dzyi* (Guangyun, in Baxter's transcription): the level, ordinary times.

What you've built

One more word for times of day.

Your turn

- *Say it: píngshí*
- *Say it: píngshí*, once more
- *Say it: wǒ píngshí qī diǎn qǐchuáng* — I usually get up at seven.
- *Recall:* say the Mandarin for the middle of the night, then the Mandarin for to wake up, then say *píngshí* again

Before you move on

What does píngshí mean? ("Usually; ordinarily".) Say it once more.

146.6 Looking back: from Travel and Fun to Day and Night

Say the Mandarin for to travel and a game.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to travel, a game, to stroll the shops, to take a walk, to go fishing
- to mop the floor, rubbish, to dry in the sun, to sort out, to water the plants
- second (of time), minute (a length of time), to be short of, punctual, a long while
- important, easy, simple, special, to find (that)
- a reason, to run behind schedule, alarm clock, to lie in, hurry
- daytime, at night, the middle of the night, to wake up, ordinarily

Before you move on

To travel? (*lǚyóu.*) A game? (*yóuxì.*) To stroll the shops? (*guàngjiē.*) To take a walk? (*sànbù.*) To go fishing? (*diàoyú.*) To mop the floor? (*tuōdì.*) Rubbish? (*lājī.*) To dry in the sun? (*shài.*) To sort out? (*zhěnglǐ.*) To water the plants? (*jiāohuā.*) Second (of time)? (*miǎo.*) Minute (a length of time)? (*fēnzhōng.*) To be short of? (*chà.*) Punctual? (*zhǔnshí.*) A long while? (半天, *bàntiān.*) Important? (重要, *zhòngyào.*) Easy? (*róngyì.*) Simple? (*jiǎndān.*) Special? (*tèbié.*) To find (that)? (*juéde.*) A reason? (*yuányīn.*) To run behind schedule? (晚点, *wǎndiǎn.*) Alarm clock? (*nàozhōng.*) To lie in? (*shuì lǎnjiào.*) Hurry? (*gǎnkuài.*) Daytime? (白天, *báitiān.*) At night? (*yèli.*) The middle of the night? (*bànyè.*) To wake up? (*xǐng.*) Ordinarily? (*píngshí.*)

146.7 Day and Night — once more

Say the Mandarin for daytime and at night.

Your turn

- *Say it:* daytime, at night, the middle of the night, to wake up, ordinarily

Before you move on

Daytime? (白天, *báitiān.*) At night? (*yèli.*) The middle of the night? (*bànyè.*) To wake up? (*xǐng.*) Ordinarily? (*píngshí.*)

Pronunciation & Character Guide

Reference material, never a gate. Every lesson teaches the sounds its own word needs, inline, and links here for anyone who wants the fuller picture. Nobody has to read this page before Lesson 1, and most readers never will.

The ids in each heading are the values a lesson's `sounds:` frontmatter list points at.

Why this page is different from every other track's

In an alphabetic or abugida track, "the sounds you'll need" is a list of *segments*: this letter is silent, that vowel is long, this consonant is retroflex. Each fact is attached to a letter, and the letter is on the page.

Mandarin adds a second, orthogonally different kind of fact. **Tone** rides on a whole syllable, is not written in the characters at all, and is *phonemic* — it distinguishes words the way a consonant does. A segmental note cannot express it. So this page has two halves: tones first, because they are the part an English speaker has no instinct for, then the segments.

The machine-readable form of the first half lives in the Chinese script reference under `tones` and `toneSandhi`.

Tones

Mandarin has four tones plus a neutral one. Pinyin writes the tone as a mark over the vowel; the characters do not record it anywhere.

The classic demonstration uses one syllable, *ma*:

- `tone-1` — first, high level (contour 55). Held high and flat, one steady note. *mā* — mother.
- `tone-2` — second, rising (35). Climbs from mid to high, like the pitch on a surprised English "huh?". *má* — hemp.

- `tone-3` — third, dipping (214). Sinks low and creaky; said alone it rises again a little at the end, but in running speech it usually just stays low. *mǎ* — horse.
- `tone-4` — fourth, falling (51). Drops sharply from high to low, like a clipped "No!". *mà* — to scold.
- `tone-neutral` — unstressed. Short and light, with no mark written at all, pitched by whatever came before it. *ma* — a question particle.

tone-lexical — tone is part of the word

The single fact that matters most, taught in the first lesson: changing the pitch of a Mandarin syllable changes **which word it is**, not how you feel about it. *mā*, *má*, *mǎ* and *mà* are four separate words. English uses pitch for mood and emphasis only, so this is a genuinely new job for an English speaker's voice.

tone-sandhi-third — two third tones in a row

When a third tone is followed by another third tone, the first is spoken as a rising second tone.

Written **nǐ hǎo**, said **ní hǎo**. Neither the pinyin nor the characters record the change; dictionaries print the citation tone each word carries alone. This is why a reader who trusts only the page mispronounces the commonest greeting in the language.

tone-sandhi-bu — 不 before a fourth tone

不 *bù* is said *bú* when the next syllable has a fourth tone: *bù shì* → *bú shì*. Taught in full on 不是, the first collocation in the track that forces it.

Segments

Pinyin is a romanization, not English spelling. A few letters do work you would not guess.

- `pinyin-n` — as in English *no*.
- `pinyin-i` — after most consonants, the *ee* of "see". (After *z-*, *c-*, *s-*, *zh-*, *ch-*, *sh-*, *r-* it is a different, buzzier vowel; no Chapter 1 word uses those.)

- `pinyin-h` — rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth, closer to the *ch* of Scottish *loch* softened.
- `pinyin-ao` — one gliding vowel, the *ow* of "how". Not two syllables.

The characters themselves

Stroke shapes, components, and stroke order for every character this track has introduced live in Chinese script reference. Unlike the Indic scripts in this curriculum, where stroke order is conventional, Chinese stroke order is a **taught, standardised system** — top before bottom, left before right, horizontal before vertical, outside before inside, and close a box last. That file marks its stroke orders `authoritative` for exactly that reason.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

ài
to love
Introduced in Chapter 55.

ǎi
short in height; low
Introduced in Chapter 61.

ānjìng
quiet
Introduced in Chapter 129.

八 *bā*
eight — first tone, and the luckiest number in the language
Introduced in Chapter 20.

bàba
dad; father
Introduced in Chapter 32.

白 *bái*
white; pale
Introduced in Chapter 60.

bàibai
bye-bye
Introduced in Chapter 76.

白菜 *báicài*
Chinese cabbage
Introduced in Chapter 101.

白天 *báitiān*
daytime
Introduced in Chapter 146.

bàn
half
Introduced in Chapter 48.

bān
to move house; to move (something heavy)
Introduced in Chapter 107.

bāng
to help
Introduced in Chapter 64.

bāngmáng
to help out; to do a favour
Introduced in Chapter 64.

半天 *bàntiān*
a long while; half a day
Introduced in Chapter 143.

bànyè
the middle of the night
Introduced in Chapter 146.

bāo
bag
Introduced in Chapter 58.

bāoguǒ
parcel; package
Introduced in Chapter 118.

bāozi
steamed bun
Introduced in Chapter 70.

bēi
a cup of; a glass of (a measure word)
Introduced in Chapter 88.

běibian
the north; on the north side
Introduced in Chapter 117.

Běijīng
Beijing
Introduced in Chapter 36.

bēizi
cup; glass
Introduced in Chapter 58.

běn
(a measure word for books)
Introduced in Chapter 88.

本子 *běnzi*
notebook
Introduced in Chapter 104.

bǐ
pen
Introduced in Chapter 104.

biéde
something else; other
Introduced in Chapter 92.

biérén
other people
Introduced in Chapter 138.

bìng
to fall ill; illness
Introduced in Chapter 50.

bǐnggān
biscuit; cracker
Introduced in Chapter 102.

病人 *bìngrén*
patient; sick person
Introduced in Chapter 130.

bīngxiāng
fridge; refrigerator
Introduced in Chapter 87.

bǐsài
match; competition
Introduced in Chapter 135.

不 *bù*
not — the character that turns a word around
Introduced in Chapter 4.

bù hǎoyìsi
excuse me; sorry to trouble you
Introduced in Chapter 65.

不客气 *bú kèqi*
you're welcome; don't mention it
Introduced in Chapter 77.

不是 *bú shì*
is not — and a pitch that moves to get out of the way
Introduced in Chapter 5.

不谢 *bú xiè*
you're welcome — real and understood everywhere, though not the commonest reply, which needs characters this book cannot yet print
Introduced in Chapter 10.

不要 *bú yào*
don't; do not want
Introduced in Chapter 91.

cā
to wipe
Introduced in Chapter 133.

cài
dish of food; vegetable
Introduced in Chapter 38.

càidān
menu
Introduced in Chapter 92.

cānjiā
to take part in; to join
Introduced in Chapter 84.

cǎo
grass
Introduced in Chapter 68.

chà
to be short of; to (before the hour)
Introduced in Chapter 143.

chá
tea
Introduced in Chapter 39.

长 *cháng*
long
Introduced in Chapter 61.

chángcháng
often
Introduced in Chapter 126.

chànggē
to sing
Introduced in Chapter 55.

chǎo
to stir-fry
Introduced in Chapter 113.

吵 *chǎo*
noisy
Introduced in Chapter 129.

chāoshì
supermarket
Introduced in Chapter 100.

车 *chē*
car; vehicle
Introduced in Chapter 44.

chéngshì
city
Introduced in Chapter 81.

车站 *chēzhàn*
station; stop
Introduced in Chapter 106.

吃 *chī*
to eat
Introduced in Chapter 38.

chídào
to be late; to arrive late
Introduced in Chapter 83.

chōngdiàn
to charge a battery
Introduced in Chapter 109.

chuān
to wear; to put on
Introduced in Chapter 59.

chuáng
bed
Introduced in Chapter 87.

chúfáng
kitchen
Introduced in Chapter 101.

出口 *chūkǒu*
exit; way out
Introduced in Chapter 112.

chūmén
to go out
Introduced in Chapter 43.

春节 *Chūnjié*
the Spring Festival; Chinese New Year
Introduced in Chapter 137.

春天 *chūntiān*
spring
Introduced in Chapter 131.

chūzūchē
taxi
Introduced in Chapter 44.

cì
time (one occurrence)
Introduced in Chapter 140.

cídiǎn
dictionary
Introduced in Chapter 104.

cōngming
clever; bright
Introduced in Chapter 123.

cuò
wrong; mistaken
Introduced in Chapter 121.

大 *dà*
big; large, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 13.

打电话 *dǎ diànhuà*
to phone; to make a phone call
Introduced in Chapter 63.

打包 *dǎbāo*
to pack food to take away
Introduced in Chapter 120.

dài
to bring; to take along
Introduced in Chapter 89.

dàizi
bag; sack
Introduced in Chapter 119.

大家 *dàjiā*
everyone, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 13.

dǎléi
to thunder
Introduced in Chapter 136.

dàngāo
cake
Introduced in Chapter 75.

dānxīn
to worry
Introduced in Chapter 125.

dào
to arrive; to reach
Introduced in Chapter 72.

dāo
knife
Introduced in Chapter 101.

dǎqiú
to play ball
Introduced in Chapter 56.

打扫 *dǎsǎo*
to clean (a room); to sweep
Introduced in Chapter 133.

大小 *dàxiǎo*
size
Introduced in Chapter 108.

大学 *dàxué*
university; college, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 13.

大学生 *dàxuésheng*
university student, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 13.

dǎzhé
to give a discount; to be on sale
Introduced in Chapter 122.

的 *de*
de — the particle that puts an owner in front of what is owned, and carries no tone
Introduced in Chapter 23.

dēng
lamp; light
Introduced in Chapter 87.

děng
to wait; to wait for
Introduced in Chapter 48.

点 *diǎn*
o'clock; dot
Introduced in Chapter 48.

diǎncài
to order food
Introduced in Chapter 71.

电话 *diànhuà*
telephone; phone call
Introduced in Chapter 63.

diànnǎo
computer
Introduced in Chapter 58.

diànshì
television
Introduced in Chapter 109.

点心 *diǎnxin*
dim sum; light snacks and pastries
Introduced in Chapter 120.

diànyǐng
film; movie
Introduced in Chapter 55.

diàoyú
to go fishing
Introduced in Chapter 141.

dìdi
younger brother
Introduced in Chapter 32.

dié
to fold
Introduced in Chapter 133.

dìfang
place
Introduced in Chapter 81.

dìng
to make a booking; to order
Introduced in Chapter 120.

dìtiě
underground; metro
Introduced in Chapter 106.

diū
to lose (a thing)
Introduced in Chapter 116.

dìyī
first
Introduced in Chapter 140.

dìzhǐ
address
Introduced in Chapter 120.

dǒng
to understand
Introduced in Chapter 53.

dōngbian
the east; on the east side
Introduced in Chapter 117.

dōngtiān
winter
Introduced in Chapter 131.

dōngxi
thing; things
Introduced in Chapter 42.

都 *dōu*
all; both
Introduced in Chapter 94.

dú
to read aloud; to study
Introduced in Chapter 54.

duǎn
short in length; brief
Introduced in Chapter 61.

duànliàn
to exercise; to work out
Introduced in Chapter 135.

duǎnxìn
text message
Introduced in Chapter 118.

dǔchē
traffic jam; to be stuck in traffic
Introduced in Chapter 95.

对 *duì*
duì — 'right', and on its own the commonest way to agree in spoken Mandarin
Introduced in Chapter 26.

对不起 *duìbuqǐ*
sorry
Introduced in Chapter 64.

duìmiàn
opposite; across from
Introduced in Chapter 82.

多大 *duō dà*
how old (asking a person's age)
Introduced in Chapter 78.

多少 *duōshao*
how much; how many
Introduced in Chapter 41.

è
hungry
Introduced in Chapter 38.

二 *èr*
two
Introduced in Chapter 3.

ěrduo
ear
Introduced in Chapter 52.

二十 *èrshí*
twenty — two ten, and the same ten words now reach ninety-nine
Introduced in Chapter 21.

儿子 *érzi*
son, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 12.

饭 *fàn*
cooked rice; meal
Introduced in Chapter 38.

fàndiàn
restaurant
Introduced in Chapter 44.

fàng
to put; to place
Introduced in Chapter 89.

fāngbiàn
convenient; handy
Introduced in Chapter 129.

fàngjià
to have time off; to go on holiday
Introduced in Chapter 137.

fángjiān
room
Introduced in Chapter 57.

fāngxiàng
direction; way
Introduced in Chapter 117.

fàngxīn
to stop worrying; to be at ease
Introduced in Chapter 125.

fángzi
house
Introduced in Chapter 57.

fāshāo
to have a fever
Introduced in Chapter 130.

fēicháng
extremely; very
Introduced in Chapter 77.

fēijī
aeroplane
Introduced in Chapter 72.

féizào
soap
Introduced in Chapter 105.

fēn
minute; to divide
Introduced in Chapter 48.

fēng
wind
Introduced in Chapter 66.

fěnhóng
pink
Introduced in Chapter 139.

fēnzhōng
minute (a length of time)
Introduced in Chapter 143.

fù
to pay
Introduced in Chapter 114.

fùjìn
nearby; in the area
Introduced in Chapter 111.

fúwùyuán
waiter; attendant
Introduced in Chapter 92.

fùxí
to revise; to go over again
Introduced in Chapter 121.

gāngcái
a moment ago
Introduced in Chapter 126.

gāngqín
piano
Introduced in Chapter 110.

gānjìng
clean
Introduced in Chapter 93.

gǎnkuài
quickly; hurry
Introduced in Chapter 145.

gǎnmào
to catch a cold; a cold
Introduced in Chapter 130.

gǎnxiè
to thank (warmly)
Introduced in Chapter 77.

gāo
tall; high
Introduced in Chapter 61.

gāoxìng
happy; glad
Introduced in Chapter 51.

gē
song
Introduced in Chapter 128.

个 *gè*
gè — the measure word, and the fact that a Mandarin number cannot touch a noun without one
Introduced in Chapter 24.

gēge
elder brother
Introduced in Chapter 32.

给 *gěi*
to give; to, for
Introduced in Chapter 89.

个子 *gèzi*
height; build (of a person)
Introduced in Chapter 124.

gōngjiāochē
city bus
Introduced in Chapter 106.

gōngrén
worker
Introduced in Chapter 80.

gōngsī
company; firm
Introduced in Chapter 80.

gōngyuán
park
Introduced in Chapter 100.

gōngzuò
to work; job
Introduced in Chapter 35.

gǒu
dog
Introduced in Chapter 67.

guāfēng
to be windy
Introduced in Chapter 136.

guǎi
to turn a corner
Introduced in Chapter 111.

guān
to shut; to close; to switch off
Introduced in Chapter 65.

guàngjiē
to stroll the shops; to go window-shopping
Introduced in Chapter 141.

guānxīn
to care about
Introduced in Chapter 123.

guì
expensive
Introduced in Chapter 42.

guònián
to celebrate the New Year
Introduced in Chapter 137.

guǒzhī
fruit juice
Introduced in Chapter 102.

hái xíng
hái xíng — 'not bad', the honest middle answer between fine and tired
Introduced in Chapter 30.

háizi
child
Introduced in Chapter 33.

汉语 *hànyǔ*
the Chinese language; Mandarin
Introduced in Chapter 16.

汉字 *hànzì*
Chinese character; Han character
Introduced in Chapter 16.

好 *hǎo*
good, well
Introduced in Chapter 1.

好不好 *hǎo bu hǎo*
is it good, written from three characters already yours and no new shape at all
Introduced in Chapter 19.

好吃 *hǎochī*
tasty; good to eat
Introduced in Chapter 69.

好喝 *hǎohē*
nice to drink
Introduced in Chapter 71.

好看 *hǎokàn*
good-looking or nice to look at
Introduced in Chapter 18.

hàomǎ
number (of a phone, a room); identifying number
Introduced in Chapter 63.

hǎotīng
pleasant to hear
Introduced in Chapter 128.

和 *hé*
hé — 'and' between two nouns, and never between two sentences
Introduced in Chapter 27.

喝 *hē*
to drink
Introduced in Chapter 39.

hēi
black; dark
Introduced in Chapter 60.

很 *hěn*
hěn — 'very', and the plain link Mandarin puts in front of an adjective
Introduced in Chapter 30.

很好 *hěn hǎo*
hěn hǎo — 'fine', the answer to how are you, and two third tones side by side
Introduced in Chapter 30.

héshì
right; suitable; a good fit
Introduced in Chapter 108.

hézi
box; small case
Introduced in Chapter 119.

hóng
red
Introduced in Chapter 60.

hòu
after; behind; later
Introduced in Chapter 82.

hòubian
behind; at the back
Introduced in Chapter 111.

huā
flower
Introduced in Chapter 68.

话 *huà*
words; speech
Introduced in Chapter 53.

huàhuà
to paint pictures; to draw
Introduced in Chapter 110.

huài
broken; bad
Introduced in Chapter 103.

huàn
to change; to exchange
Introduced in Chapter 108.

huán
to give back
Introduced in Chapter 64.

huáng
yellow
Introduced in Chapter 139.

huānyíng
welcome
Introduced in Chapter 74.

huí
to go back; to return
Introduced in Chapter 43.

huī
grey
Introduced in Chapter 139.

会 *huì*
can (having learned how)
Introduced in Chapter 90.

huídá
to answer
Introduced in Chapter 121.

火车 *huǒchē*
train
Introduced in Chapter 72.

huǒchēzhàn
railway station
Introduced in Chapter 73.

hùzhào
passport
Introduced in Chapter 116.

jì
to post; to send by post
Introduced in Chapter 118.

jǐ
how many; a few
Introduced in Chapter 48.

家 *jiā*
home or family, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 12.

jiān
to fry (in a little oil)
Introduced in Chapter 113.

jiǎndān
simple
Introduced in Chapter 144.

jiànmiàn
to meet up; to see each other
Introduced in Chapter 84.

jiāo
to teach
Introduced in Chapter 121.

jiǎo
foot
Introduced in Chapter 52.

叫 *jiào*
to be called; to call
Introduced in Chapter 34.

jiāohuā
to water the plants
Introduced in Chapter 142.

jiàoshì
classroom
Introduced in Chapter 79.

jiǎozi
dumpling
Introduced in Chapter 70.

jiàqī
holidays; time off
Introduced in Chapter 137.

家人 *jiārén*
family members, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 12.

jiāwù
housework
Introduced in Chapter 133.

jīchǎng
airport
Introduced in Chapter 73.

jīdàn
egg
Introduced in Chapter 40.

jiè
to borrow; to lend
Introduced in Chapter 64.

jiějie
elder sister
Introduced in Chapter 32.

节日 *jiérì*
festival
Introduced in Chapter 137.

jièshào
to introduce
Introduced in Chapter 74.

jiéshù
to come to an end; to finish
Introduced in Chapter 122.

jìjié
season
Introduced in Chapter 131.

jìn
near; close
Introduced in Chapter 62.

进 *jìn*
to come in; to enter
Introduced in Chapter 74.

jìngzi
mirror
Introduced in Chapter 105.

今年 *jīnnián*
this year
Introduced in Chapter 47.

今天 *jīntiān*
today
Introduced in Chapter 45.

jìnzhǐ
to forbid; no (on signs)
Introduced in Chapter 115.

jítā
guitar
Introduced in Chapter 128.

jiù
old (of things); no longer new
Introduced in Chapter 62.

九 *jiǔ*
nine — third tone, and a dip you have had since ni
Introduced in Chapter 20.

juéde
to find (that); to feel; to think (that)
Introduced in Chapter 144.

kāfēi
coffee
Introduced in Chapter 55.

kāi
to open; to switch on
Introduced in Chapter 65.

开车 *kāichē*
to drive
Introduced in Chapter 72.

kāishǐ
to begin; to start
Introduced in Chapter 122.

看 *kàn*
to look at or watch, recovered without pinyin
Introduced in Chapter 18.

看病 *kànbìng*
to see a doctor
Introduced in Chapter 130.

看见 *kànjiàn*
to see or catch sight of
Introduced in Chapter 18.

看书 *kànshū*
to read a book or read books
Introduced in Chapter 18.

kǎo
to roast; to bake
Introduced in Chapter 113.

kǎoshì
to take an exam
Introduced in Chapter 79.

kè
lesson; class
Introduced in Chapter 54.

kě
thirsty
Introduced in Chapter 39.

kě'ài
cute; lovable
Introduced in Chapter 123.

kělè
cola
Introduced in Chapter 102.

客人 *kèrén*
guest
Introduced in Chapter 74.

kěyǐ
may; can (with permission)
Introduced in Chapter 90.

kōng
empty
Introduced in Chapter 134.

口 *kǒu*
mouth
Introduced in Chapter 4.

kū
to cry; to weep
Introduced in Chapter 51.

kuài
yuan; lump
Introduced in Chapter 41.

快 *kuài*
fast; quick
Introduced in Chapter 62.

快乐 *kuàilè*
joyful; happy
Introduced in Chapter 75.

kuàizi
chopsticks
Introduced in Chapter 101.

kùzi
trousers
Introduced in Chapter 59.

là
spicy; hot
Introduced in Chapter 71.

lā
to pull
Introduced in Chapter 112.

来 *lái*
to come
Introduced in Chapter 36.

láibují
to run out of time
Introduced in Chapter 83.

lājī
rubbish
Introduced in Chapter 142.

lán
blue
Introduced in Chapter 60.

lánqiú
basketball
Introduced in Chapter 135.

lǎo
old
Introduced in Chapter 35.

lǎoshī
teacher
Introduced in Chapter 35.

了 *le*
le after a verb: the event is finished — and this is aspect, not tense
Introduced in Chapter 25.

lèi
lèi — 'tired', and asked with 吗 like any other statement
Introduced in Chapter 30.

lěng
cold
Introduced in Chapter 51.

里 *lǐ*
inside; in
Introduced in Chapter 81.

两 *liǎng*
two (of something)
Introduced in Chapter 88.

liángkuai
pleasantly cool
Introduced in Chapter 136.

liànxí
to practise
Introduced in Chapter 121.

liáotiān
to chat
Introduced in Chapter 84.

lǐbian
inside; in
Introduced in Chapter 85.

líkāi
to leave a place
Introduced in Chapter 107.

líng
zero
Introduced in Chapter 132.

六 *liù*
six — the sixth number, and the first one past where this book stopped
Introduced in Chapter 20.

lǐwù
present; gift
Introduced in Chapter 75.

lóutī
stairs; staircase
Introduced in Chapter 112.

lù
road; way
Introduced in Chapter 72.

lǜ
green
Introduced in Chapter 139.

lùkǒu
crossroads; junction
Introduced in Chapter 111.

lǚyóu
to travel; to tour
Introduced in Chapter 141.

吗 *ma*
the question particle, recovered without pinyin
Introduced in Chapter 19.

马 *mǎ*
horse
Introduced in Chapter 67.

máfan
to trouble; to bother
Introduced in Chapter 77.

mài
to sell
Introduced in Chapter 42.

买 *mǎi*
to buy
Introduced in Chapter 40.

mǎidān
to pay the bill
Introduced in Chapter 114.

妈妈 *māma*
mum; mother
Introduced in Chapter 32.

màn
slow
Introduced in Chapter 53.

mǎn
full
Introduced in Chapter 134.

máng
máng — 'busy', an adjective, so it takes 很 like 好
Introduced in Chapter 30.

māo
cat
Introduced in Chapter 67.

máojīn
towel
Introduced in Chapter 105.

màozi
hat; cap
Introduced in Chapter 59.

马上 *mǎshàng*
at once; right away
Introduced in Chapter 83.

每 *měi*
every; each
Introduced in Chapter 138.

Měiguó
America; the United States
Introduced in Chapter 36.

mèimei
younger sister
Introduced in Chapter 33.

měitiān
every day
Introduced in Chapter 97.

没有 *méiyǒu*
not have; there is no
Introduced in Chapter 87.

门 *mén*
door; gate
Introduced in Chapter 65.

门口 *ménkǒu*
doorway; entrance
Introduced in Chapter 74.

miànbāo
bread
Introduced in Chapter 40.

miàntiáo
noodles
Introduced in Chapter 70.

miǎo
second (of time)
Introduced in Chapter 143.

mǐfàn
cooked rice
Introduced in Chapter 38.

明年 *míngnián*
next year
Introduced in Chapter 47.

míngtiān
tomorrow
Introduced in Chapter 45.

明天见 *míngtiān jiàn*
see you tomorrow
Introduced in Chapter 76.

名字 *míngzi*
name — literally the characters a name is made of
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ná
to take; to hold
Introduced in Chapter 103.

nǎ
which
Introduced in Chapter 36.

那 *nà*
that
Introduced in Chapter 37.

nǎge
which one
Introduced in Chapter 37.

那个 *nàge*
that one
Introduced in Chapter 37.

男 *nán*
male
Introduced in Chapter 33.

nánbian
the south; on the south side
Introduced in Chapter 117.

nánguò
sad; upset
Introduced in Chapter 125.

nánkàn
ugly
Introduced in Chapter 124.

男人 *nánrén*
man
Introduced in Chapter 33.

nàozhōng
alarm clock
Introduced in Chapter 145.

哪儿 *nǎr*
where?
Introduced in Chapter 86.

那儿 *nàr*
there
Introduced in Chapter 85.

哪些 *nǎxiē*
which ones
Introduced in Chapter 127.

那些 *nàxiē*
those
Introduced in Chapter 127.

呢 *ne*
ne — the particle that hands the question back, and turns one word into a whole turn
Introduced in Chapter 26.

能 *néng*
can; to be able to; to be allowed to
Introduced in Chapter 90.

你 *nǐ*
you (one person)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

你好 *nǐ hǎo*
hello (literally "you good")
Introduced in Chapter 1.

你好吗 *nǐ hǎo ma*
how are you, written from three characters already yours
Introduced in Chapter 19.

你喜欢什么 *nǐ xǐhuan shénme*
asking what somebody likes, out of four words the book already had
Introduced in Chapter 28.

年 *nián*
year
Introduced in Chapter 47.

niánjì
age (of a person)
Introduced in Chapter 78.

niánqīng
young
Introduced in Chapter 94.

niǎo
bird
Introduced in Chapter 67.

你们 *nǐmen*
you all; you (more than one)
Introduced in Chapter 31.

nín
you (polite)
Introduced in Chapter 34.

niúnǎi
milk
Introduced in Chapter 39.

女 *nǚ*
female; woman
Introduced in Chapter 12.

女儿 *nǚ'ér*
daughter, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 12.

女人 *nǚrén*
woman
Introduced in Chapter 33.

pà
to be afraid of; to fear
Introduced in Chapter 51.

pá
to climb; to crawl
Introduced in Chapter 107.

pàng
fat; plump
Introduced in Chapter 94.

pángbiān
side; beside
Introduced in Chapter 81.

pánzi
plate; dish
Introduced in Chapter 101.

pǎobù
to run; to jog
Introduced in Chapter 56.

péngyou
friend
Introduced in Chapter 34.

piányi
cheap
Introduced in Chapter 42.

piào
ticket
Introduced in Chapter 73.

piàoliang
pretty; good-looking
Introduced in Chapter 59.

píjiǔ
beer
Introduced in Chapter 102.

píngguǒ
apple
Introduced in Chapter 40.

píngshí
usually; ordinarily
Introduced in Chapter 146.

qí
to ride (a bike or a horse)
Introduced in Chapter 106.

七 *qī*
seven — first tone, and a consonant English does not have
Introduced in Chapter 20.

qián
money
Introduced in Chapter 41.

前 *qián*
before; ago; front
Introduced in Chapter 78.

千 *qiān*
thousand
Introduced in Chapter 132.

qiánbāo
wallet; purse
Introduced in Chapter 116.

qiānbǐ
pencil
Introduced in Chapter 104.

前边 *qiánbian*
in front; ahead
Introduced in Chapter 111.

qǐchuáng
to get up
Introduced in Chapter 50.

qiē
to cut; to slice
Introduced in Chapter 113.

请 *qǐng*
please — a word you can say on its own, and a frame waiting to be filled
Introduced in Chapter 11.

qíngtiān
sunny day; fine weather
Introduced in Chapter 136.

请问 *qǐngwèn*
excuse me, may I ask
Introduced in Chapter 65.

qítā
other; the others
Introduced in Chapter 138.

qiūtiān
autumn
Introduced in Chapter 131.

去 *qù*
to go
Introduced in Chapter 43.

rè
hot
Introduced in Chapter 51.

人 *rén*
person
Introduced in Chapter 12.

rènao
lively; bustling
Introduced in Chapter 129.

rēng
to throw; to throw away
Introduced in Chapter 103.

rènshi
to know someone; to recognise
Introduced in Chapter 34.

rènzhēn
conscientious; serious
Introduced in Chapter 123.

rèqíng
warm; welcoming
Introduced in Chapter 123.

日 *rì*
sun, and also day
Introduced in Chapter 4.

日期 *rìqī*
date
Introduced in Chapter 47.

róngyì
easy
Introduced in Chapter 144.

ròu
meat
Introduced in Chapter 70.

ruǎn
soft
Introduced in Chapter 134.

rùkǒu
entrance; way in
Introduced in Chapter 112.

三 *sān*
three
Introduced in Chapter 3.

sànbù
to take a walk
Introduced in Chapter 141.

shài
to dry in the sun
Introduced in Chapter 142.

山 *shān*
mountain; hill
Introduced in Chapter 68.

shàngbān
to go to work
Introduced in Chapter 80.

shàngbian
on top; above
Introduced in Chapter 86.

上车 *shàngchē*
to get on (a bus or train)
Introduced in Chapter 73.

shāngdiàn
shop
Introduced in Chapter 42.

上课 *shàngkè*
to have class; to start class
Introduced in Chapter 79.

上网 *shàngwǎng*
to go online
Introduced in Chapter 109.

上午 *shàngwǔ*
morning (before noon)
Introduced in Chapter 49.

上学 *shàngxué*
go to school; attend school, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 15.

生气 *shēngqì*
to get angry
Introduced in Chapter 125.

生日 *shēngrì*
birthday
Introduced in Chapter 75.

什么 *shénme*
what — the first question word in this book
Introduced in Chapter 9.

shēntǐ
body; health
Introduced in Chapter 50.

十 *shí*
ten — and the last of the ten words that build every number to ninety-nine
Introduced in Chapter 20.

是 *shì*
to be — and how Mandarin says yes
Introduced in Chapter 5.

试 *shì*
to try; to try on
Introduced in Chapter 108.

是吗 *shì ma*
is that so, written from two characters already yours
Introduced in Chapter 19.

shíhou
time; moment
Introduced in Chapter 46.

shíjiān
time; free time
Introduced in Chapter 83.

shíkèbiǎo
timetable
Introduced in Chapter 122.

十一 *shíyī*
eleven — ten one, and the teens are finished in a sentence
Introduced in Chapter 21.

shòu
thin; slim
Introduced in Chapter 94.

shōu
to receive; to accept
Introduced in Chapter 118.

手 *shǒu*
hand
Introduced in Chapter 52.

shǒubiǎo
wristwatch
Introduced in Chapter 116.

手机 *shǒujī*
mobile phone
Introduced in Chapter 58.

shōushi
to tidy up
Introduced in Chapter 133.

shǔ
to count
Introduced in Chapter 132.

书 *shū*
book, recovered without pinyin
Introduced in Chapter 18.

shuài
handsome
Introduced in Chapter 124.

shuākǎ
to pay by card
Introduced in Chapter 114.

shuāng
a pair of (a measure word)
Introduced in Chapter 108.

shuāyá
to brush one's teeth
Introduced in Chapter 99.

书包 *shūbāo*
schoolbag
Introduced in Chapter 119.

shūfu
comfortable; well
Introduced in Chapter 96.

水 *shuǐ*
water
Introduced in Chapter 39.

shuì lǎnjiào
to sleep in; to lie in
Introduced in Chapter 145.

shuǐguǒ
fruit
Introduced in Chapter 40.

shuìjiào
to sleep; to go to bed
Introduced in Chapter 50.

说 *shuō*
to say; to speak
Introduced in Chapter 53.

shūtóu
to comb one's hair
Introduced in Chapter 99.

四 *sì*
four
Introduced in Chapter 3.

sījī
driver
Introduced in Chapter 80.

sòng
to give as a present; to see off
Introduced in Chapter 75.

suàn
to calculate; to work out
Introduced in Chapter 140.

岁 *suì*
suì — years of age, and the sentence that says how old you are without a verb in it
Introduced in Chapter 27.

suǒyǐ
so; therefore
Introduced in Chapter 96.

suǒyǒu
all; every
Introduced in Chapter 138.

tā
she; her
Introduced in Chapter 31.

他 *tā*
he; him
Introduced in Chapter 31.

tài
too; too much
Introduced in Chapter 41.

太好了 *tài hǎo le*
great!; that's wonderful
Introduced in Chapter 93.

tàiyang
sun
Introduced in Chapter 68.

他们 *tāmen*
they; them
Introduced in Chapter 31.

tán
to play an instrument; to pluck
Introduced in Chapter 110.

tāng
soup
Introduced in Chapter 70.

tèbié
special; especially
Introduced in Chapter 144.

téng
sore; painful
Introduced in Chapter 130.

tī
to kick
Introduced in Chapter 135.

tián
sweet
Introduced in Chapter 71.

天 *tiān*
day; sky
Introduced in Chapter 45.

天气 *tiānqì*
weather
Introduced in Chapter 66.

tiào
to jump
Introduced in Chapter 107.

tiàowǔ
to dance
Introduced in Chapter 110.

tíng
to stop; to park
Introduced in Chapter 107.

tīng
to listen; to hear
Introduced in Chapter 53.

同学 *tóngxué*
classmate; schoolmate, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 15.

tóu
head
Introduced in Chapter 52.

tóufa
hair (on the head)
Introduced in Chapter 124.

tuī
to push
Introduced in Chapter 112.

tuōdì
to mop the floor
Introduced in Chapter 142.

túshūguǎn
library
Introduced in Chapter 100.

wàibian
outside
Introduced in Chapter 85.

wàiguó
foreign country; abroad
Introduced in Chapter 81.

wàimài
takeaway; food delivered
Introduced in Chapter 120.

外语 *wàiyǔ*
foreign language
Introduced in Chapter 110.

wàn
ten thousand
Introduced in Chapter 132.

wán
to play; to have fun
Introduced in Chapter 56.

wǎn'ān
good night
Introduced in Chapter 76.

晚点 *wǎndiǎn*
to run behind schedule; to be late (of a train or plane)
Introduced in Chapter 145.

晚饭 *wǎnfàn*
dinner; supper
Introduced in Chapter 69.

wàng
to forget
Introduced in Chapter 95.

晚上 *wǎnshang*
evening
Introduced in Chapter 49.

晚上好 *wǎnshang hǎo*
good evening
Introduced in Chapter 49.

wéi
hello on the phone
Introduced in Chapter 63.

为什么 *wèishénme*
why?
Introduced in Chapter 95.

wēixiǎn
dangerous
Introduced in Chapter 115.

wèn
to ask
Introduced in Chapter 54.

我 *wǒ*
I, me — one word for both, and no change for either
Introduced in Chapter 8.

我们 *wǒmen*
we; us
Introduced in Chapter 31.

5 — 五 *wǔ*
the digit and the character — which one a price, a date and a phone number use
Introduced in Chapter 21.

五 *wǔ*
five
Introduced in Chapter 3.

午饭 *wǔfàn*
lunch
Introduced in Chapter 69.

洗 *xǐ*
to wash
Introduced in Chapter 99.

xiàbian
under; below
Introduced in Chapter 86.

下车 *xiàchē*
to get off (a bus or train)
Introduced in Chapter 73.

下课 *xiàkè*
to finish class
Introduced in Chapter 79.

xián
salty
Introduced in Chapter 71.

xiàng
to resemble; to take after
Introduced in Chapter 124.

想 *xiǎng*
to want to; to think; to miss
Introduced in Chapter 55.

想要 *xiǎngyào*
to want; would like
Introduced in Chapter 91.

xiāngzi
box; suitcase; trunk
Introduced in Chapter 119.

xiànjīn
cash
Introduced in Chapter 114.

xiānsheng
Mr; sir; husband
Introduced in Chapter 35.

xiànzài
now
Introduced in Chapter 45.

xiào
to laugh; to smile
Introduced in Chapter 56.

小 *xiǎo*
small; little, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 14.

小时 *xiǎoshí*
hour
Introduced in Chapter 97.

xiǎoshíhou
in childhood; when one was little
Introduced in Chapter 78.

小心 *xiǎoxīn*
to be careful; to mind (something)
Introduced in Chapter 115.

小学 *xiǎoxué*
primary school, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 14.

小学生 *xiǎoxuésheng*
primary-school student, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 14.

xiàtiān
summer
Introduced in Chapter 131.

xiàwǔ
afternoon
Introduced in Chapter 49.

xiàyǔ
to rain
Introduced in Chapter 66.

xiàzài
to download
Introduced in Chapter 109.

xībian
the west; on the west side
Introduced in Chapter 117.

xié
shoe
Introduced in Chapter 59.

xiě
to write
Introduced in Chapter 54.

谢谢 *xièxie*
thank you — the same character twice, and the second one goes light
Introduced in Chapter 10.

喜欢 *xǐhuan*
xǐhuan — 'to like', an ordinary verb with an ordinary object, and no inversion anywhere
Introduced in Chapter 28.

xǐliǎn
to wash one's face
Introduced in Chapter 99.

xìn
letter (in the post)
Introduced in Chapter 118.

xīn
new
Introduced in Chapter 61.

xìng
to have the family name; family name
Introduced in Chapter 34.

xǐng
to wake up
Introduced in Chapter 146.

xíngli
luggage
Introduced in Chapter 119.

星期 *xīngqī*
week
Introduced in Chapter 46.

星期天 *xīngqītiān*
Sunday
Introduced in Chapter 46.

星期一 *xīngqīyī*
Monday
Introduced in Chapter 46.

星星 *xīngxing*
star
Introduced in Chapter 68.

xǐshǒujiān
toilet; washroom
Introduced in Chapter 86.

xiū
to repair; to fix
Introduced in Chapter 103.

xiūxi
to rest
Introduced in Chapter 50.

xīyān
to smoke
Introduced in Chapter 115.

xǐzǎo
to have a shower; to have a bath
Introduced in Chapter 99.

xuě
snow
Introduced in Chapter 66.

学 *xué*
study; learn, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 13.

学生 *xuésheng*
student, now read and written
Introduced in Chapter 13.

xuéxí
to study; to learn
Introduced in Chapter 54.

xuéxiào
school
Introduced in Chapter 43.

xūyào
to need
Introduced in Chapter 91.

yágāo
toothpaste
Introduced in Chapter 105.

yǎnjing
eye
Introduced in Chapter 52.

yánsè
colour
Introduced in Chapter 60.

yào
to want; to ask for
Introduced in Chapter 41.

yàoshi
key
Introduced in Chapter 87.

yáshuā
toothbrush
Introduced in Chapter 105.

也 *yě*
also; too
Introduced in Chapter 92.

yèli
at night
Introduced in Chapter 146.

一 *yī*
one
Introduced in Chapter 3.

一百 *yìbǎi*
a hundred — and the one word in the run whose tone moves
Introduced in Chapter 21.

一半 *yíbàn*
one half; half (of something)
Introduced in Chapter 140.

一点儿 *yìdiǎnr*
a little; a bit
Introduced in Chapter 91.

yīfu
clothes
Introduced in Chapter 58.

yígòng
altogether; in all
Introduced in Chapter 132.

yǐhòu
after; afterwards
Introduced in Chapter 97.

一会儿 *yíhuìr*
a little while; in a moment
Introduced in Chapter 76.

yǐjīng
already
Introduced in Chapter 126.

yìng
hard; stiff
Introduced in Chapter 134.

Yīngguó
Britain; the United Kingdom
Introduced in Chapter 36.

yíngyè
to be open for business
Introduced in Chapter 122.

yínháng
bank
Introduced in Chapter 100.

yǐnliào
drink; soft drink
Introduced in Chapter 102.

yīntiān
overcast day
Introduced in Chapter 136.

因为 *yīnwèi*
because
Introduced in Chapter 96.

音乐 *yīnyuè*
music
Introduced in Chapter 128.

音乐会 *yīnyuèhuì*
concert
Introduced in Chapter 128.

一起 *yìqǐ*
together
Introduced in Chapter 84.

以前 *yǐqián*
before; in the past
Introduced in Chapter 126.

yīshēng
doctor
Introduced in Chapter 80.

一些 *yìxiē*
some; a few
Introduced in Chapter 127.

yíyàng
the same; alike
Introduced in Chapter 94.

yīyuàn
hospital
Introduced in Chapter 44.

yǐzi
chair
Introduced in Chapter 57.

用 *yòng*
to use
Introduced in Chapter 103.

有 *yǒu*
yǒu — 'to have', and also 'there is': one verb where Spanish spends three points
Introduced in Chapter 24.

yòubian
the right; on the right
Introduced in Chapter 82.

有点儿 *yǒudiǎnr*
a bit (of something unwanted); rather
Introduced in Chapter 93.

yóujú
post office
Introduced in Chapter 100.

yǒushì
to have something on; to be busy
Introduced in Chapter 95.

yǒushíhou
sometimes
Introduced in Chapter 126.

yóuxì
game
Introduced in Chapter 141.

yǒuyìsi
interesting
Introduced in Chapter 129.

yóuyǒng
to swim
Introduced in Chapter 90.

yú
fish
Introduced in Chapter 67.

雨 *yǔ*
rain
Introduced in Chapter 66.

yuán
round
Introduced in Chapter 139.

yuǎn
far
Introduced in Chapter 62.

yuányīn
reason; cause
Introduced in Chapter 145.

yuè
month; moon
Introduced in Chapter 47.

yùndòng
sport; exercise
Introduced in Chapter 56.

yǔsǎn
umbrella
Introduced in Chapter 116.

在 *zài*
to be at; in, at
Introduced in Chapter 85.

再见 *zàijiàn*
goodbye — two characters whose meanings genuinely add up
Introduced in Chapter 6.

再说 *zàishuō*
to leave it till later
Introduced in Chapter 76.

zāng
dirty
Introduced in Chapter 93.

早 *zǎo*
early
Introduced in Chapter 83.

早饭 *zǎofàn*
breakfast
Introduced in Chapter 69.

早上 *zǎoshang*
morning — and a syllable with no tone at all
Introduced in Chapter 7.

早上好 *zǎoshang hǎo*
good morning — and proof that 好 was a building block
Introduced in Chapter 7.

zěnmeyàng
zěnmeyàng — 'how is it?', the everyday way to ask how somebody is doing
Introduced in Chapter 30.

zhàn
to stand
Introduced in Chapter 89.

zhāng
(a measure word for flat things: tables, beds, tickets)
Introduced in Chapter 88.

长大 *zhǎngdà*
to grow up
Introduced in Chapter 78.

zhǎo
to look for
Introduced in Chapter 63.

zháojí
anxious; in a hurry
Introduced in Chapter 125.

zhàopiàn
photo; photograph
Introduced in Chapter 109.

zhǎoqián
to give change
Introduced in Chapter 114.

这 *zhè*
this
Introduced in Chapter 37.

这个 *zhège*
this one
Introduced in Chapter 37.

zhēn
really; truly
Introduced in Chapter 77.

zhěnglǐ
to sort out; to put in order
Introduced in Chapter 142.

这儿 *zhèr*
here
Introduced in Chapter 57.

这些 *zhèxiē*
these
Introduced in Chapter 127.

zhèyàng
like this; this way
Introduced in Chapter 127.

zhī
(a measure word for animals, and for one of a pair)
Introduced in Chapter 88.

zhǐ
paper
Introduced in Chapter 104.

zhīdào
to know a fact; to be aware
Introduced in Chapter 62.

重 *zhòng*
heavy
Introduced in Chapter 134.

中国 *zhōngguó*
China
Introduced in Chapter 17.

中国人 *Zhōngguó rén*
中国人 — a Chinese person, built out of three characters you already write
Introduced in Chapter 22.

zhōngjiān
the middle; between
Introduced in Chapter 82.

中文 *zhōngwén*
Chinese; the Chinese language
Introduced in Chapter 17.

中午 *zhōngwǔ*
noon
Introduced in Chapter 49.

中学 *zhōngxué*
middle school, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 15.

中学生 *zhōngxuésheng*
middle-school student, built from known characters
Introduced in Chapter 15.

重要 *zhòngyào*
important
Introduced in Chapter 144.

zhōumò
weekend
Introduced in Chapter 46.

zhù
to live somewhere; to stay
Introduced in Chapter 35.

zhǔ
to boil; to cook in water
Introduced in Chapter 113.

zhǔnbèi
to get ready; to prepare
Introduced in Chapter 84.

zhǔnshí
on time; punctual
Introduced in Chapter 143.

zhuōzi
table
Introduced in Chapter 57.

zhùyì
to pay attention; to take care
Introduced in Chapter 115.

字 *zì*
a written Chinese character, recovered without pinyin
Introduced in Chapter 16.

zìjǐ
oneself
Introduced in Chapter 138.

zìxíngchē
bicycle
Introduced in Chapter 106.

zǒu
to walk; to leave
Introduced in Chapter 43.

zuì
most
Introduced in Chapter 140.

zuò
to sit; to travel by
Introduced in Chapter 44.

做 *zuò*
to do; to make
Introduced in Chapter 89.

zuǒbian
the left; on the left
Introduced in Chapter 82.

做饭 *zuòfàn*
to cook
Introduced in Chapter 69.

zuótiān
yesterday
Introduced in Chapter 45.

zuòyè
homework
Introduced in Chapter 79.

zúqiú
football; soccer
Introduced in Chapter 135.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*
How many marked tones does Mandarin have, not counting the neutral one? Type the number as a word.

1.2 你 *— "you", and the first character*
Type the Mandarin word, in pinyin with its tone mark, that means 'you' (one person).

1.3 好 *— "good", and what replaces etymology here*
好 is built from two components. Type the meaning of the one on the left.

1.4 你好 *— the greeting, assembled from two things you already have*
You have just been introduced to someone. Type the Mandarin greeting in characters.

1.5 *ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written*
A dictionary prints the greeting as nǐ hǎo. Type it in pinyin the way it is actually spoken.

1.6 好 *again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word*
Read in the falling fourth tone, 好 stops meaning 'good'. Type its meaning with that tone, in English.

1.7 *Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back*
Someone greets you with 你好. Type your reply in characters.

Chapter 2

2.1 人 *— two strokes, and a person walking*
How many strokes does the character for 'person' have?

2.2 亻 — *the same person, standing sideways*
A character has the narrow upright person component at its left edge. What does that tell you about the word?

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*
When a component is inside a character for its SOUND rather than its meaning, what is it telling you?

2.4 *Putting two pieces together — and reading the result*
In this character, which half points at the MEANING — the left or the right?

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*
How many strokes are in the character for 'woman'?

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*
What does the three-stroke character with the hooked vertical and a bar across the middle mean?

2.7 *Two pieces again — and a warning about the story*
Does this character have a component that points at its pronunciation?

Chapter 3

3.1 一 — *one stroke, and that is the character*
How many strokes does the character for one have?

3.2 一 — *one, and the number is the strokes*
What is the relationship between the number of strokes in this character and what it means?

3.3 二 — *two bars, and neither is decoration*
In the character for two, which bar is longer — the top or the bottom?

3.4 二 — *two, and a syllable you have met before*
Type the pinyin, with its tone mark, for the number two.

3.5 三 — *three bars, and the pattern's last stand*
In the character for three, which of the three bars is shortest?

3.6 三 — *three, and the end of the easy road*
Do you expect the character for four to have four strokes? Why or why not?

3.7 四 — *a box, and the rule that governs every box*
Which stroke of the box in the character for four is drawn LAST?

3.8 四 — *four, borrowed for its sound*
Why do some buildings in China have no fourth floor?

3.9 五 — *count the strokes and be wrong*
How many strokes does the character for five have?

3.10 五 — *five, and the run is complete*
Which of the five numbers could you have worked out from their strokes alone?

3.11 *Practice — read the numbers off a wall*
A lift panel reads 一 二 三 五. Which floor number is missing, and why?

Chapter 4

4.1 口 — *the box, on its own*
Which stroke of this box is written last?

4.2 口 — *mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere*
What does this character mean, and what is it a picture of?

4.3 日 — *one bar inside the box*
Does the middle bar go in before or after the bottom bar?

4.4 日 — *the sun, and the day it measures*
This character means two things. What are they, and why are they the same word?

4.5 不 — *four strokes, all of them separate*
How many times do you lift the pen writing this character?

4.6 不 — *how Mandarin says no*
Mandarin has no single word meaning 'no'. So how do you answer no to a yes-or-no question?

4.7 *Practice — one box, two characters, and a refusal*
Why is 不 worth more than one word of vocabulary?

Chapter 5

5.1 是 — *finish the sun, then build under it*
Which character sits on top of this one, and must be finished first?

5.2 是 — *"is", and the nearest thing to "yes"*
Mandarin has no separate word for 'yes'. So how do you say it?

5.3 不是 — *"is not", and the second tone that moves*
不 changes tone before one particular kind of syllable. Which, and what does 不 become?

5.4 *Practice — answering either way*
Mandarin gives you no word for yes and none for no. What does it give you instead?

Chapter 6

6.1 再 — *a bar, a frame, and a line that closes it*
The frame's top, right side and hook are drawn how – as three strokes, or as one?

6.2 见 — *an eye on two legs*
What sits underneath the frame in this character, and where have you seen it before?

6.3 再见 — *the word that says what it means*
Read the goodbye word literally, character by character. What do the two characters say?

6.4 *Practice — a conversation that ends*
You have opened an exchange, answered inside it, and closed it. Which line closes it, in pinyin?

Chapter 7

7.1 早 — *sun on top, one more time*
Which piece of this character is finished before the other, and how many strokes does it take?

7.2 上 — *the same rule, read the other way*
Which stroke of this character is drawn first, and why is it not the short bar?

7.3 早上 — *morning, and a syllable that goes light*
In the pinyin for 'morning', why does the second syllable have no tone mark?

7.4 早上好 — *the greeting was a pattern all along*
Both greetings you now know end in the same character. Which one, and what does it mean on its own?

7.5 *Practice — greeting the time of day*
You meet someone at eight in the morning. You know two greetings that would both be understood. Which one fits the hour?

Chapter 8

8.1 我 — *seven strokes, and an honest admission*
Which stroke of this seven-stroke character is written last?

8.2 我 — *I, me, and saying who you are*
English has two words, 'I' and 'me', and picks between them. How many does Mandarin use?

8.3 名 — *a mouth with something above it*
Which character that you have already written forms the bottom half of this one?

8.4 字 — *a child under a roof*
This character is the word for the thing you have been writing all along. What does it mean?

8.5 名字 — *the word for a name*
The word for 'name' is made of two characters. What does the second one mean on its own?

8.6 *Practice — saying who you are*
In pinyin, what two words do you put in front of your own name to introduce yourself?

Chapter 9

9.1 什 — *both halves are old news*
Name the two pieces of this character, left first.

9.2 么 — *three strokes, and one of them turns*
The middle stroke goes down-left and then sweeps right. Is that one stroke or two?

9.3 什么 — *what*
Every earlier expression in this book gave something to the listener. What does this word do instead?

9.4 *Practice — when you did not catch it*
You did not catch what someone just said. In pinyin, what one word gets it repeated?

Chapter 10

10.1 讠 — *the speech radical*
A character has this component at its left edge. What can you guess about the word?

10.2 谢 — *twelve strokes, and three pieces*
How many pieces does this twelve-stroke character break into, and which one do you write first?

10.3 谢谢 — *said twice*
The two halves of this word are the same character. Are they said the same way?

10.4 不谢 — *answering thanks*
Why is it said bú xiè and not bù xiè?

10.5 *Practice — thanks, and the answer*
This chapter taught you both how to thank someone and how to answer being thanked. How many new characters did that take?

Chapter 11

11.1 请 — *a half that tells you the sound*
One half of this character tells you the meaning. What does the other half tell you?

11.2 请 — *please, and after you*
You hold a door open for someone and say this one word. What are you telling them?

11.3 *Practice — after you*
A character can give you two different kinds of hint at once. What are they?

Chapter 12

12.1 人 — *a person*
Type the Mandarin character for person.

12.2 女 — *female, woman*
Which taught character is the Level 1 word female or woman?

12.3 *Hear* érzi — *son*
What does érzi mean?

12.4 儿 — *fall, then bend and hook*
Write the first character of érzi.

12.5 儿子 — *son on the page*
Write son in Chinese characters.

12.6 *Hear* nǚ'ér — *daughter*
What does nǚ'ér mean?

12.7 女儿 — *daughter on the page*
Write daughter in Chinese characters.

12.8 *Hear* jiā — *home, family*
What two closely linked meanings does jiā carry?

12.9 家 — *roof first, body second*
Which taught component must be completed first when writing 家?

12.10 家 — *home on the page*
Write home or family in one Chinese character.

12.11 *Hear* jiārén — *family members*
What does jiārén mean?

12.12 家人 — *the people of the home*
Write family members in Chinese characters.

12.13 *Retrieve six people and family words*
Write son, daughter, and family members in that order.

12.14 *Payoff — six family words in four skills*
After all four checks pass, write home, person, and family members.

Chapter 13

13.1 *Hear* dà — *big*
What does dà mean?

13.2 大 — *one bar, two falls*
Which stroke comes first in 大?

13.3 大 — *big on the page*
Write dà, big, in Chinese.

13.4 *Hear* dàjiā — *everyone*
What does dàjiā mean?

13.5 大家 — *everyone on the page*
Write everyone in Chinese characters.

13.6 *Hear* xué — *study, learn*
What does xué mean?

13.7 学 — *top, cover, child*
Which familiar character closes 学 at the bottom?

13.8 学 — *study on the page*
Write xué, study or learn, in Chinese.

13.9 *Hear* xuésheng — *student*
What does xuésheng mean?

13.10 生 — *five measured strokes*
Which stroke closes 生?

13.11 学生 — *student on the page*
Write student in Chinese characters.

13.12 *Hear* dàxué — *university*
What does dàxué mean?

13.13 大学 — *university on the page*
Write university in Chinese characters.

13.14 *Hear* dàxuésheng — *university student*
What does dàxuésheng mean?

13.15 大学生 — *university student on the page*
Write university student in Chinese characters.

13.16 *Retrieve six size and school words*
Write student, university, and university student in that order.

13.17 *Payoff — six school words in four skills*
After all four checks pass, write everyone, university, and university student.

Chapter 14

14.1 *Hear* xiǎo — *small*
What does xiǎo mean?

14.2 小 — *centre, left, right*
Which stroke comes first in 小?

14.3 小 — *small on the page*
Write xiǎo, small, in Chinese.

14.4 *Hear* xiǎoxué — *primary school*
What does xiǎoxué mean?

14.5 小学 — *primary school on the page*
Write primary school in Chinese characters.

14.6 *Hear* xiǎoxuésheng — *primary-school student*
What does xiǎoxuésheng mean?

14.7 小学生 — *primary-school student on the page*
Write primary-school student in Chinese characters.

14.8 *Retrieve three primary-school words*
Write small, primary school, and primary-school student in that order.

14.9 *Payoff — three primary-school words in four skills*
After all four checks pass, write primary school and primary-school student.

Chapter 15

15.1 *Hear* zhōng — *middle*
What does zhōng mean?

15.2 中 — *close, then pass through*
What happens immediately before the final centre line in 中?

15.3 中 — *middle on the page*
Write zhōng, middle, in Chinese.

15.4 *Hear* zhōngxué — *middle school*
What does zhōngxué mean?

15.5 中学 — *middle school on the page*
Write middle school in Chinese characters.

15.6 *Retrieval 1 — middle and middle school*
Write middle and middle school in that order.

15.7 *Hear* zhōngxuésheng — *middle-school student*
What does zhōngxuésheng mean?

15.8 中学生 — *middle-school student on the page*
Write middle-school student in Chinese characters.

15.9 *Hear* tóngxué — *classmate*
What does tóngxué mean?

15.10 同 — *frame, line, box*
What three-stroke shape finishes 同?

15.11 同学 — *classmate on the page*
Write classmate in Chinese characters.

15.12 *Retrieval 2 — school and people*
Write middle school, middle-school student, and classmate.

15.13 *Hear* shàngxué — *go to school*
What does shàngxué mean?

15.14 上学 — *go to school on the page*
Write go to school in Chinese characters.

15.15 *Retrieval 3 — place, person, classmate, action*
Write middle school, middle-school student, classmate, and go to school.

15.16 *Retrieval 4 — the full school ladder*
Write primary school, middle school, and university in that order.

15.17 *Payoff — four school compounds in four skills*
After all four checks pass, write middle school, classmate, and go to school.

Chapter 16

16.1 *Hear* zì — *a written character*
What does zì mean on its own?

16.2 字 — *the familiar shape stands alone*
Write zì, a written character, in Chinese.

16.3 *Hear* hànzì — *Chinese character*
What does hànzì mean?

16.4 汉 — *watch five strokes*
After the three water strokes in 汉, what are the last two directions?

16.5 汉 — *copy with a five-part cue*
How many strokes and pen lifts does 汉 use?

16.6 汉 — *hold the route briefly*
Write 汉 after the model has been hidden.

16.7 汉字 — *two known routes, one word*
Read 汉字 without pinyin, then give its meaning.

16.8 *Hear* hànyǔ — *the Chinese language*
Which spoken word means the Chinese language: hànzì or hànyǔ?

16.9 *Retrieval 1* — 字 *and* 汉字
Write written character and Chinese character in that order.

16.10 语 — *speech, five, box*
Which part of 语 is written first, and which small shape closes it?

16.11 语 — *copy, then fade*
After covering half the model, which three-part cue rebuilds 语?

16.12 语 — *wait, then write*
Write 语 from memory. Which component should stay narrow?

16.13 汉语 — *the language in writing*
Read 汉语 without pinyin, then give its meaning.

16.14 *Retrieval 2 — character or language?*
Write Chinese character, then Chinese language.

16.15 *Checkpoint* — 字, 汉字, 汉语
Without pinyin, write character, Chinese character, and Chinese language in that order.

Chapter 17

17.1 *Hear* zhōngwén — *Chinese*
What does zhōngwén mean?

17.2 文 — *watch four open strokes*
Which two directions finish 文?

17.3 文 — *copy with the route visible*
How many strokes and pen lifts does 文 use?

17.4 文 — *wait, then open the two falls*
Write 文 after the model has been hidden.

17.5 中文 — *two known squares*
Read 中文 without pinyin, then give its meaning.

17.6 *Longer return — character or language?*
Write Chinese language, Chinese character, and written character in that order.

17.7 *Hear* zhōngguó — *China*
Which spoken word means China: zhōngwén or zhōngguó?

17.8 国 — *frame, inside, close*
When is the bottom of 国 closed?

17.9 国 — *copy with the frame open*
How many strokes and pen lifts does 国 use?

17.10 国 — *wait before closing*
Write 国 from memory. What must happen before the final bottom bar?

17.11 中国 — *China in two squares*
Read 中国 without pinyin, then give its meaning.

17.12 *Retrieval 1 — language or country?*
Write Chinese language, then China.

17.13 *Longer return — the older three*
Write written character, Chinese language, and Chinese character in that order.

17.14 *Listening score — five meanings*
Which sound means China: zhōngwén or zhōngguó?

17.15 *Reading score — no pinyin*
Read and distinguish 中文 and 中国 without pinyin.

17.16 *Writing score — from sound, no model*
Without a model, write Chinese language with 中, then China.

17.17 *Payoff — five identity words*
Without pinyin or a model, write character, Chinese character, Chinese language with 汉, Chinese language with 中, and China.

Chapter 18

18.1 *Hear* kàn — *look or watch*
What does kàn mean?

18.2 看 — *a hand above an eye*
How many strokes does 看 use?

18.3 看 — *copy hand above, eye below*
What familiar shape finishes 看?

18.4 看 — *wait, then recover the eye*
Write 看 after the model has been hidden.

18.5 看 — *the familiar sound meets the shape*
Read 看, give its meaning, then copy it once.

18.6 *Hear* kànjiàn — *see*
What does kànjiàn mean?

18.7 看见 — *looking reaches seeing*
Write kànjiàn, to see, without pinyin.

18.8 *Hear* hǎokàn — *good-looking*
What does hǎokàn mean?

18.9 好看 — *good to look at*
Write hǎokàn, good-looking, without pinyin.

18.10 *Retrieval 1 — look, see, or good-looking?*
Write look, see, and good-looking in that order.

18.11 *Hear* shū — *book*
What does shū mean?

18.12 书 — *two folds, upright, dot*
How many strokes does 书 use?

18.13 书 — *copy the compact route*
What is the final stroke of 书?

18.14 书 — *wait, then place the dot*
Write 书 after the model has been hidden.

18.15 书 — *the sound meets the shape*
Read 书, give its meaning, then write it once.

18.16 *Hear* kànshū — *read a book*
What does kànshū mean?

18.17 看书 — *look at a book, read*
Write kànshū, read a book, without pinyin.

18.18 *Retrieval 2 — the earlier three return*
Write good-looking, look, and see in that order.

18.19 *Retrieval 1 — book or read a book?*
Write book, then read a book.

18.20 *Listening score — five nearby meanings*
Which sound means read a book: kànjiàn or kànshū?

18.21 *Reading score — no pinyin*
Read 看见 and 看书, then give their meanings.

18.22 *Writing score — sound to Hanzi, no model*
Without a model, write look, see, good-looking, book, and read a book.

18.23 *Payoff — looking and reading*
Without pinyin or a model, write look, see, good-looking, book, and read a book.

Chapter 19

19.1 *Hear* ma *— the syllable that asks*
Which tone does ma carry?

19.2 吗 *— the mouth, then the horse*
How many strokes does 吗 use, and which half is written first?

19.3 吗 *— copy it, and keep the mouth small*
What is the final stroke of 吗?

19.4 吗 *— wait, then write the bar*
Which half of 吗 is completed first?

19.5 吗 *— the sound meets the shape*
Where in the sentence does 吗 go, and what does it change?

19.6 *Hear* nǐ hǎo ma *— how are you*
What does nǐ hǎo ma mean?

19.7 你好吗 *— the greeting, asked*
Write how are you, without pinyin.

19.8 *Retrieval 1 — greeting, or question?*
Write hello, then how are you.

19.9 *Hear* shì ma *— is that so?*
When do you say shì ma?

19.10 是吗 *— checking what you were told*
Write is that so, without pinyin.

19.11 *Hear* hǎo bu hǎo *— the question with the answer inside it*
What three pieces make hǎo bu hǎo?

19.12 好不好 *— the question that needed no new character*
Name Mandarin's two ways of asking a yes-or-no question.

19.13 *Retrieval 2 — which question was that?*
Which of the three does NOT end in 吗?

19.14 *Listening score — catch the question*
How many of the three did you catch by ear alone?

19.15 *Reading score — no pinyin on the card*
Reading cold, what tells you a sentence is a question?

19.16 *Payoff — the book can ask*
Give your four scores as listening, speaking, reading, writing.

Chapter 20

20.1 六 — *four strokes again, for six this time*
How many strokes does 六 have?

20.2 六 — *six, and the run starts again*
Which earlier number shares liu's tone?

20.3 七 — *two strokes, for seven*
How many times do you lift the pen writing 七?

20.4 七 — *seven*
Where is the tongue for the q of qi?

20.5 八 — *a character you have already written twice*
What is the only difference between 八 and 人?

20.6 八 — *eight, and why it costs more*
Why is eight a lucky number in Chinese?

20.7 九 — *two strokes again*
How many strokes do 七, 八 and 九 have between them?

20.8 九 — *nine*
Which tone does jiu share with ni, hao and wu?

20.9 十 — *the character that was already here*
Which character you already write has 十 inside it?

20.10 十 — *ten*
Which tone is shi, and is any other number on it?

20.11 *Payoff — one to ten*
Count aloud from one to ten in Mandarin.

Chapter 21

21.1 十一 — *eleven, and the teens in one line*
Build seventeen from shi and qi.

21.2 二十 — *twenty, and ninety-nine numbers from ten words*
What is the difference between shiyi and ershi?

21.3 百 — *a hundred, on a box you have built before*
Which stroke of 百 comes last?

21.4 一百 — *a hundred, and* 一 *moves*
Is the 一 in yibai said on the same tone as 一 counted alone?

21.5 *5 and* 五 — *the same number, two registers*
A Chinese price tag says 20. How do you say it aloud?

21.6 *Payoff — ninety-nine numbers, and the price tag*
Say sixty-eight and ninety-nine in Mandarin.

21.7 *Close the numeral slice*
Write ten and a hundred in characters.

Chapter 29

29.1 *(reading) — six characters, nothing said first*
Which character is a book?

29.2 *(reading) — six words, not six characters*
Which is the person who reads?

29.3 *(reading) — the first passage*
How old is the writer?

Chapter 30

30.1 很好 — *I'm fine*
Somebody asks you how you are doing. Answer that you are fine.

30.2 *nǐ zěnmeyàng — wǒ hěn hǎo*
In the morning exchange, who says they are busy, A or B?

Chapter 85

85.1 我在这儿 — 你在那儿
Where is the cat?

Chapter 86

86.1 你在哪儿 — 我在那儿
Where is the phone in the end?

Chapter 87

87.1 不 — 没*: two words for not*
Which negative goes with 有, 不 or 没?

87.2 你有没有 — 没有
Has A got a key?

Chapter 88

88.1 *yī → yí ge, yì tiān: the tone* 一 *takes*
Say one person: is 一 rising or falling in front of 个?

88.2 两个人
How many cups of tea does B ask for?

Chapter 89

89.1 给我
Where does the phone go in the end?

Chapter 90

90.1 我会开车
Why can't B drive tomorrow?

Chapter 91

91.1 我想要一点儿水
Does B want tea?

Chapter 92

92.1 我也要
What does C order?

Chapter 93

93.1 太大了
What is wrong with the second one?

Chapter 94

94.1 我们都是学生
Who is the tall, thin man?

Chapter 95

95.1 你为什么不去
Why isn't B going tomorrow?

Chapter 96

96.1 为什么 — 因为
Why isn't B going to class?

Chapter 97

97.1 *(reading) — a Sunday at home*
At what time do they go to buy books?

97.2 *My own line — the first Chinese with no model*
Write the word for an hour, in characters.

Chapter 98

98.1 *The same writing, with a clock*
Write the form label that asks where your home is.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4

1.2 你 *— "you", and the first character*
Answer: nǐ
Also accepted: ni3; ni

1.3 好 *— "good", and what replaces etymology here*
Answer: woman
Also accepted: female

1.4 你好 *— the greeting, assembled from two things you already have*
Answer: 你好
Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

1.5 *ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written*
Answer: ní hǎo
Also accepted: ni2 hao3; nihao (ní hǎo); ní hao

1.6 好 *again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word*
Answer: to be fond of
Also accepted: to like; like; fond of; be fond of

1.7 *Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back*
Answer: 你好
Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

Chapter 2

2.1 人 — *two strokes, and a person walking*
Answer: 2
Also accepted: two; 2 strokes; two strokes

2.2 亻 — *the same person, standing sideways*
Answer: it is about a person
Also accepted: person; about a person; it involves a person; people

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*
Answer: roughly how the word is pronounced
Also accepted: the pronunciation; how it sounds; the sound; how to say it

2.4 *Putting two pieces together — and reading the result*
Answer: the left
Also accepted: left; left half; the left half

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*
Answer: 3
Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*
Answer: child
Also accepted: a child; baby; kid; child, zi

2.7 *Two pieces again — and a warning about the story*
Answer: no
Also accepted: none; neither; no it does not

Chapter 3

3.1 一 — *one stroke, and that is the character*
Answer: 1
Also accepted: one; 1 stroke; one stroke

3.2 一 — *one, and the number is the strokes*
Answer: they are the same
Also accepted: they are the same number; one stroke means one; the same; stroke count equals the number; they match

3.3 二 — *two bars, and neither is decoration*
Answer: the bottom
Also accepted: bottom; lower; the lower one; bottom bar

3.4 二 — *two, and a syllable you have met before*
Answer: èr
Also accepted: er4; er

3.5 三 — *three bars, and the pattern's last stand*
Answer: the middle one
Also accepted: middle; the middle; middle bar; the middle bar; 2nd; second

3.6 三 — *three, and the end of the easy road*
Answer: no
Also accepted: four bars would be unreadable; you would have to count it; stacked bars stop being readable

3.7 四 — *a box, and the rule that governs every box*
Answer: the bottom
Also accepted: bottom; the bottom bar; bottom bar; closing the bottom; the closing bottom stroke

3.8 四 — *four, borrowed for its sound*
Answer: si sounds like the word for die
Also accepted: because si sounds like die; four sounds like death; si and si differ only by tone; it sounds like the word for death

3.9 五 — *count the strokes and be wrong*
Answer: 4
Also accepted: four; 4 strokes; four strokes

3.10 五 — *five, and the run is complete*
Answer: one two and three
Also accepted: 1 2 3; one, two, three; the first three; 一二三; yi er san

3.11 *Practice — read the numbers off a wall*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4; 四; four, because si sounds like the word for die; four - sounds like die; 4 - unlucky

Chapter 4

4.1 口 — *the box, on its own*
Answer: the bottom
Also accepted: bottom; the bottom bar; bottom bar; closing the bottom

4.2 口 — *mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere*
Answer: mouth
Also accepted: a mouth; an open mouth; mouth - it is a picture of one

4.3 日 — *one bar inside the box*
Answer: before
Also accepted: before it; before the bottom; the middle comes first

4.4 日 — *the sun, and the day it measures*
Answer: sun and day
Also accepted: sun and day - the sun measures the day; sun, day; the sun and the day it counts

4.5 不 — *four strokes, all of them separate*
Answer: 3
Also accepted: three; 3 times; three times

4.6 不 — *how Mandarin says no*
Answer: negate the word they asked about
Also accepted: by negating the verb; put bu in front of the word; negate what was asked; say bu plus the word

4.7 *Practice — one box, two characters, and a refusal*
Answer: it negates every word you know
Also accepted: it doubles your vocabulary; it turns any word into its opposite; every word gets a negative

Chapter 5

5.1 是 — *finish the sun, then build under it*
Answer: the sun character
Also accepted: 日; ri; the sun; sun

5.2 是 — *"is", and the nearest thing to "yes"*
Answer: echo the word back
Also accepted: repeat it; say it again; echo the word you were asked about

5.3 不是 — *"is not", and the second tone that moves*
Answer: before a fourth tone it becomes rising
Also accepted: before a falling tone, it rises; before 4th tone it becomes 2nd; it becomes second tone before a fourth tone; rising, before a fourth tone

5.4 *Practice — answering either way*
Answer: a word you keep or turn
Also accepted: the word, kept or negated; you echo it or negate it; one word and two things to do with it

Chapter 6

6.1 再 — *a bar, a frame, and a line that closes it*
Answer: one
Also accepted: as one; one stroke; 1; a single stroke; one turning stroke

6.2 见 — *an eye on two legs*
Answer: legs, from the person character
Also accepted: the legs of ren; two legs; the legs from 人; legs; 人

6.3 再见 — *the word that says what it means*
Answer: again see
Also accepted: see again; again, see; zai jian = again see; again + see

6.4 *Practice — a conversation that ends*
Answer: zàijiàn
Also accepted: zaijian; zai jian; zài jiàn; zaijian4; 再见

Chapter 7

7.1 早 — *sun on top, one more time*
Answer: the sun, four strokes
Also accepted: 日, four; the sun character, 4; 日 first, four strokes; 日 in four

7.2 上 — *the same rule, read the other way*
Answer: the vertical, because the bar does not cross it
Also accepted: vertical; the central vertical; the vertical, the bar meets it; the vertical stroke

7.3 早上 — *morning, and a syllable that goes light*
Answer: it is neutral
Also accepted: neutral tone; it lost its tone; it is unstressed; no tone, it is neutral

7.4 早上好 — *the greeting was a pattern all along*
Answer: 好, good
Also accepted: hao, good; 好 means good; 好 - good; the good character

7.5 *Practice — greeting the time of day*
Answer: 早上好
Also accepted: zaoshang hao; zǎoshang hǎo; zaoshanghao; the morning one; good morning

Chapter 8

8.1 我 — *seven strokes, and an honest admission*
Answer: the dot
Also accepted: dot; the upper right dot; the top right dot; the last dot

8.2 我 — *I, me, and saying who you are*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; one word; just one; only one

8.3 名 — *a mouth with something above it*
Answer: 口
Also accepted: kou; the mouth; 口 the mouth; mouth

8.4 字 — *a child under a roof*
Answer: character
Also accepted: a character; written character; chinese character; a written word

8.5 名字 — *the word for a name*
Answer: character
Also accepted: a character; written character; zi means character; a written unit

8.6 *Practice — saying who you are*
Answer: wǒ shì
Also accepted: wo shi; wǒshì; wo3 shi4; 我是

Chapter 9

9.1 什 — *both halves are old news*
Answer: the person radical, then ten
Also accepted: 亻 and 十; person and ten; the person, then ten; ren radical and shi

9.2 么 — *three strokes, and one of them turns*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; one stroke; a single stroke; one, unbroken

9.3 什么 — *what*
Answer: it asks
Also accepted: asks; it asks a question; asks for something back; it gets something back

9.4 *Practice — when you did not catch it*
Answer: shénme
Also accepted: shenme; shén me; shen2 me; 什么

Chapter 10

10.1 讠 — *the speech radical*
Answer: it is about speech
Also accepted: speech; it involves speaking; something to do with talking; about talking

10.2 谢 — *twelve strokes, and three pieces*
Answer: three, speech first
Also accepted: three, 讠 first; 3, the speech radical; three pieces, speech first; three - speech, body, inch

10.3 谢谢 — *said twice*
Answer: no
Also accepted: not quite; no, the second is light; no - the second goes neutral; they differ

10.4 不谢 — *answering thanks*
Answer: because 谢 is fourth tone
Also accepted: 谢 is fourth tone; bu rises before a fourth tone; the following tone is falling; because of the fourth tone after it

10.5 *Practice — thanks, and the answer*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; just one; one character; a single character

Chapter 11

11.1 请 — *a half that tells you the sound*
Answer: the sound
Also accepted: how to say it; the pronunciation; roughly how it sounds; the sound of the word

11.2 请 — *please, and after you*
Answer: go ahead
Also accepted: after you; please, go ahead; be my guest; I invite you to go first

11.3 *Practice — after you*
Answer: meaning and sound
Also accepted: what it means and how it sounds; meaning and pronunciation; sound and meaning; one for meaning, one for sound

Chapter 12

12.1 人 — *a person*
Answer: 人
Also accepted: 人 rén

12.2 女 — *female, woman*
Answer: 女
Also accepted: 女 nǚ

12.3 *Hear* érzi — *son*
Answer: son
Also accepted: a son

12.4 儿 — *fall, then bend and hook*
Answer: 儿
Also accepted: 儿 ér

12.5 儿子 — *son on the page*
Answer: 儿子
Also accepted: 儿子 érzi

12.6 *Hear* nǚ'ér — *daughter*
Answer: daughter
Also accepted: a daughter

12.7 女儿 — *daughter on the page*
Answer: 女儿
Also accepted: 女儿 nǚ'ér

12.8 *Hear* jiā — *home, family*
Answer: home and family
Also accepted: family and home; home; family; household and home

12.9 家 — *roof first, body second*
Answer: 宀
Also accepted: the roof; roof; 宀 roof

12.10 家 — *home on the page*
Answer: 家
Also accepted: 家 jiā

12.11 *Hear* jiārén — *family members*
Answer: family members
Also accepted: family; the people in a family; members of the family

12.12 家人 — *the people of the home*
Answer: 家人
Also accepted: 家人 jiārén

12.13 *Retrieve six people and family words*
Answer: 儿子 — 女儿 — 家人
Also accepted: 儿子 女儿 家人; 儿子, 女儿, 家人

12.14 *Payoff — six family words in four skills*
Answer: 家 — 人 — 家人
Also accepted: 家 人 家人; 家, 人, 家人

Chapter 13

13.1 *Hear* dà — *big*
Answer: big
Also accepted: large; big or large

13.2 大 — *one bar, two falls*
Answer: the horizontal stroke
Also accepted: horizontal; 一; the bar

13.3 大 — *big on the page*
Answer: 大
Also accepted: 大 dà

13.4 *Hear* dàjiā — *everyone*
Answer: everyone
Also accepted: everybody

13.5 大家 — *everyone on the page*
Answer: 大家
Also accepted: 大家 dàjiā

13.6 *Hear* xué — *study, learn*
Answer: study
Also accepted: learn; study or learn; to study; to learn

13.7 学 — *top, cover, child*
Answer: 子
Also accepted: 子 zi; child 子

13.8 学 — *study on the page*
Answer: 学
Also accepted: 学 xué

13.9 *Hear* xuésheng — *student*
Answer: student
Also accepted: a student

13.10 生 — *five measured strokes*
Answer: the long bottom horizontal
Also accepted: bottom horizontal; the bottom bar; horizontal

13.11 学生 — *student on the page*
Answer: 学生
Also accepted: 学生 xuésheng

13.12 *Hear* dàxué — *university*
Answer: university
Also accepted: college; university or college

13.13 大学 — *university on the page*
Answer: 大学
Also accepted: 大学 dàxué

13.14 *Hear* dàxuésheng — *university student*
Answer: university student
Also accepted: college student; a university student; a college student

13.15 大学生 — *university student on the page*
Answer: 大学生
Also accepted: 大学生 dàxuésheng

13.16 *Retrieve six size and school words*
Answer: 学生 — 大学 — 大学生
Also accepted: 学生 大学 大学生; 学生, 大学, 大学生

13.17 *Payoff — six school words in four skills*
Answer: 大家 — 大学 — 大学生
Also accepted: 大家 大学 大学生; 大家, 大学, 大学生

Chapter 14

14.1 *Hear* xiǎo — *small*
Answer: small
Also accepted: little; small or little

14.2 小 — *centre, left, right*
Answer: the centre vertical hook
Also accepted: centre vertical; vertical hook; middle stroke

14.3 小 — *small on the page*
Answer: 小
Also accepted: 小 xiǎo

14.4 *Hear* xiǎoxué — *primary school*
Answer: primary school
Also accepted: elementary school; primary or elementary school

14.5 小学 — *primary school on the page*
Answer: 小学
Also accepted: 小学 xiǎoxué

14.6 *Hear* xiǎoxuésheng — *primary-school student*
Answer: primary-school student
Also accepted: elementary-school student; a primary school student; an elementary school student

14.7 小学生 — *primary-school student on the page*
Answer: 小学生
Also accepted: 小学生 xiǎoxuésheng

14.8 *Retrieve three primary-school words*
Answer: 小 — 小学 — 小学生
Also accepted: 小 小学 小学生; 小, 小学, 小学生

14.9 *Payoff — three primary-school words in four skills*
Answer: 小学 — 小学生
Also accepted: 小学 小学生; 小学, 小学生

Chapter 15

15.1 *Hear* zhōng — *middle*
Answer: middle
Also accepted: centre; center; middle or centre

15.2 中 — *close, then pass through*
Answer: close the box
Also accepted: the box closes; draw the bottom horizontal; close 口

15.3 中 — *middle on the page*
Answer: 中
Also accepted: 中 zhōng

15.4 *Hear* zhōngxué — *middle school*
Answer: middle school
Also accepted: a middle school

15.5 中学 — *middle school on the page*
Answer: 中学
Also accepted: 中学 zhōngxué

15.6 *Retrieval 1 — middle and middle school*
Answer: 中 — 中学
Also accepted: 中 中学; 中, 中学

15.7 *Hear* zhōngxuésheng — *middle-school student*
Answer: middle-school student
Also accepted: a middle school student; middle school student

15.8 中学生 — *middle-school student on the page*
Answer: 中学生
Also accepted: 中学生 zhōngxuésheng

15.9 *Hear* tóngxué — *classmate*
Answer: classmate
Also accepted: schoolmate; a classmate; a schoolmate

15.10 同 — *frame, line, box*
Answer: 口
Also accepted: the inner 口; mouth box; a box

15.11 同学 — *classmate on the page*
Answer: 同学
Also accepted: 同学 tóngxué

15.12 *Retrieval 2 — school and people*
Answer: 中学 — 中学生 — 同学
Also accepted: 中学 中学生 同学; 中学, 中学生, 同学

15.13 *Hear* shàngxué — *go to school*
Answer: go to school
Also accepted: attend school; to go to school; to attend school

15.14 上学 — *go to school on the page*
Answer: 上学
Also accepted: 上学 shàngxué

15.15 *Retrieval 3 — place, person, classmate, action*
Answer: 中学 — 中学生 — 同学 — 上学
Also accepted: 中学 中学生 同学 上学; 中学, 中学生, 同学, 上学

15.16 *Retrieval 4 — the full school ladder*
Answer: 小学 — 中学 — 大学
Also accepted: 小学 中学 大学; 小学, 中学, 大学

15.17 *Payoff — four school compounds in four skills*
Answer: 中学 — 同学 — 上学
Also accepted: 中学 同学 上学; 中学, 同学, 上学

Chapter 16

16.1 *Hear* zì — *a written character*
Answer: a written Chinese character
Also accepted: character; written character; Chinese character

16.2 字 — *the familiar shape stands alone*
Answer: 字
Also accepted: 字 zì

16.3 *Hear* hànzì — *Chinese character*
Answer: Chinese character
Also accepted: a Chinese character; Han character; a Han character

16.4 汉 — *watch five strokes*
Answer: turn down-left, then fall down-right
Also accepted: left then right; down-left then down-right; turn left and fall right

16.5 汉 — *copy with a five-part cue*
Answer: five strokes and four lifts
Also accepted: 5 strokes, 4 lifts; five and four

16.6 汉 — *hold the route briefly*
Answer: 汉
Also accepted: 汉 hàn

16.7 汉字 — *two known routes, one word*
Answer: hànzì — Chinese character
Also accepted: hanzi, Chinese character; Chinese character; hànzì

16.8 *Hear* hànyǔ — *the Chinese language*
Answer: hànyǔ
Also accepted: hanyu; hànyǔ means Chinese language

16.9 *Retrieval 1* — 字 *and* 汉字
Answer: 字 — 汉字
Also accepted: 字 汉字; 字, 汉字

16.10 语 — *speech, five, box*
Answer: 讠 first; 口 closes it
Also accepted: speech radical then box; 讠 then 口; yan first and kou last

16.11 语 — *copy, then fade*
Answer: speech, five, box
Also accepted: 讠 五 口; yan five kou; speech five mouth

16.12 语 — *wait, then write*
Answer: 讠
Also accepted: speech radical; the left side; yan

16.13 汉语 — *the language in writing*
Answer: hànyǔ — the Chinese language
Also accepted: hanyu, Chinese language; Chinese language; hànyǔ

16.14 *Retrieval 2 — character or language?*
Answer: 汉字 — 汉语
Also accepted: 汉字 汉语; 汉字, 汉语

16.15 *Checkpoint* — 字, 汉字, 汉语
Answer: 字 — 汉字 — 汉语
Also accepted: 字 汉字 汉语; 字, 汉字, 汉语

Chapter 17

17.1 *Hear* zhōngwén — *Chinese*
Answer: Chinese; the Chinese language
Also accepted: Chinese; Chinese language; the Chinese language

17.2 文 — *watch four open strokes*
Answer: fall left, then fall right
Also accepted: left then right; down-left then down-right; left-falling then right-falling

17.3 文 — *copy with the route visible*
Answer: four strokes and three lifts
Also accepted: 4 strokes, 3 lifts; four and three

17.4 文 — *wait, then open the two falls*
Answer: 文
Also accepted: 文 wén

17.5 中文 — *two known squares*
Answer: zhōngwén — Chinese; the Chinese language
Also accepted: Chinese; Chinese language; zhongwen; zhōngwén

17.6 *Longer return — character or language?*
Answer: 汉语 — 汉字 — 字
Also accepted: 汉语 汉字 字; 汉语, 汉字, 字

17.7 *Hear* zhōngguó — *China*
Answer: zhōngguó
Also accepted: zhongguo; zhōngguó means China

17.8 国 — *frame, inside, close*
Answer: after every stroke of 玉 inside is finished
Also accepted: last; after the inside; after 玉; after the inner dot

17.9 国 — *copy with the frame open*
Answer: eight strokes and seven lifts
Also accepted: 8 strokes, 7 lifts; eight and seven

17.10 国 — *wait before closing*
Answer: finish 玉 inside
Also accepted: finish the inside; write 玉; complete all inner strokes

17.11 中国 — *China in two squares*
Answer: zhōngguó — China
Also accepted: China; zhongguo; zhōngguó

17.12 *Retrieval 1 — language or country?*
Answer: 中文 — 中国
Also accepted: 中文 中国; 中文, 中国

17.13 *Longer return — the older three*
Answer: 字 — 汉语 — 汉字
Also accepted: 字 汉语 汉字; 字, 汉语, 汉字

17.14 *Listening score — five meanings*
Answer: zhōngguó
Also accepted: zhongguo; zhōngguó means China

17.15 *Reading score — no pinyin*
Answer: 中文 — Chinese language; 中国 — China
Also accepted: 中文 Chinese, 中国 China; Chinese language; China

17.16 *Writing score — from sound, no model*
Answer: 中文 — 中国
Also accepted: 中文 中国; 中文, 中国

17.17 *Payoff — five identity words*
Answer: 字 — 汉字 — 汉语 — 中文 — 中国
Also accepted: 字 汉字 汉语 中文 中国; 字, 汉字, 汉语, 中文, 中国

Chapter 18

18.1 *Hear* kàn — *look or watch*
Answer: look at or watch
Also accepted: look; look at; watch; to look at; to watch

18.2 看 — *a hand above an eye*
Answer: nine
Also accepted: 9; nine strokes

18.3 看 — *copy hand above, eye below*
Answer: 目, the eye shape
Also accepted: 目; eye; the eye component; mu

18.4 看 — *wait, then recover the eye*
Answer: 看
Also accepted: 看 kàn

18.5 看 — *the familiar sound meets the shape*
Answer: kàn — look at or watch — 看
Also accepted: kan look watch 看; kàn look at 看; kàn watch 看

18.6 *Hear* kànjiàn — *see*
Answer: see or catch sight of
Also accepted: see; to see; catch sight of

18.7 看见 — *looking reaches seeing*
Answer: 看见
Also accepted: 看见 kànjiàn

18.8 *Hear* hǎokàn — *good-looking*
Answer: good-looking or nice to look at
Also accepted: good-looking; good looking; nice to look at; pretty

18.9 好看 — *good to look at*
Answer: 好看
Also accepted: 好看 hǎokàn

18.10 *Retrieval 1 — look, see, or good-looking?*
Answer: 看 — 看见 — 好看
Also accepted: 看 看见 好看; 看, 看见, 好看

18.11 *Hear* shū — *book*
Answer: book
Also accepted: a book

18.12 书 — *two folds, upright, dot*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4; four strokes

18.13 书 — *copy the compact route*
Answer: the dot at the upper right
Also accepted: dot; the dot; upper-right dot

18.14 书 — *wait, then place the dot*
Answer: 书
Also accepted: 书 shū

18.15 书 — *the sound meets the shape*
Answer: shū — book — 书
Also accepted: shu book 书; shū book 书

18.16 *Hear* kànshū — *read a book*
Answer: read a book or read books
Also accepted: read; read a book; read books; to read

18.17 看书 — *look at a book, read*
Answer: 看书
Also accepted: 看书 kànshū

18.18 *Retrieval 2 — the earlier three return*
Answer: 好看 — 看 — 看见
Also accepted: 好看 看 看见; 好看, 看, 看见

18.19 *Retrieval 1 — book or read a book?*
Answer: 书 — 看书
Also accepted: 书 看书; 书, 看书

18.20 *Listening score — five nearby meanings*
Answer: kànshū
Also accepted: kanshu; kànshū means read a book

18.21 *Reading score — no pinyin*
Answer: kànjiàn — see; kànshū — read a book
Also accepted: see; read a book; kànjiàn see, kànshū read; 看见 see 看书 read

18.22 *Writing score — sound to Hanzi, no model*
Answer: 看 — 看见 — 好看 — 书 — 看书
Also accepted: 看 看见 好看 书 看书; 看, 看见, 好看, 书, 看书

18.23 *Payoff — looking and reading*
Answer: 看 — 看见 — 好看 — 书 — 看书
Also accepted: 看 看见 好看 书 看书; 看, 看见, 好看, 书, 看书

Chapter 19

19.1 *Hear* ma *— the syllable that asks*
Answer: none — it is neutral
Also accepted: none; neutral; no tone; neutral tone

19.2 吗 *— the mouth, then the horse*
Answer: six, and the left 口 is written first
Also accepted: six left; 6 left; six, 口 first; 6, kou first

19.3 吗 *— copy it, and keep the mouth small*
Answer: the long horizontal across the right half
Also accepted: the long horizontal; long bar; the wide horizontal; horizontal

19.4 吗 *— wait, then write the bar*
Answer: the left 口
Also accepted: left; 口; the mouth; kou; the left half

19.5 吗 *— the sound meets the shape*
Answer: at the end, and it turns the statement into a yes-or-no question
Also accepted: at the end; end, makes it a question; at the end - question

19.6 *Hear* nǐ hǎo ma *— how are you*
Answer: how are you
Also accepted: how are you?; are you well

19.7 你好吗 *— the greeting, asked*
Answer: 你好吗
Also accepted: 你好吗 nǐ hǎo ma; ni hao ma 你好吗

19.8 *Retrieval 1 — greeting, or question?*
Answer: 你好 — 你好吗
Also accepted: 你好 你好吗; 你好, 你好吗

19.9 *Hear* shì ma *— is that so?*
Answer: after somebody tells you something, to check it and invite them to go on
Also accepted: to check what you were told; really; is that so; to show you heard

19.10 是吗 *— checking what you were told*
Answer: 是吗
Also accepted: 是吗 shì ma; shi ma 是吗

19.11 *Hear* hǎo bu hǎo — *the question with the answer inside it*
Answer: good, not, good
Also accepted: good not good; hao bu hao; the word, its negative, the word again

19.12 好不好 — *the question that needed no new character*
Answer: put 吗 at the end, or say the word, 不, and the word again
Also accepted: ma at the end and verb-not-verb; 吗 or 不; ma, or the word not the word

19.13 *Retrieval 2 — which question was that?*
Answer: 好不好
Also accepted: 好不好 hǎo bu hǎo; hao bu hao; the good-not-good one

19.14 *Listening score — catch the question*
Answer: three of three
Also accepted: 3; 3/3; three; two; 2; one; 1; zero; 0

19.15 *Reading score — no pinyin on the card*
Answer: a 吗 at the end, or a word repeated around 不
Also accepted: 吗 at the end or 不 in the middle; ma or bu; the last character, or the repetition

19.16 *Payoff — the book can ask*
Answer: four separate numbers out of four
Also accepted: 4 4 4 4; 4/4 4/4 4/4 4/4; three four four three; 3 4 4 3

Chapter 20

20.1 六 — *four strokes again, for six this time*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4; four strokes

20.2 六 — *six, and the run starts again*
Answer: si
Also accepted: 四; sì, four; four

20.3 七 — *two strokes, for seven*
Answer: once
Also accepted: 1; one; once, after the horizontal

20.4 七 — *seven*
Answer: where it is for y in yes
Also accepted: like y; the y position; front, as for y

20.5 八 — *a character you have already written twice*
Answer: the strokes are parted at the top
Also accepted: they do not touch; the gap at the top; 人 joins, 八 does not

20.6 八 — *eight, and why it costs more*
Answer: it sounds like fa, to prosper
Also accepted: it sounds like the word for prosper; fa; sounds like getting rich

20.7 九 — *two strokes again*
Answer: six
Also accepted: 6; six, two each

20.8 九 — *nine*
Answer: third
Also accepted: 3; tone 3; the third, the dip

20.9 十 — *the character that was already here*
Answer: 早
Also accepted: zao; 早, morning; morning

20.10 十 — *ten*
Answer: second, and no
Also accepted: second tone, no others; 2, none; the rise, and it is the only one

20.11 *Payoff — one to ten*
Answer: yī èr sān sì wǔ liù qī bā jiǔ shí
Also accepted: yi er san si wu liu qi ba jiu shi; yī, èr, sān, sì, wǔ, liù, qī, bā, jiǔ, shí

Chapter 21

21.1 十一 — *eleven, and the teens in one line*
Answer: shíqī
Also accepted: shiqi; 十七; shí qī

21.2 二十 — *twenty, and ninety-nine numbers from ten words*
Answer: the order
Also accepted: the order of the two words; ten-one versus two-ten; which comes first

21.3 百 — *a hundred, on a box you have built before*
Answer: the bottom horizontal
Also accepted: the floor; the closing bottom bar; the bottom bar

21.4 一百 — *a hundred, and* 一 *moves*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it falls; no — it becomes a fall; it falls

21.5 *5 and* 五 — *the same number, two registers*
Answer: èrshí
Also accepted: ershi; 二十; er shi

21.6 *Payoff — ninety-nine numbers, and the price tag*
Answer: liùshíbā jiǔshíjiǔ
Also accepted: liushiba jiushijiu; liùshíbā, jiǔshíjiǔ; liushiba, jiushijiu

21.7 *Close the numeral slice*
Answer: 十 百
Also accepted: 十, 百; 十百

Chapter 29

29.1 *(reading) — six characters, nothing said first*
Answer: shu
Also accepted: 书; shū

29.2 *(reading) — six words, not six characters*
Answer: kan shu de ren
Also accepted: 看书的人; the reader

29.3 *(reading) — the first passage*
Answer: 18
Also accepted: 十八; eighteen

Chapter 30

30.1 很好 *— I'm fine*
Answer: 我很好
Also accepted: wo hen hao; wǒ hěn hǎo; 很好; hen hao; hěn hǎo

30.2 *nǐ zěnmeyàng — wǒ hěn hǎo*
Answer: B
Also accepted: speaker b; the second speaker

Chapter 85

85.1 我在这儿 — 你在那儿
Answer: outside
Also accepted: wàibian; waibian; outside the house

Chapter 86

86.1 你在哪儿 — 我在那儿
Answer: under the chair
Also accepted: zài yǐzi xiàbian; under a chair; below the chair

Chapter 87

87.1 不 *—* 没*: two words for not*
Answer: 没
Also accepted: mei; méi; 没有

87.2 你有没有 — 没有
Answer: no
Also accepted: méiyǒu; meiyou; 没有; no key

Chapter 88

88.1 *yī → yí ge, yì tiān: the tone* 一 *takes*
Answer: rising
Also accepted: yí; yi2; it rises; rises

88.2 两个人
Answer: 2
Also accepted: two; 两; liǎng bēi; liang bei

Chapter 89

89.1 给我
Answer: in the bag
Also accepted: bāo lǐbian; bao libian; the bag; into the bag

Chapter 90

90.1 我会开车
Answer: work
Also accepted: at work; B is at work; shàngbān; shangban

Chapter 91

91.1 我想要一点儿水
Answer: no
Also accepted: bú yào; bu yao; 不要; no thanks

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92.1 我也要
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Also accepted: jiǎozi; jiaozi; water and dumplings; the same as A

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93.1 太大了
Answer: a bit small
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94.1 我们都是学生
Answer: their teacher
Also accepted: the teacher; lǎoshī; laoshi; teacher

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95.1 你为什么不去
Answer: something on
Also accepted: yǒushì; youshi; busy; has something on

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96.1 为什么 — 因为
Answer: not well
Also accepted: unwell; not feeling well; bù shūfu; bu shufu; ill

Chapter 97

97.1 *(reading) — a Sunday at home*
Answer: 2
Also accepted: two; two o'clock; 两点; liǎng diǎn; 2pm

97.2 *My own line — the first Chinese with no model*
Answer: 小时
Also accepted: xiǎoshí; xiaoshi

Chapter 98

98.1 *The same writing, with a clock*
Answer: 家在哪儿
Also accepted: jiā zài nǎr; jia zai nar

Sources for this starter edition

Character shapes, components, and stroke order follow this project's curated character inventory, whose stroke orders are marked authoritative because Chinese stroke order is a standardised taught system rather than a convention. Codepoint and glyph references are to the Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart.

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explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 44, p. 405
hot *rè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 51, p. 461
hour 小时 (xiǎoshí)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 97, p. 835
house *fángzi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 57, p. 503
Housework
chapter topic; Chapter 133, p. 1091
housework *jiāwù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 133, p. 1091
How Are You?
chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 293
how are you, written from three characters already yours 你好吗 (nǐ hǎo ma)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 19, p. 185

how many; a few *jǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 48, p. 439
how much; how many 多少 (duōshao)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 957
how old (asking a person's age) 多大 (duō dà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 78, p. 669
How You Feel
chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 461
hungry *è*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 359

I

I, me — one word for both, and no change for either 我 (wǒ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 8, p. 75
important 重要 (zhòngyào)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 144, p. 1167
in childhood; when one was little *xiǎoshíhou*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 78, p. 669
in front; ahead 前边 (qiánbian)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 111, p. 935
In Front and Behind
chapter topic; Chapter 111, p. 935
In the Bathroom
chapter topic; Chapter 105, p. 891
In the Kitchen
chapter topic; Chapter 101, p. 861
In the Shop
chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 391
inside; in *lǐbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 85, p. 719
inside; in 里 (lǐ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 81, p. 691
interesting *yǒuyìsi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 1059
is it good, written from three characters already yours and no new shape at all 好不好 (hǎo bu hǎo)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 19, p. 185
is not — and a pitch that moves to get out of the way 不是 (bú shì)
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 51

is that so, written from two characters already yours 是吗 (shì ma)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 19, p. 185
Is There Any?
chapter topic; Chapter 87, p. 737

J

Jobs
chapter topic; Chapter 80, p. 685
joyful; happy 快乐 (kuàilè)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 75, p. 647

K

key *yàoshi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 87, p. 737
kitchen *chúfáng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 101, p. 861
knife *dāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 101, p. 861

L

lamp; light *dēng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 87, p. 737
Language or country?
chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
Late Again
chapter topic; Chapter 145, p. 1173
le after a verb: the event is finished — and this is aspect, not tense 了 (le)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 25, p. 249
Le — Finished, and Changed
chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 249
Learning
chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 483
lèi — 'tired', and asked with 吗 like any other statement *lèi*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 30, p. 293
lesson; class *kè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 54, p. 483

letter (in the post) *xìn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 118, p. 983
library *túshūguǎn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 100, p. 855
like this; this way *zhèyàng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 127, p. 1043
lively; bustling *rènao*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 1059
long 长 (cháng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 61, p. 533
Long and Short
chapter topic; Chapter 61, p. 533
Looking and reading
chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 171
luggage *xíngli*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 119, p. 989
lunch 午饭 (wǔfàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 69, p. 601

M

mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words
pronunciation topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
male 男 (nán)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 33, p. 321
man 男人 (nánrén)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 33, p. 321
máng — 'busy', an adjective, so it takes 很 like 好 *máng*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 30, p. 293
match; competition *bǐsài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 135, p. 1107
may; can (with permission) *kěyǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 90, p. 771
Me Too
chapter topic; Chapter 92, p. 787
Meals
chapter topic; Chapter 69, p. 601
meat *ròu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 70, p. 609
menu *càidān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 92, p. 787
middle school, built from known characters 中学 (zhōngxué)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 137

middle-school student, built from known characters 中学生 (zhōngxuésheng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 137
milk *niúnǎi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 367
minute (a length of time) *fēnzhōng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 1161
minute; to divide *fēn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 48, p. 439
mirror *jìngzi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 891
mobile phone 手机 (shǒujī)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 58, p. 511
Monday 星期一 (xīngqīyī)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 46, p. 421
money *qián*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 957
month; moon *yuè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 47, p. 429
Months and Years
chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 429
More Housework
chapter topic; Chapter 142, p. 1155
More to Eat
chapter topic; Chapter 70, p. 609
morning — and a syllable with no tone at all 早上 (zǎoshang)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 67
morning (before noon) 上午 (shàngwǔ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 49, p. 447
most *zuì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 140, p. 1141
mountain; hill 山 (shān)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 68, p. 593
mouth 口 (kǒu)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 41
Mr; sir; husband *xiānsheng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 337
Mum and Dad
chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 313
mum; mother 妈妈 (māma)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 32, p. 313
Music
chapter topic; Chapter 128, p. 1051

music 音乐 (yīnyuè)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 128, p. 1051
My Day in Characters
chapter topic; Chapter 97, p. 835
My own line — the first Chinese with no model
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 97, p. 835

N

name — literally the characters a name is made of 名字 (míngzi)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 75
Ne and Dui
chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 259
ne — the particle that hands the question back, and turns one word into a whole turn 呢 (ne)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 26, p. 259
near; close *jìn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 62, p. 541
nearby; in the area *fùjìn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 111, p. 935
new *xīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 61, p. 533
next year 明年 (míngnián)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 47, p. 429
Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character
chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1
ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written
pronunciation topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1
nice to drink 好喝 (hǎohē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 71, p. 615
nine — third tone, and a dip you have had since ni 九 (jiǔ)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 199
noisy 吵 (chǎo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 1059
noodles *miàntiáo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 70, p. 609
noon 中午 (zhōngwǔ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 49, p. 447
not have; there is no 没有 (méiyǒu)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 87, p. 737
not — the character that turns a word around 不 (bù)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 41

notebook 本子 (běnzi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 883
now *xiànzài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 45, p. 413
number (of a phone, a room); identifying number *hàomǎ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 63, p. 549

O

o'clock; dot 点 (diǎn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 48, p. 439
often *chángcháng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 126, p. 1035
Often and Sometimes
chapter topic; Chapter 126, p. 1035
old *lǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 337
old (of things); no longer new *jiù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 62, p. 541
On the Desk
chapter topic; Chapter 104, p. 883
On the Move
chapter topic; Chapter 107, p. 905
On the Phone
chapter topic; Chapter 63, p. 549
on time; punctual *zhǔnshí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 1161
on top; above *shàngbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 86, p. 727
one 一 (yī)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 25
One Box, Two Characters, and the First Thing You Can Refuse
chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 41
One Character, Two Courtesies
chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 93
one half; half (of something) 一半 (yíbàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 140, p. 1141
One small step into school
chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 131
One to Five — Where the Character Is the Count
chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 25
oneself *zìjǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 1127

Opening Hours
chapter topic; Chapter 122, p. 1009
opposite; across from *duìmiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 82, p. 699
other people *biérén*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 1127
other; the others *qítā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 1127
Out of Town
chapter topic; Chapter 68, p. 593
outside *wàibian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 85, p. 719
overcast day *yīntiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 136, p. 1113

P

paper *zhǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 883
parcel; package *bāoguǒ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 118, p. 983
park *gōngyuán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 100, p. 855
Parting
chapter topic; Chapter 76, p. 655
passport *hùzhào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 971
patient; sick person 病人 (bìngrén)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 130, p. 1067
Paying
chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 957; Chapter 114, p. 957
pen *bǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 883
pencil *qiānbǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 104, p. 883
People under one roof
chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 111
person 人 (rén)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 111
photo; photograph *zhàopiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 919
piano *gāngqín*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 110, p. 927

pink *fěnhóng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 1135
place *dìfang*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 81, p. 691
Places in Town
chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 405
plate; dish *pánzi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 101, p. 861
pleasant to hear *hǎotīng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 128, p. 1051
pleasantly cool *liángkuai*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 136, p. 1113
please — a word you can say on its own, and a frame waiting to be filled 请 (qǐng)
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 103
post office *yóujú*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 100, p. 855
present; gift *lǐwù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 75, p. 647
pretty; good-looking *piàoliang*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 59, p. 519
primary school, built from known characters 小学 (xiǎoxué)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 131
primary-school student, built from known characters 小学生 (xiǎoxuésheng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 131
Putting two pieces together — and reading the result
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

Q

quickly; hurry *gǎnkuài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 1173
quiet *ānjìng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 1059
Quiet and Noisy
chapter topic; Chapter 129, p. 1059

R

railway station *huǒchēzhàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 73, p. 629

rain 雨 (yǔ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 66, p. 577
Reading — Characters, Words, and a First Passage
chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 289
Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time
chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 11
really; truly *zhēn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 77, p. 663
reason; cause *yuányīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 1173
red *hóng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 60, p. 525
restaurant *fàndiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 44, p. 405
right; suitable; a good fit *héshì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 108, p. 911
road; way *lù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 72, p. 621
room *fángjiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 57, p. 503
round *yuán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 1135
rubbish *lājī*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 142, p. 1155
Running Late
chapter topic; Chapter 83, p. 705

S

sad; upset *nánguò*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 125, p. 1029
salty *xián*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 71, p. 615
Saying Who You Are
chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 75
school *xuéxiào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 43, p. 397
schoolbag 书包 (shūbāo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 119, p. 989
Screens
chapter topic; Chapter 109, p. 919
season *jìjié*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 131, p. 1075

second (of time) *miǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 1161
See You Again
chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 59
see you tomorrow 明天见 (míngtiān jiàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 76, p. 655
Sending Things
chapter topic; Chapter 118, p. 983
seven — first tone, and a consonant English does not have 七 (qī)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 199
she; her *tā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 305
shoe *xié*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 59, p. 519
shop *shāngdiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 42, p. 391
short in height; low *ǎi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 61, p. 533
short in length; brief *duǎn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 61, p. 533
side; beside *pángbiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 81, p. 691
simple *jiǎndān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 144, p. 1167
six — the sixth number, and the first one past where this book stopped 六 (liù)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 199
Six to Ten, and the Character That Was Already Here
chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 199
size 大小 (dàxiǎo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 108, p. 911
Sleeping and Waking
chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 455
slow *màn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 53, p. 475
small; little, now read and written 小 (xiǎo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 131
snow *xuě*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 66, p. 577
so; therefore *suǒyǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 96, p. 827
soap *féizào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 891

soft *ruǎn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 134, p. 1099
some; a few 一些 (yìxiē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 127, p. 1043
something else; other *biéde*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 92, p. 787
Something to Drink
chapter topic; Chapter 102, p. 869
sometimes *yǒushíhou*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 126, p. 1035
son, now read and written 儿子 (érzi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 111
song *gē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 128, p. 1051
sore; painful *téng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 130, p. 1067
sorry 对不起 (duìbuqǐ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 64, p. 559
soup *tāng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 70, p. 609
Speaking and Hearing
chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 475
special; especially *tèbié*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 144, p. 1167
spicy; hot *là*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 71, p. 615
Sport
chapter topic; Chapter 135, p. 1107
sport; exercise *yùndòng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 56, p. 497
spring 春天 (chūntiān)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 131, p. 1075
stairs; staircase *lóutī*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 112, p. 943
star 星星 (xīngxing)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 68, p. 593
station; stop 车站 (chēzhàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 106, p. 897
steamed bun *bāozi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 70, p. 609
Stops and Stations
chapter topic; Chapter 106, p. 897
student, now read and written 学生 (xuésheng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 121

study; learn, now read and written 学 (xué)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 121
suì — years of age, and the sentence that says how old you are without a verb in it 岁 (suì)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 27, p. 269
summer *xiàtiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 131, p. 1075
sun *tàiyang*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 68, p. 593
sun, and also day 日 (rì)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 41
Sunday 星期天 (xīngqītiān)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 46, p. 421
sunny day; fine weather *qíngtiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 136, p. 1113
supermarket *chāoshì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 100, p. 855
sweet *tián*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 71, p. 615

T

table *zhuōzi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 57, p. 503
Takeaway
chapter topic; Chapter 120, p. 997
takeaway; food delivered *wàimài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 120, p. 997
Tall and Handsome
chapter topic; Chapter 124, p. 1023
tall; high *gāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 61, p. 533
Tastes
chapter topic; Chapter 71, p. 615
tasty; good to eat 好吃 (hǎochī)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 69, p. 601
taxi *chūzūchē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 44, p. 405
tea *chá*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 367
teacher *lǎoshī*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 337
Teaching and Practising
chapter topic; Chapter 121, p. 1003

telephone; phone call 电话 (diànhuà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 63, p. 549
television *diànshì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 919
Telling the Time
chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 439
ten — and the last of the ten words that build every number to ninety-nine 十 (shí)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 199
ten thousand *wàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 132, p. 1083
Ten Words, Ninety-Nine Numbers
chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 213
text message *duǎnxìn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 118, p. 983
thank you — the same character twice, and the second one goes light 谢谢 (xièxie)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 93
Thanks and Replies
chapter topic; Chapter 77, p. 663
that 那 (nà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 351
that one 那个 (nàge)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 351
the Chinese language; Mandarin 汉语 (hànyǔ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 16, p. 147
The City
chapter topic; Chapter 81, p. 691
the digit and the character — which one a price, a date and a phone number use *5* **— 五** (wǔ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 213
the east; on the east side *dōngbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 117, p. 977
The Grammar That Is Not There
chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 221
the left; on the left *zuǒbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 82, p. 699
the middle; between *zhōngjiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 82, p. 699
the middle of the night *bànyè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 146, p. 1179
the north; on the north side *běibian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 117, p. 977

the question particle, recovered without pinyin 吗 (ma)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 19, p. 185
The Rest of the Family
chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 321
the right; on the right *yòubian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 82, p. 699
the same; alike *yíyàng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 94, p. 807
the south; on the south side *nánbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 117, p. 977
the Spring Festival; Chinese New Year 春节 (Chūnjié)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 137, p. 1119
The Weather
chapter topic; Chapter 66, p. 577
The Week
chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 421
the west; on the west side *xībian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 117, p. 977
there 那儿 (nàr)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 85, p. 719
these 这些 (zhèxiē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 127, p. 1043
These and Those
chapter topic; Chapter 127, p. 1043
they; them 他们 (tāmen)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 305
thin; slim *shòu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 94, p. 807
thing; things *dōngxi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 42, p. 391
Things I Can Do
chapter topic; Chapter 110, p. 927
Things I Carry
chapter topic; Chapter 116, p. 971
Things You Carry
chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 511
thirsty *kě*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 367
this 这 (zhè)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 351
this one 这个 (zhège)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 351
This One and That One
chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 351

this year 今年 (jīnnián)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 47, p. 429
those 那些 (nàxiē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 127, p. 1043
thousand 千 (qiān)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 132, p. 1083
Thousands
chapter topic; Chapter 132, p. 1083
three 三 (sān)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 25
ticket *piào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 73, p. 629
time; free time *shíjiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 83, p. 705
time; moment *shíhou*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 46, p. 421
time (one occurrence) *cì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 140, p. 1141
timetable *shíkèbiǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 122, p. 1009
to answer *huídá*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 121, p. 1003
to arrive; to reach *dào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 72, p. 621
to ask *wèn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 54, p. 483
to be afraid of; to fear *pà*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 51, p. 461
to be — and how Mandarin says yes 是 (shì)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 51
to be at; in, at 在 (zài)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 85, p. 719
to be called; to call 叫 (jiào)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 34, p. 329
to be careful; to mind (something) 小心 (xiǎoxīn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 115, p. 963
to be late; to arrive late *chídào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 83, p. 705
to be open for business *yíngyè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 122, p. 1009
to be short of; to (before the hour) *chà*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 1161
to be windy *guāfēng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 136, p. 1113

to begin; to start *kāishǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 122, p. 1009
to boil; to cook in water *zhǔ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 951
to borrow; to lend *jiè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 64, p. 559
to bring; to take along *dài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 89, p. 761
to brush one's teeth *shuāyá*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 99, p. 847
to buy 买 (mǎi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 40, p. 375
to calculate; to work out *suàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 140, p. 1141
to care about *guānxīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 123, p. 1017
to catch a cold; a cold *gǎnmào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 130, p. 1067
to celebrate the New Year *guònián*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 137, p. 1119
to change; to exchange *huàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 108, p. 911
to charge a battery *chōngdiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 919
to chat *liáotiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 84, p. 711
to clean (a room); to sweep 打扫 (dǎsǎo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 133, p. 1091
to climb; to crawl *pá*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 107, p. 905
to comb one's hair *shūtóu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 99, p. 847
to come 来 (lái)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 343
to come in; to enter 进 (jìn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 74, p. 637
to come to an end; to finish *jiéshù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 122, p. 1009
to cook 做饭 (zuòfàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 69, p. 601
to count *shǔ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 132, p. 1083
to cry; to weep *kū*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 51, p. 461

to cut; to slice *qiē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 951
to dance *tiàowǔ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 110, p. 927
to do; to make 做 (zuò)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 89, p. 761
to download *xiàzài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 919
to drink 喝 (hē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 367
to drive 开车 (kāichē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 72, p. 621
to dry in the sun *shài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 142, p. 1155
to eat 吃 (chī)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 359
to exercise; to work out *duànliàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 135, p. 1107
to fall ill; illness *bìng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 50, p. 455
to find (that); to feel; to think (that) *juéde*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 144, p. 1167
to finish class 下课 (xiàkè)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 79, p. 677
to fold *dié*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 133, p. 1091
to forbid; no (on signs) *jìnzhǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 115, p. 963
to forget *wàng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 95, p. 817
to fry (in a little oil) *jiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 951
to get angry 生气 (shēngqì)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 125, p. 1029
to get off (a bus or train) 下车 (xiàchē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 73, p. 629
to get on (a bus or train) 上车 (shàngchē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 73, p. 629
to get ready; to prepare *zhǔnbèi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 84, p. 711
to get up *qǐchuáng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 50, p. 455
to give a discount; to be on sale *dǎzhé*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 122, p. 1009

to give as a present; to see off *sòng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 75, p. 647
to give back *huán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 64, p. 559
to give change *zhǎoqián*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 114, p. 957
to give; to, for 给 (gěi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 89, p. 761
to go 去 (qù)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 43, p. 397
to go back; to return *huí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 43, p. 397
to go fishing *diàoyú*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 141, p. 1149
to go online 上网 (shàngwǎng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 109, p. 919
to go out *chūmén*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 43, p. 397
to go to work *shàngbān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 80, p. 685
to grow up 长大 (zhǎngdà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 78, p. 669
to have a fever *fāshāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 130, p. 1067
to have a shower; to have a bath *xǐzǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 99, p. 847
to have class; to start class 上课 (shàngkè)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 79, p. 677
to have something on; to be busy *yǒushì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 95, p. 817
to have the family name; family name *xìng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 34, p. 329
to have time off; to go on holiday *fàngjià*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 137, p. 1119
to help *bāng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 64, p. 559
to help out; to do a favour *bāngmáng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 64, p. 559
to introduce *jièshào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 74, p. 637
to jump *tiào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 107, p. 905
to kick *tī*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 135, p. 1107

to know a fact; to be aware *zhīdào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 62, p. 541
to know someone; to recognise *rènshi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 34, p. 329
to laugh; to smile *xiào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 56, p. 497
to leave a place *líkāi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 107, p. 905
to leave it till later 再说 (zàishuō)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 76, p. 655
to listen; to hear *tīng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 53, p. 475
to live somewhere; to stay *zhù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 337
to look at or watch, recovered without pinyin 看 (kàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 171
to look for *zhǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 63, p. 549
to lose (a thing) *diū*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 971
to love *ài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 55, p. 489
to make a booking; to order *dìng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 120, p. 997
to meet up; to see each other *jiànmiàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 84, p. 711
to mop the floor *tuōdì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 142, p. 1155
to move house; to move (something heavy) *bān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 107, p. 905
to need *xūyào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 91, p. 779
to open; to switch on *kāi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 65, p. 567
to order food *diǎncài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 71, p. 615
to pack food to take away 打包 (dǎbāo)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 120, p. 997
to paint pictures; to draw *huàhuà*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 110, p. 927
to pay *fù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 114, p. 957
to pay attention; to take care *zhùyì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 115, p. 963

to pay by card *shuākǎ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 114, p. 957
to pay the bill *mǎidān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 114, p. 957
to phone; to make a phone call 打电话 (dǎ diànhuà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 63, p. 549
to play an instrument; to pluck *tán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 110, p. 927
to play ball *dǎqiú*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 56, p. 497
to play; to have fun *wán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 56, p. 497
to post; to send by post *jì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 118, p. 983
to practise *liànxí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 121, p. 1003
to pull *lā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 112, p. 943
to push *tuī*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 112, p. 943
to put; to place *fàng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 89, p. 761
to rain *xiàyǔ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 66, p. 577
to read a book or read books 看书 (kànshū)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 171
to read aloud; to study *dú*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 54, p. 483
to receive; to accept *shōu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 118, p. 983
to repair; to fix *xiū*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 103, p. 875
to resemble; to take after *xiàng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 124, p. 1023
to rest *xiūxi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 50, p. 455
to revise; to go over again *fùxí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 121, p. 1003
to ride (a bike or a horse) *qí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 106, p. 897
to roast; to bake *kǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 951
to run behind schedule; to be late (of a train or plane) 晚点 (wǎndiǎn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 1173

to run out of time *láibují*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 83, p. 705
to run; to jog *pǎobù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 56, p. 497
to say; to speak 说 (shuō)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 53, p. 475
to see a doctor 看病 (kànbìng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 130, p. 1067
to see or catch sight of 看见 (kànjiàn)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 171
to sell *mài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 42, p. 391
to shut; to close; to switch off *guān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 65, p. 567
to sing *chànggē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 55, p. 489
to sit; to travel by *zuò*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 44, p. 405
to sleep in; to lie in *shuì lǎnjiào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 1173
to sleep; to go to bed *shuìjiào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 50, p. 455
to smoke *xīyān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 115, p. 963
to sort out; to put in order *zhěnglǐ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 142, p. 1155
to stand *zhàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 89, p. 761
to stir-fry *chǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 113, p. 951
to stop; to park *tíng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 107, p. 905
to stop worrying; to be at ease *fàngxīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 125, p. 1029
to stroll the shops; to go window-shopping *guàngjiē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 141, p. 1149
to study; to learn *xuéxí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 54, p. 483
to swim *yóuyǒng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 90, p. 771
to take a walk *sànbù*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 141, p. 1149
to take an exam *kǎoshì*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 79, p. 677

to take part in; to join *cānjiā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 84, p. 711
to take; to hold *ná*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 103, p. 875
to teach *jiāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 121, p. 1003
to thank (warmly) *gǎnxiè*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 77, p. 663
to throw; to throw away *rēng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 103, p. 875
to thunder *dǎléi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 136, p. 1113
to tidy up *shōushi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 133, p. 1091
to travel; to tour *lǚyóu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 141, p. 1149
to trouble; to bother *máfan*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 77, p. 663
to try; to try on 试 (shì)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 108, p. 911
to turn a corner *guǎi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 111, p. 935
to understand *dǒng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 53, p. 475
to use 用 (yòng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 103, p. 875
to wait; to wait for *děng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 48, p. 439
to wake up *xǐng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 146, p. 1179
to walk; to leave *zǒu*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 43, p. 397
to want; to ask for *yào*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 957
to want to; to think; to miss 想 (xiǎng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 55, p. 489
to want; would like 想要 (xiǎngyào)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 91, p. 779
to wash 洗 (xǐ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 99, p. 847
to wash one's face *xǐliǎn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 99, p. 847
to water the plants *jiāohuā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 142, p. 1155

to wear; to put on *chuān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 59, p. 519
to wipe *cā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 133, p. 1091
to work; job *gōngzuò*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 337
to worry *dānxīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 125, p. 1029
to write *xiě*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 54, p. 483
today 今天 (jīntiān)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 45, p. 413
Today and Tomorrow
chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 413
together 一起 (yìqǐ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 84, p. 711
toilet; washroom *xǐshǒujiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 86, p. 727
tomorrow *míngtiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 45, p. 413
Too Much
chapter topic; Chapter 93, p. 797
too; too much *tài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 957
toothbrush *yáshuā*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 891
toothpaste *yágāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 891
towel *máojīn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 105, p. 891
traffic jam; to be stuck in traffic *dǔchē*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 95, p. 817
train 火车 (huǒchē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 72, p. 621
Travel and Fun
chapter topic; Chapter 141, p. 1149
trousers *kùzi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 59, p. 519
Trying It On
chapter topic; Chapter 108, p. 911
twenty — two ten, and the same ten words now reach ninety-nine 二十 (èrshí)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 213

two 二 (èr)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 25
Two Cups of Tea
chapter topic; Chapter 88, p. 749
two (of something) 两 (liǎng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 88, p. 749
Two pieces again — and a warning about the story
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

U

ugly *nánkàn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 124, p. 1023
umbrella *yǔsǎn*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 971
under; below *xiàbian*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 86, p. 727
underground; metro *dìtiě*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 106, p. 897
university; college, built from known characters 大学 (dàxué)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 121
university student, built from known characters 大学生 (dàxuésheng)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 121
Using Things
chapter topic; Chapter 103, p. 875
usually; ordinarily *píngshí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 146, p. 1179

V

Visiting
chapter topic; Chapter 74, p. 637

W

waiter; attendant *fúwùyuán*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 92, p. 787
wallet; purse *qiánbāo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 971
warm; welcoming *rèqíng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 123, p. 1017

water 水 (shuǐ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 367
Way In, Way Out
chapter topic; Chapter 112, p. 943
we; us 我们 (wǒmen)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 305
weather 天气 (tiānqì)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 66, p. 577
week 星期 (xīngqī)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 46, p. 421
weekend *zhōumò*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 46, p. 421
welcome *huānyíng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 74, p. 637
What?
chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 85
What I Can Do
chapter topic; Chapter 90, p. 771
What I'd Like
chapter topic; Chapter 91, p. 779
What People Are Like
chapter topic; Chapter 123, p. 1017
what — the first question word in this book 什么 (shénme)
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 85
What You Are Called
chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 329
What You Love
chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 489
where? 哪儿 (nǎr)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 86, p. 727
Where Is It?
chapter topic; Chapter 86, p. 727
Where People Come From
chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 343
Where Things Are
chapter topic; Chapter 85, p. 719
which *nǎ*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 343
which one *nǎge*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 351
which ones 哪些 (nǎxiē)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 127, p. 1043
Which Way?
chapter topic; Chapter 117, p. 977

white; pale 白 (bái)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 60, p. 525
Who Does What
chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 337
Why?
chapter topic; Chapter 95, p. 817
why? 为什么 (wèishénme)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 95, p. 817
wind *fēng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 66, p. 577
winter *dōngtiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 131, p. 1075
With a Clock
chapter topic; Chapter 98, p. 843
woman 女人 (nǚrén)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 33, p. 321
words; speech 话 (huà)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 53, p. 475
worker *gōngrén*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 80, p. 685
wristwatch *shǒubiǎo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 116, p. 971
Writing score — from sound, no model
script and writing topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
wrong; mistaken *cuò*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 121, p. 1003

X

xǐhuan — 'to like', an ordinary verb with an ordinary object, and no inversion anywhere 喜欢 (xǐhuan)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 28, p. 279
Xihuan — What You Like
chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 279

Y

year 年 (nián)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 47, p. 429
yellow *huáng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 1135
Yes, No, and a Tone That Moves
chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 51

yesterday *zuótiān*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 45, p. 413
yī → yí ge, yì tiān: the tone 一 takes
pronunciation topic; explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 88, p. 749
you all; you (more than one) 你们 (nǐmen)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 305
you (one person) 你 (nǐ)
explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
you (polite) *nín*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 34, p. 329
you're welcome; don't mention it 不客气 (bú kèqi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 77, p. 663
you're welcome — real and understood everywhere, though not the commonest reply, which needs characters this book cannot yet print 不谢 (bú xiè)
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 93
yǒu — 'to have', and also 'there is': one verb where Spanish spends three points 有 (yǒu)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 24, p. 239
young *niánqīng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 94, p. 807
younger brother *dìdi*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 32, p. 313
younger sister *mèimei*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 33, p. 321
yuan; lump *kuài*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 957

Z

zěnmeyàng — 'how is it?', the everyday way to ask how somebody is doing *zěnmeyàng*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 293
zero *líng*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 132, p. 1083

Other

一 — one stroke, and that is the character
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 25
七 — two strokes, for seven
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 20, p. 199

三 — **three bars, and the pattern's last stand**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 25
上 — **the same rule, read the other way**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 7, p. 67
下 — **a bar, a vertical, a dot**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 73, p. 629
不 — **four strokes, all of them separate**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 41
不 — **没: two words for not**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 87, p. 737
两 — **a bar, a frame, two small 人**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 88, p. 749
个 — **three strokes, and you already write two of them**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 24, p. 239
中 — **close, then pass through**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 15, p. 137
中国人 — **a Chinese person, built out of three characters you already write 中国人** (Zhōngguó rén)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 22, p. 221
为 — **a dot, a long fall, the hook of 男, a dot**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 95, p. 817
么 — **three strokes, and one of them turns**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script; Chapter 9, p. 85
乐 — **a fall, a turn, and 小**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 75, p. 647
九 — **two strokes again**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 20, p. 199
也 — **the right half of 他**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 92, p. 787
书 — **a book, the book, books**
grammar topic; Chapter 22, p. 221
书 — **copy the compact route**
script and writing topic; Chapter 18, p. 171
书 — **two folds, upright, dot**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 171
书 — **wait, then place the dot**
script and writing topic; Chapter 18, p. 171
买 — **a lid, two dots, and a cut-down 大**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 40, p. 375
了 — **aspect, and why it is not a tense**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 25, p. 249
了 — **two strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 25, p. 249

二 — two bars, and neither is decoration
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 25
五 — count the strokes and be wrong
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 25
些 — two small pieces over 二
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 127, p. 1043
人 — two strokes, and a person walking
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11
亻 — the same person, standing sideways
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11
什 — both halves are old news
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 9, p. 85
今 — a roof, a dot and a turn
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 45, p. 413
他 — the person piece, then yě
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 31, p. 305
以 — four strokes in two pairs
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 126, p. 1035
们 — the person piece, then a doorway
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 31, p. 305
会 — 人 over two bars and a bend
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 76, p. 655
做 — the person, gǔ, and a striking hand
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 69, p. 601
儿 — fall, then bend and hook
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 12, p. 111
八 — a character you have already written twice
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 20, p. 199
六 — four strokes again, for six this time
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 20, p. 199
再 — a bar, a frame, and a line that closes it
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 6, p. 59
出 — two halves like 山, one long vertical
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 112, p. 943
前 — horns, a bar, the moon and a blade
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 78, p. 669
包 — a wrapping stroke, and three strokes inside
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 119, p. 989
十 — the character that was already here
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 20, p. 199
千 — a short fall over 十
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 132, p. 1083

午 — **the top of 年**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 49, p. 447
半 — **two dots, two bars, one vertical**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 140, p. 1141
去 — **a cross on a bar, and a corner below**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 43, p. 397
口 — **the box, on its own**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 41
叫 — **a small mouth, then two strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 34, p. 329
吃 — **a mouth, then three strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 38, p. 359
同 — **frame, line, box**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 15, p. 137
名 — **a mouth with something above it**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 8, p. 75
吗 — **copy it, and keep the mouth small**
script and writing topic; Chapter 19, p. 185
吗 — **the mouth, then the horse**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 185
吗 — **wait, then write the bar**
script and writing topic; Chapter 19, p. 185
吵 — **口, then 少**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 129, p. 1059
呢 — **吗's shape, a different sound**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 26, p. 259
和 — **eight strokes, and the right half is a mouth**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 27, p. 269
哪 — **口 beside the whole of 那**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 86, p. 727
喜 — **twelve strokes, stacked in four bands**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 28, p. 279
喝 — **a mouth, a sun and a wrap**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 39, p. 367
四 — **a box, and the rule that governs every box**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 25
因 — **大 inside the frame of 国**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 96, p. 827
国 — **copy with the frame open**
script and writing topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
国 — **frame, inside, close**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 159

国 — wait before closing
script and writing topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
在 — the top of 有, a vertical, then 土
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 85, p. 719
外 — the top of 多, then a vertical and a dot
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 110, p. 927
多 — the same three strokes, twice
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 41, p. 957
大 — one bar, two falls
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 13, p. 121
天 — one more bar over 大
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 45, p. 413
太 — 大, then a dot
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 93, p. 797
女 — three strokes, seated
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11
好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
妈 — the woman piece, then a horse
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 32, p. 313
子 — three strokes, a child
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11
字 — a child under a roof
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 8, p. 75
学 — top, cover, child
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 13, p. 121
客 — under the roof, a foot and 口
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 74, p. 637
家 — roof first, body second
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 12, p. 111
对 — five strokes, and a hand on the left
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 26, p. 259
小 — centre, left, right
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 131
少 — 小 without its hook, and a sweep
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 41, p. 957
尔 — a piece that is there for its sound
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11
山 — three peaks on a base
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 68, p. 593
岁 — six strokes, and a rule that is not left-to-right
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 27, p. 269

年 — **three bars and a long vertical**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 47, p. 429
开 — **two bars, two legs**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 72, p. 621
很 — **nine strokes, two pieces**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 30, p. 293
心 — **a dot, a lying hook, two dots**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 115, p. 963
快 — **the upright heart, then guài**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 62, p. 541
想 — **a tree and an eye, over a heart**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 55, p. 489
我 — **seven strokes, and an honest admission**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 8, p. 75
我是 — **nothing agrees with anything**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 22, p. 221
我是大学生了 — **something has changed**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 25, p. 249
手 — **a fall, two bars, a hook**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 52, p. 467
打 — **the hand piece, then dīng**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 63, p. 549
扫 — **the hand piece, then three bars**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 133, p. 1091
文 — **copy with the route visible**
script and writing topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
文 — **wait, then open the two falls**
script and writing topic; Chapter 17, p. 159
文 — **watch four open strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 159
日 — **one bar inside the box**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 41
早 — **sun on top, one more time**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 7, p. 67
时 — **日, then the right half of 对**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 97, p. 835
明 — **the sun beside the moon**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 47, p. 429
星 — **日 above 生**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 46, p. 421
春 — **三 and 人 over 日**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 131, p. 1075

是 — **finish the sun, then build under it**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 5, p. 51
晚 — **日, then seven strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 49, p. 447
有 — **six strokes, and a moon underneath**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 24, p. 239
期 — **eight strokes, then the moon**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 46, p. 421
本 — **the tree piece, and a bar at its foot**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 104, p. 883
机 — **the tree piece, then jǐ**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 58, p. 511
来 — **one piece, top to bottom**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 36, p. 343
欢 — **six strokes, and two of them are already yours**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 28, p. 279
每 — **a fall and a bar over a dotted box**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 138, p. 1127
气 — **a fall, two bars, a hook**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 66, p. 577
水 — **the middle first, then the sides**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 39, p. 367
汉 — **copy with a five-part cue**
script and writing topic; Chapter 16, p. 147
汉 — **hold the route briefly**
script and writing topic; Chapter 16, p. 147
汉 — **watch five strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 147
汉语 — **我看书: topic first, comment after**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 23, p. 229
没 — **water, a small roof, and 又**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 87, p. 737
洗 — **the water piece, then xiān**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 99, p. 847
火 — **two sparks around 人**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 72, p. 621
点 — **a mark on 口, over four dots**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 48, p. 439
生 — **five measured strokes**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 13, p. 121
用 — **the moon frame, two bars, a vertical**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 103, p. 875

电 — 日 with a long tail
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 63, p. 549
男 — a field above, strength below
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 33, p. 321
病 — the sickbed piece around a box
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 130, p. 1067
白 — a short fall over 日
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 60, p. 525
百 — a hundred, on a box you have built before
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 21, p. 213
的 — eight strokes for the commonest character there is
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 23, p. 229
看 — a hand above an eye
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 171
看 — copy hand above, eye below
script and writing topic; Chapter 18, p. 171
看 — the verb that never changes
grammar topic; Chapter 22, p. 221
看 — wait, then recover the eye
script and writing topic; Chapter 18, p. 171
看书的人 — the one who reads
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 23, p. 229
站 — the standing piece, then a mark over 口
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 106, p. 897
给 — the silk piece, then 合
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 89, p. 761
网 — the frame of 两, and two crosses
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 109, p. 919
能 — 厶 over the moon piece, then two 匕
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 90, p. 771
节 — the grass piece over a hook
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 137, p. 1119
菜 — the grass piece, a hand, the tree piece
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 101, p. 861
要 — the top of 西, then 女
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 91, p. 779
见 — an eye on two legs
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 6, p. 59
讠 — the speech radical
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 10, p. 93
试 — the speech piece, then a slanting hook
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 108, p. 911

话 — the speech piece, then a mouth
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 53, p. 475
语 — copy, then fade
script and writing topic; Chapter 16, p. 147
语 — speech, five, box
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 147
语 — wait, then write
script and writing topic; Chapter 16, p. 147
说 — the speech piece, then a mouth with legs
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 53, p. 475
请 — a half that tells you the sound
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 103
课 — the speech piece, then guǒ
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 79, p. 677
谢 — twelve strokes, and three pieces
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 10, p. 93
起 — the walking piece, carrying jǐ
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 64, p. 559
车 — four strokes, the vertical last
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 44, p. 405
边 — the foot of 男, inside the walking piece
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 111, p. 935
这 — 文, then the walking piece
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 37, p. 351
进 — jǐng on the road piece
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 74, p. 637
那 — four strokes, then an ear
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 37, p. 351
都 — 者, then the ear on the right
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 94, p. 807
里 — 日, a line through it, two bars
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 81, p. 691
重 — a fall and a bar over 里
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 134, p. 1099
长 — four strokes in one piece
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 61, p. 533
门 — a dot, a post, a frame
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 65, p. 567
问 — 门 with 口 inside
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 65, p. 567
雨 — a lid, a frame and four drops
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 66, p. 577

音 — five strokes over 日
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 128, p. 1051
饭 — the food piece, then four strokes
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 38, p. 359
马 — a turn, a zigzag, a base
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 67, p. 585